

THE SORCERER'S RECKONING

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Book One of The Lattice Chronicles

VERDANTLIFE LLC

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This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places and events are products of the author's imagination. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, is coincidental.

First edition.

*For every kid who was told what they would be
before anyone asked who they were.*

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*Little light, little light, burning low,
keep the door for the ones who go.*

— Ashbourne lullaby

PROLOGUE

THE SEAL



THE STORM CAME DOWN off the Greyspine in the second hour after midnight, and Arion Vey knew that he had run out of time.

He stood at the window of the cottage with two fingers resting on the sill, tapping, tapping, a rhythm older than the house. Beyond the glass the Veil had gone the color of pewter. Lightning walked the ridgelines on long white legs. Somewhere down the valley a dog was barking at nothing, the way dogs did when the air was wrong, and the thatch above him hissed with rain.

"They're asleep," Seren said behind him. "Both of them. Finally."

He didn't turn around. If he turned around he would see her face, and if he saw her face he would not do this, and if he did not do this, they would all die. So he watched the lightning and tapped the sill, and said, "Light the lantern, love."

He heard the scrape of the striker, the soft cough of the wick. Gold light found the window and laid his own reflection over the storm: a tired man of middle years, silver at the temples, with a face that people forgot as soon as they looked away from it. He had worked hard at that face. Faces that were forgotten lived longer.

"Arion." Her voice was very steady. Seren's voice was always steadiest when she was most afraid. "Tell me again why it has to be tonight."

"Because they found the Vhessa records." He made himself say it plainly. "Because Kell has a list of every Warden who signed out the Founders' codices in the last ten years, and my name is on it, and by

tomorrow someone at the Spire will start asking why the Warden-Architect spent three months in the eastern march before half of it turned black." He breathed. "Because the thing that came through the breach has learned my scent. And because if any one of them comes looking for me, they will find the boys. And the boys burn brighter than I do."

"They're children."

"They're mine," he said. "That's the whole problem."

He turned then. He couldn't help it.

Seren Harrow stood by the hearth with the lantern in one hand. She was small and fierce and freckled, her hair tied back with a strip of blue cloth, her sleeves still rolled from the washing. There was flour on her cheek. There was always flour on her cheek; he had stopped telling her years ago, because he liked it there. She was looking at him the way she had looked at him the first time, across a market square in Saltreach, as if she could see straight through the forgettable face to the thing underneath and had decided, against all sense, that she liked it.

"Show me," she said.



THE BOYS SLEPT IN the loft, under the eaves, in a nest of quilts that smelled of woodsmoke and lavender. Arion climbed the ladder with the lantern, and Seren came after.

Anthoren was nine, all knees and elbows, sprawled on his back with one arm flung over his eyes. Even asleep he looked like he was in the middle of an argument. He had Seren's freckles and Arion's long hands and a way of staring at things until they gave up their secrets: the clock in the mill, the hinge of a door, the night sky. Last week he had asked his father why stars didn't fall, and when Arion had told him, he'd asked a second question, and a third, and by the seventh Arion had found himself sketching the motion of the heavens on the kitchen table in flour while Seren laughed at them both.

Lexander was four. He slept curled into his brother's side like a puppy, one fist wound tight in Antho's nightshirt. His hair was a riot of dark curls. He had a scab on his knee from falling off the woodpile, and a small iron horseshoe nail clutched in his other hand, which he had found in the road

three days ago and had refused to put down since. "Mine," he'd said, every time anyone reached for it. "Mine. I'm keeping it."

Arion knelt on the boards between them, and for a long moment he only looked.

Then he set the lantern down, and closed his eyes, and *looked* in the other way.

The world fell away. In its place stood the Lattice.

It was everywhere, always. Most people only ever saw the little window of it that belonged to them, a few silver lines of text when they called for it. *Name. Class. Level.* A small, tidy piece of the great machine, polished for their use. But Arion Vey had been born with the blood that saw the whole thing, and the whole thing was vast. It hung over the world like a net of light, threads beyond counting, every thread humming with mana, every knot a life. It ran through the walls of the cottage and the rain outside and the sleeping valley, out across the mountains and the sea, and the ten thousand threads that made a person were laced into it at a thousand points, so that it was impossible to say where the person ended and the Lattice began.

Most people's threads were silver.

His sons' threads were gold.

Not all of them. Not yet. The boys hadn't been Kindled; the Lattice hadn't fully taken hold of them, and wouldn't until each turned sixteen and laid his hand upon a Stone. But the gold was there, under the skin of the world, the way a vein of ore lay under rock. Antho's burned in a slow, dark, deep color, like honey held up to a candle. Lex's was bright and restless and hot, and it flickered at the edges, as if it were already trying to get out.

Root, the gold said, to anyone who knew how to read it. *Here is Root. Here is the blood of the one who made all this.*

Anyone who knew how to read it. The Wardens. The thing in the east.

And the other one. The one Arion did not let himself think about, even here, even now.

"It's so bright," Seren whispered beside him. She didn't have the blood, but she was a Listener, and Listeners could feel what they could not see.

Her hand had found his shoulder. "I can feel it from here. Like standing near a forge."

"Yes."

"Will it hurt them?"

He didn't answer at once. He reached into his coat and drew out the things he had prepared: a silver needle, a small pot of ink ground from the ash of a Founders' cedar, a strip of linen. His hands were perfectly steady. His hands were always steady. It was the rest of him that shook.

"The sealing won't hurt," he said. "They'll sleep through it. It will feel like a dream about being cold."

"And after?"

"After, the Lattice will look at them and see ordinary boys. Common blood. Common classes when they're Kindled. Nothing anyone would hunt." He threaded the needle. "Nothing anyone would *use*."

"And if it breaks?"

That was the question. He had asked it of himself every night for a month.

"It won't break," he said. "Not while I'm alive to hold it."

"Arion."

"It's a good seal, love." He dipped the needle. "It's the best work I've ever done."



HE STARTED WITH ANTHO, because Antho was older and the gold in him was deeper, harder to cover. He drew back the boy's nightshirt and laid his palm flat over his heart, and felt it beating there, quick and fierce.

Seal, he thought, in the language under language, the glyph-speech of the Founders that the scholars called Wellscrip. *Conceal. Let the gold be grey. Let the deep thing sleep.*

The needle moved. It didn't pierce the skin; it touched the threads beneath, the gold ones, and where it touched, Arion's own Authority flowed out of him like blood from a cut. He felt it go, a cold draining, the way warmth leaves a body in snow. The ash-ink hung in the air above the boy's chest, a lattice of fine black lines, and then sank into him and vanished.

Antho stirred. His face creased. He mumbled something.

"Shh," Seren whispered, stroking his hair. "Shh, sweetheart."

Antho's eyes opened a crack. They were unfocused, heavy with sleep. They found his father's face in the lantern light.

"Papa?" he said thickly. "It's cold."

"I know. Go back to sleep."

"Are you doing magic?"

"A little."

Antho considered this with the grave seriousness of the very sleepy. His gaze drifted to his brother, still curled against his side. "Will it hurt him?" he asked.

Arion's hand stopped.

"Only if it breaks," he said quietly. And then, because the boy was still looking at him, because he had always believed in telling his children the truth even when the truth was too large for them: "If it ever breaks, Antho, you look after him. Can you do that? You're his big brother. You look after him."

"Kay," Antho mumbled. His eyes were already closing. "I always do."

The last line of the glyph sank into him. Arion felt the seal settle like a lid onto a pot, and the deep honey-gold of his eldest son dimmed, and dimmed, and went grey.

He let out a breath he hadn't known he was holding. Then he turned to his younger son.



LEX WAS HARDER.

Antho's power had been deep and still. You could lay a lid on still water. Lex's was a fire, and the moment Arion's palm touched his small chest the fire *noticed*. It leapt up toward the needle like a cat after string. The threads under the boy's skin went from gold to white-gold to a color that had no name, and the heat of it came up through Arion's hand so sharply that he hissed.

"Arion?"

"He's fighting it." He set his jaw. "He's four years old and he's fighting it."

"Of course he is." Seren made a sound that was almost a laugh and almost a sob. "He's ours."

Arion bent closer. *Seal*, he thought. *Conceal. Let the gold be grey.* The fire threw the glyph back at him. *Please*, he thought, which was not Wellsript, which was not anything. *Please, little one. Let me hide you. Let me keep you safe.*

The fire flickered. Considered.

And then, in the place under language, something in his son *looked at him.*

It wasn't thought, not yet; Lex was too young for thought of that kind. It was something more basic. The sense of a hand being held out in the dark. *Who are you?*

I'm your father, Arion thought back. *I'm going away for a while. I don't want to. I'm sorry.*

The fire didn't understand the words. But it seemed to understand the sorrow, because slowly, slowly, it let itself be covered.

He worked for a long time. The needle moved and moved. The Authority poured out of him, far more than he had planned for, and the lantern burned lower, and the storm walked off down the valley grumbling to itself. Once Seren had to hold his wrist to keep it steady. Once he had to stop and press the heels of his hands against his eyes until the dizziness passed. The seal on Antho had been a lid. The seal on Lex had to be a forge-door: iron, banded, locked, with the fire still roaring behind it.

And because it had to be locked, it had to have a keeper.

He had known that for a month too. He had not told Seren.

He reached inside himself, past the Authority, past the threads, to the place where *he* was: the shape of his own mind, the knot of memory and habit and love and stubbornness that made Arion Vey into Arion Vey. And he took a piece of it. Not a large piece. A sliver, the width of a fingernail paring. He took his patience and his courtesy and his terrible jokes about smelting, and his memory of the Founders' codes, and the part of him that had once sat up all night with a feverish infant singing nonsense songs about blacksmiths. He took the part of him that was a father.

He pressed it into the seal like a maker's mark into hot iron.

Watch him, he told it. Wake when the seal wakes. Guide him. Tell him what I couldn't.

The sliver didn't answer. It wasn't awake yet. It might never be. But it settled into the lock, gold among the grey, and went still.

When Arion finally sat back on his heels, the threads of his younger son were grey as old pewter, and the only sign of what lay underneath was a faint warmth, like a hearthstone the morning after a fire.

Lex had not woken once. He slept on, fist still tight in his brother's nightshirt, the horseshoe nail still clutched in the other hand.

Arion bent and kissed his forehead. Then Antho's.

"There," he said. His voice came out hoarse. "There. Done."



AT THE BOTTOM OF the ladder, Seren put the lantern on the table and turned to him, and he saw that she had been crying the whole time, silently, the way she did everything difficult.

"How long?" she asked.

"I don't know." He could at least give her that. "Until the breaches are closed. Until the Order forgets my name. Until it's safe."

"That isn't an answer."

"It's the only one I have."

"And what do I tell them?"

He'd thought about this too. "Tell them I was a merchant," he said. "Tell them I went east for trade and didn't come back. Let them be angry with me. It's easier to be angry at a man who left than to grieve a man who's dead, and it's safer than the truth." He swallowed. "Use your name. Harrow. Not Vey. Never Vey. Raise them as Harrows. Let them grow up ordinary."

"They'll never be ordinary."

"Let them think they are. For as long as they can."

She came to him then and put her flour-smudged hand against his cheek and looked at him for a very long time, and he let her, and did not look away.

"You're a fool, Arion Vey," she said at last. "You're the cleverest fool I ever met."

"I know."

"Come back."

"I'll try."

"*Come back*," she said again, fiercely, and kissed him, and then pushed him toward the door before either of them could change their minds.



HE WALKED OUT INTO the wet grey morning. The rain had thinned to a fine mist, and the Veil lay thick along the valley floor, silver-white, softening the hedgerows and the stone walls and the roofs of Ashbourne below. Somewhere a cockerel was making a fool of itself. In the village square, the old Lattice Stone stood in its ring of mossy cobbles, faintly glowing, the way all the Stones glowed at dawn: a crack running through its face, the result of some long-forgotten lightning strike.

He didn't look back at the cottage. He had promised himself he wouldn't. He looked once, which he had not promised himself about, and saw the lantern burning in the window, small and gold against the grey.

A light left on for the lost.

Then he pulled his hood up, and let his face become forgettable, and walked into the mist.

Behind him, deep in the threads of the world, where no one in the valley could see, a line of silver text wrote itself into the great ledger of the Lattice and was filed away among ten thousand million others:

SEAL APPLIED × 2

Subjects: ANTHOREN HARROW (9)

LEXANDER HARROW (4)

Bloodline flag: CONCEALED

Authority expended: 97 / 100

WARDEN-ARCHITECT ARION VEY

Status: CONCEALED

Last known location: —

And beneath it, smaller, in a color that was not silver at all but the deep gold of embers banked for the night, something else. Something the Lattice did not file, because the Lattice did not know it was there.

GUARDIAN CONSTRUCT – DORMANT
Bound to: LEXANDER
Waiting.

Fifteen years would pass before it woke.

PART ONE



THE AWAKENING

CHAPTER 1

THE FORGE AT ASHBOURNE



THE HORSESHOE WAS WRONG, and Lex knew it before the hammer came down.

He knew it the way you know a step is missing in the dark: a tiny lurch of the stomach, a sense of the world being a finger's width off true. The iron on the anvil glowed the color of a ripe apricot, which was right. The tongs were steady, which was right. His arm was already coming down, the hammer a dull grey blur at the end of it, and the angle was right, the weight was right, everything about the blow was exactly, perfectly right.

The iron was wrong.

There was a flaw in it. A seam, deep in the heart of the bar, where some careless smelter in some faraway foundry had let a bubble of slag cool inside. You couldn't see it. You couldn't feel it through the tongs. But Lex could *hear* it, a dull note under the iron's ringing, like a cracked bell under a good one, and he knew with total certainty that if the hammer landed where he'd aimed it, the shoe would split along that seam and fly off the anvil in two pieces.

He turned his wrist. Just slightly. The hammer came down a thumb's width to the left of where he'd aimed it, at a shallower angle, and struck the iron with a bright clean *chang* that went up into the rafters and set the hanging chains trembling.

The shoe held.

Lex let out a breath. He struck again, and again, rolling the iron over in the tongs, working the curve around the anvil's horn, and the flaw stayed

buried and quiet in the heart of the metal where he'd coaxed it. When the shoe was shaped, he lifted it in the tongs and plunged it into the slack tub, and the water screamed and boiled and threw up a column of steam that smelled of rust and rain.

A small silver box opened in the corner of his vision.

SKILL PROGRESS

Smithing – Journeyman 3 (81%)

He dismissed it with a thought. Eighty-one percent. It had been eighty-one percent for nine days. It would be eighty-one percent tomorrow, and the day after, and on some bright morning a month from now it would tick over to eighty-two, and that would be a good day, and he would tell no one, because no one would care.

"You did the thing again," said a voice from the doorway.

Lex didn't turn around. "What thing?"

"The thing where you stop in the middle of a swing and stare at the iron like it insulted your mother." Brannoc Holt ducked under the lintel, which he had to do, because Brannoc Holt was the largest man in the southern Vale and possibly the largest man in Caldor. He was bald as an egg and bearded like a thundercloud, and the beard was mostly soot. He carried a basket of eggs under one arm, which made him look like a bear that had robbed a henhouse. "And then you move your wrist a hair, and the shoe comes out perfect, and you look like you want to throw up."

"I don't look like I want to throw up."

"You look like a man who's just walked across a frozen pond and heard it crack." Brannoc set the eggs down on the workbench, nudging aside a pair of tongs and a cat. The cat, a scrawny grey tom named Slag, gave him a look of profound betrayal and moved six inches to the left. "It's the slag pockets again, isn't it? You hear them."

Lex fished the shoe out of the tub and turned it over. Clean. Even. A good shoe. You'd never know there was a flaw buried in it. "It's nothing."

"It's not nothing. I've been smithing forty years, lad. I've never once heard a slag pocket."

"Maybe you're deaf."

"Maybe I am. Maybe I'm also twice your weight and could put you through that wall." Brannoc said this with great affection. He picked an egg out of the basket, examined it, and cracked it on the edge of the anvil. "Breakfast?"

"Don't cook eggs on the anvil."

"I always cook eggs on the anvil."

"It's disgusting."

"It's *efficient*." Brannoc slid the egg onto the flat of a shovel and held it over the coals, where it began to sizzle at once. "Your father would have liked that. Efficient."

Lex went very still.

"Sorry," Brannoc said after a moment. He didn't look up from the egg. "That slipped out."

"You never met my father."

"No. Your mother talked about him, though. When she brought you round to watch the forge. Said he never wasted a motion." Brannoc turned the egg with a flick of his wrist. "Said you'd got that from him."

"Did she say I got the *leaving* from him too?"

That came out harder than he'd meant it to. Brannoc looked up from the shovel, and for a moment the big man's face was very gentle, and Lex had to look away from it, out the open door of the forge, at the green.



ASHBOURNE WOKE SLOWLY, THE way villages did in the Vale, when the Veil lay thick in the hollows and the sun had to fight its way down off the mountains. Mist curled over the cobbles of the village green. It hung in silver skeins between the chestnut trees and drifted in the doorway of the Crooked Kettle, where Mother Orla was beating a rug against the wall with a violence that suggested the rug had done something unforgivable. Up the lane, the mill wheel was turning with a slow wooden groan. Somebody's goat was standing on somebody's roof again. Two of the Dunstan children were throwing pebbles at it.

And in the middle of the green, as it had stood for longer than anyone could remember, was the Lattice Stone.

It wasn't impressive, as Stones went. Lex had heard that the ones in Highcrest were twelve feet tall and carved with the faces of the Founders, and that the Great Stone in the Spire was taller than a church and glowed like moonlight even at noon. Ashbourne's Stone came up to his chest. It was grey and lichened and roughly the shape of a gravestone, and a great crack ran down its face from top to bottom, where lightning had struck it some time in his grandmother's grandmother's day. In the early morning it gave off a faint silver shimmer, like a fish's belly seen through water, and the mist always lay a little thicker around it, as if drawn there.

Three years ago, on the morning of his sixteenth birthday, he had walked up to that Stone with half the village watching and put his hand flat on its cracked, cold face.

He remembered it perfectly. He remembered all of it. That was the worst part.

He remembered the way his heart had been going, so hard he'd been afraid people could see it through his shirt. He remembered Brannoc behind him, enormous and silent, and Mother Orla dabbing at her eyes with her apron, and old Reeve Dunstan intoning the words of the Kindling in his reedy voice: *Let the Lattice see you. Let it know your worth. Let it name you as you are.* He remembered thinking, absurdly, that he hoped it would be something with a sword in it. A [Squire]. A [Guardsmen]. Something that would let him leave.

He remembered the cold. The Stone had been cold under his palm, colder than stone should be, and then the cold had gone *into* him, up his arm and into his chest and down to the soles of his feet, and for one strange instant he'd felt as if something deep inside him was knocking on a door.

And then the door hadn't opened, and the cold had gone, and the silver words had unfolded in front of his eyes for the very first time.

KINDLING COMPLETE

Welcome to the Lattice, LEX HARROW.

Class assigned: SMITH

Grade: Common

Level cap: 24

Common.

He'd stood there with his hand on the Stone and read it four times. Then he'd taken his hand away, and turned around, and said, "Smith," and everyone had clapped, and Brannoc had clapped him on the shoulder so hard it left a bruise, and Mother Orla had said, "Oh, *lovely*, Lex, that's lovely, you'll be ever so useful," and he'd smiled and smiled until his face hurt.

He'd been a smith's apprentice since he was eleven. He'd spent five years at Brannoc's anvil. Of course the Lattice made him a Smith. What else would it see when it looked at him? It looked at a boy who hammered iron, and it said: *Here is a boy who hammers iron. Let him hammer iron forever.*

Level cap: 24.

That was the part that people didn't talk about. Everyone knew it; nobody said it. Common classes stopped at twenty-four. You could work your whole life, you could be the best smith in the kingdom, and when you hit twenty-four the silver numbers simply stopped. You could hone your skills, a little. You could grow wiser and older and better at what you did. But the Lattice had decided your shape, and there was no growing out of it.

Born to the Ceiling, they called it, in the taverns, when they'd had enough ale to say it. *Born to the Ceiling and buried under it.*

Brannoc had been level twenty-four for nineteen years.



"STATUS," LEX MUTTERED, UNDER his breath, half out of habit and half out of a kind of morbid curiosity, the way you prod a sore tooth with your tongue.

The silver panel slid open in front of his eyes.

LEX HARROW

Age: 19

Class: Smith (Common)

Level: 9 Cap: 24

XP: 62%

MIG 16 AGI 9 VIT 14

INT 13 SPI 4 RES 15

Health 140/140

Mana 40/40

Stamina 150/150

SKILLS

Smithing Journeyman 3

Hammer Use Apprentice 6

Heat Sense Apprentice 2

Endurance Apprentice 4

He looked at it the way he looked at it every morning, without expectation.

Level nine. Three years after his Kindling, he was level nine, which was slow but not shameful; most smiths didn't reach double figures until their twenties. His Might was good, and his Vitality, and his Resolve was better than it had any right to be, which Brannoc said was because he was stubborn as a mule with a grudge. His Intellect was respectable. His Agility was the agility of a young man who stood in one place hitting things all day.

And his Spirit was four.

Four. The lowest score he'd ever heard of, for anyone, of any class. Old Mag the herbwoman, who was ninety and blind in one eye, had a Spirit of eleven. The Dunstan twins had Spirits of nine apiece. Spirit was the stat for mana, for sensitivity to magic, for the inner light that let a person touch the Veil and make it do things; most people didn't need much of it, but everybody had *some*, the way everybody had some blood. Lex had four. It was as if he'd been born with a hole in him where his magic should have been.

You're just practical, Mother Orla had told him once, kindly. *Some folk are dreamers and some are doers.*

He wondered sometimes, staring at that number, why it bothered him so much. What would he even have done with more Spirit? Smiths didn't need mana. Smiths needed strong arms and good eyes and patience. He had all three.

But every time he looked at that four, he felt the strangest thing. Not shame, exactly. Something more like the sense of a word on the tip of his tongue. A door in a familiar house that he walked past every day and had never once tried to open.

He closed the panel.

"Egg," said Brannoc, holding out the shovel.

Lex took the egg, which was perfectly cooked, and ate it with his fingers, and burned his tongue, and didn't complain.



THEY WORKED THROUGH THE morning.

There were shoes to finish for the Dunstans' plough horses, and a cracked kettle to braze for Mother Orla, and a set of hinges for the chapel door, which had been squealing so loudly during last week's lantern service that Sister Agathe had stopped in the middle of a prayer to glare at it. There was a new ploughshare to start for Farmer Tobbin, who had broken his old one on a rock and was taking it very personally. The forge filled with the familiar music of the work: the roar of the bellows, the hiss of the slack tub, the tap and ring and clang of iron. Slag the cat slept on the warm brick ledge beside the hearth with his paws tucked under him. Brannoc hummed hymns, badly, and occasionally broke off to tell Lex he was holding his tongs like a man holding a dead fish.

Lex didn't mind. He liked the work. He had always liked the work; that was the joke of it. If the Lattice had given him any class in the world, he would have chosen to spend his days at an anvil anyway. He loved the way iron changed in the fire, the way it went from black to red to orange to gold, softening as it heated, until it would take any shape you were patient enough to give it. He loved the weight of a good hammer. He loved the smell of hot metal and coal smoke and the way his whole body sang when he got a hard piece right.

He just wished it had been his choice.

Around midday, Pell came by.

Pell was the miller's youngest, fifteen and gangly, with a shock of straw-colored hair and a face like an eager spaniel's. He had decided some time ago that Lex was the most interesting person in Ashbourne, which said more about Ashbourne than about Lex, and he came by the forge most days on one invented errand or another.

"Da wants to know if you've fixed the gear-pin," he said, hovering in the doorway.

"I fixed the gear-pin yesterday," said Lex. "I gave it to your da yesterday. He paid me for it yesterday."

"Oh." Pell considered this. "He must've forgot."

"Must have."

Pell sidled into the forge and perched on an upturned bucket, well clear of the hearth. Brannoc, who knew perfectly well why Pell came by and thought it was funny, gave the boy a nod and went out the back to fetch more coal.

"My Kindling's in nine days," Pell said.

"I know," Lex said. "You've told me. Every day. For a month."

"Do you think I'll get something good?"

Lex set down the hinge he'd been filing and looked at the boy. Pell's face was so hopeful it hurt. "What do you want to get?"

"Ranger," Pell said at once. "Or Scout. Or—" He went pink. "Or Knight. I know you can't get Knight from a village Stone, everyone says it only happens to nobles, but Gaffer Wim says his cousin's boy got [Squire] down in Lowmarsh and he's in the King's Guard now and he has a *horse*."

"Gaffer Wim's cousin's boy," said Lex, "is a liar, and so is Gaffer Wim."

"You don't know that."

"I've met Gaffer Wim."

Pell scuffed his boot against the bucket. "Well, I want *something*. Not Miller. I don't want to be a Miller." He hesitated. "Did you know? Before your Kindling? Did you know you'd get Smith?"

"I hoped I wouldn't," Lex said, before he could stop himself.

Pell's eyes went wide.

"Not because there's anything wrong with being a smith," Lex said quickly. "It's good work. Honest work. Brannoc's the best man I know,

and he's a smith." He picked the hinge back up, mostly so he'd have something to do with his hands. "I just... wanted to see what else there was. Before the Stone told me."

"Because of your da?" Pell asked. "Everyone says he was a traveller. Before he went off. Ma says he came from Saltreach, or maybe further."

"Everyone says a lot of things."

"And your brother—"

"Pell."

The boy shut his mouth with a click.

Lex filed the hinge. The rasp went *shhk, shhk, shhk* in the quiet. Out on the green, the goat had come down off the roof and was eating the Dunstans' washing. Somewhere a woman was shouting at it.

"Sorry," Pell said, very small.

"It's fine."

"It's just, people are saying things again. About the mountains."

Lex didn't look up. "People always say things about the mountains."

"Not like this." Pell leaned forward on his bucket, lowering his voice, though there was no one to overhear but the cat. "Tobbin's brother came down from Thistledown yesterday. He says the traders up there won't go past the second ridge anymore. He says there's lights in the Hollowmaw. Green lights, and black ones, and sometimes at night you can hear something howling. Not wolves. Something *worse*." Pell swallowed. "He says the mad warlock's woken up properly. He says he's been killing Wardens. Whole patrols of them. They go up and they don't come down."

The file stopped.

"He also says," Pell went on, oblivious, "that it's not just the warlock. He says there's something in the mist up there. Something black. It comes down the gullies at night, like smoke, only it moves *against* the wind, and wherever it's been, the grass goes grey and the birds stop singing. He says it took one of the Tanner boys' sheep. Not killed it. *Took* it. They found it the next morning standing in the middle of the field with its eyes all white, and it didn't eat, and it didn't move, and when they tried to lead it home it just stood there. Breathing. Like it was waiting for something."

Lex set the file down. Very carefully.

"Who told you all this?"

"Tobbin's brother. At the Kettle. Last night." Pell looked at him uncertainly. "Do you think it's true? Do you think it's your br—do you think it's the warlock doing it?"

The forge was very quiet. The fire muttered to itself in the hearth.

"I think," said Lex, "that Tobbin's brother drinks more than Tobbin, and Tobbin drinks more than anyone."

"Oh," said Pell, deflated.

"Go home, Pell. Tell your da I fixed the gear-pin."

The boy went. Lex stood at the anvil with his hands flat on the cool iron for a long time after, staring at nothing.



HE HAD BEEN ELEVEN years old the night the cottage burned.

He did not, as a rule, let himself remember it. He had gotten very good at not remembering it, the way you get good at walking around a hole in the floor. But Pell's voice had kicked something loose, and now it came up whether he wanted it or not.

He remembered the smell first. Smoke, and something under the smoke, sharp and strange, like a lightning strike in a closed room. He remembered waking in the loft with his eyes stinging and the air full of a terrible orange light, and Antho's side of their bed empty and cold.

Antho had been sixteen. That was the day of his Kindling. Lex remembered that much: the morning, the whole village on the green, Antho walking up to the cracked Stone with his chin high and his long hands shoved in his pockets so nobody would see them shaking. Antho had been strange for weeks before. Quiet. Not sleeping. Lex had heard him get up in the night and go out to sit on the woodpile under the stars, and once he'd heard him talking, low and urgent, to someone who wasn't there.

Antho had put his hand on the Stone, and the Stone had screamed.

Lex didn't know how else to describe it. It hadn't made a sound you could hear with your ears. But every person on the green had flinched at once, and every dog in the village had started to howl, and the silver shimmer of the Stone had gone, for one instant, black. Then Antho had pulled his hand away and stood there, swaying, staring at nothing, at something only he could see, and his face had gone the color of old ash.

He hadn't told anyone what class he'd gotten. He'd walked home without a word and gone up to the loft and lain on the bed with his face to the wall. When Mother tried to talk to him, he didn't answer. When Lex tried, Antho had said, without turning round, in a voice Lex had never heard before: *Go away, Lex. Please. Go away. It's so loud.*

And that night, the cottage had burned.

Lex remembered climbing down the ladder through smoke so thick he couldn't see his own hands. He remembered the heat. He remembered the main room of the cottage, their kitchen, their hearth, the table where Mother made bread, and the shapes moving in it through the smoke. He remembered his mother's voice, calling his brother's name, over and over, *Antho, Antho, sweetheart, look at me, look at me*, and his brother's voice answering in words that weren't words, a sound like wind going through a crack in a wall.

He remembered Antho's eyes. When his brother had turned and looked at him through the smoke, Antho's eyes had been black. Not dark. Black. Black from edge to edge, like holes cut in the world.

Then something had happened that Lex had never been able to remember clearly. A darkness that was darker than the smoke. A cold that came through the heat. A sound like a door slamming somewhere very far away.

And then he was outside, coughing on his hands and knees in the wet grass of the yard, and Brannoc's huge arms were around him, and the whole cottage was a pillar of fire, and his mother was gone, and his brother was gone, and the village was screaming.

They never found her body. They never found anything. The fire had burned so hot that it melted the iron pots on the hearth.

Antho was seen once more, three days later. A shepherd saw him walking up into the Greyspine, barefoot in the snow, alone. He didn't answer when the shepherd called to him. He didn't look back.

Murderer, the village said, once they'd stopped saying *poor boy. Murderer. He went mad at his Kindling and burned his own mother alive. You could see it in his eyes.*

And Lex, who was eleven, and had seen his brother's eyes, believed them.

Brannoc took him in. Brannoc gave him a cot in the loft above the forge and a hammer and a reason to get up in the morning, and never once asked him what he'd seen. Lex had worked at the anvil every day since, and had gotten very, very good at not remembering.

And now people were saying that the mad warlock of the Hollowmaw was killing Wardens in the mountains.

He found that his hands were shaking. He pressed them flat against the anvil until they stopped.



THE AFTERNOON WORE ON. The sun came down off the Greyspine and made a brief gold appearance over the valley before the clouds took it back. Brannoc came in with the coal and saw Lex's face and didn't say anything, only clapped him on the shoulder and put him to work on Farmer Tobbin's ploughshare, which was a long, hard, heavy job that didn't leave room for thinking.

Lex was grateful. He worked until his arms ached and his shirt was soaked through and the air in the forge shimmered with heat. He worked until the thoughts went away and there was nothing in his head but the iron.

That was when he started to notice the other thing.

He noticed it first in the iron itself. He was drawing out the edge of the ploughshare, the hammer rising and falling in its steady rhythm, *chang, chang, chang*, and somewhere around the fortieth blow, the iron started to *hum*.

Not ring. Hum. A low, almost subsonic vibration that he felt through the tongs and the hammer haft and the soles of his feet, a sound that seemed to come from inside the metal and inside himself at the same time. The glow of the iron seemed to deepen. Where his hammer struck, tiny motes of light lifted off the surface like sparks, but they didn't fall. They hung in the air for a heartbeat, gold, and then winked out.

He stopped hammering. The hum stopped.

He stared at the iron. It was just iron. Orange and cooling and ordinary.

"Brannoc," he said slowly. "Did you see that?"

Brannoc was at the bellows. "See what?"

"The sparks. They were... they didn't fall."

Brannoc looked at the ploughshare, then at Lex, then at the ploughshare again. "Lad, you've been at that for three hours without a drink. Go put your head in the rain barrel."

Lex went and put his head in the rain barrel. The water was cold enough to make his teeth ache. When he came back, the ploughshare was cooling on the anvil, black and ordinary, and the forge was the forge.

But it kept happening.

Not with the iron. With everything. Small things. As the afternoon darkened toward evening, he began to notice that the fire in the hearth leaned toward him when he passed, the flames bending in his direction like flowers toward a window. He picked up a cold bar of iron from the rack and it was warm in his hand, warm all the way through, as if it had been sitting in the sun. When he reached for the slack tub, the water in it rippled, very slightly, before his fingers touched it.

And when he looked out the door of the forge at the village green, at the old cracked Lattice Stone in its ring of cobbles, he saw that the silver shimmer that always hung around it had changed color.

It was gold.

Just at the edges. Just a faint, warm gold, like the light of a lantern seen through fog, flickering at the edges of the silver. And it was leaning toward the forge. Toward *him*.

He blinked, and it was silver again.

"Brannoc," he said, and his voice came out strange. "I think something's wrong with me."



HE DIDN'T SAY IT loud enough. Brannoc had gone into the house to start supper, and the forge was empty except for Lex and the cat.

Slag was sitting bolt upright on the warm brick ledge, every hair on his scrawny body standing on end, staring at the open door.

Outside, the evening had come down blue and cold. The mist was rising off the green in long pale streamers, thicker than Lex had seen it in weeks. The chestnut trees dripped. Lamplight glowed in the windows of

the Crooked Kettle, and somewhere up the lane a mother was calling her children in for supper. Ordinary sounds. An ordinary evening.

Except that the mist was moving the wrong way.

Lex walked to the door and stood in it, looking out. The breeze was coming down off the mountains, from the north, cold and smelling of snow. And the mist on the green, the thick silver mist of the Veil, was drifting *north*. Into the wind. Toward the mountains. Slowly, steadily, like water draining out of a basin, as if something up there in the dark of the Greyspine had taken a long, deep breath and was pulling it in.

And under the mist, low in the gullies on the far side of the valley, so faint he might have imagined it, there was something else. A darker color. A smudge, like a thumbprint of soot on a window.

Lex stared at it until his eyes watered.

That was when he heard the footsteps.

They came up the lane from the south road, slow and deliberate. Boots on cobbles. A walking stick, tapping. Lex turned his head and saw a figure resolving out of the mist: a tall man, thin, in a long grey traveling cloak that hung to the tops of his boots and was dark with damp at the hem. A hood shadowed his face. He leaned on a staff of pale wood, and when he walked, small things sewn into the cloak caught the lamplight and glittered: tiny charms of brass, dozens of them, each one shaped like a lightning bolt.

On the stranger's shoulder sat a raven, black as a hole in the evening.

The stranger didn't stop at the Crooked Kettle, where any traveler would stop. He didn't stop at the Reeve's house, or the chapel. He walked straight across the green, past the Lattice Stone, without once looking at it, and came to a halt at the edge of the forge light, where the orange glow of the hearth spilled out across the wet cobbles and turned the mist to gold.

He pushed back his hood.

He was older than Lex had thought. Sixty, perhaps, or a hard-lived fifty. His face was long and lined and weathered brown, his beard close-cropped and grey, his hair grey and swept back from a high forehead. A scar ran from his left temple down into his beard, pale and jagged, like the track of a lightning strike. His eyes were very bright and very sharp and the color of a storm cloud, and they looked at Lex, at *all* of Lex, in a way that made Lex feel as if the man were reading him like a page.

The raven on his shoulder ruffled its feathers and said, in a perfectly clear voice, "*Found him.*"

"So we have, Quill," said the stranger softly. "So we have."

He looked at the forge. At the anvil, the slack tub, the cooling ploughshare. At the hearth, where the fire had risen in the last few moments to a roar, every flame bent toward the doorway where Lex stood. Then he looked back at Lex, and something in that sharp, weathered face softened, and something else in it tightened, as if he were looking at a ghost.

"You have his hands," the stranger said. "I'd know them anywhere."

Lex found his voice. "Whose hands?"

The stranger didn't answer at once. The mist eddied around his boots. Behind him, across the green, the old Lattice Stone pulsed once, faintly, gold.

"Young man," he said at last, very quietly, "I've come a long way to find you. And I'm afraid I've come almost too late." He leaned on his staff. The brass charms on his cloak chimed softly, like distant bells. "Your destiny is waiting for you, Lex Harrow. And it is not at this anvil."

CHAPTER 2

THE STRANGER IN THE FORGE LIGHT



FOR A LONG MOMENT, nobody moved.

The stranger stood at the edge of the light with his staff planted on the cobbles and the mist curling around his boots. The raven on his shoulder cocked its head and studied Lex with one bright, black, entirely too intelligent eye. In the hearth behind Lex, the fire roared and leaned and reached, every flame bent toward the doorway, as if it wanted to get a look at the newcomer too.

"I think," Lex said carefully, "you've got the wrong forge."

"I don't think so." The stranger's voice was low and pleasant, with the clipped vowels of the north. "Lex Harrow. Nineteen years old. Apprentice, and lately journeyman, to Brannoc Holt of Ashbourne. Kindled three years ago this spring as a Smith, Common grade, level cap twenty-four." The storm-grey eyes flicked down to Lex's hands, then back up. "Spirit of four."

Lex's mouth went dry. "How do you know that?"

"Because it's wrong," said the stranger. "And I've been looking for exactly that kind of wrong for a very long time."

"*Long time*," agreed the raven.

There was a heavy footstep behind Lex. A shadow fell across the doorway, blotting out half the forge light, and Brannoc Holt came up beside him with a fire poker in one enormous fist. He didn't raise it. He didn't need to. Brannoc holding a poker was a statement in itself, the way a mountain is a statement.

"Evening," Brannoc said.

"Good evening." The stranger inclined his head, unruffled. "Master Holt, I presume. You'll forgive the hour."

"Depends what you want with my boy."

"Only to talk."

"You can talk from there."

"I could," the stranger agreed. "But it's cold, and wet, and I've walked eleven miles since noon, and what I have to say is not the kind of thing either of you will want the neighbors hearing." He glanced across the green, to where Mother Orla had come to the door of the Crooked Kettle and was peering out into the mist with undisguised interest. "And I suspect your neighbors hear a great deal."

Brannoc considered this. Lex could see him weighing it: the stranger's thin frame and old age against the staff and the brass charms and the bright, hard intelligence in those eyes. Brannoc had lived in the Vale all his life, but he'd been young once, and in his youth he'd travelled, and he knew what it meant when a man wore lightning on his cloak.

"You're a sorcerer," Brannoc said.

"I am."

"Warden?"

Something flickered across the stranger's face, quick as the tail of a fish. "Not for a long time."

Brannoc grunted. He looked at Lex. Lex, who didn't know what to say, said nothing.

"You'll keep your hands where I can see them," Brannoc said at last, and stood aside.



HIS NAME WAS ELRIC Thorne.

He told them so as he lowered himself onto the bench by the forge, with a small sigh of relief, and stretched his long legs toward the fire. Quill the raven hopped down from his shoulder onto the workbench and began investigating Brannoc's basket of eggs with the air of a tax collector, until Slag the cat rose from his ledge with every hair on end and the two of them

settled into a silent, deadly staring contest that would last the rest of the evening.

"Elric Thorne," Brannoc repeated. He'd set the poker down but he hadn't sat; he leaned against the anvil with his arms folded. "Never heard of you."

"You wouldn't have. I've spent most of my life trying very hard not to be heard of." Elric held his hands out to the coals. They were long, thin, knotted hands, the knuckles swollen with age, and across the back of the right one ran another of those pale, branching scars. "It's a skill, like any other. You get better at it with practice."

"And what is it you practice," said Brannoc, "when you're not being unheard of?"

"Storms, mostly." Elric smiled. "And research. And, lately, looking for people who don't wish to be found." His gaze moved to Lex. "Which brings me to you."

Lex had been standing by the slack tub all this while, his arms crossed over his chest, trying to look like a person who wasn't shaking. He didn't know why he was shaking. He didn't know why the fire kept leaning toward him, or why the bar of cold iron he'd picked up and put down three times now was warm to the touch, or why every time this old man looked at him, he felt as though something in his chest was turning over, like a key in a stiff lock.

"You said my Spirit was wrong," he said.

"I did."

"It's not wrong. It's just low. Some people have low Spirit."

"Nobody has a Spirit of four, Lex." Elric's voice was gentle. "Not nobody *healthy*. Not nobody *alive*. The lowest natural score ever recorded in the Spire's archives was seven, and that was a man who had been born without part of his brain. Four isn't low. Four is *impossible*. Four is what you get when someone takes a natural score and puts a lid on it."

"A lid," Lex repeated.

"A seal." Elric leaned forward, the brass charms on his cloak chiming softly. "Young man, I've come a long way to tell you something, and I'm going to tell it to you plainly, because I'm too old and too tired to dress it up. You are no ordinary blacksmith. You were never meant to be. You

possess the essence of a sorcerer, a power that runs deep in your blood, deeper than you can imagine, and someone you loved very much locked it away when you were small enough to hold in one arm."

The forge was quiet. The fire crackled. Out on the green, the mist moved silently north.

"That's mad," Lex said.

"Yes, it rather is."

"I've never done anything. Not once. Not a spark. My whole life—" He stopped. He thought of the slag pockets he could hear in iron. The sparks that hadn't fallen. The fire, leaning. "My whole life," he said again, less certainly.

"Your whole life, you've been sitting on a fire with a forge-door bolted over it," said Elric. "And now the bolts are starting to give. You've noticed, haven't you? These last few days. Weeks, perhaps. Iron that's warm when it should be cold. Fire that turns to look at you. Things you can feel, or hear, that no one else can." He watched Lex's face. "The Lattice Stone on your green. It's been changing color."

Lex said nothing.

"Gold," Elric said softly. "At the edges."

"How," said Brannoc, in a voice like distant thunder, "do you know all this?"

Elric turned his head to look at the smith. For a moment the bright hard intelligence in his eyes dimmed, and he looked only old and very tired.

"Because I knew the man who made the seal," he said. "I was his friend for forty years. And his name was Arion."



LEX HAD NOT HEARD his father's name spoken aloud in eight years.

His mother had said it, sometimes, when he was very small. Never in anger. Never with tears, not where the boys could see. She would say it quietly, offhand, while she was kneading bread or mending a shirt: *Your father liked his tea black. Your father used to sing that one. Your father would have laughed at that.* As if he were a man who'd stepped out to the shops and would be back any minute. As if there were nothing strange at all about a man who walked out of his family's life when his youngest son

was four and never once wrote, never once sent money, never once came home.

He was a merchant, she'd said, when Lex was old enough to ask. *He went east for trade. Something must have happened. Roads are dangerous.* And then she would change the subject, and her face would close like a door.

After the fire, nobody said the name at all.

"My father," Lex said now, and his voice came out flat and hard and strange to his own ears, "was a merchant. He went east. He didn't come back."

"Your father was a sorcerer of the Wardens of the Lattice," Elric said. "Tier Four. One of perhaps a dozen people living who could claim the title Warden-Architect. He was the most gifted man I ever met, the most frustrating, and the most stubborn, and he didn't come back because he couldn't. Not because he didn't want to." He paused. "He did go east, though. That part's true."

"No."

"Lex—"

"No." The word came out louder than he meant it to. The fire in the hearth jumped, a sudden roaring gout of flame that made Brannoc flinch and set the chains swinging. Lex didn't notice. "You don't get to walk in here and tell me that. You don't get to tell me he was some great sorcerer who had good reasons. He *left*. He left us. He left her. Whatever he was, wherever he went, he chose that over us, and she spent eleven years pretending she wasn't waiting for him, and then she *died*, and he wasn't there, and he's never been there, and I don't—" He realized his hands had curled into fists. He made them open. "I don't care what he was."

Elric looked at him for a long moment.

"You sound like him," he said quietly. "When you're angry. Did you know that?"

Lex turned away.

There was a long silence. The fire settled slowly back down in the hearth. Quill and Slag continued their staring match. Brannoc, by the anvil, was looking at Lex with an expression Lex didn't want to see.

"Why now?" Brannoc said at last. "Fifteen years. Why come now?"

"Because the seal is failing," Elric turned back to the fire. "A seal like the one Arion put on his sons doesn't hold itself. It's not iron; it's a working, a living thing, and it needs to be fed. Arion fed it from his own life. As long as he was alive and whole, the seal would hold, quiet and invisible, and the boy would grow up thinking he was ordinary." He spread his knotted hands. "If the seal is failing, it means the life feeding it is failing too."

Lex went still.

"I don't know where Arion is," Elric said. "I've been searching for eleven years. I know he went east, to the Vhessan march, sixteen years ago. I know he came back from there changed and frightened and wouldn't tell me why. I know he disappeared not long after. And I know that for these last few months, all across Aldermere, the Lattice has been... flickering. Fraying. Like a rope with too much weight on it." He looked up at Lex. "And then a month ago I felt it. A flare of something gold, down here in the southern Vale, where there shouldn't be anything gold at all. Like a spark from under a door. And I thought: *There. That's one of his.*"

"One of his," Lex said. "You mean—"

"I mean you," said Elric. "I mean the seal on you is cracking, Lex Harrow. Which means your father is in terrible trouble, wherever he is. Which means that very soon, and I mean days, not weeks, that power of yours is going to come through whether you want it or not." He held Lex's gaze. "And I would rather be standing next to you when it does."



HE WANTED TO TEST it.

That was how Lex found himself, an hour later, standing in front of the old cracked Lattice Stone in the middle of the night with a cut on his palm.

It was full dark now. The village had gone to bed. A few lamps still burned in windows, and the Crooked Kettle was dark and shuttered, and the mist had thickened until the green was a shallow sea of silver-grey, waist-deep, drifting slowly, steadily north. The Stone stood up out of it like a rock out of the tide. Up close, its glow was stronger than Lex had ever seen it: a soft, pulsing silver, like breath, and at its edges, unmistakable now, a faint wavering fringe of gold.

"This is ridiculous," said Brannoc, who had insisted on coming. He held a lantern in one hand and the fire poker in the other.

"Very probably," Elric agreed. He had produced a small knife from somewhere in his cloak and used it to nick the ball of Lex's thumb, quickly and neatly, before Lex had quite registered what he was doing. "Hold it out. Over the crack. That's right."

Lex held his hand over the Stone. A bead of blood welled up from the cut, fat and dark in the lantern light, and trembled on his skin.

"What happens now?"

"Now," said Elric, "we find out whether I'm a mad old fool who walked eleven miles for nothing."

The drop of blood fell.

It struck the Stone right on the crack, where lightning had split it a hundred years ago, and for one heartbeat nothing happened at all.

Then the Stone *woke*.

Light came up out of it, gold light, so sudden and so bright that Lex cried out and threw his arm across his eyes. It poured out of the crack like molten metal poured from a crucible. It ran up the face of the Stone in branching lines, in shapes, in glyphs Lex had never seen and somehow almost recognized. The mist around the Stone lit up from inside like a cloud with the sun behind it. The whole green went gold, the trees, the cottages, the chapel steeple, every window flashing like a coin, and from somewhere deep in Lex's chest came an answering heat, sudden and enormous, like the door of a furnace swinging open.

The silver panel snapped open in front of his eyes on its own.

LEX HARROW

Class: Smith (Common)

Level: 9 Cap: 24

MIG 16 AGI 9 VIT 14

INT 13 SPI 4 RES 15

And then, as he watched, the numbers *moved*.

Not the Might, not the Agility. The Spirit. The little silver four shivered like a candle flame in a draft. It blurred. For an instant, just an

instant, something else showed through underneath it, as if the four had been painted on glass and there was a different number on the wall behind:

SPI 4 (██)
ERR: VALUE MASKED

Gold, not silver. A two-digit number, too blurred to read.

Then it was gone, and the four was back, and the light from the Stone was sinking back down into the crack, and the green was dark again except for Brannoc's lantern and a few gold motes drifting in the mist like fireflies.

Lex realized he was on his knees in the wet grass. He didn't remember falling. His heart was going like a hammer on an anvil. His hand was throbbing, and when he looked at it, the cut on his thumb had sealed itself shut, leaving only a thin pink line.

"Well," said Elric Thorne softly, somewhere above him. "Well, well. So it's true." He let out a long breath. "Of course it is. Of course it's true. He never did anything by halves."

Something in his voice made Lex look up.

The old sorcerer was standing very still in the drifting mist, staring at the Stone. The lantern light carved deep lines in his face. And his expression, just for a moment, before he noticed Lex watching and smoothed it away, was a strange, raw tangle of things: wonder and relief and grief, and under them something darker, something tight and hungry and sad, like a man looking through a window at a feast laid out for someone else.

Then it was gone, and he was only an old man again, offering Lex his hand.

"Up you get," he said. "I think we've made our point."

Brannoc hadn't moved. He was staring at the Stone with his mouth slightly open, the lantern trembling in his fist.

"Lady of Lanterns," he whispered. "Lady of Lanterns preserve us. I felt that in my *teeth*."

"Everyone in the valley felt it," said Elric. He didn't sound pleased. He was looking north now, past the Stone, past the edge of the village, toward the dark wall of the Greyspine. "And not only the valley, I'm afraid. That was a beacon. I'd hoped it would be smaller."

"What do you mean?" Lex got to his feet. His legs felt like wet rope. "Who else felt it?"

Elric didn't answer.

Quill had flown up from the forge and was circling overhead, a black shape against the dark. Now he let out a single harsh croak, very loud in the silence, and wheeled sharply north.

And in the quiet that followed, from somewhere up in the hills above the village, there came a sound.

It wasn't a howl. A howl was a wolf sound, a dog sound, a living sound. This was thinner and higher and colder, like wind through the gap of a broken window, and it seemed to come from several places at once. It rose, and held, and broke apart into whispers.

Every hair on Lex's arms stood up.

"Elric," Brannoc said. "What was that?"

The old sorcerer had gone very still. The brass charms on his cloak, Lex saw, had begun to glow. Faint blue sparks were crawling over them like ants.

"Master Holt," Elric said quietly, "I'm going to ask you to do something, and I need you to do it quickly and without asking why. Go to every house on this green and wake whoever's inside, and tell them to bar their doors and put out their lights and stay away from the windows. Start with the ones nearest the north road."

"What—"

"Now, Brannoc."

Something in his voice moved the big smith faster than Lex had ever seen him move. Brannoc was gone into the mist at a lumbering run, lantern swinging, bellowing names.

Lex stood by the Stone. Up in the hills, the not-howl came again. Closer.

"Lex," said Elric. "Do you have a weapon?"

"I'm a smith," Lex said. His voice sounded far away. "I have *several*."

"Get one. The heaviest you can swing."



LEX RAN.

He ran across the green through the waist-deep mist with his heart slamming, and into the forge, where the fire was roaring so high in the hearth that the flames were licking out over the brick lip and up the chimney breast. Slag the cat was nowhere to be seen. Lex went straight to the rack on the back wall and grabbed the first thing his hand fell on, which was Brannoc's old sledge, the big one, a twelve-pound head of black iron on a hickory haft as long as his arm. He'd swung it a thousand times. It had never felt like this. When his hands closed around the haft, the whole thing seemed to *hum*, a low, steady note, like the ploughshare earlier that day, and he felt the heat in his chest rise up to meet it.

He ran back out into the night.

Mist. Moonless dark. Doors were banging all around the green. He could hear Brannoc's voice, and somewhere a child crying, and Reeve Dunstan demanding to know what in the name of the Lady was going on. Lamps were going out one by one in windows like eyes closing.

And coming down the north road, over the crest of the hill where the lane ran out of the village and up toward the mountains, the mist was changing color.

It was black.

Not dark. Black. A slick, oily, absolute black, like spilled ink, like the bottom of a well. It came pouring over the hill and down the lane in a slow, heavy tide, swallowing the silver of the Veil as it came, and where it touched, things *went wrong*. The hedgerows on either side of the lane went grey, leaves and all, as if every bit of color had been drained out of them. The grass went grey. A wooden gate that it flowed over sagged suddenly on its hinges, its timbers gone pale and soft as old bread. And the smell came ahead of it on the wind, a smell Lex would never forget for as long as he lived: wet ash, and rot, and under them, faint and impossibly cold, the smell of nothing at all.

Things were moving inside it.

They came out of the black mist at the bottom of the lane, where it pooled against the first cottages: four of them, then six, then eight. At first he thought they were dogs. They had the shape of dogs, or of wolves. Lean, long-legged, slope-backed shapes, loping low to the ground. But they were the wrong size, too big and then too small, shifting from moment to

moment like shadows thrown by a guttering candle, and they had no color at all, no fur, no flesh. They were made of the black mist, folded and packed and pressed into the shape of hunting animals, and their edges smoked and frayed and drifted away behind them as they ran.

Their eyes were white. Blank, flat white, like boiled eggs, like the eyes of the Tanners' sheep.

And they were *whispering*. All of them. A soft, wet, hissing murmur that came from everywhere and nowhere, and as they got closer Lex could make out words in it, or almost words. *Bright. Bright. There. Bright. Warm. There.*

They were looking at him.

"*Gloamhounds*," said Elric Thorne beside him, very quietly. Lex hadn't heard him come up. The old sorcerer's staff was raised, and the brass charms on his cloak were blazing now, crawling with blue-white fire, and the air around him smelled sharp and clean, like the moment before a lightning strike. "Stay behind me if you can. If you can't, keep your back to something solid, and hit them with iron. Cold iron hurts them. Not much. But it hurts."

"*What are they?*"

"Hungry," said Elric, and the first hound leaped.



LEX HAD NEVER SEEN magic. Not real magic. He'd seen Old Mag light a candle with a whispered word, and Sister Agathe bless the lanterns so they burned a little brighter at service, and once, when he was small, a traveling [Illusionist] at the summer fair who'd made silver fish swim through the air over the children's heads.

This was not that.

Elric Thorne raised his staff and said a word that was not a word, and the night split open.

Lightning came down out of a clear sky. It hit the leaping gloamhound in midair with a sound like the world being torn in half, so loud that Lex felt it in his chest more than heard it, and so bright that for a long moment afterward he could see nothing but a jagged purple afterimage burned across his eyes. When his sight cleared, the hound was gone. There was a

smoking black scorch mark on the cobbles where it had been, and a few wisps of dark mist curling up off it like steam off a horse, and that was all.

The other hounds didn't slow down.

They came on in a rush, seven of them, low and fast and whispering, and Elric met them. He moved like a man thirty years younger. His staff spun and cracked and spat blue fire, and every time it touched one of the hounds, the creature screamed, that thin, cold, glass-cracking scream, and came apart in rags of smoke. Lightning danced from his fingertips. It chained from hound to hound, leaping through the black mist in forks and branches, and the air filled with the smell of ozone and burning ash. One hound got its teeth into the hem of his cloak and he struck it with the butt of his staff and it burst like a soap bubble. Another came at him from the side and he turned without looking and a crackling bolt took it in the chest and flung it twenty feet back into the dark.

Lex stood frozen with the sledge in his hands and his mouth open.

Then a hound went past him.

It went wide around Elric, low to the ground, so fast it was only a smear of dark in the corner of Lex's eye, and it wasn't going for Lex at all. It was going for the Crooked Kettle. Where a door had just been flung open, and a small figure in a nightshirt had come stumbling out into the mist, rubbing his eyes, calling, "*Mam? Mam, what's happening, what's that noise—*"

Pell.

Pell had been sleeping over at the Kettle. He did that sometimes, when his da had been at the ale.

Lex didn't think. He moved.

He ran across the green with the sledge in both hands and his boots skidding on the wet cobbles, and the hound reached the boy a heartbeat before he did. It reared up, all black smoke and white eyes and a mouth that opened far, far too wide. Pell screamed. Lex didn't. He swung the sledge sideways with everything he had, the way he'd swung it ten thousand times at ten thousand glowing billets, and twelve pounds of cold black iron caught the gloamhound square in the ribs.

It was like hitting wet sand. The hammer went *into* the creature, and the hound screamed and flew sideways and crashed against the wall of the

Kettle, and for a moment it came apart, a burst of black smoke spattering across the whitewash like ink.

Then it pulled itself back together.

It took a second. Lex watched it happen. The scattered smoke drew back in, curling, folding, packing itself down into the shape of a hound again, and the white eyes opened, and it turned toward him.

"*Get inside,*" Lex said to Pell, not looking at him. "*Get inside and bar the door. Go. Go!*"

He heard the boy scramble backward, the door slam.

The hound came at him.

He swung again. It ducked. It was fast, so much faster than him, and it went under the hammer and its teeth closed on his left forearm.

He'd been burned before. Every smith had. He'd burned his hands and his arms and once, memorably, the back of his neck, and he knew what it felt like when hot iron touched skin.

This was the opposite.

The cold went into him like a nail. It went through the skin and the muscle and into the bone and up his arm and into his shoulder and down into his chest, and everywhere it went, things *stopped*. His arm went numb. His fingers opened on their own and the sledge thudded into the mist at his feet. The cold reached his heart and his heart stuttered. He couldn't breathe. His vision was going grey at the edges, grey like the hedgerows, grey like the grass, all the color draining out of the world, and somewhere very far away he could hear the hound's whisper, close now, right against his ear, wet and pleased and hungry: *Bright. Bright. Warm. Mine.*

A red panel opened in front of his eyes.

WARNING: HEALTH CRITICAL

Health: 31/140

STATUS: GLOAM-TOUCHED

Vitality draining (-6/sec)

He was going to die.

He knew it with total clarity, the way he'd known about the slag pocket in the horseshoe that morning. He was going to die on the village green, in the mist, with a monster made of smoke hanging off his arm, and Brannoc

would find him in the morning grey and cold and white-eyed like the Tanners' sheep, and that would be that. Lex Harrow. Smith. Common grade. Level nine. Cap twenty-four.

No, he thought.

It wasn't brave. It wasn't defiant. It was simpler than that. It was the same stubbornness that had kept him at the anvil every morning for eight years. The same stubbornness that had made him refuse, at four years old, to give up an iron horseshoe nail he'd found in the road. *No. Mine. I'm keeping it.*

No. Not like this. Not cold.

And deep inside him, under the cold, under the grey, behind a door he'd been walking past his whole life, something heard him.

The door didn't open.

It *broke*.



IT STARTED IN HIS chest, in the place right under his breastbone where the cold had stopped his heart, and it was heat. Not warmth. *Heat*. The heat of the forge at full blast, of iron at white glow, of the sun on a summer anvil. It came roaring up out of some place he hadn't known was there, and the cold didn't so much retreat in front of it as simply *cease to be*, the way frost ceases to be when you hold a torch to it. His heart slammed back into motion, once, twice, hard as a hammer. Color flooded back into the world. His left arm, his numb, dead left arm, filled with a burning so fierce he cried out, and the gloamhound clamped on it *screamed*.

It let go. It reeled back. Smoke was pouring off its jaws where they'd touched him, black smoke turning grey, turning white, and Lex looked down at his arm and saw that his skin was *glowing*. Faintly. Gold. Like iron just beginning to take the heat. The bite wounds in it were sizzling shut.

The world went still.

Not stopped. Still. The hound hung in the air, reeling backward, frozen in place like a fly in amber. The mist had stopped moving. A drop of water hanging from the eave of the Crooked Kettle had stopped halfway through its fall and hung there, catching the light. There was no sound at all except his own heartbeat, slow and enormous.

And in front of his eyes, the silver panel of his status *cracked*.

He watched it happen. A fine line ran across the silver text like a crack running across ice. Then another. Then a hundred, a spiderweb of them, spreading outward from the center. Light shone through the cracks. Gold light. Warm and deep, the color of embers in a banked fire. And then the silver shattered completely, fell away in glittering pieces that dissolved before they hit the ground, and behind it, waiting, as if it had been waiting all along, was something else.

SEAL INTEGRITY: 58% ▼

Fracture detected – primary lock

GUARDIAN CONSTRUCT ... waking

GUARDIAN CONSTRUCT ... ONLINE

And a voice spoke inside his head.

It wasn't loud. It wasn't frightening. It was a man's voice, dry and calm and very precise, with an odd old-fashioned courtesy to it, like a schoolmaster or a country doctor. It sounded, absurdly, as if it had just been woken from a nap and was trying very hard not to be cross about it.

[Ah,] said the voice. [Hello. You must be the smith.]

Lex said, out loud, "What?"

[I'll take that as a yes. Good evening. Please don't panic; we haven't time. I've slowed your perception as much as I can, but I'm running on very little power and it won't last. In approximately four seconds that creature is going to resume trying to eat you.] A pause. *[I would like to prevent that. I imagine you would as well.]*

"Who are you?"

[Later. Questions later, survival now. You have a choice to make, and you have to make it quickly.]

The gold text rippled and rewrote itself.

HIDDEN CLASS AVAILABLE

EMBERWRIGHT

Grade: UNIQUE

"Sorcery through making."

The Emberwright shapes heat, metal
and mana as one material, striking
runes into iron, flesh and air.

Replaces: Smith (Common)

Level cap: NONE

ACCEPT? [YES] [NO]

He stared at it.

Level cap: none.

[That,] said the voice in his head, [is the class that was always meant to be yours. The Smith class was a disguise. A coat of paint on a forge-door. The paint has just come off.] A pause. [I won't pretend this is a small decision. If you accept, you will stop being invisible. Things will come looking for you. Some of them will be worse than this one. If you refuse, I will do my best to patch the seal back together, and you may go on being a smith, and possibly die in the next four seconds anyway.] Another pause, a fraction gentler. [But it's your choice. It was always going to have to be your choice.]

Lex looked past the panel at the frozen hound. At the black mist pooled around the cottages. At the door of the Crooked Kettle, where Pell was hiding, and Mother Orla, and all the people he'd known his whole life.

He thought of Brannoc, level twenty-four for nineteen years.

He thought of three years of the number four.

Level cap: none.

"Yes," he said.

[Thank you,] said the voice, and it sounded, oddly, relieved. [I'd hoped you'd say that. Brace yourself. This part is—]

The world started again.



THE HEAT HIT HIM like a wave hitting a seawall.

It wasn't pain, exactly. It was *more*. More of everything: more breath in his lungs, more blood in his veins, more light in his eyes. He felt his whole body ring like a struck bell, felt the note of it go down to his bones and come back up changed. Somewhere very deep inside him a fire that had been banked for fifteen years caught a full draft of air and *roared*.

The text was pouring past his eyes faster than he could read it.

CLASS ACCEPTED: EMBERWRIGHT
Level 1
SPIRIT unmasked: 4 → 22
Mana: 220 / 220
SKILL GAINED: Ember Strike
SKILL EVOLVED: Heat Sense → Forge Sense
SKILL SEALED: Runic Forging (requires forge)

The hound landed. It shook itself, scattering smoke, and turned its white eyes on him, and something in its blank whisper had changed. *Bright*, it hissed. *Too bright. Too bright. Bright.*

It was afraid.

Lex bent and picked up the sledge.

The moment his hand touched the haft, the iron *woke*. That was the only word for it. The dull black head of the hammer began to glow, the deep red of iron in the fire, then cherry, then orange. Heat poured off it in waves that set the mist steaming. The hickory haft should have charred in his grip; it didn't. The heat ran from his chest down his arm and into the iron like water down a channel, and the iron drank it and asked for more, and he knew, without anyone telling him, without understanding how he knew, exactly what to do.

[Ember Strike,] said the voice, quiet and approving. *[You already know how. You've been doing it for years. You just never had anything to put into it.]*

The hound leaped.

Lex swung.

It was the most natural thing in the world. It was the swing he'd made a hundred thousand times, from the shoulder, from the hips, with the whole weight of his body behind it, with the heat in his chest pouring out

through his arms and into the iron at the exact moment of impact. *Chang.* The hammer met the hound in midair. There was a flash of gold light, so bright that it threw every shadow on the green out long and black behind it, and a sound like a hammer striking an anvil the size of a church.

The gloamhound didn't scream this time. It didn't have time. It simply *ignited*, from the inside out, like a handful of straw thrown into a furnace. One moment it was there, black and white-eyed and hungry. The next it was a burst of gold sparks drifting down through the mist, winking out one by one as they fell.

The hammer in his hands was glowing white.

Gloamhound defeated.

+XP

LEVEL UP!

Emberwright – Level 2

Lex stood on the green with the hammer smoking in his fists and the sparks falling around him like gold snow, breathing hard.

[Well,] said the voice in his head, sounding pleased and slightly surprised. *[That went better than I expected. Nicely done, Smith.]*

"Don't call me Smith."

[I'm afraid it's the only name I have for you at the moment. My memory partitions are mostly locked. I know what you are. I don't yet know who.] A pause. *[We'll work on it. Meanwhile, there are five more of those things on the green, and the old gentleman with the lightning is very good but he's beginning to tire.]*

Lex turned.

Across the green, through the swirling dark mist, Elric Thorne was fighting with his back to the Lattice Stone. The blue fire on his cloak had dimmed. His staff was moving slower. Three gloamhounds were circling him, darting in and out, and two more were slinking around behind the chapel, toward the little row of cottages where the Dunstans lived, where a lamp had just been lit in an upstairs window.

Lex hefted the hammer. It hummed in his hands like a living thing.

"How many more of these can I do?" he asked.

[You have two hundred and twenty mana. Each Ember Strike at your current rank costs fifteen. Do the arithmetic.] A pause. [But I'd advise against doing all of them at once. You've just come out of a fifteen-year sleep. Your body isn't used to this. If you spend too much too fast, you'll fall over.]

"Noted," said Lex, and ran.



HE DIDN'T FALL OVER.

Afterward, he remembered the rest of the fight only in pieces, bright and disjointed, like scenes glimpsed through gaps in a fence. A gloamhound bursting into gold sparks against the wall of the chapel. The Dunstans' door slamming shut behind a small, terrified face. Elric's lightning and his own fire striking the same hound at the same moment, from two sides, and the sound it made: lightning and fire together, a crack and a roar. A hound's teeth raking his shoulder and the bite smoking shut a moment later as the heat in his blood burned the cold out of it. The silver-gold panels flickering past at the edge of his vision every time something died.

LEVEL UP!

Emberwright – Level 3

LEVEL UP!

Emberwright – Level 4

He remembered the last one. It was the biggest, nearly the size of a pony, and it came at him out of the black mist at the bottom of the north road, where the mist was thickest, and he could see the other mist still pouring down the lane behind it, more and more, as if it would never stop. He remembered thinking, *There's no end to them. There's going to be no end.* He remembered planting his feet on the cobbles and raising the hammer and feeling the heat in his chest flicker, low now, dangerously low, like a fire burned down to its last coals.

And he remembered Elric Thorne stepping up beside him, gasping, his face grey with exhaustion, and raising his staff one last time, and saying, between breaths, "Together. On three. One—two—"

They struck at the same moment. Lightning and fire. The hound vanished in a burst of blue and gold.

And as it died, the black mist on the north road shivered. It drew back. Slowly at first, then faster, like a tide going out, it slid back up the lane, over the crest of the hill, away up into the dark of the mountains, leaving behind it a trail of grey grass and grey hedgerows and a gate gone soft and pale as bread.

Then it was gone. And the silver Veil came drifting back down over the village, and the night was only a night, cold and wet and very quiet.

Lex let the hammer fall. It hit the cobbles with a dull clank, its glow fading from orange to red to black. His legs gave out at last, and he sat down hard on the wet ground with his back against the Lattice Stone, which was warm, he noticed vaguely. Warm as a hearthstone.

Elric Thorne sat down next to him, slowly, with a small groan, and laid his staff across his knees.

For a while neither of them said anything at all.

Across the green, doors were beginning to open. Lanterns were being lit. Someone was crying. Someone else was laughing in the high, shaky way people laugh when they have just found out they are not going to die. Brannoc's huge shape was lumbering toward them through the mist, shouting Lex's name.

"Well," said Elric at last, without opening his eyes. "That answers that, I suppose."

"What were they?"

"I told you. Gloamhounds."

"That's a name. That's not an answer."

"No," Elric agreed. "It isn't." He opened his eyes and turned his head and looked at Lex, and his face in the faint gold light still glowing off the Stone was very old and very serious. "They were the reason your father went away, Lex. And they're getting bolder. They came here tonight because they felt your seal crack. They were drawn by it, the way moths are drawn to a lamp." He paused. "They'll be back. Them, or worse."

Lex looked down at his hands. They were shaking. They were his hands, a smith's hands, scarred and calloused and familiar. They were also, very faintly, glowing.

He closed them into fists, and the glow went out.

And in the back of his mind, in the place where the door had been and wasn't anymore, a dry, calm, courteous voice cleared its throat.

[Excuse me,] it said. [I hate to interrupt. But I believe the gentleman is right, and I believe we should discuss this. Preferably before morning.] A pause. [Because the Wardens of the Lattice will also have felt that. And unlike the hounds, they know exactly where Ashbourne is.]

CHAPTER 3

WHAT WAS LEFT ON THE ANVIL



BY THE TIME THE sky over the Greyspine had begun to pale, half of Ashbourne was crowded into Brannoc's forge, and the other half was standing outside it in the mist, trying to see in.

Lex sat on the upturned bucket Pell usually claimed, with a blanket around his shoulders that he didn't need and a mug of Mother Orla's spiced cider in his hands that he hadn't touched. He was warm. He was so warm. The heat in his chest hadn't gone back to sleep after the fight; it had settled down to a steady glow, like coals banked under ash, and he could feel it in his fingertips and the soles of his feet and the backs of his eyes. When people came close to him, they flinched a little, as if they'd stepped too near a stove.

People kept coming close anyway.

"He saved my Pell," Mother Orla was telling anyone who would listen, and several who wouldn't. She'd been crying on and off for an hour and showed no sign of stopping. "I saw it. I saw it from the window. That thing had its mouth open like a barn door and Lex just *walloped* it, walloped it right into my wall, and there's a stain there now, I don't know how I'm going to get it out—"

"I saw him *glowing*," said one of the Dunstan twins.

"He blew one up," said the other. "It went *pfoom*."

"It went *pfoom*," the first agreed, with deep satisfaction.

"Lex," said Pell, for perhaps the fortieth time. The boy had attached himself to Lex's side like a burr to a sheep, and his eyes were enormous.

"Lex. Lex, are you a sorcerer? Are you a real one? Can you do it again? Can you show me? Lex—"

"Pell," said Brannoc, from the anvil, "let the lad breathe."

Not everyone was pleased.

Reeve Dunstan stood near the door with his arms folded tight across his narrow chest, and he was looking at Lex the way he might have looked at a dog that had started talking. Behind him, a knot of older villagers muttered among themselves. Lex caught words. *Wildcaster. Unlatticed. His brother.* That last one more than once. *Same blood. Same as his brother. You remember what happened then.*

Old Mag the herbwoman, ninety and half-blind, sat on the bench by the forge with her stick across her knees and said nothing at all. But whenever Lex looked at her, he found her one good eye already on him, bright and thoughtful and not at all surprised.

And Elric Thorne sat at the end of the workbench with his long legs stretched out and his eyes closed, as if he were asleep, while Quill the raven perched on his shoulder and kept watch over the room with the satisfied air of a bird who'd been right about something.

[You're very popular,] said the voice in Lex's head.

Lex didn't answer. He'd discovered, in the last hour, that if he spoke to the voice aloud, people stared. He'd also discovered that if he simply *thought* at it, very deliberately, it heard him.

Are you going to stay? he thought.

[In your head? I'm afraid so. I'm bound to the seal, and the seal is bound to you. Where you go, I go.] A pause. *[I'll try to be a considerate tenant.]*

What are you?

[That's a much harder question than it sounds.] The voice was quiet for a moment, as if thinking. *[I can tell you what I know. I'm a guardian construct: a working, placed inside your seal, meant to wake when the seal broke and guide you through what came after. I have knowledge: of the Lattice, of its workings, of things like Root and Authority. I have a purpose. Beyond that...]* Another pause. *[Beyond that, my memory is divided into partitions, and most of them are locked. I don't know who made me. I don't know when. I know how to talk, and I know a great deal about metallurgy,*

which is odd, and I appear to have opinions about the correct way to brew tea. That's about the extent of it.]

That's not very much.

[No. I was hoping you'd be less observant.]

Despite everything, Lex felt the corner of his mouth twitch.

Do you have a name?

[Guardian Construct, technically.]

I'm not calling you Guardian Construct.

[I'd rather hoped you wouldn't.]

Lex looked into the forge, where the fire had settled at last to a low, steady orange glow. He thought of the gold text breaking through the silver, the color of coals banked for the night.

Ember, he thought. I'm going to call you Ember.

There was a long silence in his head.

[Ember,] the voice repeated at last, slowly, as if trying the word for size. And then, in a tone Lex couldn't quite read, something that might almost have been emotion, if a working could feel such a thing: *[Yes. Yes, I think that will do very well. Thank you, Lex.]*

It was the first time it had used his name.



IT TOOK ANOTHER HOUR for Brannoc to clear the forge.

He did it the way Brannoc did everything: patiently, kindly and with total immovability. He thanked Mother Orla for the cider and pressed her hand. He told the Dunstan twins that if they wanted to see anything else go *pfoom* they could come back after they'd done their chores, and then he'd see what he could arrange. He told Pell, gently, that Lex needed sleep, and that a good friend would go home and let him have it. And when Reeve Dunstan opened his mouth to say something about the Order and the law and what happened to people who harbored wildcasters, Brannoc simply stood up from the anvil, all six and a half feet of him, and looked down at the Reeve without saying anything at all, until the Reeve closed his mouth again and went away.

Old Mag was the last to leave. She hobbled to the door on her stick, and paused in it, and turned her head to look back at Lex with her one good eye.

"Your mother knew," she said.

Lex went still.

"Not about the fire. Not about your brother. She didn't see that coming, poor thing, or she'd never have let him near that Stone." Old Mag's voice was thin and dry as old paper. "But she knew what you were. Both of you. She came to me once, the year after your father left, and asked me for herbs to help a child sleep through a fever that wasn't a fever. Said you'd been running hot." She sniffed. "I told her there wasn't a herb in the Vale for what ailed you. She said she knew. She said she just needed something to *do*."

"Mag," Lex said, "did she ever tell you what my father was?"

The old woman considered him for a long moment.

"She told me he was a good man who made a hard choice," she said. "And that she'd have made the same one." She turned and hobbled out into the grey morning. Over her shoulder, without looking back, she added, "She also said you'd be a menace once you woke up. She was right about that too."

The door swung shut behind her.



THEN IT WAS JUST the three of them, and Slag the cat, and Quill the raven, and the voice in Lex's head.

Brannoc put a kettle on the coals, because Brannoc's response to every crisis was to put a kettle on, and came and sat down heavily on the bench across from Lex. Elric opened his eyes. Nobody said anything for a while.

"Right," said Brannoc at last. "I'd like to know what I've been raising for eight years. If it's not too much trouble."

Elric smiled faintly. "That depends how much you know about the Lattice, Master Holt."

"I know it's there. I know it gives you a class. I know it tells you when you've gone up a level and when you've hit your cap." Brannoc's beard twitched. "I hit mine nineteen years ago. I know a lot about that part."

"Most people know about that much. It's all the Wardens want most people to know." Elric shifted on the bench, wincing; he'd strained something in the fight, Lex thought, though he hadn't complained. "Let me tell you a little more. Stop me if it sounds like heresy. It probably is."

He held up one knotted hand.

"Nine hundred years ago, give or take, the world almost ended. You'll have heard stories of the Sundering, the war of the sorcerer-kings, when magic was wild and anyone with enough of it could do anything they liked. Most of the stories are wrong about the details, but they're right about the scale. Mountains were moved. Seas were boiled. Whole kingdoms burned in a night. And at the end of it, a handful of the greatest mages left alive got together and decided it could never happen again." He turned his hand palm-up. "So they built the Lattice."

"Built it," said Brannoc. "I was always told the Lady made it. That it was her gift."

"The Wardens encourage that belief. It's tidier." Elric shrugged. "But no. People made it. Very great people, and very frightened ones. They wove a net of power over the whole world, a working so vast it's still running nine hundred years later, and every person born under it is caught in it. It *rationes* magic. Gives every man and woman a shape, a class, a set of skills, a ladder of levels, and lets them climb as far as the ladder goes and no farther. No more sorcerer-kings. No more wild power. Everything ordered. Everything in its place."

"The Ceiling," said Brannoc quietly.

"The Ceiling," Elric nodded. "Though I'll tell you a secret, Master Holt, and you can decide for yourself what you think of it. The Founders didn't build a Ceiling. Not like the one you know. Their Lattice let anyone climb as high as their talent would take them. Slowly, carefully, with trials and tests at every tier, but *anyone*." His mouth thinned. "The Ceiling came later. The Wardens added it. Three hundred years ago, give or take. Common classes stop at twenty-four, and to climb past that you need a Warden's Sanction, and a Warden's Sanction costs a great deal of money and a great deal of the right kind of birth." He looked at the big smith steadily. "You were never meant to stop at twenty-four, Brannoc. Nobody was. You were *stopped*."

The kettle began to sing on the coals. Nobody moved to take it off.

Brannoc's face had gone very still. He was staring at his own hands, the great scarred hands that had been working iron for forty years.

"Nineteen years," he said at last, very quietly.

"I'm sorry," said Elric. And he sounded it.

Lex looked at Brannoc's bowed head and felt something in his chest, the heat, the banked fire, flare suddenly hot. He didn't know what it was. Anger, maybe. A great, slow, smoldering anger that had nowhere to go yet.

He made himself breathe. The heat settled.

"And the Wardens," he said. "They're the ones who keep the Lattice?"

"Keep it. Maintain it. Police it. Profit from it." Elric took the kettle off the coals at last, and poured three mugs of something that smelled like bark and burnt honey. "They have a great tower in Highcrest called the Spire, and a great Stone at the top of it, and from that Stone, the senior Wardens can see a little further into the Lattice than the rest of us. Not far. But far enough to set Sanctions, and to grant and revoke certain permissions, and to see when something happens that shouldn't." He handed Lex a mug. "Like a flare of gold light from a village Stone in the middle of the night."

"You said gold was Root," Lex said. "What does that mean?"

"Ah." Elric sat back. "That's the interesting part."

[It certainly is,] said Ember.

"The Lattice has layers," said Elric. "Most people only ever see the top one. The silver. Their own status, their own skills. The Wardens see a little deeper, into the second layer, where the permissions are kept. But under that, at the very bottom, there's a third layer. The foundation. The Founders called it the Root. It's where the Lattice's rules are actually written, and the only people who can touch it are people of the Founders' blood." He looked at Lex over the rim of his mug. "One Founder in particular. The greatest of them. The one who designed the whole thing. And his line has been very, very thin for a very long time."

"My father," Lex said.

"Your father was born with Root in his blood. So were you. So was your brother." Elric set down his mug. "That's what a seal is for, Lex. Not to take your power away. You can't take Root out of someone; it's in the bones. A seal *hides* it. Paints it over. Makes the Lattice see a Smith where

there's a—" He paused. "What *did* it give you, in the end? I saw the fire. I didn't see the class."

Lex hesitated. Then he called up his status.



IT CAME UP GOLD now. Not silver. Gold, with a faint silver ghost of the old panel visible behind it, like a reflection in a window.

LEX HARROW		
Age: 19		
Class: EMBERWRIGHT (Unique)		
Level: 4	Cap: -	
XP: 18%		
MIG 16	AGI 9	VIT 14
INT 16	SPI 28	RES 15
Free points: 18		
Health	140/140	
Mana	104/280	
Stamina	150/150	
SKILLS		
Ember Strike Novice 4		
Forge Sense Apprentice 3		
Smithing Journeyman 3		
Hammer Use Apprentice 7		
Endurance Apprentice 5		
Runic Forging ... [SEALED]		
ROOT		
Seal integrity: 58%		
Authority: 9 / 100		
Prerogatives: True Sight		

He read it out loud, slowly. Brannoc's eyebrows climbed with every line. When he got to the class name, Elric made a small sound.

"Emberwright," the old man repeated. "Unique."

"Is that bad?"

"It's *unheard of*." Elric leaned forward, his storm-grey eyes very bright. "Unique classes appear perhaps once in a generation. There hasn't been one recorded in the Spire's archives in sixty years. And I've never heard of that one at all." He let out a breath. "No cap. Of course. Of course he'd hide a Unique under a Common. It's exactly the sort of joke Arion would make."

[It's a good class,] said Ember, sounding faintly defensive, as if Lex's class were something it had made itself and was being criticized. *[It's a very good class. It suits you.]*

"What are free points?" Brannoc asked.

"Every time you gain a level," Elric said, "the Lattice gives you a few points to put where you like. Common classes get three. Rare get four. Unique classes..."

"Six," said Lex, reading.

Elric closed his eyes briefly. "Of course they do."

[You should spend them,] said Ember. *[You've been fighting at the strength of a level-nine smith with a level-four sorcerer's mana pool. It's lopsided. Every time you swing that hammer, your body is working harder than it was built for.]*

What do you suggest?

[Vitality, first. You were badly hurt last night, and the gloam-cold went deeper than you think. More health will help you heal. Then Agility, because you are, if you'll forgive me, rather slow. Then Spirit, because Spirit is your weapon.] A pause. *[But it's your body. You know it better than I do.]*

Lex thought about it. He thought about the gloamhound ducking under his swing. He thought about the cold in his bones.

He put five points into Vitality, five into Agility, four into Spirit, two into Might and two into Resolve, and felt each one go into him like a swallow of something hot: a stretch and a settling in his muscles, a sharpening in his eyes, a deepening of the fire in his chest.

POINTS ALLOCATED		
MIG 18	AGI 14	VIT 19
INT 16	SPI 32	RES 17
Health	190/190	
Mana	120/320	
Stamina	185/185	

He flexed his hands. They felt the same and not the same, like a familiar tool newly sharpened.

"Better?" Elric asked.

"Different."

"It will feel strange for a few days. The body takes time to grow into its numbers." Elric's gaze sharpened. "Now. You said Root. Prerogatives. True Sight?"

[A Root power,] Ember explained, as Lex hesitated. [The first and simplest. It lets you see what the Lattice sees, about anyone. Their true status, including the parts they'd rather hide. It costs Authority, which you don't have much of, and which comes back slowly. One point to use it.] A pause. [I'd recommend trying it. Carefully.]

Lex looked at Elric.

He didn't mean to. Not really. He just looked, the way you'd look at anyone across a table, and he thought *True Sight* in the deliberate way he'd learned to talk to Ember, and he felt something behind his eyes go *hot*.

The world flickered gold.

And floating in the air over Elric Thorne's grey head, there was suddenly a panel. Gold, like his own. Lines of text unrolling.

ELRIC THORNE		
Age: 61		
Class: STORMCALLER (Epic)		
Tier III – Level 67		
MIG 12	AGI 21	VIT 18
INT 44	SPI 51	RES 30
Titles: Warden (revoked)		
Tempest of Varrow Ford		
Sanction history:		
Tier II – GRANTED		
Tier III – GRANTED		
Tier IV – DENIED (×3)		

Denied three times, Lex thought. He didn't know why that one line caught at him. It was the only one in the panel that didn't seem to be about power. It seemed to be about something else.

"Don't," said Elric sharply.

The gold flickered and went out. Lex blinked. The old sorcerer was looking at him with an expression that was half amusement and half something much less comfortable.

"Your eyes," Elric said. "They go gold when you do that. Like coins in a fire. Anyone who knows what to look for will know exactly what you're doing." He picked up his mug again, a little too deliberately. "And it's rude, Lex. Reading a man's status without asking. It's like reading his letters."

"Sorry," Lex said. And then, because he couldn't help himself: "Who denied you Tier Four?"

Elric's hand stopped halfway to his mouth.

"The Spire did," he said after a moment. "Twice." He drank. "And once, someone else."

He didn't say who. And Lex, looking at the old man's lined face in the firelight, didn't ask.



THEY TALKED UNTIL THE light through the door had gone from grey to pale gold.

Elric told them what he could. That the black mist was called the Gloam, and that it had first appeared sixteen years ago in the eastern march of Vhessa, and that it came from *somewhere else*, from cracks in the Lattice itself, the way water comes up through cracks in a cellar floor. That it had been spreading ever since, slowly, quietly, the Wardens hushing up every report. That whole villages in the east had gone silent. That the Order called it a *blight*, a natural thing, a disease of the land, and burned whatever it touched, and arrested anyone who said otherwise.

That Arion Vey had been among the first Wardens sent to investigate it. And that he'd come back from the east with a face like a man who'd seen his own grave, and had refused to say what he'd found, and had vanished not long after.

"He knew something," Elric said. "Something about the Gloam, and the Lattice, and why it was breaking. He wouldn't tell me what. He said it was safer if I didn't know." His mouth twisted. "He always did think he knew best."

"And now he's dying," Lex said.

"Now his seal is failing. Which means he's in trouble. Dying, maybe. Or trapped, or hurt, or giving everything he has to something else." Elric

looked at him steadily. "I don't know which. I want to find out. And I can't do it without you."

"Why not?"

"Because I've been looking for eleven years and I've found nothing. Because wherever he's gone, he's gone there by Root, and Root paths can only be walked by Root blood." Elric paused. "And because, if your seal fails completely, if he dies and the last of it gives way, it won't crack, Lex. It'll *shatter*. Everything that's been held back for fifteen years will come through at once. And without someone to guide you through it, it might do to you what it did to your brother."

The forge went very quiet.

"What do you mean," Lex said slowly, "what it did to my brother?"

Elric looked at him for a long moment. Then he looked at Brannoc, and something passed between them that Lex couldn't read.

"Not tonight," Elric said quietly. "You've had enough for one night. On the road. I'll tell you everything I know about Anthoren on the road."

"Tell me now."

The fire in the hearth jumped.

"Lex," said Brannoc gently.

Lex looked at him. At the old smith's tired, kind, soot-streaked face. And he made himself breathe, and the fire settled.

"On the road," he said. "Fine." He stood up. His legs had stopped shaking. The heat in his chest had settled to a steady, comfortable burn, like a well-fed hearth. "So I'm leaving, then."

"You have to," said Elric. "The Wardens will have seen that flare. The nearest garrison is at Millbridge, two days' ride south. They'll send someone. Probably someone unpleasant." He rose too, leaning heavily on his staff. "We should be gone by noon."

"Noon," Lex repeated. He looked around the forge. The anvil. The racks of tools. The slack tub and the bellows and the brick ledge where Slag was curled asleep. Eight years of his life. "Fine," he said again.

And then, because there was something he needed to do first, and he'd only just realized what it was: "But not without a hammer."



THE SKILL HAD BEEN sealed. *Runic Forging: requires forge.*

He felt it unseal the moment he set his hand on the anvil.

It wasn't dramatic. There was no burst of gold light, no shattering of silver text. Just a small, warm *click* somewhere behind his eyes, like a key turning in a well-oiled lock, and a line of gold writing at the edge of his vision.

SKILL UNSEALED: Runic Forging

Novice 1

"What is struck with intent remembers."

And suddenly he could see them.

The runes. They were everywhere. In the grain of the iron on the rack. In the flicker of the coals. In the air itself, when the heat-shimmer rose off the hearth: faint shapes, half-formed, the way you sometimes see faces in the bark of a tree. Shapes he'd seen a thousand times and never noticed. Shapes he almost understood.

[Wellscrip,] said Ember softly. [The language the Lattice is written in. The language under language. Every made thing has a little of it in it, if it was made well. Most smiths never see it. You've been seeing it for years without knowing what it was. That's how you hear the flaws.]

Can I write it?

[With a hammer? Yes. That's what an Emberwright does.] A pause. [I can show you a few. Simple ones. You'll learn more as you go.]

Lex went to the rack at the back of the forge, the one where Brannoc kept his best stock, the good Saltreach bar-iron that came up the river once a year and cost more than the village earned in a season. He took the heaviest bar. Then he stopped. Then he reached into the pocket of his trousers and took out the thing he always carried there.

It was a horseshoe nail. Old, black, slightly bent, worn smooth by fifteen years of a boy's fingers. He'd found it in the road outside the old cottage when he was four, the day after his father left, and he'd refused to let it go. He'd had it in his pocket the night of the fire. It was the only thing he still owned from the life before.

[That nail,] said Ember, very quietly.

What about it?

There was a long silence.

[I don't know,] Ember said at last, and it sounded troubled. *[I remember it. I think. Something about it. It's in one of the locked partitions.]* A pause. *[Put it in the hammer, Lex. I think it wants to be there.]*

He didn't ask how a nail could want anything. He laid it on the bar and folded the bar over it, and put the whole thing into the fire.



BRANNOC STRUCK FOR HIM.

That was how it was done, in the old way, for big work: one smith holding the piece and shaping it with a hand hammer, the other swinging the sledge where the first one pointed. The striker and the smith. They hadn't worked like that in years. Not since Lex was fifteen, and his arms had gotten strong enough to swing the sledge himself.

Brannoc didn't say anything. He just picked up the big sledge, the one Lex had used the night before, its head still faintly scorched, and took his place on the other side of the anvil, and waited.

They worked.

Lex pulled the folded bar from the fire when it reached the color of a sunrise. He laid it on the anvil and touched it with his hand hammer, *tink*, and Brannoc's sledge came down where he'd touched, *CHANG*, and the iron spread and lengthened under the blow. *Tink. CHANG. Tink. CHANG.* The old rhythm. Lex could do it in his sleep. His body knew it the way it knew breathing.

But this time, every time his hand hammer touched the iron, he put something into it.

He didn't know how to describe it, even to himself. It was like the Ember Strike, but smaller and more careful. A thread of heat, a thread of *intent*, flowing out of his chest and down his arm and through the hammer into the metal. And as it went in, he *thought* the shape Ember was showing him: a rune like a flame folded over itself, a rune like a closed fist, a rune like a road curving home. *Ardent. Steadfast. Homeward.* The iron took them. He could feel it taking them. Each one sank into the metal like a drop of ink into water and spread through it and settled, and the iron's color

changed, very slightly, deepening from orange toward a rich red-gold that didn't belong to any heat he'd ever seen.

Brannoc noticed. Lex saw him notice. The old smith's eyes went wide, and then narrow, and then, very slowly, something in his face that Lex had never seen there before began to shine.

He didn't stop swinging.

They worked through the morning. They drew out the head and punched the eye and drifted it clean. They shaped the faces: one flat and broad for striking, one tapered to a wedge for splitting, the way Brannoc had taught him, the way you'd make a cross-peen hammer for the forge, only bigger, heavier, a hammer for a man to swing with both hands. Lex cut a haft from the seasoned ash in the rafters and fitted it and wedged it, and then he heated the head one last time and laid his palm flat against the iron.

It was hot enough to take the skin off a normal man's hand. It didn't burn him. It hummed.

He put one more rune into it. He didn't know where it came from; Ember hadn't shown it to him. It just rose up from somewhere deep inside him and went down his arm into the metal, a shape like an open hand held out in the dark. And as it sank into the iron, the whole hammer *rang*, a long, clear, singing note that went up into the rafters and set every chain and tool in the forge trembling, and went on, and on, fading slowly, like a bell at the end of a song.

Brannoc set down the sledge.

Lex quenched the hammer in the slack tub. The water didn't scream this time. It sang too, a low hiss that rose into something almost like a voice, and then it was quiet.

He lifted the hammer out. It was dark iron, almost black, with a faint red-gold sheen in its depths, like embers seen through smoked glass. It was heavy and perfectly balanced. When he held it, it felt like part of his arm.

ITEM CREATED	
ANVILSONG	
Two-handed war-hammer	
Grade: SUPERIOR	
Maker: Lex Harrow, Emberwright	
Runes:	
ARDENT	– stores heat; Ember Strike +25% power, –5 mana
STEADFAST	– cannot break while its maker lives
HOMEWARD	– returns to the maker's hand when called (30 paces)
???	– [unreadable]
"It remembers the hand that made it."	

Runic Forging – Novice 1 → Novice 6	
LEVEL UP!	
Emberwright – Level 5	

"Anvilsong," Lex said aloud. He didn't know where the name came from either. It was just there, written on the inside of his head, the way the last rune had been.

[Anvilsong,] Ember agreed quietly. [That fourth rune. I can't read it.] A long pause. [I don't think it's one of mine.]

Brannoc was looking at the hammer. He hadn't said a word in four hours. Now he reached out, slowly, as if afraid it might bite him, and laid one huge scarred finger against the iron of the head.

"It's warm," he said.

"It'll stay warm," said Lex. He knew that without knowing how he knew it. "As long as I'm alive."

Brannoc took his hand away. He stood there by the anvil for a long moment with his head down, and Lex saw his shoulders shake, once, and realized with a lurch that the old smith was crying.

"Brannoc—"

"Forty years," Brannoc said hoarsely. "Forty years I've been at this anvil. I've made ten thousand horseshoes. I've made ploughshares and hinges and kettles and nails, so many nails, and I was proud of every one, and I'd have

told you I was the best smith in the southern Vale and meant it." He wiped his face with the back of his wrist, smearing soot. "And I never knew it could *sing*."

Lex didn't know what to say. So he set the hammer down on the anvil and went around it and put his arms around the old man, the way he hadn't since he was eleven years old and crying in the wet grass outside a burning house. Brannoc's huge arms closed around him, and held on.

"She asked me to look after you," Brannoc said into his hair, very quietly. "Your mother. Once. Years before. She came by the forge with you on her hip and she said, *Brannoc, if anything ever happens to me, you look after my boys*. I laughed. I said what's going to happen to you, Seren? And she just looked at me." He was quiet for a moment. "I only managed the one of you. I'm sorry."

"You did fine," Lex said. His throat was very tight. "You did fine, Brannoc. You were—" He stopped. Tried again. "My father left. You stayed. That's all a father has to do. You *stayed*."

Brannoc made a sound like a laugh with something broken in the middle of it, and held on harder.



THEY LEFT AT NOON.

The whole village turned out to watch them go. Lex hadn't expected that. He'd expected to slip away quietly, the way his brother had, alone up the north road with nobody watching. Instead there were people lining the green: Mother Orla with a basket of bread and cheese she pressed into his arms, crying again; the Dunstan twins, solemnly demanding one more *pfloom* and being solemnly refused; Farmer Tobbin, who shook his hand and said gruffly that he'd find someone else to finish the ploughshare. Even Reeve Dunstan was there, standing at the back with his arms folded, and when Lex passed him the Reeve looked away and muttered something that might have been *good luck* and might have been *good riddance*.

Pell walked beside him all the way to the edge of the green.

"I could come," the boy said. "I could carry things. I'm good at carrying things. I'm strong. I carried a whole sack of flour once, all the way from the mill—"

"Pell," said Lex.

"I'd be useful. I would."

"I know you would." Lex stopped, at the edge of the cobbles, where the north road began. He put down the basket and crouched so that he was looking the boy in the eye. "That's why I need you to stay. Somebody has to look after Brannoc. Somebody has to look after the village. If those things come back—"

"I can't fight them. I'm not a sorcerer."

"Neither was I. Until last night." Lex held his gaze. "Nine days, Pell. Your Kindling's in nine days. And whatever the Stone says, whatever it tells you you are, I want you to remember something for me. Can you do that?"

Pell nodded, wide-eyed.

"It's not the end," said Lex. "Whatever it says. It's not the end of what you can be. It's just the beginning of what they'll *let* you be. And that's not the same thing." He stood and ruffled the boy's straw-colored hair. "Remember that."

He picked up the basket and turned to the road.

Brannoc was waiting there, at the very edge of the village, where the cobbles gave way to packed earth. He'd changed out of his apron into a clean shirt, which he did perhaps twice a year. He had a pack in one hand, stuffed full, and a purse in the other, and he held them both out to Lex without a word.

"I can't take your money."

"It's not mine. It's yours. Your wages. Eight years of 'em." Brannoc pushed the purse into his hand. "I've been putting a bit by. For when you'd want your own forge."

Lex looked at the purse. It was heavy. Much heavier than eight years of an apprentice's wages had any right to be.

"Brannoc—"

"Take it, lad. Take it and go find him." Brannoc's voice was rough. "Go find your father. And when you've found him, you look him in the eye, and you tell him from me that his son's the best smith I ever trained, and that if he wants to argue about it, he can come down to Ashbourne and argue with *me*."

Lex laughed. It came out wet. "I will."

"And come back."

"I will. I promise." Lex hefted Anvilsong onto his shoulder. The hammer was warm against his neck. "Hammer-oath."

Brannoc's face did something complicated. Then he put out his huge hand, and Lex clasped it, smith to smith, the way it had been done in the Vale for a thousand years. *What's struck on the anvil holds.*

"Hammer-oath," said Brannoc.

Then he let go, and stepped back, and Lex turned and walked up the north road, out of Ashbourne, with Elric Thorne beside him and the raven on Elric's shoulder and a voice in his head and the warm weight of the hammer across his back.

He didn't look back. He'd promised himself he wouldn't.

He looked once. He hadn't promised himself about that. Brannoc was still standing at the edge of the cobbles, enormous and alone, with one hand raised. Behind him the village lay small and grey in its valley, the mist thinning in the noon light, the cracked old Stone glinting on the green.

In the window of the forge, someone had lit a lantern. In the middle of the day.

A light left on for the lost.

Lex turned his face to the mountains and walked on.



THEY'D GONE PERHAPS A mile, climbing steadily, when Quill gave a sharp croak and launched himself off Elric's shoulder, circling up and back toward the south.

Elric stopped. He turned. Lex turned with him.

From up here, on the first rise of the foothills, you could see the whole of the Vale laid out below them: the patchwork fields, the silver thread of the river, the cluster of grey roofs that was Ashbourne. And beyond it, the south road, winding away toward Millbridge through the green hills.

There were riders on the road.

A dozen of them, maybe more. They were too far away to make out faces. But Lex could see the grey of their cloaks, all alike, and the glint of steel at their hips, and the banner the lead rider carried, snapping in the wind: a silver net on a field of grey. A lattice.

They were riding hard. Toward Ashbourne.

"That was fast," said Elric quietly. "That was very fast. Millbridge is two days' ride." He narrowed his eyes. "Unless they weren't coming from Millbridge. Unless they were already on their way."

"Already on their way? Why would they—"

"I don't know." Elric turned back to the mountains. His face was grim. "But I think we should walk faster."

[I concur,] said Ember.

Lex looked down at the village one last time, at the riders closing on it, at the tiny glint of a lantern in the forge window. The heat in his chest flared, hard and bright.

Then he shifted Anvilson on his shoulder, and turned his back on everything he'd ever known, and walked faster.

CHAPTER 4

THE ENIGMATIC BROTHER



THEY CAMPED THAT FIRST night in a fold of the foothills, where a stand of wind-bent pines broke the worst of the cold coming down off the Greyspine, and Lex lit the fire without touching it.

He didn't mean to. He'd gathered the kindling and stacked it the way Brannoc had taught him, and he'd crouched with the flint and steel in his hands, and he'd thought, idly, *catch*, the way you'd think it at any fire. And the kindling caught. All at once, with a soft *whump*, every twig flaring orange from the inside, as if it had been waiting.

He stared at it.

[You'll want to be careful with that,] Ember said mildly. [In a dry forest you might set fire to a county.]

"I didn't do anything."

[You did. You just did it without noticing. That's what happens when a power's been bottled for fifteen years. It leaks.] A pause. *[It'll settle as you learn to hold it. For now, try not to think "catch" around anything you're fond of.]*

Across the fire, Elric Thorne lowered himself onto a flat rock with a small groan and stretched his legs out toward the flames. Quill hopped down from his shoulder and began picking at a heel of Mother Orla's bread with the concentration of a jeweler.

"Talking to it again?" Elric asked.

Lex hesitated. He hadn't told Elric much about Ember. Only that there was a voice, and that it had helped him in the fight, and that it seemed to

know things about the Lattice. He hadn't told him about the courteous dry tone, or the jokes, or the way the voice sometimes paused before it spoke, as if choosing words with care.

He wasn't sure why he hadn't. It just felt private. Like a letter you hadn't finished reading.

"Sometimes," he said.

"Arion talked about constructs once. Long ago. A kind of working you could leave inside something to watch over it." Elric was looking into the fire. "I didn't know he'd ever made one. He never told me." He was quiet for a moment. "He never told me a great many things, it turns out."

Lex broke a piece of bread off the loaf and didn't eat it.

"You said you'd tell me about my brother," he said. "On the road. We're on the road."

Elric didn't look up from the fire. "So we are."

"So tell me."



"**EIGHT YEARS AGO,**" **ELRIC** said, "the Spire's Lattice Watch recorded an event at the Ashbourne Stone. I wasn't there. I'd left the Order by then. But I still had friends in the Spire, people who'd pass me a letter now and then, and one of them sent me a copy of the record because the name on it was *Harrow*, and she knew I'd been asking after a woman named Seren Harrow for years."

"You knew my mother?"

"I knew *of* her. Arion talked about her. Not often. When he did, he'd get a look on his face like a man warming his hands at a fire." Elric smiled faintly. "He never told me where she lived. Never told me her name was Harrow. I worked that out myself, years later, from a few things he'd let slip." His smile faded. "By then it was too late. By then the Lattice Watch had already filed its report."

"What did it say?"

Elric reached into his cloak and drew out a small leather folder, worn soft at the edges, tied with a strip of faded ribbon. He untied it carefully and took out a single sheet of paper, folded in thirds, and held it out across the fire.

Lex took it.

It was a copy, made in a tidy, cramped hand. The ink had faded to brown. At the top was the silver lattice sigil of the Wardens, drawn in pen.

LATTICE WATCH – INCIDENT RECORD

Station: Ashbourne (S. Vale, Caldor)

Event: KINDLING – ANOMALOUS

Subject: ANTHOREN HARROW, 16

Class assigned: ██████████

Grade: ERROR

Level at Kindling: 1 → 9 (!!)

Root signature: DETECTED (!!)

Secondary event, same night:

Breach (minor), duration 4 min.

Location: Harrow residence.

Fire. One fatality presumed.

Disposition: Subject fled. Classed

WILDCASTER / UNSTABLE.

Retrieval team dispatched.

Lex read it twice. The second time, his hands had started to shake, and he had to hold the paper against his knee to keep it still.

One fatality presumed.

His mother. Reduced to three words in a clerk's handwriting.

"Retrieval team," he said. His voice came out hoarse. "They sent people after him."

"They sent a team of six Wardens up into the Greyspine three weeks after the fire." Elric's voice was very even. "None of them came back. They sent another team the next spring. Two came back out of eight. They said the warlock of the Hollowmaw had been waiting for them. That he'd come out of the dark like a piece of the night tearing loose. That the dark *moved* for him." He paused. "They sent a third team the year after that, and a fourth, and then they stopped sending teams, because it was getting expensive, and because some bright clerk in the Spire realized it was cheaper to let the mountains keep him. The Hollowmaw went on the maps as forbidden ground. The traders at Thistledown started telling stories. And the mad warlock of the Greyspine became the sort of thing mothers frighten children with."

Lex stared at the paper. *Root signature: DETECTED.*

"He's like me," he said slowly. "Isn't he? He's got it too. The gold. The Root."

"He's exactly like you," said Elric. "That's the whole tragedy of it."

[*Lex,*] Ember said quietly in his head. [*Breathe.*]

He hadn't realized he'd stopped. He made himself do it. In. Out. The fire beside him, which had leaped up a foot higher in the last minute, settled slowly back down.

"Why?" he said. "If he's like me, if Father sealed him like he sealed me, why did his break? Why did it happen to *him*?"

Elric was quiet for a long moment.

"I've thought about that a great deal," he said at last. "I think it's because your seals weren't the same. Arion would have had to make them differently. You were four; your brother was nine. He was older, and his power was older, settled deeper. I'd guess your father put a lid on him. A good lid, a strong one, but a lid." Elric turned his hands over in the firelight, looking at them. "And a lid is only as strong as the hand holding it down. When your brother turned sixteen and put his hand on that Stone, the Lattice reached into him to give him his class, and it found Root under the lid, and it *pulled*. And the hand that should have been holding the lid down wasn't there."

"Because Father was gone."

"Because your father was gone. Away, somewhere, pouring himself into whatever it was he went to do. Feeding your seal, and your brother's, from a great distance, and getting weaker every year." Elric looked up. "Your seal was made to hold for a long time. Your brother's was made to hold until your father came back. He didn't come back."

"So it broke."

"It broke. All at once. At the worst possible moment, in front of a Lattice Stone, with the whole weight of the Lattice pulling on it. And whatever came through..." Elric shook his head. "I don't know what happened to him, Lex. I don't know what he saw or what he heard or what it did to his mind. But I know the Lattice didn't know what to make of him. *ERROR*. That's not a class. That's the Lattice throwing up its hands."

Lex folded the paper. He folded it very carefully, along the old creases, and handed it back across the fire.

"He killed her," he said.

"Did he?"

"*You read it.* One fatality. The fire was in our house. He was standing in the middle of it with his eyes black and that sound coming out of him and she was calling his name, and then she was gone, and he *walked away.*" Lex's voice cracked. He clenched his jaw until it stopped. "He walked away and he didn't look back. He left me there."

"I know," said Elric softly.

"So don't ask me *did he.*"

"I'm sorry. You're right." Elric tucked the folder back into his cloak. "But I'll tell you something, and you can do what you like with it. I've known a great many people who did terrible things, Lex. Some of them meant to. Most of them didn't. And I've learned that what a person does in the worst moment of their life is not always the whole of who they are." He met Lex's eyes across the fire. "Your father taught me that, actually. Ironic, given everything."

Lex looked away into the dark.

Up on the mountains, very far away, a wind was blowing across the snowfields. He could hear it, faintly, a long cold sighing.

"Why are you telling me this?" he said. "Why now? Why does it matter what happened to him?"

Elric was silent for a moment. Then he reached into his cloak again, deeper this time, into some inner pocket against his chest. And he drew out a second paper.

This one wasn't a copy. It was a letter, written on thick cream stock gone yellow with age, sealed once with blue wax, the seal long since broken. He held it for a moment in both hands, looking at it, before he passed it over.

"Because of this," he said.



THE HANDWRITING WAS SMALL and neat and slanted slightly backward, as if the writer had been left-handed and fighting it. The ink was black.

E.—

I've no right to ask anything more of you. I'm asking anyway. I always do.

I can't come back. Not yet. Perhaps not ever. What I found in the east is worse than I told you, and the only way to hold it is from inside, and the only way inside is a door I can't come back through once it's closed. I've made my peace with that. I've made my arrangements. The boys are hidden as well as I can hide them, and S. knows what to do.

But if the seals fail, if the boys wake, then I'll be failing too, and you'll know it, and so will everything else that's hunting. If that happens, find them. Both of them. Bring them together. The way to me runs through Avaloria, and the Way opens only to two of the blood. One of them alone can't reach me. Both together can.

I know what I'm asking. I know what it means that I'm asking you, and not someone else. I've never been fair to you, old friend. I'm sorry for that too.

Mind the quench.

—A.

Lex read it three times.

"Mind the quench," he said at last.

"It's a smith's phrase, I think," said Elric. "He used to say it. *Mind the quench*. Whenever he meant *be careful*, or *don't rush*, or *the important part is at the end*. I never knew where he got it."

[It's what you say to an apprentice,] said Ember in Lex's head, and its voice was very odd, very quiet. *[When the iron's shaped and you're about to put it in the water. The quench is where the iron gets its hardness. It's also where it cracks, if you're careless. You don't rush the quench.]* A pause. *[I don't know how I know that. I mean, I know it as metallurgy. But I know it as a saying*.* As something someone said to someone. Over and over.]* Another pause. *[That partition's locked.]*

Lex looked at the letter in his hands. At the small, neat, backward-slanting writing.

He'd never seen his father's handwriting. Not once. His mother had kept nothing. Or if she had, it had burned with the cottage.

He found that he was touching the letters with his thumb. Tracing them. He made himself stop.

"When did you get this?" he asked.

"Eleven years ago." Elric's voice was flat. "It was the last time I heard from him. He'd sent me letters before that. Four years of them, after he disappeared. Short ones. Never saying where he was. Just that he was alive, and working, and that I shouldn't look for him." He held out his hand for the letter, and Lex, after a moment, gave it back. "Then that one came. And then nothing."

"And you never found him."

"I never found Avaloria." Elric folded the letter along its old creases and slipped it back into the pocket against his chest. "It's a legend. A Founders' temple, one of the great ones, older than the Spire. The old texts say it stands on an island in a lake of glass, in the far north, beyond the mountains. I've walked the far north. I've been to every lake in it. I've found nothing." He looked at Lex. "Because the Way opens only to two of the blood. I'm not of the blood."

"So you need me."

"I need you. And I need your brother." Elric's storm-grey eyes held his. "That's why it matters, Lex. That's why I'm telling you all this. Because your father is dying somewhere north of those mountains, and the only way to reach him is together. You and Anthoren. Both."

The fire crackled. Quill had finished the bread and was cleaning his beak against a rock, very thoroughly.

"I'm not going to find my brother," Lex said.

Elric said nothing.

"He's a murderer. He's mad. He's killed—how many Wardens? Twenty? Thirty? He's been living in a cave in the mountains for eight years doing Lady knows what. Everyone in the Vale thinks he's a monster. And you want me to walk up to him and say, *Hello, Antho, it's me, your little brother, let's go on a trip together to find the father who abandoned us?*"

"Yes," said Elric. "That's exactly what I want."

"You're mad."

"Very possibly." Elric leaned back against his rock and closed his eyes. "But your father isn't. And your father told me to bring you together. So I'm going to try."



HE DIDN'T SLEEP MUCH that night.

He lay by the fire wrapped in Brannoc's spare blanket with the heat of the coals on his face and the cold of the mountain night at his back, and he looked up through the pine branches at the stars, and he thought.

He thought about his mother calling his brother's name through the smoke. *Antho, Antho, sweetheart, look at me.*

He thought about Antho's eyes.

He thought about the last real memory he had of his brother before all that, before the weeks of silence and the strange late nights on the woodpile. Antho at fifteen, sprawled on the riverbank below the mill, teaching him to skip stones. Antho had been endlessly patient about it. *No, flutter. Flick your wrist. Low, low, like you're trying to make it fly under a door.* And when Lex had finally made one skip four times, Antho had whooped so loud he'd frightened a heron off the far bank, and picked Lex up and swung him round, and said, *Lex, that was brilliant, you're brilliant, you're going to be better at this than me.*

He thought about that for a long time.

[You're awake,] Ember said quietly, some time after midnight.

I can't sleep.

[I noticed.] A pause. *[Would it help to talk?]*

About what?

[Anything. Your brother. Your father. The relative merits of charcoal versus coke as a forge fuel.] Another pause. *[I'm told I'm a good listener. I'm not sure who told me. That partition's locked too.]*

Lex almost smiled.

Do you think he's right? he thought. *Elric. Do you think Father's really dying?*

[I think the seal is failing,] said Ember carefully. *[I can feel it. It's like... the walls of a house, getting thinner. Something that was being fed isn't being fed as well as it was. Whether that means the one feeding it is dying, or*

trapped, or simply very far away and very tired...] A pause. *[I don't know. I'm sorry. I'd tell you if I knew.]*

Would you?

[Yes,] said Ember, without hesitation. *[I would. I don't think I was made to lie to you.]*

Lex lay looking up at the stars.

If I go, he thought slowly, if I go up there and find him, and he's what everyone says he is. What happens then?

[Then we'll deal with it.]

He could kill me.

[He could try.] Ember's voice was very dry. *[But I'd like to point out, with all due respect, that you've already been nearly killed once this week, and it didn't take.]*

Despite himself, Lex laughed. A short huff of breath in the cold air.

And if he's not what they say?

Ember was quiet for a long moment.

[Then you'll have a brother again,] it said at last. *[And I think you might like that more than you're willing to admit.]*



WHEN HE WOKE IN the grey light, the Lattice had left him a message.

It was waiting at the edge of his vision when he opened his eyes, a silver panel with a faint gold border, glowing softly in the dawn mist like a lantern left burning.

QUEST OFFERED

THE LOST FATHER (Main Quest)

Your father, Arion, is alive – for now. Find him.

- ◇ Find the Temple of Avaloria
- ◇ The Way opens to two of the blood

Reward: ???

Failure: ???

ACCEPT? [YES] [NO]

He lay there looking at it for a long time.

[The Lattice offers quests sometimes,] Ember explained, unprompted. [When it recognizes that you're on the edge of something significant. Accepting it won't change anything about the task itself, but it will track your progress, and it may grant rewards along the way. Experience. Items. Occasionally, knowledge.] A pause. [Failure conditions are listed as unknown. That's unusual. Usually the Lattice is very precise about what happens if you fail.]

What does that mean?

[It means either the Lattice doesn't know what will happen if you fail. Or it does know, and has decided not to tell you.] Another pause. [I'm not sure which I find more comforting.]

Lex looked at the line. *The Way opens to two of the blood.*

He thought of a boy on a riverbank, whooping at a stone that skipped four times.

"Yes," he said aloud.

The panel flickered, and folded itself up, and something new unrolled in its place.

QUEST ACCEPTED: The Lost Father

CHAIN QUEST UNLOCKED

THE BROTHER IN THE MOUNTAIN

Anthoren Harrow dwells in the
Hollowmaw, high in the Greyspine.
Find him. Survive the meeting.

- ◇ Reach Thistledown
- ◇ Find the Hollowmaw
- ◇ Speak with your brother

Survive the meeting, Lex thought.

"Comforting," he said.



ELRIC WAS ALREADY UP, standing at the edge of the pines with his staff in one hand and Quill on his shoulder, looking north at the mountains. The Greyspine rose up before them in the dawn like a wall at the end of the world: grey rock and white snow and black forest, ridge piled on ridge, the high peaks lost in cloud. Somewhere up there, Lex knew, was

a cleft called the Hollowmaw, and in the Hollowmaw was a cave, and in the cave was his brother.

"I'm not coming with you," Elric said without turning around.

Lex stopped buckling his pack. "What?"

"Not up the mountain. Not yet." Elric turned. His face in the dawn light was lined and tired and very serious. "There are people I need to see. Old friends. Some of them may know things about Avaloria, or about the Gloam, or about what the Order is planning. Some of them may be willing to help us, when the time comes. And some of them are..." He paused. "Delicate. They won't talk to me if I have a wildcaster at my heels."

"You're leaving me to go and find my murderous brother *alone*?"

"You won't be alone. You'll have your—" Elric gestured vaguely at Lex's head. "Your construct."

[*Ember,*] said Ember, sounding faintly offended.

"And I'll send Quill to you when I can. He'll find you, wherever you are. He's very good at that." Elric scratched the raven under the beak, and Quill closed his eyes in bliss. "Go to Thistledown. It's two days' walk north and east, on the lower slopes. A trading post, mostly trappers and miners. Hire a guide there. Tell them you want to go to the Hollowmaw, and pay them twice what they ask, and don't take no for an answer."

"And then what? I walk up to his cave and knock?"

"Something like that." Elric's mouth twitched. "Lex. Listen to me. I don't believe your brother will hurt you."

"You don't *know* that."

"No. I don't know it. But I believe it." Elric stepped closer. "Whatever's happened to him, whatever he's become, he's still Arion's son, and your father put something into those seals, something of himself. I could see it in you, last night, when your power came through. It came through *clean*. It came through like something that knew you. If there's anything of that left in your brother..." He shook his head. "I'm gambling, I'll admit. But I think it's a good gamble."

"And if it isn't?"

"Then hit him with your hammer," said Elric, "and run."

Lex stared at him.

Then, despite everything, he laughed. It came out of him unexpectedly, the first real laugh since the night of the hounds, and Elric smiled too, crookedly, and for a moment the two of them stood there in the dawn mist like old friends instead of strangers who'd met two days ago.

"There's one more thing," Elric said. "You need to grow."

"Grow?"

"Levels. Skills. Strength. You're level five, Lex. You're a fire in a lamp, and you need to be a fire in a forge." Elric's eyes were very bright. "The mountains are full of things that will try to kill you. Let them try. Every one you put down will make you stronger. By the time you reach the Hollowmaw, I want you strong enough that your brother has to take you seriously. And by the time we reach Avaloria..." He paused. "By the time we reach Avaloria, I want you strong enough to stand next to your father."

Something in the way he said it caught at Lex. The faintest edge in the old man's voice. Like the dull note under the ring of good iron.

He almost used True Sight. He caught himself in time.

"Fine," he said.

Elric nodded. He reached out, unexpectedly, and gripped Lex's shoulder. His hand was thin and knotted and surprisingly strong.

"Mind the quench," he said quietly.

Then he turned and walked away down the slope, west and south, his grey cloak blending into the grey mist, the brass charms on it chiming faintly until the sound faded and was gone. Quill circled once over Lex's head, croaked something that might have been "*Good luck*," and flew after him.

Lex stood alone at the edge of the pines with his hammer and his pack and a voice in his head, looking up at the mountains.

[Well,] said Ember after a moment. *[That's that, then.]*

"That's that."

[Shall we?]

Lex shouldered Anvilson. It was warm against his neck, humming faintly, like a cat purring.

"We shall," he said, and started to climb.



TWO DAYS LATER, AND thirty miles south, Warden-Captain Daxian Roole stood in the middle of Ashbourne's village green and looked at a cracked old Lattice Stone that was glowing gold.

It wasn't glowing much. You had to look closely, and at the right angle, in the early morning when the light was low. But it was there. A faint warm shimmer along the edges of the crack, like light leaking from under a door. He'd seen a great many Lattice Stones in his twenty years with the Order. He'd never once seen one glow gold.

He'd been told he might.

He was a tall man, lean and weathered, with close-cropped iron-grey hair and a face like a hatchet: all angles and planes, as if someone had carved it in a hurry and never gone back to smooth it. He wore the grey cloak and silver lattice-pin of the Order, and a sword at his hip that had seen more use than ornament. His eyes were pale blue and missed nothing.

Behind him, his squad was finishing with the village. Twelve Wardens, moving from house to house with the brisk efficiency of people who'd done this a hundred times. Knocking on doors. Asking questions. Using Inspection on anyone who looked nervous, which in Roole's experience was everyone, because people always looked nervous when the Wardens came, whether or not they'd done anything.

He'd gotten the story in an hour. It wasn't hard. The whole village was talking about it.

Monsters made of black mist, coming down the north road in the night. A stranger in a grey cloak with lightning on it. And Lex Harrow, the blacksmith's apprentice, the quiet one, the one whose mother died and whose brother went mad, *glowing* like a coal in the fire and smashing monsters into gold sparks with a hammer.

Gloamhounds, Roole thought, looking at the scorch marks still faint on the cobbles. *This far west. This far south.* That was going to be in his report. That was going to make some people at the Spire very unhappy.

"Captain."

He turned. Corporal Fenn was coming across the green toward him: a short, wiry woman with a tracker's squint and a [Tracker] class to match. She jerked her head back toward the smithy.

"The big one won't talk," she said. "The smith. Says the boy went south. To Saltreach. Says he took the coast road two days ago, and if we hurry we'll catch him at Millbridge." She spat. "He's lying."

"I know," said Roole. "Bring him."

Brannoc Holt came out of the smithy without needing to be brought. He walked across the green with the slow, heavy tread of a man who had made up his mind about something, and stopped in front of the Warden-Captain, and looked at him.

He was very large. Roole had been told that. He hadn't been told how *steady* the man was. Like a wall.

"Master Holt," Roole said.

"Captain."

"Your apprentice went south, you say. To Saltreach."

"He did."

"Two days ago."

"Two days, aye."

Roole looked at him for a long moment. Then, without looking away, he called up his Inspection. It didn't take long. It never did with commoners; there wasn't much to read.

BRANNOC HOLT

Class: Smith (Common)

Level: 24 (CAP)

Level twenty-four. Capped. Roole had seen ten thousand panels like it, and he felt, as he sometimes did and would never have admitted, a small tired twist of something that wasn't quite pity.

"Master Holt," he said, "I've been a Warden for twenty years. In that time I've had more people lie to me than I could count. Most of them were lying to protect themselves. Some of them were lying to protect someone else." He paused. "You're the second kind. I can always tell. The second kind look you right in the eye."

Brannoc said nothing. He looked Roole right in the eye.

"I'm not going to arrest you," Roole said. "I could. Harboring a wildcaster's a hanging offense in some provinces, and Caldor's not as soft about it as it used to be. But I'm not going to. Do you want to know why?"

"I expect you'll tell me."

"Because I'd do the same." Roole's pale eyes didn't waver. "If it were my son, I'd stand where you're standing and lie to my face and I'd sleep sound after." He let that sit for a moment. "But I want you to understand something, Master Holt, and I want you to understand it very clearly. Whatever came down that road two nights ago, whatever was hunting your boy, I'm not the worst thing that's going to come looking for him. Not by a long way. And I'd rather find him before *they* do."

Something flickered in the big smith's face. Then it was gone.

"He went south," Brannoc said. "To Saltreach."

Roole sighed. "Of course he did."

"Captain!"

It was Fenn again. She'd gone off to the north edge of the green while they talked, where the road ran up out of the village toward the mountains, and she was crouched on the packed earth there with her fingers spread over a patch of grey, dead grass.

"Tracks," she called. "Two days old. Two men, heading north. One heavy, carrying something big, one light, with a staff." She stood and dusted off her hands. "They go up into the foothills. Toward the Greyspine."

Roole didn't look at Brannoc. He didn't need to. He could feel the big man go still beside him, the way a wall goes still, which is to say, more so.

He turned and looked north. Up the road, up the foothills, to the great grey wall of the mountains standing up against the morning sky, snow on the peaks, cloud on the ridges, and somewhere up there in the high cold dark, a cleft that had been marked on the Order's maps for eight years as forbidden ground.

"The Greyspine," he said quietly. "The Hollowmaw." He let out a long breath through his nose. "Of course. Where else would a Harrow go?"

"Captain?" said Fenn. "Orders?"

Roole was silent for a long moment, looking up at the mountains. He thought about the report he'd have to write. He thought about the four retrieval teams that had gone up into those mountains over the years, and the handful of men who'd come down. He thought about the gold light leaking from the crack in the Stone behind him.

And he thought about the letter in his pocket, sealed with the private sigil of the High Warden herself, that had found him on the road five days ago, before any flare, before any monsters, and ordered him to Ashbourne with all possible speed. *A Root signature has been detected flickering in the southern Vale. Locate the source. Retrieve it. Alive, if possible.*

If possible.

"Mount up," he said. "We're going hunting."

CHAPTER 5

THE ROAD TO THISTLEDOWN



THE WOLVES FOUND HIM on the second morning.

He'd been climbing for a day and a half by then, up out of the foothills and into the true mountains, where the road shrank to a track and the track shrank to a goat path and the goat path finally gave up altogether and became a vague suggestion of flattened grass between boulders. The air had turned thin and sharp. The pines had thinned out and gone stunted and twisted, crouching low against the rocks as if they were afraid of the wind. Twice he'd crossed snowfields, old dirty snow from the winter, crusted and grey and pocked with the tracks of things he didn't recognize. Once he'd stopped at the edge of a gully and looked down and seen, far below, a patch of grass gone the color of ash, and the thin black thread of something that might have been smoke and might not, curling up out of a crack in the rock.

He'd gone around that gully. A long way around.

[Wise,] Ember had said.

The wolves came out of the morning mist in a tight grey wedge, five of them, loping silently across the slope toward him. They were big, bigger than any wolf he'd seen in the Vale, with thick shaggy coats the color of granite and pale yellow eyes. A small silver tag floated over the lead wolf's head as it came, the way tags floated over anything the Lattice considered a threat.

GREYSPINE WOLF – Level 6

[Five of them,] Ember observed. *[Level six. Ordinary beasts, not Gloam-touched. A pack hunting what it thinks is a lone traveler with a heavy pack and a heavy hammer, who will be slow.]* A pause. *[I would like you to prove them wrong.]*

"I'm working on it," Lex muttered, and set his back to a boulder, and swung Anvilsong off his shoulder.

He'd spent his six free points the night before, sitting by a fire he hadn't lit with flint, while Ember talked him through it. Three into Agility, three into Vitality. *[You're going to be fighting alone,]* Ember had said. *[You need to be able to take a hit and get out of the way of the next one.]* He'd felt the points go in, a loosening in his joints, a deepening in his breath, and this morning when he'd stood up from the fire his body had felt lighter than it ever had in his life, as if he'd been carrying a sack of coal on his back for nineteen years and someone had finally cut the strap.

LEX HARROW – Emberwright, Level 5		
MIG 18	AGI 17	VIT 22
INT 17	SPI 34	RES 17
Health	220/220	
Mana	340/340	

The lead wolf leaped.

He moved without thinking, the way he'd move to catch a falling tool. He sidestepped, quicker than he'd ever moved before, and the wolf's jaws snapped shut on air where his throat had been. He brought Anvilsong around in a short, flat arc and felt the heat go down his arms into the iron, *Ember Strike*, and the hammer caught the wolf on the shoulder with a flash of gold and a smell of singed fur. The wolf yelped and tumbled away across the rocks.

It didn't die. Ordinary beasts were tougher than gloamhounds, it turned out. Gloamhounds were made of mist and hunger, and the fire went straight through them. Wolves were made of muscle and bone and stubbornness, and the fire had to fight its way in.

The other four came at him all at once.

He fought. He didn't know how else to describe it afterward. He had no training, none at all; Brannoc had taught him to swing a hammer at iron, not at things that dodged. But he had strength, and the new quickness in his legs, and the hammer was so perfectly balanced that it seemed to know where it wanted to go. He kept his back to the boulder so they couldn't get behind him. He swung low to keep them off his legs. When one darted in, he struck at it, and when it darted out, he let it go and turned to the next.

And under it all, steady as a heartbeat, Ember's voice.

[Left. Low. Good. The one on the right is circling. Watch its shoulders, not its eyes; wolves telegraph with the shoulders. Now. Good. You're spending too much mana. Not every swing needs fire; save it for when you'll connect. Breathe. There's one trying to get above you on the rock—]

He spun, and swung upward, and the hammer caught a wolf in midair as it leaped down from the top of the boulder. Gold fire. A yelp cut short. The wolf hit the ground and didn't get up.

Greyspine Wolf defeated. +XP

The rest broke.

Two of them, anyway. They turned and fled back into the mist with their tails low, and the wounded lead wolf limped after them. The fifth lay where it had fallen near the boulder, panting, one foreleg crushed. It looked up at him with its pale yellow eyes and bared its teeth, but there was no fight left in it.

Lex stood over it, breathing hard. His arms ached. His mana bar, glowing faint gold at the edge of his vision, had dropped by more than half.

[You should finish it,] Ember said quietly. [It won't survive with that leg. It'll starve, or the others will eat it.]

He knew that. He was a village boy; he'd seen animals put down before. He'd held a lantern for Farmer Tobbin once when the old plough-horse broke its leg in a ditch. He lifted the hammer.

The wolf watched him.

He brought the hammer down, quick and clean, without fire. It was over in an instant.

Greyspine Wolf defeated. +XP

LEVEL UP!

Emberwright – Level 6

He sat down on a rock afterward and didn't move for a while.

[Are you all right?]

I'm fine.

[You're shaking.]

It's the cold.

[It's not the cold.] A pause. *[It's all right, you know. To not like that part. It would worry me more if you did.]*

Lex looked at the dead wolf. Grey fur, stirring in the wind. Already the Lattice had stopped tagging it; it was just meat now, just a shape on the hillside.

Does it get easier? he asked.

Ember was quiet for a moment.

[For most people, yes,] it said. *[I'm not sure I'd want it to, for you.]*



HE LEVELED AGAIN BY evening, and once more the next morning.

The mountains were full of things that wanted to kill him, just as Elric had said. Rock-lizards the size of dogs that lay perfectly still on sun-warmed ledges, the color of the stone, and lunged when you got too close. A thing like a huge shaggy goat with horns like a ram's and a temper like a bull's that charged him across a snowfield and nearly sent him over a cliff. A swarm of small grey bats that came boiling out of a crack in the rock at dusk, shrieking, and that he finally drove off by swinging Anvilson in a wide blazing circle over his head until the air around him shimmered with heat.

That had been a new thing. He hadn't known he could do it until he did. He'd been swinging the hammer, desperate, and the heat had come pouring off the iron in waves, not in a single strike but in a continuous rolling pulse, and the bats had veered away from it like smoke from a fan.

SKILL LEARNED: Heat Shaping
Novice 1
"Heat is a material. Shape it."

[Oh, very good,] Ember said, sounding genuinely delighted. [I was going to teach you that next week. You've saved me a lesson.]

He practiced it that night by the fire. He found he could pull the heat out of the coals into his hands and hold it there, a ball of shimmering air the size of an apple, and toss it from palm to palm. He could push it into a cold stone until the stone glowed dull red and then tuck it into his bedroll to keep his feet warm. He could, if he concentrated hard enough, push it out of himself in a short sharp burst, like the breath of a bellows, hot enough to scorch the grass a few paces away.

[That last one will be a weapon, eventually,] said Ember. [When it's stronger. For now, it's a party trick.]

"It's a useful party trick."

[All the best ones are.]

By the third morning, when he came over a high rocky shoulder and saw Thistledown below him for the first time, he was level eight.

LEX HARROW – Emberwright, Level 8
Free points: 18 (unspent)
SKILLS
Ember Strike Novice 9
Heat Shaping Novice 4
Forge Sense Apprentice 3
Hammer Use Apprentice 9
Endurance Journeyman 1
Runic Forging ... Novice 6

But he'd only gotten to level eight because of the bear.



IT HAD HAPPENED LATE on the second day.

He'd been following a stream up a narrow valley, looking for a place to cross, when he smelled it: wet ash, and rot, and under them, faint and cold, the smell of nothing. The Gloam smell. He'd stopped dead on the bank with every hair on his arms standing up.

[Lex,] Ember had said quietly. [Up the slope. To your left. Don't move suddenly.]

He'd looked.

At first he'd thought it was a boulder. A huge grey-brown mound of a thing, half-hidden among the stunted pines thirty paces up the hillside. Then it had lifted its head.

It was a bear. Or it had been a bear once. It was a cave bear, the great shaggy kind that lived high in the Greyspine and that the trappers at Thistledown spoke of with careful respect, twice the size of a plough-horse and covered in a thick coat of brown fur. But the fur was wrong. Great patches of it had gone grey, the dead lifeless grey of the hedgerows on the north road, and where the grey patches were, the flesh underneath seemed to have shrunk, pulled tight over the bones. One of its eyes was small and dark and rimmed with red, a beast's eye. The other was flat, blank, boiled-egg white.

And it was whispering.

Low, wet, almost too faint to hear. Not words. Just a hiss, like breath going in and out of a cracked bellows, rising and falling.

The tag that floated over its head wasn't silver. It was silver with black bleeding into the edges, like ink spreading on wet paper.

GLOAM-TOUCHED CAVE BEAR

Level 14 – ELITE

Corruption: 41%

[Fourteen,] said Ember. [Elite. Corrupted, partially. That means it's stronger than it should be, angrier than it should be, and it doesn't feel pain the way it should.] A pause. [I think you should leave. Very quietly. Now.]

He'd started to back away.

The bear had come down the hill.

It was faster than anything that size had any right to be. It came crashing down through the pines like a landslide, roaring, and the roar was two sounds at once: a bear's bellow and, underneath it, the thin glass-cracking scream of a gloamhound. Lex had time to swing Anvilsong off his shoulder and plant his feet, and then it was on him.

He didn't remember all of it clearly. He remembered the first blow: a great clawed paw coming around in a sideways swipe that he got the hammer haft up to block, and the force of it lifting him off his feet and throwing him into the stream. He remembered the cold of the water closing over his head, and coming up gasping, and the bear standing over him on the bank with its blank white eye fixed on him and black smoke curling from its jaws. He remembered swinging, *Ember Strike*, and the hammer slamming into its foreleg in a flash of gold, and the bear barely flinching. The fire had scorched the grey patch of fur and the bear had just *shrugged it off*.

[The corruption,] Ember was saying, fast and clipped. [The grey parts don't feel it. Hit the brown parts. The living parts. The fire hurts what's still alive in it.]

He remembered the bear's claws catching him across the ribs, three hot lines of pain through his coat and shirt and skin, and his health bar plunging, and the cold seeping into the wounds the way it had with the gloamhound, and the heat in his chest rising up to burn it out again. He remembered rolling, scrambling, getting his feet under him on the slippery stones of the streambed. He remembered thinking very clearly: *I can't win this. Not straight on. It's too big and too strong and I'm too slow.*

[Then don't fight it straight on,] said Ember, as if it had heard him. Perhaps it had. [You're a smith, not a soldier. How do you move a thing too heavy to lift?]

Leverage.

[And how do you hit something you can't reach?]

He looked at the hammer in his hands. At the runes he'd struck into it, three readable and one not, glowing faint red-gold in the dark iron.

Homeward. Returns to the maker's hand when called. Thirty paces.

The bear came at him again. He ran.

Not away. Sideways. Up the far bank of the stream and along it, splashing through the shallows, the bear crashing after him. He ran until he reached a place where the stream bent around a big outcrop of rock, and he went around the rock and stopped and turned. The bear came around after him. And Lex threw the hammer.

He threw it as hard as he could, straight at the bear's head, and the bear did exactly what he'd hoped it would. It ducked. It dropped its huge head low and the hammer went whirling over its back, end over end, and clanged off the rock behind it and fell into the stream, twenty paces away.

The bear raised its head. Its white eye fixed on him. It saw that his hands were empty. And something in the wet hiss of its whisper changed, rose, became almost a sound of triumph.

It charged.

Lex held out his hand.

Homeward, he thought. *Come back.*

Behind the bear, in the stream, the hammer *leaped*. It came up out of the water in a spray of droplets and flew back toward him, straight as an arrow, straight as a homing bird, back toward the hand that had made it. And between the hammer and the hand was the back of the bear's skull.

He put everything he had into it. Every scrap of mana he had left. He felt it drain out of him, a great hot rush down his outstretched arm and across the empty air and into the iron as it flew, and the hammer blazed white, white as a star, and struck the bear at the base of the skull with a sound like a mountain splitting in half.

The bear went down.

It went down like a felled tree, all at once, its great bulk crashing forward into the stream at Lex's feet, so close that the spray of it soaked him. It shuddered. The black smoke poured out of its jaws in a long dark sigh, and the whisper rose, and broke, and stopped.

The hammer smacked into his palm. He closed his fingers around it, because his hand knew what to do even if the rest of him didn't, and then his legs gave out and he sat down in the cold water next to the dead bear and just breathed for a while.

GLOAM-TOUCHED CAVE BEAR defeated.

ELITE KILL — bonus XP

LEVEL UP!

Emberwright — Level 7

LEVEL UP!

Emberwright — Level 8

SKILL UP: Ember Strike → Novice 9

SKILL UP: Hammer Use → Apprentice 9

[Leverage,] said Ember after a while, sounding very pleased with itself, or perhaps with him. *[That was beautifully done.]*

I nearly died.

[Yes. That part was less beautiful.] A pause. *[But you didn't. And you thought your way out instead of fighting your way out. That's the difference between a smith and a brute, Lex. It'll keep you alive more often than strength will.]*

Lex looked at the dead bear. Already the grey patches in its fur were crumbling, flaking away like old ash, and the white eye had gone dull and filmy. The black mist that had been in it had gone somewhere. He hoped very much it had gone nowhere near him.

"It was a bear," he said aloud. "Before. It was just a bear. Living up here, eating berries and fish and minding its own business. And then that stuff got into it." He swallowed. "Is that what happens to people? The Tanners' sheep. The ones that just stand there."

[I think so,] said Ember quietly. *[I think that's what the Gloam does. It gets into living things and hollows them out, a little at a time, and fills the hollow with itself.]*

"Why?"

Ember was quiet for a long time.

[I don't know,] it said at last. *[But I don't think it's because it's hungry. Not really. Hunger is a living thing's feeling. I think it's because something on the other side of it is. And this is how it eats.]*



THISTLEDOWN WAS A PALISADE of grey logs perched on a shelf of rock above a narrow valley, with a gate and a watchtower and a column of chimney smoke going straight up into the cold still air. Inside the palisade, Lex found perhaps forty buildings crowded together like sheep in a storm: trappers' cabins and miners' bunkhouses, a smithy, a store, a stable, and, in the middle of it all, a long low hall with a sod roof and a painted sign over the door that showed a fire burning in a hearth. **THE LAST HEARTH**, it said underneath, in faded letters. And below that, in smaller, newer letters that someone had added with a hot iron: *NO WARLOCKS*.

"Charming," Lex said.

[I believe it's meant as a joke.]

"I'm not laughing."

Nobody else was laughing either. The Last Hearth was full of the kind of people who didn't laugh much: trappers in greasy furs, miners with grey dust ground into the creases of their hands, a few hard-faced traders playing cards at a corner table. They looked up when Lex came in. They looked at his hammer. They looked away.

He found the factor, a heavy, sweating man named Grell who ran the store and the Hearth and, as far as Lex could tell, most of Thistledown, and asked him about guides.

"Guides to where?" said Grell.

"The Hollowmaw."

The room went quiet.

It went quiet the way a forge goes quiet when someone drops a hot billet: all at once, every conversation stopping mid-word, every head turning. One of the card players laid down his hand. A trapper at the bar set his mug down very carefully, as if afraid of making noise.

Grell looked at him for a long moment.

"No," he said.

"I'll pay."

"Son, you could pay me in Saltreach gold and Sunreach rubies and I couldn't find you a guide for the Hollowmaw. Nobody goes up there. Nobody's gone up there in eight years and come back right." Grell leaned across the counter, lowering his voice. "There's a warlock up there. Mad as a rabid dog. He kills anything that comes near. Wardens, trappers, miners,

don't matter. And now there's this black stuff coming down the gullies, and he's at the bottom of that too, if you ask me." He jabbed a fat finger at Lex's chest. "You want to die, you go up there on your own. Don't you take anyone from my post with you."

Lex looked around the room. Every eye that met his slid away.

"Fine," he said. "Thank you for your help."

He'd gotten as far as the door when a voice behind him said, "I'll take you."



SHE WAS SITTING ALONE at a table in the far corner, near the fire, with her boots up on a chair and a mug of something steaming in her hands. She was young, about his age, maybe a year older, slim and wiry, with a long fox-red braid hanging over one shoulder and a face full of freckles. She wore a patched leather coat over a wool tunic, and there was a short bow propped against the wall beside her and two knives at her belt, one on each hip.

Her eyes were green, and very sharp, and they were looking him up and down with an expression of frank assessment, the way Brannoc looked at a bar of iron before he decided what to make of it.

"Wren," said Grell from behind the counter, in a warning tone.

"I heard you, Grell." She didn't look away from Lex. "You said nobody from your post. I'm not from your post. I'm from my mam's post, which is a cabin on the east ridge with a hole in the roof." She took a sip from her mug. "And I'll take him."

"Wren, don't be daft—"

"Triple," she said to Lex. "Whatever you'd have paid anyone else. Triple. Half now, half when we get there."

Lex walked slowly back across the room. People got out of his way. He stopped at her table.

"You'd take me to the Hollowmaw," he said. "For money."

"For a *lot* of money." Wren set down her mug. "And not *to* the Hollowmaw. Near it. Close enough you can see it. Then you're on your own, and I'm going home." She tilted her head. "That's the deal."

"Why?"

"Why what?"

"Why you? Nobody else will."

She shrugged. "Nobody else needs the money like I do."

He looked at her. At the patched coat and the worn boots. At the bow, which had been mended at the grip with a wrapping of sinew, and was cracked near one tip, he noticed, a hairline crack that would split the first time anyone drew it hard.

[Ask her,] Ember suggested quietly. [Before you look. You learned that lesson.]

"Can I look at your status?" he asked.

Wren blinked. Then, unexpectedly, she laughed. It was a short bright bark of a laugh, startled out of her.

"Ask? You're asking?" She shook her head. "Nobody asks. Wardens don't ask. Grell's Inspection-scroll doesn't ask." She waved a hand. "Go on. It's not much to look at."

He looked.

He felt the heat go up behind his eyes, and the world flickered gold, and over her head unrolled a gold panel. He saw her see it, saw her see *something*, because her green eyes went suddenly very wide, and her hand went to the knife on her hip.

WREN ASHDOWN		
Age: 20		
Class: Tracker (Common)		
Level: 19		Cap: 24
MIG 11	AGI 22	VIT 13
INT 14	SPI 9	RES 16
SKILLS		
Tracking	Journeyman	8
Archery	Journeyman	5
Climbing	Expert	1
Weather Sense ...	Journeyman	2
Knife-work	Apprentice	9

He let it go. The gold flickered out.

Wren's hand was still on her knife. She was staring at him.

"Your eyes," she said, very quietly, so that nobody else in the room could hear. "They went gold. Like a cat's in lamplight."

[Ah,] said Ember. [I did say.]

Lex didn't say anything. He waited.

Wren looked at him for a long, long moment. He could see her thinking. He could see her weighing it, the same way she'd weighed him when he first walked in. The gold eyes. The hammer. The question about the Hollowmaw, where a mad warlock lived whose eyes, everybody said, went black.

Then she took her hand off her knife, and picked up her mug, and leaned back in her chair.

"Quadruple," she said.

"What?"

"Quadruple. You're not a trader, and you're not a trapper, and you're not a Warden, and you're going to the Hollowmaw with eyes that do *that*." She took a sip. "Whatever you are, you're trouble. Trouble costs extra."

He stared at her.

Then, for the second time in three days, he laughed.

"Fine," he said. "Quadruple."

"Done." She held out a hand across the table. It was small and hard and calloused, a climber's hand. He shook it. "Wren Ashdown."

"Lex."

"Just Lex?"

"For now."

She raised an eyebrow. "Fine. Just Lex." She looked at the hammer on his shoulder. "I'm going to call you Hammer."

"Please don't."

"Too late," said Wren. "Sit down, Hammer. You look like you fought a bear."

"I did fight a bear."

"*Did* you." She kicked the chair across from her out from the table with one foot. "Then you'll want a drink. And I'll want to hear about it. And you'll want to hear how we're getting up there, because I'll tell you right now, it isn't pretty."



IT WASN'T PRETTY.

The Hollowmaw lay three days north and east, Wren told him over a supper of mutton stew and black bread, high in the Greyspine, above the snowline. The usual way up was the Sawback Pass, over a ridge the trappers called the Teeth. But an avalanche had come down off the Teeth two weeks ago and buried the pass under forty feet of snow, and it wouldn't be clear until midsummer.

"So there's no way up," Lex said.

"There's one." Wren tore a piece off her bread. "Under."

"Under?"

"There's a Delve under the Teeth. An old one. The trappers call it the Frostvault. It runs right through the ridge, west to east, and comes out on the far side, right across the valley from the Hollowmaw." She chewed. "Nobody uses it much, because it's a Delve, and Delves have things in them. But in a bad spring, when the pass is shut, it's the only way through."

[*A Delve,*] said Ember, with interest. [*The Lattice spawns them at knots of mana. They're like... trials. Dungeons. Floors of challenges, guardians, rewards. Dangerous. Very good for experience.*]

"Have you been through it?" Lex asked.

"Twice." Wren shrugged. "Once with my da, when I was fourteen. Once on my own last autumn, running furs to the east side when the pass froze early." She looked at him over her bread. "The first time, Da nearly lost a hand. The second time, I nearly lost my head. It's not a stroll, Hammer."

"Then why are you willing to do it again?"

Wren's face went still. For a moment she looked down at her stew, stirring it slowly with her spoon.

"My mam's sick," she said at last. "Grey-lung. She worked the deep mines at Coldwater for twelve years, and last winter the black stuff started coming up through the lower shafts, and half the miners down there started coughing. Mam was one of them." She stirred her stew. "There's a physic in Highcrest who can treat it. Maybe. If you can pay him. If you can

get her there." She looked up. Her green eyes were hard and bright. "Quadruple gets me most of the way."

Lex didn't say anything for a moment. He thought about the Gloam-touched bear, its fur crumbling to grey ash. He thought about the Tanners' sheep.

"I'm sorry," he said.

"Don't be sorry. Just pay me." She went back to her stew. But some of the hardness had gone out of her shoulders. "And don't die. Dead men are terrible at paying."

He reached into his pack and took out Brannoc's purse. He counted out half of what she'd asked, and then, after a moment's thought, he counted out the other half too, and pushed the whole pile across the table to her.

Wren stared at it.

"That's all of it," she said. "That's the whole fee."

"I know."

"You're supposed to pay half when we get there. That's the *point* of half. So I don't run off."

"Are you going to run off?"

She looked at him. He looked back.

"No," she said slowly.

"Then take it. Send it to your mother tonight, if there's a way to send it. If something happens to me in the Frostvault, I'd rather she had it."

For a long moment, Wren didn't move. Then she reached out and slowly gathered up the coins, and put them in a pouch at her belt, and tied it closed.

"You're an idiot, Hammer," she said. Her voice was a little rough.

"So I'm told."

"A big soft idiot with gold eyes." She shook her head. Then she looked at the bow propped against the wall beside her, and back at him. "Can you fix that? The crack in the upper limb. You're carrying a smith's hammer, and you've got burn scars on your arms. I'm guessing you're a smith."

"I'm a smith," said Lex. "I'm not a bowyer."

"Can you fix it or not?"

He picked up the bow. He ran his thumb along the upper limb until he found the crack, a fine dark hair-line in the yew, and as his thumb passed over it, his Forge Sense *rang*. Not like iron. Differently. Softer. But he could hear it, the flaw in the wood, the way he could hear a slag pocket in a bar, and he could hear, very faintly, the shape of something that might mend it. A rune. Small and simple. Something like a knot, or a stitch.

[Interesting,] said Ember. [Runic Forging isn't only for metal. Anything that's been made can take a rune. Wood, leather, cloth. Metal's just the easiest.]

"I can try," he said.



HE WAS UP LATE in Thistledown's little smithy, which the old miner who ran it had grudgingly let him use for a silver penny, working on Wren's bow by the light of the forge.

It was delicate work, much harder than iron. He couldn't hammer a rune into wood. He had to *coax* it, warming the yew gently with Heat Shaping until it was soft and supple, then pressing the rune in with the tip of a heated awl, a fraction at a time, so slowly and carefully that his eyes ached and his hand cramped. Twice he felt it start to go wrong, felt the wood begin to scorch, and had to stop and let it cool and start again.

But by midnight the crack was gone. In its place, set into the grain of the yew where the crack had been, was a tiny mark like a knot of thread, glowing faintly gold for a moment before it faded.

ITEM IMPROVED
WREN'S BOW (Ashdown yew, mended)
Grade: Common → FINE
Rune: KNIT – the wood will not crack along this seam again
Runic Forging – Novice 6 → Novice 8

He was holding it up to the firelight, admiring the grain, when he heard the horses.

They came in through Thistledown's gate fast, a dozen or more, hooves loud on the frozen earth. Men's voices. A lantern swinging. And a voice he

didn't recognize, clipped and hard, carrying through the cold night air: "Wardens of the Lattice. Open up. Everyone out where we can see you."

Lex went very still.

[That's the squad we saw on the south road,] said Ember quietly. [It must be. They've ridden hard.]

Through the smithy's half-open door, he could see the yard. Torchlight. Grey cloaks. A tall, lean man with a face like a hatchet, swinging down from a big grey horse and looking slowly around the yard with pale, cold eyes. Men were coming out of the bunkhouses, blinking, pulling on coats. Grell was hurrying out of the Hearth, wringing his hands.

"Looking for a young man," the hatchet-faced Warden was saying. "Nineteen. Big. Dark hair. Carrying a hammer. He'd have come in sometime in the last day or so."

Lex's hand tightened on the bow.

[We need to leave,] said Ember. [Now. Out the back. Quietly.]

Wren—

[She'll be fine. She's a local. They're looking for you.]

He turned toward the back of the smithy, toward the little door that let out onto the woodpile and the palisade wall behind it.

Wren was standing in it.

She had her pack on her back and her coat buttoned to the chin. She looked at him, and at her bow in his hands, and at the gold mark glowing faintly in the yew.

"Took you long enough," she said.

"How did you—"

"I've been sitting on the woodpile for an hour waiting for you to finish. It's freezing out here." She held out her hand, and he gave her the bow, and she ran her thumb along the mended limb. Her eyebrows went up. "Huh. That's good work, Hammer."

From the yard came the voice of the hatchet-faced Warden: "Search the buildings. All of them."

"There's a gap in the palisade behind the woodpile," Wren said briskly, slinging the bow over her shoulder. "Kids use it to sneak out and go skating on the tarn. It's tight. You'll have to leave the hammer for a minute and pass it through after." She turned. "Come on."

"Wren," he said. "If they catch you helping me—"

"Then they catch me." She looked back at him over her shoulder, and her green eyes were bright in the forge light. "You paid me in full, Hammer. Nobody pays me in full. I'm not losing a customer like that to a bunch of grey-cloaks." She jerked her head at the door. "Besides. I want to see what you are."

She slipped out into the dark.

Lex looked once more through the front door of the smithy at the torch-lit yard, at the grey cloaks, at the tall pale-eyed man turning slowly, scanning, his gaze sliding across the buildings like a blade across a whetstone.

Just for a moment, that pale gaze passed over the smithy door. And stopped.

Lex didn't wait to see what came next. He ducked out the back door into the freezing night, and followed Wren Ashdown into the dark.

CHAPTER 6

THE TEETH OF THE MOUNTAIN



THE GAP IN THE palisade was barely wide enough for a child, and Lex was not a child.

He went through it sideways, sucking in his breath, with the logs scraping his chest and back and Wren hissing at him from the other side to *hurry up, Hammer, lean left, no, your other left*. He got stuck once, halfway, and for one awful moment he was sure he'd be found there in the morning by a squad of Wardens, wedged in a fence like a cork in a bottle. Then something gave, possibly his coat, possibly a rib, and he popped out onto the frozen hillside behind Thistledown and sat down hard in the snow.

"Hammer," Wren whispered. She was crouched beside the gap, holding out her hands.

He reached back through the gap for Anvilson where he'd left it leaning against the logs. Then he stopped, and thought about it, and held out his hand instead.

Homeward, he thought.

The hammer slid through the gap on its own, scraping over the snow like a dog wriggling under a gate, and leaped the last few feet into his palm.

Wren stared at it.

"Huh," she said.

"Don't."

"I didn't say anything."

"You were going to."

"I was going to say *bub*," said Wren. "I said it. I'm done." She stood up and brushed the snow off her knees. "Come on. They'll have Fenn on our trail by morning."

"Who's Fenn?"

"The little woman with the squint. She was in the yard with the grey-cloaks. She's a Tracker too." Wren slung her bow over her shoulder and started up the slope, moving fast and low, her boots barely seeming to touch the snow. "I've seen her work. She's good. Not as good as me. But good."



THEY CLIMBED THROUGH THE night.

There was a moon, a fat lopsided one, three days off full, and it turned the snowfields to silver and the shadows to ink. Wren led. She went up the mountain the way water goes down it, choosing every step without seeming to think about it, finding footholds in rock that looked smooth as glass to Lex, traversing slopes he'd never have dared alone. When the snow was crusted, she walked on top of it. When it was soft, she found the places where the wind had packed it hard. Twice she stopped dead and held up a hand, and they waited in silence while something large moved across the slope above them in the dark, and then went on.

Lex followed, and sweated, and slipped, and tried very hard not to fall off the mountain.

[She's very good,] Ember observed, sometime after midnight.

I noticed.

[Her Climbing skill is Expert. That's rare for a Common class. You don't get to Expert in anything without years of practice and a great deal of natural talent.] A pause. *[She's capped at twenty-four.]*

I know.

[I'm only saying.]

He knew what Ember was saying. He'd been thinking about it since he'd seen her status in the Last Hearth. *Climbing — Expert 1. Level 19. Cap 24.* Five more levels, and then nothing. A girl who climbed mountains like water flowing uphill, and in a year or two the Lattice would tell her she'd climbed as high as she was allowed.

He thought of Brannoc, staring at his hands. *Nineteen years.*

The heat in his chest stirred.

They stopped to rest in the lee of a big boulder a little before dawn. Wren pulled a strip of dried meat out of her pack and tore it in half and handed him the bigger piece without asking. They sat side by side with their backs against the cold rock, chewing, watching the sky over the eastern peaks begin to pale.

"So," Wren said. "Are you going to tell me?"

"Tell you what?"

"What you are. Why the Wardens are chasing you up a mountain in the middle of the night. Why your eyes go gold." She chewed. "Why you want to go to the Hollowmaw, when every person in Thistledown would cut off their own foot before they went near it."

Lex didn't answer right away. He looked out over the mountains, ridge after ridge going grey and then blue in the growing light.

"My father was a sorcerer," he said at last. "I didn't know that until a week ago. I thought he was a merchant who left us. Turns out he was something else, and when he left, he put a seal on me. On my power. So nobody would find me." He turned Anvilson over in his lap, looking at the runes. "The seal broke. Now people are finding me."

Wren was quiet for a moment. "And the Hollowmaw?"

"My brother's there."

He felt her go still beside him.

"Your brother," she said slowly.

"His seal broke eight years ago. Badly. He—" Lex stopped. Started again. "Our mother died. Our house burned down. He ran away up here. And now everyone calls him the mad warlock of the Greyspine."

The silence stretched for a long time. The sky over the eastern peaks had gone from grey to pale gold.

"So you're the warlock's brother," Wren said at last.

"Yes."

"And you're going up there to find him."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Because my father's dying somewhere. And the only way to reach him is if both of us go together." Lex laughed shortly. It didn't sound much like a laugh. "That's what I'm told, anyway."

Wren chewed her dried meat. She didn't say anything for so long that he started to wonder if she was working out how to get her money back and leave him on the mountain.

"My da was killed by a rock-wyrm," she said finally. "Three winters ago. Up on the north face, past the Teeth. He was running a trapline and it came out of a crevasse and took him. I found what was left a week later." She tore off another piece of meat. "Mam was down the mines by then, so it was me and my little brothers on the ridge. Tam and Robbie. They're eleven and nine. I've been running Da's lines ever since."

"I'm sorry."

"Don't be sorry. It's the mountain. The mountain kills people." She shrugged. "What I'm saying is, I don't have a da either. Not one that's coming back. If someone told me I could find mine, if I'd just go and knock on a mad warlock's door..." She was quiet for a moment. "I'd probably do it. I'd be scared out of my mind. But I'd do it."

Lex looked at her.

She didn't look back. She was looking at the sunrise, her freckled face lit gold, her jaw set.

"Thank you," he said.

"Don't thank me. You paid me." She stood and brushed off her hands. "Come on, Hammer. The Teeth are an hour up. And Fenn will be on the trail by now."



THE TEETH WERE WELL named.

They were a ridge of black rock running east and west across the top of the world, jagged and broken, each spire of stone sharp as a fang and streaked with ice. Snow lay deep in the gaps between them. And on the eastern side, where the Sawback Pass should have been, there was only a great raw scar where half the mountain had come down: a slope of shattered ice and boulders and snow, forty feet deep, stretching for half a mile.

"Told you," said Wren.

The entrance to the Frostvault was at the base of the westernmost Tooth, where the ridge met the slope. It didn't look like much. A crack in the rock, tall and narrow, black inside. Old ice hung from the lip of it like teeth. But as they came close, Lex felt something change in the air: a kind of pressure, a humming, like standing near a big bell after it's been struck. The silver Veil that hung thin over everything up here was thicker around the crack, drawn toward it, swirling slowly into the black.

And when he stepped through the crack, a panel opened in front of his eyes.

DELVE ENTERED
THE FROSTVAULT

Floors: 3
Recommended level: 12 - 18
Current fellowship: NONE

Warning: Delve guardians do not
retreat. Delve exits open only on
completion or death.

"Delve exits open only on completion or death," Lex read aloud. "That's cheerful."

"It means you can't go back." Wren had stepped in beside him. He could see from the slight unfocus of her eyes that she was reading her own panel. "Once you're in, you're in. Only way out is through."

"You didn't mention that."

"You didn't ask." She glanced sideways at him. "Also, you're level eight. Recommended's twelve. I didn't mention that either."

"I'm aware."

"I'm nineteen. So we average out." She paused. "Sort of."

[You should form a fellowship,] said Ember. *[It'll let you share experience, and see each other's health. In a Delve, that matters.]*

"How do I—"

[Just want it. And ask.]

Lex looked at Wren. He thought *fellowship*, deliberately, the way he did with True Sight, and felt something shift in the Lattice around them, like a door being held open.

"Do you want to—" he started, and then stopped, because he didn't know the words, and Wren was already looking at him with her eyebrows raised.

"Is that a fellowship invitation?" she said. "Just popped up. From *Lex*, it says." Her eyes narrowed. "It doesn't say your class."

[I've hidden it,] said Ember. [Your class shows as —. People will see your name and your level, and nothing else. It seemed wiser.]

"Do you want to accept it?" Lex asked.

Wren looked at him for a long moment.

"I haven't been in a fellowship since my da," she said.

She accepted.

FELLOWSHIP FORMED

Lex	Lv 8	(-)
Wren Ashdown	Lv 19	Tracker
Shared experience: ON		

A thin silver bar appeared at the edge of his vision, below his own. *Wren — Health 130/130*. He could feel her, faintly, the way you can feel someone standing behind you in a dark room.

"All right, Hammer," Wren said. She unslung her bow and nocked an arrow. "Stay behind me on the first floor. It's mites, mostly. They come in swarms."

"Mites?"

"You'll see."



HE SAW.

The first floor of the Frostvault was a cave, but not like any cave he'd imagined. It was ice. All of it. Walls of blue-white ice, floor of black ice, ceiling hung with icicles thick as tree trunks. Light came from somewhere inside the ice itself, a cold blue glow, as if the whole cave were a lantern made of frozen water. Their breath smoked. Their boots squeaked on the floor. The air was so cold it burned the inside of Lex's nose.

The mites came out of the walls.

They were small, no bigger than a fist, glassy and many-legged, like spiders made of ice. And there were *hundreds* of them. They came pouring out of cracks in the walls with a sound like sleet on a window, a skittering clicking flood, and the silver tag that floated over them read simply:

FROST MITE – Level 4 (×213)

"Wren," said Lex.

"I know."

"There's two hundred."

"I *know*." She was already shooting. Her arrows went into the flood with sharp little cracks, and every one burst a mite into glittering shards. But there were so many. "Hammer, if you've got anything that does *a lot* of fire all at once, now would be the time."

He did. He thought he did.

He planted his feet, and lifted Anvilson over his head in both hands, and pulled the heat up out of his chest the way he'd pulled it out of the coals by the campfire, the way he'd driven off the bats. Not a strike this time. A *wave*. He pushed it into the hammer and the hammer drank it and blazed orange, then gold, and then he swung it down and around in a great flat circle at waist height, and let go.

The heat went out from him like the blast from an opened furnace door.

It rolled across the ice in a shimmering ring, and where it touched, the mites didn't so much die as *melt*. The front ranks of them sagged and slumped and dissolved into puddles, and the puddles steamed, and the steam rose in a great white cloud that filled the cave. The ones behind kept coming. He swung again. And again. The floor turned to slush under his boots. Water was pouring down the walls. Somewhere a huge icicle cracked and fell and shattered like a dropped chandelier.

Then it was over, and the cave was full of fog and the sound of dripping, and his mana bar was a third of what it had been.

FROST MITE ×213 defeated.

+XP (shared)

SKILL UP: Heat Shaping → Novice 8

LEVEL UP!

Lex — Level 9

Wren lowered her bow. She was looking at him through the steam with her mouth slightly open.

"Huh," she said.

"You said you were done saying that."

"I lied." She looked around at the dripping cave, the shattered icicles, the slush that had been two hundred monsters. "The first time I came through here with Da, it took us an hour to get across this cave. We did it with torches and oil." She shook her head. "Huh."



THE SECOND FLOOR WAS worse.

It was a mine. Or had been, once, long before the Lattice took the place and made it a Delve. There were old timber props in the ice, frozen solid, and rusted rails running along the floor, and here and there the shape of a pickaxe or a lantern locked in the walls like a fly in amber. The tunnels branched and twisted and doubled back. Wren knew the way. She'd marked it the last time she came through with small scratches at the junctions, a habit her father had taught her.

And there were dead men in the ice.

Lex saw the first one at a bend in the tunnel, standing upright inside the wall, perfectly preserved: a miner, middle-aged, bearded, in a leather apron and a felt cap, his eyes open, his mouth open, frozen in the middle of a shout. Lex stopped and stared at him.

"Don't look at them," Wren said quietly, without turning round. "Just keep walking."

"Who were they?"

"The miners who worked here. Before the Delve. A hundred years ago, maybe more. The mana knot opened up underneath them, and the Lattice made the mine into a Delve, and they were still in it." She kept walking. "Da

said the Lattice doesn't care what's in the way when it makes a Delve. It just makes it."

The second miner was further on. The third was a little further.

The fourth one turned its head to watch them pass.

FROST-WIGHT – Level 11 (×6)

They came out of the walls the way the mites had, but slower, with a great creaking groan of splitting ice: six of them, the frozen dead, stiff and slow and terribly strong. Their skin was blue-white. Their eyes were glazed with frost. They carried picks and shovels and broken lengths of rail, and they came shuffling down the tunnel from both directions at once with a sound like old timbers settling.

Wren put an arrow through the eye of the first one. It didn't stop.

"They're dead already," she said through her teeth. "Arrows don't do much. You have to break them."

"Break them," Lex repeated. He hefted Anvilson.

[Ice is brittle,] said Ember. [Heat it and it softens. Heat it fast and it cracks. Hit it hard while it's cracking and it shatters. You know this. You've watched it happen in your slack tub a thousand times.]

He knew it.

The first wight swung a pick at him. He ducked under it and touched it with his hand, not the hammer, just his bare palm against its frozen chest, and pushed *heat* into it. Fast. All at once. He felt the ice under his palm go from rock-hard to soft to *wet* in a heartbeat, and heard it crack, a sound like a frozen pond splitting in the spring, and then he stepped back and swung the hammer with an Ember Strike behind it, and the wight burst apart into a thousand shards.

"Oh, that's good," said Wren behind him. "Do that again."

He did it again.

It wasn't easy. It wasn't quick. The wights were strong, and one of them caught him across the shoulder with a length of iron rail that numbed his whole left arm, and another grabbed Wren from behind and nearly crushed her before Lex got to it. Her health bar dropped to half at the edge of his vision and he felt it like a hand closing on his own throat. But he got to it.

He got his palm on its back and the heat into it and the hammer through it, and it came apart, and Wren rolled clear, gasping.

When it was done, there was nothing left in the tunnel but broken ice and six piles of something that had once been men.

Lex stood among them, breathing hard.

"Are you all right?" he asked Wren.

"Ribs," she said. She was sitting against the wall, one arm wrapped around her middle. "Bruised. Not broken. I'll live." She looked up at him.

"You?"

"Arm's numb."

"It'll come back." She got to her feet, wincing. "Most things do."

FROST-WIGHT ×6 defeated.

+XP (shared)

LEVEL UP!

Lex – Level 10

LEVEL UP!

Wren Ashdown – Level 20

Wren stopped. She'd seen it too. She stood very still in the cold blue tunnel, looking at something only she could see, and Lex watched her face change. It wasn't joy, exactly. It was something more complicated.

"Twenty," she said quietly. "Took me a year to get from eighteen to nineteen." She looked at him. "Four left."

He knew what she meant. Four levels left before the Ceiling.

He didn't say anything. There wasn't anything to say.



HE FOUND THE HIDDEN room by accident.

They were halfway across the second floor, picking their way along a narrow ledge above a frozen shaft, when his Forge Sense *rang*. Not loud. A faint, hollow note, like knocking on a wall that turns out to have a cupboard behind it. He stopped. He put his hand on the ice beside him.

"What?" said Wren.

"There's something behind this."

"There's ice behind that. And then more ice. And then a mountain."

"No. It's hollow." He pressed his palm flat. He could feel it, or hear it, or both: a space behind the ice, a shape, a *made* shape. Square corners. Straight edges. Something built. "There's a room."

[He's right,] said Ember, sounding interested. *[I can feel it too. It's warded. Very old wards, very faded.]* A pause. *[Founders' work, I think.]*

He used Heat Shaping. Slowly, carefully, he pushed the heat into the ice, and the ice went soft and slumped and ran down in streams of meltwater, and behind it, there was a door.

It was stone. Grey, smooth, perfectly square, set flush into the living rock of the mountain. There was no handle. In the center of it was a carving: a hand, open, palm up, and above the palm, a single flame.

Lex stared at it. He knew that shape. He didn't know how he knew it. But his own hand came up, on its own, and he found himself looking at Anvilson, at the fourth rune on the hammer's head, the one that neither he nor Ember could read. The one that had risen up out of him at the end of the forging.

An open hand, held out in the dark.

"That's the same mark," Wren said, looking over his shoulder. "That's the mark on your hammer."

He put his hand on the door.

It swung open without a sound.



THE ROOM BEHIND IT was small, perhaps ten feet square, and completely dry. There was no ice in it at all. The walls were smooth grey stone, and they were covered from floor to ceiling in writing.

Not ordinary writing. Wellschrift. The language under language, the glyph-speech of the Founders. Lines and lines of it, carved into the stone with a precision that made Lex's smith's eye ache with envy. And he could read it. Not all of it. Not even most of it. But words jumped out at him from the walls like faces in a crowd, half-recognized.

Root. Anchor. Hollow. Seal. Blood.

And a name, repeated over and over, carved larger than the rest. *Vey.*

[It's a waystation,] Ember said softly. *[The Founders built them all over the mountains, nine hundred years ago, when they were weaving the Lattice.]*

Places to rest. Places to record.] A pause. [I can read more of it than you can. Do you want me to tell you what it says?]

Yes.

Ember was silent for a long moment.

[Mostly it's technical,] it said at last. *[Measurements of mana flow. Notes on the knot beneath the mountain. But there's a passage here, near the door, that's different. It's a sort of... dedication.]* A pause. *[It says: "Let those of the blood who come after find rest here. The Lattice is a lantern we have hung over the dark. Keep it lit. And if the dark comes calling, remember: a lantern is lit for the ones behind."]*

Lex went cold all over.

A lantern's lit for the ones behind.

"That's my mother's song," he said aloud.

Wren looked at him. "What?"

"The last line. That's from a song my mother used to sing to us. When we were small. *Little light, little light, burning low...*" He stopped. His throat had closed up. "It's a lullaby. Everyone in the Vale knows it. It's about the Lady of Lanterns. It's—it's just a song."

[Little light, little light, burning low,] said Ember, very quietly, in his head. *[Keep the door for the ones who go.]*

Lex went absolutely still.

[If the dark comes calling, don't you mind,] Ember went on, and it wasn't speaking anymore, not exactly. It was almost humming. Almost singing. A low, tuneless, slightly off-key murmur, like a man singing to himself while he worked. *[A lantern's lit for the ones behind.]*

It stopped.

How do you know that? Lex thought. *How do you know that song?*

There was a very long silence in his head.

MEMORY PARTITION 2 ... UNLOCKED

[I don't know,] Ember said finally. Its voice was strange. Unsteady, in a way Lex had never heard it. *[Something just opened. A partition. And there's... there's a memory in it. Just one. It's very small.]* A pause. *[It's dark. There's a fire, banked low, and rain on a roof. And there's a child. Very small. Crying, with a fever. And someone is walking up and down with the*

child in his arms, singing that song. Badly. Off-key. Over and over, until the child falls asleep.] A long silence. [I don't know whose memory it is. I don't know why I have it.]

Lex didn't say anything. He couldn't.

He stood in the little stone room with the writing all around him and the name *Vey* carved over and over in the walls, and he thought about a man walking up and down in the dark, singing badly to a sick child. And he thought about the prologue to every story he'd ever told himself about his father. *He left. He chose that over us. He never cared.*

"Lex?" Wren's voice, close beside him. Gentle, for once. "You all right?"

"I'm fine," he said.

He wasn't. But he turned, and walked out of the room, and the door swung shut behind him without a sound. And when he looked back, the ice was already creeping back over it, slow and blue and silent, sealing it away.

DISCOVERY: Founders' Waystation

+XP

LEVEL UP!

Lex – Level 11



THE THIRD FLOOR WAS a single cavern, vast and round and dark, and in the middle of it, the guardian was waiting.

They felt it before they saw it. The cold. Not the ordinary cold of the Delve, which was bad enough, but a deeper, heavier cold that pressed down on them like a weight as they came out of the tunnel onto the cavern floor. Frost formed on Lex's eyelashes. Wren's breath came out in great white clouds. The ice under their feet was black and smooth as glass, and it creaked.

Then something in the middle of the cavern stood up.

It was a troll. Or it was shaped like one: huge and hunched and long-armed, three times the height of a man, with a head like a boulder and a jaw full of icicle teeth. But it was made of ice. Blue-white, glassy, glowing faintly from within, with a heart of darker blue pulsing slowly in the center

of its chest like a lantern behind frosted glass. Frost poured off it in waves. Where its feet touched the floor, the ice spread and thickened.

RIMEWARDEN – Level 18
DELVE GUARDIAN

"That's new," said Wren faintly. "That wasn't here last time."

"What was here last time?"

"A much smaller troll." She was already backing away, nocking an arrow. "Delve guardians change. The Lattice makes them harder if more people come through." She swallowed. "Or if stronger people come through."

[It's reacting to you,] said Ember quietly. [The Delve senses your power and scales its guardian to match. I'm sorry. I should have anticipated that.]

The Rimewarden opened its mouth and roared, and the roar was a blast of freezing wind that hit them like a wall.

Lex was flung backward across the ice. He slid, spinning, and slammed into the cavern wall. Frost was crawling over his coat, his hands, his face. His health bar dropped. He could feel the cold going into him, deep, deeper than the gloamhound's bite, and the heat in his chest flaring up to fight it.

Across the cavern, Wren had gone down too. She was on her hands and knees, coughing, frost white in her hair.

The Rimewarden turned toward her.

"No," Lex said, and got up.

He didn't remember deciding to. He was simply up, and running, his boots skidding on the black ice, Anvilsong blazing in his hands. The troll raised one great fist over Wren's head. Lex threw himself between them and swung the hammer up with an Ember Strike behind it, and fist and hammer met.

The impact went through him like a lightning bolt. His arms went numb to the shoulders. But the fist cracked. A great split ran up through the troll's ice knuckles in a burst of steam, and the Rimewarden roared and pulled back.

"Wren. Get up."

"Working on it." She was on her feet, swaying, an arrow already on the string. "That thing's eighteen, Hammer. You're eleven. I'm twenty. Combined, that's—"

"Not how it works."

"I know it's not how it works!" She loosed. The arrow struck the Rimewarden in the chest and shattered harmlessly against the ice. "My arrows don't even scratch it!"

[The heart,] said Ember. *[The dark blue core in its chest. That's what animates it. It's the only part that matters. Everything else is just ice.]*

"The heart," Lex said. "Wren, the heart. In its chest. Can you hit it?"

"Through two feet of ice? No!"

"If I crack the ice."

She looked at him. He saw her understand.

"Then yes," she said.



IT TOOK EVERYTHING THEY had.

The Rimewarden was strong and it was huge and it didn't tire, and every time it roared, the freezing wind knocked them flat and coated them in frost, and every time it swung its great fists, the ice floor cracked and heaved. Lex couldn't get close. When he did, the cold that poured off it sapped his strength like a leech, and his mana drained faster than he could use it, just keeping himself warm enough to move.

But he kept going in. Again and again. Wren kept it busy from the side, darting across the ice with her arrows, shooting at its eyes, its knees, its ears, anything to make it turn its head. And every time it turned, Lex closed in and struck.

Not at the heart. At the ice around it. *Ember Strike* after *Ember Strike*, each one blasting a shallow crater of steam into the troll's chest, each one cracking it a little deeper. The Rimewarden roared and knocked him flying. He got up. Went back in. Struck again. A crack spread across its chest like a spider's web. It knocked him flying again. His health was under half now, and his mana was nearly gone.

[One more,] said Ember. *[You've got one more good one in you. Make it count.]*

He looked across the cavern at Wren. She was crouched behind a pillar of ice, her face white with frost, her last three arrows on the string.

"Ready?" he shouted.

She nodded.

He went in one last time. He didn't swing. He ran straight at the Rimewarden, under its swinging fist, and slapped his bare palm flat against the cracked ice of its chest, right over the heart. And he pushed. Every last drop of heat he had, every last scrap of mana, all at once.

The ice around the heart *exploded*.

It burst outward in a blast of steam and shards, and Lex was thrown backward across the cavern for the third time, and as he flew, he saw the heart, the dark blue pulsing heart, suddenly naked in the middle of a smoking crater in the Rimewarden's chest.

Wren loosed.

All three arrows. One after another, so fast the bowstring sang a single note. The first struck the heart and cracked it. The second struck the crack and split it. The third went straight through.

The Rimewarden stopped.

It stood there for a long moment, perfectly still, frost still pouring off it. The light in its chest flickered. Dimmed. Went out.

Then it fell apart. All at once, every piece of it, like a wall of ice falling into the sea. A great roaring crash, and then a long ringing silence, and then the sound of water dripping.

Lex lay on his back on the cold black ice and looked up at the ceiling of the cavern and did not move.

RIMEWARDEN defeated.

DELVE GUARDIAN — bonus XP (shared)

LEVEL UP!

Lex — Level 12

LEVEL UP!

Wren Ashdown — Level 21

THE FROSTVAULT — CLEARED

Exit unsealed.

After a while, a face appeared over him. Freckled. Frost-white. Grinning.

"Hammer," said Wren. "We killed it."

"We killed it."

"We *killed* it. That was eighteen. We killed an eighteen." She dropped down onto the ice beside him and lay there too, looking up at the ceiling, laughing helplessly. "Da would have *died*. He'd have died all over again from shock."

Lex started laughing too. He couldn't help it. It hurt his ribs and his arms and everything else, and he lay there on the black ice in the bottom of a mountain next to a freckled girl he'd met two days ago, and laughed until he couldn't breathe.



THE GUARDIAN LEFT TREASURE behind. Delve guardians always did, Wren told him. The Lattice rewarded those who cleared its trials.

Where the Rimewarden had fallen, among the shards of ice, there was a chest. Old, iron-bound, rimmed with frost. Inside were three things.

A cloak, thick white fur lined with grey wool, that seemed to shed the cold like water off a duck.

FROSTWALKER'S MANTLE

Cloak — Grade: FINE

Cold resistance: high

"Woven from the hide of something
that did not mind the snow."

A quiver of arrows with heads of blue crystal that steamed faintly in the air.

RIMEBITE ARROWS (×20)

Grade: FINE

On hit: freezes target briefly

And a stone, the size of a hen's egg, dark blue and faintly glowing, cold enough to burn the hand that held it. The Rimewarden's heart, Lex realized, or what was left of it. The arrows had split it, but the larger half remained, and when he picked it up, his Forge Sense rang like a bell.

RIMEWARDEN'S HEART (cracked)

Crafting material – Grade: SUPERIOR

"Cold that remembers being alive."

[That,] said Ember, sounding very pleased, [is a remarkable thing to put into a blade. Or a shield. Or anything that ought to be very, very cold.]

Lex gave Wren the arrows and tried to give her the cloak, and she pushed it back at him.

"You're the one who's going to be sitting outside a warlock's cave in the snow," she said. "I'm going home." She looked at the blue stone in his hand. "Keep that too. I don't know what it's for. I don't want to know what it's for."

They climbed out of the Frostvault at dusk.

The exit was on the far side of the Teeth, a crack in the rock just like the entrance, and it let them out onto a high windswept shoulder of the mountain with the whole of the eastern Greyspine spread out before them. Snow, and black rock, and cloud, and the sun going down behind them in a sky the color of a forge.

And there, a mile away across a deep valley, in the face of the highest mountain Lex had ever seen, a cleft.

It was huge. A great black split in the mountainside, a hundred feet tall, as if some giant had driven an axe into the rock and wrenched it out again. Ice hung from its lip. Snow lay heaped around its base. And deep inside it, so deep it was hard to be sure it was there at all, a light was flickering. Not firelight. Something green and cold, and something else, darker than dark, that seemed to pulse in time with the green, like a heartbeat.

As they watched, a sound came echoing across the valley from it. A long, low, wavering note. Not a howl. Something stranger. Almost like music. Almost like a flute.

"The Hollowmaw," said Wren quietly.

Lex looked at it for a long time.

"That's as far as I go," Wren said. "That was the deal."

"I know."

"Near enough you can see it. Then I go home."

"I know, Wren."

She stood beside him in the dusk with her bow over her shoulder and her new arrows at her hip and the wind pulling at her fox-red braid, and she didn't go anywhere.

"You're going to go over there," she said. "Tonight. On your own. Into the warlock's cave."

"Yes."

"Even though everyone who's gone in there for eight years has come out dead."

"Yes."

"Even though he's your brother, and he burned down your house, and everyone says he's mad."

"Yes."

Wren was quiet for a long moment.

"You're an idiot, Hammer," she said at last. But she said it softly.

Across the valley, the strange flute-like note came again, rising and falling, and broke off.

Lex shifted Anvilson on his shoulder and pulled the Frostwalker's Mantle tighter around him. It was warm. He hadn't expected it to be so warm.

"Probably," he said. And he started down the slope toward the Hollowmaw.

He didn't look back. He'd promised himself he wouldn't.

So he didn't see Wren Ashdown stand there on the mountainside for a long time after he'd gone, watching him go, her jaw set and her hands clenched into fists at her sides. And he didn't see her, after a while, swear softly under her breath, and unsling her bow, and start down the slope after him.

CHAPTER 7

THE HOLLOWMAW



[Before you go any further,] said Ember, [I need you to do something for me.]

Lex was halfway down the slope, picking his way between boulders in the blue dusk, with the Hollowmaw looming across the valley ahead of him like an open mouth. He didn't stop. "What?"

[Spend your points.]

"I'll do it later."

[You said that at level eight. You said it at level ten. You've been saying it for two days.] Ember's voice was very patient, in the specific way that patient voices get when they are running out of patience. *[You have forty-two unspent points, Lex. Forty-two. You fought a level-eighteen Delve guardian with the body of a level-five. You're walking into the lair of a man who has killed every Warden sent after him for eight years. Please. I'm asking nicely.]*

Lex stopped.

He hadn't meant to forget. He just kept forgetting. Every time a level came, it came in the middle of something, a fight, a fall, a crisis, and by the time the crisis was over, he was too tired to think about numbers.

He sat down on a rock and called up his status.

LEX HARROW		
Class: EMBERWRIGHT (Unique)		
Level: 12		
MIG 18	AGI 17	VIT 22
INT 24	SPI 48	RES 17
Free points: 42		

[Where do you want them?] he asked.

[Where do you want them?] Ember countered. *[It's your body.]*

Lex thought about it. He thought about the Rimewarden's fist, and the wights, and the bear. He thought about how many times in the last week he'd been knocked flat and gotten back up, and how much harder it got every time.

He thought about his brother, and the Wardens who never came down.

He put ten into Vitality. Eight into Might, eight into Agility. Ten into Resolve, because Ember had told him that Resolve was what kept your mind your own when something tried to get into it, and he didn't know what was waiting in the Hollowmaw, but he had a feeling it might try. The last six he put into Spirit.

They went into him all at once, and it was like being dropped into a hot bath and a cold river in the same moment. His muscles clenched and released. His bones ached and then didn't. His heart thudded, slow and heavy, and his breath came deep and easy, and the fire in his chest flared up so bright he saw gold at the edges of his vision.

POINTS ALLOCATED		
MIG 26	AGI 25	VIT 32
INT 24	SPI 54	RES 27
Health	320/320	
Mana	540/540	
Stamina	290/290	

He sat on the rock for a moment, breathing.

[Better?] said Ember.

"I feel like I could pick up a horse."

[You probably could. A small one. Please don't try.] A pause. [Thank you, Lex.]

He stood. The hammer felt lighter on his shoulder than it had that morning. His legs felt like springs. Across the valley, the strange green light flickered in the depths of the Hollowmaw, and the dark thing that pulsed with it.

He started walking again.



THE MOON CAME UP as he crossed the valley floor, fat and white, a night off full. It lit the snow so bright he could have read by it. It lit the black rock of the mountain face. And it lit, as he came closer, the thing that was wrong with the Hollowmaw.

The Gloam was there.

Not much of it. Not the tide of oily black that had come pouring down the north road into Ashbourne. Just threads. Thin dark wisps of it, curling out of the great cleft like smoke from a smoldering fire, drifting down the mountainside and pooling in the hollows of the snow. Where they pooled, the snow went grey. A stunted pine at the base of the cliff had gone grey to the tips of its needles, and stood there in the moonlight like a tree made of ash.

But the threads didn't go far. That was the strange thing. They came out of the cleft, and drifted, and pooled, and then, at a certain distance from the mouth of the Hollowmaw, maybe fifty paces out, they *stopped*. As if they'd hit a wall. They curled up against nothing, against empty air, and writhed there, and sank back.

[A ward,] Ember said quietly. [There's a ward around the cleft. A circle. I can feel it.] A pause. [It's very strong. And very strange. It isn't Lattice-work, not exactly. It's something older, something rougher. Like a wall built of stones fitted together by hand, without mortar.]

"My brother made it?"

[Who else?]

Lex walked toward the place where the threads stopped. And there, half-buried in the snow, he found the first stone.

It was a rock, a plain grey rock the size of his fist. Someone had drawn on it in charcoal. Not words. A glyph. A shape like a door with a bar across it. And as Lex crouched to look at it, he saw the next one, ten paces to the left, and the one beyond that, a great ring of charcoal-marked rocks running around the mouth of the Hollowmaw in a circle a hundred paces across.

[Wellscrip,] said Ember, very softly. [Crude. Self-taught, I think. Some of the glyphs are wrong, or half-remembered, or invented to fill gaps. But it works.] A long pause. [He's not keeping people out, Lex. Or not only. He's keeping the Gloam in.]

Lex looked up at the cleft. At the green light flickering deep inside it, and the dark pulse that moved with it.

"There's a breach in there," he said slowly. "Isn't there. Like the one Elric talked about. A crack in the Lattice, where the Gloam comes through."

[I think so.]

"And he's been sitting on top of it." Lex stood. "For eight years."

He stepped over the ring of stones.



THE MISTWRAITHS CAME AT him the moment he crossed the line.

He'd half expected it. He'd felt the change in the air as he stepped over, the cold weight of the Gloam pressing on him, the smell of wet ash and rot and nothing. And the threads of black mist that had been pooling in the hollows of the snow suddenly *rose*. They lifted up out of the drifts and twisted and knotted and took shape: tall, thin, ragged shapes, like men made of torn black cloth, with long trailing arms and no legs at all, just tails of smoke that dragged across the snow behind them. Their faces were blank. Their eyes were white.

MISTWRAITH – Level 15 (×4)

Four of them. Fifteen. He was twelve.

He was twelve with forty-two points he'd spent ten minutes ago.

He found out what that meant very quickly.

The first wraith came at him, its long arms reaching, and he didn't dodge it. He didn't need to. He stepped *into* it, faster than he'd ever moved, faster than he'd known a man his size could move, and brought Anvilson around in a blazing arc. The wraith came apart like smoke in a gale. The second came from the side and he turned and caught it on the backswing. Gold fire. A thin cold scream. Gone.

The third wraith wrapped its arms around him from behind.

Cold. Deep, numbing cold, like the gloamhound's bite, pouring into him through his back and shoulders. He felt his health bar drop, felt the grey start to creep in at the edges of his sight. But his Resolve was twenty-seven now, and his Vitality was thirty-two, and the fire in his chest didn't flicker this time. It *roared*. The cold met the heat and the heat ate it, and Lex reached back over his shoulder with his bare hand and grabbed the thing by its ragged face and pushed fire into it, and the wraith screamed and burned and was gone.

The fourth one fled. It turned and streamed away back toward the Hollowmaw like smoke up a chimney, and vanished into the dark of the cleft.

MISTWRAITH x3 defeated. +XP

Lex stood in the moonlit snow, breathing hard, steam rising off him in the cold.

[That,] said Ember, [is what happens when you spend your points.]

"All right. All right, you were right."

[I usually am. It's one of my less endearing qualities.]

But the wraith that had fled had gone *into* the cleft. And as Lex looked up at the dark mouth of the Hollowmaw, he saw the green light inside it flare suddenly bright, and heard, echoing out across the snow, that strange wavering flute-like note again, sharp now, urgent, like an alarm.

Something in there knew he was coming.

He shouldered Anvilson and walked into the dark.



THE CLEFT WAS A cave, and the cave went deep.

It narrowed quickly from the great split in the mountainside to a passage barely wide enough for two men side by side, floored with rough rock and walled with black stone that glistened with frost. The moonlight faded behind him. The green light ahead grew stronger. And as he went deeper, he began to see things.

Charcoal marks on the walls. More of the barred-door glyphs, and others, dozens of others, scrawled across the rock in overlapping layers, some fresh and dark, some faded almost to nothing. Wards on wards on wards. Some of them were crossed out. Some had been written over three or four times, as if the writer had tried and failed and tried again.

And lanterns.

The first one hung from a spike driven into the wall at the first bend of the passage. An old tin lantern, dented and rusted, its glass cracked. Unlit. Then another, a few paces on. Then three together, hanging from a single spike like fruit from a branch. As he went deeper, there were more and more of them. Tin lanterns and brass lanterns, paper lanterns gone yellow and brittle, a fine glass lantern with a broken handle that looked like it had come from some noble's carriage, a battered miner's lamp, a little clay oil-lamp of the kind they used in the chapel at Ashbourne. Dozens of them. Scores. Hanging from spikes and pegs and outcrops of rock, from ropes strung across the ceiling, crowded together in the dark.

None of them were lit.

Lex stopped in the middle of the passage and stared at them, and something in his chest twisted so hard he had to put his hand against the wall.

A light left on for the lost.

The village said Antho had gone mad. The village said he'd become a monster up here in the dark, a killer, a beast. The village had never seen this. A cave full of lanterns, collected one by one over eight long years, scavenged from wrecked caravans and dead men's packs and Lady knew where else, hung up in the dark like a prayer. And never once lit.

[Lex,] said Ember quietly.

"I'm fine."

[You're not. That's all right.] A pause. [I think we're close.]

They were.

The passage opened out ahead into a cavern, and the green light was coming from there, and so was the sound. Not the flute now. A low, wet, whispering hiss, like the gloamhounds, but deeper, bigger, coming from everywhere at once.

And something else. Something small, and close, right at his feet.

A crackle. Like sparks.

He looked down.



THERE WAS A DRAGON on the floor of the passage.

It was small. About the size of a large cat, or a small dog. Long and lean and sinuous, with a narrow wedge-shaped head and a whip of a tail and four clawed feet that gripped the rock like a lizard's. Its scales were blue-grey, the color of a storm cloud, and they shimmered faintly as it moved, catching the green light. It had a crest of soft spines running down its back. It had wings, or one wing, folded neatly against its side, a fine membrane of grey-blue skin stretched over delicate bones. The other wing was wrong. Torn. Half of it missing, the bones twisted, the membrane ragged and scarred.

Its eyes were gold. Not like Lex's eyes when he used True Sight; a different gold, a deep molten amber, slit-pupiled like a cat's.

And it was hissing at him. Its back was arched, its crest standing straight up, its jaws open to show rows of small sharp teeth. Little blue sparks were crackling along its spines and leaping between its teeth, and the air around it smelled sharp and clean, like the moment before a storm.

STORM-DRAKE (juvenile) – Level 9

Name: ASHKA

Bonded to: 

"Hello," said Lex carefully.

The little dragon hissed louder. The sparks along its back flared.

[A storm-drake,] said Ember, in a tone of total wonder. [A real one. I didn't think there were any left in the Greyspine. The Wardens hunted them almost to extinction two hundred years ago.] A pause. [She's bonded to someone. And her wing's been hurt. A crossbow bolt, I'd guess, from the shape of the damage.]

Lex crouched down slowly, very slowly, until he was at eye level with the drake. She didn't stop hissing. But she didn't attack, either.

"Ashka," he said. "That's your name?"

The hissing faltered.

"I'm not going to hurt you." He held out his hand, palm up, the way you'd hold it out to a strange dog. "I'm looking for someone. I think you know him."

The drake looked at his hand. Her nostrils flared. She stretched her long neck out, very cautiously, and sniffed his fingers. And then her whole body went still, and her golden eyes went wide, and she made a sound he'd never heard an animal make before. A sort of chirping trill, high and surprised.

She sniffed his fingers again. Then his wrist. Then she climbed, without asking, onto his outstretched hand and up his arm, her small sharp claws pricking through his sleeve, and poked her narrow head into the collar of his coat and sniffed at his neck, and trilled again, louder, almost frantic.

"What?" said Lex. "What is it? What's—"

And then he felt it. Not with his ears. With something else. A flash of *something* from the little dragon pressed against his neck, like a picture thrown at him out of the dark. A face. A man's face, gaunt and bearded and wild-haired, with eyes that were sometimes black and sometimes grey. And a smell attached to the face, a scent, a feeling. And then his own scent, the same and not the same. And a question, as clear as if she'd spoken it aloud:

Same? Same? Same blood? Same?

"Yes," Lex whispered. "Same blood."

Behind him, in the passage, someone spoke.

"Ashka," said a voice. "*Come here.*"



HE HADN'T HEARD ANYONE come up behind him. He hadn't felt anything. One moment the passage at his back had been empty, a dark tunnel hung with unlit lanterns. The next, there was a man standing in it.

No. Not standing. The shadows in the passage were *moving*. They were pouring off the walls and the ceiling and the floor like water off a roof, and gathering, and pressing together, and out of them, as if he were made of

them, as if the dark itself were tearing loose and taking the shape of a man, stepped Anthoren Harrow.

He was tall. Taller than Lex remembered, though of course Lex had been eleven the last time he'd seen him. And thin, terribly thin, his face all hollows and angles under a wild tangle of black beard. His hair was long and matted and hung past his shoulders. He wore what might once have been a Warden's grey cloak, torn and patched and stained, over layers of furs and rags. His feet were bare on the freezing rock. His hands were bare too, long-fingered and scarred with old burns, and the shadows coiled around them like smoke around a candle.

And his eyes were black.

Not dark. Black. Edge to edge, like holes cut in the world. Exactly the way Lex remembered them through the smoke on the worst night of his life.

The little dragon on Lex's shoulder chirped anxiously and didn't move.

"Ashka," said Antho again. His voice was hoarse, rough with disuse, a voice that hadn't spoken to another human being in a very long time. "Come away from him. *Now.*"

The dragon trilled. She pressed closer against Lex's neck.

Antho's black eyes moved from the dragon to Lex's face. And Lex saw them *not* recognize him. He saw them move over his features without stopping, the way you'd look at a stranger in a crowd. Of course. He'd been eleven. He was nineteen now, and broad from the forge, with burn scars on his arms and a hammer on his shoulder.

And underneath Antho's voice, so faint that Lex almost thought he'd imagined it, he heard something else. A second voice. A whisper, coming out of his brother at the same time as his brother's words, wet and soft and hungry.

[warm... warm iron... smells of fire... smells of home...]

"Who sent you?" said Antho. The shadows around his hands thickened. "The Spire? Kell? I told them. I told them the last time. Stop sending people. *Stop sending people up here.* I can't—" He pressed the heel of one hand against his temple, hard, as if he had a headache. "I can't always hold it. When they come. It gets out. I can't always stop it."

[hungry... hungry... little thing smells so warm...]

"Antho," said Lex.

His brother went still.

"Antho, it's me."

For a long moment, nothing. The black eyes stared at him. The shadows coiled.

Then something passed across Antho's gaunt face. Something like a crack running across ice. And for one heartbeat, just one, the black in his eyes *flickered*, and Lex saw something underneath it, grey and startled and human.

"No," Antho whispered.

[yes yes yes yes —]

"No," said Antho, louder, and he wasn't talking to Lex. He was talking to the thing inside him. "No, no, not him, you can't, *not him—*"

The shadows exploded.



THEY CAME OFF HIM in a wave, a great black tide of them, pouring down the passage toward Lex like water from a burst dam. Lex had time to throw up his arm, time to feel the fire in his chest leap up, and then they hit him.

It wasn't like the Gloam. The Gloam was cold. This was something else. This was *nothing*. An absence. Like falling into a hole in the world. The shadows wrapped around him, around his arms and legs and chest, and where they touched, he felt himself going *quiet*: the fire in his chest dimming, the sound of his own heartbeat fading, everything becoming soft and muffled and far away, like a man going deaf, like a man going to sleep in the snow.

SHADOWBIND (Hollow)

Movement: RESTRICTED

Mana regeneration: HALTED

He heard Ashka shriek, a high furious sound, and felt her leap off his shoulder. Felt sparks crackle somewhere near him, blue-white, and the shadows flinch.

"Ashka, *no—*"

He couldn't move. He could barely see. Through the swirling dark, he could make out his brother's shape, standing in the passage with his arms out and the shadows pouring off him, and his face—

His face was terrible. It was *two* faces. One of them was his brother's, twisted in an agony of effort, teeth gritted, tears streaming down into his beard. And the other was the black-eyed thing, the hungry thing, the thing that had looked out at Lex through the smoke eight years ago. They flickered back and forth across his features like two pictures in a magic lantern, one and then the other, faster and faster.

[let me let me let me let me let me in—]

[Lex,] said Ember sharply, from very far away. [Lex, listen to me. You have to break it. Push the fire out. All of it. Now.]

He's my brother.

[I know. You won't hurt him. It isn't him holding you. It's the thing inside him. Burn it.]

He pushed.

The fire came up from his chest the way it had on the green at Ashbourne, the way it had in the Frostvault: everything at once, a furnace blast. It met the shadows and the shadows *screamed*, not with Antho's voice but with the other one, the wet hungry whisper rising to a shriek, and they burst away from him in rags and tatters of dark.

Lex fell to his knees on the cold rock, gasping.

Antho staggered back. He hit the wall of the passage and slid down it. The shadows were still pouring off him, but thinner now, ragged, and his eyes—

His eyes were flickering. Black to grey to black.

[Clarity,] said Ember, very quietly. [Look.]

A panel had opened over Antho's head. Not silver. Not gold. Red. Red and broken, the letters glitching and jumping, as if the Lattice itself couldn't hold them steady.

ANTHOREN HÆRROW

Class: HOLLÆW-TOUCHED WÆRLOCK

Grade: ERROR

CLARITY: 14 / 100 ▼▼

WARNING – below 20

[REDACTED] may act through host

Clarity, Lex thought. Fourteen out of a hundred.

His brother was drowning.

Lex looked down at Anvilsong, lying on the rock where he'd dropped it. He could pick it up. He could call it to his hand and put an Ember Strike into it and end this. The thing in his brother was weak right now, ragged, burned. One good blow. Elric had said it, on the mountainside, half-joking. *Hit him with your hammer, and run.*

He looked at his brother's face. At the tears in his beard. At the long scarred hands pressed against the rock, shaking.

He didn't pick up the hammer.

He did the only thing he could think of.

He sang.



HE DIDN'T HAVE MUCH of a voice. He'd never had one. Brannoc hummed hymns, badly; Lex didn't even do that. But he knew the tune. He'd known it his whole life. He'd heard it a hundred times in the dark, in the loft under the eaves, with his brother's warm back against his and the rain on the thatch and his mother's voice drifting up the ladder from the kitchen below. And he'd heard it two hours ago, hummed off-key by a voice in his head that didn't know why it knew it.

"Little light, little light, burning low," he sang. His voice cracked on the first line. He kept going. *"Keep the door for the ones who go."*

Antho went absolutely still.

The shadows stopped moving. They hung in the air of the passage like smoke in a windless room.

"If the dark comes calling, don't you mind," Lex sang. He was crying now. He didn't care. *"A lantern's lit for the ones behind."*

Silence.

The red panel over Antho's head flickered.

CLARITY: 14 → 19 ▲

"*Little light, little light,*" Lex sang again, softer, because his voice was going. "*Burning low...*"

"*Keep the door,*" Antho whispered.

His voice was barely there. Hoarse and cracked and shaking. But he was singing. Lex heard it. His brother was sitting against the wall of the passage with his head in his hands, and he was singing the lullaby back, the way they'd sung it together in the dark when they were small.

"*For the ones who go.*"

CLARITY: 19 → 27 ▲

"*If the dark comes calling,*" they sang together, both of them, two broken voices in a cave full of unlit lanterns. "*Don't you mind. A lantern's lit for the ones behind.*"

CLARITY: 27 → 34 ▲

 suppressed

The shadows fell.

They didn't burst or scatter. They just *fell*, like a cloak slipping off a man's shoulders, and puddled on the rock floor of the passage, and sank into it, and were gone. The cold that had been pressing on everything lifted. The wet hungry whisper stopped, mid-hiss, as if a door had swung shut on it.

And Antho lifted his head.

His eyes were grey.

Grey, and red-rimmed, and wet, and absolutely human. The grey of a winter sky, of rain on a slate roof. Their mother's eyes.

He looked at Lex for a long, long time. Lex saw him really look this time. Saw his gaze move over Lex's face and stop, and catch, and hold, the way your eye catches on a word you know in a page of foreign writing.

"Lex?" he whispered.

"Hi, Antho."

"Lex." Antho's voice cracked. "You—you got *tall*."

Lex laughed. It came out as a sob. "You got hairy."

Antho made a sound that might have been a laugh. Then his face crumpled, and he put his hands over it, and his thin shoulders shook.

Ashka came scurrying out of the shadows where she'd been hiding and climbed into his lap and pushed her narrow head up under his chin, chirping anxiously, little blue sparks crackling along her spines. Antho wrapped his arms around her without looking and held on.

Lex sat on the cold rock floor, three feet away, and didn't know what to do.

He'd imagined this moment a hundred times. Not hoped for it, never that, but imagined it, the way you imagine your worst fears, lying awake. He'd imagined finding his brother a monster. A madman. A killer with black eyes who laughed at him. He'd imagined fighting him. He'd imagined, in his darkest moments, killing him, and feeling nothing.

He had never once imagined this. His brother sitting in the dark with a little broken-winged dragon in his arms, crying like a child.



IT WAS A LONG time before either of them spoke.

When Antho finally lowered his hands, his face was blotched and wet, and he looked older than twenty-four. Much older. He looked at Lex, and then at the hammer on the floor, and then at Lex's hands, and something in his expression changed. Sharpened. A kind of horror dawning.

"Your seal," he said. "It broke."

"A week ago."

"No." Antho's voice was very quiet. "No, no, no. It wasn't supposed to. Yours was supposed to hold. Yours was the strong one. He made yours *different*, I saw him do it, I was there—" He stopped. His face went white. "If yours broke, then he's—"

"Dying," said Lex. "Maybe. That's what I've been told."

Antho stared at him.

"Father's alive?" he whispered.

"For now."

Something went across Antho's face that Lex couldn't read. Grief and rage and wild hope, all tangled together, like iron and slag in a bad bar. Antho opened his mouth. Closed it again. Looked away.

"I looked for him," he said at last, very quietly. "Did you know that? The first two years. When I could think. When the thing in me let me think. I went east, all the way to the edge of the Blightmarch. I went to Saltreach. I went to every place I could remember him ever talking about." He laughed, short and harsh. "I thought, if I could just find him, he'd know how to fix it. He'd know how to make it stop. He made the seal; he'd know how to put it back." He stroked Ashka's spines, slowly, over and over. "I never found him. And every time I went near people, every time I went near a town, it got *louder*. The thing. It wanted them. It wanted to go into them. So I came back up here. Where there's nobody. Where I can't hurt anybody."

"You hurt Wardens," said Lex.

Antho closed his eyes.

"Yes," he said. "I did. Some of them." His jaw worked. "They came up here with crossbows and chains and Inspection scrolls, and they shot Ashka, and they tried to take me back to the Spire, and when they got close, I couldn't hold it. It got out. It went into them." His voice was flat and dead. "Some of them I killed. Some of them it killed. I don't always know which. I don't always remember." He opened his eyes and looked at Lex. "That's what I am, Lex. That's what you came all this way to find."

Lex looked at him for a long time.

Then he said the thing he'd been carrying for eight years. The thing he'd carried up the mountain, through the wolves and the bear and the Delve. The thing that was heavier than the hammer.

"You killed her," he said.

The cave was very quiet.

Antho didn't flinch. He didn't look away. He sat there against the wall with the little dragon in his arms and looked at his brother with their mother's grey eyes.

"No," he said. "I didn't."

"I *saw* you."

"You saw me standing in the kitchen with my eyes black and the house on fire." Antho's voice was very steady. "You were eleven. You came down the ladder in the smoke. And you saw me, and you saw her, and then something happened you couldn't see. Something happened that you couldn't remember after. Isn't that right?"

Lex said nothing. His heart was pounding.

"I'll tell you what happened," said Antho quietly. "If you want to know. I've never told anyone. There's never been anyone to tell."

"Tell me."



"**WHEN I TOUCHED THE** Stone," Antho said, "it was like a door opening. You know. You've felt it now. Like something that's been locked up inside you your whole life, and suddenly the lock's gone. But mine didn't open onto fire, the way yours did. Mine opened onto..." He searched for the word. "Nothing. A great big nothing. A dark that goes on forever, under everything. Under the world. And there was something in it."

He stopped. Ashka chirped softly, and he stroked her head.

"It noticed me," he said. "That's the only way I can describe it. The way you'd notice a crack of light under a door, if you'd been in the dark a long, long time. It noticed me, and it came toward the light, and it started to *push*. And the push was a voice. It's never stopped, Lex. Not once, not in eight years. Every waking minute, and most of the sleeping ones. It wants. That's all it is. It *wants*." He swallowed. "That first day, I didn't know what it was. I just knew it was loud. And it was getting louder. And by nightfall, it was so loud I couldn't hear anything else."

"You told me to go away," Lex said. "In the loft. You said *it's so loud*."

"I remember." Antho's mouth twisted. "I'm sorry. I was trying to keep you away from it."

"What happened that night?"

Antho was quiet for a long moment.

"It got through," he said at last. "That night, in the kitchen. I went downstairs because I couldn't stand the loft anymore, I couldn't stand being near you, I was so afraid it would get out and go *into* you. And Mam was there, banking the fire. And she looked at me, and I knew she could see

it. She was a Listener, Lex. Did you know that? She could feel things. She could feel what was in me." He shut his eyes. "And it saw her see it. And it *pushed*. And something tore."

"Tore."

"A hole. In the air. Right there in the kitchen, in front of the hearth. Like someone had taken a knife to the world and cut it open. It was black inside, black like the inside of my head, and *cold*, cold enough to freeze the fire in the grate. And it was getting bigger. And the thing was on the other side of it. Coming *through*. I could feel it. It was using me like a door, and it was coming through, into our house, toward you, and I couldn't stop it. I tried. I tried so hard. I couldn't stop it."

His voice had dropped to a whisper.

"And Mam stood up," he said. "She stood up from the hearth, and she walked past me, and she stood in front of the hole. Right in front of it. And she started to sing."

Lex's breath caught.

"*Little light, little light*," Antho whispered. "She sang it right into the dark. And I felt the thing stop. Just for a second. Like it was listening. Like it didn't know what that was, a song, a person singing into the dark without being afraid. And she looked back at me over her shoulder, and she said—" His voice broke completely. He pressed his face into Ashka's spines for a moment, and when he lifted it again, it was wet. "She said, *Look after your brother, Antho. I'll keep the door*."

"No," Lex said.

"And she walked into it."

"No—"

"She walked into the dark. Still singing. I could hear her for a long time. Getting fainter. And the hole closed behind her. Like a door slamming. From the *other side*." Antho's hands were shaking. "And when it closed, everything it had been holding back came out at once. All the heat. All the fire that it had frozen. The kitchen just *went*. Everything. The whole house. That's why it burned so hot. That's why they never found her." He looked at Lex. "Because she wasn't there to find. She was on the other side of the door. She closed it on herself to keep the thing from getting to you."

Lex couldn't speak.

"She told me to look after you," said Antho. "And I couldn't. I couldn't even look after myself. The thing was still in me, still talking, still pushing, and I knew if I stayed it would get out again. It would go into you. Or into Brannoc, or Orla, or anyone. So I ran." He laughed, harsh and broken. "I told myself I was keeping you safe. Keeping the door, like she said. Maybe I was. Or maybe I was just a coward who couldn't stand to look at you." He shook his head. "I've never been able to work out which."

The cave was silent. Somewhere deep in it, the green light flickered and the dark pulse moved, slow as a sleeping heart.

Lex sat on the cold rock floor and looked at his brother.

Eight years. Eight years of hating him. Eight years of lying awake in the loft above the forge and remembering those black eyes in the smoke, and building the hate up, brick by brick, wall by wall, until it was a house he lived in. A house with no doors and no windows, where he didn't have to look at anything else. *Murderer. He went mad and burned his own mother. He walked away and he didn't look back.*

And all that time his brother had been up here in the dark, alone, with a monster in his head. Collecting lanterns.

"I've hated you," Lex said. His voice came out very small. "For eight years. I've hated you every day."

"I know," said Antho quietly. "I've hated me longer."

Lex looked at him. At the gaunt face and the wild beard and the grey, grey eyes.

Then he got up off the rock floor, and crossed the three feet of cave between them, and sat down next to his brother against the wall. Close enough that their shoulders touched.

Antho went rigid. Ashka chirped.

Lex didn't say anything. He didn't know what to say. He just sat there with his shoulder against his brother's shoulder, the way they'd slept in the loft under the eaves when he was small, Antho's warm back against his. And after a long moment, he felt Antho's shoulder, very slowly, begin to relax.

They sat in the dark together, surrounded by unlit lanterns, and neither of them said anything for a long time.

CHAIN QUEST: The Brother in the Mountain

- ◆ Reach Thistledown DONE
- ◆ Find the Hollowmaw DONE
- ◆ Speak with your brother ... DONE

QUEST COMPLETE

+XP

LEVEL UP!

Emberwright – Level 13

CLARITY: 34 → 41 ▲

Proximity: blood kin detected

"Lex," Antho said at last, very quietly.

"Yeah."

"Your eyes." His brother turned his head. "When you came in. When you were fighting it. They went gold."

"They do that."

Antho looked at him for a long time. Then, for the first time, something moved at the corner of his mouth. Small. Crooked. Exactly, Lex realized with a jolt, like his own.

"Mine go black," Antho said. "We're a matched set."

And from the mouth of the passage behind them, where the moonlight still faintly reached, came a small, sharp, unmistakable sound. The creak of a bowstring being drawn.

"Hammer," said Wren Ashdown's voice, very steady. "I really, really hope that's your brother. Because if it isn't, I've got an arrow pointed at the back of his head."

CHAPTER 8

TWO KINDS OF DARK



ANTHO DIDN'T MOVE. THAT was the first thing Lex noticed. Anyone else, hearing a bowstring creak behind their head in the dark, would have flinched, or spun, or thrown up their hands. Antho just sat very still against the wall of the passage, and closed his eyes, and let out a slow, tired breath.

"Hello," he said, without turning around. "You must be the one who's been following him since the Frostvault."

Behind them, Wren's voice didn't waver. "How did you know that?"

"Ashka told me." The little dragon in his lap chirped. "She smelled you an hour ago. A girl, she said. Pine sap and wet leather and fear." Antho opened his eyes. "Mostly fear. Though you're hiding it well."

"I'm not afraid," said Wren.

"You've got an arrow pointed at the mad warlock of the Greyspine. If you weren't afraid, you'd be stupid. And I don't think you're stupid." Antho tilted his head slightly, still not turning. "Lex. Is she a friend of yours?"

Lex looked over his shoulder. Wren was standing at the bend of the passage, perhaps ten paces back, a dark shape against the faint grey of the moonlit mouth of the cave. Her bow was at full draw. The arrowhead, one of the blue Rimebite arrows from the Frostvault, was steaming faintly in the cold air, and it was pointed with perfect steadiness at the back of his brother's skull.

"Yes," Lex said. "She's a friend."

"Then would you ask her to put that away? I've had enough arrows in this cave for one lifetime." Antho's hand moved slowly over Ashka's torn wing. "So has she."

"Wren," said Lex. "It's all right. He's my brother."

Wren didn't lower the bow. "I saw what he did. I was at the bend. I saw the shadows. I saw his *eyes*."

"I know."

"He nearly killed you."

"*It* nearly killed me," said Lex. "Not him." He held her gaze through the dark. "It's all right. I promise."

For a long moment, nothing. Wren's arms didn't shake. Her face, what he could see of it, was white and set. Then, very slowly, she let the bowstring down, and lowered the bow, though she didn't put the arrow back in the quiver.

"Fine," she said. "But I'm keeping it out."

"That's fair," said Antho mildly. He turned his head at last and looked at her over his shoulder, and Lex saw Wren take an involuntary half step back. In the green light from the cavern, Antho's gaunt bearded face looked like something carved out of old wood. But his eyes were grey, and tired, and only human.

"You said *quadruple*," Wren said to Lex, not taking her eyes off Antho. "I should have said *ten times*."



ANTHO'S LAIR WAS THE cavern at the end of the passage.

It was bigger than Lex had expected. Round and high-roofed, like the inside of a bell, with walls of black rock that glistened with frost and a floor worn smooth by water a thousand years ago. Here, too, there were lanterns: hanging from every spike and outcrop, crowding the walls, dangling from ropes strung across the ceiling. Hundreds of them, maybe. Unlit, all of them, silent, swaying slightly in some draft Lex couldn't feel.

There was a fire in a ring of stones near the entrance. A real fire, small and smoky, burning on twisted lengths of dead pine. There was a heap of furs and rags against the wall that Lex supposed was a bed. There was a crude table made of a flat slab of rock balanced on two others, and on it,

and around it, and spilling off it onto the floor in great drifts, there was *paper*.

Paper, and parchment, and birch bark, and the flat inside surfaces of torn leather, and anything else that would take a mark. All of it covered in writing. Charcoal and soot and ink made from something dark that Lex didn't want to think about. Drawings and diagrams, maps and lists, columns of numbers. And glyphs. Endless glyphs, Wellsript, written and rewritten and crossed out and written again, the way they'd been written on the walls of the passage.

And at the far end of the cavern, where the floor sloped down into darkness, there was the breach.

Lex felt it before he saw it. A cold that went deeper than the cold of the mountain. A pull, like standing at the edge of a cliff. The smell, wet ash and rot and nothing, so thick here that it coated the back of his throat. And then, as his eyes adjusted, he saw it: a place in the air at the bottom of the slope where the darkness was *wrong*. Not black. Blacker than black. A crack, ragged and vertical, perhaps the height of a man and a hand's width across, hanging in empty space with nothing on either side of it. As if someone had taken a knife to the world and cut it, and the cut had never healed.

The Gloam was seeping out of it. Slowly. A thin dark trickle, like water seeping from a cracked dam.

And around it, in a circle on the floor, there was a ring of fire.

Green fire. That was the light he'd seen from across the valley. It burned in a perfect circle around the crack, low and steady, without fuel, without smoke, a cold green flame like foxfire in a marsh. Glyphs had been scratched into the rock beneath it. And where the trickle of Gloam from the crack reached the green fire, it hissed and recoiled, like a slug touching salt.

"*Lady of Lanterns*," Wren whispered. She'd come in behind them, the arrow still in her hand. "What *is* that?"

"A wound," said Antho. He'd gone to the fire by the entrance and was crouched beside it, feeding it twigs, not looking at the crack. "A hole in the Lattice. A door into the place the thing comes from." He set Ashka down by the fire, and the little dragon curled up close to the flames with a

contented chirp. "It opened about four years ago. I was hunting in the valley and I felt it tear, like a seam ripping in a coat. I came up here and found it. It was smaller then. I've been keeping it from getting bigger ever since."

"For four years," said Lex.

"For four years." Antho broke a stick over his knee. "The green fire's mine. A ward. I worked it out myself, from bits and pieces. It doesn't close the hole. I don't know how to close it. But it slows it down. Keeps most of the Gloam inside the circle. What gets past the fire, the ring of stones outside catches." He fed the broken stick into the flames. "Most of it."

"The black mist in the gullies," said Wren slowly. "The stuff the trappers talk about. The grey grass. The sheep."

"Is what gets past both." Antho didn't look at her. "I'm sorry. I'm doing my best. I can't always hold it. When I'm tired. When the thing in my head is loud. When the Wardens come, and I have to—" He stopped. "It gets out. A little. I can't stop all of it."

"And the stories," said Wren. "The warlock in the Hollowmaw. That the black mist comes from him. That he's the one doing it."

Antho laughed. It wasn't a nice sound. "I expect it looks that way from Thistledown."

Lex looked at the crack in the air. At the green fire guttering around it. At the trickle of Gloam seeping out, slow and steady and endless.

He thought about Elric on the green at Ashbourne, staring north at the mountains. *They came here tonight because they felt your seal crack. They'll be back.* And he thought about the hounds coming down the north road, and where they might have come from.

"How much has it grown?" he said quietly. "Since you found it?"

Antho was silent for a moment.

"It was a finger's width," he said at last. "When I found it. Four years ago." He looked at the crack, finally, for the first time since they'd come into the cavern. "It's been growing faster, these last few months. Like something on the other side is pushing harder. Or like something on this side that was holding it shut is getting weaker."

Lex thought about the seal. About the walls of a house getting thinner.

[Lex,] said Ember quietly. [I think your father isn't only feeding your seal. I think he's feeding something much bigger. And I think it's failing.]



THEY SAT AROUND ANTHO'S fire and ate Mother Orla's bread, the last of it, gone hard as a brick, and some dried meat from Wren's pack, and a stew Antho made in a dented iron pot from snowmelt and something he said was rabbit, and that Lex decided not to ask about.

Antho ate like a starving man. Then he stopped halfway through his bowl and looked at it, and looked at Lex, and set it down.

"You should have the rest," he said. "You've come a long way."

"I'm fine."

"You're bigger than me. You need more."

"Antho. Eat the stew."

His brother looked at him for a long moment. Then, slowly, he picked up the bowl again. Lex pretended not to notice that his hands were shaking.

Wren sat on the far side of the fire with her bow across her knees and watched them both. She'd put the arrow back in her quiver eventually, after Antho had made the stew and given her a bowl and gone and sat as far from her as the cavern allowed. But she hadn't stopped watching him. Every time he moved, her eyes followed.

"You can ask," Antho said to her at last, without looking up from his stew. "Whatever it is you want to ask."

Wren's jaw tightened. "Did you kill the Wardens? The ones who came up here."

"Some of them."

"How many?"

Antho was quiet for a while. "Eleven," he said at last. "That I know of. That I remember." He set down his spoon. "There may be more. When the thing is out, when Clarity drops low enough, I don't always remember what happens. I just wake up afterward and there's—" He stopped. "And there's whatever there is."

"And you don't feel bad about it?"

Antho looked up at her then. Lex saw her flinch at the look on his face.

"I feel bad about all of it," Antho said quietly. "Every single one. Every day. I can tell you their faces. I can tell you which ones had wives, because they talked about them when they were dying. I can tell you that one of them was nineteen and had a cleft chin and kept calling for his mother." His voice didn't rise. It got flatter, and quieter, and somehow worse. "They came up here with crossbows and chains, to drag me back to the Spire, where the Wardens would have locked me in a white room and *studied* me for the rest of my life. And they shot Ashka out of the sky when she tried to protect me. And I still feel bad about every single one of them. I'd give anything to undo it." He looked back down at his stew. "But I can't. So I sit up here, and I keep the hole from getting bigger, and I try not to let anyone else come close enough to get hurt. That's all I've got."

Wren didn't say anything. After a moment, she looked away into the fire.

Lex watched his brother eat. He thought about the green fire burning around the breach, and the ring of charcoal-marked stones in the snow, and four years of keeping a door shut on something that wanted to come through.

Look after your brother, Antho. I'll keep the door.

"You've been doing what she did," he said slowly. "Haven't you. Keeping the door."

Antho went very still.

Then he set down his bowl, and got up without a word, and walked away to the far side of the cavern, and stood there with his back to them, looking at the green fire.

Lex didn't follow. After a while, Ashka uncurled from beside the flames and went padding across the cavern floor, her torn wing dragging slightly, and climbed up onto Antho's shoulder. He reached up and touched her without turning round.

"That was the wrong thing to say," Wren said quietly.

"I know."

"Or the right one."

"I know that too."



LATER, WHEN ANTHO HAD come back and sat down by the fire again and they'd all pretended nothing had happened, Lex asked if he could look at him.

"Look at me?"

"My eyes. The gold thing. It lets me see the Lattice. Your status, all of it. Even the parts that are hidden." Lex hesitated. "Elric said it's rude to do it without asking."

"Elric." Antho's face went sharp. "Elric Thorne? Father's friend? The one with the lightning?"

"He found me. In Ashbourne. He told me about you."

Antho was quiet for a moment. "He came up here once," he said. "Six years ago, I think. Seven. He stood outside the ring of stones and called my name. Said he was a friend of Father's and he wanted to help." He stared into the fire. "I didn't go out. It was a bad night. Clarity was low and the thing was loud, and it wanted him. It *really* wanted him." He frowned. "I remember that. It wanted him more than it wanted the Wardens. I thought it was strange at the time."

"Why would it want him more?"

"I don't know. Maybe it just liked the taste of him." Antho shook his head. "He went away after a while. I never saw him again." He looked at Lex. "Go on, then. Look. I want to know what it says too. I've never been able to read my own panel properly. It's all broken."

Lex looked.

The gold rose up behind his eyes, and he braced himself for the red glitching panel he'd seen in the passage. But True Sight saw deeper than the Lattice's ordinary display. The panel that unrolled over Antho's head was gold, like his own, though shot through with jagged veins of red and black, like a cracked windowpane with darkness leaking through.

ANTHOREN VEY (registered: HARROW)		
Age: 24		
Class: HOLLOW-TOUCHED WARLOCK		
Grade: ERROR (corrupted UNIQUE)		
Tier: IXX – Level 31		
MIG 14	AGI 24	VIT 20
INT 41	SPI 58	RES 9
CLARITY: 44 / 100		
SKILLS		
Shadowbind Expert 3		
Void Bolt Expert 1		
Hollow Gate Journeyman 6		
Grave-Speech Journeyman 2		
Ward-Scribing Journeyman 9		
(self-taught; 31% glyphs invalid)		
ROOT		
Seal: SHATTERED		
Authority: IXX / 100 (UNSTABLE)		
Breach-link: ACTIVE		
IXX (HOLLOW) – bound to host		

He read it out. All of it. When he got to *Vey*, Antho made a small sound.

"That's Father's name," he said. "Isn't it. His real one."

"Elric says so."

"Vey." Antho said it slowly, tasting it. "Anthoren Vey." He laughed, short and strange. "I've been Antho Harrow so long I'd forgotten anyone ever called me anything else." He was quiet for a moment. "Mam called him that once. *Arion Vey*. When she thought we were asleep. She was crying." He shook his head. "I'd forgotten that too."

"Resolve nine," said Wren, who'd been listening to all of it with her arms folded. "That's low. That's really low. Mine's sixteen."

"Resolve is what keeps your mind your own," said Lex, echoing Ember. "When something tries to get into it."

"It used to be higher," said Antho. "Fourteen, I think, when I was Kindled. It's been going down. Every year, a point or two." He looked at his hands. "The thing wears it away. Like water wearing down a stone."

"*Corrupted unique*," Lex said. He was staring at that line. "Your class was supposed to be unique. Like mine. Something special. And it got... broken."

"Breach-link: active," said Wren. "Hollow, bound to host." She looked at Antho. "That's the thing. That's the voice in your head. It's *tied* to you. Like a dog on a chain."

"Or like a man on a dog's chain," said Antho quietly. "Depending on the day."

[Lex,] said Ember softly. [*The breach-link. Look at it carefully. Do you see what it's connected to?*]

He looked. He let True Sight go deeper, the way he had in the Frostvault waystation, and the panel seemed to open like a flower, unfolding layers beneath layers. And there, under the line that read *Breach-link: ACTIVE*, there was a thread. A fine dark thread, invisible to ordinary eyes, running out of the panel and across the cavern and down the slope to the crack in the air at the bottom.

His brother wasn't just guarding the breach.

He was *tied* to it.

"Antho," he said slowly. "The hole. You said you found it four years ago. That you felt it tear."

"Yes."

"Did you ever think—" Lex stopped. Started again. "Did you ever think maybe you felt it tear because it was *you*? Not you doing it. But the thing in you. Pulling on the world from the inside. Wanting a door."

Antho stared at him.

Then he looked down the slope at the crack in the air, and his face went grey.

"Oh," he said very quietly. "Oh, Lady. Oh, no."



THEY DIDN'T SLEEP MUCH that night. Lex didn't think any of them did.

He lay on a heap of furs Antho had given him, near the fire, with Anvilsong close by his hand and the Frostwalker's Mantle pulled around

him, and stared up at the hundreds of unlit lanterns hanging from the cavern ceiling, swaying gently in the draft from the breach.

He could hear his brother moving around in the dark. Pacing. Muttering. Once, very quietly, playing a few notes on something that sounded like a flute, a thin breathy wavering sound, before stopping abruptly. Once, talking to someone in a low urgent voice, and then falling silent. Lex didn't know if he'd been talking to Ashka or to the thing in his head.

[He's frightened,] said Ember quietly.

I'd be frightened too.

[It's not the breach. Or not only. I think he's frightened of you.] A pause.
[Of what you might think of him. He's spent eight years believing he was a monster. And then you walked in and sang to him, and sat next to him, and for the first time in eight years, he isn't sure anymore.] Another pause.
[That's very frightening, for someone who's built his whole life around being sure.]

Lex lay looking up at the lanterns.

What do I do? he thought.

[I don't know,] said Ember. *[I'm not sure there's anything to do. I think you just stay.]*

That's what Brannoc did.

[Then Brannoc is a wise man.]

Across the fire, Wren had finally fallen asleep sitting up, her back against the wall and her bow across her knees. Her head had tipped sideways onto her shoulder. In the firelight, with her face slack and her freckles dark against her skin, she looked very young.

Lex looked at her for a long moment. Then he got up quietly, and took the Frostwalker's Mantle off his own shoulders, and laid it over her.

She didn't wake. But in her sleep, she pulled it closer.

When he turned around, Antho was standing at the edge of the firelight, watching him. Ashka was on his shoulder. His face was in shadow, unreadable.

"She's not just your guide, is she," Antho said quietly.

"She's my guide."

"Lex. I've been alone in a cave for eight years. I haven't forgotten *everything*."

Lex felt his face go hot. "She's my guide. I paid her. She's going home tomorrow."

"Is she." Antho looked at Wren, asleep under the white fur cloak. Something moved at the corner of his mouth. That small crooked thing again. "She followed you across a valley in the dark to a cave everyone says is full of death. With an arrow on the string. To protect you from *me*." He shook his head. "I don't think she's going home tomorrow."



THE WARDENS CAME AN hour before dawn.

Ashka felt them first. She'd been asleep on Antho's shoulder while he sat by the fire, and she woke all at once with a shriek that echoed off the cavern walls and set every lantern swinging. Sparks crackled down her spine. Her golden eyes were fixed on the passage.

Antho was on his feet before the echo died. "Wardens," he said. "Ashka says—a lot of them. More than usual. On the slope below the stones." His face went tight. "They brought a Tracker."

"*Fenn*," said Wren. She was awake and on her feet with an arrow on the string, the Frostwalker's Mantle tumbling off her shoulders. "*Dammit. Dammit.* She followed the Frostvault exit."

"How many?"

Antho shut his eyes. Lex felt something move in the cavern, a stirring in the dark, like the shadows were listening. "Fourteen," Antho said. "Fifteen. They're spreading out. Surrounding the ring of stones." His eyes opened. "One of them's strong. Much stronger than the others. He feels like a blade."

"Roole," said Lex. "The Warden-Captain. Tall man, face like a hatchet. He was at Ashbourne. And Thistledown."

"He's here for you." Antho looked at him. "Not me. They've never brought this many for me." He paused. "Your flare must have been very bright."

[It was,] said Ember grimly. [And I suspect the High Warden wants you very badly. A Root signature that hasn't gone mad yet would be worth more to the Spire than all the gold in Saltreach.]

From outside the cave, very faint, came the sound of a voice. A man's voice, clipped and hard, carrying up the slope and into the passage.

"Anthoren Harrow!"

Antho went very still.

"This is Warden-Captain Daxian Roole of the Wardens of the Lattice. I know you're in there. I know your brother's in there with you. I'm not here for you, Harrow. Send out the boy and the girl, and I'll leave you to your mountain. You have my word."

Silence in the cave. The lanterns swayed.

"Lex Harrow," the voice called. "You're not under arrest. Not yet. The High Warden wants to speak with you. That's all. She can help you. She can teach you to control what's happening to you. You don't want to end up like your brother." A pause. "Come out, and nobody needs to get hurt."

Lex looked at Antho. His brother's face was very pale in the firelight.

"He's lying," Antho said quietly. "About the teaching. About the helping. They told me the same thing. Eight years ago. That they'd *help* me." His jaw tightened. "They wanted to take me apart and see how I worked."

"I know."

"You'd better go out the back," said Antho. "There's a crack at the top of the cavern, behind the breach. It goes up to a ledge on the north face. Ashka can show you the way. I'll hold them here."

"What?"

"I'll hold them. I've done it before. They won't get past the stones." Antho was already turning toward the passage, the shadows beginning to gather around his hands. "Go. Take the girl. Go find Father."

"No."

"Lex—"

"No." Lex stood up. He picked up Anvilson, and it hummed in his hands, warm and steady. "The way to Father opens to two of the blood. Both of us. Together. That's what he said. I'm not leaving you here."

Antho stared at him.

"And besides," Lex said, "if you go out there alone, and your Clarity drops, and the thing gets out, you'll kill them. All fifteen of them. And you'll spend the next eight years remembering their faces." He shook his head. "I'm not letting you do that either."

"Then what do you suggest?" Antho's voice cracked. "We *talk* to them?"

"No," said Lex. "We fight them. Together. And we don't kill anyone."

There was a long silence.

"You're mad," said Antho.

"Probably. It runs in the family." Lex hefted the hammer. "Can you keep your Clarity up if I'm with you?"

Antho looked at him. Then he looked at the red panel only Lex could see.

CLARITY: 44 / 100

*Proximity: blood kin detected
(+regeneration)*

"Maybe," Antho said slowly. "When you were sitting next to me, it went up. I felt it." He swallowed. "Maybe."

"Then stay close."

"Hammer." Wren had come up beside them. She had her bow in her hand and an arrow on the string and her jaw set in a way Lex was beginning to recognize. "I'm not going out the back either. Just so you know."

"Wren, they're Wardens. If they catch you helping us—"

"Then they catch me." She looked at him with those sharp green eyes. "You said it yourself. They're here for the boy and the girl. I'm already in this. And if I'm going to be hanged for it anyway, I'd rather be hanged for something good."

[*Lex,*] said Ember quietly. [*You're forming a fellowship. The Lattice is asking.*]

He saw it. A silver box, unfolding.

FELLOWSHIP INVITATION

Anthoren Harrow (Lv 31) wishes to
join your fellowship.

And below it, in gold, something he'd never seen before.

BLOODBOND AVAILABLE

Two of Vey blood stand together.

A Bloodbond is a fellowship of kin.

- Shared experience
- Shared mana, by consent
- Clarity anchor (Anthoren)
- ??? (locked)

FORM BLOODBOND?

He looked at Antho. His brother was looking back at him, his grey eyes very wide. He'd seen it too.

"Yes," Lex said.

"Yes," said Antho, at the same moment.

The fire in Lex's chest *leaped*. And somewhere beside it, very close, he felt something else. Something cold and quiet and deep, like a still pool at the bottom of a well. Not frightening. Just *there*. Just his brother.

BLOODBOND FORMED

Lex Vey Lv 13

Anthoren Vey Lv 31

Wren Ashdown Lv 21 (fellow)

CLARITY: 44 → 58 ▲

Clarity anchor: ACTIVE

Antho let out a long, shaking breath. He looked down at his own hands as if he'd never seen them before.

"It's quieter," he whispered. "It's so much quieter."

[It's still there,] said Ember gently. [But you're holding his hand now, so to speak. It's harder for the thing to pull him under when someone's holding his hand.]

"Right," said Lex. He looked at his brother and at Wren, at the lanterns swaying overhead, at the passage leading out into the grey pre-dawn and fifteen Wardens with crossbows and chains. "Let's go and say hello."



THEY CAME OUT OF the Hollowmaw into the first grey light of morning, and the Wardens were waiting for them.

They'd spread out in a wide arc on the slope below the cave mouth, just outside the ring of charcoal-marked stones. Fifteen of them in grey cloaks, crossbows leveled. A few had swords drawn. Corporal Fenn crouched at one end of the line with her squinting tracker's eyes fixed on the cave. And in the middle, standing a little ahead of the rest with his sword in his hand and his pale eyes cold, was Warden-Captain Daxian Roole.

He looked at the three of them coming out of the cave. Lex with his hammer. Wren with her bow. And Antho, tall and gaunt and barefoot in the snow, with a little blue-grey dragon on his shoulder and shadows coiling like smoke around his long scarred hands.

Something went across Roole's hatchet face. Lex couldn't tell what it was.

"Well," the Warden-Captain said. "This is unexpected."

"Captain Roole," said Lex. "I'm not coming with you."

"So I gather." Roole's gaze moved from Lex to Antho and back. "You've made friends with your brother. The man who burned your mother alive."

"He didn't."

"The Lattice Watch says otherwise."

"The Lattice Watch," said Antho quietly, "says a great many things."

Roole looked at him. Pale eyes, steady and cold. "You've killed eleven of my brothers and sisters, Harrow. I've read the reports. I knew some of them."

"I know," said Antho. "I'm sorry."

Something flickered in Roole's face again. It was there and gone so fast that Lex almost missed it. But he didn't miss it. Surprise.

"We're leaving," said Lex. "The three of us. We have somewhere to be. We don't want to hurt anyone. Please. Let us go."

"I can't do that," said Roole. "You know I can't." He raised his sword. "Last chance, boy. Come quietly."

Lex hefted Anvilson.

"No," he said.

Roole sighed. It was a very small sigh, and very tired. "Bolts," he said.

Fifteen crossbows fired at once.



ANTHO MOVED FIRST.

He threw out his hands, and the shadows went *up*. They rose off the ground in front of the three of them like a wall, a curtain of solid black, and the crossbow bolts hit it and vanished. Not bounced. *Vanished*. Swallowed whole, like stones dropped into a deep well.

[*Shadowbind,*] said Ember, with something like admiration. [*Used defensively. Very clever.*]

The wall fell. And Lex charged.

He went straight at the Warden line, down the slope through the snow, faster than any man his size had a right to move. The Wardens on the left flank scrambled to reload. He was among them before they could. He didn't use the hammer's head. He swung it sideways, flat, catching a crossbow out of one Warden's hands and sending it spinning into the snow, then reversed the swing and struck another crossbow so hard it shattered. He hit a third Warden in the chest with the haft, not the head, and knocked him flat on his back in a drift. A sword came at him and he caught it on Anvilson's iron and *pushed heat* into the steel. The Warden yelped and dropped the sword, his hand smoking.

Behind him, he felt Wren loosing arrows. He saw them strike: not into flesh, but into crossbow stocks, into sword hands, into the snow at the Wardens' feet. And where her blue Rimebite arrows struck, frost exploded outward, freezing boots to the ground and fingers to triggers.

And Antho.

Antho walked down the slope through the snow with the shadows pouring off him like water, and where they went, Wardens stopped. The shadows wrapped around their legs and arms and held them, not crushing, not choking, just *holding*, the way they'd held Lex in the passage. The Wardens struggled and swore and couldn't move.

Bloodbond – shared action

Antho: Shadowbind ×4

Lex: Disarm ×3

Wren: Rimebite ×5

Lex felt it through the Bloodbond. A pull, a draw on his strength. Antho was taking mana from him. Not much. Just enough. And at the same time, he felt the cold still pool of his brother's power steady itself, the dark in it settling, calming, like water when the wind drops.

CLARITY: 58 → 52 ▼ (Hollow use)

52 → 56 ▲ (anchor)

He's holding, Lex thought. He's using the dark, and he's holding.

Then Roole hit him.

He hadn't seen the Warden-Captain coming. One moment he was turning from a disarmed Warden, the next there was a blur of grey cloak and steel at the edge of his vision and something slammed into his side like a battering ram. He went flying. He hit the snow and rolled and came up on one knee, and his health bar had dropped by a third.

Roole stood over him, sword raised. His blade was glowing. Not gold, not fire. A cold, pale silver light, like moonlight on ice, rippling along the steel.

DAXIAN ROOLE

Class: INQUISITOR (Rare)

Tier II – Level 46

Forty-six.

"You're strong, boy," Roole said. He wasn't even breathing hard. "Stronger than you should be. But you're green. You swing that hammer like a smith, not a soldier." He came forward. "Yield."

"No," Lex said, and got up.

Roole came at him.

It was nothing like the wolves, or the bear, or the Rimewarden. Those had been beasts, strong and fast and stupid. Roole was a man who had been fighting for twenty years, and he fought like it. His sword was everywhere at once. Lex blocked one strike and the second was already coming, from a different angle, and the third behind it. He took a cut across the forearm. Another across the ribs, shallow, burning cold, like the silver light on the blade was trying to freeze him from the inside. He swung Anvilsong and Roole simply wasn't there; he'd stepped aside by an inch

and the hammer went past him, and then the pommel of Roole's sword hit Lex in the temple and the world went white.

He was on his knees in the snow again. His ears were ringing. Blood was running into his left eye.

"Yield," said Roole.

[*He's right,*] said Ember, fast and quiet. [*You can't beat him in a straight fight. He's forty-six. He's spent his life doing this. You have to fight smarter.*]

How?

[*What does he not know about you?*]

Lex looked up at Roole through the blood in his eye. At the silver light on the sword. At the cold pale eyes. *You swing that hammer like a smith.*

He let Anvilsong fall from his hand into the snow.

Roole's eyes narrowed. "Good. Now—"

"I'm not a soldier," Lex said. "You're right." He held out his empty hand. "I'm a smith."

And he called the hammer.

Not to his hand. *Through* Roole. The way he'd done with the bear.

Except that Anvilsong was lying in the snow at his feet, not behind Roole, and that wouldn't work. So he didn't call it. He *pushed*. He put his palm flat on the snow and pushed heat down through it, into the ground, into the snow under Roole's boots.

The snow turned to water. All at once. A circle of it six feet across, melting in an instant, and Roole's boots went through it into the slush and the mud beneath, and he staggered, off balance, just for a heartbeat.

That was all Lex needed.

He came up off his knees and drove his shoulder into Roole's chest, the way he'd shoulder a stuck forge door, all his weight and all his strength behind it. Twenty-six Might. Roole went over backward into the slush with a splash. Lex landed on top of him and grabbed his sword wrist and pushed heat into it, not much, just enough, and Roole cried out and his fingers opened and the silver-lit sword fell into the snow.

Lex held out his hand. Anvilsong leaped into it.

He raised it over Roole's head. It blazed gold.

Roole lay on his back in the slush and looked up at the hammer, and at Lex, and didn't flinch. His pale eyes were perfectly steady. Waiting.

The whole slope had gone silent. The Wardens held in Antho's shadows had stopped struggling. Wren had an arrow on the string, not loosing. Corporal Fenn was frozen in a crouch at the end of the line, her face white. Everyone was looking at the hammer.

Lex held it there, blazing over Roole's head, for a long, long moment.

Then he lowered it.

"I said," he told Roole quietly, "we don't want to hurt anyone."

He stood up. He stepped back. He held out his hand to the Warden-Captain, lying in the slush.

Roole looked at the hand for a long time. Then, slowly, he took it, and let Lex pull him to his feet.

They stood facing each other in the trampled snow, both of them soaked and bleeding.

"You could have killed me," Roole said.

"Yes."

"Why didn't you?"

Lex looked at him. "Because you told me to yield three times," he said. "You could have put that sword through me twice, and you hit me with the pommel instead." He paused. "You didn't kill me when you could have. So I'm not killing you."

Roole's face didn't move. But something behind his eyes did.

"Take your men," said Lex, "and go home, Captain. Tell the High Warden I'm not coming. Tell her if she wants to talk to me, she can come up the mountain herself." He turned to go. Then he stopped, and looked back. "And tell her the black mist in the gullies isn't coming from my brother. It's coming from a hole in the Lattice. He's been holding it shut for four years. Alone. While you sent people up here to kill him."

He walked back up the slope to where Antho and Wren were waiting.

Behind him, after a long moment, he heard Roole say, very quietly, "Release them, Harrow."

Antho looked at Lex. Lex nodded. The shadows fell away from the Wardens like cloaks slipping off.

Nobody moved. Nobody reached for a weapon. The fifteen Wardens stood in the trampled snow in the grey dawn light, staring at the three figures by the mouth of the Hollowmaw, and at Daxian Roole, who stood among them with his sword in the slush at his feet and his pale eyes fixed on Lex's back.

"Captain?" said Fenn uncertainly. "Orders?"

Roole didn't answer for a long time.

"Gather the wounded," he said at last. "We're going down."

"But sir, the High Warden—"

"I know what the High Warden ordered, Corporal." Roole bent and picked up his sword. He looked at it, at the silver light fading from the blade. Then he sheathed it. "I'll answer for it."

He looked up the slope one last time. His eyes met Lex's across the snow.

He didn't say anything. He didn't nod. He just looked. And then he turned, and walked away down the mountain, and his Wardens followed him.



LEX STOOD AT THE mouth of the Hollowmaw and watched them go until they were small grey shapes far down the slope. Then his legs gave out, and he sat down in the snow.

Encounter ended.

Opponents defeated: 0

Opponents disarmed: 15

Opponents spared: 15

TITLE EARNED: The Merciful Hammer

+5% to all non-lethal actions

"You held the killing blow, and
the world took note."

LEVEL UP!

Emberwright – Level 14

"You let him go," said Antho. He'd sat down in the snow next to him. Ashka climbed off his shoulder and onto Lex's lap and curled up there, chirping. "The Warden-Captain. You had him. And you let him go."

"Yes."

"He'll come back. They always come back."

"Maybe." Lex looked down the mountain. "Maybe not."

Antho was quiet for a long moment.

"Fifteen," he said at last. "Fifteen Wardens. And nobody died." He shook his head slowly. "I've never—not once in eight years—" He stopped. His voice was strange. "I didn't know you could do that. Fight them and not kill them. I didn't know that was a thing you could *do*."

"Neither did I," said Lex. "Until this morning."

Wren dropped down into the snow on Lex's other side. She'd put her bow away. She looked at him for a long time with her sharp green eyes.

"You're an idiot, Hammer," she said.

"So you keep telling me."

"A big soft *brilliant* idiot." She leaned her shoulder against his. "Your brother's right. That was mad. I've never seen anything like it." She paused. "Are you hurt?"

"A bit."

"Let me see."

He let her see. She took a strip of cloth from her pack and started wiping the blood from his face with brisk, rough, careful fingers. On his other side, Antho sat with his arms around his knees, staring down the mountain at the place where the Wardens had disappeared.

"Lex," Antho said quietly.

"Yeah."

"You said the way to Father opens to two of the blood."

"That's what his letter said."

"Then I suppose," said Antho, "I'd better come with you."

Lex turned his head and looked at his brother. Antho didn't look back. He was looking at the mountains, ridge after ridge going gold now in the rising sun. His gaunt face was very still. But his hand, resting on the snow between them, was close to Lex's, and after a moment, Lex moved his own hand an inch, until their fingers touched.

Neither of them said anything else.

The sun came up over the Greyspine. And behind them, deep in the cave, among the hundreds of unlit lanterns, the green fire burned on around the breach, holding the dark at bay. For now.

CHAPTER 9

THE OLD FOUNDERS' ROAD



"IF I LEAVE," SAID Antho, "it gets out."

He was standing at the bottom of the slope in the cavern, a careful three paces back from the ring of green fire, looking at the breach. In the daylight leaking in through the passage, the crack in the air looked smaller than it had at night. Thinner. Almost nothing, a dark scratch on the world. But the cold still came off it in slow waves, and the trickle of Gloam still seeped out of it, and the green fire still hissed and spat where the two met.

"The fire holds it," Antho went on. "Mostly. But the fire needs feeding. Every day. Sometimes twice a day, when it's pushing hard. If I go, the fire burns down. Three days, maybe four. Then the stones outside have to hold it alone." He shook his head. "They won't. Not for long. And then it'll come down the gullies, and into the valleys, and into Thistledown."

"So we fix the fire," said Lex.

"I've been trying to fix the fire for four years."

"You've been trying alone."

Antho turned and looked at him.

[He's right, you know,] said Ember, to Lex. [About the fire. I've been studying it. The glyphs he's used are clever but crude. About a third of them are wrong, and the right ones are held together by sheer stubbornness. It's like a wall built of uncut stones. It stands, but it takes constant mending.] A pause. [But I think there's something else he hasn't realized. Ask him about the link.]

"The breach-link," Lex said. "In your status. The thread that ties you to it."

Antho's face went tight. They'd talked about it, late the night before, after the Wardens left. After Lex had told him what he'd seen with True Sight: the fine dark thread running from his brother's panel down the slope and into the crack. Antho hadn't said much. He'd just sat by the fire for a long time, staring at the green flames, and then got up and walked away into the dark.

"What about it?" he said now.

"Ember thinks—" Lex stopped. It still felt strange, saying the name out loud to someone else. "The voice. The construct. It thinks the link works both ways. The thing on the other side uses you to hold the door open. Like a wedge. Like a foot in the doorway." He hesitated. "Which means if you're *here*, right next to it, it's got a foot in the door. But if you go away—"

"It loses its grip," said Antho slowly.

[Not entirely,] said Ember. [He's still bound. But distance weakens the pull. The further he goes, the less purchase it has. The door won't close on its own. But it won't be pushed open as hard, either.]

Lex repeated it. Antho listened in silence, his long scarred hands clenched at his sides. When Lex finished, his brother turned back to the breach and stared at it for a long time.

"So I've been making it worse," he said at last, very quietly. "Four years. Sitting here, guarding it. And all that time I've been the thing holding it open."

"You didn't know."

"That doesn't—" Antho's voice cracked. He stopped. Took a breath. "That doesn't make it better, Lex."

"No," Lex agreed. "But it means you can stop."



THEY MADE NEW WARDS.

It took them the whole of that day and most of the next. Lex didn't have a forge. He didn't have an anvil. He had Anvilsong, and a flat slab of black rock by the cavern entrance that would serve, and his own two hands. And he had Heat Shaping, which had climbed to Novice 9 in the

Frostvault and was, Ember assured him, quite capable of bringing a lump of iron up to working heat without coal or bellows, if he was patient.

He was patient. He was a smith.

For iron, he had the Wardens' crossbows.

They'd left most of them behind on the slope, tangled in the snow where Wren's frost-arrows and Antho's shadows had torn them from their owners' hands. Fifteen crossbows, steel-limbed and iron-fitted, and nearly two hundred bolts. Lex gathered them up in the morning, and Wren helped him carry them into the cavern, and Antho sat on a rock and watched with a strange expression as Lex took the first crossbow apart with his bare hands and laid its steel limb on the black stone and began to heat it.

"Those are Warden weapons," Antho said.

"They were."

"They shot Ashka with ones just like those."

Lex looked up. Antho's face was unreadable.

"I know," said Lex. "That's why I'm using them."

He made nails.

Not ordinary nails. Ward-nails, Ember called them: iron spikes as long as his forearm, thick as his thumb, tapered to a point at one end and flattened to a broad head at the other. And on each head, he struck a glyph.

That was where Antho came in.

"Not that one," Antho said, the first time, leaning over the black stone to look at the shape Lex was tracing in the cooling iron. "That's *bar*. You want *bind*. The bar keeps things out. The bind keeps them in."

"How do you know?"

"I've been getting it wrong for four years. I've had a lot of practice." Antho reached out, hesitated, and then traced a shape in the air above the iron with one long finger. "Like this. The upstroke curves back on itself."

[He's right,] said Ember, sounding surprised. *[That's better than the one I was going to show you. It's not the textbook form, but it's... cleaner. More suited to the purpose.]* A pause. *[He has a good instinct for this. Self-taught, and frequently wrong, but with a real instinct underneath.]*

"Ember says you're right," Lex told him.

Antho blinked. "It does?"

"It says you're frequently wrong but you've got good instincts."

Antho stared at him for a moment. Then, unexpectedly, he laughed. It was a short, rusty sound, as if the mechanism hadn't been used in a long time, but it was a real laugh.

"That's the nicest thing anyone's said to me in eight years," he said.

They worked together after that. Lex heated and shaped. Antho drew the glyphs in the air, and argued with Ember through Lex about the details, and corrected and was corrected in turn. Wren kept the fire going and fetched snowmelt for quenching and, when she got bored, went outside and practiced her archery on the trees at the edge of the ward-stones until Antho asked her very politely to stop because the noise was upsetting Ashka. Ashka was not upset in the least. Ashka spent most of the day sitting on Lex's shoulder, watching the iron glow, and occasionally reaching down to sniff the hot metal with every sign of profound interest.

[Storm-drakes like heat,] said Ember. [And lightning. And shiny things. And, apparently, you.]

By the evening of the second day, they had twelve nails.

They drove them into the rock in a ring around the green fire, a pace outside it. Lex held each one and Antho set it, and then Lex struck it home with Anvilson. *Chang*. With every strike, he put the glyph into the stone as well as the iron. *Bind*. The rock took it. The nails sank in like they were going into clay.

And when the twelfth nail went home, the green fire *changed*.

It didn't go out. It didn't flare. It simply settled. As if it had been straining against something for four years and suddenly, finally, didn't have to anymore. The flames dropped to a low, steady glow. The hissing where the Gloam touched them faded to a whisper. And the crack in the air, the breach, seemed to *shrink*. Not much. A hair's width. But Lex saw it.

HIDDEN QUEST COMPLETE

KEEPER OF THE DOOR

Reinforce the Hollowmaw ward.

Breach containment: 61% → 94%

+XP (shared)

SKILL UP: Runic Forging → Apprentice 2

SKILL UP: Ward-Scribing (Antho) →
Journeyman 10 → Expert 1

Antho stood very still, looking at it.

"Ninety-four," he whispered. "It's never been above seventy. Not once."

"It'll hold?" said Wren.

[For a good long while,] said Ember. [Months, at least. Possibly longer, if he's far away. The nails don't need feeding the way the fire did. They just are.]

"Months," Lex told them.

Antho didn't say anything. He just stood there at the edge of the green fire with his arms wrapped around himself, staring at the breach. Then, abruptly, he turned and walked to the far wall of the cavern, where the lanterns hung thickest, and began to look through them. He took one down, then put it back. Took down another. Put it back.

"What are you looking for?" said Lex.

"The right one." Antho didn't turn round. He took down a third lantern. Turned it over in his hands. It was small, and clay, and plain: the kind they used in the chapel at Ashbourne for the lantern service, when everyone in the village brought a little lamp and set it in the windows for the ones who hadn't come home. Its glaze had cracked. Someone had once painted a little flower on the side of it, a long time ago, and most of the paint had worn away.

"This one," Antho said quietly. "I found this one in the ashes. Of the cottage. A week after. I went back, at night, when no one would see me. It was the only thing left that wasn't melted." He turned it over. "It was Mam's. She used to put it in the kitchen window. Every night. You remember?"

Lex remembered.

"I never lit it," said Antho. "I never lit any of them. I didn't—" He stopped. "It felt like I didn't have the right. I was the reason she was gone. I didn't get to leave a light on for her." He looked down at the little clay lamp in his scarred hands. "I don't have any oil, anyway. Haven't for years."

Lex looked at the lamp.

Then he held out his hand.

"Give it here," he said.



HE DID IT ON the black stone, by the cavern entrance, in the last of the evening light.

It wasn't iron, so he couldn't strike it. He had to *coax* it, the way he'd done with Wren's bow in Thistledown: warming the clay with Heat Shaping until it was soft at the very surface, then pressing the rune into it with the tip of a heated ward-nail, slowly, a fraction of a fraction at a time. His hands ached. His eyes watered. Antho sat beside him and didn't say a word.

The rune was *Ardent*. The same one he'd struck into Anvilson. The rune that held heat.

When it was done, he set the lamp on the stone and held his palm over it and pushed a single thread of fire down into the little clay bowl where the wick should have been.

It caught.

A small flame. Gold. Steady. It burned in the empty bowl without oil, without wick, without anything, and it didn't flicker even when the draft from the breach came drifting up across the cavern.

ITEM CREATED

SEREN'S LAMP

Clay lantern — Grade: FINE

Rune: ARDENT — burns without fuel
while the maker lives

"A light left on for the lost."

Antho made a sound Lex had never heard a person make before.

He picked up the lamp very carefully in both hands, the way you'd pick up a bird's egg, and held it close to his face, and looked at the flame. It lit him from below: the hollows of his cheeks, the wild beard, the grey eyes swimming with tears.

"It won't go out?" he whispered.

"Not while I'm alive."

"*Lex.*" Antho's voice broke completely. He didn't say anything else.

He carried the lamp out of the cavern. Down the passage, between the hundreds of unlit lanterns, out through the great cleft of the Hollowmaw into the blue mountain dusk. Lex and Wren followed. Antho walked out past the ring of charcoal stones, past the place where the Wardens had stood, and stopped at the very edge of the slope, where the mountain fell away into the valley and the whole of the eastern Greyspine lay spread out below, ridge after ridge going dark under the first stars.

There was a flat rock there. He knelt and set the lamp on it, facing out. Facing the world.

Then he sat back on his heels and looked at it.

"For you, Mam," he said quietly. "For when you come home."

Lex stood behind him in the snow. Wren stood beside Lex. Neither of them said anything.

The little flame burned steady in the dusk, gold and small and very bright, and somewhere across the valley, Lex thought, if anyone was looking, they would see it. A single point of light on the dark face of the mountain, above the Hollowmaw, where for eight years there had been nothing at all.



"I'M COMING WITH YOU," said Wren.

It was later that night. They were sitting around Antho's fire, the three of them and Ashka, eating the last of the not-rabbit stew. Lex had been wondering how to say goodbye to her. He'd been wondering all day. He'd rehearsed it in his head, between strikes of the hammer: *Thank you. I couldn't have done it without you. Go home to your mother.* It had sounded fine in his head.

He set down his bowl. "Wren—"

"Don't."

"Your mother—"

"My mother has your money. I gave it to Grell's wife the night we left Thistledown, before I went to sit on the woodpile. Hilde's honest, which is more than you can say for Grell. She'll have sent it down with the morning mule train." Wren didn't look up from her stew. "Tam can run the traplines. He's eleven. I was running them at eleven. Robbie can help." She took a bite. "And Mam would skin me alive if she knew I'd turned down a chance to fix the thing that made her sick."

"Fix it?"

"The black stuff." Wren looked up. Her green eyes were hard and bright in the firelight. "The Gloam. It came up through the mine shafts at Coldwater. It's in the gullies here. It's coming out of that hole in the cave, and your brother's been sitting on it for four years, and nobody else even knew it was there." She jabbed her spoon at Lex. "You said your father knows something about it. Something nobody else knows. That's why he went away. That's why he's dying." She set the spoon down. "If he knows how to stop it, I want to be there. I want to see it stopped. With my own eyes."

"It'll be dangerous."

"Everything's dangerous. I live on a mountain."

"You don't have to—"

"Hammer." She said it quietly. "I'm level twenty-one. I've got three levels left before the Ceiling. Three. And I've gained two of them in the last three days, walking around with you." She held his gaze. "I want to see how high I can climb before the world tells me to stop. And I don't think I'm going to find out on a trapline."

Lex didn't know what to say.

"Besides," said Wren, picking up her spoon again, "you can't afford me anymore. You gave me all your money. So this is me doing it for free, and you're going to have to live with that."

Across the fire, Antho was watching them both. Something moved at the corner of his mouth.

"She's coming," he said to Lex.

"I know she's coming."

"I'm just saying. In case you hadn't noticed."



QUILL ARRIVED THE NEXT morning.

They were packing to leave. Antho had dug a battered leather satchel out from under his heap of furs and was filling it with things that seemed to Lex to be chosen at random: a bundle of birch-bark notes, a knife, a coil of rope, a small bone flute wrapped in a scrap of cloth, a fistful of charcoal sticks. Wren had been out at first light hunting and had come back with two ptarmigan and a hare. And Lex had been standing at the mouth of the Hollowmaw, looking at the little clay lamp still burning steady on its rock above the valley, when a black shape came out of the sky and landed on the snow in front of him with a soft thump.

"*Found you,*" said Quill.

The raven had a slip of paper tied to his leg. He held the leg out, imperiously, and waited while Lex untied it. Then he hopped up onto the rock beside the lamp and began picking at his feathers, glancing occasionally at Ashka, who had come scurrying out of the cave at the sound of his voice and was now staring at him with her crest standing straight up.

The two of them looked at each other for a long moment. Then Ashka sneezed, a small sharp crackle of blue sparks, and Quill hopped back two paces, and they both pretended the other wasn't there.

The paper was written in a fine, spiky, rapid hand. Elric's, Lex supposed. It was short.

L.—

If you are reading this, you are alive, and so presumably is your brother, and I am an old man who gambles well.

I have news. Some good, some less so. The good: I've spoken with a friend who has seen the old Founders' records at the Spire, the ones that are kept locked. She says the Way to Avaloria cannot be found by walking. It must be called. And it can be called only by a lodestone, a Founders' stone that knows its way home, woken by three songs from three shrines along the old Founders' Road, north of the Greyspine: the Lithic Oracle, the heart of the Thornwood, and the Barrow Throne in the drowned country.

The less good: I don't know where the lodestone is. Arion had one. I saw it once, years ago, a small grey stone on a cord. He told me he'd given it to someone, "so she'll always have a way to find me." I assumed he meant your mother. If so, it is very likely lost.

Look anyway. I'll find you on the Road.

The Order has posted notices in every village from here to Highcrest. You are both named. Five hundred crowns each, alive. I'm sorry.

Mind the quench.

—E.

Lex read it twice. Then he went back into the cave.

Antho was still kneeling by his heap of furs, packing the satchel. He looked up as Lex came in.

"Elric's raven," Lex said. "There's a letter."

He read it aloud. When he got to the part about the lodestone, Antho went very still. When he got to *a small grey stone on a cord*, his hand went to his throat.

Lex stopped reading.

Slowly, without a word, Antho reached into the collar of his ragged shirt and drew out a cord. It was old leather, black with age and grime. And hanging from it was a stone.

It was small. Smaller than a hen's egg. Smooth and grey and slightly flattened, like a river pebble, with a hole bored through it for the cord. There was nothing remarkable about it at all. You could have walked past a hundred like it on any riverbank in the Vale.

"Mam wore it," Antho said quietly. "Every day. As long as I can remember. She never took it off. Not even to sleep." He turned the stone over in his fingers. "It was in the ashes. With the lamp. Right where she'd been standing. The cord had burned away, but the stone was fine. Not even warm." He swallowed. "I've worn it ever since. I don't know why. It never did anything. It's just a stone."

[It isn't,] said Ember. Its voice was very soft. *[Lex. Look at it.]*

He looked. He felt the heat rise behind his eyes, and the world went gold, and the little grey stone in his brother's hand *changed*.

It was covered in writing.

Tiny, impossibly fine Wellscript, spiraling around the stone from the hole at the top to the base, in lines so small they looked like the grain of the rock. Faint gold, like his own panel. And at the center, on the flattest side of the stone, a single larger glyph: an open hand, with a flame above the palm.

LODESTONE OF RETURN (dormant)

Founders' work — Grade: UNKNOWN

Bound to: ARION VEY

Songs held: 0 / 3

"I will always find my way home."

"It's the lodestone," Lex said. His voice came out strange. "It's *the* lodestone. Antho, it's what Elric's looking for. It's what Father gave her."

Antho stared down at the little grey stone in his palm.

"*So she'll always have a way to find me,*" he whispered.

For a long moment, neither of them could say anything at all.

[*There's more writing,*] said Ember quietly. [*Around the edge. Smaller than the rest. It's old Wellscript, very formal. I think it's a kind of verse.*] A pause. [*Shall I read it?*]

Yes.

Ember read it, and Lex repeated it aloud, slowly, the words coming strange and heavy in his mouth:

"Two of the blood, the bright and the deep, one who forges, one who keeps. Sing the stone the Founders' songs, and walk the Way where the lost belong."

Antho looked up at him.

"One who forges," he said slowly. "One who keeps."

"The bright and the deep," said Lex.

They looked at each other across the dim cavern, surrounded by unlit lanterns. And Lex felt, through the Bloodbond, something move in his brother: something cold and quiet and deep, like a still pool stirred for the first time in years.

MAIN QUEST UPDATED: The Lost Father

- ◆ Find the Lodestone of Return .. DONE
- ◇ The Lithic Oracle (0/3)
- ◇ The heart of the Thornwood
- ◇ The Barrow Throne
- ◇ The Way opens to two of the blood

**THEY LEFT THE HOLLOWMAW** at noon.

Antho walked out last. He stopped at the mouth of the great cleft and turned and looked back into the dark, at the passage with its hundreds of hanging lanterns, at the faint green glow far back in the depths where the ward-nails held the breach. He stood there for a long time.

Lex waited. He didn't say anything.

When Antho finally turned away, his face was very pale. His hands were shaking slightly. And Lex, watching the red panel only he could see, saw the number start to fall.

CLARITY: 63 → 58 ▼

58 → 51 ▼

WARNING: host leaving breach range

 *resisting*

[It doesn't want him to go,] said Ember quietly. [It's pulling. Hard.]

Antho had stopped walking. He stood in the snow just outside the ring of charcoal stones, his eyes squeezed shut, his hands pressed against his temples. The shadows around his feet were stirring.

[little brother... don't go ... ~~don't~~ go ... warm here ... stay ... stay ... stay ...]

Lex heard it. Faintly. Through the Bloodbond. The wet, hungry whisper, pleading.

"Antho," he said.

"I'm fine." His brother's voice was tight. "I'm fine. It's just loud. It's always loud when I try to leave. That's why I always come back." He laughed, thin and cracked. "I tried to go to Thistledown once. To buy oil. I got halfway down the valley and it got so loud I couldn't think. I just turned around."

"Antho, look at me."

His brother opened his eyes. They were grey. But at the edges, very faintly, Lex could see the black creeping in, like ink bleeding into wet paper.

Lex didn't sing this time. He didn't know if it would work twice. Instead he reached out and took his brother's hand, the way he'd done in the snow after the Wardens left, and held on.

The Bloodbond *pulled*. He felt it. A draw of heat from his chest, down his arm, through his hand into his brother's. Not mana. Something warmer than that. Something like a hearth fire seen through a window on a winter night.

CLARITY: 51 → 57 ▲

Clarity anchor: ACTIVE

Antho let out a long breath.

"Walk," Lex said. "Just walk. One step. Then another. I'll be right here."

Antho walked.

One step. Then another. Down the slope, away from the Hollowmaw, with his brother's hand in his and a little blue-grey dragon riding on his shoulder, chirping anxiously into his ear. Wren walked on his other side, close but not touching, her bow in her hand. Quill flew overhead in slow circles, croaking.

With every step, the whisper got fainter.

By the time they reached the floor of the valley, Lex couldn't hear it at all. By the time they'd climbed the far slope and stood on the high windswept shoulder of the mountain where the Frostvault let out, Antho's hand had stopped shaking. He let go of Lex's hand. He stood on the shoulder and turned and looked back across the valley at the Hollowmaw, small and dark in the face of the great mountain.

And above it, a single point of gold light. Steady. Burning.

"It's quiet," Antho said. He sounded astonished. "It's still there. But it's—it's *far away*. Like someone shouting in another room." He turned to Lex. His grey eyes were very wide. "I haven't been this far from it in four years. I didn't know it could be this quiet."

CLARITY: 66 / 100

 – signal weak (distance)

"Sixty-six," Lex told him.

Antho closed his eyes. His face did something complicated.

"I'd forgotten," he said quietly. "What it's like. To hear myself think." He opened his eyes again and looked at Lex, and at Wren, and at the long road north stretching away below them through the mountains. "Right," he said. "Right. Let's go and find Father." He paused. "So I can punch him."

Lex laughed. He couldn't help it.

"Get in line," he said.



THE OLD FOUNDERS' ROAD began on the north side of the Greyspine, where the mountains fell away in great ragged ridges toward a land of grey moors and dark forests and wide, silver, mist-filled valleys. Wren knew the way down. It took them two days.

The Road itself, when they found it, was barely a road at all. It had been paved once, long ago, with great slabs of grey stone fitted together so precisely you couldn't have slipped a knife blade between them. But nine hundred years of frost and root and rain had heaved most of the slabs up out of true, and moss had grown over them, and grass between them, and in places the forest had swallowed them entirely. Still, it ran north. Straight as a ruled line, over hill and through valley, as if whoever built it had decided where it was going to go and the land had simply been told to get out of the way.

And at intervals along it, every few miles, there were stones. Waystones, waist-high, carved with the open hand and the flame.

"Founders' Road," said Antho, running his scarred fingers over the first one they came to. "Nine hundred years old. Built when the Lattice was woven." He looked north along the line of heaved and mossy slabs, vanishing into the mist. "I read about it once. In a book I stole off a dead Warden." He paused. "That sounds worse than it was."

"It sounds exactly as bad as it was," said Wren.

"He was already dead. I didn't kill that one."

"That's not as reassuring as you think it is."

They walked.

It was a strange few days, walking the Road. Lex thought about it often afterward. The three of them and the little dragon and the raven, heading north through a grey, misty, empty country. Antho's Clarity rose a little every day as the Hollowmaw fell farther behind them: sixty-eight, seventy-one, seventy-three. He started to talk more. Not much at first. Then more. He'd point out a plant by the roadside and tell them its name and what it was good for, and what it would kill you if you ate it. He'd tell them about the stars at night, the way he used to when Lex was small, sketching the constellations in the air with one long finger. He knew an astonishing number of things. Eight years alone in a cave with stolen books, Lex supposed, would do that to a person.

He still had bad moments. Times when he'd go quiet and grey-faced in the middle of a sentence and stop walking, and stand there in the road with his eyes shut and his hands pressed to his temples. Times when Lex would wake in the night and find his brother sitting up by the dying fire, staring into the dark, his lips moving soundlessly. Once, on the third night, Lex woke to the sound of the bone flute, a thin wavering tune drifting across the camp, and lay still and listened, and realized after a while that it was the Lantern Song, played over and over, very softly, until the sky began to grey.

He didn't say anything about it in the morning. Neither did Antho.

And there was Wren. Wren, who'd watched Antho with her hand near her knife for the first two days, and then on the third day had handed him a strip of dried hare without being asked. Wren, who'd sat beside him on the fourth evening and asked him, abruptly, what the thing in his head actually *said*, and listened in silence for a long time while he told her. Wren, who'd insisted on the fifth morning, in a tone that brooked no argument, that Antho was going to wash in the next stream they came to, *all* of him, because she was not walking another mile downwind of eight years of cave.

He'd washed. Lex had cut his hair afterward with Wren's knife, sitting on a rock by the stream, hacking off great matted ropes of it while Antho complained bitterly and Ashka tried to catch the falling locks in her mouth. And then Antho had trimmed his own beard, peering into the still water at

the edge of the stream, and when he'd finally turned round, Lex had stared at him.

He looked like their father. Not exactly. Lex barely remembered their father's face. But there was something in the set of the jaw, in the long straight nose, in the grey eyes under dark brows. Something that caught at a memory Lex hadn't known he still had: a man's face, bending over him in the dark, close, smiling. A voice humming a song. Off-key.

"What?" said Antho. "What's wrong? Is it bad? Wren, is it bad?"

"It's not bad," said Wren. She was looking at him with her head tilted, a strange expression on her face. "You clean up all right, Warlock."

"*Warlock*," Antho repeated. "Is that my name now? He gets *Hammer* and I get *Warlock*?"

"You're lucky you get anything," said Wren, and walked off up the Road.

Antho looked at Lex. Lex shrugged.

"She calls everyone something," he said. "It means she likes you."

"Does it." Antho looked after her, his newly-clean face thoughtful. "She called you an idiot six times yesterday. I counted."

"That *definitely* means she likes me."



ON THE SIXTH NIGHT, they camped in the ruins of an old Founders' waystation, a roofless square of grey stone beside the Road, with the open hand and the flame carved over the empty doorway. Wren had gone to fill the waterskins at a spring she'd found. Ashka was asleep in a coil by the fire. Quill had gone off somewhere on raven business.

Lex and Antho sat side by side with their backs against the old stone wall, looking up at the stars.

"Do you remember skipping stones?" said Antho. "At the millpond. The summer before."

"I remember."

"You were terrible at it. You kept throwing them straight down into the water. *Plunk*. Like you were trying to drown them."

"I was ten."

"You were *terrible*," Antho was smiling slightly in the dark. "And then on the last day, you got one to skip. Do you remember how many times?"

"Four," said Lex. "It skipped four times. You picked me up and swung me round."

Antho was quiet for a moment.

"Five," he said.

Lex turned his head.

"It skipped five times," said Antho. "I counted. I always count." He was looking up at the stars, not at Lex. "I told you four, because I'd never done more than four myself, and I didn't want my little brother beating me on the first day he got it right." He paused. "I was a petty, jealous fifteen-year-old. I'm sorry. It was five."

Lex stared at him.

Then he started to laugh. Helplessly, uncontrollably, the way he hadn't laughed since he was a child. He laughed until his ribs hurt and his eyes streamed, and beside him Antho started laughing too, that rusty, unpracticed laugh, and the two of them sat against the cold stone wall of a nine-hundred-year-old ruin in the middle of nowhere and laughed like idiots until Wren came back with the waterskins and stood in the empty doorway and stared at them both.

"What," she said. "What's funny?"

"*Five*," Lex managed. "It was *five*."

Wren looked at Antho. Antho had his face in his hands, shoulders shaking.

"You're both idiots," she said, and sat down by the fire. But Lex saw her smiling as she said it.



LATER, WHEN THE FIRE had burned low and Wren was asleep and Antho was a dark shape wrapped in his furs on the far side of the coals, Lex lay awake looking at the stars and thinking.

[You're happy,] said Ember quietly.

He thought about it.

I think I am, he admitted. *Is that strange?*

[No. I don't think so.] A pause. [I think you've been carrying something very heavy for a very long time. And you've just put it down. It would be strange if you didn't feel lighter.]

I hated him so much. For so long.

[I know.]

And it was all wrong. Everything I thought. Everything the village said. He stared up at the sky. How do I know the rest of it isn't wrong too? Father. Elric. The Order. Any of it.

Ember was quiet for a long time.

[You don't,] it said at last. [That's the hard part. You don't know. You just keep looking. And when you find out you were wrong about something, you change your mind, and you keep going.] A pause. [That's what your brother did tonight, I think. Over a stone that skipped five times instead of four. He's been carrying that for nine years. Tonight he put it down.]

Lex lay looking at the stars for a long time.

Ember, he thought. Do you think my father is a good man?

The silence that followed was the longest yet.

[I don't know,] said Ember, very softly. [I think he loved your mother. I think he loved you both. I think he did something very hard and very frightening because he thought it was right.] A pause. [Whether that makes a man good... I'm not sure I'm the one to judge.]

Why not?

Another long silence.

[I don't know that either,] said Ember. [It's just a feeling. Like there's a partition I can't open, and behind it, the answer to that question. And I'm not sure I want to know what it is.]

Lex lay awake for a long time after that, looking up at the stars, until the fire was only embers and the sky in the east had begun, very faintly, to grey.

CHAPTER 10

THE LITHIC ORACLE



"AGAIN," SAID ANTHO.

Lex threw the bolt.

It was one of the Wardens' crossbow bolts, a short, heavy iron-headed dart he'd salvaged from the slope below the Hollowmaw. He'd brought a bundle of forty of them, wrapped in oilcloth at the bottom of his pack, for no particular reason except that it had seemed a waste to leave good iron lying in the snow. Now he held one between his fingers and pushed heat into the iron head until it glowed cherry-red, and then he *threw* it, not with his arm, or not only, but with Heat Shaping, pushing the hot air behind it the way a bellows pushes air into a fire.

It flew. Fast. Faster than he could have thrown it by hand. It streaked across the clearing in a thin line of red light and struck the dead pine at the far side with a hiss and a thunk, and buried itself to the fletching in the trunk, and smoke curled up from the wound.

"Better," said Antho.

"It hit the tree."

"It hit the tree a hand's width below where you were aiming. Last time it was two." His brother was sitting cross-legged on a mossy rock at the edge of the clearing, Ashka curled in his lap and a staff of black, wind-twisted pine across his knees, cut on their second day out of the mountains, watching with the critical air of a schoolmaster. "You're still thinking about your arm. Stop thinking about your arm. Your arm isn't what's throwing it."

"Then what is?"

"You are. The heat is. The arm's just habit." Antho held up one long scarred hand and, without seeming to do anything at all, a small knot of shadow formed in his palm, the size of a plum, dark and dense and utterly silent. He flicked his fingers. The shadow shot across the clearing, faster than Lex's bolt, and struck the dead pine a finger's width from the bolt's fletching, and the bark where it hit simply *vanished*, leaving a neat round hole that went in half an inch and stopped.

VOID BOLT – Expert 1

"Show-off," said Lex.

"Eight years in a cave," said Antho mildly. "I had a lot of time to practice."

They'd been on the Road for nine days. The Greyspine was a grey wall far behind them to the south, and the country they walked through now was moorland, wide and rolling and empty, covered in heather and bracken and great grey boulders that sat on the hilltops like sleeping beasts. The Road ran straight across it, north, heaved and broken and mossy, marked every few miles by a waystone with the open hand and the flame. They'd seen no one. No villages, no farms, no travelers. Only sheep, once, on a far hillside, and a hawk hanging in the wind, and in the distance, every evening, the mist rising off the low places in long silver skeins.

Antho had started teaching Lex on the second day out from the mountains. It had begun almost by accident. Lex had been trying to light the fire with Heat Shaping, the way he'd done in the foothills, and had set the bracken around it alight instead, and Antho had stamped it out and then sat down and said, with the air of a man who'd been holding his tongue for some time: *You do realize you're doing that completely wrong.*

He hadn't realized. Nobody had ever taught him. Ember had told him what his skills did, and guided him in fights, and talked him through his points. But Ember was a construct of knowledge, not of practice. It knew what a thing was; it didn't always know what a thing *felt* like, from the inside.

Antho knew. Antho had spent eight years alone in a cave with nothing but a power he didn't understand and a voice that wanted to eat him, and

he'd learned, by trial and error and sheer stubbornness, how to make the power do what he wanted. He knew how it felt when it went right. He knew, much better, how it felt when it went wrong.

"Your fire and my dark aren't the same," he'd said that first evening, sitting by the half-burned bracken. "But they're not as different as you'd think. They both come from the same place. The Root, Ember calls it." He'd shaped a little knot of shadow in his palm and let it dissolve. "The trick is the same. You don't push it. You *let* it. Like water finding a crack."

"That's not what Ember says."

"What does Ember say?"

"Heat is a material. Shape it."

Antho had thought about that. "Fine," he'd said. "Both. Shape it, and let it. You shape the channel. Then you let it flow."

It had made no sense at all. And then, three days later, halfway through a fight with a pack of moorland wolves, it had suddenly made perfect sense, and Lex had stopped *pushing* his Ember Strikes and started *letting* them, and the fire had come down his arm into the hammer like a river let out of a sluice, twice as hot and half as tiring.

SKILL UP: Ember Strike →

Apprentice 3

Mana efficiency improved.

[Hub,] Ember had said, sounding faintly put out. [He's a better teacher than I am.]

He's had more practice.

[I've been around since you were four.]

Asleep.

[That's not my fault,] said Ember, with dignity.

Now Lex picked up another bolt, and heated it, and looked at the dead pine across the clearing.

"Don't think about your arm," said Antho.

Lex didn't think about his arm. He thought about the heat. He thought about the forge, the bellows, the way the air rushed in under the coals and the fire leaped up to meet it. He shaped the channel. Then he let it go.

The bolt left his fingers like a shot from a sling. It hit the pine a finger's width from Antho's shadow-hole, so hard that the trunk shuddered and a shower of dead needles came pattering down, and the iron head went in so deep that only the very tip of the fletching showed.

SKILL LEARNED: Slag Shot

Novice 1

"Hurl heated iron with the breath of the forge."

Antho raised his eyebrows.

"*There*," he said. "That one."



THEY REACHED THE LITHIC Oracle on the eleventh day.

Wren saw it first. She'd been scouting ahead, as she did every morning, ranging out along the Road a mile or two in front of them and then circling back, and she came back that morning at a run, her face flushed and strange.

"There's a gorge," she said. "Up ahead. The Road goes into it. And there's something in it." She hesitated. "Statues."

"Statues?"

"Lots of statues." Wren's jaw tightened. "People. Stone people. All down the sides of the gorge." She paused. "Some of them are wearing armor. Some of them are wearing *clothes*. Like real clothes. With buttons."

Lex and Antho looked at each other.

"The Oracle," said Antho quietly. "The first shrine. The book said a guardian. It didn't say what kind."

[A stone guardian who asks questions,] said Ember. [Lithic means stone. An oracle answers questions, or asks them. I'd guess the statues are the people who gave the wrong answers.]

"Ember thinks the statues are people who gave the wrong answers," Lex said.

Wren stared at him. "*Gave the wrong answers*. To what?"

"To whatever she asks."

"*She*?"

Lex didn't know why he'd said *she*. It had just come out.



THE GORGE WAS A deep cleft in the moor, cut by a river long since dried up, its walls sheer grey stone a hundred feet high. The Road ran straight into it and down along its floor, the heaved grey slabs gleaming wet with the mist that pooled between the walls. And on either side of the Road, all along the floor of the gorge and up onto ledges in the rock walls, there were statues.

Wren had been right. They were people.

Lex walked slowly between them with Anvilsong on his shoulder, and his skin crawled. They were grey stone, all of them, the same grey as the gorge walls. But they weren't carved. They couldn't have been carved. No sculptor alive could have made stone look like this: every fold of a cloak, every crease of a sleeve, every strand of hair. A woman in a traveling dress with her hand raised to her mouth, her stone eyes wide. A man in old-fashioned armor, his sword half-drawn, his face twisted in fury. A boy, no older than fifteen, sitting on a rock with his chin in his hands as if he'd been thinking hard about something when the stone took him. A Warden in a grey cloak, his lattice-pin carved in perfect detail on his chest, his mouth open in the middle of a word.

Some of them were very old. Worn by weather, softened by moss, their faces rubbed almost smooth. Some of them were not old at all.

"How many?" Wren whispered.

Antho was counting. He always counted. "Two hundred and twelve," he said quietly. "That I can see." He stopped beside the boy on the rock and looked down at him for a long moment. "They're not dead," he said. "Not exactly."

"What do you mean?"

"Grave-Speech. It's one of my skills. I can hear the dead, sometimes. If they want to be heard." He touched the stone boy's shoulder, very lightly. "These aren't dead. They're just—*still*. Waiting." He took his hand away. "It's very quiet inside them."

Ashka, on his shoulder, made an unhappy little trilling sound and pressed against his neck.

At the end of the gorge, the walls drew close together, and the Road ran up a broad flight of grey stone steps, and at the top of the steps, sitting on a great flat plinth of rock with the dead river's dry falls rising behind her, was the Oracle.



SHE WAS ENORMOUS.

She was the size of a small house, lying on the plinth the way a cat lies on a hearth, with her great forepaws stretched out in front of her and her hind legs tucked beneath. She had the body of a lion, grey stone, every muscle carved in perfect smooth relief. She had wings, folded along her back, the wings of a great eagle, each feather a separate blade of stone. And she had the face of a woman.

It was an old woman's face, lined and serene, with heavy-lidded eyes and a long straight nose and a mouth that was very nearly smiling. Her hair, stone too, was bound up in a heavy coil on the back of her head. She was the most beautiful thing Lex had ever seen, and the most frightening, and as they came up the steps toward her, her stone eyes opened.

They were silver. Not stone. Living silver, like the light of the Lattice, swirling slowly, like mist in a bowl.

THE LITHIC ORACLE

Founders' Guardian – Level ???

SHRINE TRIAL: THE FIRST SONG

Answer truly.

Answer falsely, and be still.

"Ah," said the Oracle.

Her voice was the sound of millstones grinding, slow and deep and heavy, and yet somehow, underneath it, there was something almost warm. Something almost amused.

"Visitors," she said. "How lovely. It has been eleven years since anyone came to me who was not a fool or a thief." Her silver eyes moved over them, one by one: Wren with her bow, Antho with the dragon on his shoulder, Lex with his hammer. When they reached Lex, they stopped, and something moved in them. A swirl in the silver.

"Oh," said the Oracle softly. "Oh, *now*. Look at you."

Lex didn't know what to say. So he said, "Hello."

The Oracle laughed. It was like a small landslide, distant and rumbling.

"Hello," she said. "Hello, child of the blood. Hello, little bright one, little hammer-hand. I wondered when one of you would come." Her gaze moved to Antho. "And you. The deep one. Oh, what a dark you carry. What a heavy, hungry dark." She tilted her great stone head. "You are very brave to carry it so far from its door."

Antho's hand tightened on his staff. He didn't say anything.

"And you," said the Oracle to Wren. Her silver eyes narrowed slightly. "You are not of the blood. What are you doing in such company, little climber?"

Wren lifted her chin. "Keeping them alive."

The Oracle laughed again. "Oh, I *like* you," she said. "You may stay."



"**YOU HAVE COME FOR** the song," said the Oracle, when she had finished laughing. "The first of the three. I can feel the stone you carry." Her silver gaze dropped to Antho's chest, where the lodestone hung on its cord beneath his shirt. "It is hungry, that little stone. It has been waiting a long time to sing."

"Yes," said Lex. "We've come for the song."

"Then you know the price."

"We answer your questions."

"You answer them *truly*." The Oracle's great stone paws flexed on the plinth, a grinding of rock on rock. "Not cleverly. Not correctly. *Truly*. There is a difference, and every soul in that gorge behind you learned it too late." Her voice dropped. "I will ask three. One for each of you. If you answer truly, you will have your song. If you answer falsely..." She let the silence finish the sentence.

Wren swallowed audibly.

"What if we don't want to answer?" said Antho.

"Then you may turn around and walk back down my steps, and go home, and never find the one you are looking for." The Oracle's eyes swirled. "That is always an option. Very few take it."

The three of them looked at each other. Ashka chirped nervously.

"I'll go first," said Lex.

"No," said the Oracle. "You will go first, little hammer-hand, because I will choose you first. That is not the same thing." Her heavy-lidded eyes settled on him, and he felt the weight of them like a hand on his chest. "But since you were brave enough to offer, I will be kind, and ask you something you know."

She was quiet for a moment. The mist drifted between the gorge walls.

"I am given by the hammer," said the Oracle, "and stolen by the fire. I am lost in the quench, if the quench is rushed. Old smiths keep me in their arms. Young smiths think they have me. What am I?"



LEX STOOD VERY STILL.

[Careful,] said Ember, very quietly. *[She said truly, not correctly. There may be more than one answer.]*

He thought about it. He thought about the forge. *Given by the hammer.* Every blow on hot iron did something to it. Packed the grain tighter. Made it harder, tougher. *Stolen by the fire.* Put iron back in the fire too long, too hot, and it lost all that. Went soft again. *Lost in the quench, if the quench is rushed.* Plunge hot steel into cold water too fast, too carelessly, and it would crack, or warp, or go brittle as glass.

Mind the quench.

"Temper," he said.

The Oracle's silver eyes swirled.

"Which temper?" she said softly.

And Lex understood. He understood what she was really asking. Because there were two. There was the temper of steel, the hardness and toughness and springiness that a smith worked into a blade with hammer and fire and water. And there was the other kind. The temper of a man. *Old smiths keep me in their arms.* Brannoc, steady as a wall, never once raising his voice in eight years. *Young smiths think they have me.* Lex, nineteen, standing in the forge shouting at a stranger about his father, the fire in the hearth leaping up a foot high.

"Both," he said.

The Oracle looked at him for a long, long moment.

Then she smiled. A real smile, slow and deep, the stone lines of her face rearranging themselves like hills shifting in a dream.

"Both," she agreed. "Truly answered, little hammer-hand. You will keep yours in your arms one day. Not yet. But one day."

FIRST QUESTION – ANSWERED TRULY

Lex let out a breath he hadn't known he'd been holding.



"**THE CLIMBER NEXT,**" SAID the Oracle, and turned her great head toward Wren.

Wren's knuckles went white on her bow. But she didn't step back.

"Don't be afraid, little one," said the Oracle. "I will ask you something you know too. Something the mountain taught you." Her silver eyes half-closed. *"I climb without hands, and fall without breaking. I hide the hunter and the hunted alike. I am thickest where the world is lowest, and thinnest where it is high. The Founders made a net of me, and called it mercy. What am I?"*

Wren frowned.

Lex watched her think. He could see her working it through. *Climbs without hands. Falls without breaking. Hides the hunter and the hunted.* She'd hunted on the mountain her whole life. She'd hidden from things on the mountain her whole life. She knew what lay thick in the valleys and thin on the peaks, every morning, every evening, rising off the low places in long silver skeins.

"Mist," she said slowly. And then, frowning harder: "But the last part. *The Founders made a net of me.*" She looked at Lex. "The Veil. The silver mist. It's thicker around the Lattice Stones. Everyone says it's the Lattice breathing. That it's *part* of it." She turned back to the Oracle. "The Veil," she said, more firmly. "You're the Veil. The mist that's the Lattice."

The Oracle's silver eyes opened wide.

"*Truly* answered," she said, and there was something almost like approval in the grinding stone voice. "And more truly than you know, little climber. The Veil is the breath of the net. It rises from it as mist rises from warm water on a cold morning. Where the net is strong, the Veil is thin and

bright. Where the net is weak..." She paused. "Where the net is weak, the Veil grows thick and grey, and other things come up through it." Her gaze moved to Antho. "Darker things."

SECOND QUESTION – ANSWERED TRULY

Wren exhaled. Her hands were shaking. Lex reached over without thinking and squeezed her shoulder, and she didn't pull away.

"And now," said the Oracle, "the deep one."



ANTHO STEPPED FORWARD.

He did it slowly, with Ashka on his shoulder and his staff in his hand and his grey eyes fixed on the Oracle's silver ones. He'd gone very pale. Through the Bloodbond, Lex could feel his heart pounding.

CLARITY: 74 → 69 ▼ (fear)

"I will not be kind to you," said the Oracle softly. "Not because I do not wish to be. But because you would not believe a kind question, and you would answer it falsely, and you would be still." Her silver eyes swirled. "So I will ask you something hard. Something you know too well. Are you ready?"

"No," said Antho.

"Truly answered," said the Oracle, with a faint ghost of a smile. "Here is your question, deep one."

She was quiet for a long moment. When she spoke again, her voice had dropped so low it was almost lost in the grinding of the stone.

"What grows heavier the longer it is carried, and lighter the moment it is set down? What can be set down only by another's hand, and never by your own?"

Antho went absolutely still.

Lex saw it go into him. Saw the words land. Saw his brother's face go from pale to grey, saw his long scarred fingers tighten on his staff until the knuckles stood out like stones.

He knew the answer. Of course he knew. Lex knew it too. Everyone on the steps knew it.

"Guilt," said Antho. His voice was barely a whisper.

The Oracle didn't move. Her silver eyes held his.

"*Truly?*" she said.

"Yes."

"Then answer me this, deep one, for the answer is not finished until you do." The Oracle leaned forward, her great stone head lowering until her face was level with his, so close that her breath, cold as the inside of a mountain, stirred his newly-cut hair. "*Whose hand?*"

Antho opened his mouth.

Nothing came out.

Lex watched him try. Watched him search for an answer and not find one. *Whose hand?* His mother's? She was gone into the dark. His father's? His father had sealed him and left him and never come back. The Wardens he'd killed? Their families? The village? The world?

There was no one. There had been no one for eight years. That was the whole point. That was why he'd stayed in the cave.

CLARITY: 69 → 58 ▼
58 → 47 ▼

"I don't know," Antho whispered.

And at his feet, the stone began to climb.



LEX SAW IT HAPPEN. A faint greyness, rising from the steps into the soles of his brother's bare feet. Spreading. Creeping up over his ankles like frost creeping over a window. Where it touched, the skin went grey, and hard, and still.

"*Antho—*"

"I don't know," Antho said again, louder, and his voice was cracking. He looked down at his feet. At the grey creeping up over his shins. "I don't know whose hand. There isn't anyone. There's never been anyone. That's the *answer*. That's the true answer. *I don't know.*"

"That is not an answer," said the Oracle gently. "That is a door you have shut. I asked you whose hand, deep one. Not whether there is one."

The stone reached his knees. Ashka was shrieking, sparks flying off her spines, scrabbling at his shoulder. Antho didn't seem to notice. He was staring at the Oracle, and his eyes, Lex saw with horror, were beginning to go black at the edges.

CLARITY: 47 → 38 ▼



stirring

[Lex,] said Ember sharply. [She asked whose hand. She didn't say it had to be his answer.]

Lex stepped forward.

"Mine," he said.

The Oracle's head turned. Slowly. Her silver eyes found his.

"Mine," Lex said again. He walked past Wren, up the last step, until he was standing right beside his brother. The grey was at Antho's thighs now. Lex didn't look at it. He looked at the Oracle. "Whose hand sets it down. It's mine. I'm his brother. I'm the one he left. I'm the one he thinks he failed." He swallowed. "So I'm the one who gets to set it down."

He reached out and took his brother's hand. The stone had reached Antho's waist. His fingers were cold as ice.

"I forgive you," Lex said. He said it to the Oracle, and he said it to Antho, and he said it, he realized, to himself, to the eleven-year-old boy kneeling in the wet grass outside a burning house. "For leaving. For not coming back. For all of it. I forgive you, Antho. You can put it down now."

The gorge was utterly silent.

Antho turned his head and looked at him. His eyes were black at the edges and grey in the middle and wet all over. His mouth was shaking.

"You can't," he whispered. "You can't just—"

"I can," said Lex. "I just did."

The stone stopped.

It stopped at Antho's chest, a hand's width below his heart. For a long, long moment it simply stayed there, grey and hard and still, and nobody breathed.

Then it began to recede.

Slowly. Like a tide going out. The grey sank back down out of his chest, his waist, his thighs, his knees, leaving warm living skin behind it. Down his

shins. Down over his ankles. Back into the steps, where it faded and was gone.

Antho's legs gave out. Lex caught him. They went down together onto the cold grey step, Antho's face pressed into Lex's shoulder, his whole body shaking, and Ashka climbed frantically between them chirping and crackling, and Lex just held on.

CLARITY: 38 → 61 ▲
 61 → 79 ▲▲
 – suppressed

THIRD QUESTION – ANSWERED TRULY
 (by two voices)

SHRINE TRIAL COMPLETE

The Oracle watched them for a long time without speaking.

"*Truly* answered," she said at last, very softly. "By two hands. As it should be." She lifted her great stone head and looked out over the gorge, at the two hundred and twelve grey statues standing in the mist. "Do you know, in nine hundred years, no one has ever answered that question rightly? They all say *guilt*. And then they all say *I don't know*. Or they name someone dead, or someone far away, someone who will never come. And they go still." She looked back down at the two brothers on her steps. "No one ever brought anyone with them who could answer for them."



IT WAS A LONG time before Antho lifted his head. When he did, his eyes were red-rimmed and swollen and completely, entirely grey.

He looked at Lex.

He didn't say anything. He didn't need to.

"Get up, the both of you," said Wren, behind them. Her voice was very rough. "You're blocking the steps."

They got up. Lex kept a hand on his brother's arm. Antho didn't shake it off.

"You have earned your song," said the Oracle. "Hold up the stone."

Antho drew the lodestone out from under his shirt on its old black cord, and held it up in the misty light.

The Oracle closed her silver eyes.

And she sang.

It wasn't a song with words. It wasn't even a song with a tune, not exactly. It was the sound of the mountain. The sound of stone. Deep and slow and immense, so low that Lex felt it in his bones more than heard it with his ears: the grinding of continents, the patience of bedrock, the long slow breath of a world that measured time in ages. It filled the gorge. It made the grey walls hum. It made the statues tremble on their ledges.

And the lodestone answered.

A faint grey light rose up inside it, deep in the heart of the little river-pebble. It pulsed, once, in time with the Oracle's song. Then again. Then steadily, a slow grey heartbeat, as if the stone had been asleep and was waking.

The song ended. The echoes rolled away down the gorge and faded into the mist.

LODESTONE OF RETURN

Songs held: 1 / 3

◆ The Song of Stone

"I will always find my way home."

MAIN QUEST UPDATED: The Lost Father

◆ The Lithic Oracle DONE

◇ The heart of the Thornwood

◇ The Barrow Throne

+XP (shared)

LEVEL UP! Lex — Level 16

LEVEL UP! Wren Ashdown — Level 22

LEVEL UP! Anthoren — Level 32

Antho was staring at the faintly glowing stone in his hand.

"It's warm," he said. "It's never been warm before."

◆ ◆ ◆

"MAY I ASK YOU something?" said Lex.

The Oracle had settled back onto her plinth. Her silver eyes were half-closed, like a cat's in the sun. She opened them a little wider.

"You may ask, little hammer-hand. I do not promise to answer."

"You said it had been eleven years since anyone came who wasn't a fool or a thief." Lex hesitated. "Who came eleven years ago?"

The Oracle was quiet for a long moment.

"Your father," she said.

Antho went still beside him.

"He came up my steps alone," said the Oracle. "On a grey morning, like this one. He looked very tired. He did not have the stone; he had given it away. He did not want a song. He knew he could not use one, alone." Her eyes swirled. "He wanted to ask *me* a question."

"What did he ask?"

The Oracle looked at him. Then at Antho. Then out at the gorge again, at the grey statues in the mist.

"He asked me how a man might mend a net," she said slowly, "from inside it. Without tearing it further. Without falling through." She was silent for a moment. "I could not answer him. It is the only question I have ever been asked that I could not answer. He thanked me, and went away north, and I have been thinking about it for eleven years."

"Have you found the answer?" said Antho. His voice was hoarse.

"No," said the Oracle. "But I have begun to think," and here her silver gaze moved slowly from one brother to the other, the bright one and the deep one, standing side by side on her steps, "that a man alone cannot do it. That a net mended from inside needs more than one pair of hands."

She closed her eyes.

"Go now," she said. "You have a long way to travel, and the Thornwood does not wait. And the one you seek is very tired." A pause. "Tell him the Oracle is still thinking about his question. He will understand."



THEY WALKED BACK DOWN the steps, and down the gorge, between the two hundred and twelve grey statues standing silent in the mist.

Halfway down, Antho stopped.

He was standing beside the boy on the rock. The one who sat with his chin in his hands, as if he'd been thinking hard about something when the stone took him. Antho looked down at him for a long time.

Then he crouched, and put his hand on the boy's stone shoulder again.

"I'm sorry," he said quietly. "I hope someone comes for you. I hope someone brings someone who can answer for you."

The boy didn't move. But Lex thought, just for a moment, that the stone face looked a little less troubled.

Antho stood up. He walked on.

They came out of the gorge onto the open moor in the afternoon light. The mist was lifting. The Road ran on ahead of them, north, straight as a ruled line, toward a dark smudge on the far horizon that Wren said was the edge of a forest.

"The Thornwood," said Antho. He was looking at it with an odd expression. Then he turned to Lex. "Lex."

"Yeah."

"Back there. On the steps." Antho's voice was very quiet. "Did you mean it?"

Lex looked at his brother. At the clean-shaven jaw and the cut hair and the grey eyes, red-rimmed still, looking back at him with something in them that Lex had never seen before. Not guilt, for once. Not grief. Something more fragile than either. Something like hope, held very carefully, the way you'd hold a bird's egg.

"Yes," he said. "I meant it."

Antho looked at him a moment longer. Then he nodded, once, and turned and walked on up the Road toward the dark line of the forest, and Ashka rode on his shoulder chirping softly into his ear.

Lex watched him go.

[That was well done,] said Ember quietly.

I didn't plan it.

[I know. That's why it was well done.] A pause. *[Lex. When you said it. When you said "I forgive you." Did you feel anything?]*

He thought about it.

It felt like putting down the hammer, he said slowly. At the end of a long day. When your arms have been aching for hours and you didn't even notice, and then you put it down and suddenly you notice. Everything goes light.

[Yes,] said Ember softly. [That's exactly what I felt too. Through the seal.] A long pause. [It's strange. I don't think I've ever felt anything before. Not really.]

Wren fell into step beside him. She didn't say anything for a while. Then she bumped her shoulder against his arm, lightly, the way she'd done in the snow below the Hollowmaw.

"You're still an idiot, Hammer," she said.

"I know."

"But I'm glad you were the one who came up those steps first." She looked ahead at Antho, walking alone up the Road with his dragon. "I don't think anyone else could have answered that."

They walked on together toward the Thornwood.

CHAPTER 11

OATHKEEPER



THEY SMELLED THE VILLAGE before they saw it.

It was the third day out from the Oracle's gorge. The moor had begun to give way to farmland, poor thin farmland, stone-walled fields of oats and barley gone ragged and untended, a few sheep wandering loose with nobody to mind them. The Road ran on through it, straight and heaved and mossy. And on the morning wind, coming down off a low ridge to the east, there was smoke.

Not woodsmoke. Lex knew woodsmoke; he'd lived his whole life in it. This was thicker and greasier and sourer, and under it, faint but unmistakable, was the smell he'd learned to dread. Wet ash. Rot. Nothing.

"Gloom," said Antho quietly. He'd stopped in the middle of the Road, his face gone pale. Ashka, on his shoulder, was hissing softly, sparks crawling along her spines. "And fire. A lot of fire."

Wren was already moving. She went up the side of the ridge at a crouching run, quick and silent as a fox, and flattened herself among the heather at the top. Lex saw her go very still. Then she turned her head and waved them up, sharply, urgently.

They went up after her and lay down beside her in the heather, and looked.

There had been a village in the valley below. There wasn't anymore.

It had been a small place. Twenty houses, perhaps, around a green with a well in the middle and a little stone chapel at one end, like a hundred other villages in Caldor. Now most of the houses were burning. Not

burning brightly, the way a house burns when it's set alight. Burning *dully*, sullenly, with a thick black smoke that rolled low across the ground instead of rising. And the smoke was mixed with something else. Darker. Oilier. Moving in a way smoke shouldn't move.

The Gloam lay over the whole valley like a stain.

It wasn't the thin threads of the Hollowmaw, or the creeping tide that had come down the north road at Ashbourne. It was thick, and it was everywhere. It filled the low places between the houses. It had soaked into the fields, turning the oats grey. It hung in the air like fog. And moving through it, between the burning houses, were shapes.

Gloamhounds. A dozen of them, maybe more. Loping silently through the smoke, their white eyes glinting.

And something else. Something bigger. Lex couldn't see it clearly through the smoke; only a vast dark hump of a shape, moving slowly across the far side of the green, and the sound of it: a heavy, dragging, grinding sound, like a sledge full of stones being pulled over cobbles.

"There," said Wren, very quietly, pointing.

At the far end of the village, the little stone chapel was still standing. Its door was shut. Its windows were dark. And in front of its door, on the steps, a single figure was standing with a sword in his hand.

He was a big man, broad and heavy-shouldered, in battered armor that might once have been fine and was now dented and scratched and patched with leather. His head was bare. His hair was grey. And he was fighting.

As they watched, three gloamhounds came at him at once out of the smoke. He met them on the chapel steps. His sword moved in a short, brutal, economical arc, and the first hound came apart in rags of black smoke. He took the second on his armored forearm and threw it back down the steps. The third got its teeth into his leg, and he grunted and brought the pommel of his sword down on its head, and it burst, and he staggered.

He didn't fall. He planted his feet again on the chapel steps. Behind him, the door stayed shut.

"There are people in there," said Antho. "In the chapel. I can feel them. Lots of them." He closed his eyes. "Thirty. Forty. Frightened. Children."

"He's holding the door," said Wren.

Lex watched the grey-haired man on the steps. Watched the next wave of hounds come at him out of the smoke. Watched him meet them, and stagger, and hold.

His sword, Lex noticed, was broken. It had snapped about a third of the way down the blade, leaving only a jagged stump of steel. He was fighting with half a sword.

"Right," said Lex, and stood up.



HE DIDN'T THINK ABOUT it. Afterward, he realized he hadn't thought about it at all. He simply stood up out of the heather and ran down the ridge into the smoke with Anvilson in his hands, and somewhere behind him he heard Wren swear and Antho call his name, and then they were running too.

The first gloamhound saw him coming and turned. Lex didn't slow down. He hit it with an Ember Strike at a dead run and it exploded into gold sparks, and he ran through the sparks without stopping. The second came at him from the side. He threw a Slag Shot at it without breaking stride, a bolt from his belt heated cherry-red and flung with the breath of the forge, and it struck the hound in the chest and the hound burned.

He'd spent his points that morning. Finally. Ember had been nagging him for three days. Twenty-four points, from four levels he'd forgotten about, and he'd put them where it felt right without thinking too hard, and he felt them now as he ran. His legs were springs. His lungs were bellows. The hammer in his hands weighed nothing at all.

LEX VEY – Emberwright, Level 16		
MIG 32	AGI 31	VIT 38
INT 28	SPI 66	RES 29
Health	380/380	
Mana	660/660	

Behind him, Wren's arrows were singing. He saw them strike hounds out of the corner of his eye, blue Rimebite heads bursting into frost, freezing the creatures mid-leap so that they hung in the air for an instant before they shattered. And Antho—

Antho came down the ridge like a piece of the night tearing loose. The shadows poured off him in a black wave, and where they touched the Gloam, something strange happened. The Gloam *recoiled*. It shrank back from Antho's shadows the way it shrank back from the green fire in the Hollowmaw, as if it recognized them, as if it were afraid of them. And the hounds caught in the shadows simply stopped, and went still, and dissolved.

CLARITY: 81 → 76 ▼ (Hollow use)
76 → 79 ▲ (anchor)

[His shadows and the Gloam,] said Ember, sounding startled. *[They come from the same place. The Hollow. But his are his*. Bound. Controlled.]** A pause. *[The Gloam is afraid of him. Of what he's holding in.]*

They cut through the hounds like a scythe through barley. In a minute, maybe less, the green was clear. Lex skidded to a halt at the bottom of the chapel steps, breathing hard, steam rising off him, Anvil song glowing orange in his hands.

The grey-haired man on the steps was staring at him.

Up close, he was older than Lex had thought. Fifty, maybe more. His face was broad and weathered and seamed with scars, his nose had been broken more than once, and his grey hair was cut short as a soldier's. His eyes were dark brown and very steady. There was blood running down his left leg where the hound had bitten him, and the bite was already turning grey at the edges.

"Well," the man said. His voice was deep and rough and oddly calm. "You're not what I was praying for. But I'll take it."

"There's something else," Lex said. "Something big. On the far side of the green."

"I know." The man shifted his grip on his broken sword. "It's coming back. It comes every few minutes. Circles the village, then comes back for the chapel." He looked at Lex, at the glowing hammer, at Antho coming up behind with shadows still curling around his hands, at Wren with an arrow on the string. "You'd better get inside, lad. All of you. It's not something you want to meet."

"What is it?"

The grinding, dragging sound came again. Closer. From the smoke on the far side of the green.

"That," said the grey-haired man quietly, "used to be the miller."



IT CAME OUT OF the smoke slowly, and Lex understood at once why the man on the steps had been fighting with his back to the door instead of running.

It had been a man once. It was still shaped like one, mostly. But it was enormous, twice the height of a man and half again as wide, as if something had taken a big, strong, heavy man and *stretched* him, and stuffed the stretched skin full of something else. The Gloam poured off it in thick oily streams. Its skin was grey, the dead lifeless grey of the bear in the mountains, and cracked all over like dried mud, and through the cracks, a darker black seeped out like tar. Its arms hung down past its knees. In one hand, it dragged a millstone. A real one, a great round grinding stone as wide as a cartwheel, chained to its wrist with a length of rusted iron.

Its face was still a face. That was the worst part. A broad, jowly, ordinary face, with a fringe of beard and a mole on one cheek. A miller's face. The kind of face Lex had seen a thousand times at the Ashbourne mill. But the eyes were white, blank, boiled-egg white, and the mouth hung open, and out of it came the whisper. Not the thin hiss of the hounds. Something deeper. Many voices at once, low and wet and soft, all saying the same thing.

[quiet ... be quiet ... all be quiet ... quiet now ... quiet ...]

GLOAMED – "The Miller"

Level 24 – ELITE

Corruption: 88%

"Gloamed," said Antho softly. He'd gone white. "That's what they call it. When it takes a person. Not just touches them. *Takes* them." His voice was barely audible. "That's what the thing in my head wants to do to everyone. That's what it would do to me, if I let it."

The Gloamed miller stopped at the edge of the green. Its blank white eyes moved slowly across the four of them on the chapel steps. And the whisper rose.

[quiet ... more ... more to be quiet ... bright ones ... be quiet ...]

It began to swing the millstone.

Slowly at first. Then faster. Round and round on its chain, a great grey disc of stone whirling through the smoke with a deep thrumming roar, like a waterwheel in flood. Faster. Faster.

"Down!" roared the grey-haired man.

The millstone came at them like a thrown plate.

Lex didn't go down. He didn't have time to think about going down. He stepped forward and planted his feet on the chapel steps and swung Anvilsong up to meet it with everything he had: every ounce of Might, every drop of fire, the whole of the furnace in his chest poured down his arms into the iron.

Hammer met millstone.

The sound was like the world's biggest anvil being struck by the world's biggest hammer. The millstone *exploded*. It burst into pieces, gravel and dust and chunks of grey rock flying in every direction, and the force of the blow ran back up through the hammer into Lex's arms and shoulders and spine and drove him to one knee on the step. His arms were numb. His ears were ringing. His mana bar had dropped by a quarter in a single strike.

But the millstone was gone.

The Gloamed miller stared at the empty chain dangling from its wrist. Its blank face showed nothing. The whisper faltered, stuttered, rose again.

[... bright ... too bright ... quiet the bright one ... QUIET ...]

It came across the green at them at a lumbering run.



IT TOOK ALL FOUR of them.

Wren's arrows froze its legs, slowing it, and it broke the ice and kept coming. Antho's shadows wrapped around it, and it tore through them like a bull through a hedge, though Lex saw it flinch where they touched. Lex hit it with Ember Strike after Ember Strike, and each one blasted a smoking crater in its grey cracked skin, and black tar poured out, and it didn't stop.

It swung its great arms at them like clubs. It caught Wren a glancing blow that sent her tumbling across the cobbles, her health bar plunging, and Lex felt it through the fellowship like a blow to his own chest. It caught Antho full in the side and threw him into the wall of a burning house, and Lex felt *that* through the Bloodbond like a cold hand closing on his heart.

CLARITY: 79 → 64 ▼ (injury)

"Antho!"

"*I'm fine—*"

He wasn't fine. Lex could feel it. The pain, and the fear, and under them, something stirring. Something cold.

And the grey-haired man was there.

He came off the chapel steps with his broken sword in his hand, limping on his grey-bitten leg, and he went straight at the Gloamed miller without hesitating. He didn't use magic. Lex saw no glow, no fire, no shadow. He just fought. He fought like a man who had been fighting all his life and had learned every hard lesson there was to learn. He went in low, under the swinging arms, and struck at the knees with the jagged stump of his sword. He took a blow on his armored shoulder that would have killed Lex outright and rolled with it and came up on the far side. He was slower than Lex. He was older. He was bleeding. But every move he made was exactly the move he needed to make, no more, no less, and the Gloamed miller couldn't touch him.

[A soldier,] said Ember. [A real one. Look at his feet. He never stops moving them.]

"*The chest!*" the grey-haired man shouted at Lex. "There's a heart in there! Black, like a coal! I saw it when your fire opened him up! Hit the same place twice!"

Lex saw it. When his last Ember Strike had blasted a crater in the miller's chest, for a moment, just a moment, he'd seen something deep inside: a darkness darker than the rest, pulsing slowly, like the Rimewarden's heart. Like the Gloam's heart.

"I need it to hold still!" he shouted back.

"Then I'll make it hold still!"

The grey-haired man threw himself at the Gloamed miller's legs. Not to strike. To *grab*. He wrapped both arms around one of its huge grey knees and dug his heels in and *held*, and the thing staggered, trying to shake him off.

"Antho!" Lex shouted. "Wren!"

His brother was already moving. He'd dragged himself up out of the rubble of the burning house, and his eyes were flickering black at the edges, but he threw out both hands, and the shadows came off him in a rush and wrapped around the Gloamed miller's other leg and its arms and its throat and *pulled*. And from across the green, sitting up among the cobbles with blood on her face, Wren loosed her last Rimebite arrow, and it struck the miller in the back of the neck, and frost exploded outward across its shoulders, locking them in place.

For one heartbeat, the Gloamed miller was still.

Lex ran at it.

He didn't use Ember Strike. He used something else. Something he'd never done before, that came up out of him like the fourth rune on the hammer, from somewhere deep and unknown. He ran at it with Anvilsong held low, and as he ran, he pushed heat into the hammer, not in a single strike but continuously, pouring, a river of fire flowing down his arms into the iron. The hammer went from orange to gold to white. It was so hot that the air around it shimmered and warped. And when he reached the Gloamed miller, he didn't swing it.

He drove it straight into the crater in its chest, head-first, like a smith driving a hot punch through a bar.

The heart burst.

The Gloamed miller didn't scream. It *sighed*. A long, deep, shuddering sigh, all the whispering voices letting out their breath at once. The Gloam poured out of it in a great black gout, out of its mouth and its eyes and the cracks in its skin, rising, writhing, and then thinning, and fading, and gone. The grey skin crumbled. The huge stretched body sagged and slumped and collapsed in on itself like a tent with the pole pulled out.

And on the cobbles at Lex's feet, where the monster had been, there was a man.

An ordinary man. Big and heavy and middle-aged, with a fringe of beard and a mole on his cheek. Grey-faced, in torn clothes. Lying on his back with his eyes closed.

Breathing.

GLOAMED – "The Miller" – PURGED

Host: ALIVE

ELITE KILL – bonus XP (shared)

LEVEL UP! Lex – Level 17

LEVEL UP! Wren Ashdown – Level 23

SKILL LEARNED: Forge-Heart Thrust

Novice 1

"Drive the fire home."

Lex stared down at him.

"He's alive," he said. "He's alive. I thought—I thought it ate them. I thought there was nothing left."

The grey-haired man let go of the miller's knee, or the place where its knee had been, and sat back heavily on the cobbles. He was breathing hard. He looked at the man lying beside him, and something went across his scarred face that Lex couldn't read.

"So did I," he said quietly. "So did I, lad."



THERE WERE THIRTY-SEVEN PEOPLE in the chapel. Women, mostly, and old men, and children. A great many children. They came out slowly, blinking, when the grey-haired man called to them, and stood on the chapel steps in the grey smoky light and looked at the ruin of their village, and at the four strangers standing among it, and at the ordinary middle-aged man lying unconscious on the cobbles.

A woman came running out of the crowd. She threw herself down beside the miller and gathered him into her arms, sobbing.

"*Hob*," she said. "Oh, Hob, oh, Hob, Lady of Lanterns, oh, *Hob*—"

The miller's eyes opened. They were brown. Ordinary brown. He looked up at his wife's face, confused, as if waking from a long sleep.

"Bess?" he said. His voice was cracked and faint. "Bess, what—where—I was dreaming. I was dreaming it was so *quiet*—"

His wife held him and wept.

Lex had to turn away.

He found himself standing beside the grey-haired man, who had sat down on the bottom step of the chapel with his broken sword across his knees and was looking at the bite on his leg. It had gone grey all around the edges, the grey spreading in thin branching lines up toward his knee, like frost on a window.

"That needs looking at," Lex said.

"It does." The man didn't seem worried. "I've had worse. Not much worse. But worse." He looked up at Lex. "You don't happen to know how to get the grey out, do you? I've seen men lose a leg to it. Seen men lose more."

[*Heat,*] said Ember. [*The same way it came out of you. The same way it came out of the miller. The Gloam can't stand fire. Not yours.*]

Lex knelt on the step and laid his hand flat over the bite, and pushed. Gently, this time. Not a strike. A slow warm flow of heat, like the warmth of a hearth on a winter evening, seeping down through the man's skin into the wound.

The grey hissed. It shrank back down the leg, the branching lines retreating, fading, until there was only an ordinary bite wound, red and bloody and clean.

The man watched it happen without a word. When it was done, he looked at his leg for a long moment. Then he looked at Lex.

"Thank you," he said.

"You're welcome."

"I'm Garrick," the man said. "Garrick Dunmore." He held out his hand. It was huge and scarred and calloused, a soldier's hand. "Sir Garrick, once upon a time. Not anymore."

Lex shook it. "Lex."

"Just Lex?"

"For now."

Garrick's mouth twitched. "Fair enough."



HIS STORY CAME OUT that evening, in pieces, around a fire they built in the middle of the village green while the survivors gathered what they could save from the burned houses.

He'd been a knight once. A real one, a Knight of the Silver Lattice, the order of knights that served the Wardens, sworn to protect the Lattice and enforce its law. Thirty years he'd served. He'd fought in the border wars against the Vhessan raiders and in the sea war off Saltreach and in a dozen smaller campaigns whose names Lex didn't recognize. He'd risen to captain. He'd had a wife and a daughter and a house in Highcrest with a garden.

"And then I didn't," he said, poking the fire with a stick.

Six years ago, he'd been sent with a company of knights to a village in the eastern march. A village of unlatticed folk: people who refused the Kindling, who lived outside the Lattice, who practiced the old hedge-magic of the Listeners in defiance of the Order's law. There were villages like that in the east, he said. Not many. A few. People who'd decided the Lattice's gifts weren't worth the Lattice's chains.

"We were told to bring them in," Garrick said. "For Kindling. By force, if necessary." He stared into the fire. "When we got there, they wouldn't come. Old men and women, mostly. Children. A few young ones with bows. They stood in their village square and told us they'd rather die free than live on the Wardens' leash." He paused. "So the Warden in command ordered us to burn the village."

The fire crackled. Nobody said anything.

"I refused," said Garrick simply. "I told him I'd been a knight thirty years and I'd killed a great many men, but I'd never burned a child and I wasn't going to start. He ordered me again. I refused again. So he had me arrested, and burned the village anyway, with the rest of my company. And when we got back to Highcrest, they stripped me of my spurs and my sword-belt and my name, and broke my sword over a block in the Spire courtyard, and threw me out the gate."

He lifted the broken sword from his knees. It had been a fine blade once. Lex could see that, even now. Good steel, well-forged, with a plain

cross-guard and a hilt wrapped in worn leather. The pommel was a disc of silver, engraved with a lattice. The blade had snapped clean about a third of the way down.

"Oathkeeper," Garrick said. "My father's sword. And his father's. They broke it in front of me. I picked up the pieces when they weren't looking. Kept them." He turned the broken blade in the firelight. "Never could bring myself to get it reforged. Felt wrong, somehow. Like I'd be pretending it never happened."

"Your wife?" said Wren quietly. "Your daughter?"

Garrick was silent for a long time.

"My wife died the next winter," he said at last. "A fever. I wasn't there. I was drunk in a tavern in Saltreach, feeling sorry for myself." He poked the fire. "My daughter wrote to me once, after. Told me exactly what she thought of me. She wasn't wrong." He paused. "Elowen. She'd be twenty-three now. She was training for the Silver Lattice when I left. Wanted to be a knight like her father." His mouth twisted. "I hope she got over that."

"What have you been doing?" said Lex. "Since then?"

"Wandering," Garrick shrugged his broad shoulders. "Drinking, for a while. Then not drinking, for a while longer. Doing odd jobs. Guarding caravans. Hunting things that needed hunting." He looked around at the ruined village, at the survivors huddled around their own small fires. "I was passing through here three days ago. Stopped for the night at the inn, which was there," he pointed at a smoking heap of timbers, "and the next morning the black stuff came down off the moor. And the miller went out to see what it was. And came back like that." He shook his head. "I got the ones I could into the chapel. Then I stood on the steps."

"For three days?" said Antho.

"Seemed like the thing to do."

There was a long silence around the fire.

"You held a chapel door alone for three days," said Wren slowly. "With half a sword. Against gloamhounds. And *that*." She jerked her head at the place on the cobbles where the Gloamed miller had fallen.

"I'm a stubborn old man." Garrick smiled faintly. "My wife used to say a mule could take lessons from me." He looked across the fire at the three of

them, one by one. "My turn, I think. Who are you? A smith whose hammer catches fire. A warlock whose shadows eat the black stuff. A Tracker who can shoot the eye out of a gloamhound at forty paces. And a dragon." He nodded at Ashka, asleep in Antho's lap. "Haven't seen one of those in twenty years. Thought the Wardens had killed them all."

Lex looked at Antho. Antho looked at Wren. Wren shrugged.

"We're looking for our father," said Lex.



THEY TOLD HIM. MOST of it. Not all.

Lex didn't know why he trusted the old knight. He just did. Maybe it was the three days on the chapel steps. Maybe it was the broken sword. Maybe it was the way Garrick listened, silently, without interrupting, his dark eyes moving from face to face, nodding now and then, his scarred face giving away nothing.

When they'd finished, Garrick was quiet for a long time.

"The Gloam," he said at last. "It's coming from holes in the Lattice. Not a blight. Not a disease of the land. *Holes*. And the Order knows."

"The Order calls it a blight," said Antho. "They burn what it touches and arrest anyone who says otherwise."

"I know. I've seen them do it." Garrick turned the broken sword over in his hands. "I've been seeing it for years. Villages in the east going quiet. Wardens riding out to *contain the blight*. Never coming back with any answers." He looked up. "I always thought it was strange that they never seemed to want to *stop* it. Only to keep it quiet."

"Elric says the Gloam is the reason our father went away," said Lex. "He says Father found something in the east. Something about why it's happening."

"And now you're going to find him."

"Yes."

Garrick was silent again for a long time. The fire crackled. Across the green, a child was crying, and a woman was hushing it.

"My father had a saying," the old knight said at last. "*A man who sharpens his sword at the battle has already bled.*" He turned the broken blade so it caught the firelight. "I've been sitting around for six years

waiting for the battle to come to me. Feeling sorry for myself. Telling myself I'd done my part. I'd made my stand, refused the order, lost everything for it, and that was enough." He shook his head slowly. "It wasn't enough. It was a beginning. And I've been treating it like an end."

He looked across the fire at Lex.

"I'm a stubborn old man with half a sword and a bad leg," he said. "But I know how to fight, and I know how the Order works, and I've got a few friends left in the Silver Lattice who might still listen to me." He paused. "If you'll have me, I'd like to come with you."

Lex looked at Antho. His brother's face was unreadable, but he gave a very small nod.

He looked at Wren. She was looking at the old knight with her head tilted and her eyes narrowed. Then she shrugged.

"He held a door for three days," she said. "I'll take him."

Lex looked back at Garrick. At the broken sword in his hands.

"On one condition," he said.

Garrick raised an eyebrow.

"Let me fix that," said Lex.



THERE WAS A SMITHY in the village. Or there had been. It was half-burned, its roof fallen in, but the forge itself, a big brick hearth with a good iron anvil beside it, had come through the fire untouched. The village smith hadn't. He'd been one of the first the Gloam took, Bess the miller's wife told them quietly. He was one of the grey-faced sleepers lying in rows on the chapel floor, the ones that the hounds had touched but not taken all the way. Lex had gone down the rows with his hands, pushing warmth into each one until the grey faded, and some of them had woken, and some hadn't yet. The smith hadn't yet.

Lex worked in his forge that night.

He cleared the fallen timbers away from the hearth, and Garrick helped him, and Antho, and even some of the villagers. He built up a fire in the old brick hearth with charcoal from the smith's store and coaxed it to a roar with Heat Shaping. And then he took the two pieces of Oathkeeper, the hilt with its jagged stump of blade and the long broken tip that Garrick had

carried wrapped in oilcloth for six years, and he laid them on the anvil, side by side, and looked at them.

[It's good steel,] said Ember quietly. [Very good. Old. Folded many times. Whoever made this knew what they were doing.]

Can I mend it?

[You could weld it. Heat both ends, hammer them together. It would hold.] A pause. [But it would always have a seam. A weak place. Right where it broke.]

Lex looked at the broken edges of the steel. He ran his thumb along them and felt his Forge Sense ring, and he could hear it, faintly: the shape of the break. The stress lines running through the metal from the place where they'd struck it over the block. Six years of grief, folded into the steel.

I don't want to mend it, he thought. I want to reforge it.

[That's a much bigger job.]

I know.

He reached into his pack and took out the Rimewarden's heart.



HE WORKED THROUGH THE night.

He heated both pieces of Oathkeeper until they were glowing, and drew them out, and folded them together, and folded them again. He took the old blade and made it new, keeping the old steel but changing its shape, its grain, its heart. And at the core of the new blade, folded into the very middle where no one would ever see it, he laid a thin sliver of the Rimewarden's cracked blue heart.

The cold of it fought the fire. He felt it fight. The blue crystal and the glowing steel hissed and spat against each other on the anvil, and for a while he thought it was going to crack, the way iron cracks when you quench it carelessly. But he didn't rush it. He coaxed it. He shaped the channel, and let the fire flow, and slowly, slowly, the cold and the heat settled into each other, and the steel took on a strange, faint, blue-white sheen, like frost on a winter window.

Garrick struck for him. Lex hadn't asked. But when he'd lifted the first heat out of the fire, the old knight had simply picked up the dead smith's

sledge and stepped up to the other side of the anvil and waited, the way Brannoc had waited in Ashbourne.

They worked. *Tink. CHANG. Tink. CHANG.*

And Lex put runes into the steel.

He didn't plan them. They came up out of him the way the fourth rune had come for Anvilson, rising unbidden from somewhere deep. A rune like a shield held up against a storm. A rune like a door held shut against a pushing hand. And a third, that he didn't know until it was already going down his arm into the iron: a rune like two hands clasped. A promise. An oath.

When it was done, the sun was coming up.

Lex quenched the blade in the slack tub, slowly, carefully, minding the quench. The water didn't hiss. It *froze*. A thin skin of ice crackled across the surface of the tub from the place where the blade went in, and spread to the edges, and stopped.

He drew the sword out of the ice.

It was a longsword, plain and straight, with Oathkeeper's old cross-guard and Oathkeeper's old leather-wrapped hilt and Oathkeeper's old silver pommel engraved with a lattice. The blade was longer than the original, and a little narrower, and it shone with a faint blue-white sheen, like moonlight on snow. Frost formed on it in the warm air of the forge, and melted, and formed again. When Lex turned it in the morning light, the three runes caught the sun for an instant along the fuller, faint gold, and then faded into the steel.

ITEM CREATED	
OATHKEEPER (reforged)	
Longsword	
Grade: MASTERWORK	
Maker: Lex Vey, Emberwright	
Runes:	
BULWARK	– the bearer's guard holds against blows that should break it
BIND	– Gloam struck by this blade cannot re-form
OATH	– bound to the one who swears upon it; grows keener while the oath is kept
Rimewarden's heart (core): strikes carry frost	
"What was broken in shame is made whole in purpose."	

Runic Forging → Apprentice 6
FIRST MASTERWORK CREATED
+XP

Lex held it out across the anvil, hilt first.

Garrick Dunmore stood on the other side of the anvil with the dead smith's sledge still in his hands, and looked at the sword, and didn't move.

"It's yours," said Lex. "It was always yours. I just made it remember."

Slowly, Garrick set down the sledge. Slowly, he reached out and took the hilt. His scarred hand closed around the old worn leather, and Lex saw him feel it: the balance, the weight, the cold that came off the blade. Saw him feel the runes, maybe, the way Lex felt Anvilson's runes humming in his own grip.

The old knight turned the sword over in the light. He looked at the blue-white sheen of the blade, and the frost forming and melting along its edge. He looked at the silver pommel, his father's pommel, his grandfather's.

Then he did something Lex didn't expect.

He went down on one knee in the ashes of the burned smithy, with the sword held point-down before him, both hands on the cross-guard, and bowed his grey head.

"Garrick—" Lex started.

"Let me," said Garrick quietly. "Let me do this properly. I haven't in six years." He lifted his head and looked up at Lex, and his dark eyes were wet. "I swore my first oath on this sword when I was nineteen. Your age. I swore to protect the Lattice, and serve the Wardens, and keep their law." His mouth twisted. "I broke that oath, in the end. Or they broke it for me. I've never been sure which."

He closed his eyes.

"So I'll swear a new one," he said. "Not to the Lattice. Not to the Wardens. To you." His voice was steady and deep, and it filled the ruined smithy. "To you and your brother. And to the girl with the bow. And to the people in that chapel, and every village like this one between here and the Blightmarch." He opened his eyes. "I swear to stand on the steps. Wherever the steps are. For as long as I can stand."

The sword in his hands *rang*.

A long, clear, singing note, like Anvil-song at the end of its forging, rising up through the burned rafters and out into the morning. The runes along the blade flared gold, all three at once, and the frost on the steel thickened and sparkled like a field of snow under the rising sun.

OATH SWORN – Garrick Dunmore

Bound to: OATHKEEPER

GARRICK DUNMORE

Class: KNIGHT-ERRANT (Rare)

Tier II – Level 41

Title gained: Oathbound

Garrick stayed on his knee for a long moment, looking at the sword.

Then he stood up. He sheathed it, slowly, in the battered old scabbard at his hip, and it slid home with a sound like a sigh. And he looked at Lex, and at Antho and Wren standing in the doorway of the smithy in the morning light, and at Ashka on Antho's shoulder, and Quill, who had

arrived at some point in the night and was perched on the anvil looking smug about it.

"Right," said Sir Garrick Dunmore. "Which way's this Thornwood?"

CHAPTER 12

THE THORNWOOD



THE FOREST ROSE OUT of the farmland like a wall.

There was no gradual thickening of trees, no scattered copses and hedgerows growing denser until they became woods. One moment the Road was running between stone-walled fields of ragged barley under a pale grey sky. The next it ran straight into a line of trees so tall and so dark and so close together that they looked like the front rank of an army.

They were thorn trees. That was the first thing Lex noticed. Not oak or ash or pine. Thorns. Huge ones, impossibly huge, their trunks as wide as a cottage, their bark black and ridged and glistening as if wet. They had no leaves on their lower branches, only thorns: thorns as long as a man's forearm, curved like claws, black and wicked, bristling out from every limb in all directions. Higher up, where the light reached, there were leaves. Small and narrow and silver. Thousands upon thousands of them, rustling in a wind that Lex couldn't feel down on the Road, so that the whole forest seemed to whisper.

The Road went in under the trees and vanished into darkness.

"Well," said Garrick. "That's cheerful."

They stood at the edge of the forest for a long moment. Nobody moved. Ashka had climbed down off Antho's shoulder into the front of his coat and was peering out, her golden eyes very wide. Quill had flown up to the top of the nearest waystone and was sitting there with his feathers fluffed, refusing to come down.

ZONE ENTERED: THE THORNWOOD

Founders' Wild – Danger: HIGH

WARNING:

Memory drain: ACTIVE

Resolve checks every hour

Do not leave the Road.

"*Memory drain,*" read Wren. Her voice was flat. "What does that mean?"

[It means exactly what it says, I'm afraid,] said Ember. [The forest feeds on memory. It's an old enchantment, older than the Lattice. Founders' wilds were places they set aside to keep certain powers contained, and the Thornwood was one of them. It eats what you remember. Slowly. A little at a time.] A pause. [The Road protects you. Mostly. As long as you stay on it.]

Lex told them.

"And if we step off the Road?" said Antho.

[Then you'll be lost,] said Ember. [Not lost as in "can't find the way." Lost as in "can't remember that there was a way." You'll wander until the forest has eaten everything you are. And then you'll stay.]

Lex told them that too.

There was a long silence.

"Right," said Garrick. He drew Oathkeeper from its scabbard, and frost formed on the blade in the warm afternoon air. "Then we stay on the Road."

"It'll try to make us leave," said Antho quietly. He was looking into the darkness under the trees with an odd expression. "Won't it. That's how it works. It doesn't drag you off. It makes you *want* to go."

[Yes,] said Ember. [I'm afraid so.]

Wren unslung her pack. She dug around in it for a moment and came out with a coil of rope: her climbing rope, thin and strong and well-worn, the rope she'd used on every cliff and crevasse in the Greyspine.

"Then we tie ourselves together," she said. "Like on a glacier. If one of us falls, the others hold."



THE ROAD WENT ON under the trees.

It was dim in the Thornwood, but not dark. Light came down from far above, filtered through the silver leaves, grey-green and shifting, like light seen from the bottom of a river. The black trunks rose on either side of the Road like the pillars of some vast cathedral. The thorns bristled out over the Road from both sides, so low in places that they had to duck, and the paving slabs beneath their feet were the only thing in the world that was flat and straight and grey and certain.

And it was quiet. That was the worst of it. No birds. No insects. No wind, down here, though the leaves far above never stopped rustling. Only the whisper of the leaves, and the soft scuff of their boots on the stone, and the creak of Wren's rope tying them all together: Wren in front, then Lex, then Antho, then Garrick at the back.

The first hour passed. Lex felt the Resolve check go through him like a cold wind, a faint pressure at the back of his skull, like a hand trying to open a door. It didn't open. He walked on.

[You're fine,] said Ember. [Your Resolve is high. Very high, for your level. You put a lot of points into it.]

You told me to.

[I'm aware. I'm saying I'm glad you listened.]

The second hour. The check came again. He felt it press harder this time. And when it was gone, there was a small strange gap in his mind. A place where something had been and wasn't. He frowned, walking. He felt for it, the way you feel with your tongue for a tooth that's been pulled.

It was the name of Brannoc's cat.

He knew the cat. He could see it: scrawny and grey, sleeping on the warm brick ledge by the forge, staring down Quill across the workbench. He could see its face. He just couldn't remember what it was called.

He stopped walking.

"Hammer?" Wren had felt the rope go taut. She turned.

"The cat," Lex said. "Brannoc's cat. I can't remember its name."

Wren's face went still. "I can't remember my horse," she said quietly. "Da's horse. The grey mare we had when I was small. I used to ride her up to the high pastures every summer. I loved her more than anything." She swallowed. "I can see her. I just can't remember what we called her."

"It's taking the small things first," said Antho, behind them. "Things you won't miss." He laughed thinly. "It's polite, at least."

"What about you?" Lex said.

His brother was quiet for a moment.

"I don't know," Antho said. "That's the problem. How would I know what I've forgotten?"

Nobody had an answer to that.

They walked on.



IN THE THIRD HOUR, the forest began to show them things.

Lex saw it first out of the corner of his eye. A light, off among the trees, to the left of the Road. Warm and gold, like a lamp in a window. He turned his head to look and it was gone. Just black trunks and black thorns and grey-green dimness.

A little later, it came again. Closer.

And this time, when he turned, it didn't vanish.

There was a cottage among the trees.

It shouldn't have been there. It couldn't have been there. There was no clearing, no path, no break in the endless black trunks. But there it was, thirty paces off the Road, sitting in a little pool of warm late-afternoon light: a small stone cottage with a thatched roof and a woodpile against one wall and a door painted blue. Smoke rising from the chimney. A lantern burning in the kitchen window.

Lex knew it. He'd know it anywhere. It was the cottage he'd been born in. The cottage that had burned.

And the door was opening.

A man came out of it. A tall man in a long dark coat, with a pack on his back and a traveling staff in his hand. He paused on the step and turned his head and looked back into the house, and Lex saw his face. Silver at the temples. Grey eyes. A face that was hard to remember, even while you were looking at it, as if it slid off your attention like water off oiled leather.

His father.

He'd never been able to picture his father's face. Not since he was small. He'd tried, over and over, lying awake in the loft above the forge. But all

he'd ever been able to summon was a vague shape, a blur, a dark coat and a voice. And now here it was, sharp and clear, thirty paces away. Real. Close enough to touch.

His father stepped off the cottage step. He pulled up his hood. And as he did, he looked across the thirty paces of black trunks and grey-green light, and his eyes met Lex's.

"Lex," he said.

His voice was exactly the way Lex had always imagined it. Quiet and deep and a little rough. He felt his feet stop on the Road. Felt Wren's rope go taut ahead of him.

"Lex," his father said again. "I'm sorry. I have to go."

"*Why?*" The word came out of Lex like something torn. He hadn't meant to say anything. "Why did you go? Why didn't you come back? Why did you *leave us?*"

His father looked at him for a long moment. Then he smiled. It was a sad smile, and tired, and gentle.

"Because you weren't worth staying for," he said.

Lex's heart stopped.

"Any of you," his father went on, in the same quiet, gentle voice. "Not your mother. Not your brother. Not you. You were a burden. A chain around my leg. I had important things to do, and you were in the way. So I hid you, and I left you, and I never looked back." He held out his hand across the thirty paces of forest. "But you can come with me now, if you want. You can come and see what was more important than you. Just step off the Road, Lex. Just one step. And you'll understand."

Lex's foot moved.

He didn't tell it to. It just moved. Off the edge of the grey paving slab, toward the soft black earth beneath the trees. Toward the cottage. Toward his father, holding out his hand.

[LEX.]

Ember's voice. Not quiet. Not calm. Loud as a hammer on an anvil, ringing through his skull.

[That's not a memory. Look at it. LOOK at it. You never heard him say that. You were four years old and asleep in the loft. That's not your father. That's a wound wearing your father's coat.]

His foot hung in the air over the edge of the Road.

[The forest found the deepest hurt in you and dressed it up in a face and sent it out to fetch you. That's all. It's a lure. It's bait on a hook. It doesn't know what he said. It doesn't know anything about him at all. It only knows what you're afraid he said.]

The man by the cottage was still holding out his hand. Still smiling his sad, tired, gentle smile.

But now that Lex looked, really looked, there was something wrong with it. The smile didn't reach the eyes. The eyes were too still. Too flat. Like the eyes of a statue. And the face, the face he'd been so sure of, was *shifting*, very slightly, at the edges, like a reflection in disturbed water. Becoming someone else. Becoming no one.

[He sang to you,] Ember said, very quietly now. [When you were small and sick. Off-key. Over and over. Until you fell asleep. Remember? I gave you that memory. In the Frostvault. That one is real.]

Lex put his foot back down on the Road.

The cottage flickered. The man by the door flickered. The warm gold light dimmed, and went grey, and was gone, and there was nothing among the black trees but black trees.

He stood on the Road, shaking.

"Lex?" Wren's voice. She'd come back along the rope and grabbed his arm. Her face was white. "Lex, you were *leaving*. You were stepping off. I said your name four times and you didn't hear me."

"I'm all right," he said. His voice came out hoarse. "I'm all right now. It showed me something. I nearly—" He stopped. "I'm all right."

"Your hands are shaking."

"I know."

She didn't let go of his arm. She stood there on the Road beside him, holding on, until the shaking stopped.

RESOLVE CHECK – PASSED (assisted)
Memory drain: resisted

Thank you, Lex thought.

[You're welcome,] said Ember. And then, more quietly, in a voice that sounded almost shaken itself: *[I didn't like that. I didn't like it at all. Seeing him like that. Wearing that face.]*

You've never seen him.

There was a long silence.

[No,] said Ember at last. *[No. I haven't. Have I.]*



IT CAME FOR ALL of them, in the end.

It came for Wren in the fourth hour. Lex felt the rope go suddenly slack ahead of him and looked up and saw her standing at the edge of the Road with her face turned toward the trees, her lips parted. And there among the black trunks was a man in trapper's furs, broad and red-bearded and laughing, with a brace of hares over one shoulder and a bow in his hand, calling her name. *Wren! Wrennie! Come on, girl, the lines won't check themselves!*

She'd taken two steps toward him before Lex reached her. He grabbed her around the waist and hauled her back onto the grey stone and held her there while she fought him, sobbing, clawing at his arms, screaming *Da, Da, Da*, until the man among the trees flickered and went grey and was gone. And then she stopped fighting, and turned in his arms, and pressed her face into his chest and shook.

He didn't say anything. He just held her.

It came for Garrick in the fifth hour. A woman in a blue dress, standing in a garden among roses, under a sky that was the wrong color for the Thornwood. Garrick didn't move. He stood at the back of the rope line with Oathkeeper in his hand and looked at her, at his wife, for a long, long time, and tears ran down his scarred face into his grey stubble. But he didn't step off the Road.

"I wasn't there," he said to her quietly. "When it mattered. I was drunk in Saltreach." He swallowed. "I'm sorry, Mara. I'm so sorry. But I'm here now. I'm here *now*, and I'm not leaving these children." He raised the sword, and frost bloomed along the blade, and the runes flared gold. "I'm standing on the steps."

The woman in the garden smiled at him. And faded.

And it came for Antho.



IT CAME LAST, AND it came hardest.

They were deep in the forest by then. Five hours, six. It was hard to tell. The light had gone from grey-green to a dim, murky, underwater brown. The trees had grown even larger, so vast now that their trunks were like walls on either side of the Road, and the thorns bristled out over the paving slabs so thick that they walked bent double, ducking and weaving, the rope catching and snagging. Everyone was exhausted. Everyone had lost something. Lex had lost the name of Brannoc's cat, and the color of the chapel door at Ashbourne, and the words to a hymn Brannoc used to hum, and something else, something important, that he couldn't put his finger on, a gap in his mind like a missing tooth.

And from somewhere off among the trees, faint and sweet and terrible, someone began to sing.

Little light, little light, burning low...

Lex felt Antho stop behind him.

He turned. His brother was standing on the Road with his face turned toward the dark between the trees, and his eyes were wide, and his lips were moving.

There was a woman among the thorns.

She was small and freckled, with her hair tied back in a strip of blue cloth and her sleeves rolled to the elbow and a smudge of flour on her cheek. She was standing in a doorway. Not a cottage door. Just a doorway, standing alone among the black trees, a frame of grey stone with nothing on either side of it and only darkness inside. And she was singing. Singing into the dark behind her, the way she'd sung on the worst night of their lives. And then she turned her head, and looked at Antho over her shoulder, and smiled.

"Antho," she said. "Sweetheart. Come here. I've been waiting so long."

Lex felt it hit his brother through the Bloodbond like a blow to the chest.

CLARITY: 77 → 60 ▼▼

60 → 44 ▼▼

WARNING

 — AWAKE

"Mam," Antho whispered.

"Come and keep the door with me," the woman in the doorway said. "You were always supposed to. You know that. It should have been you, sweetheart. Not me. You were the one who opened it." She held out her hand. "Come and close it with me. Come into the dark. It's so quiet here. You'll never have to hear it again."

[Yes ... yes ... go ... go to her ... it's quiet there ... so quiet ... go ...]

Lex heard it. Through the Bloodbond. The wet, hungry whisper, louder than it had been since the Hollowmaw. *Eager.*

Antho took a step toward the edge of the Road.

"Antho!"

His brother didn't hear him. Antho's eyes had gone black at the edges, the black creeping in like ink across wet paper, and the shadows were rising off him, uncontrolled, curling up off his hands and shoulders and pooling at his feet. He took another step. The rope between them went taut.

"Antho, it's not her! It's the forest! It's not real!"

"She's right," Antho said. His voice was very calm. Terribly calm. "It should have been me. I opened it. I should have been the one to close it." Another step. The rope creaked. "She's been waiting so long, Lex. All alone in the dark. Keeping the door. It's my turn."

CLARITY: 44 → 31 ▼▼

31 → 22 ▼

"Garrick!"

The old knight was already moving. He came up the rope line at a stumbling run, ducking under the thorns, and threw both his arms around Antho from behind, the way he'd grabbed the Gloamed miller's knee. He dug his heels into the paving slabs and *held*.

Antho didn't fight him. He just kept walking. Slowly. Inexorably. Dragging the old knight with him, step by step, toward the edge of the

Road, as if Garrick weighed nothing at all. The shadows were pouring off him now. They wrapped around Garrick's arms and legs. Garrick grunted with pain but didn't let go.

"*Hammer, the rope!*" Wren had braced herself against a thorn trunk at the front of the line, the rope wrapped around her waist and her heels dug in. "*I can't hold him! He's too strong!*"

CLARITY: 22 → 16 ▼

 ACTING THROUGH HOST

Lex let go of the rope.

He went to his brother. He went around Garrick and stood in front of Antho, between him and the edge of the Road, between him and the woman in the doorway. He put both his hands flat on his brother's chest. And he looked into his brother's eyes, which were almost entirely black now, only a thin ring of grey left at the very center.

"Antho," he said. "Look at me."

Antho looked at him. Through him. Past him, at the doorway.

"*She said look after your brother,*" said Lex. "Remember? That's what she said. Not *come with me*. Not *it should have been you*. She said *look after your brother, Antho, I'll keep the door*." He pressed his hands harder against his brother's chest. "She chose. She chose to go in. She chose to keep the door so you could look after me. And you *haven't*. Not yet. You've been hiding in a cave for eight years. You owe her. You owe her a brother who's looked after. So you don't get to walk into the dark. Not yet. Not until you've done what she asked."

The thin ring of grey in Antho's eyes flickered.

"I'm right here," said Lex. "I'm right in front of you. Look after me."

He pushed the fire into him.

Not a strike. Not a blast. The slow warm flow he'd used on Garrick's leg, on the sleepers in the chapel. The hearth on a winter night. He poured it through his palms into his brother's chest, through the Bloodbond, down into that cold, still, deep pool, and he felt it meet the dark there, and the dark hiss.

CLARITY: 16 → 24 ▲

"*Antho*," sang the woman in the doorway. "*Sweetheart. Come here.*"

And Antho looked at her. Really looked. Past Lex's shoulder, at the small freckled woman in the stone doorway among the thorns.

"No," he said. His voice cracked. "No. You're not her. She'd never say that. She'd never say it should have been me." The grey was spreading back into his eyes, pushing out the black. "She sang into the dark so I wouldn't have to. She'd never ask me to come in." His voice rose. "*You're not her!*"

The woman in the doorway stopped singing.

For one long moment, she stood there among the thorns, perfectly still. Her face was Seren's face, freckled and fierce and kind. And then it wasn't. It went grey. It went flat. It went *nothing*, like a mask with no one behind it. And the doorway behind her went dark, and darker, and then it simply wasn't there anymore, and neither was she.

The shadows fell off Antho like water.

He sagged in Garrick's arms. His knees gave out. Lex caught him, and the three of them went down together onto the grey paving slabs of the Road, a tangle of arms and legs and rope, and lay there, breathing hard.

CLARITY: 24 → 41 ▲

41 → 58 ▲

■ – suppressed

Nobody said anything for a long time.

"Well," said Garrick at last, from somewhere underneath Antho's legs. "That was unpleasant."

Antho started to laugh. It was a shaky, broken, hysterical sort of laugh, and it went on a little too long, and then it turned into something else, and he pressed his face into Lex's shoulder for the second time in a week.

Lex just held on.



THE HEART OF THE Thornwood was a clearing.

They came to it an hour later, or what felt like an hour. The Road simply ran out from under the thorns into open air, and there was sky above them for the first time in seven hours: a pale grey evening sky, with the first stars showing. The clearing was round and perhaps a hundred paces across, carpeted in soft grey moss. And in the middle of it was a tree.

It was a thorn tree, like all the others, but it was the largest Lex had ever seen or ever imagined. Its trunk was as wide as the whole village green at Ashbourne. Its branches spread out over the clearing like the vaults of a cathedral ceiling, black and thorned and immense, and from them hung silver leaves, millions of them, whispering, whispering, whispering. Its roots coiled out across the moss like the arms of some vast sleeping creature, and they were black. And in places, Lex saw, they were *grey*.

The grey of the hedgerows at Ashbourne. The grey of the bear in the mountains. The grey of the miller's skin.

And sitting among the roots, at the foot of the great tree, was a woman made of thorns.

She was tall. Very tall, taller than Garrick, and thin as a winter sapling. Her body was woven of black thorned branches, twisted and braided together like wickerwork, and silver leaves grew from her shoulders and her head like hair. Her face was carved from the same black bark as the tree, long and narrow and ancient, with eyes like two drops of sap catching the light. She was sitting with her long thorned arms wrapped around her knees, and she was shivering.

As they came out into the clearing, she lifted her head.

THE THORN MOTHER

Founders' Guardian – Level ???

Condition: BLIGHTED

SHRINE TRIAL: THE SECOND SONG

"Ah," said the Thorn Mother. Her voice was the whisper of the leaves, ten million of them, speaking all at once. "More of you. More bright ones. More full ones. Full of remembering."

She unfolded herself from among the roots. She was even taller standing. Her thorned feet whispered over the moss as she came toward them.

"I am *so hungry*," she said.

Garrick raised Oathkeeper. Frost bloomed along the blade. Wren knocked an arrow. Antho's shadows stirred.

"Wait," said Lex.

He was looking at the roots. At the grey patches spreading through them, slowly, like rot through a timber. He was looking at the Thorn Mother's face. At the way she was shivering. At the way the silver leaves on her head were curling at the edges, dry and brown.

[She's sick,] said Ember quietly. *[Look at her with True Sight.]*

He looked. The gold rose behind his eyes.

THE THORN MOTHER
Founders' Guardian
Bound to: the Thornwood (900 yrs)
Condition: BLIGHTED
Gloam infection: roots (34%)
Spreading: +1% per week
Source: breach (minor), beneath
Memory drain: ESCALATED
(compensatory – feeding to survive infection)

"She's not hungry," Lex said slowly. "She's *dying*. The Gloam got into her roots. There's a breach under the forest. And she's been eating more and more memories to stay alive." He looked up at the towering thorned figure. "That's why the forest's been showing us things. That's why it's been so hard. She's starving."

The Thorn Mother stopped.

Her sap-drop eyes fixed on him. For a long moment, she didn't move. The leaves whispered.

"You can *see* it," she said at last. "The rot. You can see it in me." Her voice dropped to a rustle. "None of the others could see it. The ones who came before. They only saw a monster in the trees that took their remembering."

"I can see it."

"Can you *burn* it?"

Lex looked at the grey patches in the roots. They were everywhere. Spreading through the whole vast root system of the great tree, down into the earth, toward something below. Something cold. He could feel it now: the breach, deep beneath the clearing, like a splinter under a fingernail.

"Not all at once," he said. "If I burn it all at once, I'll burn the tree. And the forest."

[He's right,] said Ember. [Fire alone would kill her. You'd need to draw the Gloam out first. Pull it away from the living wood. Then burn it.]

"Pull it away," Lex repeated. He turned and looked at his brother.

Antho was staring at the grey roots. His face was very pale. His hands were shaking.

"You want me to—" he started.

"The Gloam's afraid of you," said Lex. "I saw it at the village. It shrank away from your shadows. It knows what you've got in you. It *recognizes* it." He held his brother's gaze. "You don't have to fight it. Just call it. Pull it out of the roots. Into the open. And I'll burn it."

Antho didn't say anything for a long moment.

"If I call it," he said quietly, "it might come *into* me. The thing inside me might want it. Might eat it. Might get stronger."

"I'll be right next to you."

"Lex, if my Clarity drops again—"

"Then I'll catch you again." Lex looked at him steadily. "That's what I'm for."



IT TOOK THEM ALL night.

Wren found the worst of the rot. She went over the great roots on her hands and knees like a hound on a scent, running her fingers over the black bark, following the grey veins of infection from root to root to root, and wherever the grey was thickest, she marked it with a strip of red cloth from her pack. *Here. And here. And here. It's coming from under the big root on the east side. That's where it started. Follow the trail back and that's where it goes.*

Garrick stood guard. Things came out of the forest in the night, drawn by the noise, by the light, by the smell of the Gloam being disturbed: briar-hounds, huge and lean and made of woven black thorns, their eyes glowing white. Garrick met them at the edge of the clearing with Oathkeeper blazing with frost, and every one he struck shattered into splinters and didn't rise again. *Bind*, Lex thought, watching him. *Gloam*

struck by this blade cannot re-form. The old knight fought all night without complaining, his breath smoking in the cold air.

And Antho called the Gloam.

He knelt among the roots at the place Wren marked, with his scarred hands flat on the black bark, and closed his eyes, and *called*. Lex knelt beside him, close enough that their shoulders touched. He felt it through the Bloodbond: the cold, deep pool of his brother's power stirring, opening, reaching down into the roots like a hand reaching into dark water. Searching. Finding. And then *pulling*.

The Gloam came out of the roots like poison out of a wound.

It rose out of the black bark in thin, oily threads, writhing, resisting, clinging to the wood. Antho's jaw clenched. Sweat stood out on his forehead despite the cold. The threads came out farther. Farther. And as they came, the grey in the bark around them faded back to black.

CLARITY: 64 → 57 ▼ (Hollow use)
57 → 51 ▼

And Lex burned them.

Not with an Ember Strike. That would have burned the tree too. He used Heat Shaping, the finest, most careful Heat Shaping he'd ever done: drawing heat into a narrow white thread of fire no thicker than a needle and touching it to each strand of Gloam the instant it came free of the wood. The Gloam hissed and shriveled and burned away into nothing, and the bark beneath it stayed black and alive and whole.

Root after root. Thread after thread. Hour after hour.

CLARITY: 51 → 46 ▼
46 → 52 ▲ (anchor)
52 → 47 ▼

Antho's Clarity went up and down like a fever chart. Twice, Lex felt the thing in him stir, eager, reaching for the Gloam as it came out of the roots, wanting to *taste* it. Both times Lex put his hand on his brother's back and pushed warmth into him, and both times the thing subsided, sullen, back down into the dark.

And toward dawn, when the sky over the clearing was going from black to grey and the first birds Lex had heard in the Thornwood began to sing somewhere far off among the trees, they reached the source.

It was under the great root on the east side, where Wren had said it would be. A crack in the earth. Small, no wider than a finger, but black, utterly black, and cold enough to frost the moss around it. A breach. A tiny one. The same as the one in the Hollowmaw, only younger.

Antho looked at it for a long time.

"I can't close it," he said quietly. "I don't know how."

"Neither do I." Lex looked at it. Then he reached into his belt and took out one of the ward-nails, the last of the twelve he'd forged in the Hollowmaw, the spare. "But I can nail it shut."

He drove the nail into the earth beside the crack with one blow of Anvil-song. *Bind*. The glyph flared gold. The crack shuddered, and narrowed, and the cold coming off it dimmed to a faint chill.

SHRINE TRIAL COMPLETE

The Thorn Mother's blight: PURGED

Breach (minor): CONTAINED (78%)

+XP (shared)



THE THORN MOTHER STOOD in the middle of her clearing in the dawn, and the silver leaves on her head were no longer curled and brown. They were bright, and shining, and whispering in the morning wind. She stood straighter. Her thorned limbs had stopped shivering. And her sap-drop eyes, when she turned them on the four of them, were very bright.

"You have healed me," she said. "In nine hundred years, no one has ever healed me." She came toward them across the moss. "I am still bound. I still feed. But I need not feed so *much*. The forest will be quieter now." She paused. "I am sorry for what I took from you. I was so hungry."

"Can you give it back?" said Wren. Her voice was rough. "What you took?"

The Thorn Mother looked at her.

"Yes," she said. "Some of it. I can give back what I have not yet digested. That is most of it, from you." She tilted her long head. "Hold out your hands."

They held out their hands.

And the Thorn Mother sang.

It wasn't like the Oracle's song. The Oracle had sung like stone: deep and slow and immense. The Thorn Mother sang like *leaves*. Ten million voices whispering at once. The sound of a forest in the wind, of sap rising in spring, of buds breaking open, of roots reaching down into the dark earth and finding water. The sound of things growing. The sound of things *remembering*.

And as she sang, the memories came back.

Lex felt them come back into him like warm water filling a cold basin. Small things. The name of Brannoc's cat. *Slag*. Of course. *Slag*. The color of the chapel door at Ashbourne. Green, faded green, with a brass handle shaped like a lantern. The words of Brannoc's hymn. *Lantern-bearer, light the way*. All the small, ordinary, precious things the forest had taken.

And then something else.

Something he hadn't lost to the forest. Something he'd lost long before. Something the Thorn Mother had found, deep in the roots of him, and was giving back.

He was four years old. He was standing in the road outside the cottage in the grey light of a rainy morning, and there was a horseshoe nail in his hand. He'd just found it in the mud. And a man was crouching in front of him. A tall man in a dark coat, with a pack on his back, and silver at his temples, and grey eyes. And the man was looking at the nail.

What have you got there, little one?

Mine, Lex heard himself say, in a tiny four-year-old voice. He clutched the nail to his chest. *Mine. I'm keeping it.*

And the man laughed. A real laugh, warm and surprised, his whole face creasing up. And he reached out and folded Lex's small fingers closed over the nail, gently, with his own long hand.

Keep it, then, he said. *Keep it, little smith. Never let anyone take it from you.* He smiled. *Mind the quench.*

And then he stood up, and pulled up his hood, and walked away into the mist.

Lex stood in the clearing at the heart of the Thornwood with tears running down his face.

Little smith.

[Oh,] said Ember, very softly, in his head.

Lex couldn't speak.

[I remember that,] said Ember. Its voice was shaking. *[I remember that. The rain. The nail. I remember saying—]* It stopped. *[Lex. I call you Smith. I've called you Smith from the first moment I woke up. I didn't know why. I thought it was just because of the hammer. But it wasn't. Was it.]*

MEMORY PARTITION 3 ... UNLOCKED

[Little smith,] Ember whispered. *[That's what I called you. That's what he called you.]* A long silence. *[Lex, I think I know who made me.]*

Lex stood in the dawn light with his hand over the place on his coat where, beneath it, in his trouser pocket, there was no nail anymore, because he'd folded it into the heart of a hammer.

So do I, he thought.

Neither of them said anything else.



"**THE SONG,**" **SAID THE** Thorn Mother, when she'd finished singing, when the clearing was quiet again except for the birds. "You came for the song. Hold up the stone."

Antho held up the lodestone on its cord. It was still glowing faintly grey from the Oracle's song, pulsing slowly like a heartbeat.

The Thorn Mother bent down, very close, until her long bark face was only inches from the little grey stone. And she breathed on it. A long, slow breath that smelled of green sap and new leaves and rain on moss.

The lodestone flared. A second light woke inside it, green as spring, twining around the grey like ivy around a stone.

LODESTONE OF RETURN

Songs held: 2 / 3

- ◆ The Song of Stone
- ◆ The Song of Leaves

MAIN QUEST UPDATED: The Lost Father

- ◆ The Lithic Oracle DONE
- ◆ The heart of the Thornwood .. DONE
- ◇ The Barrow Throne

+XP (shared)

LEVEL UP! Lex – Level 18

LEVEL UP! Lex – Level 19

LEVEL UP! Anthoren – Level 33

LEVEL UP! Wren Ashdown – Level 24

And beneath it, a second panel, grey-edged and plain, that only Wren could see.

Lex saw her see it. Saw her face go still, and then very carefully blank, the way a person's face goes blank when they've been expecting a blow for a long time and it has finally landed.

"Wren?" he said.

She didn't answer. She was looking at something only she could see.

"Wren, what is it?"

"Twenty-four," she said quietly.

She didn't need to say anything else. He knew. He'd known it was coming. They all had.

WREN ASHDOWN – Level 24

LEVEL CAP REACHED

Class: Tracker (Common)

Further experience will not be recorded.

He didn't see it. He didn't need to.

Wren stood in the dawn light in the clearing at the heart of the Thornwood, with her bow in her hand and her rope still coiled around her waist and her fox-red braid over her shoulder, and she didn't cry. She didn't

say anything at all. She just stood there and looked at the panel only she could see, and then she closed it, deliberately, with a little flick of her eyes, and looked up at the sky.

"Well," she said. "That's that, then."

Lex felt the fire in his chest flare. Hot and hard and furious. The way it had flared in Brannoc's forge, watching the old smith stare at his hands. *Nineteen years.* He thought of her on the mountain, climbing like water flowing uphill. He thought of her on the Oracle's steps, answering truly. He thought of her at the front of the rope line in the Thornwood, her heels dug in, holding all of them on the Road.

And the Lattice had looked at her and said: *This far. No further.*

"Wren—" he started.

"Don't." She didn't look at him. "Don't, Hammer. Not now. I knew it was coming. I've known my whole life." Her voice was very steady. "I got further than I thought I would. Further than Da. That's something." She turned away. "I'm going to see if there's water in this place. I'm thirsty."

She walked off across the clearing toward the edge of the trees.

Lex watched her go. His hands were clenched into fists. The heat was coming off him in waves; the moss around his boots had begun to smoke.

[*Lex,*] said Ember quietly.

It isn't fair.

[*No. It isn't.*]

She's worth ten of most people. A hundred. And the Lattice just—just stops her. Because some Warden three hundred years ago decided Trackers didn't need to climb any higher.

[*Yes.*]

There has to be a way to change it.

Ember was quiet for a long moment.

[*There is,*] it said at last. [*Root can change it. Root is where the rules are written. You have Root. You have a Prerogative called Sanction, which you can't use yet. And there's another, deeper one.*] A pause. [*It's called Unbind. It breaks a Ceiling. I can see it in the locked part of your panel. You're not strong enough to use it. Not yet. Not for a long time, maybe.*] Another pause. [*But it's there.*]

Lex stared after Wren, at her slim straight back disappearing between the black trunks at the edge of the clearing.

Then I'll get strong enough, he thought.

He didn't say it aloud. He didn't need to. Ember had heard.



WHEN WREN CAME BACK, a little later, with her face washed and her waterskin full and her eyes only slightly red, the Thorn Mother was waiting for them all in the middle of the clearing.

"You have given me my life back," she said, in her voice of ten million leaves. "I have given you a song, and your remembering. It is not enough." She tilted her long bark head. "So I will give you one thing more. A direction."

She raised one long thorned arm and pointed. Not back along the Road, and not ahead of it. East. Into the forest. Toward a place where, Lex now saw, the black trunks seemed to part a little, and there was a faint path running between them, barely visible, carpeted in silver fallen leaves.

"There is a keeper of leaves in my forest," said the Thorn Mother. "A girl of the tower. She came here two winters ago, running. Running from her own kind. I did not eat her, because she reads the old script, and she spoke to me in it, and no one has spoken to me in the old script in four hundred years." Her sap-drop eyes glittered. "She lives in the old house of leaves, where the Founders kept their books. She knows things about the net. About your blood. About the one you seek." She paused. "You should speak with her. She is very lonely. And I think she is very frightened."

"A girl of the tower," said Garrick slowly. "You mean a Warden?"

"I mean," said the Thorn Mother, "a girl who ran away from the Wardens. Who found something in their books that they did not want found." Her leaves whispered. "Follow the silver path. It will not eat you. I promise."



THEY FOLLOWED THE SILVER path.

It wound away east through the Thornwood, between the black trunks, under the bristling thorns, and the forest along it was different now. Quieter. Gentler. The light coming down through the silver leaves

was gold instead of grey-green, and there were birds singing, and once, a deer that stood in the path and looked at them with soft dark eyes before bounding away.

Lex walked beside Wren. Neither of them said anything for a long time.

"Lex," she said at last, very quietly.

He looked at her. She almost never called him Lex.

"In there," Wren said. "In the forest. Before the Thorn Mother. When it was eating things." She was looking straight ahead, not at him. "For about a minute, I couldn't remember your name."

He didn't say anything.

"I could see your face," she went on. "I knew who you were. I knew you were *important*. But I couldn't remember your name. And I didn't know why it mattered so much. I just knew that it did." Her voice was very steady. "It was the worst minute of my life. Worse than finding Da on the north face. Worse than the Ceiling." She stopped walking. "I don't know what that means. I don't know what to *do* with that."

Lex stopped too.

They stood together on the silver path, in the gold light, with the birds singing.

"I don't know either," he said.

She turned and looked at him. Her green eyes were very bright.

He didn't know which of them moved first. Maybe neither. Maybe both. But she was closer suddenly, much closer, and he could see every freckle on her face, and her breath was warm on his chin, and her hand had come up and was resting very lightly on his chest, over his heart, where the fire was, and he thought she must be able to feel it pounding—

"*Ahem*," said Garrick, from somewhere behind them.

They sprang apart.

"Sorry," said the old knight. He did not look sorry in the least. "Didn't mean to interrupt. But there's a house up ahead. Made of leaves." He pointed past them, up the path. "And there's a young woman in spectacles standing in the door of it. Pointing a crossbow at us." He paused. "She looks terrified. I thought you'd want to know."

Behind him, Antho had his hand over his mouth. His shoulders were shaking. Ashka, on his shoulder, was making a small chirping noise that sounded suspiciously like laughter.

Wren's face had gone the color of her hair.

"I'm going to go see about the crossbow," she said, and stalked off up the path.

Lex stood alone on the silver path for a moment, his face burning.

[Well,] said Ember, sounding very amused. *[That was nearly interesting.]*

Shut up.

[I didn't say anything.]

You were going to.

[I was going to say,] said Ember, with great dignity, *[that your father would have liked her. I think. That's all.]* A pause. *[Though I'm not entirely sure how I know that either.]*

Lex shook his head, and shouldered Anvilson, and followed Wren up the path toward the house of leaves.

CHAPTER 13

THE LEAFBOUND ARCHIVE



THE HOUSE WAS MADE of a living tree.

That was the first thing Lex understood as he came up the silver path behind Wren. It wasn't a house built *in* a tree, or *of* wood. It was a tree, one of the great black thorns of the forest, that had been persuaded long ago to grow into the shape of a house. Its trunk had split near the ground into a dozen great limbs that curved up and out and back together again, like the ribs of a basket, and between the limbs, smaller branches had been woven into walls, and the walls had been coaxed to leaf. Silver leaves, thick and glossy, overlapping like shingles. There were windows where the branches parted, round ones, with something thin and clear stretched across them like the inside of an eggshell. There was a door, an arch of living wood twined with ivy, with a little round step of stone in front of it.

And in the door, exactly as Garrick had said, there was a young woman with a crossbow.

She was thin, and not very tall, with a pale narrow face and a long nose and a great untidy mass of dark brown hair that had been pinned up at some point and was now mostly coming down. She wore the remains of a long grey robe, the kind of robe Lex had seen on the Wardens at Thistledown, but with the silver lattice-pin torn off the breast and the hem cut short and patched with leather. She had spectacles on: little round ones, with wire rims, perched on the end of her long nose. And behind the spectacles, her eyes were enormous and dark and absolutely terrified.

The crossbow was pointed at Wren's chest. It was shaking so badly that Lex wasn't sure it would hit anything if she fired it.

"Stay where you are," said the young woman. Her voice was high and thin and very precise, like a schoolteacher's. "I mean it. I know how to use this."

"No you don't," said Wren.

"I—I do. I've read the manual."

"You've got the bolt in upside down."

The young woman looked down at the crossbow. Her face went from white to red. She looked back up.

"It's—it's a *deterrent*," she said.

Wren held up her empty hands. "We're not here to hurt you. The Thorn Mother sent us. She said you read the old script."

The young woman's eyes flicked past Wren. To Garrick, with his grey hair and his scarred face and the frost-edged sword at his hip. To Lex, with the hammer on his shoulder. To Antho—

And her whole face changed.

Lex saw it happen. Saw recognition go through her like a lightning strike. Her mouth fell open. The crossbow jerked up, away from Wren, and swung toward his brother.

"*You*," she breathed. "You're—you're *him*. The Ashbourne warlock. Anthoren Harrow. I've seen your file. I've *read your file*. Eleven Wardens. Four retrieval teams. *Corrupted unique, breach-linked, unstable*—"

"Hello," said Antho mildly.

"*Stay back!*"

Ashka, on Antho's shoulder, sneezed.

It was a small sneeze, but she was a storm-drake, and a small sneeze from a storm-drake came out as a sharp crackling burst of blue sparks, and one of the sparks drifted across the gap between them on the evening air and landed on the end of the young woman's long nose.

She yelped. She dropped the crossbow. It hit the stone step and went off with a *thwack*, and the bolt, upside down, shot sideways into the leafy wall of the house and stuck there quivering, and the young woman stumbled backward over her own robe and sat down hard in the doorway with her spectacles askew.

There was a long silence.

"Well," said Garrick. "That's one way to do it."



HER NAME WAS SERAPHINE Ilvane, and she had been, until two winters ago, a junior archivist in the Spire of the Wardens of the Lattice.

She told them this sitting at a long table in the main room of the leaf-house, with a cup of something hot clutched in both hands and a fresh red mark on the end of her nose where Ashka's spark had landed. She still didn't let Antho out of her sight. Every time he moved, her eyes flicked to him. But she'd stopped shaking, mostly, and she'd let them in, and made them all something to drink from a pot of dried leaves that smelled of mint and honey, and now she was talking very fast, as if she hadn't had anyone to talk to in a long time and was afraid they'd leave before she'd said everything.

The room was extraordinary. It was round, with a high domed ceiling where the living branches met and twined together overhead. The walls were shelves: shelves grown out of the living wood itself, curving, uneven, following the grain of the branches. And every shelf was full of books.

Old books. Ancient books. Books bound in leather gone black with age and books bound in wood and books that were just bundles of parchment tied with cord. Scrolls in cases of carved bone. Tablets of grey stone with Wellschrift cut into them. Hundreds of them, thousands, crowding every shelf from floor to ceiling, spilling onto the floor in stacks, piled on the table among cups and candle-stubs and inkpots and sheets of paper covered in tiny, cramped, neat handwriting.

"The Leafbound Archive," said Seraphine, gesturing around her with her cup. "One of the original Founders' libraries. There were seven, once. This is the only one left. The others were destroyed, or lost, or—" Her mouth tightened. "Or taken into the Spire's sealed vaults, where nobody's allowed to read them."

"And you found it," said Lex.

"I was *looking* for it. I'd read about it. In a footnote. In a commentary on a commentary on a translation of a Founders' codex that nobody had opened in a hundred and fifty years." Seraphine pushed her spectacles up

her nose. "Nobody reads footnotes. That's the great secret of archives. Everything important is in the footnotes."

[I like her,] said Ember.

"I was a Lattice Scribe," Seraphine went on. "That's my class. Rare grade. It means I can read the Lattice a little more deeply than most people. Not as deeply as a senior Warden. But I can read *records*. Old Lattice records, the kind the Spire keeps in its archives. Kindling ledgers, sanction rolls, incident reports." She looked down into her cup. "That's what I did for six years. Read old records and copied them and filed them. It was very boring. I loved it."

"Then why did you run?" said Garrick.

Seraphine was quiet for a moment.

"Because I read something I wasn't supposed to read," she said.



"**THE KINDLING LEDGERS,**" SHE said. "Every Kindling ever held, at every Stone in Aldermere, is recorded in the Lattice. Who was Kindled. Where. When. What class they received. What grade." She turned her cup around in her hands. "The Spire keeps copies. Hundreds of years of them. I was assigned to cross-reference the ledgers from the last century, for a census. Very boring work. Nobody else wanted it."

"And?" said Wren.

"And the numbers were wrong." Seraphine looked up. Behind her spectacles, her dark eyes were very bright. "I don't mean a few errors. I mean *systematically* wrong. If you take every Kindling in Caldor in the last hundred years and sort them by family, noble against common, the distribution of grades is impossible. Commoners get Common and Uncommon classes. Nobles get Rare and Epic. Not mostly. *Always*. Ninety-eight percent of Rare-grade classes in the last century went to children of noble houses or Warden families." She set down her cup. "That's not blood. Blood doesn't work like that. Talent doesn't work like that. That's someone *choosing*."

The room was very quiet.

"The Wardens rig it," said Garrick slowly.

"The Wardens rig it. There's a flag in the Lattice. A permission. Senior Wardens can set it on a child before their Kindling. It doesn't guarantee a good class, but it *weights* it, like loaded dice." Seraphine's mouth twisted. "Noble houses pay for the flag. It's very expensive. It's been going on for three hundred years."

Lex thought of the Ashbourne green. Of the morning of his own Kindling, his heart pounding, half the village watching. Of Pell, fifteen, asking hopefully *do you think I'll get something good?*

Of Wren, standing in the clearing at the heart of the Thornwood, looking at a panel only she could see.

He felt the heat in his chest go up like a forge with the bellows going.

"Three hundred years," Wren said. Her voice was very flat. "Every kid in every village in Caldor. For three hundred years."

"Yes."

"And nobody ever noticed?"

"People noticed." Seraphine looked at her. "People always notice. They say *born to the Ceiling*. They say *some folk are dreamers and some are doers*. They say *the Lattice knows best*." She shrugged her thin shoulders. "They just didn't have the ledgers."

"And you did," said Lex.

"And I did." Seraphine took off her spectacles and rubbed her eyes. "I didn't know what to do. I was twenty-seven. I'd spent my whole life in the Spire. I believed in it. I believed the Lattice was the Lady's gift and the Wardens were its stewards and everything was ordered and fair." She put her spectacles back on. "So I did the stupid thing. I wrote a report. I took it to my supervisor."

"What happened?" said Antho.

It was the first thing he'd said since they sat down. Seraphine's eyes jumped to him. For a moment she looked frightened again. Then something else came into her face. Something almost defiant.

"He thanked me," she said. "He said it was very thorough work. He said he'd pass it up to the High Warden personally. And that night, someone came to my room in the Spire with a knife." She lifted her chin. "I wasn't there. I'd gone to the archives to check a reference. I always go to the

archives at night; it's quieter. When I came back, my door had been forced and my bed had been cut to ribbons."

"*Lady*," breathed Wren.

"I took what I could carry and ran. Some codices. My notes. A copy of the ledgers." Seraphine gestured at the stacks of paper on the table. "And I came looking for the one place in Aldermere where I thought nobody would ever follow me." She looked around at the shelves of living wood, the silver leaves rustling at the round windows. "It took me three months to find it. The Thorn Mother nearly ate me. And then I spoke to her in Wellsript, and she stopped." Seraphine smiled faintly. "She was so surprised. Nobody had spoken to her in the old script in four hundred years. We've been friends ever since. Sort of. In the way that one can be friends with a nine-hundred-year-old memory-eating tree."



"**YOU CAME FOR SOMETHING,**" Seraphine said later, when Garrick had gone outside to see to the perimeter and Wren had gone with him, and only Lex and Antho remained at the long table with her. "The Thorn Mother wouldn't have sent you otherwise. She doesn't send people to me. She keeps me secret." She looked between the two of them. "Two of you. Brothers. I can see it. You have the same jaw." Her eyes narrowed. "And you're both on the Spire's wanted rolls. Five hundred crowns each. I heard the notice read in Thornhollow market a month ago, when I went out for flour." She paused. "*Lex and Anthoren Harrow. Wildcasters.* What are you?"

Lex looked at Antho. Antho looked back. Then, slowly, without a word, Antho drew the lodestone out of his collar on its old black cord, and laid it on the table between them.

It was glowing. Faintly. Grey and green, twined together, pulsing slowly like a heartbeat.

Seraphine went absolutely still.

She stared at the stone. She leaned closer to it, very slowly, the way you'd lean toward a sleeping animal. Her spectacles slid down her nose and she didn't push them back. Her lips moved. She was reading, Lex realized. Reading the tiny spiral of Wellsript that covered the stone, which he

could only see with True Sight, and which she apparently could see without it.

"*Lodestone of Return*," she whispered. "*Bound to—*" She stopped. Her face went white. "*Bound to Arion Vey.*"

She looked up at them.

"Arion Vey," she said. "Warden-Architect Arion Vey. He's in the rolls. He's one of the last entries before the Vhessa incident. And then he just—stops. No death record. No discharge. Nothing. As if he walked off the edge of the world." Her eyes went from Lex to Antho and back. "*Vey*. You're not Harrows. You're *Veys*."

"Apparently," said Antho.

"Do you know what that *means*?"

"Not really," said Lex. "We were hoping you might."

Seraphine stared at them for a long moment. Then she pushed her chair back from the table, got up, and walked to one of the shelves. She ran her finger along the spines of the books there, muttering under her breath, then pulled one out: an enormous book, bound in black leather gone grey with age, so heavy she had to carry it in both arms. She brought it back to the table and set it down with a thump that made the cups jump.

She opened it.

The pages were vellum, thick and yellowed and covered in Wellschrift. And in the middle of the first page, drawn in faded gold ink, was a symbol.

An open hand, palm up. And above the palm, a single flame.

"*The hand that holds the light out for others*," Seraphine read aloud. "The mark of the House of Vey. The mark of the first Founder. The one who designed the Lattice." She looked up at them. "His name was Aurelian. Aurelian Vey."



SHE TALKED FOR A long time. Lex listened, and Antho listened, and Ember listened, and once or twice Ember spoke up in Lex's head to add something or correct something, and Lex repeated it, and Seraphine stopped and stared at him and said *how do you know that?* and he said *I have a voice in my head* and she said *of course you do* and went on.

Nine hundred years ago, the world had almost ended. The war of the sorcerer-kings, the Sundering. Seraphine told it the way Elric had told it, but with more names and more dates and more terrible details. Mountains moved. Seas boiled. And at the end of it, out of the ruin, came seven great mages. The Founders. And the greatest of them was Aurelian Vey.

"He was a Listener," Seraphine said. "That's what they called the old mages. Before the Lattice. They didn't have classes or levels. They *listened* to the world. To the elements. Fire and stone and water and wind. They heard what the world wanted to do, and they asked it nicely, and sometimes it did it." She turned a page. "Aurelian was the greatest Listener who ever lived. And he looked at what the sorcerer-kings had done, and he decided that the world couldn't be trusted to listen to anyone anymore. So he built the Lattice."

"To ration magic," said Lex. "So no one could get too powerful."

"That's what the histories say." Seraphine hesitated. "That's what *most* of the histories say."

"What do the rest say?"

Seraphine turned another page. Then another. She found what she was looking for and turned the book around so they could see it, though they couldn't read it.

"This is Aurelian's own account," she said. "Or a copy of it. The oldest copy that exists. And it says that the Lattice had *two* purposes." She traced a line of Wellscrip with her finger. "*To bind the will of men, and to bind the hunger beneath.*"

Antho went very still.

"*The hunger beneath*," he repeated quietly.

"I don't know what it means," said Seraphine. "I've spent two years trying to work it out. There are references all through the Founders' records. *The hunger. The Hollow. The thing that woke in the Sundering.* But they never say what it is. Only that the Lattice is a *lid* as well as a *net*. That it holds something down." She looked up. "Something that's been trying to get out ever since."

Lex looked at his brother.

Antho was staring down at the open book, at the faded gold hand and flame, at the line of Wellscript under Seraphine's finger. His face was very pale. His hands, resting on the table, had curled slowly into fists.

"I know what it is," he said.

Seraphine stared at him.

"I've been listening to it," said Antho, "for eight years."



IT WAS A LONG time before anyone spoke again.

Seraphine sat with her hand still resting on the open book, staring at Antho. Antho sat with his fists on the table, staring at nothing. Ashka had crept down off his shoulder and into his lap and was pressed against his stomach, chirping very softly.

"Breach-linked," Seraphine whispered at last. "That's what your file said. *Breach-linked, unstable*. I thought it was jargon. I thought it meant your power was unstable." She swallowed. "It means you're *tied* to it. To the hunger. To the thing under the lid."

"Yes."

"And it talks to you."

"It never stops."

Seraphine looked at him for a long moment. And Lex saw the fear go out of her face, slowly, the way frost goes out of a window when the sun comes up. In its place came something else. Something he couldn't name. Pity, maybe. Or wonder. Or something more complicated than either.

"Eight years," she said quietly. "Alone with that."

"Seven and a half, really," said Antho. "The first six months, I mostly screamed."

Seraphine laughed. It burst out of her, startled and shocked and slightly hysterical, and she clapped a hand over her mouth. "I'm sorry. I'm so sorry. That isn't funny."

"It's a little funny," said Antho. Something moved at the corner of his mouth. "You have to laugh. Or you'd just keep screaming."

They looked at each other across the table. And Lex, watching them, had the odd feeling that something had just happened that he didn't quite understand.

[Hm,] said Ember thoughtfully.

What?

[Nothing. Just an observation.] A pause. *[Your brother hasn't looked at anyone like that since we met him. Not even you.]*



"AVALORIA," SAID LEX. "THAT'S where we're going. That's where our father is."

They'd moved on from the hunger. None of them wanted to talk about it anymore, Antho least of all. Seraphine had made more tea. Garrick and Wren had come back in from the perimeter, Wren very carefully not looking at Lex, Lex very carefully not looking at Wren, and Garrick looking at both of them with an expression of deep and silent amusement. Now they were all sitting around the long table in the round room, with candles lit against the dark and the silver leaves rustling at the windows.

"Avaloria." Seraphine had gone very still again. "You're sure?"

"His letter said so. The way to him runs through Avaloria." Lex nodded at the lodestone. "And that's what calls the Way. Three songs. We've got two."

"The Temple of Avaloria," said Seraphine slowly. She got up again and went to the shelves and came back with another book, smaller this time, bound in green leather. She opened it to a page with a drawing on it: an island, in the middle of a lake, with a building on it. Columns and domes and towers, impossibly delicate, drawn in faded silver ink. "One of the Seven Temples. The greatest of them. The Founders built it as the Anchor."

"The Anchor?"

"The place where the Lattice is tied to the world. Every net needs an anchor. A place where the threads are knotted fast, or the whole thing would drift." She traced the drawing with one finger. "The Spire has one of the Seven, the Great Stone at the top. That's how the senior Wardens see into the Lattice. But Avaloria is older. Deeper. Avaloria is where the Root is." She looked up at Lex. "The records say only those of the Founder's blood can enter it. *Vey* blood. Everyone else who's looked for it has found nothing but an empty lake."

"Two of the blood," said Antho. "The Way opens to two of the blood."

"And your father went there." Seraphine looked from one to the other. "Sixteen years ago. After the Vhessa Breach." She bit her lip. "I've seen the requisition record. It was one of the things I copied, before I ran. Warden-Architect Arion Vey signed out the *Avaloria Codex* from the sealed vault, three days after he came back from the east. He never returned it. Two months later, he vanished from the rolls."

"What's the Vhessa Breach?" said Garrick.

Seraphine looked at him. Then she reached into the stacks of paper on the table, sorted through them with quick, practiced fingers, and pulled out a single sheet. She handed it to Garrick.

It was a map. A map of Aldermere, drawn in the Spire's precise style, with the kingdoms marked in faint grey lines. And scattered across it, in red ink, there were marks. Little red crosses. Lex counted them from where he sat. Twenty. Twenty-five.

Most of them were in the east, in Vhessa, clustered thick around a place on the eastern border that someone had marked with a much larger cross and the word *ORIGIN*. But there were others. Scattered across Caldor. Up in the north. Down in the south. One, Lex saw with a jolt, high in the Greyspine, exactly where the Hollowmaw would be.

"Breaches," said Seraphine quietly. "That's the Spire's private map. The one they don't show anyone. Every known breach in the Lattice, every place the Gloam has come through." She tapped the large cross in the east. "That's Vhessa. The first one. The biggest. It opened sixteen years ago. And every single one since has opened *after* it. They're spreading. Like cracks spreading out from a hammer-blow on glass."

Garrick was staring at the map. His scarred face had gone grey.

"I fought in Vhessa," he said quietly. "Twenty years ago. In the border wars. There were villages there. Towns. A whole province." He traced the area around the origin cross with one thick finger. "There's nothing there now?"

"There's the Blightmarch," said Seraphine. "That's what the Spire calls it. The whole eastern province, gone grey. Nobody goes in. Nobody comes out." She paused. "Except—"

"Except?"

Seraphine hesitated. Then she reached into her papers again and pulled out a letter. Old, creased, the seal broken.

"Two Wardens went east to investigate the breach when it first opened," she said. "Two of the most senior in the Order. One was Warden-Architect Arion Vey." She looked at Lex and Antho. "The other was Warden-Commander Morvane."

She unfolded the letter.

"This is from Commander Morvane's aide," she said. "Written to a friend in the Spire archives, about ten years ago. My predecessor kept it. I don't know why. I found it in his desk after he retired." She began to read, her voice very quiet: "*The Commander has not slept in three months. He does not eat. He does not seem to need to. He is very pale now, paler than any man should be, and when he walks through the camp, the men fall silent, and some of them do not speak again for days. He has begun gathering some of them around him. He calls them the Quiet. They stand very still and watch him and say nothing, and their eyes have gone pale like his. Yesterday he told me that he has seen the truth of the world, and that it is beautiful, and that it is silence. I do not think he is himself anymore. I do not know who he is. I am afraid.*"

She lowered the letter.

"The aide was reported dead two weeks later," she said. "Gloom exposure. And Commander Morvane was given command of the eastern containment, and has held it ever since. He never comes to the Spire. He sends reports. They're always very calm. Very orderly." Her voice dropped. "And the Blightmarch keeps getting bigger."

[*Quiet,*] said Ember softly. [*The Gloamed miller. That's what it kept saying. "Quiet. Be quiet. All be quiet."*]

Lex's skin had gone cold all over.

"He's in it," he said. "Isn't he. Morvane. He went into the breach with our father, and something happened, and he came out—*full* of it. Like the miller. Like the bear. Only all the way."

"I don't know," said Seraphine. "I don't know anything for certain. I just have papers." She looked down at the letter in her hands. "But I think whatever your father found in Vhessa, Commander Morvane found it too. And I think it found him."



LEX FOUND THE DRAWING an hour later.

He'd been wandering along the shelves while the others talked. He couldn't read most of the books. But he could see the Wellsript on their spines, the way he saw runes in iron, and every so often a word would jump out at him. *Root. Anchor. Seal. Blood.* And then, on a low shelf near the floor, half-hidden behind a stack of scrolls, there was a slim book bound in grey leather, with the open hand and the flame stamped on its spine in faded gold.

He took it out. He opened it.

It was full of drawings. Diagrams. Not of the Lattice, or of Temples, or of breaches. Of *tools*. Hammers and tongs and anvils and chisels, drawn with loving, careful precision, every one of them covered in runes. And on the facing pages, in tiny Wellsript, notes. He couldn't read the notes. But he could read the runes on the tools. *Ardent. Steadfast. Homeward. Bind.* The same runes he'd struck into Anvilsong and Oathkeeper and the ward-nails. And on the last page, a hammer. A big two-handed hammer, like Anvilsong, with a flat striking face and a tapered wedge. And on its head, four runes.

Three he knew. The fourth was an open hand, held out in the dark.

He brought it to Seraphine.

She took it from him and looked at the cover, and her eyes went wide. She turned the pages very slowly. When she got to the last one, the hammer, she stopped.

"Where did you find this?"

"On the bottom shelf. Over there."

"I've never seen it before. I've catalogued every book in this archive. Twice." She turned it over in her hands. "It's a smith's book. A Founder's smith's book. *The Book of Making*, it says. *As written by the hand of—*" She stopped. Looked up. "*As written by the hand of Aurelian Vey, in the third year of the Weaving, for those of his blood who come after and have the gift of the forge.*"

Lex stared at her.

"He was a smith," Seraphine whispered. "Aurelian. The first Founder. He wasn't only a Listener. He was a *maker*. That's how he wove the Lattice. He didn't cast it. He *forged* it." She turned to the last page again. To the hammer with the four runes. She touched the fourth one, the open hand. "This is the mark of the House of Vey. Aurelian put it on his own hammer. The hammer he used to make the Lattice." She looked up at Lex. "How did you know this rune?"

Lex didn't answer. He swung Anvilson down off his shoulder and laid it on the table beside the book, head up.

Four runes, glowing faintly red-gold in the dark iron.

Three he'd been taught. The fourth had come up out of him, unbidden, at the very end of the forging, from somewhere deeper than memory.

Seraphine looked at the hammer. At the book. At the hammer again.

"*Emberwright*," she said slowly. "That's your class, isn't it. I heard you say it. Sorcery through making." She shook her head. "There hasn't been a Vey with the forge-gift in—I don't know. Centuries. The book says it's rare. That it only comes once in a great while in the line." She touched the fourth rune on Anvilson, very gently, as if afraid it might burn her. "You put the family mark into your first real work without knowing it was there. Your blood remembered what you didn't."

Lex didn't know what to say.

[*Lex,*] said Ember, very quietly. [*Keep that book. Whatever else you do. Keep it.*]

Why?

[*Because it's yours. It was always meant to be yours.*] A pause. [*And because I can read the notes. All of them. And some of them are about things you're going to need to know.*]



"I'M COMING WITH YOU," said Seraphine.

It was very late. The candles had burned down to stubs. Garrick was asleep in a chair by the door with Oathkeeper across his knees. Wren had curled up on a heap of cushions in the corner and was either asleep or pretending to be. Antho was sitting at the end of the long table, idly

turning the pages of the green book with the drawing of Avaloria in it, with Ashka asleep on his shoulder.

Lex looked at Seraphine. "It's dangerous."

"I know it's dangerous. There's a price on my head larger than yours." She pushed her spectacles up her nose. "I've spent two years hiding in a tree reading about the Lattice. I've read everything here. Some of it three times. And there are still things I don't understand. Things I can't understand from books." She looked at the lodestone, glowing faintly on the table. "If you're really going to Avaloria, if you're really going to walk into the Anchor of the Lattice, I want to be there. I want to *see* it." She paused. "And you'll need someone who can read the Wellscrip. I'm the best reader alive outside the Spire. Possibly inside it, too."

"Ember can read it," said Lex.

"Ember can read it to *you*. In your head. And then you have to repeat it, slowly, and get half the words wrong." Seraphine raised an eyebrow. "I've been listening all evening. You pronounced *Anchorage* as *anchor rag*."

[*She's not wrong,*] said Ember.

Lex sighed. "Fine."

"Besides," said Seraphine. She glanced down the table at Antho, and then away again quickly. "Someone needs to study your brother's condition properly. Scientifically. Breach-linking has never been documented in a living subject. It's unprecedented. If I could take proper notes, measure his Clarity over time, correlate it with—"

"I'm right here," said Antho, without looking up from the book.

Seraphine went pink. "I know you're right here. I'm speaking *about* you, not *around* you. There's a difference."

"Is there."

"Yes. One is rude and the other is—" She stopped. "Clinical."

Antho turned a page. Something moved at the corner of his mouth.

"Clinical," he said. "That's a new one. I've been called a monster, a murderer, a madman, and the Ashbourne warlock. I've never been called *clinical*."

"You're not clinical. Your *case* is clinical."

"Ah," said Antho. "My case."

Seraphine opened her mouth. Shut it again. Turned even pinker.

Lex looked from one to the other. Then he looked away and very carefully didn't smile.

[Hm,] said Ember again.

Stop it.

[I'm only observing.]



THE KNOCK CAME JUST before dawn.

Lex was the only one awake. He'd been sitting at the long table for hours with Aurelian's *Book of Making* open in front of him, turning the pages slowly, looking at the drawings of hammers and tongs and anvils covered in runes he didn't know yet, while Ember read the notes to him in a low murmur. *[This one is for tempering. This one is a warding-mark for doors. This one—oh. This one's clever. This one lets a blade cut light.]* He'd lost track of time.

The knock came again. Three sharp raps on the living-wood door.

Garrick was on his feet in an instant, Oathkeeper drawn, frost blooming along the blade. Wren rolled off her cushions with an arrow already on the string. Antho's eyes opened, grey and alert, and the shadows stirred around his hands. Seraphine sat bolt upright in her chair with her spectacles askew, clutching the crossbow she'd fallen asleep holding.

"Who is it?" Lex called.

"An old man," said a voice outside, *"who has walked a very long way, and whose raven has been sulking for two days because nobody gave him any of the ptarmigan."*

Lex let out a breath.

He went to the door and opened it.

Elric Thorne stood on the little round stone step, leaning on his lightning-scarred staff, his grey cloak dark with dew, the brass storm-charms on it glinting faintly in the grey light. Quill sat on his shoulder, looking deeply aggrieved. The old sorcerer's face was lined and tired, and there was mud on his boots up to the knee, and a new cut along one cheekbone. But his storm-grey eyes were bright and sharp as ever, and when he saw Lex, they crinkled at the corners.

"Hello, Lex," he said. "You look well. Better than well." His gaze moved past Lex into the room. To Antho, sitting at the end of the table with Ashka on his shoulder and shadows still curling around his hands. And Elric's face went very still. "And you found your brother."

"I found my brother."

"*Well.*" Elric let out a long breath. "Well, well. I'm very glad." He looked at Antho for a long moment. "Hello, Anthoren. I don't expect you remember me. I came up to the Hollowmaw once, a long time ago. You didn't come out."

"I remember," said Antho quietly. He didn't get up. "It wasn't a good night."

"No. I didn't think it was." Elric's gaze moved on. To Garrick, with his frost-edged sword. To Wren, with her bow. And then to Seraphine, sitting very straight in her chair with the crossbow in her lap.

And something in Elric's face changed.

It was very quick. Lex almost missed it. The faintest tightening around the eyes. The faintest narrowing. Like a man who'd seen a coin on the ground and was trying to decide whether it was real.

"Seraphine Ilvane," Elric said softly.

Seraphine went white. "You—you know me?"

"Everyone at the Spire knows you, girl. Or knows your name." Elric came into the room, slowly, leaning on his staff. He didn't take his eyes off her. "The archivist who stole from the sealed vaults and vanished. The High Warden has put a price on your head of two thousand crowns." He smiled faintly. It didn't reach his eyes. "Four times what she's offering for these two. You must have taken something very valuable."

"I took the truth," said Seraphine. Her voice shook, but she held his gaze.

"Did you." Elric looked at her a moment longer. Then he turned away, and the smile came back, warmer this time, and he lowered himself into a chair at the table with a small groan. "Well. I'm sure you'll tell me all about it. But first, I'd very much like a cup of whatever that is, and something to eat, and for someone to tell me what in the Lady's name happened to Lex's face. It looks like someone hit it with a sword."

"Someone did," said Lex.

"Of course they did." Elric sighed. "Of course they did. Sit down, all of you. I have news. And very little of it is good."

Lex sat down. But as he did, he glanced at Seraphine, and saw that she was still staring at Elric, her face white, her hands tight on the crossbow in her lap.

And he glanced at Elric, and saw that the old sorcerer, while he smiled and accepted a cup of tea from Garrick and scratched Quill under the beak, was watching her too. Out of the corner of his eye. Very carefully.

Like a man watching a coin on the ground.

CHAPTER 14

THE STORMCALLER'S LESSONS



"AGAIN," SAID ELRIC.

Lex held out his hand, palm up, and called the heat.

It came the way Antho had taught him: shape the channel, then let it flow. A thread of warmth rising from his chest, down his arm, pooling in his palm. A shimmer in the air. A small ball of heat, invisible except for the way it bent the light, the way the air above a summer road bends.

"No," said Elric. "Stop."

Lex let it go. The heat dissipated with a faint *whuff*.

They were standing in a clearing on the eastern edge of the Thornwood, where the black trees gave way to rolling grey country and the Road ran on toward a low, misty, marshy horizon. They'd left the Leafbound Archive two days ago. The Thorn Mother had let them go with a rustle of silver leaves and a promise that the forest would remember them kindly. Seraphine had brought a pack so full of books she could barely lift it, until Garrick had quietly taken half of them and put them in his own.

And every evening since, Elric had been teaching.

"You're doing it like your brother," the old sorcerer said now. He was leaning on his staff at the edge of the clearing, watching Lex with his sharp grey eyes. "*Letting* it. Like water finding a crack."

"It works."

"It works for him. His power is deep and still. It *wants* to pool. It wants to find the low places and settle there." Elric shook his head. "Yours doesn't. Yours is fire. Fire doesn't settle. It *climbs*. It leaps. It wants to go everywhere

at once. If you only *let* it, it'll go everywhere at once, and most of it will be wasted." He lifted a hand. "Watch."

A spark leaped from his fingertips. Blue-white, crackling. It didn't fly off, the way lightning would. It *hung* there, in the air above his palm, a tiny knot of energy the size of a pea. And then it began to turn. Around and around, faster and faster, tracing a circle in the air, and then another circle inside the first, and another, until there were seven circles of blue-white light nested one inside the other above his palm like the rings of a gyroscope, spinning, humming, perfectly controlled.

"Circles," said Elric. "That's how the Spire teaches it. You don't pour your power out like water from a jug. You *structure* it. Give it a shape to run in. A path. A circuit. And it goes round and round that path, building, building, until you decide to let it out." He closed his fist. The circles collapsed inward with a sharp *crack*, and a single bolt of lightning leaped from his knuckles across the clearing and struck a dead tree, and the tree split down the middle with a sound like a cannon. "And then it goes where you *tell* it. All of it. Nothing wasted."

Lex stared at the smoking tree.

"Your brother's way is good for defense," said Elric. "For holding. For shields and bindings and walls. That's why it suits him." He came across the clearing. "Your way should be good for *striking*. For forging. For driving the fire exactly where you want it to go. Try it. Give the heat a circle to run in."

Lex held out his hand again.

He called the heat. He didn't let it pool this time. He *shaped* it. A circle. A ring of warmth in his palm. He tried to make it turn.

It wobbled. It flared. It collapsed in a puff of hot air that singed the hair off the back of his hand.

"Again," said Elric.



IT TOOK HIM FOUR evenings.

Four evenings of wobbling, collapsing, singeing circles. Four evenings of Elric's patient, dry, relentless voice saying *again*. Four evenings of Antho

sitting at the edge of the clearing with Ashka in his lap, watching, saying nothing, his face unreadable.

And on the fifth evening, it worked.

He held out his hand, and called the heat, and gave it a circle. And this time the circle held. It turned. Slowly at first, a single ring of shimmering air above his palm, and then faster, and then a second ring inside the first, and a third. He felt it building. Felt the heat gathering, concentrating, growing hotter and denser with every turn, like a forge with the bellows working, until the air above his palm was shimmering so fiercely it was hard to look at.

"Now," said Elric quietly. "Not out. *In*. Over your skin."

Lex didn't understand. And then, suddenly, he did. He didn't let the circles out. He let them *spread*. Down over his hand, his wrist, his arm, his shoulder, a thin shell of heat, not burning, just *there*, wrapping around him like a second skin. Like armor. Like the glowing surface of iron fresh from the fire.

SKILL LEARNED: Ironskin

Novice 1

"The forge's heat, worn as a coat."

Damage reduction while active.

Mana drain: 2/sec

Elric picked up a stone and threw it at him.

It struck Lex's shoulder and bounced off. He barely felt it. Where it had touched, the stone was glowing faintly red.

"There," said Elric. He looked, for a moment, almost proud. Then something else crossed his face. Lex couldn't name it. "Your father learned that in an afternoon," the old sorcerer said quietly. "I spent a month teaching it to him, and he looked at me on the last day and said *Oh, I see, it's like folding steel*, and did it on the first try." He smiled faintly. "I could have strangled him."

"It *is* like folding steel," said Lex. He let the Ironskin go, and the shell of heat sank back into him.

Elric laughed. It came out a little forced. "Of course it is," he said. "Of course it is. You're both smiths, aren't you. In your different ways."

He turned away and walked back to the fire.

[*Hm,*] said Ember.

What?

[*Nothing. He's a good teacher. He really is.*] A pause. [*I just wondered why it seemed to hurt him to say that.*]



ELRIC'S NEWS WAS BAD.

He'd told them most of it that first morning in the Leafbound Archive, over tea and bread, while the light came up grey through the round windows. The rest came out in pieces over the following days, around the evening fire.

The Order was mobilizing. Not against the Gloam. Against *them*. Roole's report on the Hollowmaw had gone up to the Spire, and it had caused, Elric said, *a considerable stir*.

"He told the truth," Elric said, poking the fire with his staff. "That's what's caused the trouble. Warden-Captain Roole wrote in his official report that the Ashbourne warlock was holding a breach shut. That the Gloam in the Greyspine was coming from a hole in the Lattice, not from Anthoren Harrow. That Lex Harrow had disarmed fifteen Wardens and spared them all, including Roole himself." He shook his head. "The High Warden didn't like that. The High Warden doesn't like anything that contradicts the official story. And the official story is that the Gloam is a natural blight and the Ashbourne brothers are dangerous wildcasters."

"What happened to Roole?" said Lex.

"Relieved of command. Recalled to Highcrest. Under investigation." Elric shrugged. "He'll be fine, probably. He has a good record and friends in the Order. But they've sent someone else after you now. Someone less inclined to tell the truth in his reports."

"Who?"

"Inquisitor-General Vane. You don't want to meet him." Elric's face was grim. "And the bounties have doubled. A thousand crowns each."

Wren whistled. "That's more than Thistledown makes in ten years."

"It's more than most *towns* make in ten years. Every bounty hunter, mercenary and desperate farmer between here and Saltreach will be watching the roads." Elric looked around the fire at them. "We need to stay

off them. Which means the Founders' Road is still our best path. Nobody uses it. Nobody knows it's there."

"And the Gloam?" said Garrick. "What about the black stuff? The breaches?"

Elric was quiet for a moment.

"Getting worse," he said at last. "Much worse. I went east, after I left Lex in the foothills. As far as the edge of the Blightmarch. I didn't go in. Nobody goes in." He stared into the fire. "It's grown. It's grown a great deal in the last year. There are villages along the border that were green last spring and are grey now. And there are things moving in the grey. Hounds. Wraiths. Worse. Whole companies of Gloamed, standing in the fields, not moving, just *waiting*." He looked up. "And they're organized. That's what frightened me most. They're not wandering. They're placed. Like soldiers on a map. Like someone is *arranging* them."

"Morvane," said Seraphine quietly.

Elric's head turned sharply. "What do you know about Morvane?"

Seraphine hesitated. Then she told him about the letter from the aide. Elric listened in silence. When she finished, he was quiet for a long time.

"I knew Morvane," he said at last. "A long time ago. When he was young. When we were all young." His voice was very soft. "He was a hard man. A rigid man. He believed in order above everything. He believed the Lattice was the greatest gift ever given to humanity, because it made the world *make sense*." He shook his head slowly. "If anything in the Hollow could find a way into a man like that, it would find it through that. Through the love of order. Through the longing for everything to just be *quiet*."

[Quiet,] said Ember. *[Be quiet. All be quiet.]*

Lex shivered, though the fire was warm.



ANTHO DIDN'T LIKE ELRIC.

He never said so. He was polite, in his strange, careful way. He answered when Elric spoke to him. He listened to Elric's stories around the fire. He watched Elric's lessons with Lex from the edge of the clearing. But he never sat next to the old sorcerer. Never walked beside him on the Road.

And Lex, watching his brother's red panel out of the corner of his eye, noticed something else.

Antho's Clarity dropped whenever Elric was near.

Not much. A few points. Seventy-four to seventy. Seventy-one to sixty-seven. It always came back up once Elric moved away. But it was there, every time, as regular as a tide.

On the sixth night, Lex asked him about it.

They were sitting together at the edge of camp, a little way from the fire, watching the stars come out over the grey marshy country to the east. Elric had gone off into the dark to *scout*, he said, as he did most evenings. The others were by the fire. Wren was showing Seraphine how to string a bow, and Seraphine was doing it badly, and Garrick was laughing at both of them.

"It's the lightning," said Antho. "I think. The thing in my head doesn't like lightning. It's too bright. Too loud."

"Is that all?"

Antho didn't answer right away. He was turning the lodestone over in his fingers, watching it pulse grey and green in the dark.

"No," he said at last. "That's not all." He hesitated. "It *likes* him, Lex."

Lex turned his head.

"It wants him," Antho said quietly. "The way it wanted him at the Hollowmaw, when he came up and called my name. More than it wanted the Wardens. More than it wants most people." He frowned. "I asked it why. I don't usually ask it things. It's never a good idea. But I asked."

"What did it say?"

Antho was quiet for a long moment.

"It said he's hungry too," he said.

The night was very still. Somewhere off in the marshes, a bird called, low and mournful.

"Hungry," Lex repeated.

"That's what it said. *Hungry one. He's hungry too.* Like it recognized something. Like they were the same." Antho shook his head. "I don't know what it means. Maybe nothing. It says a lot of things. Most of them are nonsense. Most of them are just *want want want* over and over." He put

the lodestone back inside his shirt. "But it's never said that about anyone else."

Lex sat there in the dark for a long time after that, thinking.

He thought about Elric's face in the lantern light on the Ashbourne green, the first night, staring at the Stone. That strange raw look. *Like a man looking through a window at a feast laid out for someone else.*

He thought about the panel he'd seen with True Sight, in the forge. *Tier IV — DENIED (×3).*

Twice by the Spire. And once, someone else.

[Lex,] said Ember quietly. [I don't think he means you any harm.]

I didn't say he did.

[You were thinking it.] A pause. [I've been watching him too. He's teaching you well. He's protecting you. He walked a long way to bring you news. Those aren't the actions of an enemy.]

Then what are they?

Ember didn't answer for a long time.

[The actions of a man who wants something,] it said at last. [I'm just not sure what it is yet.]



THE GLOAMHOUNDS CAME ON the seventh night.

Lex woke to Ashka's shriek, and Wren's shout, and the smell: wet ash and rot and nothing, thick on the air, rolling in off the marshes. He was on his feet with Anvilson in his hands before he was fully awake. The fire had burned low. The camp was dark. And out in the darkness, beyond the circle of dying firelight, white eyes.

Dozens of them.

"Up!" Garrick roared. "Everyone up! Backs to the fire!"

They came in a rush, low and fast and whispering. Lex met the first one with an Ember Strike that turned it to gold sparks. He threw up Ironskin as the second one leaped, and its teeth closed on his forearm and *scorched*, and it fell back shrieking with smoke pouring from its jaws. He swung. Another one burst. Beside him, Garrick's blade flashed blue-white, and every hound it touched shattered into black splinters and didn't re-form. Wren's arrows

sang. Antho's shadows rose up in a wall around the fire, and where they touched the hounds, the hounds recoiled, and *went still*, and dissolved.

And Seraphine stood in the middle of them, by the fire, with her crossbow in her hands and the bolt in the right way up this time, and shot a gloamhound through the eye at ten paces, and then stared at it as it burst into smoke as if she couldn't believe what she'd done.

"*Good shot!*" Wren shouted.

"I—I was aiming at the other one!"

"*Still counts!*"

It was over in ten minutes. Twenty hounds, perhaps thirty. They came out of the marsh and broke against the five of them like waves against rocks and fell back into the dark and didn't come again. When it was done, Lex stood by the fire with Anvilsong smoking in his hands and steam rising off his skin and looked around.

Everyone was standing. Everyone was alive. Garrick had a gash across his cheek. Wren had a bite on her calf, already going grey at the edges, which Lex knelt and burned clean. Seraphine was sitting on the ground by the fire with her crossbow across her knees, shaking, laughing, crying, all at once.

"I shot one," she kept saying. "I shot one. I've never shot anything. I've never shot *anything*."

"You shot it very well," said Antho. He'd sat down beside her. Not touching. Just close. His shadows were sinking back into the ground around them. "Right through the eye. I couldn't have done better."

Seraphine looked at him. She was still shaking. "You could have," she said. "You did. I saw you. You did about fifteen of them."

"Yes, well. I've had eight years of practice."

She laughed, wet and shaky. And after a moment, without seeming to think about it, she leaned sideways until her shoulder touched his.

Antho went very still. But he didn't move away.

CLARITY: 66 → 71 ▲

Lex looked away. He found he was smiling.

And then he stopped smiling, because he'd looked around the camp, and counted, and someone was missing.

"Where's Elric?"



ELRIC CAME BACK AN hour later.

He came walking out of the dark from the east, from the direction of the marshes, leaning on his staff, his grey cloak dark with mud to the knee. Quill was on his shoulder. He stopped at the edge of the firelight and looked around at the camp, at the scorch marks on the ground and the wisps of black smoke still curling up from where the hounds had died, and his face went still.

"What happened?"

"Gloamhounds," said Garrick. "Thirty of them. Maybe more." His voice was very even. "Where were you?"

"Scouting." Elric came into the firelight. "There's a ridge about two miles east. I went up it to look at the marshes. I saw—" He stopped. Looked around again. "Is everyone all right?"

"Everyone's fine," said Lex.

"Thank the Lady." Elric let out a long breath. He sat down heavily on a rock by the fire. "I didn't hear anything. I didn't see anything. The wind must have been wrong." He shook his head. "I'm sorry. I should have been here."

Nobody said anything.

Lex looked at him. At the mud on his boots. At the lined, tired face in the firelight. At the storm-grey eyes, which were looking into the fire and not at any of them.

He almost used True Sight.

He didn't. He didn't know why. Maybe because Elric had told him, that first night in the forge, that it was rude. Maybe because some part of him didn't want to know.

[He's telling the truth about not hearing it,] said Ember quietly. [I think. There's a ridge to the east, two miles off. And the wind is from the west. He wouldn't have heard.]

Then why does it feel wrong?

Ember didn't answer.



LATER THAT NIGHT, WREN came and sat down beside Lex at the edge of camp.

She didn't say anything for a while. She'd been avoiding him, a little, since the silver path in the Thornwood. Not unkindly. Just carefully. As if they were both standing on a frozen pond and neither of them wanted to be the one to make it crack.

"I saw him burn something," she said at last, very quietly.

Lex looked at her.

"Elric. Two nights ago. When he said he was going scouting. I couldn't sleep, so I went to check the snares I'd set, and I saw him on a rock a little way off, with a candle." Wren's voice was flat. "He was writing a letter. Then he read it over. Then he held it in the candle flame until it burned, and dropped the ashes in a puddle, and stirred them with his staff." She paused. "He did it three times. Wrote a letter, read it, burned it. Three letters."

"Maybe he couldn't get the words right."

"Maybe." Wren didn't sound convinced. "People who can't get the words right crumple up the paper. They don't burn it and stir the ashes into a puddle."

Lex didn't say anything.

"I'm not saying anything," said Wren. "I'm just telling you what I saw."

"I know."

"He's been good to us. He found you. He's teaching you. He brought us news." She was quiet for a moment. "And I've lived on a mountain my whole life, Hammer, and the mountain teaches you one thing above everything else. When something smells wrong, you don't wait to find out why. You just get ready."



ELRIC FOUND HIM THE next morning.

The others were breaking camp. Lex had gone down to a stream to fill the waterskins, and Elric came down after him, slowly, picking his way between the reeds with his staff.

"A word," the old sorcerer said quietly. "If you have a moment."

Lex straightened up with a dripping waterskin in each hand. "What is it?"

Elric glanced back up the slope toward the camp. Seraphine was there, folding her blanket, her back to them.

"The archivist," Elric said, very low. "How much do you trust her?"

Lex blinked. "She's been honest with us. As far as I can tell."

"As far as you can tell," Elric nodded slowly. "I'm sure she has. I'm sure she seems very honest. She's very convincing." He leaned on his staff. "Lex, I've spent my life around the Spire. I know how the sealed vaults are warded. I know what it takes to get into them, and what it takes to get out with codices under your arm." He shook his head. "A junior archivist doesn't do that. Not alone. Not without help. Someone had to let her in. Someone had to let her out. Someone had to make sure the wards were down for an hour on the right night." He looked at Lex steadily. "So either she had a powerful friend inside the Spire, who has since vanished. Or she still has one. And she's still working for them."

Lex stared at him.

"I'm not saying she's a spy," said Elric. "I'm saying ask yourself the question. She knew a great deal about you very quickly. She knew about Avaloria. She knew about your father's requisition record. She knew about *Morvane*." He spread his knotted hands. "Where does a junior archivist hiding in a tree for two years learn all that?"

"From her papers. She told us. She copied them before she ran."

"Did she show you the papers?"

Lex opened his mouth. Shut it again.

She'd shown them the map. The aide's letter. The books. But the rest of it, the requisition record, the Kindling ledgers—she'd *told* them about those. She'd recited them from memory.

"I'm only asking you to be careful," Elric said gently. "That's all. Watch her. Don't tell her anything you don't have to. Especially about the lodestone. Especially about Avaloria." He put a hand on Lex's shoulder. His grip was thin and knotted and surprisingly strong. "Your father trusted too easily, sometimes. It's the one flaw he had." He smiled faintly. "Well. One of several."

He turned and went back up the slope toward the camp.

Lex stood by the stream with the waterskins dripping in his hands, and the cold water running over his boots, and a feeling in his chest like a slag pocket buried in good iron. A dull note under the ring.

[Lex,] said Ember slowly. [I don't know what to think.]

Neither do I.

[He's not wrong that it would be hard to get out of the sealed vaults alone. And she did know a great deal.] A pause. *[But Wren's not wrong either. About the letters. About things that smell wrong.]*

So who do I trust?

The silence went on for a long time.

[I don't know,] said Ember at last. [But I think I know who your father would have told you to trust.]

Who?

[The people who stood next to you in the dark,] said Ember quietly. [When the hounds came. Who were there.]

Lex looked up the slope at the camp.

Wren, slinging her bow over her shoulder. Garrick, buckling on Oathkeeper. Antho, crouched by the ashes of the fire with Ashka on his shoulder, helping Seraphine roll up a blanket that she had somehow tied in a knot. Seraphine, laughing at something Antho had said, pushing her spectacles up her nose.

And Elric, a little apart from the rest of them, leaning on his staff and looking east toward the grey marshes, his face unreadable.



THEY REACHED THE EDGE of the Drowned Barrows that afternoon.

It was Seraphine who recognized it first, from her books. The ground had been getting wetter all day: grey grass giving way to sedge and reeds, firm earth giving way to soft, squelching peat. The Road ran on across it on a raised causeway of ancient stone, but on either side the land sank lower and lower, and pools of black water began to appear among the reeds, and then larger pools, and then lakes, still and dark and mirror-flat.

And rising out of the water, here and there, were mounds.

Great round grassy mounds, like upturned bowls, some no bigger than a haystack and some as large as a house. Dozens of them. Hundreds.

Stretching away across the flooded country as far as the eye could see, half-sunk in the black water, wreathed in mist.

"Barrows," said Seraphine softly. "Burial mounds. From the Sundering. Nine hundred years ago, this was a battlefield. The greatest battle of the whole war. Forty thousand dead in a single day." She looked out over the drowned land. "They buried them where they fell. Kings and soldiers and sorcerers. And then the sea came in, and the rivers changed course, and the whole plain flooded. It's been underwater ever since."

The mist drifted between the mounds. The water was utterly still. Not a bird. Not an insect. Not a sound.

And the cold that came off the water was not the cold of a marsh. It was deeper than that. Older. It went into Lex's bones and stayed there.

ZONE ENTERED: THE DROWNED BARROWS

Founders' Wild — Danger: SEVERE

WARNING:

Restless dead: ACTIVE

Spirit-touch: drains Vitality

"The Barrow Throne," said Antho. He was looking out over the water with a strange expression. His hand had gone to the lodestone at his throat. "The third song. It's out there somewhere."

"In the center," said Seraphine. "The books say there's a great mound at the heart of the Barrows. Bigger than the rest. Where the greatest king of the Sundering was buried, with his whole court around him." She swallowed. "They call him the Barrow-King."

"Is he still in there?" said Wren.

Seraphine didn't answer.

Antho closed his eyes. He stood very still on the stone causeway, with the black water on either side and the mist drifting around him. And Lex felt it through the Bloodbond: the cold, deep pool of his brother's power, stirring, opening, *listening*.

"Grave-Speech," Antho said quietly. "I can hear them. All of them." His face had gone grey. "So many. *Thousands*." He opened his eyes. "They're not resting, Lex. They're angry. They've been angry for nine hundred years."

"About what?"

Antho looked out over the drowned barrows, the endless mist-wreathed mounds sinking into the black water.

"About being forgotten," he said.

Behind them, Elric Thorne stood on the causeway with his staff in his hand and his grey cloak stirring in a wind none of them could feel, and looked out over the Barrows, and said nothing at all. But his face, Lex saw, had gone very pale.

And out in the mist, among the mounds, something began to move.

CHAPTER 15

THE DROWNED BARROWS



[Before anything else,] said Ember, *[your points.]*

"Not now—"

[Eighteen of them. Three levels. You've been carrying them since the Thornwood.] A pause. *[Something is coming out of the mist, Lex. Something dead and angry and very, very old. I would really, truly prefer that you meet it with all of yourself.]*

Lex swore under his breath. He called up his status. He didn't have time to think about it, so he didn't. Three into Might, three into Agility, four into Vitality, four into Spirit, four into Resolve. He felt them go in like swallowing hot coals, a sudden rushing surge through every limb, and the cold of the Barrows that had been sitting in his bones since they stepped onto the causeway pulled back an inch.

LEX VEY – Emberwright, Level 19		
MIG 35	AGI 34	VIT 42
INT 31	SPI 76	RES 33
Health	420/420	
Mana	760/760	

[Thank you,] said Ember.

"You're welcome. *Now* can I—"

The dead came out of the water.



THEY ROSE ALL AROUND the causeway at once. Out of the black pools between the barrows, out of the reeds, out of the mist itself. They came up slowly, the way a drowned body comes up after many days: first a shape beneath the surface, pale and wavering, then a helmet breaking the water, then shoulders, arms, the glint of corroded bronze.

Soldiers. Hundreds of them.

They wore armor of a kind Lex had never seen: bronze scales gone green and black with nine hundred years of water, tall crested helms, round shields painted with symbols long since washed away. Their faces under the helms were not faces anymore. Bone, mostly, and the grey ghost of flesh, and eyes that glowed with a cold, pale, watery light, like moonlight seen from the bottom of a lake. Water poured off them as they rose. It ran from their armor and their empty eye sockets and their open mouths in endless dripping streams. And they were *transparent*. Not entirely. Just enough. Enough that Lex could see the mist through them, and the far barrows, and the black water.

DROWNED DEAD – Level 18–22

(×347)

Spirit-touch: drains Vitality

"Three hundred and forty-seven," said Antho quietly. He always counted.

"*Backs together!*" Garrick had Oathkeeper out. Frost bloomed along the blade. "Circle! Seraphine in the middle!"

"I can fight—"

"*In the middle, girl!*"

They formed a circle on the narrow causeway: Garrick and Lex facing one way, Wren and Antho the other, Elric at the end, Seraphine crouched in the center with her crossbow. Ashka was on Antho's shoulder, hissing, sparks crackling down her spine. Quill had taken off with a harsh croak and was circling overhead in the mist.

The Drowned Dead came toward them across the water. They didn't swim. They *walked*, on the surface of the black pools, as if the water were solid ground, slow and steady and silent, their armor clinking faintly, water pouring off them.

And they were whispering. Not like the gloamhounds, not *bright bright bright*. Something else. Something sadder.

[... *who ... who are we ... who were we ... remember ... remember us ... who ...*]

The first one reached the causeway. It raised a corroded bronze sword and swung it at Garrick's head.

Garrick blocked. Oathkeeper rang against the ancient bronze, and frost exploded outward from the impact. The dead soldier staggered back. But it didn't break. It didn't shatter the way the briar-hounds had. Garrick's eyes widened.

"*Bind* doesn't work on them!" he shouted. "They're not Gloam!"

[*He's right,*] said Ember sharply. [*They're not corrupted. They're dead**. Restless spirits. A different thing entirely.]*

Lex hit one with an Ember Strike. The fire went *through* it. Gold flame washing through a transparent body, and the spirit shuddered and hissed and its outline wavered like smoke in a breeze. But it didn't burn. It reformed. It kept coming.

And it touched him.

Its hand closed on his forearm. It wasn't cold, exactly. It was *empty*. A draining. Like a wound opening and the blood running out. He felt his health drop, felt his strength go out of him through the place where the dead hand gripped, felt his heart stutter—

He threw up Ironskin. The heat flared over his skin and the dead hand let go with a hiss, and Lex staggered back, gasping.

SPIRIT-TOUCH

Vitality drained: -38

Health: 342/420

"*Fire doesn't kill them!*" he shouted.

"*Nothing kills them.*" Wren was loosing arrows as fast as she could draw, and they went straight through the dead soldiers and splashed into the water beyond. "*They're already dead.*"

The circle tightened. The Drowned Dead pressed in on every side. Hundreds of them, walking on the water, their swords rising and falling, their dead hands reaching. Garrick held them back with sheer strength and

skill, Oathkeeper blazing blue-white. Lex held them back with Ironskin and fire, beating them back, beating them back, and every time he did, they reformed and came on. Elric's lightning crackled and forked through the mist, and the spirits it struck went flying back across the water, and then came walking back.

And Lex's mana was dropping. Ironskin drained it. Every Ember Strike drained it. Five hundred. Four hundred.

[You can't win this way,] said Ember. [You can only lose slowly.]

Then what do I do?

[I don't know. They're not Gloam. They're not monsters. They're people. Dead people. Angry people.]** A pause. *[What do angry dead people want?]*

And behind him, in the middle of the circle, Lex heard his brother's voice.

"Stop!"



ANTHO HAD STEPPED FORWARD.

He'd pushed past Wren, out of the circle, onto the open causeway, and he was standing there alone with his staff in one hand and the other raised, palm out, toward the advancing dead. His eyes were wide. His face was grey. And the shadows weren't pouring off him. They were very still, coiled close around his feet like sleeping cats.

"Stop," he said again. Not shouting now. Quietly. "Please. I can hear you."

The nearest of the Drowned Dead stopped.

It stood on the water three paces from Antho, a tall soldier in green-black bronze with a crested helm and water streaming from its empty eyes. Its sword was half-raised. It didn't lower it. But it didn't strike.

"I can hear you," Antho said. "Grave-Speech. I can hear the dead. I can hear *you*." He swallowed. "You're asking who you are. Who you were. You keep asking. Over and over. *Remember us. Who were we.*" His voice cracked. "You don't know. Do you. You've forgotten your own names."

The dead soldier didn't move.

All across the black water, the Drowned Dead had stopped. Hundreds of them, standing still on the surface of the pools, their swords raised, their

pale watery eyes fixed on the gaunt young man standing alone on the causeway.

[... who ... who were we ...]

"I don't know," Antho said. "I'm sorry. I don't know your names." He lowered his hand slowly. "But I'll listen. If you tell me. If you can remember even one. I'll listen."

The dead soldier looked at him for a long, long time.

Then, very slowly, it lowered its sword.

And it whispered. A sound like water running over stones, like wind in reeds, like the last breath going out of a drowning man. Lex couldn't make out the words. But Antho could. Lex saw him hear it. Saw his brother's face crumple.

"*Tobin*," Antho whispered. "Tobin of the Ford. You were a shepherd. You had a daughter. Her name was Lise." He was crying. "You were nineteen. You were nineteen and you didn't even want to fight. The king's men came to your village and took you."

The dead soldier stood very still on the water.

And then its outline *wavered*. Not like smoke in a breeze. Like a reflection in water when the ripples settle. Growing clearer. More solid. For one moment, just one, Lex saw a face under the corroded helm. A young man's face. Freckled. Frightened. Ordinary.

Tobin, it whispered. *Tobin. I was Tobin.*

And it sank. Slowly, gently, back down into the black water, like a man lying down to sleep. And was gone.

DROWNED DEAD – "Tobin of the Ford"

LAID TO REST

The silence across the Barrows was absolute.

Then, from every direction at once, from every black pool and every misty mound, from three hundred and forty-six dead throats, came a single sound. A whisper. A sigh. A plea.

[... remember us ... remember us ... remember us ...]

They weren't attacking anymore. They were coming toward Antho. Slowly. From every side. Lowering their swords. Holding out their dead, dripping, corroded hands.

"*Antho*—" Lex started forward.

"It's all right." His brother didn't turn around. He was standing on the causeway with the dead closing in all around him, and he wasn't afraid. "It's all right, Lex. They don't want to hurt anyone. They never did." He swallowed. "They just want someone to *listen*."



HE LISTENED FOR HOURS.

The dead came to him one by one across the water, and stood before him, and whispered, and he listened. Sometimes the names came quickly. Sometimes they came slowly, in fragments, as if the dead had to dig for them through nine hundred years of black water and silence. Sometimes they didn't come at all, and the dead soldier would stand there trembling, its dead hands clenched, trying and trying to remember, until Antho reached out very gently and touched its corroded bronze arm and said *it's all right, it's all right, take your time*, and the name would come.

Aldo, a cooper's son. Gavin, a fisherman. Bel, who sang. Marrick, a lord's third son who'd wanted to be a priest. Hessa, a woman who'd disguised herself as a man to follow her husband to war. Garth, a baker. Ilyan, a smith.

He said each name aloud. And each time he did, the dead soldier who'd whispered it would grow clearer, more solid, a face showing through the bone and bronze, and then sink, gently, into the water, and be gone.

But there were so many. Three hundred and forty-six. And Antho's voice was going hoarse, and his face had gone from grey to white, and Lex could feel through the Bloodbond how much it was costing him. Not mana. Something else. Each name was a weight. Each death was a stone laid on his chest.

CLARITY: 72 → 64 ▼ (grief)
64 → 58 ▼

"He can't hold all of them," said Seraphine quietly. She'd come out of the circle and was standing beside Lex, watching. "Not alone. He'll remember the first fifty. Maybe a hundred. And then they'll start to blur.

And then they'll be forgotten again." She bit her lip. "They need to be *written down*."

Lex turned to her. "Can you?"

"Write them? Yes. On paper." She was already pulling a notebook out of her pack. "But paper rots. Paper burns. Paper gets lost." She looked out over the Barrows. "These people have been forgotten for nine hundred years. They need something that won't be forgotten again."

[The Lattice,] said Ember suddenly.

Lex blinked.

[The Lattice keeps records. Of everyone. Every Kindling, every death. Seraphine said so.] A pause. *[But these people died before the Lattice was woven. They were never in it. They have no records. That's why they've forgotten themselves. There's nothing anywhere in the world that holds their names.]*

So?

[So she's a Lattice Scribe. She can read the records. Can she write them?]

Lex turned to Seraphine. "Can you write into the Lattice? Not on paper. Into the Lattice itself. Into its records."

Seraphine stared at him.

"I—" She stopped. "There's a skill. *Inscribe*. Every Scribe has it. It's how we annotate records in the Spire. Small things. Corrections. Cross-references. I've never—" She looked out at the dead. "It's never been used for anything like this. I don't even know if it *can*."

"Try."

Seraphine looked at him. Then she looked at Antho, standing on the causeway with the dead crowded around him, his voice cracking, his face white as bone.

She set her jaw. She pushed her spectacles up her nose. And she walked out onto the causeway and stood beside him.

"Say them again," she said quietly. "All of them. From the beginning. I'll write them down."



AND LEX HAD HIS own idea.

He'd been looking at the barrows. At the great grassy mounds rising out of the black water. Each one a grave. Each one with nothing on it at all: no stone, no marker, no name. Nine hundred years of nothing.

[What are you thinking?] said Ember.

Graves need markers, Lex thought. *Something that lasts.*

He looked down at the causeway under his feet. Ancient stone. Founders' stone. Nine hundred years old and still straight and true.

He knelt. He laid his palm flat on the grey stone. And he called a rune.

He didn't know what it was. It came up out of him the way the fourth rune had come for Anvilson, and the oath rune for Oathkeeper. From somewhere deep. A shape like a hand pressed flat against a wall. Like a mark left on a door. *I was here.* He pushed heat down into the stone through his palm, slow and steady and careful, and the rune went with it, and he felt the stone take it, the way iron takes a rune on the anvil.

And then he did something he'd never done. He *held it open.*

[Oh,] said Ember softly, understanding. *[Oh, that's clever.]*

A rune is a shape. A shape can hold something. And Lex held the rune open in the stone like a cup held out under a spring, and waited.

Out on the causeway, Antho said a name. *Tobin of the Ford.* Seraphine's lips moved, her eyes fixed on something only she could see, her hand moving in the air as if writing. And the name went into the Lattice. Lex felt it go. A tiny thread of silver, writing itself into the great ledger of the world. And then, because the rune was open and waiting, the name went into the rune as well. Into the stone. Into the causeway. Gold, glowing for an instant under Lex's palm, then sinking in.

Tobin of the Ford.

Carved into the stone. Not by a chisel. By fire, and memory, and the Lattice itself.

"Aldo," said Antho. *"A cooper's son."*

Seraphine wrote. The silver thread went into the Lattice. The gold went into the stone.

"Gavin. A fisherman."

It took all night.



LEX REMEMBERED THAT NIGHT for the rest of his life.

The mist and the black water and the cold. The dead coming one by one across the water to stand before his brother. Antho's voice, hoarse and cracked and steady, saying their names. Seraphine beside him, her face white with concentration, her hand moving in the air, writing and writing and writing. And Lex kneeling on the causeway behind them with his palm flat on the ancient stone, holding the rune open, feeling every name go into it, one after another, three hundred and forty-six of them, until the stone was warm under his hand and his arm was numb to the shoulder and his mana was nearly gone.

And Garrick, standing guard over all of them with Oathkeeper drawn. And Wren, crouched on the causeway beside Lex, holding a waterskin to his lips when he got too tired to lift his own hand. And Ashka, curled on Antho's shoulder, chirping softly to him whenever his voice faltered.

And Elric.

Elric stood at the end of the causeway all night, alone, with his back to them. Looking out at the barrows. He didn't help. He didn't speak. Once, Lex glanced up and saw that the old sorcerer's shoulders were shaking, very slightly, and wondered if he was cold. Or something else.

The last name came just before dawn.

It belonged to a woman. A tall dead soldier in corroded bronze with a great dent in her helm, who stood before Antho trembling for a long, long time before the name came.

"*Hessa*," Antho whispered. His voice was almost gone. "You followed your husband. You cut off your hair and put on his brother's armor. You found him on the second day, and he was already dead. You stayed anyway. You stayed and fought because you didn't know what else to do." He swallowed. "You wanted to go home. You never did."

Hessa, the dead woman whispered. *Hessa. I was Hessa.*

Seraphine wrote. The silver thread went into the Lattice. The gold went into the stone.

And Hessa sank into the black water, gently, like a woman lying down to sleep, and the water closed over her without a ripple.

And the Barrows were empty.



LEX TOOK HIS HAND off the causeway.

His palm left a print on the stone. Faint and gold. And all around it, spreading out along the causeway in both directions, as far as he could see in the grey dawn light, there were names. Hundreds of them. Carved into the ancient Founders' stone in a script that wasn't Wellsript and wasn't common letters but something in between, glowing faintly gold and then fading, slowly, into the grey. *Tobin of the Ford. Aldo. Gavin. Bel, who sang. Marrick. Garth. Ilyan the smith. Hessa.*

Three hundred and forty-six names, written into the road by fire.

RUNE DISCOVERED: REMEMBRANCE

"I was here."

Runic Forging → Apprentice 9

DROWNED DEAD ×346 – LAID TO REST

HIDDEN QUEST COMPLETE

THE ROLL OF THE DROWNED

Return what was taken.

+XP (shared) – substantial

LEVEL UP! Lex – Level 20

LEVEL UP! Lex – Level 21

LEVEL UP! Anthoren – Level 34

LEVEL UP! Anthoren – Level 35

LEVEL UP! Seraphine Ilvane – Level 39

LEVEL UP! Seraphine Ilvane – Level 40

SKILL UP (Antho): Grave-Speech →

Expert 1

SKILL UP (Seraphine): Inscribe →

Master 1 (!)

Seraphine sat down on the causeway very suddenly, as if her legs had been cut out from under her.

"*Master,*" she whispered. "Inscribe went to Master. It was Journeyman yesterday. It's never—nobody in the Spire has ever—" She stared at nothing. "I wrote three hundred and forty-six names into the Lattice. Into

the *permanent records*. People who've been dead for nine hundred years." She looked at Antho. "They're in it now. They're real now. Anyone with the right access could look them up." Her voice cracked. "They'll never be forgotten again."

Antho sat down beside her. He didn't say anything. He couldn't; his voice was gone. He just sat there on the causeway in the grey dawn light with his head bowed and his scarred hands hanging between his knees.

After a moment, Seraphine reached out and took one of those hands in both of hers.

He didn't pull away.



THE BARROW THRONE WAS in the center of the Drowned Barrows, as Seraphine's books had said. They reached it at midday, following the causeway out across the black water. It was the largest mound of all, as big as a hill, rising steep and grassy out of a lake of perfectly still water. And in its side, facing the causeway, there was a door.

Bronze. Green-black with age. Taller than three men. Carved all over with figures of kings and soldiers and sorcerers, worn almost smooth. And it was standing open.

"It wasn't open before," said Seraphine. "The books say it's always sealed. That no one has passed it in nine hundred years."

"Maybe it's an invitation," said Garrick.

"Maybe it's a trap," said Wren.

"In my experience," said Elric quietly, "those are frequently the same thing."

It was the first thing he'd said since dawn. They all looked at him. He was standing at the edge of the causeway, leaning heavily on his staff, looking at the open door. His face was grey and drawn. He looked older than Lex had ever seen him.

"Are you all right?" said Lex.

"Tired," said Elric. "Just tired. It was a long night." He straightened. "Let's go and meet this king."



THE HALL INSIDE THE barrow was vast, and dry, and lit by a pale green light that seemed to come from the walls themselves. It went down, and down, a great sloping passage lined with bronze-armored figures standing in niches, still as statues. Not dead. Not Drowned. Just *bones*, finally, at rest, in their armor. And at the bottom of the passage, a round chamber like the inside of an upturned bowl, and in the center of the chamber, on a throne of black stone, the Barrow-King.

He was huge. Larger than the Oracle had been, larger than the Rimewarden, a vast armored figure seated on the black throne with a two-handed sword across his knees. His armor was bronze, like his soldiers', but finer: worked all over with gold that had survived where the bronze had greened, so that he glimmered faintly in the pale light like a fish in deep water. His helm was crowned. His face, beneath it, was a skull. And in the eye sockets of the skull burned two cold points of white light.

They were looking at Lex.

THE BARROW-KING

Founders' Guardian (bound) – Level ???

SHRINE TRIAL: THE THIRD SONG

"*Vey*," said the Barrow-King.

His voice was the sound of a tomb door grinding shut.

"*Vey blood. I smell it. I have smelled it for nine hundred years, in my dreams, in the dark, under the water.*" The white lights in his eyes flared. "*The blood of the one who bound me. Who bound my kingdom, my people, my name. Who wrote us out of the world's memory with his net, so that no one would ever remember that we had stood against him.*"

He rose from his throne.

It was like watching a mountain stand up. He rose and rose, his corroded armor grinding, his crowned helm nearly scraping the domed ceiling of the chamber, the two-handed sword in his fist longer than Lex was tall.

"*And you come to my hall. Wanting a song.*"

Garrick stepped in front of Lex. Oathkeeper was in his hand, frost blooming along the blade. Wren had an arrow on the string. Antho's

shadows were stirring around his feet, though slowly, wearily. Elric raised his staff.

"No," said the Barrow-King. *"Put down your weapons. I will not fight you."*

Nobody put down their weapons.

"*I could,*" said the Barrow-King. *"I could kill every one of you. I was a sorcerer-king when your Founders were children, and I am still strong, even dead, even bound."* His white eyes moved from face to face. *"But you gave my people back their names."*

The chamber was silent.

"*I heard them,*" said the Barrow-King. *"All night. One by one. Tobin. Aldo. Gavin. Hessa. I heard them rise from the water and remember themselves and lie down to rest. My soldiers. My people. The ones who followed me into the last battle and died for a cause the Vey wrote out of history."* His voice dropped. *"I have tried for nine hundred years to remember their names. I could not. The net took them from me as it took them from the world."* The white eyes turned to Antho. *"You listened. You heard what I could not."* Then to Seraphine. *"And you wrote them where the net itself cannot erase them."* Then to Lex. *"And you, Vey—you, of all the blood—you carved them into the Founders' own road. Where every Vey who walks it will see them forever."*

He was silent for a long moment.

"*I hated your blood,*" he said at last. *"I hated it for nine hundred years. I will not pretend otherwise."* The white lights flickered. *"But you are not the one who bound me. And you have done more for my people in one night than I could do in nine centuries."*

He sank back down onto his black throne. Slowly. Like a mountain settling.

"*Hold up the stone,*" he said. *"And I will sing."*



ANTHO HELD UP THE lodestone. It was glowing grey and green, pulsing like a heartbeat.

The Barrow-King closed his skull's eyes. The white lights dimmed to faint embers.

And he sang.

It was the saddest sound Lex had ever heard. Low and slow and vast, like wind moving over a battlefield the morning after. Like the sea coming in over a plain where forty thousand men lay dead. Like a mother singing over a cradle that would never be filled again. It was the song of the dead. Of everyone who had ever been lost, and forgotten, and lain alone in the dark under the water, waiting for someone to remember their names.

And it was beautiful. That was the strangest part. Under the grief, there was something else. Something that rose. Something like the moment the last of the Drowned Dead had sunk into the water at dawn, at rest, remembered. Something like peace.

The lodestone answered.

A third light woke inside it. Not grey, not green. A deep, soft, dark blue, like water at twilight, like the sky just after the sun goes down. It wrapped around the other two. Grey and green and blue, twined together inside the little river-pebble, pulsing in time, three songs, one heartbeat.

And then the lodestone *blazed*.



IT WASN'T A GENTLE light. It was a flood. White and gold, pouring out of the little stone in Antho's hand, filling the domed chamber, so bright that Lex threw up his arm across his eyes. He heard Wren cry out. Heard Garrick swear. Felt the Bloodbond *lurch* in his chest, like a rope pulled taut.

And then, through the light, he saw something.

A chamber. Vast and round and high-domed, much larger than the Barrow-King's hall. Walls of white stone, carved with Wellsript, glowing gold. The floor was a single sheet of something clear and dark, like black glass, or still water. And in the center of the floor, rising up out of it, was a crystal.

It was enormous. Taller than a man. Clear as ice, faceted like a jewel, glowing from within with a soft pulsing light. And inside it, suspended as if floating in water, there was a man.

He was standing upright, his arms at his sides, his eyes closed. He wore a long dark coat. His face was turned slightly upward, toward the domed

ceiling. It was a lean face, lined, tired. Silver at the temples. A long straight nose. A jaw that Lex had seen in the still water of a stream a week ago, on his brother's freshly-shaven face.

And as Lex watched, the man in the crystal opened his eyes.

They were grey.

They looked straight at him. Through the vision. Through the light. Through whatever impossible distance lay between the Barrow-King's hall and wherever that chamber was. They looked at him, and they *saw* him, and something moved in them. Something that went into Lex like a hot nail.

The man's lips moved. No sound came. But Lex could read them. He didn't know how. He just could.

Lexander.

Then the grey eyes moved. Past Lex. To his brother.

Anthoren.

Then they closed again.

And the light went out.



LEX WAS ON HIS knees on the floor of the Barrow-King's hall. He didn't remember falling. Antho was beside him, on his knees too, the lodestone clutched in his fist against his chest. It was glowing softly now, grey and green and blue, pulsing like a slow heart.

Neither of them could speak.

LODESTONE OF RETURN

Songs held: 3 / 3

- ◆ The Song of Stone
- ◆ The Song of Leaves
- ◆ The Song of the Dead

THE WAY MAY BE CALLED.

Seek the waters that hold the sky.

MAIN QUEST UPDATED: The Lost Father

- ◆ The Barrow Throne DONE
- ◇ Seek the waters that hold the sky
- ◇ The Way opens to two of the blood

[Lex,] said Ember.

Its voice was very strange. Not dry. Not calm. Not courteous. It sounded like something cracking open.

[*That was him. That was him*. I saw him. Through your eyes. And I—*]* It stopped. [*I know him. I know that face. I know it the way you know your own hands. I've known it all along. I've been looking out through it.*]

MEMORY PARTITION 4 ... UNLOCKED

[*Oh,*] Ember whispered. [*Oh. Oh, Lex. I'm so sorry. I'm so sorry I left.*]

Lex knelt on the cold floor of the Barrow-King's hall with tears running down his face, and his brother's hand gripping his shoulder hard enough to bruise, and a voice in his head that was weeping.

And somewhere above him, on his black throne, the Barrow-King spoke again. Quietly. Almost gently.

"He is alive, your father. But he is very tired. He has held the net together alone for longer than any man should hold anything." The white lights in the skull's eyes flickered. *"Go to him quickly, children of the blood. And go carefully."*

He looked up. Past Lex and Antho, past Garrick and Wren and Seraphine, to the back of the chamber, where Elric Thorne stood in the shadows by the passage, leaning on his staff, his face unreadable in the pale green light.

And then the Barrow-King's gaze moved, slowly, across all of them. Every face. One by one.

"For one who walks beside you," the dead king said softly, *"counts your steps for another."*

The white lights in his eyes went out.

And the Barrow-King was still.

CHAPTER 16

WHAT THE DEAD REMEMBER



NOBODY SPOKE ON THE way out of the barrow.

They climbed the long sloping passage in silence, past the bronze-armored bones standing at rest in their niches, and came out through the great green-black door into the late afternoon. The mist had lifted. The black water lay still and flat all around the mound, reflecting a pale washed sky, and across it, the causeway ran away south, back the way they'd come, and on its grey stones, if you knew where to look, you could see the faint gold traces of three hundred and forty-six names.

Lex sat down on the causeway at the foot of the barrow and put his head in his hands.

He felt the others settling around him. Garrick, lowering himself onto the stones with a grunt. Wren, crouching beside him, not touching. Seraphine, sitting down with her back against the bronze door, pulling her knees up to her chest. Antho, standing at the edge of the causeway looking out over the water with the lodestone glowing softly in his fist.

And Elric. Lex didn't look up. But he heard the tap of the staff on the stone, and felt the old sorcerer stop a little way off.

For one who walks beside you counts your steps for another.

Nobody said it. But it was sitting in the middle of all of them like a stone dropped into still water, and the ripples were spreading.



IT WAS ELRIC WHO broke the silence. Of course it was.

"We should talk about what the king said," he said quietly.

Nobody answered.

"I know it's hard. I know none of you want to." Elric leaned on his staff. "But a warning like that, from a guardian like that, in a place like that, is not something to ignore. The dead see things the living can't." He paused. "And he was looking at someone when he said it."

"He was looking at all of us," said Wren sharply.

"At the end, yes. He looked at everyone." Elric's voice was very gentle. "But when he started. When he said the first words. Where were his eyes?"

Silence.

Lex lifted his head. He thought back. The Barrow-King, vast on his black throne, the white lights in his skull burning. He'd looked past Lex and Antho. Past Garrick and Wren. Toward the back of the chamber.

Toward Elric, standing in the shadows by the passage.

And Seraphine, standing beside him.

"I think we all know," said Elric softly, "who stood at the back of that room."

Seraphine had gone white. She was staring at Elric with her mouth slightly open, her hands tight around her knees.

"You stood at the back of the room too," said Garrick. His voice was very level. "Right beside her."

"I did," Elric agreed. "So I'm a suspect too. Of course I am. I'd expect nothing less." He spread his knotted hands. "I'm not accusing anyone. I'm asking us to think. Who among us came out of nowhere? Who among us has secrets we don't know? Who among us has a reason to be watched?" He looked at Seraphine. Not unkindly. Almost sadly. "Who among us fled the Spire two years ago with stolen codices, and has never once explained how she got past the vault wards?"

"I—" Seraphine's voice cracked. "I *told* you. I went to the archives at night. I always went at night—"

"To the general archives. Yes. But the sealed vault isn't the general archives. The sealed vault has wards on it that would take a Tier Three Warden an hour to dismantle. You're a Tier Two Scribe." Elric's voice didn't rise. "So who opened them for you?"

Seraphine opened her mouth. Nothing came out.

"Enough."

It was Antho. He'd turned from the water. His face was very pale, but his voice was steady, and the shadows around his feet were stirring.

"She sat with me all night," he said. "On that causeway. While I said their names. Three hundred and forty-six of them." He took a step toward Elric. "She wrote every single one into the Lattice. Her hand was shaking by the end. Her voice was gone. She didn't stop." Another step. "Where were *you*?"

Elric didn't move. "At the end of the causeway. Keeping watch."

"With your back to us."

"Someone had to watch the water."

"For *eight hours*?"

"Antho," said Lex quietly.

His brother stopped. He stood there on the causeway, a few paces from Elric, breathing hard. The shadows had risen up around his ankles like black water.

CLARITY: 68 → 61 ▼

Elric looked at him for a long moment.

"You're right to be angry," the old sorcerer said quietly. "You're right to defend her. She was brave last night. Very brave." He turned his head and looked out over the black water, at the faint gold names on the causeway. "I didn't help, it's true. I couldn't. I don't have Grave-Speech, and I'm not a Scribe, and I'm not a Vey." He was quiet for a moment. "And I'll admit it was hard for me to watch. I've been to many battlefields. I've left many dead behind me, unburied, unnamed. Hearing those names last night..." He stopped. Swallowed. "Some of us have more to remember than others."

Nobody said anything.

"I'm not asking anyone to leave," Elric said. "I'm only asking you to be careful. That's all. We're very close now. Closer than anyone has been to Arion in sixteen years." He looked at Lex. "Whoever the king was warning us about, they'll make their move soon. If they're going to make it at all."

He turned and walked away down the causeway, slowly, leaning on his staff. A little way off, he stopped and sat down on the stones with his back to them, and looked out at the water.



SERAPHINE WAS CRYING.

She was trying not to. She'd pressed her face into her knees and her shoulders were shaking and she wasn't making any sound at all. Antho went and sat down next to her. He didn't touch her. He just sat there.

"I didn't do anything," she whispered into her knees. "I swear I didn't. I don't know how the vault wards came down. They just—they were *down*, that night. I thought it was a mistake. I thought someone had forgotten to set them. I didn't ask. I just went in." She lifted her face. It was blotched and wet behind her spectacles. "I've thought about it a hundred times. Why were they down? Who left them down? I don't *know*."

"I believe you," said Antho.

"He's right, though. Isn't he? I don't have any proof. I can't explain it." She looked at Lex. "I should go. I should go back to the Archive. If there's a chance it's me, if someone's using me somehow without my knowing—"

"No," said Lex.

"Lex—"

"No." He stood up. He was tired, bone-tired, more tired than he'd been in his life. His arm still ached from holding the rune open all night. But he stood up anyway. "You're not going anywhere. Neither is anyone else."

He looked around at them. Wren, crouched on the causeway with her bow across her knees. Garrick, sitting with Oathkeeper laid across his lap. Antho and Seraphine, side by side against the bronze door. And Elric, alone, a little way off, his back to them.

"The dead king said someone's counting our steps for someone else," he said. "Fine. Maybe that's true. Maybe someone is. But I'm not going to start picking people off one at a time and sending them away on a *maybe*." He took a breath. "Ember told me something, after the hounds came. When I asked who to trust." He looked at Seraphine. "It said trust the people who stood next to you in the dark. When it counted. Who were there."

Seraphine stared at him.

"You were there," said Lex. "Last night. You stood next to my brother all night and wrote three hundred and forty-six dead people back into the world. I don't care how the vault wards came down. I care about that."

Nobody said anything for a moment.

Then Wren stood up, and slung her bow over her shoulder, and walked over to Seraphine, and held out her hand.

"Up you get, Spectacles," she said. "You're sitting on the only dry rock."

Seraphine looked up at her. Then, slowly, she took the hand, and let Wren pull her up.

"*Spectacles*," she repeated, wiping her eyes. "Is that—is that my name now?"

"It means she likes you," said Antho.



THEY CAMPED THAT NIGHT on the causeway, a mile south of the Barrow Throne, at a place where the old Founders' stone widened into a sort of platform with a low wall around it. Garrick built a fire. Wren went off along the causeway and came back an hour later with two fat eels from the black water, which she swore were safe to eat and which nobody else was entirely sure about. They ate them anyway. They were surprisingly good.

Elric sat a little apart, as he had all afternoon. He ate his eel in silence, and then took Quill on his wrist and walked off a little way along the causeway into the dark.

Lex lay on his back by the fire and looked up at the stars.

Ember, he thought.

The voice didn't answer at once. It hadn't said much since the Barrow-King's hall. Since the vision. Since it had wept in his head.

[I'm here,] it said at last. Very quietly.

Are you all right?

A long pause.

[I don't know,] Ember said. *[I don't know if I can be all right. I don't know if I'm the kind of thing that can be.]* Another pause. *[Partition four opened, when I saw his face. I can see more now. Remember more. Not everything. But more.]*

What do you remember?

Ember was quiet for a long time. When it spoke again, its voice was different. Slower. More careful. Like someone feeling their way along a dark passage.

[I remember a cottage,] it said. [A storm. Two children asleep in a loft. A woman with flour on her cheek, holding a lantern.] A pause. [I remember a silver needle and a pot of ash-ink. I remember putting a seal on a little boy who fought it, who was four years old and fought it like a cat fighting a sack.] Another pause. [I remember being afraid. So afraid. Of the Order. Of the thing in the east. Of something else, something I can't see, something behind a partition that's still locked.]

Lex lay very still.

[And I remember,] said Ember, [reaching inside myself. Into the place where I was. And cutting off a piece. A small piece. The width of a fingernail paring. And pressing it into the seal like a maker's mark into hot iron.] Its voice was barely a whisper now. [Watch him. Wake when the seal wakes. Guide him. Tell him what I couldn't.]

The fire crackled. Somewhere out on the black water, a fish jumped.

[That piece was me,] said Ember. [I'm what he cut off. I'm what he left on the anvil.]

Lex didn't say anything for a long time.

Are you him? he asked at last. *Are you my father?*

[No,] said Ember. And then, more slowly: [No. I don't think so. I'm a piece of him. A sliver. Some of his memories. Some of his habits. His patience, maybe. His jokes. The way he makes tea.] A pause. [I think he took the part of himself that was a father, and gave it to you, so you'd have one even if he couldn't be there. But I'm not him. He's in that crystal. He's whole. Or as whole as a man can be, after cutting pieces out of himself.]

Lex stared up at the stars.

So you're the part of him that stayed, he said.

Ember didn't answer for a long, long time.

[Yes,] it said at last, and its voice cracked down the middle. [Yes. I suppose I am.]

They didn't say anything else after that. They didn't need to.



LATER, MUCH LATER, ANTHO came and lay down beside him.

He didn't say anything. He just lay down on the stones, a hand's width away, and looked up at the stars too. Ashka crawled out of his coat and curled up in the space between them, chirping softly, and went to sleep.

"He said my name," said Antho at last, very quietly. "In the vision. He looked at me and said my name."

"I know."

"He hasn't said my name in fifteen years." Antho's voice was steady. Too steady. "The last time he said it, I was nine years old and half asleep, and he was putting a seal on me. *If it ever breaks, you look after him. You're his big brother. You look after him.*" He laughed, very softly. "And I said *I always do.* And then it broke, and he wasn't there, and I didn't look after anyone."

"You did," said Lex. "In the Thornwood. On the causeway last night. You've been looking after all of us."

Antho didn't answer that.

"When I see him," he said instead, "when we get there, when he's standing in front of me, I'm going to ask him why." His voice dropped. "Why mine wasn't strong enough. Why he made yours so it would hold for fifteen years, and made mine so it would break the first time it was tested. Why he left me to find out what was under it alone, in front of the whole village, with Mam standing there." He swallowed. "I want to know if he knew. If he *knew* it would break. If he decided I was the one who could be risked."

Lex turned his head and looked at his brother. In the dim firelight, Antho's face was all hollows and shadows, his grey eyes fixed on the stars.

"Maybe he didn't know," said Lex.

"Maybe." Antho was quiet for a moment. "But I'd rather hear him say it."



IN THE MORNING, SERAPHINE told them where they were going.

"*The waters that hold the sky,*" she said, sitting by the rekindled fire with a book open on her knees. "It's in the old texts. Over and over. It's what the Founders called Mirrormere." She turned the book around so they could

see. A map. The northern half of Aldermere, the Greyspine curving across it like a spine, and then, north and east of the mountains, beyond a great blank stretch marked only with tiny drawings of trees and hills, a lake. Long and narrow and shaped like a teardrop. "The Lake of Glass. The books say it's so still, it holds the sky perfectly. You can't tell where the water ends and the air begins." She tapped the map. "That's where Avaloria stands. On an island in the middle. Where only those of the blood can find it."

"How far?" said Garrick.

Seraphine traced a line with her finger. "From here? North and east. Through the Fells, here, and then around the northern arm of the Greyspine, here." She paused. "Three weeks, maybe. Four. If we're careful."

"And if we're not careful," said Wren, "if we take the roads?"

"Two weeks. But we'd pass within a day's ride of Highcrest." Seraphine looked up. "And there's a thousand crowns on each of your heads, and two thousand on mine."

There was a silence around the fire.

"We need supplies," said Garrick at last. "Real ones. Not eels and dried hare. Seraphine's boots are coming apart. Wren's down to six arrows. My armor's held together with string." He looked at Lex. "And you've got a pile of iron and a smith's book full of runes and no forge to put them in."

"I want to go to Highcrest," said Wren.

They all looked at her.

"My mam," she said. Her jaw was tight. "I sent the money with Hilde. I told her to take Mam down to Highcrest, to the physic on Fennel Street. If she made it, she'll be there now." She looked down at her hands. "I want to know if she made it. I want to know if the physic could help." She lifted her chin. "I know it's dangerous. I know it's stupid. I want to go anyway."

"My daughter's in Highcrest," said Garrick quietly. "Elowen. If she's still with the Silver Lattice." He turned Oathkeeper over in his hands. "I haven't seen her in six years. I wasn't going to. I didn't think I had the right." He looked at the sword. "But I've got a new oath now. And I'd like her to know her father isn't a drunk anymore. Even if she never wants to see me again."

"And I," said Elric, from the far side of the fire, "have friends in Highcrest. People who can get us supplies without asking questions, and hide us for a few days without anyone the wiser." He looked at Lex. "And there's someone at the Spire I need to speak to. Someone who may know what's waiting for us at Avaloria. What your father's been doing there. What we'll have to do to get him out."

"At the *Spire*?" said Seraphine sharply. "You want to go *into* the Spire?"

"Not into it, girl. Near it. Very carefully." Elric smiled faintly. "I've been not-being-noticed by the Spire for longer than you've been alive. I'm rather good at it."

Lex looked around the fire. At all of them.

Wren, with her jaw set and her eyes bright. Garrick, with his father's sword across his knees. Seraphine, pale and frightened and stubborn. Antho, silent, with the lodestone glowing softly at his throat and Ashka asleep in his lap.

And Elric, smiling faintly across the fire, his storm-grey eyes unreadable.

[It's dangerous,] said Ember quietly. *[Very dangerous.]*

I know.

[But they need it. All of them. Not just the supplies.] A pause. *[Sometimes people need to go home before they can go on.]*

"Highcrest," said Lex.



HE SPENT HIS POINTS that afternoon.

He did it sitting on the low wall of the causeway, with his status open in front of him and the black water stretching away on every side. Twelve points. Two levels' worth. He'd only gotten them the night before.

[You're doing it,] said Ember. It sounded startled. *[Right away. Without being asked.]*

I'm learning.

[Clearly.] A pause. *[Should I be worried? Is this a sign of fever?]*

Lex snorted. He put two into Might, two into Agility, three into Vitality, three into Spirit, two into Resolve, and felt them settle into him like hot iron settling into a mold.

LEX VEY – Emberwright, Level 21		
MIG 37	AGI 36	VIT 45
INT 33	SPI 83	RES 35
Health	450/450	
Mana	830/830	
ROOT		
Seal integrity: 31%		
Authority: 34 / 100		
Prerogatives: True Sight		
	Sanction	[LOCKED]
	Unbind	[LOCKED]

He looked at the last lines for a long time.

Seal integrity: 31%. It had been fifty-eight on the night of the gloamhounds. It was falling. Slowly. Steadily. Every week a little lower.

Like a house getting thinner.

[He's getting weaker,] said Ember quietly. *[Your father. Every week. The seal's falling because he's falling.]*

How long?

[I don't know.] A long pause. *[Not long.]*

Lex closed his status. He sat on the low wall and looked north, toward the far horizon, where the Drowned Barrows gave way to grey hills and beyond them, somewhere, mountains and a lake that held the sky.

Then we'd better hurry, he thought.



THAT NIGHT, HE WOKE for no reason.

The fire had burned to embers. The others were asleep: Wren curled under her blanket with her bow beside her, Garrick snoring softly with his back against the wall, Seraphine and Antho a little way apart on the far side of the fire, Ashka a small dark coil between them. The stars were very bright over the black water.

Elric wasn't there.

Lex lay still and listened. And after a moment, he heard it: a soft murmur of voice, off in the dark along the causeway. And the rustle of wings.

He got up quietly. He didn't take Anvilson. He walked along the causeway in the starlight, placing his feet carefully on the ancient stones, until he could see a shape ahead: a tall thin figure in a grey cloak, standing at the edge of the causeway, with a raven on its outstretched wrist.

Elric was talking to Quill. Low and urgent. Lex couldn't make out the words. He saw the old sorcerer tie something to the raven's leg, a small rolled slip of paper. He saw him lift his wrist.

And Quill flew.

Not south, toward Highcrest. Not north, toward Mirrormere.
East.

The raven rose into the starlit sky on silent black wings and turned and flew east, out over the drowned barrows, toward the far dark horizon where, weeks and weeks away, beyond the Fells and the eastern march, the Blightmarch lay grey and silent under the same stars.

Lex stood very still on the causeway.

Elric lowered his arm. He stood for a long moment looking after the raven. Then he turned, and saw Lex standing in the starlight twenty paces away, and went very still himself.

For a long moment, neither of them moved.

"Couldn't sleep?" said Elric at last. His voice was perfectly calm.

"No."

"Nor could I." The old sorcerer came back along the causeway, slowly, leaning on his staff. "I was sending word to a friend. In Saltreach. Someone who may be able to help us in Highcrest." He stopped beside Lex. His face in the starlight was lined and tired and perfectly composed. "Quill knows the way. He'll be back in a few days."

Lex looked at him.

Saltreach is west, he thought. Quill flew east.

He didn't say it. He didn't know why he didn't say it. Something in him said *wait*. Something in him said *don't let him know you saw*. Something in him that sounded very much like Wren, saying: *When something smells wrong, you don't wait to find out why. You just get ready.*

"Good," said Lex. "That's good."

"Go back to sleep, lad." Elric put a hand on his shoulder, briefly, and then let it fall. "We've a long way to go tomorrow."

He walked on past Lex toward the fire.

Lex stood alone on the causeway for a long time after, looking east into the dark where the raven had gone.

[Lex,] said Ember, very softly. [Saltreach is west.]

I know.

[He knows you know. I think. He saw your face.]

I know that too.

Ember was quiet for a long moment.

[What are you going to do?]

Lex looked down at the causeway under his feet. In the starlight, very faintly, he could see the gold traces of a name carved into the ancient stone. *Hessa*. Who'd followed her husband to war, and found him dead on the second day, and stayed and fought anyway, because she didn't know what else to do.

Keep walking, Lex thought. And watch.

He went back to the fire and lay down. But he didn't sleep again that night. And across the embers, wrapped in his grey cloak with his back to the others, Elric Thorne didn't sleep either.

CHAPTER 17

HIGHCREST



HIGHCREST ROSE OUT OF the morning mist like a ship out of fog.

Lex had heard about it his whole life. Everyone in the Vale had. The capital of Caldor, the seat of kings, the city on the crag. He'd imagined it a hundred times, lying awake in the loft above the forge. None of his imagining had come close.

It was built on a mountain. Not on top of one: *on* it, all over it, climbing up its sides in terraces and tiers, street above street, roof above roof, the way ivy climbs a wall. At the bottom, where the mountain's skirts spread out into the river valley, the buildings were low and crowded and dark, timber and thatch and mud brick, smoke rising from a thousand chimneys into the grey sky. Higher up they grew taller, and paler, and finer: stone houses with slate roofs, then mansions with gardens, then great halls with columns and domes. And at the very top, on the summit of the crag, two things stood above everything else.

One was a castle. Grey and massive and many-towered, flying a blue banner with a silver crown.

The other was a tower. White. Impossibly tall, impossibly slender, rising from the summit beside the castle like a needle stuck into the sky. Taller than the castle. Taller than anything Lex had ever seen or imagined. And at the very top of it, so high that it seemed to be touching the clouds, there was a light. Silver-blue. Pulsing slowly. Like a heartbeat.

"The Spire," said Seraphine quietly. She'd stopped on the road beside him. Her face was pale. "And the Great Stone."

The Veil lay thick around the city. Thicker than Lex had ever seen it, even in the deepest hollows of the Vale. It swirled around the base of the white tower in great slow silver spirals, drawn toward it like water toward a drain. The whole city glimmered faintly through it, as if seen through gauze.

"Six years," said Garrick softly, on his other side. He was looking up at the castle, at the blue banner. His scarred face was unreadable. "Six years."

"Hoods up," said Elric. "Everyone. And remember: we're a merchant's family from the Fells, come to sell wool at the autumn market. I'm the grandfather. Lex, you're my grandson. Antho, you're his cousin. Wren, you're his betrothed."

Wren choked.

"Seraphine, you're a hired clerk. Garrick, you're our guard. Keep your sword wrapped." Elric looked at Antho. "And keep that dragon *in your pack*."

Ashka, poking her head out of the top of Antho's satchel, hissed.

"She doesn't like the pack," said Antho.

"She'll like a Warden's crossbow bolt even less." Elric pulled his own hood up over his grey hair. "Come on. And for the Lady's sake, nobody use any magic until we're off the street."



THEY WENT IN THROUGH a gate in the lower city that wasn't really a gate. It was a gap in an old wall behind a tannery, where the stink was so overpowering that no Warden ever came near it, and an old woman with no teeth sat on a stool and took a copper penny from each of them without looking up. Beyond it, the Lower Town closed around them like a fist.

Lex had never seen so many people in one place. The streets were narrow and crooked and steep, climbing up the side of the mountain in switchbacks and stairways, and every one of them was packed. Porters with loads on their backs. Women with baskets. Children everywhere, barefoot, darting between legs. Beggars on corners. Hawkers shouting. Carts jammed in alleyways too narrow for them, their drivers swearing. The noise was tremendous. The smell was worse: smoke and sewage and cooking and

sweat and animals, all mixed together into a thick warm fug that hung in the air like the Veil.

And everywhere, on every wall, on every door, nailed to every post, there were notices.

Lex saw the first one on the wall beside the tannery gate and stopped dead. Wren ran into the back of him.

It was printed on cheap grey paper, already peeling at the edges. Across the top, the silver lattice of the Wardens. And below it, two faces. Badly drawn. One was a young man with curly hair and a heavy jaw. The other was a gaunt bearded man with wild eyes. Neither of them looked much like Lex or Antho. But the names underneath were very clear.

**WANTED – BY ORDER OF THE SPIRE
WILDCASTERS**

ALEXANDER HARROW, 19
ANTHOREN HARROW, 24
("The Ashbourne Warlock")

1,000 CROWNS EACH – ALIVE
Report sightings to any Warden.

"They spelled my name right," said Antho. "That's something."

"Keep walking," said Elric through his teeth.

They kept walking. Up the crooked stairs, through the jostling crowds, past notice after notice after notice. Lex's face, Antho's face, and once, on the door of a tavern, Seraphine's: a thin, narrow, spectacled face with *SERAPHINE ILVANE – THIEF – 2,000 CROWNS* printed beneath it in large letters. Seraphine pulled her hood lower and walked faster.

And there were Wardens. Not many. Pairs of them, in grey cloaks, standing on corners and at the tops of stairways, watching the crowds with cold eyes. Each time they passed a pair, Lex felt his heart stop, and kept his head down, and kept walking. Each time, nothing happened.

"Nearly there," muttered Elric. "Nearly there."



ELRIC'S FRIEND KEPT A chandlery on a crooked lane halfway up the Lower Town, in a narrow building of blackened timber that leaned against

its neighbors like a drunk against a wall. A painted sign over the door showed a candle and a bell. Inside, it was dim and cramped and smelled of tallow and beeswax and lamp oil. And behind the counter, polishing a brass lantern with one hand, stood the largest woman Lex had ever seen.

She was taller than Garrick. Broader than Brannoc. Her grey hair was cropped short as a soldier's, and her face was broad and red and seamed, and her left sleeve was pinned up empty at the elbow. She looked up as they came in, and her small sharp eyes went over all of them, one by one, and stopped on Elric.

"Thorne," she said. Her voice was like gravel in a bucket.

"Hedda."

"You said a few days. That was three weeks ago."

"I was delayed."

"You're always delayed." Hedda set down the lantern. Her eyes moved to Lex, then to Antho, then to Seraphine. They narrowed. "These are the ones on the notices."

"Yes."

"You brought the Ashbourne warlock into my *shop*."

"Yes."

"And the archivist thief."

"Yes."

Hedda Vorne looked at Elric Thorne for a long moment. Then she let out a long gusty breath through her nose, like a bellows.

"Back room," she said. "Now. Before someone sees you." She lifted the hinged section of the counter. "And if that's a dragon I see in the boy's pack, it stays off my shelves. I've got a hundred crowns of beeswax up there."



THE BACK ROOM WAS a forge.

Lex stopped in the doorway and stared. He couldn't help it. After weeks of heating iron with his bare hands on flat rocks in the wilderness, it was like walking into a cathedral. A real forge, a big brick hearth with a hood and a chimney. A real anvil, a good one, heavy and square and worn smooth on top by years of use. Racks of tools on the walls: tongs and

hammers and chisels and punches and swages. A slack tub. A grinding wheel. Bins of charcoal and coal. Bar-stock stacked in the corner, good iron and steel, more than he'd ever seen in one place outside Brannoc's best Saltreach shipment.

"Lady of Lanterns," he breathed.

Hedda had come in behind him. She was looking at him with an odd expression.

"You're the smith," she said. It wasn't a question.

"Yes."

"Thorne said there was a smith." She looked at the hammer on his shoulder. Then, slowly, she reached out with her one hand and touched Anvilson's head. She held her fingers there for a long moment. Her eyebrows went up. "It's *warm*."

"It stays warm."

"Runes," said Hedda. She ran her thumb over the four marks on the hammer's head. "Real ones. Not paint. Not etching." She looked up at him. "I was a Warden armorer for twenty-two years, boy. I made blades for knights and Inquisitors. I put Lattice-enchancements on steel with scrolls and ink and a year's training for every one." She took her hand away. "I never once made anything that was *warm*."

"Hedda was the best armorer the Spire ever had," said Elric from the doorway. "Until a Gloamed knight took her arm off, eight years ago, in the first clearing of the eastern march. The Order pensioned her off with half pay and a thank-you note."

"A very nice note," said Hedda drily. "Good paper." She looked at Lex. "You can use the forge. While you're here. I don't use it much anymore." She glanced at her empty sleeve. "Hard to hold the tongs and the hammer at the same time."

"Thank you," said Lex. He meant it more than he could say.

Hedda shrugged her massive shoulders. "Make something worth looking at," she said. "That's all the thanks I want."



HE MADE A GREAT many things worth looking at.

They stayed in Hedda's back rooms for four days, hidden, while Elric went out each morning and came back each evening with news and supplies, and Lex worked. He worked from first light until late into the night. Hedda's forge roared and her anvil rang, and the sound of it was covered by the roar and ring of a hundred other forges in the Lower Town, so nobody noticed one more.

He made arrows for Wren. Fifty of them, with good steel heads he forged himself, and on every head, the rune *Knit* so they wouldn't break, and on ten of them, using a sliver of the Rimewarden's heart, the cold rune from the *Book of Making* that would freeze whatever they struck. He made her a new hunting knife, too, with a blade like a leaf and a handle wrapped in leather, and the rune *True* struck into the steel near the hilt, so it would always find the place she aimed it.

He made a new prod for Seraphine's crossbow, steel instead of horn, and a new trigger mechanism that wouldn't let her load the bolt upside down. She looked at it for a long time when he gave it to her, and then said, very primly, *that is a very thoughtful modification*, and went red to the ears.

He mended Garrick's armor. Every dent, every patch, every strip of leather and length of string. He reforged the worst of the plates and riveted them back in place and struck *Bulwark* into the breastplate where it would sit over the old knight's heart. Garrick stood in the forge while Lex fitted it to him, and moved his arms, and twisted, and stamped, and then looked down at himself and said quietly, *my father had armor like this. When I was a boy. I used to polish it for him.*

And he made two things for his brother.

The first was a lantern.

He'd been thinking about it since the Hollowmaw. Since the hundreds of unlit lanterns hanging in the dark. Since he'd seen Antho's face light up with Seren's lamp burning in his hands. He'd found the rune he needed in the *Book of Making*, on the third night, with Ember reading the notes aloud to him by candlelight. [*Hush,*] Ember had said. [*A rune of silence. For bells that ring too loud, or dogs that bark too much, or—*] A pause. [*Or voices that won't stop. Lex. Look at this.*]

He made it out of black iron, small enough to hang from a belt: a lantern-shaped cage, with a little glass chimney he begged off Hedda's

shelves. Inside, where the wick should go, he struck *Ardent*, so it would burn without fuel. And on the iron frame, all around it, he struck *Hush*. Over and over. Twelve times. One for every ward-nail in the Hollowmaw.

He gave it to Antho on the fourth evening, in the back room, by the light of the forge.

Antho took it and turned it over in his long scarred hands. He looked at the little flame burning inside the glass. He looked at the runes on the frame.

"What does it do?" he said.

"Light it," said Lex. "Hang it on your belt. And tell me what you hear."

Antho looked at him. Then he hooked the lantern onto his belt, and stood very still, with his eyes closed.

Lex watched the red panel only he could see.

CLARITY: 74 → 81 ▲

81 → 87 ▲



— DAMPENED

Antho's eyes flew open.

"Lex," he whispered.

"What do you hear?"

"Nothing." His brother's voice cracked. "It's—it's still there. I can feel it. But it's like—like someone shouting through a wall. Through a thick wall. Far away." He put his hand on the lantern. "It's *quiet*."

ITEM CREATED

THE KEEPER'S LANTERN

Focus — Grade: MASTERWORK

Maker: Lex Vey, Emberwright

Runes:

ARDENT — burns without fuel

HUSH x12 — dampens Hollow voices

Clarity floor: +15

Clarity decay: -40%

Shadow focus: Hollow powers cost

less Clarity to wield

"For the one who keeps the door."

Antho didn't say anything. He stood in the forge-light with his hand on the little iron lantern and his eyes very bright, and after a moment he turned away and went and stood in the corner with his back to the room, and his shoulders were shaking.

Seraphine got up from the table where she'd been reading and went and stood beside him. She didn't say anything either. She just put her hand on his arm.

The second thing was for Ashka.

It took him two whole days. It was the most delicate work he'd ever done. Far more delicate than Wren's bow, or Seren's lamp. He used silver wire, thin as thread, that Hedda had in a drawer, and he worked it on the very tip of the anvil with the smallest hammer in the forge, so small it looked like a toy in his hand. He shaped it into a frame. A lattice of fine silver strands, light as a cobweb, curved to follow the line of the little dragon's torn wing. And on every joint of the frame, he struck a rune so small he had to use a jeweler's lens Hedda lent him to see it. *Knit*, to hold it together. *Steadfast*, so it wouldn't break. And *Homeward*, so that whatever happened, it would always come back to the place it belonged.

Ashka sat on the workbench and watched him the whole time, her golden eyes enormous, her head tilting first one way and then the other.

When he fitted it to her wing, she held perfectly still. He slid it over the torn membrane and the twisted bones, gently, gently, and fastened it at the shoulder with a tiny silver clasp. The frame settled against the wing like a second skeleton, supporting it, holding the torn edges in place.

Ashka spread her wings.

Both of them. The whole one, and the torn one in its silver cage. For the first time since Lex had known her, they opened together, wide and blue-grey and shimmering in the forge-light. She looked at the torn wing. She flexed it. The silver frame flexed with it, perfectly, as if it had grown there.

She made a sound Lex had never heard her make. Not a chirp. Not a trill. A long, high, wavering *cry*, like a hawk's. And she leaped off the workbench.

She didn't fall. She *glided*. Across the forge, wings spread, her silver-framed wing catching the air, her whip of a tail streaming out behind.

She didn't fly, not really. She couldn't flap the torn wing hard enough for that. But she glided all the way across the room and landed on Antho's shoulder with a thump, and stood there with her wings still spread, crying out again and again, sparks crackling all down her spine like a little storm.

Antho was staring at her. Then at Lex.

"She's never—" he started. "Not since the bolt. Not once in four years. She'd try, and she'd fall, and she'd—" He stopped. His voice was gone.

Ashka folded her wings. She turned her narrow head and looked across the forge at Lex with her golden eyes. And then a picture came into his head, sent from her, sharp and bright and overwhelming. *Sky. Wind. Up, up, up. Antho on the ground, small, far below. Lightning. FREE.*

Same blood, she sent. Same blood. Thank you. Thank you. Same blood.

Runic Forging → Journeyman 1

TITLE EARNED: Dragon-Friend

Beasts of the old world regard
you kindly.



ON THE SECOND DAY, Wren went to Fennel Street.

Lex went with her. Elric didn't like it. Elric said it was too dangerous, too exposed, that the Wardens would be watching the physics' houses for exactly this reason. Wren looked at him without expression and said, *I'm going*, and went. And Lex went after her, with his hood up and Anvilsong wrapped in sacking over his shoulder like a sack of tools.

The physic's house was a narrow stone building in a street of narrow stone buildings, a few tiers up from Hedda's lane, where the Lower Town began to give way to something cleaner and quieter. There was a brass plate on the door. MASTER ODO FENWICK, PHYSIC. And on the step, sitting in the thin autumn sunshine with a small boy on either side of her, there was a woman.

She was thin. Very thin, with a grey shawl around her shoulders and grey threaded through her red hair. She was coughing, a dry harsh cough that shook her whole body. But when it passed, she lifted her head, and her face was Wren's face, twenty-five years older, freckled and sharp and fierce.

Wren stopped in the middle of the street.

The woman on the step looked up. She saw Wren. And her whole face changed.

"*Wrennie*," she said.

Wren ran.

Lex stood in the street and watched her go. He watched her fall to her knees on the step and throw her arms around her mother, and the two small boys pile on top of them both, shouting, *Wren! Wren! Wren's back!* He watched her mother hold her and rock her and cough and laugh and cry all at once. He watched Wren, who never cried, who'd stood in the clearing at the heart of the Thornwood and looked at the Ceiling without a tear, press her face into her mother's shoulder and sob like a child.

He stayed where he was. It wasn't his to be part of.

After a while, Wren's mother looked up over her daughter's head. Her eyes found Lex, standing in the street with his hood up and a sack of tools on his shoulder. She looked at him for a long moment.

"So," she said. Her voice was rough. "You must be the Hammer."

Lex felt his face go hot. "Yes, ma'am."

"Come here, then. Let me look at you."

He went. He stood at the bottom of the step while Wren's mother looked him up and down with Wren's sharp green eyes. The two little boys had stopped shouting and were staring at him too. The older one had Wren's freckles. The younger one had a gap where his front teeth should be.

"Maren Ashdown," said Wren's mother. "And these are Tam and Robbie. And you're the one who paid my daughter four times what she asked, all in advance, and then took her off on some mad quest to find your father instead of letting her come home." She coughed. "Hilde told me everything. Brought us down here herself on the mule train. Paid for the first week with Master Fenwick out of your money before I could stop her."

"I'm sorry," said Lex. "About taking her. I tried to make her go home. She wouldn't."

"No," said Maren Ashdown. "She wouldn't." Something moved at the corner of her mouth. "She never would. Not once in her whole life." She

looked at her daughter, who was sitting beside her now, wiping her eyes, glaring at Lex as if daring him to mention it. "Is she being looked after?"

"She's looking after *me*, mostly," said Lex.

Maren laughed. It turned into a cough, and the cough went on for a long time, and when it stopped, she had to lean on Wren's shoulder.

"Master Fenwick says it's slowed," she said, when she could speak again. "The grey-lung. He's got me on some foul tea that tastes like a goat's armpit, and he says it's slowed. Not stopped. Not cured. But slowed." She looked at Lex. "He says there's no curing it. Not while the black stuff's still coming up through the mines. Not while it's still in the air. He says what I need isn't a physic." She paused. "He says what I need is for it to *stop*."

She held his gaze.

"Wren says you're trying to stop it," she said. "You and your brother. And your father."

"Yes, ma'am."

"Can you?"

Lex looked at her. At her thin face and her grey-threaded hair. At the two little boys pressed against her sides.

"I don't know," he said. "But I'm going to try."

Maren Ashdown looked at him a moment longer. Then she nodded, once, sharply, exactly the way Wren nodded.

"Good," she said. "Then you'd best take my daughter with you." She put her arm around Wren's shoulders. "Because she's the best tracker in the Greyspine, and the best shot, and the most stubborn girl ever born. And if anyone can help you find your way to the end of this, it's her."

Wren had gone the color of her hair.

"*Mam—*"

"Hush, Wrennie. I'm talking to the Hammer." Maren looked at Lex. "You'll bring her back to me?"

"I'll try," said Lex. "I promise I'll try."

"Don't try." Maren's eyes were very sharp. "*Do*."



ON THE THIRD DAY, Lex saw the Kindlings.

He hadn't meant to. He'd gone out with Elric in the morning, hooded, to help carry supplies back from a market in the middle tiers, and they'd come up a stairway into a little square, and there was a crowd.

In the middle of the square was a Lattice Stone. Not like the cracked old Stone on the green at Ashbourne. This one was tall, taller than a man, white and polished and carved with the faces of Founders, glowing silver in the morning light. And in front of it stood a girl.

She was perhaps sixteen. Thin and small and dark-haired, in a patched brown dress, with a face like a bird's: sharp and quick and bright. Her mother stood behind her in the crowd, twisting her hands in her apron. A Warden in a grey robe stood beside the Stone, a bored-looking man with a ledger.

"Kindling," said Elric quietly. "Every Lower Town Stone holds them on the first of the month. For everyone who's turned sixteen." He tugged Lex's sleeve. "Come on. We shouldn't stand here."

Lex didn't move.

The girl put her hand on the Stone. The silver glow flared, briefly. And Lex saw her face change. Saw the brightness go out of it. Saw it go carefully, deliberately blank, the way Wren's had gone blank in the Thornwood.

"*Laborer*," the bored Warden read from the girl's panel, and wrote it in his ledger. "Common. Next."

The girl turned away from the Stone. Her mother caught her in her arms. The girl didn't cry. She just stood there with her face blank, staring at nothing.

And Lex, before he could stop himself, used True Sight.

Not on the girl. On the *Stone*.

The world flickered gold. And the Lattice Stone in the middle of the square *opened* to him, the way his own panel had opened, layer beneath layer. He saw the silver threads running into it from the great net of the Lattice. He saw the Kindling record of the girl, just written, *Laborer*, *Common*. And beneath it, deeper, in a layer most people couldn't see, he saw something else.

A flag. Attached to the Stone itself. A small, neat, grey line of text, like a note in a ledger margin.

STONE: Lower Town (Tier 4), Highcrest

Permission flags:

WEIGHT: COMMON+ (applied)

DENY: RARE, EPIC (applied)

Set by: Warden-Adjutant Corvis

Authorized: Office of the High
Warden*DENY: RARE, EPIC.*

Every child who put their hand on that Stone. Every single one. Every month. For however many years that flag had been there.

He felt the fire in his chest go up like a forge with the bellows going full. *[Lex,] said Ember sharply. [Your eyes. Stop. People can see.]*

He stopped. The gold flickered out. But his hands had clenched into fists, and the heat was pouring off him, and the cobbles around his boots had started to steam.

"Lex," said Elric, very low and very urgent. "*Walk. Now.*"

He walked. But as he turned, his eyes caught on a figure at the edge of the crowd.

A young woman. Not much older than him. Tall, slender, with a plain grey cloak over a plain grey dress, and her hood up, and a basket of bread on her arm. She'd been handing out loaves to the families waiting in the square. She was standing near the girl who'd just been Kindled, and she'd bent down to say something to her, and the girl had looked up at her with wide eyes.

Lex heard what she said. He didn't mean to. She wasn't speaking loudly. But the square had gone quiet, and her voice was clear and low and very steady.

"What would you have chosen?" the young woman asked the girl. "If you could have chosen anything?"

The girl stared at her. "I—I wanted to be a Healer," she whispered. "Like the Sisters at the Lantern House. I've been helping them since I was ten."

The young woman in the grey cloak looked at her for a long moment. Then she took a loaf from her basket and put it in the girl's hands.

"Then keep helping them," she said. "Whatever the Stone says. Do you hear me? Keep helping them."

And then she straightened up, and turned, and looked across the square.

Straight at Lex.

Her face under the hood was fine-boned and pale, with a pointed chin and dark, serious eyes. She looked at him the way Elric had looked at him that first night in the forge: as if reading him like a page. And Lex realized, with a cold jolt, that she must have seen it. His eyes going gold. The steam rising off the cobbles.

She didn't call out. She didn't point. She didn't call the bored Warden with his ledger.

She just looked at him for a long, long moment. And then she inclined her head, very slightly, the smallest of nods. And turned, and walked away into the crowd with her basket of bread, and was gone.

"Who was that?" Lex said.

Elric didn't answer at once. He was staring after the young woman in the grey cloak. His face had gone very still.

"Nobody," he said at last. "A charity worker. The Lower Town's full of them." He tugged Lex's sleeve again, harder. "*Walk*, Lex. Before someone else notices you."

They walked. But Lex looked back once, at the edge of the square. And he saw, just for a moment, a glimpse of grey cloak far off up a stairway, climbing toward the upper tiers of the city. And beneath the hem of the cloak, as she climbed, the flash of a shoe that was far too fine for any charity worker in the Lower Town. Blue silk. Embroidered with silver.

With a tiny silver crown.



QUILL CAME BACK THAT night.

He came in through the open window of Hedda's back room, a black shape out of the dark, and landed on the anvil with a thump and an aggrieved croak. There was a slip of paper tied to his leg.

Elric untied it. He read it. Then, without being asked, he held it out to Lex.

"Here," he said quietly. "You should see this."

Lex looked at him.

"You saw him fly east," said Elric. "On the causeway. I saw your face." He held the paper out a little further. "I told you Saltreach. I lied. I'm sorry. Read it."

Lex took the paper.

It was written in a small, cramped, hurried hand.

E.—

Your friends' route north is clear for now. The Commander's forces are moving west along the Fells, but slowly, and they are not yet past the Thornhollow line. Avoid the eastern passes. If you mean to reach the lake before the first snows, go by the Highcrest road and the northern arm.

I cannot write again for some weeks. They watch the birds.

—H.

Lex read it twice. He looked up.

"Who's H.?"

"A friend," said Elric. "A Warden. One of the few left in the eastern containment who isn't—" He paused. "Quiet. She's been passing me word of Morvane's movements for three years. At great risk to herself." He held Lex's gaze. "I lied about Saltreach because I thought the archivist might be awake. And because the fewer people who know H. exists, the longer H. stays alive." He spread his hands. "I'm sorry, Lex. I should have told you. You deserved to know. I'm an old man and I've been keeping secrets so long I've forgotten how to stop."

Lex looked down at the paper again. *They watch the birds.*

[It seems genuine,] said Ember slowly. [The hand is different from Elric's. The details make sense. It would explain the raven.]

It would, Lex thought.

He looked up at Elric. At the lined, tired face. At the storm-grey eyes, steady and honest and apologetic.

And he felt something in his chest unknot. Just a little. A slag pocket he'd been listening to for days, and it turned out to be nothing. Just a sound in the iron.

"Thank you," he said. "For showing me."

"Thank you for not asking me in front of the others," said Elric quietly. "That was well done." He smiled faintly. "Suspicion is healthy, Lex. It keeps you alive. Don't ever apologize for it. Not to me, not to anyone." He took the paper back, and folded it, and tucked it into his cloak. "Your father always trusted too easily. I'm glad you don't."

He turned away toward the fire.

Lex watched him go. And he didn't see, because he wasn't looking, the way the old sorcerer's hand shook, very slightly, as he tucked the paper away.



THE WARDENS CAME AT midnight.

Lex was asleep. They all were, except Hedda, who sat up in the front of the shop most nights with a lamp and a cudgel across her knees, because she said she was old and didn't need much sleep and it was her shop. He woke to the sound of her voice, very loud, in the street outside. *What's all this, then? What's all this at this hour?*

And another voice. Cold. Thin. Precise. A voice like a blade drawn slowly from a sheath.

Hedda Vorne. By order of the Spire, stand aside.

Lex was on his feet with Anvilson in his hands before he was fully awake. Around him, the others were scrambling up. Garrick, Oathkeeper already drawn. Wren, an arrow on the string. Antho, the Keeper's Lantern glowing at his belt, Ashka on his shoulder with her new silver-framed wing half-spread. Seraphine, fumbling for her spectacles and her crossbow.

Elric, standing by the window, very still, looking out into the street.

"How many?" said Garrick.

"Thirty," said Elric quietly. "Forty. All along the lane. Both ends." He turned from the window. His face was grey. "And at the front of them, a man in black. With chains."

"Chains?"

"Inquisitor-General Vane," said Elric. "He's found us."

From the front of the shop came a crash, and Hedda's roar, and the sound of the door splintering.

CHAPTER 18

THE INQUISITOR



THE MAN WHO CAME through the splintered door of Hedda's shop looked like a shadow that had learned to stand up straight.

He was tall and very thin, all length and no width, in a long black coat that hung to his ankles and buttoned to his throat. His hair was black, slicked flat against a narrow skull. His face was long and pale and smooth, so smooth it looked polished, with a thin mouth and a thin nose and eyes the color of wet slate. He wore no armor. He carried no sword. Around his left forearm, wrapped from wrist to elbow, he wore a length of chain.

It was the strangest chain Lex had ever seen. Not iron. Not steel. Something silvery and black at the same time, like oil on water, and every link was carved with tiny glyphs. Wellschrift. Lex could see them from across the room: *Sever. Sever. Sever.* Over and over.

LUCIUS VANE

Class: GRAND INQUISITOR (Epic)

Tier III – Level 63

"Hedda Vorne," said the man in black. His voice was the cold, thin, precise voice they'd heard through the wall. "Harboring wildcasters. Harboring a fugitive thief. Obstructing the Spire." He didn't look at Hedda. He was looking past her, down the narrow shop, toward the curtained doorway to the back room. "I'm disappointed. You had a good pension."

Hedda Vorne stood in the middle of her shop with her cudgel in her one hand and a cut across her forehead streaming blood into her eyes.

Behind her, through the broken door, Lex could see grey cloaks crowding the lane outside. Torches. Crossbows.

"Get out of my shop, Vane," said Hedda.

"Stand aside."

"I was making blades for the Spire when you were still wetting your bed in the novice dormitory." Hedda raised the cudgel. "*Get out of my shop.*"

Vane sighed.

He moved his left arm. Just slightly. A flick of the wrist. And the chain *uncoiled*. It shot off his forearm like a striking snake, silver-black, glyphs glowing, and wrapped itself three times around Hedda's arm and cudgel and chest before she could move.

Hedda staggered. Her face went grey. She didn't fall. She was too big and too stubborn to fall. But the cudgel dropped from her fingers, and she sagged against the counter, and Lex, watching through a gap in the curtain, saw a silver panel flicker over her head and go dark.

HEDDA VORNE

STATUS: SEVERED

Lattice connection: SUPPRESSED

All skills: UNAVAILABLE

"Severance chains," Elric whispered beside him. "Lady of Lanterns. He's brought Severance chains." His voice was very tight. "They cut you off from the Lattice. All of it. Your skills, your stats, your class. Everything the Lattice gives you." He swallowed. "If he gets those on you, you're nothing. You're a level-one nobody with no class and no skills and no magic."

"Is there a back way out?" hissed Garrick.

"The cellar." It was Hedda's voice. Weak and rough, from the front of the shop. She hadn't turned around. She was still slumped against the counter, wrapped in silver-black chain. But she'd raised her voice just enough to carry. "Under the forge. Trapdoor under the slack tub. Old smugglers' tunnel. Goes to the drains."

Vane's slate-grey eyes went to her. For the first time, he looked almost interested.

"Thank you, Hedda," he said. "That's very helpful."

And he started down the shop toward the curtain.



GARRICK MET HIM IN the doorway.

The old knight came through the curtain with Oathkeeper drawn and frost blooming along the blade, and swung for Vane's head without a word. It was a beautiful swing. Lex had watched Garrick fight for weeks now and had never seen him make a better one.

Vane stepped back half a pace, and the blade passed an inch from his nose.

The chain moved. It came off Hedda as if it had a mind of its own, uncoiling, whipping back to Vane's arm, and then out again, straight at Garrick. Garrick got Oathkeeper up in time. The chain wrapped around the blade instead of his body, three times, glyphs flaring.

And Oathkeeper *rang*.

It was the same long, clear, singing note it had made in the burned smithy when Garrick swore his oath on it. The runes along the blade flared gold, all three of them at once. And the chain *slipped*. Its coils loosened. Slid. Fell away from the steel like a snake sliding off a hot stone.

Vane's eyes widened.

"What," he said softly, "is *that*?"

"Masterwork," said Garrick, and swung again.



THE BACK ROOM EXPLODED into chaos.

Wardens came pouring in through the front of the shop behind Vane, crossbows raised. Garrick held the doorway, Oathkeeper flashing, frost and gold. Wren was loosing arrows through the gap over his shoulder, the new steel-headed arrows Lex had made her, and where they struck crossbows and sword-hands, the rune *True* guided them home. Seraphine had her new crossbow up and was firing too, slower, but steadier than she'd ever been.

And Lex was hauling the slack tub off the trapdoor.

It was full. Twenty gallons of water. He got his arms around it and *heaved*, thirty-seven Might, and it slid across the floor in a great sloshing wave, and there under it, set into the flagstones, was a square wooden trapdoor with an iron ring.

"Go!" Garrick roared from the doorway. *"Everyone down! I'll hold them!"*

"Garrick—"

"I'm standing on the steps, boy! Go!"

Antho was first down. He dropped through the trapdoor into darkness with the Keeper's Lantern glowing at his belt, and the little flame lit a narrow stone stair going down. Seraphine went after him. Then Wren.

Then the chain came through the doorway past Garrick.

It came so fast Lex barely saw it. A silver-black blur, past Garrick's guard, past Oathkeeper's ringing blade, across the forge, straight at Lex. He threw up Ironskin. He swung Anvilson. Neither of them mattered. The chain wrapped around his left arm, three times, from wrist to elbow, and the glyphs on its links flared silver.

And the world went *quiet*.

Not silent. Lex could still hear Garrick shouting, the crossbows twanging, the crash and clatter of the fight. But something inside him went quiet. The silver panel at the edge of his vision went dark. His skills flickered out like candles in a wind. Ironskin. Ember Strike. Heat Shaping. Gone. All of it gone. He felt the strength drain out of his arms like water out of a bucket. His legs went weak. The hammer in his right hand went from weightless to heavy, terribly heavy, the weight of twelve pounds of iron in the hand of a young man who'd been hammering it for eight years and was, suddenly, only that.

LEX VEY

STATUS: SEVERED

Lattice connection: SUPPRESSED

Class skills: UNAVAILABLE

Stats: reverted to base

"There," said Vane softly, from the doorway. Garrick was still blocking it, still fighting, but Vane had reached past him with the chain the way a fisherman reaches past a rock with his line. "There. Now. Let's have a look at you."

He began to reel Lex in.

Lex dug in his heels. It didn't matter. The chain pulled him across the forge floor, step by step, toward the doorway, toward Vane. He tried to call the fire. It didn't come. He tried to call anything. Nothing came.

[Lex,] said Ember.

It was very faint. Faint as a whisper from the bottom of a well. But it was there.

Ember? I thought—the chain—

[The chain cuts the Lattice,] said Ember, faint and fast. [Silver threads. It's very good at it. It's cut every silver thread you have.] A pause. [But you're not only silver, Lex. You haven't been since the night of the gloamhounds. Your class isn't in the Lattice. It's under it. In the Root. Gold.]

I can't feel it.

[Because you've been reaching for it through the silver. Out of habit. Stop reaching through the silver. Reach down. Past it. To the gold.]**

The chain pulled him another step. He was halfway to the doorway. Vane's thin pale face was smiling slightly.

Lex closed his eyes.

He stopped reaching for the fire the way he'd always reached for it, through the silver panel and the silver threads and the skill names Ember had taught him. He reached *down*. Past all of that. Down into the place under his breastbone where, on the night of the gloamhounds, a door had broken. Where the fire had been banked for fifteen years.

It was there.

It had always been there. Not in the Lattice. Not given by the Lattice. *His*. Under everything. The way the forge is under the iron.

He let it out.



IT CAME UP THROUGH him like a furnace door swinging open.

The silver panel at the edge of his vision stayed dark. But behind it, under it, something else flared into life. Gold. Not a panel. Just *gold*. A heat so fierce that the flagstones under his boots cracked and the water from the overturned slack tub flashed into steam all around him.

The chain on his arm screamed.

The glyphs on its links had been glowing silver. Now they glowed red. Then orange. Then white. The chain was *beating*, link by link, from the place where it touched his skin outward, the way an iron bar heats in the forge. *Sever. Sever. Sever.* The glyphs were trying to cut him off from the Lattice. But there was nothing left to cut. He wasn't using the Lattice.

He was using what was under it.

The chain *melted*.

It went soft and bright and liquid, from his wrist to his elbow, and dripped off his arm in molten silver-black drops that sizzled on the wet flagstones. The rest of it, the part still connecting him to Vane's arm, went white-hot along its whole length in a single flash, faster than any heat Lex had ever made, and Vane shrieked and let go and staggered back clutching his forearm, his black sleeve smoking.

Lex stood in the middle of the forge with steam pouring off him and his eyes blazing gold, and the silver panel at the edge of his vision flickered, and flickered, and came back on.

SEVERANCE — BROKEN

Root-layer class: UNAFFECTED

Lattice connection: RESTORED

NEW UNDERSTANDING:

"What the Lattice gives, the
Lattice can take. What is yours,
it cannot."

Vane was staring at him from the doorway. His face, for the first time, wasn't smooth. It was twisted with pain and shock and something else. Something almost like fear.

"*Impossible*," he said. "Nothing breaks the chains. *Nothing*. They cut everything the Lattice—"

"I know," said Lex. "I'm not using the Lattice."

Garrick, still in the doorway, still holding back the Wardens with Oathkeeper, turned his head and grinned at Lex through the blood on his face.

"Go, boy," he said. "Before he works out what that means."



LEX WENT.

He dropped through the trapdoor into the dark. A moment later, Garrick came down after him, backing down the stairs with Oathkeeper still raised, and slammed the trapdoor shut over their heads. Lex heard something heavy hit it from above. Heard Vane's voice, cold and furious, shouting orders.

And then he heard another voice. Gravelly. Defiant.

Ob, I'm so sorry, Inquisitor. Was that your foot? I'm terribly clumsy since I lost the arm.

Hedda.

"She's free," said Garrick, very low, at the bottom of the stairs. "The chain came off her when he threw it at you. She'll stall them." He paused. "She knew she'd have to. When she let us in."

Lex stood in the dark at the bottom of the stairs and felt something tear in his chest.

"We have to go back for her—"

"No," said Garrick. "We don't." He put his hand on Lex's shoulder. "She chose. Like I did, on the steps of that chapel. Like your mother did, Antho told me, in your kitchen." His voice was very quiet. "You honor that by running, lad. Not by going back and making it mean nothing."

Above them, through the trapdoor, came the sound of breaking glass. And Hedda Vorne's voice, raised in a roar of pure unrepentant fury. *My BEESWAX! That's a hundred crowns of beeswax, you—*

Lex ran.



THE SMUGGLERS' TUNNEL WAS narrow and low and stank of old water. It ran down from the cellar under Hedda's forge in a long sloping passage of rough stone, and then joined a larger tunnel, arched and brick-lined, with a channel of black water running down its middle. The Old Drains, Seraphine called them. Built three hundred years ago when Highcrest still had a wall around the Lower Town, abandoned when the new sewers went in, used now by smugglers and thieves and rats.

They ran. Antho in front with the Keeper's Lantern lighting the way. Seraphine and Wren behind him. Lex and Garrick at the back. And Elric in the middle, leaning on his staff, breathing hard.

Behind them, far off, they heard shouting. Splashing. The Wardens had found the trapdoor.

"Where does this come out?" Wren panted.

"The Rivergate," said Elric. "At the bottom of the city. Where the river comes in under the walls." He coughed. "There'll be a grating. Old. Rusted. We can break it."

They ran on. The tunnel sloped down and down. The water in the channel grew deeper and faster. The shouting behind them grew closer.

And then Seraphine stumbled.

She went down hard on the wet bricks, and her pack burst open as she fell, the strap snapping. Books spilled out across the tunnel floor. Papers. Her notebook. Her spare spectacles. And something else, something small and bright that bounced on the bricks with a high metallic *ting* and rolled to a stop at Lex's feet.

He looked down at it.

It was a token. Silver, the size of a coin, thick and heavy. Stamped on one side with the lattice of the Wardens. And on the other side, a seal. A tower, with a star above it.

"*Leave the books!*" Garrick was hauling Seraphine up by the arm. "*Leave them! No time!*"

"My notes—"

"*Leave them!*"

Lex bent and picked up the silver token.

Elric was there before he'd straightened up. The old sorcerer's hand closed over his, quick and hard, and took the token out of his fingers, and slipped it into his cloak.

"Later," Elric said, very low. His face in the lantern-light was grey and strange. "Later, Lex. Run."

Lex ran. But he'd seen the seal on the token. He'd seen it before. On the wanted notices nailed to every wall in the Lower Town. Just above the words *BY ORDER OF THE SPIRE*.

The seal of the Office of the High Warden.

And behind him, as he ran, he heard Seraphine's voice, high and frightened and bewildered. *That's not mine. That's not mine. I've never seen that before in my life.*



THE GRATING AT THE Rivergate was rusted, as Elric had said. Lex broke it with one Ember Strike. It burst apart in a spray of red-hot iron flakes, and they scrambled through into cold night air and the roar of the river.

They were at the very bottom of Highcrest. Behind them, the city rose up the mountain in a great dark mass, pricked with a thousand lights, and at the top, the white needle of the Spire with its silver-blue heart pulsing against the clouds. In front of them, the river ran fast and black between stone quays. Barges were moored along the far bank. A bridge crossed the water a little way upstream.

And on the near quay, between them and the bridge, there were knights.

A dozen of them. In full plate, silver-chased, with blue cloaks and helms with tall white plumes. Knights of the Silver Lattice. They were drawn up in a line across the quay, swords out, torches burning. Waiting.

"*Lady,*" breathed Wren.

"They knew," said Antho. "They knew where the tunnel came out."

"Of course they knew," said Elric bitterly. "Vane's not a fool."

Garrick had stopped.

He was standing very still on the wet quay, with Oathkeeper in his hand, staring at the line of knights. Not at all of them. At one. The one in the center of the line. The one with no plume on her helm, but a captain's blue sash across her breastplate, and her sword held level and steady in front of her.

She'd seen him too. Lex saw it. Saw her sword point waver, just slightly. Saw her go still.

Then she reached up with her free hand and pulled off her helm.

She was young. Twenty-three, perhaps. Tall and broad-shouldered, with close-cropped dark hair and a strong square jaw. Her nose had been

broken once and set slightly crooked. Her eyes were dark brown and very steady.

They were Garrick's eyes.

"Father," said Elowen Dunmore.



NOBODY MOVED.

The river roared. The torches hissed and flickered in the wind off the water. Behind them, in the drain, Lex heard splashing. Shouting. Getting closer.

Garrick didn't say anything for a long moment. He just stood there, looking at his daughter.

"Elowen," he said at last. His voice was very rough. "You made captain."

"Last spring." Her sword didn't waver. "No thanks to you."

"No." Garrick swallowed. "No thanks to me."

"You're on the notices." Her voice was flat. Controlled. Lex could hear the effort in it. "Not by name. *Unknown accomplice. Large. Grey-haired. Armed with a sword that freezes.*" Her eyes went to Oathkeeper. "That's Grandfather's sword. They broke it. I watched them break it. In the courtyard."

"I know."

"And now you're running with wildcasters. With the Ashbourne warlock." Her jaw tightened. "With a thief who stole from the Spire."

"Yes."

"*Why?*"

Garrick looked at her. The torchlight caught the scars on his face, the grey in his stubble, the tears standing in his eyes.

"Because they're right," he said simply. "And the Spire's wrong. It's been wrong for a long time. I knew it six years ago, in the east, when they told me to burn that village. I just didn't know what to do about it." He held up Oathkeeper, so the torchlight caught the blue-white blade. "Now I do."

Elowen stared at the sword.

"It's different," she said slowly. "It's not the same blade."

"It was reforged. By him." Garrick nodded at Lex. "He's a smith. And something more than a smith." He paused. "I swore a new oath on it. To

stand on the steps. For people who need someone to stand there." He lowered the sword. "I'm not a drunk anymore, Elowen. I'm not the man who wasn't there when your mother died. I can't take that back. I can't take any of it back." His voice cracked. "But I'm trying to be someone she'd have been proud of. Someone *you* could be proud of. Even if you never want to see me again."

The splashing in the drain behind them was very loud now. Lex could hear Vane's voice. Cold and precise and furious.

Elowen Dunmore stood on the quay with her sword in her hand and her father in front of her, and her face was doing something terrible. Something that was trying very hard to stay blank and couldn't.

"Captain?" One of the knights in the line beside her. Uncertain. "Captain, the Inquisitor-General's orders were—"

"I know what the orders were, Sir Aldous."

"They're coming up the drain, Captain. We need to—"

"I know."

She looked at her father for a long moment more.

"Mother kept your letters," she said quietly. "All of them. The ones you sent from Saltreach, after. She never answered them. But she kept them. In a box under her bed." Her voice was very steady. "I found them after she died. I read every one."

Garrick couldn't speak.

Elowen lowered her sword.

"Knights of the Silver Lattice," she said, loudly and clearly, turning to the line of plumed helms beside her. "There's been a mistake. These are travelers. Wool merchants from the Fells. They've fallen in the river and come out through the drain." She looked at them, one by one, daring any of them to argue. "Let them pass."

"Captain—"

"That is an order, Sir Aldous."

The line of knights hesitated. Then, slowly, they parted.

Garrick didn't move. He was staring at his daughter.

"Go, Father," said Elowen. Her voice cracked down the middle. "Go before I change my mind."

And then, before anyone could stop her, she crossed the quay in three long strides, and threw her arms around his neck, armor and all, and held on. Just for a moment. Just for a heartbeat. And Garrick's arms came up around her, and he made a sound Lex had never heard a man make, and held her too.

Then she let go, and stepped back, and put her helm back on.

"Go," she said.



THEY RAN ALONG THE quay, through the parted line of knights, toward the bridge.

They didn't reach it.

Vane came out of the drain behind them like a black crow out of a chimney. His sleeve was charred to the elbow and his forearm was wrapped in a bandage, and his long pale face was white with fury. Wardens poured out after him. A dozen. Two dozen. Crossbows raised.

"*Captain Dunmore!*" Vane's voice cracked across the quay like a whip. "*Stop them! In the name of the High Warden!*"

Elowen didn't move. Her knights didn't move.

Vane's slate-grey eyes went from the line of knights to the fleeing figures on the quay. And he raised his good arm, and a second chain uncoiled from it, longer than the first, silver-black and glowing, and he threw it.

Not at Lex.

At Antho.

It flew across the quay like a striking snake. Antho turned. He saw it coming. And he didn't raise his hands. He didn't call his shadows. He just looked at it, with the Keeper's Lantern glowing at his belt and Ashka on his shoulder with her silver-framed wing spread wide.

The chain wrapped around him. Three times. Chest, arms, waist. The glyphs flared silver.

And nothing happened.

Antho stood there in the coils of the Severance chain and looked down at it with mild interest.

"Oh," he said. "That's clever. I can feel it cutting." He tilted his head. "There's not much to cut."

The shadows came up off him.

Not in a wave. Not in a wall. They came up slowly, quietly, from the ground around his feet, and wrapped around the silver-black chain the way ivy wraps around a post. And where they touched it, the glyphs on the links went dark. One by one. *Sever. Sever. Sever.* Dark, dark, dark. Swallowed. Like stones dropped into a deep well.

The chain fell off him in loose dead coils and lay on the quay at his feet. Vane stared at it.

"*What are you?*" he whispered.

"The Lattice gave me an error," said Antho quietly. "When I was sixteen. I've never really been in it since." He looked across the quay at the Inquisitor-General. "Your chains cut silver. There's no silver in me. There's only dark." He paused. "You should go home, Inquisitor. You don't know what you're hunting."



THEY WOULD NEVER HAVE reached the bridge. Vane's Wardens were raising their crossbows. Two dozen bolts, at thirty paces, on an open quay.

But they didn't have to reach the bridge.

"*Here!*"

A voice from the river. Lex turned. There was a barge moored at the quay a little way upstream: a long low flat-bottomed river-barge, stacked high with sacks of grain, with a single lantern burning at its stern. And standing on its deck, with a boat-hook in one hand and a sword in the other, there was a tall lean man with a face like a hatchet and close-cropped iron-grey hair.

He wasn't wearing a grey cloak. He was wearing a plain brown coat, like a bargeman's. But Lex knew him.

"*Roole,*" he breathed.

"*Get on the boat, Harrow!*" Daxian Roole roared. "*Unless you'd rather stay and chat with the Inquisitor-General!*"

They ran for the barge.

The crossbows fired. Lex heard them. Felt a bolt whistle past his ear. Heard Wren cry out and saw her stumble and then keep running, a bolt sticking out of her pack. Garrick turned at the edge of the quay and swept Oathkeeper in a great flat arc, and frost exploded outward in a wall of ice across the stones, and the next volley of bolts thudded into it and stuck there, quivering.

They tumbled onto the barge. Roole was already shoving off from the quay with the boat-hook. The current caught them. The barge swung out into the river, turning, moving.

On the quay, Vane had pushed through his Wardens to the very edge of the stones. He stood there with the river roaring below him and his pale face twisted, staring at the barge.

Staring at Roole.

"*Captain Roole,*" he said. His voice carried across the water, cold and thin and deadly. "*You were relieved of command. You were ordered to your quarters. You were under investigation.*"

"I know," said Roole.

"*This is treason.*"

"I know that too." Roole leaned on his boat-hook. The barge was drifting farther out now, the current pulling it upstream against the wind, toward the dark mass of the bridge. "I said I'd answer for it, Vane. When I came back from the mountains. I said I'd answer for letting them go." He looked across the widening water at the Inquisitor-General. "I'm answering."

The barge slid under the dark arch of the bridge, and the quay and Vane and the knights and the torches were gone.



THE RIVER CARRIED THEM north and west through the night, out of the city, past the last straggling houses of the Lower Town, into dark farmland under a cold moon.

Roole stood at the tiller and didn't say anything for a long time. The others sat among the grain sacks, breathing hard, bleeding, shaking. Wren had pulled the crossbow bolt out of her pack and was staring at it. It had gone straight through her bedroll and stopped a finger's width from her

spine. Garrick sat with Oathkeeper across his knees, staring back the way they'd come, toward the distant lights of Highcrest. His face was wet. He didn't wipe it.

Seraphine sat a little apart from everyone, with her arms wrapped around her knees and her spilled pack in her lap, half its contents gone. She hadn't said a word since the drain.

Lex went and sat beside Roole at the tiller.

"Why?" he said.

Roole didn't look at him. He was watching the river ahead, the dark water silver under the moon.

"I went back to Highcrest," he said at last. "After the Hollowmaw. I wrote my report. I told the truth. About the breach. About your brother holding it. About you sparing fifteen men who'd come to drag you off in chains." He was quiet for a moment. "They read it. And then they called me into the High Warden's office, and the High Warden told me to write it again."

"Write it again?"

"*Differently.*" Roole's jaw tightened. "She told me what to say. That the warlock was the source of the Gloam. That you'd ambushed my squad and we'd barely escaped. That the breach was a lie you'd told to confuse me." He shook his head. "I've been a Warden for twenty years, Harrow. I've done things I'm not proud of. I've hunted people who maybe didn't deserve hunting. But I've never once falsified a report." He looked at Lex for the first time. "I told her no. She relieved me of command. Told me I'd be investigated for corruption. Told me to go to my quarters and think about my future."

"And you came to the drain instead."

"I've been watching Hedda's shop for three days. I knew Thorne knew her. I guessed he'd bring you there." Roole looked back at the river. "When Vane went in tonight, I knew which way you'd run. Hedda and I served together in the east, years ago. She told me about the tunnel once, over too much ale." He shrugged. "I borrowed a barge."

"*Borrowed.*"

"I'll return it. Eventually." Something moved at the corner of Roole's hatchet face. Almost a smile. "Or I'll be hanged, and it won't matter."

Lex looked at him for a long moment.

"What happens to you now?" he said.

"Now?" Roole leaned on the tiller. "Now I drop you at the Ferrow landing, about twenty miles upriver, where the north road starts. And then I take this barge back down to Highcrest, and I walk into the Spire, and I tell them exactly what I did and why." He paused. "And then I find out what happens to me."

"They'll hang you."

"Maybe. Maybe not. I have friends. Not as many as I did. But some." Roole's pale eyes were steady. "And I have a report. The true one. I made copies. Some of them are already in places the High Warden can't reach." He looked at Lex. "Somebody has to stand in that building and tell the truth out loud, Harrow. Even if nobody listens. Especially if nobody listens."

Lex didn't know what to say.

"Find your father," said Roole quietly. "Find the truth about the Gloam. All of it. Then come back to Highcrest, and show it to us. To all of us." He looked out over the moonlit river. "There are more Wardens like me than you'd think. Like Hedda. Like that girl on the quay. We just need something to stand on."



THEY REACHED THE FERROW landing an hour before dawn. A rickety wooden jetty on the riverbank, a ruined boathouse, and a muddy track leading away north through the dark fields. They climbed off the barge one by one. Roole didn't get off. He stood at the tiller with the boat-hook in his hand and watched them go.

Lex was the last. He stopped at the edge of the barge and turned back.

"Captain," he said.

Roole looked at him.

"Thank you," said Lex. "For the boat. And for the report. And for not hitting me with the sharp end of your sword, that first time."

Roole looked at him for a long moment. Then, very slowly, he held out his hand.

Lex took it. Roole's grip was hard and dry and very strong.

"Go on, Harrow," said Daxian Roole. "Go find him."

He pushed off from the jetty. The barge swung out into the current and turned downstream, toward Highcrest, and the single lantern at its stern dwindled into the grey dawn mist and was gone.



THEY WALKED NORTH AS the sun came up.

Nobody talked much. They were all too tired. Too battered. Too full of the night. Lex walked at the front with Wren, who had bound up a cut on her arm with a strip of her shirt and was limping slightly. Garrick walked behind them with his hand on Oathkeeper's hilt and his eyes far away. Antho and Seraphine walked together, close, not talking. Ashka glided from one to the other on her silver-framed wing, landing on shoulders, chirping, as if trying to cheer them up.

And Elric walked at the back. Alone.

Halfway through the morning, he caught up with Lex.

"The token," he said quietly. "From the archivist's pack."

Lex didn't look at him. "I saw it."

"Then you know what it is." Elric held it out. The silver coin with the lattice on one side and the tower-and-star seal on the other. "A passkey. From the Office of the High Warden. It opens every sealed door in the Spire. Every vault. Every ward." He turned it over in his knotted fingers. "There are perhaps a dozen of these in existence. The High Warden keeps them very close."

"She said it wasn't hers."

"She did." Elric's voice was very gentle. "And perhaps it isn't. Perhaps someone planted it on her. Perhaps someone slipped it into her pack in Hedda's shop, while she slept." He looked at Lex. "Or perhaps that's how a junior archivist got past the sealed vault wards, two years ago. Perhaps someone in the High Warden's office gave it to her. Perhaps she's been carrying it ever since. Perhaps she's still using it."

Lex stopped walking.

He turned and looked back along the muddy track. Seraphine was walking beside Antho, thin and pale and exhausted, her spectacles askew, her half-empty pack clutched to her chest. As he watched, she stumbled,

and Antho caught her arm, and she looked up at him and said something, and he smiled.

"She stood next to my brother all night in the Barrows," Lex said. "She wrote three hundred and forty-six names into the Lattice."

"She did," Elric agreed. "And it was very moving. And very convincing." He put the token back in his cloak. "And it made all of you trust her completely. Which is exactly what a very good spy would do."

Lex didn't say anything.

"I'm not asking you to do anything," said Elric. "Not yet. Just watch. That's all I've ever asked." He put a hand on Lex's shoulder. "We're close now, Lex. Mirrormere is less than two weeks north. Whoever the Barrow-King was warning us about, they'll have to move soon." He squeezed Lex's shoulder. "Be ready when they do."

He walked on ahead.

Lex stood on the muddy track in the morning sunlight and watched him go.

[Lex,] said Ember slowly.

I know.

[It could have been planted.]

I know.

[Anyone could have put it there. In Hedda's shop. While she slept.] A long pause. *[Anyone who had access to the High Warden's office. Anyone who knew how the Spire worked. Anyone who'd been not-being-noticed by the Spire for longer than she's been alive.]*

Lex looked up the track at Elric's back. At the grey cloak, the brass charms glinting in the sun, the lightning-scarred staff tapping on the stones.

Then he looked back at Seraphine.

I don't know who to believe, he thought.

[Neither do I,] said Ember quietly. [So let's keep watching. Both of them.] A pause. *[And let's get to your father. Quickly. Before whoever it is gets there first.]*

Lex shifted Anvilsong on his shoulder, and turned his face to the north, and walked on.

LEVEL UP!

Emberwright – Level 22

CHAPTER 19

THE LODESTONE WAKES



THE LODESTONE WOKE ON the fourth day north of the river.

They were crossing high moorland by then, a great rolling emptiness of heather and bog-cotton and grey stone under a vast grey sky, with the northern arm of the Greyspine rising ahead of them like a wall at the end of the world. No roads. No villages. No people. Only the wind, which never stopped, and the curlews, which cried and cried over the bogs, and the cold.

Antho stopped in the middle of a sheep track, very suddenly, and put his hand to his chest.

"It's moving," he said.

Lex turned. His brother had drawn the lodestone out on its old black cord and was holding it up in the grey light. It was glowing. Not the slow soft pulse it had held since the Barrow Throne: grey and green and blue twined together, beating like a sleeping heart. This was brighter. Stronger. And it wasn't hanging straight down from the cord. It was *pulling*. Leaning out sideways, away from Antho's chest, at an angle no stone on a string should hang, as if something far away had hold of it and was drawing it gently in.

North and east. Toward the mountains.

"It's pointing," said Seraphine softly. She'd come up beside him and was staring at it through her spectacles. "Like a compass needle. *I will always find my way home.*" She looked at Antho. "It's found the way."

Antho turned slowly on the spot. The lodestone turned with him, always leaning the same way, northeast, toward a notch in the mountains where two great grey peaks leaned together like old men sharing a secret.

"How far?" said Garrick.

Nobody knew.

[Close,] said Ember. [It wasn't pulling yesterday. It's pulling today. That means we've crossed into range of whatever it's looking for.] A pause. [Ten days. Perhaps less.]

Lex told them.

Nobody said anything for a moment. They all stood on the windy moor, looking at the little glowing stone pulling at its cord, pointing at the notch in the mountains.

Ten days. After weeks. After months. After fifteen years.

"Right," said Antho, very quietly. He let the stone fall back against his chest. It kept pulling, leaning out against his shirt like a dog on a leash. "Right. Let's go."



THEY WALKED. THE MOUNTAINS grew closer. The lodestone pulled harder.

And the silence among them grew.

It had started on the barge. Or maybe before that. Maybe in the Barrow-King's hall, with the dead king's white eyes moving slowly over all their faces. But it had grown on the long days north. Like frost spreading across a window, slow and quiet, until you looked up one morning and couldn't see through the glass.

Seraphine walked alone, mostly. Or with Antho. She didn't talk much anymore. She'd lost half her books in the Old Drains, and her notebook with three hundred and forty-six names written in it, and her spare spectacles, and something else, something harder to name. She walked with her shoulders hunched and her eyes on the ground and her half-empty pack clutched to her chest, and when anyone spoke to her, she flinched.

Antho stayed close to her. He didn't say anything about the token. He didn't need to. He walked beside her every day, and sat beside her every

night, and when Elric was near, the shadows around his feet stirred and coiled like cats with their hackles up.

Garrick was carefully neutral. He was kind to Seraphine, the way he was kind to everyone. He was polite to Elric. He watched them both with his steady dark eyes and said nothing.

Wren watched Elric. All the time. Lex saw her doing it. When the old sorcerer went off into the dark in the evenings, Wren's eyes followed him. When he came back, she watched his boots, his hands, his face. She didn't say anything either.

And Elric was the same as ever. Kind. Patient. Dry. He taught Lex in the evenings, circles and structures and the careful folding of power, and Lex learned. He told stories around the fire, about Arion when he was young, about the Spire in the old days, about battles and storms and cities by the sea. He made them laugh, sometimes, even now.

And he watched Seraphine. Out of the corner of his eye. Very carefully. Like a man watching a coin on the ground.



ON THE SIXTH NIGHT, Lex went to find her.

She was sitting on a rock a little way from the fire, alone, with her arms wrapped around her knees, looking north toward the dark mass of the mountains. Antho had gone to fetch water. Ashka was curled asleep in Seraphine's lap; the little dragon had taken to sleeping there lately, when Antho wasn't around.

Seraphine looked up as Lex came near. He saw her face go tight. Saw her brace.

"You want to ask me about the token," she said.

"Yes."

"I've told you. It isn't mine." Her voice was flat and tired. "I don't know how it got in my pack. I've never seen it before. I never had one." She looked back at the mountains. "You don't have to believe me. Nobody has to believe me. I wouldn't believe me."

Lex sat down on the rock beside her.

"Can I look?" he said.

She turned her head. "Look?"

"True Sight. At you. Properly. All the way down." He hesitated. "I don't know if it'll show anything. I don't know if it can see the kind of thing Elric's worried about. But I'd like to look. If you'll let me."

Seraphine stared at him for a long moment. Her dark eyes behind her spectacles were very wide.

"You're *asking*," she said.

"Elric says it's rude not to."

Something went across Seraphine's face that Lex couldn't read. Then she let out a breath, and straightened her shoulders, and lifted her chin.

"Look," she said. "Look as deep as you like."

He looked.

The gold rose behind his eyes, and the world flickered, and over her head a panel unrolled. He let True Sight go deeper. Deeper than he'd ever pushed it on anyone. Layer beneath layer, the way he'd looked into the Lattice Stone in Highcrest, the way he'd looked into his brother's breach-link in the Hollowmaw.

SERAPHINE ILVANE

Age: 29

Class: LATTICE SCRIBE (Rare)

Tier II – Level 40

MIG 8 AGI 14 VIT 12

INT 52 SPI 31 RES 24

SKILLS

Inscribe Master 1

Record-Reading Expert 6

Wellscrip Expert 9

Crossbow Novice 4

Oaths sworn: NONE

Bindings: NONE

Lattice permissions:

Archive access – REVOKED

(by Office of the High Warden,
two years ago)

Passkey bonds: NONE

He read it out to her. All of it. When he got to the last lines, her breath caught.

"*Passkey bonds: none*," she whispered.

"That's what it says."

"The passkeys bond to their bearer. That's how they work. You carry one for a day, it starts to know you. You carry one for two years—" She stopped. Her hands were shaking. "If I'd been carrying it, if I'd used it on the vault wards, it would show. It *would* show."

"I know," said Lex. "Ember told me."

Seraphine put her hands over her face.

She didn't cry. She just sat there on the rock with her face in her hands, breathing in long shaky breaths, and Ashka woke up in her lap and chirped and pushed her narrow head up against Seraphine's chin.

"Thank you," Seraphine said at last, very muffled. "Thank you. I didn't think—nobody's—" She lifted her face. "Thank you for looking."

"It doesn't prove everything," said Lex. "Elric will say True Sight can't see what's in someone's heart. That someone could be working for the Spire without any oath or binding. That a spy doesn't need a passkey bond to be a spy."

"He would say that." Seraphine's mouth twisted. "He's said it already. To Garrick. I heard him." She looked at Lex. "Do *you* believe it?"

Lex didn't answer right away. He looked across the camp at the fire, where Elric was sitting with Quill on his shoulder, talking quietly with Garrick, his lined face lit orange by the flames.

"I believe you," he said at last. "I believe what I saw." He paused. "And I'd like to look at that token."



ELRIC GAVE IT TO him without hesitation.

"Of course," the old sorcerer said, and reached into his cloak, and held it out across the fire. "Look as long as you like." He smiled faintly. "I'd have offered sooner, if I'd thought of it."

Lex took the silver coin and turned it over in his fingers. The lattice on one side. The tower and star on the other. It was heavy and cold.

He looked at it with True Sight.

PASSKEY

Office of the High Warden

Grade: SUPERIOR (Lattice-bound)

Opens: all Spire wards, Tier I-III

Last bearer: [REDACTED]

(signature obscured)

Bond strength: residual

Signature obscured.

[That's interesting,] said Ember slowly. [Someone has scrubbed the bearer record. Deliberately. That takes skill. And a very high Intellect.] A pause. [A junior archivist couldn't do it. A Lattice Scribe could, maybe, with Master-rank Inscribe.] Another pause. [Seraphine got Master-rank Inscribe in the Barrows. Two weeks ago.]

And before that?

[Before that, she was Journeyman. She couldn't have done it.] A pause. [Unless she had help.]

Lex looked up from the token. Elric was watching him across the fire, his storm-grey eyes very steady.

"Well?" said the old sorcerer.

"The bearer's obscured," said Lex. "Someone scrubbed it."

Elric nodded slowly. "That's what I'd expect," he said. "A spy would scrub it. The first thing she'd do." He held out his hand for the token. "Thank you for looking, Lex. I know it's hard. I know you like her. So do I." He took the token back and tucked it away. "But the dead king didn't say *one who walks beside you is unlikable*. He said *one who walks beside you counts your steps for another*." He looked into the fire. "The ones who count your steps are always the ones you like best. That's what makes them good at it."

Lex didn't say anything.

Across the camp, on her rock in the dark, Seraphine sat with Ashka in her lap and looked north at the mountains and didn't turn around.



THE STORM CAME ON the eighth day.

They saw it coming from a long way off: a wall of black cloud rolling across the moor from the west, lit from within by flickers of lightning, trailing grey veils of rain beneath it. The wind picked up until it was screaming across the heather, flattening it, tearing at their cloaks. The temperature dropped like a stone.

"Shelter!" Garrick shouted over the wind. "We need shelter!"

There wasn't any. There was nothing on the moor but heather and bog and stone. Wren found a hollow in the lee of a big granite boulder, a shallow scoop in the ground barely big enough for all of them, and they crowded into it with their cloaks over their heads as the first drops hit like thrown pebbles.

And then the storm was on them.

Lex had seen storms in the Vale. Summer thunderstorms that rolled down off the Greyspine and rattled the shutters and flooded the millrace. This was nothing like that. This was the sky falling. The rain came down in sheets, in walls, so hard it bounced back up off the ground and soaked them from below. The wind howled like a living thing. And the lightning—

The lightning was everywhere. Fork after fork of it, splitting the black sky from horizon to horizon, striking the moor all around them so close that Lex felt the hair on his arms stand up and tasted metal in his mouth. The thunder came on top of it, instantly, deafening, a sound like the world's biggest hammer striking the world's biggest anvil, over and over and over.

Elric was standing up.

He'd come out of the hollow and was standing on the open moor with his staff raised and his grey cloak whipping around him and the brass storm-charms on it blazing blue-white. His face was lifted to the sky. His eyes were closed. And the lightning was *coming to him*. Not striking him. Arcing down out of the black clouds and curving at the last instant, bending toward his staff, wrapping around it in crackling coils, and then fading, absorbed, swallowed.

[*He's drinking it,*] said Ember, startled. [*The storm. He's a Stormcaller. He's taking the power out of it.*]

Why?

[I don't know. Because he can? Because it feels good?] A pause. *[Because he's storing it for something.]*

And then Ashka went out.

Lex felt her go. She'd been curled in Antho's coat, pressed against his chest, shivering. And then suddenly she wasn't. She'd squirmed out and climbed up onto the top of the boulder, into the full fury of the wind and the rain, and was standing there with her wings spread, both of them, the whole one and the torn one in its silver frame, her head thrown back, crying out into the storm.

"*Ashka!*" Antho lunged after her. "*Ashka, get down! Come back!*"

She didn't come back.

The lightning came down.

It struck the top of the boulder. Struck *her*. A great white fork of it, out of the black sky, straight down onto the little blue-grey dragon with her wings spread, so bright that for a long moment Lex couldn't see anything at all.

Antho screamed.

When Lex's sight came back, Ashka was still standing on the boulder.

She was glowing. Every scale on her body was lit from within, blue-white, crackling, like a lantern full of lightning. Sparks were pouring off her spines in a continuous stream. Her golden eyes were blazing. And her wings—

Her wings were bigger.

Not much. But Lex saw it. They'd *grown*. The whole wing and the torn one both. The silver frame on the torn wing had stretched to fit, the way the runes Lex had struck into it let it stretch, and the membrane inside it was glowing, and the torn edges were—

The torn edges were *knitting*. Slowly. Lit from within by the lightning she'd swallowed. Not healed. Not whole. But closer. A little closer.

ASHKA – Storm-Drake (juvenile)

Lightning absorbed: MASSIVE

LEVEL UP! Level 9 → 14

GROWTH STAGE: Juvenile → Adolescent

Wing damage: 61% → 38%

Ashka threw back her head and screamed into the storm. Not a chirp. Not a trill. A real scream, high and wild and fierce, the cry of a hawk, the cry of something that belonged in the sky.

And she leaped off the boulder, and spread her wings, and *flew*.

Not a glide. A flight. She beat her wings, both of them, the whole one and the silver-framed one, and she rose. Up off the boulder. Up into the wind. Up into the black screaming sky, into the rain and the lightning, a small blue-white shape blazing like a star, spiraling up and up and up until she was lost in the clouds.

Antho stood at the foot of the boulder with the rain streaming down his face, staring up at the place where she'd vanished.

"She's flying," he said. "She's *flying*."

The lightning flashed. And in the flash, high above them, Lex saw her. Turning in the storm. Wheeling. Riding the wind like a leaf, like a hawk, like she'd been born to it. Which she had.

Then she came down.

She came out of the clouds in a long spiraling dive, wings folded, falling like a stone, and at the last instant spread them wide and swooped low over the moor, so low her belly brushed the heather, and up again, and around, and landed on Antho's shoulder with a thump that nearly knocked him over.

She was bigger. Lex could see it now. Not cat-sized anymore. The size of a small dog. Her scales were still crackling with leftover lightning. Her golden eyes were blazing. And she was making a sound in her throat that Lex had never heard before, a deep rumbling purr, like a cat the size of a horse.

Antho was laughing. And crying. Both at once. He had his arms around her and his face pressed against her storm-wet scales, and he was saying something over and over that Lex couldn't hear over the wind.

Ashka turned her head. She looked at Lex across the hollow, through the rain. And a picture came into his head, sharp and bright and overwhelming. *Sky. Storm. Lightning in her belly like warm food. Antho's face, small and far below. FLYING.*

Same blood, she sent. *Your silver. Your wing-cage. Same blood. Thank you. FLYING.*



THE STORM PASSED IN the night.

In the morning, the moor was washed clean and glittering, every blade of heather hung with drops of water, the sky a pale, scrubbed, delicate blue. They climbed out of the hollow soaked to the skin and stiff with cold. Garrick built a fire with wet heather and swore at it for half an hour until Lex took pity on him and lit it with a thought.

Ashka spent the whole morning in the air. She'd go up in long spirals, higher and higher until she was only a speck, and then come down in screaming dives, and pull up just over their heads, and go up again. Every time she landed on Antho's shoulder, she was a little more tired, and a little more pleased with herself, and a little bigger. Antho couldn't stop smiling.

And Lex sat by the fire next to Wren, drying his boots, and didn't say anything for a long time.

"You're thinking," said Wren. "I can see it. You get a little line between your eyebrows."

"I don't have a line."

"You do. Right there." She poked it. "What is it?"

He looked at the fire.

"Ashka," he said slowly. "She was hurt. For four years. The Wardens shot her out of the sky and tore her wing, and she couldn't fly. She'd try, and fall, and try again, and fall." He was quiet for a moment. "And then someone made her a frame. And the storm came. And she flew."

Wren was watching him.

"It's like the Ceiling," said Lex. "Isn't it. Someone tore her wing so she couldn't fly. Someone set a Ceiling so people couldn't climb. And she was always *meant* to fly. That's what she *is*. She just needed someone to—" He stopped.

"Make her a frame," said Wren quietly.

"Yes."

They sat in silence for a while. Across the moor, Ashka came screaming down out of the sky in another dive, and Antho laughed out loud.

"There's a Prerogative," said Lex. "In my panel. Locked. Ember told me about it in the Thornwood. After you hit twenty-four." He didn't look at

her. "It's called Unbind. It breaks a Ceiling. Permanently. Lets someone climb past twenty-four. Re-rolls their class to something better."

Wren didn't say anything.

"I can't use it yet," said Lex. "I'm not strong enough. My Authority's too low. I don't know when I'll be strong enough." He turned and looked at her. "But when I am—"

"Don't."

He stopped.

"Don't make promises for me, Hammer." Wren was looking at the fire, not at him. Her jaw was tight. "I've heard a lot of promises. *Next year the mine will pay better. Next spring we'll get the roof fixed. Your da will be home by supper.*" Her voice was very steady. "I don't want promises. I've got enough of them. They're heavy to carry."

"Wren—"

"If you want to make a promise," she said, "make it for *you*. Not for me. You want to break the Ceiling? Fine. Break it. For Brannoc. For that girl in Highcrest. For everyone." She turned and looked at him, and her green eyes were very bright. "But don't do it for me. I don't want to be the reason. I don't want to be the thing you're carrying."

Lex looked at her for a long time.

Then he reached out, slowly, and took her hand. Her small, hard, calloused climber's hand. She didn't pull it away.

"All right," he said. "Not for you." He held on. "But *with* you. Is that all right?"

Wren looked down at their hands. Something moved at the corner of her mouth.

"That's all right," she said quietly.

They sat by the fire with their hands together, not saying anything, watching Ashka wheel and scream in the clean blue sky, until Garrick came back from the stream with the waterskins and coughed very loudly and very pointedly from twenty paces off, and Wren snatched her hand back and went the color of her hair, and Garrick grinned like a wolf.



LEX SPENT HIS POINTS that afternoon, the six from level twenty-two. He'd almost forgotten. Ember reminded him only once, which Lex suspected was some kind of record.

LEX VEY – Emberwright, Level 22		
MIG 38	AGI 37	VIT 47
INT 34	SPI 86	RES 36
Health	470/470	
Mana	860/860	
ROOT		
Seal integrity: 26%		
Authority: 41 / 100		

Seal integrity: 26%.

It had been thirty-one at the Barrows. Two weeks ago.

[Faster,] said Ember quietly. *[It's falling faster now.]*

Lex closed his status and looked north at the mountains, at the notch where the two grey peaks leaned together. The lodestone was pulling toward it so hard now that Antho had to hold it in his fist to keep it from tugging the cord off his neck.

Two more days, he thought.

[Two more days,] Ember agreed. And then, very quietly: *[Lex. When we get there. When you see him.]*

What?

A long pause.

[I don't know what will happen to me,] said Ember. *[I'm a piece of him. Cut off. Pressed into a seal. When the seal breaks completely, when he's there in front of you, whole—]* It stopped. *[I don't know if I'll still be me. I don't know if I'll still be here.]*

Lex stopped walking.

What do you mean?

[I mean I might go back,] said Ember. *[Into him. Where I came from. Like a river going back into the sea.]* A pause. *[Or I might just stop.]*

Lex stood on the moor in the afternoon light with the wind tugging at his cloak and the mountains rising ahead of him.

I don't want you to go, he thought.

There was a very long silence.

[I know,] said Ember softly. *[I don't want to go either.]* A pause. *[I've grown rather fond of you, little smith.]*

Lex walked on. He didn't trust himself to say anything else.



THEY CAME OVER THE last ridge on the evening of the tenth day.

The notch between the two grey peaks was a pass, high and narrow and cold, floored with old snow. They'd climbed it all afternoon, the lodestone pulling so hard now that it was humming audibly, a thin high singing note like a wet finger on the rim of a glass. Antho walked in front with the stone in his fist and his face set and Ashka gliding in slow circles overhead.

And at the top of the pass, the world opened up below them.

A valley. Long and narrow and deep, walled on every side by mountains, their peaks white with snow and gold with the last of the sunset. The valley floor was a single sheet of water. A lake. Long and narrow and shaped like a teardrop, filling the valley from wall to wall.

It was perfectly still.

Not calm. *Still*. Lex had seen calm water before: the millpond at Ashbourne on a windless morning, the black pools of the Drowned Barrows. This was different. There was not a ripple on it. Not a breath. Not a flicker. It lay in the bottom of the valley like a great slab of polished glass, and it held the sky.

All of it. Every cloud, every streak of gold and rose and violet from the setting sun, every first faint star. The mountains on every side, upside down, every peak and ridge and snowfield, as sharp and clear as the real ones above. There was no line between the water and the air. No horizon. You couldn't tell where the world ended and its reflection began. It was as if the valley held two skies, one above and one below, and the travelers on the ridge stood between them, suspended, floating in a great bowl of light.

And in the center of the lake, so far away it was only a faint shape in the dusk, there was nothing.

Just water. Just sky. Just reflection.

No island. No temple. Nothing.

"Mirrormere," whispered Seraphine. "The waters that hold the sky."

The lodestone in Antho's fist had stopped humming. It had gone silent. It hung on its cord, perfectly still, pointing straight down at the lake. At the center of the lake. At the place where there was nothing at all.

"Only those of the blood can find it," said Elric quietly behind them. "Everyone else who's looked for it has found nothing but an empty lake." He leaned on his staff. His face, in the last of the sunset, was very strange. "I've stood on this ridge before, you know. Three times. Over the years. And every time, that's all I saw." He was quiet for a moment. "An empty lake."

Lex looked at the lake. At the perfect stillness. At the two skies, and the nothing in the middle.

Then he looked at his brother.

Antho was looking back at him. His grey eyes were very wide. The lodestone was glowing in his fist, grey and green and blue.

Two of the blood.

"Together?" said Antho quietly.

"Together," said Lex.

CHAPTER 20

MIRRORMERE



THEY WENT DOWN TO the shore in the dark.

There was a path. They hadn't seen it from the ridge, but it was there once they started looking: a narrow track of grey stone slabs, Founders' work like the Road, winding down the steep side of the valley in long switchbacks between the pines. It was old and worn and in places half-buried under fallen needles, but it was straight and true, and it led them down, down, through the cold dark trees, until they came out onto a beach of fine pale shingle at the edge of the water.

Up close, Mirrormere was even stranger.

The water lapped at nothing. There were no waves on the shingle, no ripples, no sound at all. It lay against the shore like a sheet of black glass laid on the ground. And in it, perfectly, impossibly, the night sky was reflected: every star, every faint smear of cloud, the thin new moon just rising over the eastern peaks. Lex stood at the edge and looked down and saw the sky beneath his feet, as deep and vast and endless as the sky above, and for one dizzy moment he felt that if he stepped forward he would fall into it and never stop falling.

He took a step back.

"Don't touch it," said Elric quietly. "Not yet."

"Why not?"

"Because I touched it. The first time I came here. Twenty years ago." The old sorcerer was standing a little way along the shingle, leaning on his staff, looking at the water. "I knelt down and put my hand in it, the way

you'd put your hand in any lake." He was quiet for a moment. "It was very cold. And I saw something in it. A reflection. Not of my face." He shook his head. "I didn't touch it again."

"What did you see?" said Wren.

Elric didn't answer.



ANTHO STOOD AT THE very edge of the water with the lodestone in his fist.

It had stopped pulling. It hung perfectly still on its cord, pointing straight down at the black glass of the lake. Glowing. Grey and green and blue, twined together, pulsing slowly.

"So what do we do?" he said. "How do we call it?"

Seraphine had her green book open, the one with the drawing of Avaloria in it, and was reading it by the light of the Keeper's Lantern at Antho's belt. "*Two of the blood,*" she read. "*At the shore of the waters that hold the sky. Let the stone be given to the water, and the blood be given to the stone, and the Way will rise.*"

"*Given to the water,*" said Antho slowly. "You mean throw it in?"

"I think you mean *lay* it in. Gently." Seraphine looked up. "And then blood. From both of you. On the stone."

Antho looked down at the lodestone in his hand. At the little grey river-pebble his mother had worn every day for fifteen years. That he'd found in the ashes of their house, and worn every day for eight more.

"If it sinks," he said, "if it doesn't work—"

"Then we'll dive for it," said Lex.

Antho looked at him. Then, slowly, he lifted the cord over his head.

He knelt on the pale shingle at the edge of the black water. Lex knelt beside him. Antho held the lodestone out over the lake, on its cord, so that it hung an inch above the surface. Above its own reflection. Above the stars.

He looked at Lex.

Lex drew his knife and cut the ball of his thumb, the way Elric had cut it on the Ashbourne green, a lifetime ago. A bead of blood welled up. He held his hand out over the stone.

Antho cut his own thumb. Held it out beside Lex's.

Two drops fell. One from each of them. They struck the lodestone at the same instant.

And Antho let go of the cord.



THE STONE DIDN'T SINK.

It touched the surface of the lake, and the surface of the lake *took* it. Not like water taking a dropped pebble. Like a hand closing around something precious. The lodestone rested on the black glass, glowing, and the light from it spread outward. Grey and green and blue, rippling out across the water in rings, the first ripples Lex had seen on Mirrormere, spreading wider and wider, a hundred paces, a thousand, out toward the center of the lake.

And where the ripples passed, the reflection changed.

The stars in the water didn't vanish. But something rose up through them, as if from far below. A line. A path. A narrow road of pale silver light, glowing faintly, running out from the shingle at their feet across the surface of the lake, straight as a ruled line, toward the center. Toward the place where there was nothing.

And at the end of it, as the ripples reached the center of the lake, something *appeared*.

It came up out of the water the way a reflection comes into focus when ripples settle. An island. Small and steep and rocky, rising out of the black glass. And on the island, rising from its summit, white in the starlight, impossibly delicate, a building.

Columns. Domes. Towers. Arches. Spires so slender they looked like they'd been spun from glass. Walls of white stone that glowed faintly from within, the way the Lattice Stones glowed at dawn. A great central dome, crowned with a spire, and at the very top of the spire, a light. Gold. Steady. Like a lantern left burning in a window.

"*Avaloria*," breathed Seraphine.

Behind them, Elric made a sound. A small, broken sound, like a man who has been punched in the stomach.

Lex turned. The old sorcerer was standing on the shingle, staring out across the lake at the white temple. His face in the starlight was grey. His hand on his staff was shaking.

"Twenty years," Elric whispered. "Twenty years, I've been looking. I stood on that ridge three times. I walked this shore. I put my hand in that water." His voice cracked. "And it was here all along. Right there. And I couldn't see it."

"It opens to two of the blood," said Antho quietly. He'd risen from his knees. The lodestone had vanished; the lake had taken it, or it had become part of the silver road. He was looking at Elric with an expression Lex couldn't read. "You're not of the blood."

"No," said Elric. "No, I'm not." He laughed, very softly. It wasn't a nice sound. "I've never been of the blood. I've only ever been *beside* it."

He looked at the silver road. Then at Lex. Then at Antho.

"Will it carry me?" he said. "Will it let me walk it? Or will I step onto it and fall through into the water like a fool?"

[I don't know,] said Ember. [The Way opens to two of the blood. That's all the old texts say. They don't say whether it carries anyone else.]

Lex looked at the silver road. At the five people standing behind him on the pale shingle. Wren with her bow. Garrick with his sword. Seraphine with her spectacles and her green book. Elric with his staff, shaking. And Antho, beside him, with Ashka on his shoulder.

He held out his hand to Wren.

"Together," he said. "All of us. Hold on to each other. Whatever happens, don't let go."



THEY WALKED OUT ONTO the lake in a line, holding hands.

Antho in front. Then Lex. Then Wren, then Garrick, then Seraphine, and Elric at the back, his thin knotted hand gripping Seraphine's so hard she winced.

The silver road held them.

It was strange to walk on. Not solid like stone. Not soft like water. Something in between, faintly yielding, like walking on a taut sheet of silk. It glowed under their feet, pale silver, and on either side of it, close enough

to touch, was the black glass of the lake with the stars in it. Below them. All around them. Lex looked down and saw the sky going down and down forever, and the narrow silver road suspended above it like a thread across an abyss, and felt his stomach lurch.

"Don't look down," said Wren behind him. Her hand was very tight in his. "Climber's rule. Don't look down. Look at where you're going."

He looked at where he was going. At the white temple on its island, glowing in the starlight, growing slowly closer.

They walked for a long time. Much longer than it should have taken. The island seemed to come no closer, and then all at once it was much closer, and then it seemed to drift away again. The stars wheeled overhead. The thin moon climbed. Nobody spoke.

And then, halfway across, the road stopped.

Not ended. *Stopped*. There was a place where the silver path widened into a broad round platform, like a landing on a stair. And standing around the edge of the platform, facing inward, there were mirrors.

Six of them. Tall, oval, taller than a man, standing upright on the silver road with nothing holding them up. Their frames were white stone, carved with Wellsript. Their glass was perfectly clear, perfectly black, like the lake itself.

And in each one, there was a reflection.

Not of the platform. Not of the stars. Of *them*.



TRIAL OF THE WAY: THE MIRRORS

"See what you are. Choose what you will be."

LEX LET GO OF Wren's hand. He didn't mean to. His feet carried him across the platform on their own, toward the mirror that was waiting for him, the way his foot had carried him toward the edge of the Road in the Thornwood.

It was him.

Not him now. Him *older*. Forty, maybe. Fifty. Broad and heavy and thick-bellied, with grey in his dark hair and deep lines around his eyes and burn scars all up and down his arms. He was standing in a forge. Brannoc's

forge, in Ashbourne. Lex knew every stone of it. The same anvil. The same hearth. The same brick ledge by the fire, with a cat sleeping on it. A different cat. Slag would be long dead.

The man in the mirror was hammering a horseshoe.

He did it beautifully. Every stroke perfect. Lex could see it: the economy of motion, the ease, the decades of practice in every swing. When the shoe was done, the man lifted it in the tongs and looked at it and nodded, satisfied, and plunged it into the slack tub. Steam rose.

And a silver panel hung in the air beside him.

LEX HARROW

Class: Smith (Common)

Level: 24 (CAP)

The man in the mirror looked up. Through the glass. At Lex.

"Hello," he said.

His voice was Lex's voice. Deeper. Slower. Tired, but not unhappy.

"You could have this," said the man in the mirror. "You know that, don't you? You could still have it. Turn around. Walk back across the lake. Go home." He gestured around the forge with the tongs. "Brannoc's old now. He'll need someone to take over. You'd be good at it. You *are* good at it." He smiled. "Pell's Kindled now. He came by the forge last week. Got [Miller], poor lad. He'll get used to it. Everyone does."

Lex couldn't speak.

"It's a good life," the man in the mirror said gently. "A quiet one. Nobody hunting you. No monsters. No Wardens. No voice in your head. No father lying in a crystal waiting for you to save him." He set down the tongs. "You'll marry, probably. Someone from the village. You'll have children. You'll make ten thousand horseshoes and every one of them will be good. And you'll never once have to find out whether you're strong enough." He tilted his head. "Isn't that what you wanted? When you were sixteen? Standing in front of that Stone with your heart going? You wanted it to tell you who you were, so you wouldn't have to decide."

The fire in Lex's chest was very low.

"Level twenty-four," said the man in the mirror. "It's not so bad, you know. Brannoc was happy. Mostly. You'd be happy too." He held out his hand. Through the glass. "Come home, Lex. It's easier."

Lex looked at the hand.

It was his own hand. Scarred and calloused and strong. A smith's hand. A good hand.

He thought of Brannoc, staring at his own hands in the forge. *Nineteen years.*

He thought of the girl in Highcrest, standing in front of the white Stone with her face going carefully blank. *Laborer. Common. Next.*

He thought of Wren in the clearing at the heart of the Thornwood, looking at a panel only she could see. *That's that, then.*

"It's not so bad," he said slowly. "You're right. It's not so bad for *me*." He looked at the man in the mirror. "I'd be fine. I'd be happy, probably. I'd make good horseshoes." He swallowed. "And the girl in Highcrest would still be a Laborer. And Brannoc would still be twenty-four. And Wren would still be stuck. And every kid in every village would still put their hand on a rigged Stone and be told what they are." He shook his head. "I can't. I can't go home and make horseshoes knowing that. Knowing I could have done something."

"You don't know that you can."

"No," said Lex. "I don't. But I'm going to find out."

The man in the mirror looked at him for a long moment. Then he smiled. Not sadly. Something else. Something almost proud.

"Good," he said. "That's the right answer. I always hoped I'd give it."

And the mirror *cracked*.

A single line, from top to bottom, through the center of the glass. Then a hundred lines, spreading out like frost. And then the whole thing shattered, silently, into a thousand glittering pieces that fell and dissolved before they touched the silver road.

MIRROR OF THE SELF – BROKEN

Choice: "I'm going to find out."



HE TURNED AROUND.

Wren was standing in front of her mirror with her hand pressed against the glass and tears running down her face. Lex looked past her, into it, and saw what she saw.

The sky.

A great wide blue sky, and a figure in it. Wren. Not on a mountain. Not climbing. *Flying*. Arms spread, braid streaming, high above a grey-green world spread out below her like a map. The wind lifting her. Carrying her. She was laughing.

And beside her, in the air, a silver panel.

WREN ASHDOWN

Class:  (Epic)

Level: 51

"That's not real," Wren whispered. "That's not real. That can't happen. That's not—"

"*It could be,*" said the Wren in the mirror, from the sky. Her voice was carried on the wind. "*If you let it.*"

Wren pulled her hand away from the glass. She stood there shaking.

"I don't want to want it," she said. "I don't want to want it that much. It hurts. It hurts to want something you can't have."

"*Who says you can't?*"

Wren didn't answer. She turned away from the mirror. She looked across the platform at Lex, and her face was wet and furious and terrified.

And her mirror didn't crack. It just went dark. Quietly. Like a lantern going out. Waiting.



GARRICK WAS KNEELING BEFORE his mirror, the way he'd knelt in the burned smithy. Oathkeeper was point-down before him. In the glass, Lex saw a woman in a blue dress, standing in a garden. And a young woman beside her, in armor, with a captain's sash and a crooked nose. They were both smiling at him.

Garriick wasn't crying. He was just looking. His face was very peaceful.

"I'm on the steps," he told them quietly. "I'm standing on the steps."

His mirror shattered.

Seraphine stood before hers with her arms wrapped around herself. In her glass, she was sitting at a long table in a vast library, white and gold and full of light, surrounded by books, reading. People were coming to her. Asking her questions. Listening to her answers. Respecting her. Her reflection looked up from the book and smiled.

Seraphine bit her lip. She stood there a long time. And then she said, very quietly, "I'd rather be out here. Being useful. Even if nobody believes me."

Her mirror shattered.



AND ANTHO.

Lex had been afraid to look. He looked now.

His brother was standing before the sixth mirror, very still, with Ashka on his shoulder and the Keeper's Lantern glowing at his belt.

And in the mirror was Antho.

But not Antho. His eyes were black. Fully black, edge to edge, like holes cut in the world. And his face was calm. Utterly, terribly calm. Peaceful. Serene. The face of a man who'd never once heard a voice in his head, because he *was* the voice.

"Hello, Anthoren," said the thing in the mirror.

Its voice was Antho's voice. And under it, a second voice. Wet and soft and hungry. The Murmur, wearing his face.

"It's quiet in here," the thing said. "*Did you know that? It's so quiet. No arguing. No fighting. No screaming at three in the morning. No lanterns. No little brother to look after. Just quiet.*" It smiled. Antho's smile, crooked and sad. "*You've been fighting me for eight years. Aren't you tired? Don't you want to rest?*"

Antho didn't move.

"Let me in," said the thing in the mirror. "*All the way. Stop holding the door. Stop keeping it shut. Just let go, and let me in, and you'll never hear me again. Because there won't be anyone left to hear.*" It tilted its head. "*Your mother went into the dark. Don't you want to be with her?*"

CLARITY: 79 → 71 ▼
71 → 63 ▼

Lex took a step toward him.

"No," said Antho.

Lex stopped.

His brother hadn't turned around. He was looking straight into the mirror, into the black eyes of the thing wearing his face. His hand had gone to the Keeper's Lantern at his belt. He was holding it.

"No," Antho said again. Quietly. Steadily. "I'm tired. You're right. I'm so tired I could lie down on this road and sleep for a year." His fingers tightened on the lantern. "But she didn't go into the dark so I could follow her. She went in so I wouldn't have to." He took a breath. "She said *I'll keep the door*. Not *we'll*. *I'll*. She kept it. For me. For Lex." He lifted his chin. "And now it's my turn. I'm keeping it. For as long as I have to. And I'm not letting you through."

"*You can't hold it forever.*"

"No," said Antho. "Probably not." He glanced back over his shoulder. At Lex. "But I don't have to hold it alone anymore."

He turned back to the mirror.

"I keep the door," he said. "That's what I am. Not you. *Me*."

The thing in the mirror looked at him for a long moment. Its black eyes were unreadable.

Then it smiled. A different smile. Not Antho's. Something older. Something hungry and patient and very, very old.

"*For now*," it said.

And the mirror shattered.

CLARITY: 63 → 82 ▲▲

 - repelled

MIRROR OF THE SELF - BROKEN

Choice: "I keep the door."

Antho stood very still in the falling glitter of the broken glass. Then his knees gave out, and he sat down hard on the silver road, and Ashka climbed down into his lap and pressed against his chest, rumbling.

Lex went and sat down beside him. Their shoulders touched.
Neither of them said anything.



IT WAS ONLY LATER, much later, after Wren had come and sat down on Lex's other side, and Garrick and Seraphine had joined them, that Lex realized someone was missing.

Elric.

He looked around. There were six mirrors on the platform. Five of them had shattered, or gone dark. Lex's. Wren's, dark and waiting. Garrick's. Seraphine's. Antho's.

The sixth was still standing.

Elric stood in front of it. He'd been standing there the whole time, Lex realized. All through the others. Silent. Motionless. Leaning on his staff with both hands, staring into the glass.

Lex got up. He walked across the platform, slowly, quietly. He didn't mean to look. He told himself afterward that he hadn't meant to look.

He looked.

In the mirror, there was a room.

A vast round room, white and high-domed, with a floor like black glass. The room Lex had seen in the vision in the Barrow-King's hall. And in the center of the room, where the crystal had been, there was a throne. A tall white throne, carved with Wellsript, glowing gold.

And Elric was sitting on it.

Not old. Young. Thirty, maybe. Tall and straight and handsome, with dark hair and bright storm-grey eyes and no scar on his face. He wore a long dark coat, like the coat Lex had seen on his father in the vision. And around his head, floating, a circlet of light. Gold. Root-gold.

Above his head, a panel.

ELRIC THORNE
Class: 
Tier IV – Level 99
Authority: 100 / 100

The young Elric on the throne was smiling. Not kindly. Not warmly. The smile of a man who has finally, finally been given what he was owed.

And the room around him was empty.

Completely empty. No one else. No friends, no family, no voices, no faces. Just the vast white dome and the black glass floor and the throne in the middle and the one man sitting on it, alone, crowned with gold, smiling at nothing.

The old Elric stood in front of the mirror and looked at it. His face was grey. His hands on his staff were white at the knuckles.

He didn't shatter it.

He didn't turn away.

He just stood there and *looked*. The way a starving man looks through a window at a feast.

Then he turned his head, very slowly, and saw Lex standing beside him.

For one long moment, they looked at each other.

Lex saw the old sorcerer's face change. Saw something go across it, quick as a fish's tail in dark water. Shame. Fear. And under them, very deep, something hard and cold and bitter that Lex had heard once before. A dull note under the ring of good iron.

Then it was gone. Smoothed away. And Elric was only an old man again, tired and grey and leaning on his staff.

"Don't," he said quietly. "Don't ask me, Lex. Please." He looked back at the mirror. At the young man on the throne. "We all have things we want. Things we're ashamed to want." His voice was very soft. "That's all this is. A foolish old man's foolish dream."

He reached out with the end of his staff and touched the glass.

It didn't shatter. It went dark. Slowly. Like the mirror in front of Wren. Not broken. Just waiting.

"Come on," said Elric. He turned away from it. "We're nearly there."

He walked across the platform toward the silver road, toward the island, toward the white temple glowing in the starlight.

Lex stood alone in front of the dark mirror for a long moment.

[*Lex,*] said Ember. Its voice was very quiet. Very careful. [*Did you see the class name? On the panel?*]

It was obscured.

[*Not to me.*] A long pause. [*I could read it. Through the obscuring. Just barely.*]

What did it say?

Ember didn't answer for a long time.

[Warden-Architect,] it said at last.

Lex closed his eyes.

[It's only a mirror,] said Ember. [It only shows what people want. Not what they'll do. Everyone wants things they shouldn't. Wren wants to fly. Garrick wants his wife back. Your brother wants silence. It doesn't mean—]

I know, Lex thought.

[It doesn't mean anything.]

I know.

But when he turned and followed the others across the platform toward the island, he walked a little faster than he needed to. And he made sure that, when they took hands again to walk the last stretch of the silver road, he was the one standing between Elric and his brother.

CHAPTER 21

THE TEMPLE OF AVALORIA



THE SILVER ROAD ENDED at the foot of a stair.

It was white stone, like the temple above it, and it climbed the steep rocky side of the island in a single straight flight, a hundred steps, two hundred, so many that Lex stopped counting. Antho didn't stop counting. Antho never stopped counting. "Three hundred and sixty-five," he said, when they reached the top. "One for every day."

"Of course it is," said Seraphine faintly, leaning on Garrick's arm.

At the top of the stair was a door.

It was enormous. Taller than the bronze door of the Barrow Throne, taller than the gates of Highcrest. Two great leaves of white stone, smooth and seamless, glowing faintly from within. There was no handle. No hinge. No lock. In the center, where the two leaves met, there was a single carving, waist-high, deep-cut and perfect.

An open hand. And above the palm, a flame.

Lex looked at it. Then at Antho.

"Together," said his brother.

They put their hands on it. Lex's right, Antho's left. Side by side, palms flat on the white stone, fingers just touching.

The door didn't open. It *dissolved*. One moment it was there, solid and white and seamless. The next it was light. Pale gold, shimmering, like sunlight on water. And then it was gone, and there was only an archway, and beyond it, darkness.

And a voice. Not Ember. Not the Murmur. Something vast and old and impersonal, like the voice of the Lattice itself, speaking in Wellscrip that Lex somehow understood.

BLOOD OF THE ROOT RECOGNIZED
LEXANDER VEY
ANTHOREN VEY
WELCOME HOME.
Companions of the blood: PERMITTED
(under guardianship)

Welcome home.

Lex stood in the archway and couldn't move.

"What?" said Wren behind him. "What is it? What does it say?"

"It says *welcome home*," said Antho. His voice was very strange.



THE INSIDE OF THE temple was white.

White stone walls, white stone floors, white columns rising up into darkness overhead. Everything glowed faintly, the way the door had glowed, a soft pale light that came from the stone itself and cast no shadows. It was very quiet. Their footsteps echoed. Their breath smoked in the cold air.

And everywhere, on every wall, every column, every floor-slab, there was Wellscrip. Carved deep and fine and precise, in lines and spirals and great concentric circles. Seraphine made a sound like someone who'd walked into a room full of treasure and didn't know where to look first.

"Don't touch anything," said Elric sharply.

Seraphine snatched her hand back from a column.

They walked. There was only one way to go: a long white corridor running straight into the heart of the island, wide enough for ten people abreast, high enough that the ceiling was lost in shadow. At the end of it, far ahead, there was a faint gold glow.

They'd gone perhaps a hundred paces when the light came out of the walls.

It came in shapes. Tall shapes, man-shaped, but taller. Made of light. Pale gold, translucent, shimmering, like figures seen through a heat-haze. They stepped out of the white walls on either side of the corridor as if the stone were water, and turned, and faced the six of them, and raised their hands.

They held swords. Swords of light, long and straight and blazing.

LUMEN WARDEN – Level 22–26

(×12)

Founders' Guardian

"Under guardianship," said Seraphine weakly. "It said *companions permitted under guardianship*."

"I think," said Garrick, drawing Oathkeeper, "this is the guardianship."



THE LUMEN WARDENS DIDN'T attack Lex. Or Antho.

That became clear in the first heartbeat. Twelve shining figures stepped out of the walls, and ten of them moved toward Garrick and Wren and Seraphine and Elric, swords raised, and two of them stopped in front of Lex and Antho and simply *stood there*. Blocking the way. Not threatening. Waiting.

"They're testing the others," said Antho. "Not us."

[*Testing whether the companions are worthy,*] said Ember. [*Or whether they're a danger to the blood.*]

Garrick met the first one with Oathkeeper. The sword of light and the sword of frost-steel clashed with a sound like a bell, and gold sparks showered across the white floor. The Lumen Warden staggered. Garrick pressed forward. Behind him, Wren was loosing arrows, and they struck the shining figures and passed through them in bursts of gold light, and the figures flickered and wavered but didn't fall.

Elric raised his staff, and lightning cracked down the corridor and struck three of them at once, and they *screamed*: a high, pure, ringing scream, like a crystal glass shattering. They came apart in clouds of glittering motes. And then the motes drew back together, and they reformed, and came on.

"*They're made of Lattice!*" Elric shouted. "*Pure Lattice! You can't kill them, you can only scatter them!*"

"*Then how do we get past?*" Wren shouted back.

Lex looked at the two Lumen Wardens standing in front of him and Antho. Motionless. Waiting.

He used True Sight.

The world flickered gold. And the shining figure in front of him *opened*, the way the Lattice Stone in Highcrest had opened. He saw what it was made of. Silver threads. Thousands of them, woven together into the shape of a man. And at the center of the weaving, where a heart would be, a single glyph. Gold. Root-gold.

Guard.

And beneath it, smaller:

Yield to the blood.

"They take orders," he said. "Antho. They take orders from *us*."

Antho looked at him. Then at the shining figure in front of him. Then back.

"Orders," he said slowly.

Lex stepped forward. He walked straight up to the Lumen Warden, so close he could feel the faint warmth coming off its shining body. He looked up into its blank, featureless face.

"Stop," he said. "They're with us. They're not a danger. *Stop.*"

The Lumen Warden didn't move.

[Not in words,] said Ember quietly. *[In Root. Say it the way you'd say catch to a fire. The way you'd say Homeward to the hammer.]*

Lex closed his eyes. He reached down, past the silver, the way he'd done with Vane's chain. Down to the gold. And he thought, not in words, but in fire, in intent, in the language under language:

STOP. They are mine. They walk with the blood.

He felt the gold go out of him. A small draining. Like a thread pulled from a spool.

PREROGATIVE (minor): COMMAND

Authority -5 (41 → 36)

And all twelve Lumen Wardens stopped.

Mid-swing. Mid-stride. Mid-scream. They froze in place, shining, and then, slowly, all together, they lowered their swords. They turned. And they bowed. All twelve of them, at once, a deep slow bow, toward Lex and Antho.

Then they stepped back into the walls and were gone.



THE CORRIDOR WAS SILENT.

Garrick stood with Oathkeeper still raised, breathing hard, frost dripping off the blade. Wren had an arrow half-drawn. Seraphine was flat against a column with her crossbow clutched to her chest. And Elric was standing in the middle of the corridor, very still, with lightning still crackling faintly around the head of his staff, staring at Lex.

"You *commanded* them," he said quietly.

"I asked them to stop."

"You *commanded* them. With Root." Elric's voice was very strange. "Founders' guardians. Nine hundred years old. And they bowed to you." He let out a long breath. "Your father did that once. In the Spire. Spoke to the Great Stone, and the whole Spire lit up like a bonfire, and every Warden in the building felt it." He shook his head slowly. "He was thirty years old. And I'd been trying to make the Great Stone so much as *flicker* for ten years."

He lowered his staff. The lightning faded.

"Well," he said, with an effort at lightness that didn't quite land. "It's very useful to have you along."

LUMEN WARDENS ×12 – DISMISSED

+XP (shared)

LEVEL UP! Lex – Level 23

LEVEL UP! Lex – Level 24

And then, beneath it, a second panel. Grey-edged. Plain. A panel Lex had seen only once before, over Wren's shoulder, in the clearing at the heart of the Thornwood.

LEX VEY – Level 24**TIER I COMPLETE**

Further advancement requires:

- TIER TRIAL at a Trial Gate
- SANCTION: not granted

Experience held in reserve.

He stopped walking.

He stood in the white corridor and looked at it. *Sanction: not granted.* The same grey letters. The same flat, final, indifferent tone. *Experience held in reserve.* As if the Lattice were a clerk at a counter, sliding a form back across the desk: *Sorry. Not without the proper stamp.*

He'd known it was coming. Ember had told him about Tiers, and Trials, and Sanctions. Elric had told him. He'd known, in his head, that at twenty-four he'd need a Trial Gate and the right permission to go further.

He hadn't known what it would *feel* like.

It felt like a door closing. A heavy door. Iron. With no handle on his side.

"Hammer?"

Wren had come up beside him. She was looking at his face. And she knew. He saw her know. Saw her see the grey panel in his eyes, or in his face, or in the set of his shoulders.

"Twenty-four," she said quietly.

"Twenty-four."

She didn't say anything for a moment. Then she bumped her shoulder against his arm, gently, the way she did.

"Now you know," she said.

He looked at her.

"Now you know what it feels like," said Wren. Her voice wasn't bitter. It was just very tired, and very honest. "Mine doesn't say *Trial Gate*. Mine doesn't say *Sanction*. Mine just says *cap reached*. That's all. Forever." She looked up at him. "But now you know. A little. What it feels like to stand at the door."

Lex looked at her for a long moment.

"Yes," he said. "Now I know."

"Good," said Wren. "Don't forget it."



THE CORRIDOR RAN ON. And at the end of it, there was a chasm.

The white floor simply stopped. Beyond it was nothing. Darkness. A great round shaft dropping away into the heart of the island, so deep that the faint light from the walls didn't reach the bottom. Cold air rose out of it. And something else. A smell Lex knew. Faint, very faint, but there.

Wet ash. Rot. Nothing.

"The Hollow," said Antho quietly. He'd stopped at the very edge, looking down. His face had gone pale. "It's down there. Not the Gloam. The *thing*. Under everything." His hand went to the Keeper's Lantern at his belt. "I can feel it. It's so far down. But it's there."

CLARITY: 82 → 77 ▼



– stirring (proximity)

On the far side of the chasm, thirty paces away, the corridor went on. White floor. White walls. And the gold glow, much closer now, much brighter.

There was no bridge.

There were two plates of white stone set into the floor at the edge of the chasm, one on each side of the corridor, ten paces apart. Each one was carved with a hand. A right hand on the left plate. A left hand on the right plate.

"*The Bridge of Two Hands*," read Seraphine from her green book. Her voice was very quiet. "*Let the blood stand apart, and reach together.*"

Lex looked at the two plates. Ten paces apart. Too far to touch each other.

"Apart," said Antho slowly. "And together."

They went to the plates. Lex to the left. Antho to the right. Ten paces apart, on either side of the corridor, with the chasm yawning in front of them. They knelt. They laid their hands flat on the carved stone. Lex's right. Antho's left.

Nothing happened.

"Authority," said Lex suddenly. "It wants Authority. Root. Like the Lumen Wardens."

[Not just Authority,] said Ember. [Both of you. At the same time. Reaching for each other.]

Lex closed his eyes. He reached down past the silver to the gold. And then he reached *out*. Across the ten paces of white floor. Through the Bloodbond. Toward the cold, still, deep pool that was his brother.

He felt Antho reaching back.

They met in the middle. Over the chasm. Fire and dark, gold and shadow, two threads of Root reaching across the empty air and touching, and twining, and holding.

BLOODBOND – SHARED AUTHORITY	
Lex: 36 → 26	
Anthoren:  → 	

And the bridge appeared.

It came up out of the dark of the chasm like a thing being drawn on the air with a pen of light. Gold, from Lex's side. Black, from Antho's. Two threads, braided together, spanning the thirty paces of empty space from one edge of the corridor to the other. Not wide. Barely wide enough to walk. A rope bridge made of fire and shadow, glowing and pulsing, humming faintly with power.

"Lady of Lanterns," whispered Garrick.

"Go," said Lex, through his teeth. Holding the bridge took everything he had. He could feel it pulling on him, through the plate, through the Bloodbond. "Go now. All of you. We can't hold it long."

They went. Wren first, of course, light-footed as a cat, not looking down. Then Seraphine, with Garrick's hand on her shoulder steadying her. Then Garrick. Then Elric, slowly, leaning on his staff, his face grey.

Halfway across, Elric stopped.

He stood on the braided bridge of gold and black, thirty paces above the bottomless dark, and looked down. Into the chasm. Into the Hollow. And Lex, kneeling at his plate with sweat pouring down his face, saw the old sorcerer's lips move.

He couldn't hear what Elric said. But Antho could. Lex felt it through the Bloodbond: a sudden stab of cold from his brother, a sudden flicker of shock.

Then Elric walked on, and reached the far side, and turned around.

"*Now you,*" he called. "*Both of you. Together.*"

Lex and Antho stood up from the plates. The bridge flickered but held. They walked out onto it from opposite ends, Lex on the gold side, Antho on the black, until they met in the middle, above the darkness. And then they walked the rest of the way side by side, each with one hand on the other's shoulder, and the bridge held, and they stepped off onto the far side of the chasm.

The bridge faded behind them like a dream.



"**WHAT DID HE SAY?**" Lex asked his brother quietly, a little later, as they walked on down the white corridor. "Elric. On the bridge. I saw his lips move."

Antho didn't answer for a long moment.

"He was talking to it," he said at last. "To the thing. Down in the Hollow." His voice was very low. "He said *not yet*."

Lex stopped walking.

"*Not yet,*" Antho repeated. "That's all. Just those two words. Very quiet. Like he was talking to a dog that was pulling on its leash." He looked at Lex. "And the thing in my head heard him. And it went quiet. For a moment. Like it was *listening*."

They looked at each other in the glowing white corridor.

Ahead of them, Elric was walking with Garrick, talking quietly, leaning on his staff. His grey cloak swayed. The brass storm-charms on it chimed faintly.

"Maybe he was talking to himself," said Lex.

"Maybe," said Antho.

Neither of them believed it.



THE CORRIDOR ENDED IN a round chamber with an anvil in it.

It was the most beautiful anvil Lex had ever seen. White stone, like everything else in the temple, but not stone. Something harder. Something that rang faintly when he came near it, the way Anvilsong rang, a deep humming note that he felt in his teeth. It stood on a plinth in the center of the chamber, waist-high, its face worn smooth and polished by long-ago hands, its horn curving out elegant and sharp. Around it, set into the floor in a perfect circle, was a ring of Wellsript, glowing gold.

And above it, hanging in the air, a panel.

TRIAL GATE: THE ANVIL OF ASCENT

TIER TRIAL – Tier I → Tier II

Required: SANCTION

Status: NOT GRANTED

Trial unavailable.

Lex stood in front of the anvil and read it, and felt the iron door close again in his chest.

Not granted.

"Of course," said Elric quietly behind him. "Of course. Even here. The Order's rules reach even here." His voice was bitter. "They wrote the Sanction into the Lattice three hundred years ago, and now even the Founders' own Trial Gates obey it."

Lex looked at the panel. *Not granted.*

He thought of Wren in the corridor. *Now you know.*

He thought of Brannoc. Of the girl in Highcrest. Of three hundred years of children putting their hands on rigged Stones.

He thought: *The Order wrote this. People wrote this. It's not the Lattice. It's not the Founders. It's a rule some Warden added because he could.*

And he thought: *I'm a Vey.*

He reached down past the silver to the gold, and he laid his hand on the anvil.



The anvil *rang*.

It was like Anvilsong's ring at the end of its forging. Like Oathkeeper's ring when Garrick swore his oath. But deeper. Much deeper. A single vast

note that went down through the floor and into the island and into the black glass of the lake and out across the whole valley, so that Lex felt the mountains themselves shiver with it.

The panel above the anvil flickered.

The grey letters wavered. *SANCTION: NOT GRANTED.* They blurred, the way the Spirit score on his panel had blurred on the night Elric cut his thumb on the Ashbourne Stone. And then, through them, under them, behind them, something else showed through. Gold. Root-gold.

FOUNDERS' GATE
Original law: SUPERSEDES
SANCTION requirement: added later (Warden amendment, 300 yrs)
Founders' Gates do not recognize Warden amendments.
BLOOD OF THE ROOT: Sanction WAIVED.
TIER TRIAL – available. Begin?

Behind him, Lex heard Elric draw in a sharp breath.

"Yes," said Lex.



THE TRIAL WAS SIMPLE.

That was what the panel said, when it unrolled itself in gold in front of his eyes. *Forge.* That was all. *Forge something worthy of the next tier.*

He knew what he was going to forge. He'd known it from the moment he saw the anvil.

He laid Anvilson on its white face.

[Lex,] said Ember. [Are you sure?]

It's the best thing I've made. It's the first thing I made. It has the nail in it. He laid his palm flat on the hammer's head. *If I'm going to forge something worthy, I'm going to make it better. Not start over.*

[Reforging is harder than forging. You know that. You have to take out what's wrong without losing what's right.]

I know.

He called the heat. Not into a forge. There was no forge here. Into the anvil itself. Into the white stone, through his palm, and the anvil took it and *glowed*, and the hammer lying on it began to heat. Red. Orange. Gold.

And then the Trial began.

It wasn't a monster. It wasn't a riddle. It wasn't a mirror.

It was the metal.

As Anvilsong heated on the white anvil, Lex began to hear it. The way he heard slag pockets in a bar. The way he'd heard the flaw in the horseshoe on the morning Elric came to Ashbourne. A dull note, under the ring. Not one. Many. Flaws. Buried deep in the iron.

He'd never heard them before. Anvilsong was the best work he'd ever done. He'd have sworn on Brannoc's life it was flawless.

But the anvil was showing them to him. Drawing them up out of the heart of the metal, the way heat draws water out of wood.

And they weren't slag.

The first one he touched with his Forge Sense was hate.

He heard it. Felt it. A hard dark knot deep in the iron, where he'd folded the bar over the horseshoe nail on that first night in Ashbourne. His hate for Antho. Eight years of it. He hadn't known it was there. He'd been hammering it into the metal with every blow, that night, without knowing. *Murderer. Monster. He left me there.*

[You put yourself into everything you make,] said Ember quietly. *[Every smith does. You just put more of yourself in than most.]*

It's not there anymore. The hate. I forgave him. On the Oracle's steps.

[You forgave him. But you never took it out of the iron.]

So he took it out.

He did it the way you work out a slag pocket. Not by hiding it. Not by hammering over it and hoping it would hold. You find it. You heat the metal around it until it's soft. You fold the bar back on itself and hammer the flaw out to the surface, where you can see it, and then you cut it away. And you let the good metal close over the place where it was.

It hurt. Not his body. Something deeper. He heard the hate come up through the iron, and he heard himself at eleven, sobbing in the wet grass outside a burning house, and he heard himself at fifteen, alone in the loft

above the forge, building that hate up brick by brick into a house with no doors. And he cut it away. And the metal closed over it, clean.

The next one was his father.

He left. He chose that over us. He never cared. A hard black seam running through the whole length of the haft, where he'd fitted the ash wood to the iron. He'd been thinking about his father that whole night. He'd hammered his father into every blow.

He heated the iron around it. He folded it out. He looked at it.

He thought about a man walking up and down in the dark, singing off-key to a sick child. He thought about a man crouching in a muddy road, folding a little boy's fingers closed over a horseshoe nail. *Keep it, little smith.* He thought about a man in a crystal, opening grey eyes, mouthing his name.

He didn't know yet if he could forgive his father. He didn't know if he wanted to. But he knew that the hate in this seam was built on a story that wasn't true, a story about a man who hadn't cared. And whatever his father was, he wasn't that.

He cut it away.

There were others. Smaller. Leaving Brannoc standing alone at the edge of the cobbles. Not seeing the hunger in Wren's eyes at the Last Hearth until she told him about her mother. Laughing at Pell. Hating himself, at sixteen, standing in front of the Ashbourne Stone, reading *Common* four times and smiling until his face hurt.

One by one, he found them. One by one, he heated the iron around them and folded them out where he could see them and cut them away. It took a long time. He lost track of how long. His arms ached. His eyes streamed. His mana bar dropped, and dropped, and the anvil drank the heat out of him like a thirsty man drinking from a well.

And then there was one left.

It was very deep. Right at the heart of the hammerhead. Folded around the horseshoe nail itself. And it wasn't hate. It wasn't anger.

It was fear.

The fear he'd felt, at four years old, in the muddy road, watching a tall man in a dark coat walk away into the mist. The fear he'd carried every day of his life since. The fear he'd hammered into the nail, and folded into the

hammer, and carried on his shoulder up the mountains and through the forest and across the lake.

Everyone leaves.

He held his Forge Sense on it for a long time.

[You don't have to cut that one out,] said Ember quietly. *[Not today. Some fears are too deep. Some you carry your whole life.]*

If I don't take it out, the hammer won't be worthy.

[Maybe. Or maybe a smith who's afraid of being left is a smith who will never leave anyone himself.] A pause. *[Maybe that's not a flaw, Lex. Maybe that's the temper.]*

Lex stood at the anvil with the glowing hammer under his hands and thought about that.

He thought about Antho in the Thornwood, walking toward the doorway in the trees, and himself standing in front of his brother with his hands on his chest. *Look after me.* He thought about Garrick on the chapel steps. About Hedda in her shop, stalling the Wardens so they could run. About Wren, following him down the mountain in the dark with an arrow on the string, when she'd said she was going home.

Everyone leaves.

No, he thought. Not everyone. Not anymore.

He didn't cut the fear out.

He *tempered* it.

He heated it, gently, the way you'd temper a blade: not to soften it, but to change it. To make it less brittle. More springy. To give it a little flex, so it wouldn't shatter under a hard blow. And as he did, he put a rune into it. Not one he'd been taught. Not one from the *Book of Making*. One that came up out of him from the place under the gold, the way the fourth rune had come on that first night.

A shape like a hand held out. Not open, this time. Closed. Holding on to another hand.

Stay.



THE HAMMER RANG.

It was the loudest sound he'd ever heard. Louder than the anvil. Louder than the Rimewarden's fall. Louder than Oathkeeper. A single vast singing note that filled the round chamber and the white corridor and the whole temple and the whole island, and went out across the lake, across the valley, across the mountains, so loud that Lex thought every person in Aldermere must hear it.

Gold light poured off the anvil. Off the hammer. Off *him*.

He quenched Anvilson in nothing. There was no slack tub. He held it up in the air, glowing white-gold, and the cold of the temple flowed over it, and it cooled, slowly, from white to gold to orange to red to the deep dark iron-black it had always been. But not quite the same black. There was something in it now. A sheen. Like embers glowing deep under ash. Like a fire banked for the night that would never, ever go out.

ITEM REFORGED

ANVILSONG

Two-handed war-hammer

Grade: SUPERIOR → MASTERWORK

Maker: Lex Vey, Emberwright

Runes:

ARDENT – Ember Strike +40%,
–8 mana

STEADFAST – cannot break while its
maker lives

HOMEWARD – returns to the maker's
hand (100 paces)

VEY – THE HAND HELD OUT
Once per day: give your
strength to another
(health or mana, up to half
your own)

STAY – the bearer cannot be
severed from those he holds
dear by any working of the
Lattice or the Hollow

Flaws: NONE

"It remembers the hand that made it.
And the hands it held."

The fourth rune. *The Hand Held Out*. He could read it now. He'd always been able to read it, he realized. He just hadn't been ready.

And then the other panel.

TIER TRIAL – COMPLETE

LEX VEY

Class: EMBERWRIGHT (Unique)

TIER II – ADEPT

Level: 24 → 25 → 26 → 27

(reserve experience applied)

Tier II gift: KINDLE

Imbue an ally's weapon or
arrows with your fire.

ROOT

Prerogative unlocked: SANCTION

Prerogative: UNBIND – [LOCKED]

requires: Tier III, Authority 60+

He stood at the white anvil with the hammer in his hands and the gold light fading around him, and he couldn't move.

Twenty-seven.

Tier Two.

Sanction: unlocked.

He turned around.

They were all standing at the edge of the chamber, where the corridor came in. Wren. Garrick. Seraphine. Antho. They were staring at him. Antho's face was white. Seraphine had both hands over her mouth. Garrick looked as if he'd seen a god walk out of a forge. Wren was crying, very quietly, the tears running down her freckled face, and she didn't wipe them away.

And Elric.

Elric stood a little apart from the others, leaning on his staff with both hands, and his face was the face Lex had seen in the mirror on the silver road. The face of a starving man looking through a window at a feast.

"*Sanction waived*," the old sorcerer whispered. "*Sanction waived*. Just like that. Because of your blood." His voice cracked. "Do you know how long I waited? For mine? Do you know how many times I stood in front of

the Great Stone in the Spire and begged? *Twice* they said no. *Twice*. And the third time—" He stopped. His jaw clenched. "And you walk in here and put your hand on an anvil, and the Founders themselves say *you don't need permission*."

"Elric—"

"No." The old sorcerer straightened. He smoothed his face. It took him a visible effort. "No. Forgive me. That was unworthy. I'm happy for you, Lex. Truly." He smiled. It didn't reach his eyes. "Some of us have to earn what others are born holding. That's all. That's the way the world is. It isn't your fault."

He turned away.

Wren was watching him go. Her face was wet, but her eyes were very sharp.



BEYOND THE ANVIL OF Ascent, there was one more door.

It was small. Much smaller than the great white door at the top of the stair. Just an archway in the white wall, the height of a man, with the open hand and the flame carved over it. And through it, gold light. Warm, steady, pulsing slowly. Like a heartbeat.

Antho was standing in front of it. He'd walked there while the others were still staring at Lex. He was standing very still, with Ashka on his shoulder and the Keeper's Lantern glowing at his belt, looking through the archway at the light.

Lex went and stood beside him.

Through the archway, he could see a room. Round. Vast. High-domed. White walls carved with Wellsript, glowing gold. A floor like black glass, like still water, like Mirrormere itself.

And in the center of the floor, rising up out of the black glass, a crystal.

Taller than a man. Clear as ice. Faceted like a jewel. Glowing from within.

And inside it, standing upright with his arms at his sides and his eyes closed and his face turned slightly upward, there was a man in a long dark coat. Silver at the temples. A long straight nose. A jaw Lex had seen in the still water of a stream, on his brother's freshly-shaven face.

Their father.

Neither of them moved.

"Fifteen years," said Antho, very quietly.

"Fifteen years," said Lex.

They stood in the archway side by side, looking at the man in the crystal. And Lex felt his brother's hand find his. Long scarred fingers, cold, shaking. He held on.

"Together?" said Antho.

"Together."

They walked through the archway into the heart of Avaloria.

And as they stepped onto the black glass floor, the light inside the crystal *moved*. It flowed outward, through the faceted walls, into the air of the chamber. It gathered. It took shape. Pale gold, translucent, shimmering, like the Lumen Wardens but softer, warmer. The shape of a man. Tall. Lean. In a long dark coat. With silver at his temples and grey eyes and a face that was very hard to remember even while you were looking at it.

The shape looked at them. At Lex. At Antho. At their joined hands.

And it smiled. A tired smile, and sad, and so full of love that Lex couldn't breathe.

"Hello, boys," said Arion Vey.

CHAPTER 22

THE ETHEREAL FATHER



FOR A LONG MOMENT, nobody said anything at all.

Lex stood on the black glass floor with his brother's hand crushed in his and looked at the shape of light standing in front of the crystal. At the long dark coat, pale gold and translucent. At the silver temples. At the grey eyes. At the face that slid off his attention like water off oiled leather, so that he had to keep looking, and looking, to hold it.

He had imagined this moment every night for fifteen years.

He had imagined what he would say. He'd had whole speeches, once. When he was small, they'd been speeches about how he'd been good, how he'd helped Mam, how he'd learned to read. When he was older, after the fire, they'd been speeches about how much he hated him. How he'd left. How he'd never come back. How Mam had died waiting. He'd rehearsed them in the loft above the forge, lying awake, until he could say them in his sleep.

He couldn't remember a single word of any of them.

"Hello," he said.

It came out very small.

His father's face did something complicated. The shape of light was faint, flickering at the edges like a candle in a draft, and it was hard to read its expression. But Lex saw the grey eyes fill. Saw the lips press together. Saw the long hands, translucent and gold, curl slowly into fists at his sides, the way Antho's did when he was trying not to feel something.

"Lexander," said Arion Vey. His voice was quiet and deep and a little rough. It was exactly the voice from the Thornwood, the voice Lex had imagined his whole life. It was nothing like it. It was better and worse. "Look at you. Look how tall you are." He swallowed. "You were so small. The last time. I could hold you in one arm."

Lex couldn't answer.

Arion's eyes moved to Antho.

"Anthoren," he said. And his voice broke completely on the name.

Antho didn't move. He was standing perfectly still beside Lex, his hand rigid in Lex's grip, his face white as the walls of the temple. Ashka was on his shoulder, very still too, her golden eyes fixed on the shape of light.

"Antho," said their father. "I'm so—"

"Don't."

Antho's voice was flat. Dead. A voice Lex hadn't heard from him since the Hollowmaw.

"Don't say it," said Antho. "Don't say you're sorry. Not yet. I'm not ready to hear it." His jaw worked. "I don't know if I'll ever be ready to hear it."

Arion closed his mouth.

The two of them looked at each other across the black glass floor. Father and son. The same jaw, the same long straight nose, the same grey eyes. One made of light. One made of eight years of darkness.

"All right," said Arion quietly. "All right. I won't say it." He bowed his head. "Not until you want me to."

CLARITY: 77 → 68 ▼



THE OTHERS HAD COME to the archway behind them. Lex heard them. Felt them. Wren's quick light step, Garrick's heavy one, Seraphine's hesitant shuffle. They stopped in the archway and didn't come further.

And Elric.

Arion's grey eyes lifted past his sons to the archway. And found the old sorcerer standing there, leaning on his staff. And something went across his translucent face that Lex had never seen on anyone. Joy, and grief, and

gratitude, and something like shame, all at once, the way a sunrise is many colors at once.

"*Elric*," he said.

Elric didn't move.

"Old friend," said Arion. "You found them. Of course you found them. I knew you would." He took a step forward, across the black glass, toward the archway. His form flickered. "I asked you. Eleven years ago. I asked too much. I always asked too much. And you did it anyway."

Elric made a sound.

It wasn't a word. It was something torn out of him. He let go of his staff. It fell to the floor with a clatter that echoed around the great dome. And the old sorcerer stumbled forward across the black glass and stopped in front of the shape of light that was his oldest friend, and his face crumpled, and he wept.

He wept like a child. Like a man who had been holding something in for twenty years and couldn't hold it anymore. His thin shoulders shook. His knotted hands came up and reached for Arion, and passed through the gold light, and closed on nothing, and he wept harder.

"*Twenty years*," he said. "*Twenty years, Arion. I looked for you. I looked everywhere. I stood on that ridge three times. I put my hand in that water.*" His voice cracked to pieces. "*You never told me. You never told me anything. You just left.*"

"I know."

"*You always left. You always went first. You always—*" Elric stopped. He pressed his hands over his face.

Arion stood in front of him, translucent and gold and flickering. He reached out with one long hand and laid it on the old man's shoulder. It passed into the grey cloak a little way, the way light passes into water. But Elric felt it. Lex saw him feel it. Saw him go still.

"I know," said Arion softly. "I know, old friend. I've never been fair to you. Not once in forty years." His voice was very gentle. "You deserved better than me. You always did."

Elric lowered his hands. He looked up into the face of light. His own face was wet and grey and broken open, every line in it deep as a scar.

"I missed you," he said. "Lady help me, I missed you."

Lex stood on the black glass with his brother's hand in his and watched them. The old sorcerer and the shape of light. And something in his chest that had been clenched tight since the silver road, since the mirror and the throne and the young man crowned with gold, since *not yet* whispered over the chasm, slowly began to unclench.

He loves him, Lex thought. Look at him. Whatever he wants, whatever he's ashamed of wanting, he loves my father.

[Yes,] said Ember. Very quietly. [He does.] A long pause. [I've known that for forty years.]



THEY SAT ON THE black glass floor in a half-circle around the crystal, and Arion told them.

Not everything. Lex knew that even as he listened. There were places in the story where his father's voice would slow, and his translucent face would go still, and he would choose his next words with great care, like a man stepping between stones in a stream. Places where he said *I'll tell you more of that another time*. Places where he didn't say anything at all.

But he told them a great deal.

He told them about the House of Vey. About Aurelian, who had woven the Lattice nine hundred years ago, not as a gift but as a cage and a lid. A net over the will of men, so no one could ever again wield unchecked power. And a lid over the hunger beneath.

"The Hollow," said Arion. "That's what the Founders called it. The empty place behind the world. And in it, something that woke in the Sundering. Something that eats." His grey eyes went to Antho. "You know it. Better than anyone alive. You've been listening to it for eight years."

Antho didn't answer. His hands were clenched on his knees.

"The Lattice holds it down," said Arion. "Has held it down for nine hundred years. But the Lattice is *old*. Older than anything should be. And it's tired. It's fraying. Thinning. Like an old net left too long in the sea." He paused. "And where it thins, the hunger's breath seeps through. That's the Gloam. Not a blight. Not a disease of the land. The *breath* of the thing under the world, leaking up through the cracks."

"The breaches," said Seraphine.

"The breaches." Arion nodded. "There were three, when I was young. Small ones. Far away. The Order patched them and kept them quiet. Then, sixteen years ago, in Vhessa, there was a fourth." His voice had slowed. "A large one. The largest ever recorded. I was there when it opened."

"What happened?" said Lex.

His father looked at him. For a long moment, he didn't answer.

"Something went wrong," he said at last. "I'll tell you all of it. I promise. But not today." He looked away, at the crystal. "Not today."

[He's hiding something,] said Ember quietly. [I can feel it. Like a locked partition. Like a door with no handle on this side.]

Do you know what it is?

[No. Whatever it is, he didn't give me that piece.] A pause. *[He kept it for himself.]*



"WHY DID YOU LEAVE?"

It was Antho. He hadn't spoken in a long time. He'd been sitting very still with his hands on his knees and his eyes fixed on the floor, while their father talked about Aurelian and the Hollow and the Lattice. Now he lifted his head.

"That's what I want to know," he said. "Not about Aurelian. Not about the Gloam. I don't care about any of that. I've been living with the Gloam for eight years." His grey eyes met their father's. "Why did you leave us?"

Arion was quiet for a long moment.

"Because of what you are," he said. "Both of you."

He looked from one to the other.

"Root blood is rare. There are perhaps three of us in the world, in any generation. Usually fewer. And Root is *bright*. To anyone who knows how to look, it shines like a lantern in a dark room." His voice was very steady. "The Order knows how to look. The senior Wardens. The High Warden. If they'd found you, they'd have taken you. Raised you in the Spire. Trained you. *Used* you. Made you into keys for their locks. You'd have been the High Warden's tools from the age of five." He paused. "I couldn't let that happen."

"So you sealed us," said Antho.

"So I sealed you. To hide you. From the Order." Arion's eyes flickered. "And from the hunger. The Gloam is drawn to Root the way moths are drawn to a flame. When the Vhessa breach opened, it learned my scent. I knew it would learn yours too, if you stayed near me. So I hid you, and I went away, as far as I could go." He paused again. "And from—"

He stopped.

The chamber was very quiet.

"From what?" said Lex.

His father didn't answer. His translucent face had gone very still, the way it did at the places in the story where he chose his words like stones.

"From other things," he said at last. "Things I'll tell you about another time."

[Another locked door,] murmured Ember.

"And then you came here," said Lex.

"And then I came here." Arion turned and looked at the crystal behind him. At the body inside it, standing upright with its eyes closed. "Because I'd found something else, in the east. Something worse than the breach. The Lattice wasn't just thinning, Lexander. It was *failing*. Unraveling. Thread by thread. And if it unraveled completely, the lid would come off, and the hunger would come through. All of it. Not a breath. The whole thing."

Nobody spoke.

"Avaloria is the Anchor," said Arion. "The place where the Lattice is tied to the world. If you hold the Anchor, you can hold the net. Not mend it. Not yet. But hold it together. Keep it from unraveling further." He spread his translucent hands. "So I came here, and I anchored myself into the heart of it. My body, my blood, my Authority. All of it. I became a knot in the net. And I've been holding it ever since." He looked at his sons. "Fifteen years."

"Fifteen years," whispered Seraphine. "Alone. In a crystal."

"Not entirely alone." Something almost like a smile touched his face. "I could feel you both. Through the seals. Faintly. Like hearing music from another room." He looked at Lex. "I felt it when you picked up your first hammer. When you were eleven. I felt it when you forged your first nail."

He looked at Antho, and the smile faded. "And I felt it when your seal broke."



ANTHO STOOD UP.

He did it very slowly, unfolding from the black glass floor with Ashka on his shoulder and the Keeper's Lantern glowing at his belt. He stood there, tall and gaunt, looking down at the shape of light.

"You felt it," he said. "When mine broke."

"Yes."

"You *felt* it. Eight years ago. In front of the whole village. With Mam standing there." His voice was very quiet. Very even. Terrifyingly even. "And you didn't come."

"I couldn't—"

"*You didn't come.*"

The shadows rose off him. Not in a wave. Slowly. Like smoke rising off a banked fire.

CLARITY: 66 → 58 ▼
58 → 51 ▼

"Why was mine weaker?" said Antho. "Why did his hold for fifteen years and mine break the first time it was tested?" He took a step forward. "I was there. I was nine. I was half asleep but I remember. You took longer on him. You worked on him for hours. You barely spent any time on me." Another step. "Did you know? When you made it? Did you know mine would break?"

Arion didn't flinch. He didn't look away. He looked up at his eldest son with his grey eyes very steady and very wet.

"Yes," he said.

The chamber went utterly silent.

"Not that it *would*," said Arion. "That it *could*. That it might." His voice was very low. "I had a hundred points of Authority, Antho. That's all any of us has. That's the most anyone can hold. And sealing a Root child takes a great deal. Sealing two—" He stopped. "Your power was deep. Still. Settled. I could put a lid on it, and the lid would hold, as long as I was there

to keep my hand on it. Lexander's was a fire. It fought me. It took everything I had. Ninety-seven points. Almost all of it went into him."

"So you chose," said Antho. "You chose him."

"I chose to make his seal so it could hold on its own. Because a fire, if it gets out, burns everything around it. And I chose to make yours so it needed me." His voice cracked. "Because I was sure I'd be back. Before you turned sixteen. I was *sure*. I'd find a way to hold the Lattice and come home, and I'd lift your seal myself, gently, and teach you. I'd be there." He closed his eyes. "I wasn't."

"No," said Antho. "You weren't."

"I'm—"

"I said don't say it."

The shadows were pouring off him now. Lex could feel it through the Bloodbond: the cold deep pool of his brother's power, churning. Not the Murmur. Not the hunger. *Antho*. His own grief and rage, eight years of it, rising up.

"Do you know what happened?" said Antho. "When it broke? Do you know what came through?" His voice rose. *"Do you know what happened to Mam?"*

And their father opened his eyes and said, very quietly:

"Yes."

Antho stopped.

"I felt it," said Arion. "Through the Lattice. The night it happened. I felt your seal shatter. I felt the hunger come through you. I felt it tear the door open." His translucent face was wet. "And I felt her walk into it. I felt the door close behind her. From the other side."

The silence was absolute.

"You *knew*," Antho whispered. "You knew. All this time."

"I knew."

"And you didn't—you never—" Antho's voice broke. "You let me think. Eight years. Everyone thought I killed her. *I* thought I killed her. And you *knew*."

"I couldn't reach you. I couldn't reach anyone. I was here. In the crystal. Holding the net." Arion's voice was barely audible. "I could feel you. Hear you, almost. Like music in another room. But I couldn't speak. I couldn't

move. I couldn't do anything but hold." He looked up at his son. "I'm not asking you to forgive me, Antho. I know what I did. I know what it cost you. I know what it cost her." His voice dropped to a whisper. "I'm only telling you the truth. Because you asked for it. And because you deserve it."

Antho stood over him, shaking, with the shadows rising off him and his eyes going black at the edges.

CLARITY: 51 → 42 ▼



— *stirring*

Lex stood up.

He went and stood beside his brother. He didn't touch him. He didn't say anything. He just stood there, shoulder to shoulder, the way he'd stood in the Thornwood, the way he'd sat beside him on the Oracle's steps.

After a long moment, Antho's shoulder pressed against his.

CLARITY: 42 → 49 ▲

"I can't," Antho said hoarsely. Not to their father. To Lex. "I can't do this right now. I can't."

"I know."

"I need to—" He stopped. "I need to walk."

He turned and walked away across the black glass floor, toward the archway, out of the chamber. Ashka rode on his shoulder, her head turned back, looking at the shape of light with her golden eyes. The shadows trailed behind him like a cloak.

Seraphine got up and went after him without a word.

Arion watched them go. His translucent face was very still.

"She'll be good for him," he said quietly. "The Scribe. I can feel it." He looked at Lex. "He's been alone too long."

"Whose fault is that?" said Lex.

His father looked at him.

"Mine," he said simply.



"YOUR TURN," SAID ARION, after a long time.

Lex sat down again on the black glass in front of him. Wren had come to sit beside him. Garrick was standing near the archway, watching the corridor where Antho had gone. Elric was sitting a little apart, his staff across his knees, his face unreadable.

"My turn for what?" said Lex.

"To be angry with me. To ask me why." Arion looked at him. "You have every right. You're angrier than he is, I think. You've just buried it deeper."

Lex didn't answer for a long time.

"I was angry," he said at last. "For fifteen years. I hated you. I hated you so much I hammered it into my first real work without knowing." He looked down at Anvilson, lying across his knees. "And then the anvil in the next room made me take it out. Today. An hour ago."

His father was very still.

"I don't know what I feel now," said Lex. "I don't know if I'm angry. I don't know if I forgive you. I don't know if I want to." He looked up. "I know you sang to me. When I was small and sick. I know you called me *little smith* in the road the morning you left, and told me to keep the nail. I know you put a piece of yourself into my seal so I'd have someone, even if you couldn't be there." He swallowed. "I know that piece has been the best friend I've ever had."

Arion's face went very still.

"It woke," he whispered. "The construct. It woke?"

[Hello,] said Ember.

Lex didn't hear it in his head, the way he always did. He heard it in the *air*. Faint and gold, like a voice heard through a wall. Coming from him, from the place under his breastbone where the seal was, but out loud. In the chamber.

His father heard it too.

The shape of light went absolutely still.

[Hello,] said Ember again. Quietly. Uncertainly. *[I'm sorry. I don't—I don't quite know how to do this. I don't know what to call you.]*

Arion stared at the place on Lex's chest where the voice was coming from.

"You can call me whatever you like," he said at last. His voice was very rough. "You're—you're me. A piece of me. You can call me anything."

[I'm not you,] said Ember. [I thought I might be, for a while. When the partitions started opening. I thought I might be you, or the beginning of you, or the part of you that was missing.] A pause. [But I'm not. I've been with him for six weeks. Awake. I've watched him forge and fight and grieve and laugh. I've watched him forgive his brother on a stone sphinx's steps and carry three hundred and forty-six dead people's names into a road. You weren't there for any of that.] Another pause. [I was. So I'm not you. I'm something else now. I'm Ember.]

Arion didn't say anything for a long time.

"Ember," he repeated at last. Something moved in his translucent face. Something that might have been a smile. "He named you."

[He did. The first night. He said the gold looked like coals banked for the night.]

"It does." Arion's voice was very soft. "It does, doesn't it." He looked at Lex. Then back at the place where the voice came from. "Did I give you the right things? When I cut you? I was in such a hurry. I was so frightened. I didn't know what I was taking."

[You gave me your patience,] said Ember. [And your courtesy. And a great deal about metallurgy. And your memory of singing to him when he was sick.] A pause. [And your terrible jokes. He's told me several times that my jokes are terrible.]

Lex made a sound that was half a laugh and half something else.

"They are terrible," he said.

"They were always terrible," said Arion. And he laughed. A real laugh, soft and rough and surprised out of him, his translucent face creasing up exactly the way it had in the Thornwood's memory, crouching in a muddy road. "Your mother used to throw bread at me."

[I remember,] said Ember. [Partition four. Flour. She had flour on her cheek. Always.]

Arion stopped laughing.

He looked at the place on Lex's chest for a long, long moment.

"I'm glad you woke," he said quietly. "I'm glad it was you who was there. Instead of me." He looked at Lex. "I think you were probably better at it."

[I had a good teacher,] said Ember. [In a manner of speaking.]



IT WAS WREN WHO asked the question nobody else would.

"What happens now?"

They all looked at her. She was sitting beside Lex with her arms around her knees, looking at the shape of light with her sharp green eyes.

"You're in a crystal," she said bluntly. "Holding the net. You've been there fifteen years. His seal is down to twenty-six percent." She jerked her head at Lex. "That means you're dying. Isn't it? Getting weaker. Every week."

Arion looked at her. Then something like approval came into his face.

"Yes," he said. "I'm dying."

Lex's heart stopped.

"Not quickly," said Arion. "Not yet. But I've been pouring myself into the Anchor for fifteen years, and there's very little left to pour. A year, perhaps. Less, if the breaches keep spreading." He looked at Lex. "When I go, the seal on you goes too. That's what Elric was afraid of. When it goes all at once, without anyone to guide you—"

"I've got Ember," said Lex.

"Yes. You do." Something moved in Arion's face. "That's the one thing I did right."

"And when you go," said Wren, "what happens to the net?"

Arion was quiet for a moment.

"It unravels," he said. "The Anchor drops. The Lattice starts to come apart. Not all at once. Slowly, at first. More breaches. Bigger ones. More Gloam. And then faster. And then—" He stopped.

"And then the lid comes off," said Garrick quietly from the archway.

"And then the lid comes off."

Nobody said anything.

"Unless," said Lex.

His father looked at him.

"There's always an *unless*," said Lex. "Brannoc says that. *There's always an unless, lad. You just have to find it.*" He held his father's gaze. "What's the unless?"

Arion looked at him for a long moment. Then at the archway, where Antho had gone.

"The unless is the two of you," he said quietly. "Together."

He stood up, a column of gold light in the center of the black glass floor.

"I can't step out of the crystal. Not on my own. If I let go of the Anchor, even for a moment, the net drops. But if someone else could *hold* it for me—take the weight, just for a little while, long enough for me to step out and wake my body—" He looked at Lex. "It takes Root to hold the Anchor. More Root than one person has. More than I had, even. I've been barely managing, alone. But two of the blood, together, sharing the weight, through a Bloodbond—"

"Could hold it," said Lex.

"Could hold it. For a little while. Long enough." Arion's voice was very steady. "And then, with my body awake, and all three of us—" He stopped. "The Oracle told you what I asked her, didn't she. Eleven years ago."

"*How a man might mend a net from inside it,*" said Lex.

"And what did she say?"

"That a man alone can't. That it needs more than one pair of hands."

Arion nodded slowly.

"Three pairs," he said. "Three of the blood. Holding the net together, from inside. Not just holding it. *Mending* it." His grey eyes were very bright. "I've been thinking about it for eleven years. I think it could work. I think we could do it."

"Here?" said Seraphine. She'd come back into the archway, quietly. Antho was behind her. His face was grey and set, but his eyes were grey too, and the shadows around his feet had settled. He didn't come into the chamber. He stood in the archway and listened.

"Not here," said Arion. "Not now. The waking has to be done carefully, at the right time, in the right place. There's a ritual. Old. Founders' work. It needs a full moon, and a Twin Stone, a second Anchor-point, linked to this one, where the weight can be shared." He looked at Seraphine. "There are

four Twin Stones left in Aldermere. The nearest is under the old fortress at Caldris, on the Vhessan border. Built on a Founders' waystation. The Order's forgotten it's there."

"Fort Caldris," said Garrick slowly. "I served there. Twenty years ago. There was a cellar under the keep nobody was allowed into."

"That's it." Arion nodded. "The crystal can be moved. Carefully. Along the Lattice's own threads, from Anchor to Twin. It will take time. And people to guard it on the way. And people to guard the fortress when we get there, because the moment the crystal leaves Avaloria, every Warden and every Gloamed thing in Aldermere will feel it." He looked around at them. "I'll need allies. Many of them."

"I have friends," said Elric quietly. It was the first thing he'd said since he wept. His voice was steady now. Very steady. "In the Silver Lattice. In the free companies. Among the Wardens who aren't loyal to Kell. People who'll come if I ask them."

Arion looked at him for a long moment. Something moved in his translucent face. Gratitude. And something else Lex couldn't read.

"Thank you, old friend," he said softly.

Elric smiled. It was a strange smile.

"I've always been beside you, Arion," he said. "Haven't I. I've never once been anywhere else."



LEX FOUND ANTHO LATER, sitting at the edge of the chasm, in the white corridor, alone.

Seraphine had gone back to the chamber; Lex had passed her in the corridor, and she'd touched his arm and said *he wants you*, very quietly, and walked on. Ashka was curled asleep in Antho's lap. The Keeper's Lantern glowed at his belt. He was looking down into the darkness, into the Hollow, his face very still.

Lex sat down beside him. Their legs dangled over the edge. Below them, the dark went down forever.

"He knew," said Antho, after a long time. "About Mam. All this time. He felt the door close."

"I know."

"He didn't say she was dead." Antho's voice was strange. "Did you notice that? I kept waiting for him to say it. *She died. I'm sorry she died.* He never said it." He looked down into the chasm. "He said *I felt her walk into it. I felt the door close behind her. From the other side.*" He was quiet for a moment. "From the other side, Lex. Not *she died. From the other side.*"

Lex didn't say anything. He'd noticed. He'd been trying not to notice.

"I'm probably reading too much into it," said Antho. "I've been alone in a cave for eight years. I read too much into everything." He laughed, very softly. "Seraphine says it's a sign of an overactive pattern-recognition faculty. She says it like it's a compliment."

"Maybe it is."

"Maybe." Antho stroked Ashka's spines. "I can't forgive him, Lex. Not yet. Maybe not ever. I don't know." He was quiet for a long time. "But I'll hold the net with you. When it's time. I'll take the weight. I'll help wake him." He looked at Lex. "Not for him. For you. And for Mam. And for whatever's on the other side of that door."

"That's enough," said Lex. "For now. That's enough."

They sat side by side at the edge of the chasm, looking down into the dark.

And from very far below, so faint that Lex wasn't sure he'd heard it, a sound came drifting up out of the Hollow. Not the Murmur. Not the hunger. Something else.

A woman's voice. Singing. Very faint. Very far away.

Little light, little light, burning low...

Antho went rigid.

Lex grabbed his arm. "Did you—"

"Yes."

They sat absolutely still, listening. Straining.

Nothing. Only silence. Only the cold air rising out of the dark.

"It was the thing," said Antho at last, hoarsely. "It was the thing in the Hollow. It knows that song. It heard her sing it, the night she went in. It's mocking me. It does that." His hands were shaking. "It's done it before."

"Has it?"

Antho didn't answer.

[Lex,] said Ember, very quietly. [I heard it too. And I don't think that was the hunger.] A pause. [The hunger doesn't sing. It only wants.]

Before Lex could answer, the white corridor flashed red.



IT CAME FROM EVERYWHERE at once. The glow in the walls, the soft white light that came from the stone itself, went red. Blood red. Pulsing. And the voice came, the vast impersonal voice that had said *welcome home*. Not calm now. Urgent.

ALERT — AVALORIA

The Way has been crossed.

UNAUTHORIZED PRESENCE on the lake.

Gloam signature: MASSIVE

Root signature: STOLEN (partial)

Lex was on his feet. Antho was on his feet beside him, Ashka shrieking on his shoulder.

From the chamber, their father's voice. Loud. Sharp. More alive than Lex had heard it yet.

"Lexander! Anthoren! Here! Now!"

They ran.

The great domed chamber was red too, the Wellscript on the walls blazing crimson, the black glass floor reflecting it like blood. Arion's shape stood in the center, in front of the crystal, flickering wildly, his translucent face turned up toward the dome. Wren and Garrick and Seraphine were on their feet, weapons drawn. Elric stood by the archway with his staff raised and lightning crackling around its head.

"What is it?" Lex shouted. "What's happening?"

"The Way," said Arion. "You called it. With the lodestone. It's still open. It stays open until the Anchor is reset." His voice was tight. "And something has followed you across it."

Above them, the great dome *changed*. The white stone went clear, like glass, like the surface of Mirrormere. And through it, they could see the sky. The night sky, full of stars. And the lake, far below, black and still.

And on the lake, on the silver road, coming toward the island—

Lex's blood turned to ice.

The Gloam. A tide of it. Black and oily and endless, pouring across the silver road like ink spilling across a page. And in it, shapes. Hundreds of them. Gloamhounds, loping. Mistwraiths, drifting. Gloamed men, tall and stretched and grey, marching in ranks like soldiers. Hollow-knights in black armor, their eyes white.

And above them, in the sky, something enormous.

It was a dragon. Or it had been. It was the size of a barn, a cathedral, a hill. Its wings blotted out the stars. Its scales were grey, dead grey, the grey of the hedgerows and the bear and the miller, cracked all over like dried mud, and through the cracks black Gloam seeped and dripped and trailed behind it in the air like smoke. Its eyes were white. Blank. Boiled-egg white. And it was coming toward the island, slow and steady and silent, on wings that made no sound at all.

SORROWMAW

Gloom-Wyrm – Level 58

CATASTROPHIC THREAT

Ashka screamed. A thin, high, terrible sound, full of grief and horror.

"*That's a storm-drake,*" Antho whispered. His face was white. "That was a storm-drake. Like her. Look at the shape of the wings. The crest." His voice shook. "That was one of *hers*."

And on the dragon's back, standing upright between its vast grey shoulders as if it were the deck of a ship, there was a man.

He was very tall and very thin, in a long white coat that hung to his ankles. His skin was white. Not pale. *White*, like chalk, like bone, like paper. And all over his face and hands, black veins of Gloam ran under the skin like cracks in porcelain. His hair was white and long and lifted in the wind. His eyes were white.

He wasn't looking at the island. He was looking up. At the clear dome. At the chamber. At them.

He smiled.

"*Morvane,*" breathed Seraphine.

Arion's shape had gone absolutely still in the center of the chamber.

"How," he said. Very quietly. "How did he find the Way? It opens only to blood. Only to two of the blood. He couldn't have—"

"*Root signature: stolen,*" said Lex. He was staring at the panel still hanging in the red air. "That's what it says. *Stolen, partial.* Someone gave him—"

He stopped.

Slowly, very slowly, he turned his head and looked at the archway.

Elric was standing in it. With his staff raised and lightning crackling around its head. Looking up at the dome, at the dragon, at the white man standing on its back.

His face was grey. His eyes were wide. His mouth was open, slightly, as if in shock.

He looked exactly like a man seeing his worst nightmare walk across a lake toward him.

Or exactly like a man who'd been expecting it.

Lex couldn't tell which.

CHAPTER 23

THE SORCERER'S RECKONING



"How long?" said Garrick.

He was at the archway, Oathkeeper drawn, looking up through the clear dome at the black tide pouring across the silver road. His voice was perfectly calm. The calm of a man who has stood in a lot of doorways.

"Minutes," said Arion. "Ten. Perhaps fifteen. The road is long, and the Way slows those who aren't of the blood." His translucent shape was flickering badly, like a candle in a high wind. "But the dragon doesn't need the road."

High above them, beyond the dome, Sorrowmaw turned in a slow vast circle over the lake. Its grey wings made no sound. The white figure standing on its back had not stopped smiling.

"Defenses," said Lex. His voice came out steadier than he felt. "What defenses does the temple have?"

"The Lumen Wardens. They'll obey you now. You commanded them; they're yours." Arion looked at him. "The wards on the stair, the doors, the corridor. Old, but strong. The Scribe can strengthen them, if she's quick. She has Master Inscribe." He looked at Seraphine. "Can you read the ward-circles on the corridor floor?"

Seraphine pushed her spectacles up her nose. Her hands were shaking. Her voice wasn't. "Yes."

"Then go. Every circle you strengthen buys us a minute." Arion turned to Garrick. "Sir Knight. The stair. Three hundred and sixty-five steps. It's

the only way up from the shore. If they come by the road, they come up the stair."

"Then that's where I'll stand." Garrick was already turning. He stopped in the archway and looked back at Lex. "On the steps, lad." Something moved at the corner of his scarred mouth. "Literally, this time."

He was gone.

"I'll go with him," said Wren. She had an arrow on the string. "Someone has to shoot the things he can't reach."

"Wren—"

"Don't, Hammer." She looked at him. Her face was white and fierce. "Not now." And then she did something she'd never done. She stepped forward, and reached up, and grabbed the front of his coat, and pulled his face down, and kissed him. Hard and fast and clumsy. Her lips were cold and tasted of salt.

Then she let go.

"*Don't die*," she said, and ran after Garrick.

Lex stood there with his mouth open.

[Well,] said Ember faintly. *[That happened.]*

"*Lexander*." His father's voice, sharp. "Your points. You have thirty unspent. Spend them. *Now*."

[I told you,] said Ember. *[I've been telling you.]*



HE SPENT THEM STANDING in the red-lit chamber with the dragon circling overhead. He didn't think. There wasn't time to think. Six into Might. Six into Agility. Seven into Vitality. Six into Spirit. Five into Resolve.

They went into him like a forge-blast. Like being struck by lightning. Every muscle in his body clenched and released. His heart slammed. His vision went white, then gold, then cleared, sharper than it had ever been. He could see every crack in the white stone. Every glyph in the walls. Every grey scale on the dragon wheeling far overhead.

LEX VEY – Emberwright		
TIER II – Level 27		
MIG 44	AGI 43	VIT 54
INT 39	SPI 102	RES 41
Health 540/540		
Mana 1020/1020		
Authority: 26 / 100		

Over a thousand mana, he thought dizzily.

[And twenty-six Authority,] said Ember. [That's the number that matters tonight. The crossing at the chasm cost you. Spend it carefully.]

Antho was standing beside him. His brother's face was grey and set. The Keeper's Lantern glowed at his belt, and the shadows coiled around his feet, quiet, controlled. Ashka was on his shoulder, staring up through the dome at the vast grey dragon, and she was making a sound Lex had never heard. A low, broken, keening whine, over and over.

"She knows it," Antho said quietly. "The dragon. She knows it, Lex." His hand was on her back. "She keeps sending me the same picture. A big blue-grey shape in the sky. Lightning. Wings over a nest in the rocks. *Father. Father. Father.*"

Lex looked up at Sorrowmaw. At the dead grey scales and the black Gloam weeping from the cracks. At the white blank eyes.

"That's her father?"

"That *was* her father." Antho's voice was very flat. "The Wardens shot her out of the sky four years ago. She was barely out of the egg. I never knew what happened to the rest of them. I thought they were dead." He swallowed. "I think I'd have preferred dead."

Overhead, Sorrowmaw folded its wings and dove.



IT DIDN'T COME FOR the dome. It came for the stair.

Lex saw it through the clear stone: the vast grey shape plunging down out of the stars toward the island's flank, toward the long white flight of three hundred and sixty-five steps where Garrick and Wren had gone. It

opened its jaws. And out of them poured not fire but *Gloam*. A great black torrent of it, thick and oily, rolling down the stair like a flood.

"*Garrick!*"

Lex was running before he knew he'd moved. Down the corridor, past Seraphine on her knees with her hands on a glowing ward-circle, past the Anvil of Ascent, through the white corridor toward the great door.

He came out onto the top of the stair into chaos.

The black flood had hit the steps halfway down. It was boiling there, churning, a great seething mass of Gloam. And standing in it, waist-deep, with Oathkeeper blazing blue-white in both hands, was Garrick.

The Gloam broke around him like a river around a rock. Where it touched the frost-steel blade, it hissed and froze and shattered, and didn't come back. *Bind*. Gloam struck by this blade cannot re-form. The old knight was swinging in great slow arcs, carving a space around himself, and where he carved, the stair was clean.

Behind him, five steps up, Wren crouched with her bow. She'd nocked an arrow. And as Lex watched, she drew, and the arrowhead caught fire.

Not ordinary fire. *Gold*. His fire. The Tier II gift he hadn't even had time to think about yet.

Kindle.

He hadn't done it on purpose. He'd *wanted* it, running down the corridor. Wanted her arrows to burn. And the gift had simply gone out of him to her, through the fellowship, through whatever was between them now since the kiss in the chamber.

Wren loosed. The burning arrow streaked down the stair and struck a Gloamed soldier climbing out of the black flood, and the soldier *ignited*, gold fire running through it, and it screamed and came apart.

Wren looked up at him over her shoulder. Her green eyes were wide.

"*Did you do that?*"

"*I think so!*"

"*Do it again!*"

He did it again. He reached out through the fellowship, to her bow, to Garrick's sword, and *pushed*. Wren's next arrow caught gold fire. Oathkeeper's blue-white blade flared with gold along its edge, frost and

flame together, and the next Gloamed thing Garrick struck burst like a bonfire.

"*Ha!*" roared Garrick. "*Now we're smithing!*"

And up the long white stair, out of the black boiling flood, they came. Gloamhounds by the dozen. Mistwraiths drifting up the steps like smoke. Tall stretched grey Gloamed men with white eyes, marching. Hollow-knights in black armor, their swords dripping darkness.

Lex hefted Anvilson and went down the steps to stand beside Garrick.



HE DIDN'T REMEMBER ALL of it. Afterward, it came back to him in flashes, bright and terrible, like glimpses through smoke.

Anvilson in his hands, blazing, the new Masterwork runes singing. An Ember Strike that didn't just kill a Gloamed knight but *went through* it and the three behind it, a lance of gold fire tearing down the stair. *Ardent: +40%*. The hammer leaving his hands as he threw it, whirling end over end down the steps through a pack of hounds, and coming back to his palm a hundred paces later trailing sparks. *Homeward: 100 paces*.

Garrick beside him, steady as a wall. Never retreating. Never stepping back. Every swing exactly where it needed to be. Once, a Hollow-knight's black blade got past Oathkeeper and opened a long gash across Garrick's shoulder, and Lex felt it through the fellowship, and without thinking reached out with the fourth rune on Anvilson. *The Hand Held Out*. He gave Garrick a quarter of his own health in a single rush of warmth, and watched the gash close, and the old knight turned his head and stared at him.

"*What was that?*"

"*Don't ask!*"

Wren above them, shooting, shooting, every arrow burning gold, every arrow finding its mark. *True*. Running out of arrows. Lex Kindling the rocks at her feet so she could throw them, burning, down the stair.

And the dragon.

Sorrowmaw came back three times. Three great dives out of the stars, three black torrents of Gloam pouring down the stair. The first time, Garrick held. The second time, Lex threw up Ironskin over all three of

them, stretching it thin, stretching it farther than he knew he could, a shell of shimmering heat that the Gloam broke against like waves against a seawall. The third time—

The third time, Ashka met it.

She came out of the temple door above them like a thrown spear. Blue-white, crackling, her silver-framed wing beating hard. She flew straight up the dragon's dive, straight into the path of the falling grey mountain, screaming. A tiny blazing spark against that vast dead shape.

And Sorrowmaw *stopped*.

It pulled out of its dive. It hung in the air above the stair, its vast grey wings beating slow and silent, and its blank white eyes fixed on the little storm-drake hovering in front of its face. And the Gloam pouring from its jaws faltered. Thinned. Stopped.

Ashka cried out. Not a scream. A different sound. High and thin and plaintive, over and over. The sound of a hatchling calling.

And from somewhere deep inside the vast grey dead shape, something *answered*.

A sound. Very faint. Very deep. A rumble, like distant thunder. Like a storm far away over the mountains.

The white eyes flickered. For one heartbeat, just one, Lex saw something else in them. Gold. A deep molten amber, slit-pupiled like a cat's. Ashka's eyes.

Then it was gone. The white came back. And Sorrowmaw roared, a sound like a mountain cracking in two, and swept one vast grey wing at the little dragon in front of it.

Ashka tumbled away through the air. Lex's heart stopped. Then she caught herself, wings spread, and steadied, and hung there, crying.

The dragon didn't come after her. It turned. Slowly. And beat its great grey wings, and rose, and rose, up into the stars, and wheeled away over the lake.

And from its back, as it turned, Lex saw the white figure in the long white coat step off.

He didn't fall. He *drifted*. Down through the night air like a feather, like a leaf, like a man who'd forgotten that falling was a thing that happened. His white coat billowed around him. His white hair lifted. He

came down past the stair, past the island's rocky flank, and landed lightly, without a sound, on the white stone at the very top of the steps.

Right in front of the temple door.

He turned his head and looked down the stair at the three of them. At Lex, and Garrick, and Wren. His white eyes were utterly calm.

"Excuse me," said Morvane. "I have an appointment."

And he walked into the temple.



LEX RAN.

Up the stair, three steps at a time, Anvilson in his hand. Behind him, he heard Garrick roar something and Wren shout his name. He didn't stop. He reached the top and plunged through the great door into the white corridor, red-lit, pulsing, and saw the white figure far ahead, walking. Not hurrying. Walking. Down the long corridor toward the heart of the temple.

The Lumen Wardens came out of the walls.

All twelve of them. Shining. Gold. Swords of light raised. They stepped into the corridor in front of Morvane in a line, a wall of light, and Lex felt them go through him. *His*. Commanded. Obeying.

Morvane didn't stop walking.

He raised one white hand. Black veins of Gloam pulsed under the skin like cracks in porcelain. And the Gloam came out of him. Not in a torrent. Not in a flood. It seeped out of his fingertips like smoke from a snuffed candle, slow and soft, and drifted toward the Lumen Wardens.

And where it touched them, they went *quiet*.

That was the only word for it. Their light didn't go out. It *dimmed*. It went from gold to grey. Their swords sagged. Their shining forms stopped moving, stopped shimmering, and stood there in the corridor like statues, grey and dull and still.

[Quiet,] whispered Ember, horrified. *[He's making them quiet.]*

Morvane walked between them. Past them. On toward the Anvil of Ascent and the chamber beyond.

And Lex caught up with him at the chasm.



THERE WAS NO BRIDGE. Of course there wasn't. The Bridge of Two Hands had faded behind them hours ago. The chasm yawned across the corridor, black and bottomless, thirty paces wide.

Morvane stopped at the edge and looked down into it.

"Ah," he said softly. "Of course." He looked across the chasm at the far side, where the corridor went on toward the Anvil and the heart of the temple. "The Bridge of Two Hands. *Let the blood stand apart and reach together.*" He smiled faintly. "Arion always did love a poetic lock."

Lex stopped ten paces behind him with Anvilson raised.

Morvane didn't turn around.

"Hello, Lexander," he said.

Lex's skin crawled.

"I've been wanting to meet you," said Morvane. His voice was soft and reasonable and pleasant, like a schoolmaster's. "Both of you. Ever since I felt your seal crack, back in the spring. Such a bright little flare. Such a lovely, hopeful light." He turned his head, slightly, so Lex could see the side of his chalk-white face, the black veins under the skin. "I sent my hounds to fetch you. You burned them. That was very rude."

"What do you want?"

"What I've always wanted." Morvane looked back down into the chasm. "Quiet."

He stepped off the edge.

He didn't fall. He walked. On nothing. On the empty air above the bottomless dark, as if it were solid stone. And under his feet, where he stepped, the Gloam seeped out of him and pooled on the air and held him up, a black path forming one step at a time across the chasm.

Lex stared.

"*Root signature: stolen,*" said Morvane, halfway across, conversationally. "I expect you saw that, on your way in. The temple's very good at noticing things." He kept walking. "Your father gave it to me, you know. Sixteen years ago. In Vhessa. Not on purpose. He was trying to do something very foolish and very brave, and it went wrong, and some of his Root came off in my hands." He reached the far side and stepped onto the white stone. "Just a little. Not enough to open the Way on my own. But enough to *walk* it, once someone else had opened it." He turned around and looked back

across the chasm at Lex. "So I want to thank you. For calling it. I've been waiting sixteen years for someone to call it."

He smiled. And turned. And walked on down the corridor toward the heart of Avaloria.

Lex stood at the edge of the chasm with his heart pounding.

He took it from Father, he thought. In Vhessa. Sixteen years ago. That's how he walked the Way.

Not Elric. Not the raven. *Father's Root, stolen in Vhessa.*

Something in his chest that had been clenched since the red light flashed went loose with relief. And then, immediately, something else clenched in its place.

He's going to the crystal.

[Lex,] said Ember urgently. *[The bridge. You need the bridge. You need your brother.]*

He didn't need to call. Antho was already there.

His brother came out of the shadows at the edge of the corridor like a piece of the night tearing loose. He must have followed Morvane in from the chamber side, Lex realized. Must have seen him coming. Must have been waiting on the far side of the chasm the whole time, in the dark, watching. Ashka was on his shoulder again, battered, crying softly.

"Plates," said Antho across the chasm. His voice was hoarse. "There are plates on this side too. Same as yours. Hands."

Lex looked down. There they were. Two carved hands in the white floor at his feet. And on the far side, at Antho's feet, two more.

"Apart," said Lex. "And together."

They knelt. Lex on his side. Antho on his. Thirty paces apart, across the bottomless dark. They laid their hands on the stone.

They reached for each other.

BLOODBOND – SHARED AUTHORITY

Lex: 26 → 18

The bridge came up out of the dark, gold and black, braided. Lex ran across it. Antho met him in the middle. They didn't stop. They ran the rest of the way together and leaped off the far end onto the white stone, and the

bridge faded behind them, and they ran down the corridor past the Anvil of Ascent, past the archway, into the heart of Avaloria.



MORVANE WAS STANDING IN front of the crystal.

The great domed chamber was blazing red. The Wellsript on the walls was flaring crimson, pulsing faster and faster, like a heart about to burst. The black glass floor reflected it all, so that the room seemed to be standing in a pool of blood.

Elric was on the floor by the archway. His staff lay beside him. He was on his hands and knees, gasping, his grey cloak smoking. As Lex ran past, the old sorcerer looked up, and his face was grey and wild and full of something Lex couldn't read.

"He walked through me," Elric gasped. *"I hit him with everything I had and he just walked through."*

Lex didn't stop.

Arion's shape stood between Morvane and the crystal. Flickering wildly. Translucent. Barely there. His arms were spread wide, like a man trying to block a doorway with his body. His face was white with effort.

And Morvane was looking at him with an expression of gentle, patient, terrible affection.

"Arion," he said. "Old friend."

"Get out of my temple, Corvin."

Morvane laughed. Softly. "Corvin. No one's called me that in sixteen years." He tilted his head. "I'm not Corvin anymore, Arion. You know that. You saw what happened to him. You were *there*." His white eyes glittered. "You were the one who did it to him."

Arion's flickering shape went very still.

"Have you told them?" said Morvane softly. He glanced past Arion at the two brothers standing in the archway. "Your boys. Have you told them what you did in Vhessa? What you tore open? What came through?" He smiled. "No. I can see you haven't. Your face always did give you away."

"Lexander," said Arion, without turning around. His voice was strained. *"Anthoren. Get back."*

"No," said Lex.

Morvane looked at him with mild interest.

"You want the Anchor," said Lex. He was walking forward across the red-lit black glass floor, Anvilson in his hand. Antho was beside him, step for step. "You want to take my father's place. Hold the net yourself."

"Not hold it," said Morvane. "*Rewrite* it." His voice was very soft and very reasonable. "Do you know what the Lattice is, Lexander? It's a net over the will of men. That's what Aurelian made it for. To bind the will. To stop people from doing whatever they like, from tearing the world apart with their wanting." He spread his white hands. "But it doesn't go far enough. It never did. It binds the will, but it doesn't *quiet* it. People still want. They still fight. They still hate and grieve and scream at three in the morning." His white eyes went to Antho. "Don't they, Anthoren?"

Antho's shadows stirred.

"I've seen the truth of the world," said Morvane. "In Vhessa. When the breach opened, and the hunger came through, and filled me." His voice dropped to a whisper. "It's silence. Under everything. A great, peaceful, endless silence. No wanting. No fighting. No pain." He smiled. "And I can give it to them. All of them. Everyone under the Lattice. If I hold the Anchor, I can rewrite the net, so that every thread in it runs through *me*. One will. One voice. One quiet." He turned back to the crystal. "No more war. No more grief. No more *noise*."

He reached past Arion's flickering shape, as if it weren't there at all, and laid his white hand on the crystal.



THE WORLD LURCHED.

Lex felt it. Everyone in the chamber felt it. Everyone in Aldermere felt it, he learned later. A great sideways heave, like a ship struck by a wave. The black glass floor tilted under his feet. The red light in the walls guttered. And somewhere, everywhere, a vast deep groan, like the timbers of the world creaking under too much weight.

ALERT — ANCHOR COMPROMISED
Foreign Root contact: ACTIVE
Lattice integrity: 71% → 68% → 64%

Arion screamed.

His shape didn't break. It *bent*. Twisted. Like light through a warped glass. Inside the crystal, the body that had stood upright for fifteen years with its eyes closed opened its mouth in a silent howl. The crystal flickered. Black veins of Gloam were spreading out from the place where Morvane's white hand touched it, branching through the clear faceted walls like cracks through ice.

"*Father!*"

SEAL INTEGRITY: 26% → 21% → 17%
--

Lex felt it in his chest. The seal. The thing that had been holding his power for fifteen years. Shuddering. Cracking. Going.

His father was dying. Right in front of him.

"*Lex.*" Antho's voice. Beside him. Urgent. "*Lex, the Bloodbond. There's something in it. Something locked.*"

He felt it too. In the place where his fire touched his brother's dark. A door. Small. Gold and black. He'd seen it in the panel when they formed the Bloodbond in the Hollowmaw, a lifetime ago. ??? (*locked*).

It was opening.

BLOODBOND – LOCKED FEATURE
Requirement met:
Two of the blood, in the heart
of the Anchor, in defense of the
Root.
UNLOCKED.

And the words unrolled in front of both of them at once. Gold and black. Braided.

BLOODBOND PREROGATIVE

RECKONING

Two of the blood pour their
 Authority together, and the Root
 itself passes judgment.

What is lawful, stands.
 What is stolen, burns.
 What is hollow, is unmade.

Cost: ALL shared Authority

Lex looked at Antho. Antho looked back. In the red light, his brother's grey eyes were very wide.

"All of it," said Antho.

"All of it."

"Your seal's at seventeen. If you spend all your Authority—"

"I know."

"It might break. All the way. Right now."

"I know." Lex held his brother's gaze. "Do you have any better ideas?"

Antho looked at Morvane. At the white hand on the crystal. At the black veins spreading. At their father's shape, twisting, screaming silently, holding on.

"No," he said.

They reached for each other.



IT WASN'T LIKE THE Bridge of Two Hands. It wasn't like the Bloodbond's gentle pull, or the shared Authority on the plates. It was like two rivers meeting in a flood. Like a forge-fire and a winter night colliding. Lex poured everything he had into the place where his fire touched his brother's dark: every scrap of Authority, every thread of Root, all eighteen points of it, all at once. And he felt Antho pour back. Not as much. Antho's Authority had always been strange, broken, unstable. But it was *deep*. Deeper than Lex's. Like a well with no bottom.

They met. They twined. They braided together, gold and black, fire and shadow, bright and deep.

One who forges. One who keeps.

And the Root passed judgment.



THE LIGHT CAME OUT of them.

Not from their hands. From *them*. From their chests, from the place under the breastbone where the seals were, where the fire and the dark lived. Gold from Lex. Violet-black from Antho. Two streams of it, pouring out into the red-lit chamber, twisting together in midair into a single braided storm, gold and shadow, flame and void, spiraling, blazing.

It struck Morvane.

He didn't scream. He *froze*. His white hand still on the crystal. His white face turning, slowly, toward the brothers. And for the first time since he'd stepped off the dragon's back, his expression changed. The gentle, patient, terrible calm cracked down the middle like a dropped plate.

The braided light went into him.

And Lex saw what it saw. The Root, judging. Looking at everything Morvane was, everything tied into him, every thread that ran between him and the Lattice and the Hollow. Sorting them. Weighing them.

What is lawful, stands.

There wasn't much. A few faint silver threads. The ghost of a Warden-Commander named Corvin Morvane, who had loved order and believed in the Lattice and been a hard, rigid, honest man. Those threads, the Root left alone.

What is stolen, burns.

Gold threads. Root-threads. Arion's Root, torn off in Vhessa sixteen years ago, grafted into Morvane like a stolen branch onto a dead tree. The braided light found them and *burned* them. Gold fire running through Morvane's white body, through the black veins, and he shrieked, at last, a high, thin, inhuman sound, as the stolen Root went up like dry kindling.

What is hollow, is unmade.

And the Gloam.

The black veins under his skin. The darkness in his white eyes. The hunger that had filled him in Vhessa and made him into this. The braided light found it, and the violet-black part of it, Antho's part, the dark that

knew the dark, *pulled*. And the gold part, Lex's part, the fire that ate the cold, *burned*.

The Gloam came out of Morvane in a great black gout, out of his mouth and his eyes and his fingertips, writhing, shrieking, and the braided light caught it and tore it apart.

Not all of it. Lex felt that. Felt the Root's judgment reach for the deepest, darkest knot of hunger at Morvane's center and *not quite reach it*. Felt their Authority running out. Felt the light beginning to thin.

But enough.

Morvane's hand came off the crystal.

He flew backward across the chamber as if struck by a battering ram. He hit the far wall, below the blazing red Wellsript, and slid down it, and crumpled on the black glass floor in a heap of white coat and white hair.

The black veins in the crystal stopped spreading. Then, slowly, they began to fade.

The red light in the walls flickered. Steadied. Went from crimson to orange to gold.

ANCHOR – STABILIZED

Foreign Root contact: SEVERED

Lattice integrity: 64% → 66%

And the braided light went out.



LEX WAS ON HIS knees. He didn't remember falling. Antho was beside him, on his hands and knees on the black glass, gasping. Ashka was crouched between them, her wings spread over them both like a little blue-grey tent.

RECKONING – EXECUTED

Authority: 0 / 100

Anthoren – Authority:  / 100

SEAL INTEGRITY: 17% → 14%

Fourteen percent. It had held. Barely. He could feel it in his chest: thin as paper, cracked all over, but holding.

He looked up.

Morvane was getting to his feet.

Slowly. Painfully. Like a very old man. He used the wall to push himself up. His white coat was torn and scorched. His white hair was singed. And his face—

His face was different. The black veins under the skin were fainter. Fewer. And for one moment, one strange moment, his eyes weren't white. They were brown. Ordinary brown. A man's eyes. Confused. Frightened.

"*Arion?*" he said. His voice was different too. Rougher. Human. "*Arion, what—where—*"

Then the white came back. Seeping up through the brown like water through sand. The black veins pulsed and thickened. And the gentle, patient, terrible calm settled back over his face like a mask.

But not all the way. There was a crack in it now. Lex could see it. A fault line, running down through the calm.

Morvane looked at the two brothers on their knees in the middle of the floor. His white eyes were utterly cold.

"That," he said softly, "was very rude."

He looked down at his own white hands. At the faded veins. At the places where his stolen Root had been.

"You burned it," he said. "The Root. Arion's Root. Sixteen years, I carried it." His voice was very quiet. "I'll need to find more now."

He looked up. Past the brothers. Past Arion's flickering shape. To the archway, where Elric Thorne was still crouched on the floor, his staff beside him, his grey cloak smoking.

Morvane looked at him for a long moment.

"Elric," he said.

Just that. Just the name. Quiet. Almost gentle.

Elric didn't move. He stared back at the white figure with his face grey and wild.

Then Morvane turned, and walked to the center of the chamber, and looked up through the clear dome at the sky. High above, a vast grey shape was circling.

"Until next time, Arion," he said. "We'll speak again soon. You and I and your boys." He smiled. "I'll bring more friends."

And the Gloam rose up around him like a black column, and lifted him off the floor, up through the clear dome as if it weren't there, up into the night sky. And Sorrowmaw swept down out of the stars and caught him on its vast grey back, and wheeled, and beat its silent wings, and flew away east over the mountains.

Below, on the lake, the black tide on the silver road had stopped. Then it turned. Slowly. Like a wave going out. And flowed away across the black glass water, back the way it had come, and was gone.



THE HEART OF AVALORIA was very quiet.

The walls glowed gold again. The black glass floor reflected them. The crystal stood in the center, clear and faceted and glowing softly, and inside it, the body of Arion Vey stood upright with its eyes closed, as it had for fifteen years.

His shape of light was kneeling in front of it. Faint. So faint now. Barely there. Lex could see the crystal through him.

"Father," said Lex.

Arion lifted his head. His translucent face was exhausted, beyond exhausted, the face of a man who has carried something too heavy for too long and has just felt it nearly crush him. But his grey eyes, when they found his sons, were shining.

"You did it," he whispered. "Both of you. Together." He looked from one to the other. "The Reckoning. I'd read about it. In the oldest codices. I never thought—" He stopped. His voice cracked. "I never thought I'd see it. I never thought anyone would."

Antho got slowly to his feet. He stood there, swaying, with Ashka on his shoulder and the Keeper's Lantern flickering low at his belt. He looked down at their father.

"He said you did it to him," said Antho. "In Vhessa. He said you were the one."

Arion's face went very still.

"He said you tore something open," said Antho. "And something came through."

The chamber was silent.

"Yes," said Arion at last. Very quietly. "I'll tell you. All of it. When I'm out of here. When I can look at you with my own eyes and not through a ghost." He looked at Antho. "I promise. I won't hide it anymore."

Antho looked at him for a long time.

Then he nodded, once. And turned away. And went to sit down against the wall of the chamber, with Ashka in his lap, and closed his eyes.

LEVEL UP! Lex – Level 28

LEVEL UP! Lex – Level 29

LEVEL UP! Lex – Level 30

LEVEL UP! Anthoren – Level 36

LEVEL UP! Anthoren – Level 37

LEVEL UP! Anthoren – Level 38

TITLE EARNED (both): THE RECKONING

"Two of the blood stood in the
heart of the Anchor, and the Root
passed judgment through them."

WORLD NOTICE

Lex stared.

World Notice.

He'd heard of them. Ember had told him, weeks ago. Things the Lattice announced to everyone. Every person under the net, all at once, everywhere. Rare. Very rare. Once in a generation, maybe.

The panel unrolled in front of his eyes. And he knew, with total certainty, that at that exact moment it was unrolling in front of every pair of eyes in Aldermere. Every farmer in his field. Every Warden in the Spire. Brannoc in his forge. Wren's mother on her step in Highcrest. Hedda Vorne, wherever she was. Daxian Roole. Elowen Dunmore. The girl in the Lower Town who'd been made a Laborer.

WORLD NOTICE

At the Anchor of the Lattice, the
Root has passed judgment.

A RECKONING has been executed.

The blood of the Founder walks the
world again.

Across the chamber, Elric Thorne was still on the floor by the archway. He'd picked up his staff. He was holding it across his knees. And he was staring at the panel hanging in the air, his face grey, his mouth slightly open.

Lex couldn't read his expression. He was too tired to try.



HE WENT OUT OF the chamber, later, and found Wren.

She was sitting at the top of the three hundred and sixty-five steps with her bow across her knees and her quiver empty, looking out over the lake. Garrick was lying on his back on the stair a few steps down, Oathkeeper on his chest, snoring. The steps below them were scorched and cracked and strewn with drifts of grey ash where the Gloamed things had died.

Lex sat down beside her.

Neither of them said anything for a while. Out on the lake, the silver road still glowed faintly across the black glass water. The stars were very bright. Far to the east, over the mountains, the sky was just beginning to grey.

"You kissed me," said Lex.

"I did."

"In the chamber. In front of my father."

"Your father was a ghost made of light. I don't think he counts." Wren didn't look at him. "I thought we were going to die. I thought I'd better do it before we did."

"We didn't die."

"I noticed." She was quiet for a moment. "I'm not sorry."

"Good," said Lex. "Neither am I."

She turned her head and looked at him. Her freckled face was streaked with ash and sweat and dried blood. Her fox-red braid had half come undone. Her green eyes were very bright.

He kissed her. Properly, this time. Slowly. Not because they were going to die. Because they weren't.

When they broke apart, she was smiling. A real smile. Small and crooked and surprised, as if it had snuck up on her.

"You're still an idiot, Hammer," she said.

"I know."

She leaned her head on his shoulder. They sat together at the top of the stair and watched the sky go grey, then pink, then gold, over the eastern mountains. The direction the dragon had flown. The direction Morvane had gone.

The direction the war was coming from.

[Lex,] said Ember softly. [You know this isn't over.]

I know.

[He'll come back. With more. Your father's weaker than ever. The seal's at fourteen percent. The Lattice is at sixty-six. And Morvane knows where we are now.]

I know.

[And there's still the matter of who told him.] A pause. *[He walked the Way with stolen Root. But he had to know where the Way was. Someone told him to look for the waters that hold the sky.]*

Lex looked out over the lake. Over the silver road glowing faintly in the dawn. Back toward the shore. Toward the pine-covered slopes where, two nights ago, an old man in a grey cloak had stood on a ridge and looked down at an empty lake.

I know, he thought.

He didn't say anything else. He sat at the top of the stair with Wren's head on his shoulder and Anvilsong across his knees and the sun coming up over the mountains, and he watched the east.

Below him, on the stair, Garrick snored. Behind him, in the heart of the temple, his brother slept against a wall with a dragon in his lap, and his father knelt in front of a crystal, barely there, holding the world together.

And somewhere far to the east, beyond the mountains, a white figure on a grey dragon was flying home to gather an army.

The brothers had found their father. They had stood together in the heart of the Anchor and the Root had passed judgment through them, and the whole world had seen it.

The final battle was coming. They would face it side by side.

The Sorcerer's Reckoning had begun.

PART TWO



THE SHADOW'S DESCENT

CHAPTER 24

FORT CALDRIS



THE CRYSTAL MOVED AT night.

That was the first thing they learned, in the long hard weeks after Avaloria. It moved only at night, and only along the old Founders' roads, and only from waystone to waystone. Each evening at sunset, Lex and Antho would kneel beside it wherever it stood, in a clearing or a ruined waystation or the lee of a hill, and lay their hands on its cold faceted surface, and reach together through the Bloodbond into the Root. And each evening the crystal would go faint, and fainter, like a reflection when the water is stirred, until they could see the grass through it. And then it would be gone.

And in the morning, it would be standing beside the next waystone along the road. Ten miles on. Fifteen. Waiting for them.

"It's walking the threads," Seraphine had explained, the first time. She'd been white with exhaustion and shaking with excitement. "The Lattice's own threads. The ley-lines the Founders built the roads along. It can travel along them the way a bead slides along a string. But it needs the blood to push it. And it needs an anchor at each end. And it needs—" She'd stopped, and pushed her spectacles up her nose, and looked at the empty grass where the crystal had stood a moment before. "It needs to stop, every night. To rest. Like a man walking a long way."

"Like Father," Antho had said quietly.

It took them twenty-six days to walk from Mirrormere to the Vhessan border.

Lex remembered very little of it afterward. Only pieces. The crystal standing beside a grey waystone in the dawn mist, frost on its facets, their father's body upright inside it with eyes closed. His father's shape of light, so faint now that it appeared only at dusk and only for a few minutes, flickering beside the crystal like a candle at the end of its wick, speaking in a voice like wind through dry grass. Ashka spiraling high overhead every morning, growing a little bigger every week, until she was the size of a large dog and could carry a hare in her claws. Wren beside him on the road, her hand finding his when the others weren't looking. Antho walking alone at the front, the Keeper's Lantern glowing at his belt, Seraphine a few steps behind him, always a few steps behind him.

And the people.

They came in ones and twos at first. Then in dozens. Then more.

Elric's friends.



THE FIRST WAS A woman named Teodra Hale, who met them at a crossroads in the Fells on the fifth day: a broad weathered woman in battered leather armor, with a greatsword on her back and two missing fingers on her left hand. She was captain of a free company called the Ashen Banners, forty swords strong, and she'd fought beside Elric in the border wars twenty years ago and owed him her life twice over.

"He wrote me," she said, looking the brothers up and down with frank, unimpressed eyes. "Said there was work. Said there was a dead man in a crystal who needed carrying, and a white-faced thing in the east who wanted to stop us carrying it." She spat. "I said, Thorne, that's the stupidest thing you've ever written me. And he said, Teodra, you've never once turned down a stupid fight." She grinned. "He was right."

The Ashen Banners fell in behind them on the road.

Then came the Wardens.

Not many. A dozen, at first. Then thirty. Men and women in grey cloaks with their silver lattice-pins torn off, who came out of the hills and the forests and the back roads in small frightened groups, and stood at the edge of the camp, and asked if this was where the Reckoning was. They'd seen the World Notice. Every person under the Lattice had seen it. *The*

blood of the Founder walks the world again. And some of them, a few, the ones who'd been quietly sickened for years by the Ceiling and the rigged Stones and the burned villages, had read it and walked away from their posts that same night.

"We didn't know where to go," said one of them, a thin young Warden with a burn scar on his cheek. "We just knew it wasn't the Spire anymore."

Then the Knights.

They came on the eighteenth day. Twenty of them, in plain armor with no plumes and no blue cloaks, riding hard down the road from the south. Their leader swung down from her horse in front of Lex and pulled off her helm, and it wasn't Elowen Dunmore. It was a stocky grey-haired woman with a face like a closed fist.

"Dame Otilie Brand," she said. She looked at Garrick, who'd come up beside Lex, and something in her fist of a face softened very slightly. "Dunmore. Your girl sends her regards. She'd have come herself, but she's been told to stay in Highcrest by someone very important." A pause. "Someone with a crown on her shoes."

Garrick went very still. "The Princess?"

"Didn't say. Not my place to say." Dame Brand handed Lex a sealed letter. The seal was blue wax, with a small silver crown. "She said give you this. And she said tell the smith with the gold eyes: *I saw the World Notice. I keep helping the Sisters.*"

Lex opened the letter later, alone. It was very short. Four lines, in a firm, neat, elegant hand.

To the blood of the Founder.

I cannot help you openly. Not yet. The High Warden watches me as closely as she watches you.

These twenty are mine. They are the best I have.

Bring him home. Then come and see me. —L.



BY THE TIME THEY reached Fort Caldris, they were three hundred strong.

It stood on a high rocky spur at the edge of the Vhessan border, where the green hills of Caldor ended and the grey began. It was old. Older than

the kingdom, Garrick said. A square keep of black stone with four squat towers, surrounded by a curtain wall, surrounded by a ditch, surrounded by a great open slope of rock and heather where nothing could approach without being seen. The Order had used it once as a border garrison. Now it was half-abandoned: a skeleton guard of thirty old soldiers, commanded by a castellan who'd been sent here as a punishment twenty years ago and had never been recalled.

His name was Brisk. Old Tamsin Brisk. He was seventy, bald, lame in one leg, and had served with Garrick in the eastern march when they were both young men. When he saw Garrick coming up the road at the head of three hundred people and a crystal, he limped out through the gate with his walking stick and stood in front of his old comrade and looked at him for a long time.

"You look terrible," he said at last.

"So do you."

"You're on notices. I've had twelve of them sent to me. *Unknown accomplice, large, grey, sword that freezes.*" Brisk squinted at Oathkeeper. "That it?"

"That's it."

Brisk grunted. He looked past Garrick at the crystal, standing beside the waystone at the foot of the road where it had appeared that morning. At the body inside it.

"Is that Arion Vey?" he said.

"It is."

"Thought so." The old castellan was quiet for a moment. "He came through here once. Sixteen years ago. On his way east, to Vhessa. Him and Morvane. Stopped the night. Arion beat me at cards." Brisk shook his head. "Nobody ever beats me at cards."

He turned and limped back toward the gate.

"Well, don't stand there," he called over his shoulder. "Bring him in. Bring them all in. I've got a cellar under the keep nobody's been allowed into for a hundred years. I expect that's what you want."



THE TWIN STONE WAS in the cellar.

They went down to see it the first evening: Lex and Antho and Seraphine and Elric and Garrick, with Brisk limping ahead of them with a torch. Down a long spiral stair of black stone, so old the steps were worn into hollows, to a heavy door bound with iron that hadn't been opened in a century. Brisk had the only key. It took him and Garrick together to turn it.

Beyond the door was a round room. Small. Low-ceilinged. Cold. The walls were the same black stone as the keep above, but carved, every inch of them, with Wellsript. Faint and old and half-worn away. And in the center of the floor, there was a stone.

It wasn't tall. Waist-high. White, like the stone of Avaloria, and glowing faintly from within. It was roughly the shape of the cracked old Stone on the green at Ashbourne, Lex thought, and his heart turned over. And set into its top, worn smooth, there were three carved hands. A right hand. A left hand. And between them, a third, larger hand, palm up.

"*Three of the blood,*" whispered Seraphine. "Three pairs of hands. Mending the net from inside."

The crystal came that night. They didn't carry it. They didn't need to. Lex and Antho knelt beside it at sunset at the foot of the road, and reached together, and it faded away into nothing. And when they went down into the cellar at dawn, it was there. Standing beside the Twin Stone, upright, faceted, glowing softly, with their father's body inside.

Linked. Anchored. Home, or as near as it could get.

TWIN STONE OF CALDRIS
Linked: AVALORIA (Anchor)
Status: ACTIVE
Waking ritual: AVAILABLE
at full moon
requires: three of the blood
Next full moon: 4 days

Four days.



ARION CAME OUT THAT night.

Not his body. His shape. Faint and gold and flickering, beside the crystal, beside the Twin Stone. Fainter than he'd been at Avaloria. So faint

that Lex could see the carved Wellscript on the walls straight through him. But his voice was steadier here. Stronger. The Twin Stone, he said, was feeding him a little.

"Four days," he said. "And then we try."

They were all there. Lex and Antho, and Seraphine, and Elric, and Garrick, and Wren, who'd come down the spiral stair behind Lex and stood close beside him. And Teodra Hale, and Dame Brand, and old Brisk leaning on his stick. The leaders of their small, ragged army, crowded into the low round room under the keep.

"Tell us how it works," said Garrick.

Arion told them.

On the night of the full moon, when the Lattice was strongest, Lex and Antho would lay their hands on the Twin Stone. The right hand and the left. And they would reach together, through the Bloodbond, through the Stone, all the way back along the threads to Avaloria, to the Anchor. And they would *take the weight*.

"All of it," said Arion. "Everything I've been holding for fifteen years. For a little while. Long enough." He looked at his sons. "It will be very heavy. It will be the heaviest thing you've ever carried. You'll feel the whole net pulling on you. Every thread. Every knot. Every breach." His voice was quiet. "You may not be able to hold it. If you can't, let go. Don't try to be brave. Let go, and it will come back to me, and we'll find another way."

"And if we can hold it?" said Lex.

"Then I'll step out." Arion looked at the crystal. At the body inside it. "Out of the light, and back into myself. It will take a few minutes. Ten, perhaps. I'll have to remember how to be a body again. How to breathe. How to have a heartbeat." Something like a smile touched his translucent face. "I've forgotten, a little."

"And then?"

"And then I lay my hand on the third place. The center. And the three of us hold it together. And we start to mend." Arion's grey eyes were very bright. "Not all at once. It will take a long time. Months. Years, maybe. But we'll have started. The net will stop unraveling. The breaches will start to close."

There was a silence in the low round room.

"And while you're doing all this," said Teodra Hale, "Morvane sits on his hands in the Blightmarch and lets you?"

Arion's face went still.

"No," he said. "He won't."



HE WASN'T SITTING ON his hands.

The reports came in every day. Scouts, mostly: the Ashen Banners' outriders and the young Wardens who'd deserted to them, who knew how to move quietly in the grey country. They rode out east from Fort Caldris every morning into the edge of the Blightmarch, and came back every evening, and their faces were grey.

He was gathering.

The Gloamed were moving. Not wandering, not drifting, the way Elric had seen them on the border in the spring. *Marching*. In columns. In ranks. Hounds and wraiths and stretched grey men and black-armored Hollow-knights, thousands of them, moving west through the grey country in great silent rivers, converging on a point three days east of Caldris where the old Vhessan road crossed the border. And over them, every day, circling in the grey sky: a vast dead shape with silent wings.

"Three days," said Teodra Hale, the evening after the last report came in. She was standing at the big table in the keep's hall, where they'd spread out Seraphine's map of Aldermere. She jabbed a three-fingered hand at the grey country east of the fortress. "He's three days out. Massing. When he's done massing, he'll come." She looked around the table. "Full moon's in two."

"So we have a day to spare," said Garrick.

"We have a day to spare if he doesn't come early. If he doesn't know what we're doing down in that cellar. If he can't feel it when you start pulling the net around." Teodra looked at Lex. "Can he feel it?"

Lex looked at his brother.

"He'll feel it," said Antho quietly. "The thing in him will. It always knows when the Root moves. It knew when Lex's seal cracked. It'll know when we pick up the Anchor."

"So the moment you start, he comes."

"Yes."

Teodra looked down at the map for a long moment. Then she straightened.

"Then we hold the walls," she said. "Three hundred, behind good stone, on a high spur, with a ditch. Against however many thousand he's got." She shrugged. "I've had worse odds." She paused. "Not *much* worse."

"We only have to hold until the ritual's done," said Garrick. "Ten minutes, Arion said. Then three of the blood are holding the net, and Morvane can't take the Anchor anymore, because it's not one man in a crystal. It's three of them, awake."

"Ten minutes," said Dame Brand. "Against an army." She smiled grimly. "I like those odds better."

"Ten minutes for him to step out," said Elric quietly from the end of the table. "And however long after that for the three of them to start the mending." He was looking down at the map. His face was unreadable. "And if anything goes wrong while they're doing it—if anyone gets into that cellar—"

"Then nobody gets into the cellar," said Garrick.

Elric looked up at him. "*Nobody?*"

The hall went quiet.

"Say what you mean, Thorne," said Garrick.



ELRIC SAID WHAT HE meant.

He did it slowly and carefully and with great reluctance, standing at the end of the long table in the firelit hall with the whole of the war council watching him. He took the silver token out of his cloak. The passkey. The lattice on one side and the tower and star on the other. He laid it on the map, in the middle of the grey country, where everyone could see it.

"This fell out of Seraphine Ilvane's pack," he said, "in the Old Drains under Highcrest. Three weeks ago. Lex saw it. Garrick saw it. It's a passkey from the Office of the High Warden. It opens every ward in the Spire. There are perhaps a dozen in existence."

Seraphine had gone white. She was sitting at the other end of the table beside Antho, and Lex saw her hands clench in her lap.

"She says it isn't hers," Elric went on. "She says she's never seen it. And Lex looked at her with his Root-sight, and her panel says she has no passkey bond." He held up a hand before anyone could speak. "I know. I know. I'm not saying she's lying about that. I'm saying a passkey bond can be scrubbed, by someone with enough skill. And this token's bearer signature has been scrubbed. Deliberately." He looked down the table at Seraphine. "By someone with Master-rank Inscribe."

"I didn't have Master-rank Inscribe until the Barrows!" Seraphine's voice cracked. "*You* know that! You were *there*!"

"I was." Elric nodded slowly. "And you've had it for six weeks since."

The silence in the hall was terrible.

"Here's what I'm asking," said Elric quietly. "Only this. On the night of the ritual, when the three of them are in that cellar with their hands on the Stone, holding the whole weight of the Lattice, completely defenseless, I'm asking that the door to the cellar be guarded. By people we're *sure* of." He looked around the table. "And that anyone we're *not* sure of be kept somewhere else. Safe. Comfortable. Watched." He spread his knotted hands. "That's all. For one night. Until it's done. And then, if I'm wrong, I'll get down on my knees and beg her pardon in front of all of you."

Nobody spoke.

Antho stood up.

He did it very slowly. The shadows rose up around his feet as he did, and the Keeper's Lantern at his belt flickered, and the temperature in the hall seemed to drop.

"No," he said.

"Antho—" said Lex.

"*No*." His brother's voice was quiet and very cold. "She's not going anywhere. She's going to be in that cellar with me. Writing down every thread we touch, every knot we tie. Because she's the only one here who can read what we're doing." He looked at Elric. "And because I trust her."

"I know you do," said Elric gently. "That's what worries me."

The shadows surged.

CLARITY: 79 → 70 ▼

"*Enough*," said Garrick.

The old knight had stood up too. He put a hand on Antho's shoulder. Antho flinched, but didn't shake it off.

"I'll guard her," said Garrick. He looked down the table at Seraphine. His scarred face was very kind. "Not in a cell. In the north tower, where there's a fire and a good chair and a window. With me sitting at the door. All night." He looked at Elric. "Will that satisfy you, Thorne?"

Elric looked at him for a long moment.

"Yes," he said at last. "Yes. That would satisfy me."

"And it'll satisfy me too," said Garrick, "because I'll know she's safe. Whatever happens down in that cellar." He looked at Antho. "Lad. I know you want her with you. But you'll be holding the weight of the whole world in your hands. You won't be able to protect her. Let me do it."

Antho stood there with Garrick's hand on his shoulder and the shadows coiling around his feet, shaking.

Then Seraphine said, very quietly, "He's right."

Antho turned.

"He's right, Antho." She'd taken off her spectacles. Her face was very pale and very calm. "If there's any doubt, any at all, I don't want to be in that room. I don't want to be the reason it goes wrong." She looked down at the passkey lying on the map. "I didn't put that in my pack. I swear by everything I have. But I can't prove it. And if I'm wrong about who did—if someone's using me somehow, without my knowing—" She stopped. "I'll go to the tower. With Sir Garrick."

"Seraphine—"

"I'll write it all down afterward. You can tell me everything." She smiled at him. It was a very small, very brave smile. "I'm a Scribe. I'm good at taking notes from other people's accounts."

Antho stared at her. Then he sat down, very suddenly, as if his legs had given out.

Elric picked the passkey up off the map and put it back in his cloak.

"Thank you," he said quietly. "All of you. I know that was hard." He looked at Seraphine. "Especially you."

Seraphine didn't look at him.



LEX COULDN'T SLEEP THAT night.

He went up on the walls, in the dark, and stood looking east. The grey country lay under a sky full of cloud, no stars, no moon. Far away, on the horizon, there was a faint glow. Not fire. Not light. A sort of greyness, darker than the night around it, like a bruise on the sky.

[The Blightmarch,] said Ember quietly. [And his army.]

Three days out.

[Three days.] A pause. [Lex, you should spend your points.]

He laughed, shortly. He'd forgotten. Again. Eighteen points, from the three levels at Avaloria.

He spent them standing on the wall in the dark. Three into Might. Three into Agility. Four into Vitality. Four into Spirit. Four into Resolve.

LEX VEY – Emberwright		
TIER II – Level 30		
MIG 47	AGI 46	VIT 58
INT 42	SPI 112	RES 45
Health 580/580		
Mana 1120/1120		
ROOT		
Seal integrity: 11%		
Authority: 54 / 100		

Eleven percent.

[It's going,] said Ember softly. [Every day. If the ritual doesn't work—] It'll work.

[I hope so.] A pause. [Lex. About Elric.]

He didn't answer.

[You defended her,] said Ember. [At Avaloria. On the road. You looked at her with True Sight, and you saw nothing. And you've seen the things Elric does. The raven going east. The mirror. The not yet over the chasm.] A pause. [But you didn't say anything tonight. When he laid the passkey on the table. You let Garrick take her to the tower.]

I know.

[Why?]

Lex stood on the wall in the dark and looked east at the bruise on the sky.

Because Morvane walked the Way with Father's stolen Root, he thought slowly. Not with anything Elric gave him. Father said so. Morvane said so. He closed his eyes. And because I saw Elric's face when he saw Father. In the chamber. When he wept. He swallowed. You can't fake that. You can't fake forty years.

Ember was quiet for a long time.

[No,] it said at last. [You can't.] A pause. [But you can love someone for forty years and still want what they have so badly it eats you alive. The two things aren't opposites, Lex. They live in the same house. Sometimes they're the same thing.]

Lex didn't answer that.

[I'm a piece of him,] said Ember. [Your father. I have forty years of Elric in me. Memories. Partition five opened at Avaloria, when I spoke to him. I can see more now.] A pause. [I remember the three Sanctions. The two from the Spire, and the third.]

Lex opened his eyes.

The third, he thought. "Once, someone else."

[It was him,] said Ember quietly. [Your father. Eleven years ago, in a letter. The last letter, before the one Elric showed you. Elric asked him for Sanction to Tier Four. Your father had the Root to give it. He said no.] A long pause. [He said, "Not yet, old friend. Not because you aren't strong enough. Because you want it too much."]

Lex stood very still.

[I don't know if it means anything,] said Ember. [It was eleven years ago. Elric still came. He still found you. He still wept.] A pause. [But you asked me once, on the causeway, whether I thought your father was a good man. And I said I didn't know. And now I think I know something else.]

What?

[That he was right,] said Ember softly. [Elric did want it too much. And your father said so, out loud, in a letter, to his oldest friend. And I don't think Elric ever forgave him.]



ON THE THIRD NIGHT, the full moon rose over Fort Caldris.

It came up huge and gold over the eastern hills, over the grey country, over the bruise on the horizon that had grown and grown in the last two days until it filled half the sky. Lex stood on the wall and watched it rise. Beside him, Wren stood with her bow. Below them, in the courtyard, the Ashen Banners and the deserted Wardens and Dame Brand's twenty knights were taking their places on the walls. Torches. Crossbows. Cauldrons of oil. Teodra Hale's voice, rough and steady, calling orders.

Out on the grey slope below the fortress, nothing moved. Yet.

"He'll come," said Wren quietly. "The moment you start."

"I know."

"We'll hold." She didn't look at him. "Ten minutes. We'll hold for ten minutes."

"I know." He took her hand. "Not for me."

"No," she said. "*With* you."

She turned and kissed him, quick and hard, the way she had in the chamber at Avaloria. Then she let go and went to her place on the wall.

Lex went down to the cellar.



THEY WERE ALL THERE. Antho, kneeling by the Twin Stone, with Ashka curled on his shoulder and the Keeper's Lantern glowing at his belt. Their father's shape, beside the crystal, so faint now that he was barely more than a gold shimmer in the torchlight. Old Brisk at the door with his walking stick and a sword he hadn't drawn in twenty years.

And Elric.

He was standing by the door, beside Brisk, with his staff in his hand. His grey cloak. His brass storm-charms, glinting faintly. His face, lined and tired and unreadable.

"I'll guard the stair," he said quietly. "Me and Brisk. Nobody gets down here. Nobody."

Arion's shape turned toward him.

For a long moment, the two of them looked at each other across the low round room. The old sorcerer and the shape of light.

"Elric," said Arion softly. "Before we begin. Will you walk with me? Just for a moment?"

Something flickered across Elric's face. Lex couldn't read it.

"Of course," said Elric.

They went to the far side of the cellar together. Arion's faint gold shape and Elric's tall grey one. They stood by the curved black wall, close together, and spoke in low voices. Lex couldn't hear what they said. He didn't try. He knelt by the Twin Stone beside his brother and looked at the three carved hands on its white surface and tried to breathe.

It didn't take long. A minute. Two.

When Elric came back, his face was grey. His hands on his staff were white at the knuckles. He walked past Lex without looking at him and took his place by the door beside Brisk and stood there, very straight, staring at nothing.

Arion's shape came back to the crystal. He looked at his sons. His translucent face was very sad.

"What did he say?" said Lex quietly.

His father didn't answer for a moment.

"He asked me for something," he said at last. "Something he's asked me for before. Something I couldn't give him." He looked at the crystal. "I told him no. Again." His voice was very soft. "Gently. As gently as I could."

Lex turned his head and looked at Elric, standing by the door in the torchlight.

The old sorcerer was looking at the Twin Stone. At the three carved hands. And on his face was the expression Lex had seen in the mirror on the silver road. The starving man at the window.

But something else, too. Something new. Something that hadn't been there before.

Something that had *decided*.

"*Lexander*," said his father. "*Anthoren*. The moon is up. It's time."

Lex looked away from Elric. He looked at the Twin Stone. At the right hand, carved in the white stone, waiting for him.

He laid his palm on it.

Beside him, Antho laid his on the left.

And somewhere above them, far above, on the walls of Fort Caldris, a horn began to blow.

CHAPTER 25

SHADOWS OF BETRAYAL



THE WEIGHT CAME DOWN on him like a mountain.

Lex had thought he was ready for it. His father had warned them. *It will be the heaviest thing you've ever carried.* He'd lifted anvils. He'd swung sledges for eight years. He'd held a rune open in an ancient road for a whole night while three hundred and forty-six names went through it.

He had never carried anything like this.

He laid his palm on the carved right hand of the Twin Stone, and reached down through it, through the Bloodbond, along the threads, all the way back across the mountains and the moors and the lake that held the sky to the white temple on its island, to the Anchor. And he *took hold*.

And the whole world came down on him.

He felt it. Every thread. Every knot. The vast silver net of the Lattice spread over all of Aldermere like a fishing net spread over the sea, and every thread of it *pulling*. Pulling at him. Pulling at the place in his chest where the seal was, where the fire was. Ten thousand million lives, every one of them a knot in the net, every one of them a weight. Brannoc at his anvil. Pell at the mill. Wren's mother on her step. The girl in Highcrest who wanted to be a Healer. All of them, all at once, hanging from his hand.

And the breaches.

He felt them like wounds. Like burns. Twenty-seven of them, scattered across the net, black holes in the silver where the threads had torn and frayed. He felt the cold coming through them. The hunger. The breath of the thing beneath the world, seeping up through every tear. The one in the

Hollowmaw, held shut by his own ward-nails. The one under the Thornwood. And far to the east, vast and black and gaping like a mouth: Vhessa. The first. The worst. The wound that all the others radiated out from like cracks from a hammer-blow on glass.

His knees buckled. He caught himself on the Twin Stone. The breath went out of him in a sound that wasn't a word.

"Lex." Antho's voice. Beside him. Strained to breaking. "*Lex, I've got it. I've got the left side. Hold the right. Don't let go.*"

He felt his brother. Through the Bloodbond. Through the Stone. On the other side of the net, holding the left half of the weight the way Lex held the right. The cold deep pool of him, braced, straining, shaking.

Together.

Lex set his teeth. He set his feet. He *held*.

ANCHOR – WEIGHT TRANSFERRED

Bearers: LEXANDER VEY (right)

ANTHOREN VEY (left)

Load: 100%

Lattice integrity: 66% (stable)

And in the crystal beside them, their father opened his eyes.



IT WAS SLOW. AGONIZINGLY slow.

The gold shape of light that had been Arion's ghost for fifteen years flowed back into the crystal like water flowing into a basin. It went in through the faceted walls and filled them, and the crystal glowed brighter, and brighter, until Lex had to narrow his eyes against it. And inside the crystal, the body that had stood upright with its eyes closed for fifteen years *breathed*.

Lex saw its chest rise. Saw it fall. Saw the fingers twitch at its sides. Saw the grey eyes open, and blink, and focus.

And the crystal began to soften.

Not crack. Not shatter. *Soften*, the way ice softens in spring, going from hard and clear to wet and pliant. The faceted walls blurred. Their edges rounded. Drops of something that wasn't water began to run down them and fall to the floor and vanish before they touched the stone.

Arion Vey took a step forward.

Inside the softening crystal, slowly, stiffly, like a man who had forgotten how to walk, he took a step. And another. His hand came up and pressed against the inside of the crystal wall, and the crystal gave under it, like a curtain of thick gel. His fingers came through. His hand. His wrist.

A real hand. Flesh and bone. Long-fingered, scarred across the knuckles, a smith's hand like Lex's own.

Ten minutes, Lex thought dizzily, through the crushing weight. *He said ten minutes.*

Above them, through the ceiling, through the black stone of the keep, through the walls of the fortress, he heard the horns. Heard the roar. Felt, through the fellowship bar at the edge of his vision, Wren's health flicker as something struck her. Felt Garrick's dip, and steady, and dip again.

Hold. Just hold. Ten minutes.

Arion's arm came through the crystal to the elbow. His shoulder. The side of his face, pressing through the softening wall like a man pushing through deep water, his grey eyes fixed on his sons. His lips moved. No sound yet. He'd forgotten how. But Lex could read them.

Almost.



BEHIND THEM, ELRIC MOVED.

Lex didn't see it at first. He couldn't see anything but the Twin Stone and his own hand on it and the crystal and his father pushing through it. The weight of the world was pressing down on him so hard that the edges of his vision had gone grey. But he heard the tap of a staff on stone. Footsteps. Coming from the door.

Coming *toward* the Stone.

"*Elric?*" That was Brisk. The old castellan's voice. Puzzled. "Elric, you said we'd guard the stair. What are you—"

Elric didn't answer.

He came around the Twin Stone, on the side between Lex and Antho, where the third carved hand lay waiting in the white stone. The center hand. The larger one. Palm up. The place meant for Arion. For the third of the blood.

He stood over it. His face was grey. His eyes were very bright.

"Elric," said Lex. It came out a croak. He couldn't move. He couldn't let go of the Stone. "Elric, what are you doing?"

The old sorcerer looked down at him.

"I'm sorry, Lex," he said quietly. "I truly am."

He lifted his left hand. And Lex saw, for the first time, that there was something on his palm. A mark. Not a scar. A *glyph*, inked into the skin. Black. Branching. Like the black veins under Morvane's white skin. Like cracks in porcelain.

Elric laid his marked palm on the third carved hand.



IT WAS LIKE A sluice gate opening.

Lex felt it through the Stone. Felt the river of gold that had been flowing out of the Anchor, out of the net, back into his father, the fifteen years of Authority that Arion had poured into holding the world together, finally coming home. He felt it turn. Swerve. Like water finding a new channel. And go *into Elric*.

Into the black glyph on Elric's palm. Up his arm. Into him.

The old sorcerer gasped. His back arched. His head went back. The brass storm-charms on his grey cloak flared, all at once, blazing, not blue-white this time but *gold*. Gold like Lex's eyes. Gold like Root. And over his head, a panel exploded open: silver at first, then cracking, the gold showing through, the way Lex's own panel had cracked on the night of the gloamhounds.

ELRIC THORNE

Class: STORMCALLER (Epic)

Tier III – Level 67

AUTHORITY: 0 → 23 → 41 → 64

Source: STOLEN (ARION VEY)

Graft: HOLLOW (Morvane)

And in the crystal, their father screamed.

He was halfway out. His head and shoulder and arm were through the softening wall. And the gold went out of him like blood from a cut throat. Lex saw it. Saw his father's face go grey. Saw the grey eyes go wide with

shock, and then with understanding, and then with a grief so vast that Lex felt it like a blow.

The crystal *hardened*.

All at once. The soft gel-like walls went hard and clear and faceted again in a single instant, with a sound like ice cracking on a pond. Arion was caught in it. Halfway out. His head and arm and shoulder outside, frozen in the air, his body still inside. And black veins began to spread through the crystal from the place where his arm came out. Branching. Like cracks through ice. Like Gloam.

"*FATHER*—"

The weight on Lex's hand *lurched*.

Without Arion stepping out, without the third of the blood laying his hand on the center place, the ritual was breaking. The Anchor's weight, which Lex and Antho had been holding, began to slip. To drag. To pull back toward its old resting place, toward the crystal, toward the half-trapped man inside it. And there was no Authority left in him to hold it.

RITUAL — BROKEN

Anchor load: returning to CRYSTAL

Crystal Authority: 0 (STOLEN)

Lattice integrity: 66% → 61% → 58%

The whole fortress shook. Lex felt it. Dust sifted down from the low ceiling. Far above, faint through the stone, he heard screams.

"*Let go!*" Elric shouted. He'd taken his hand off the center place. He was staggering back from the Stone, his face grey and wild, gold light still streaming off the storm-charms on his cloak. "*Both of you! Let go, or it'll pull you in with him! Let it go back!*"

Lex didn't let go.

"*Why?*" he screamed at him. "*WHY?*"



ELRIC STOOD IN THE middle of the low round room with gold light pouring off him, and looked at Lex, and his face did something terrible.

"*Why?*" he said. His voice cracked down the middle. "You want to know *why*?"

He laughed. It wasn't a laugh.

"Forty years," he said. "Forty years I stood beside him. I was there when he came to the Spire, a boy with a forgettable face and blood that lit up the Great Stone like a bonfire. I was there when he made Warden-Architect at thirty. I was there for every triumph. Every discovery. Every *first*." He was shaking. "I taught him the Circles. *Me*. And he learned in an afternoon what took me a month. *Oh, I see, it's like folding steel*." His voice twisted. "And I *smiled*. I smiled and I clapped him on the shoulder and I said *well done*."

"*Elric—*"

"He never aged!" It burst out of him like something tearing. "Do you understand that? Forty years. I went grey. I went bent. I lost my teeth and my eyes and half my strength. And he stood beside me looking exactly as he had at thirty, because the Root doesn't let you age, not the way the rest of us do." His face crumpled. "I gave him my *youth*, Lex. I spent it standing next to him. And all he ever gave me back was *not yet*."

He pressed his hand against his chest, against the gold light pouring off him.

"Three times," he said. "I asked for Sanction. Three times. The Spire said no twice. And the third time, I asked *him*. Your father. My oldest friend. He had the Root. He could have given it to me with a thought." His voice dropped to a whisper. "And he said *not yet, old friend. Not because you aren't strong enough. Because you want it too much*."

He looked at the crystal. At Arion's face, frozen halfway out of it, grey, eyes wide.

"And tonight," he said, "I asked him one more time. One last time. Here. Before the ritual. I said, *Let me be the third. Give me Sanction, give me a little Authority, let me stand in the center with your sons and hold the net. I've earned it. I've given everything*." His mouth twisted. "And he looked at me with those eyes and said *I'm sorry. I can't. The net would feel it. It would feel how much you want it*."

He turned back to Lex.

"So I took it," he said simply.



"YOU TOLD HIM," LEX said. His voice was barely a voice. "Morvane. You told him where to find the lake."

"I told him where to *look*," Elric didn't deny it. "He had your father's Root already, from Vhessa. Enough to walk the Way, once it was open. He only needed to know where it was." He smiled faintly. "*The waters that hold the sky*. One raven. That's all it took."

"The raven," said Lex. "On the causeway. East."

"East." Elric nodded. "Not to *H*. There is no *H*. I wrote that letter myself, in Highcrest, with my left hand, and gave it to Quill to bring back to me." He looked at Lex almost sadly. "You wanted so much to believe me. I could see it in your face."

"*The passkey*—"

"Mine." Elric reached into his cloak and took it out. The silver token. "I took it from the High Warden's office eleven years ago. The night your father said no. I lowered the vault wards with it two years ago, so the archivist would find the Kindling ledgers and run, and the Spire would tear itself apart looking for her, and nobody would look at me." He turned it over in his fingers. "And I put it in her pack in Hedda's shop while she slept. Because I knew one day I'd need someone for you to look at instead."

Antho made a sound.

It wasn't a word. It came from deep in his chest, low and terrible, and the shadows around his feet *surged*.

"And tonight," said Elric, "I used it to lower the wards on the postern gate. Before I came down here." He looked up at the ceiling. At the screams, faint through the stone. "Morvane's people are already inside the walls."

"*You*—" Lex couldn't find the words. "*Brisk*. Brisk is *right there*. Garrick. Wren. *Three hundred people*. They trusted you. *I* trusted you—"

"I know." Elric's face was grey. "I know. I didn't want it this way. I want you to know that. I wanted—" He stopped. "It doesn't matter what I wanted. It never mattered. Not to him. Not to anyone."

Old Brisk had moved.

Lex hadn't seen him. Nobody had. The old castellan had come away from the door, slowly, quietly, limping on his bad leg, with the sword he

hadn't drawn in twenty years finally in his hand. He'd come around behind Elric while the old sorcerer was talking. And now he raised the sword.

"You were my friend too, Thorne," he said hoarsely. "Thirty years. You and me and Arion and Dunmore, in the eastern march."

Elric turned.

He didn't raise his staff. He didn't need to. He lifted his left hand, the one with the black glyph on it, and gold lightning leaped from it. Not blue-white. *Gold*. Root-gold. It struck Brisk in the chest.

The old castellan didn't make a sound. He just stopped. Stood there for a moment with his sword raised and a look of mild surprise on his lined face. And then he folded, slowly, like a coat sliding off a peg, and lay on the black stone floor, and didn't move.

Elric stared down at him.

For one long moment, his face was absolutely naked. Horror. Grief. A man looking at what he had done and seeing, for the first time, what he was.

Then it closed. Like a door. Like a lid on a pot.

"I'm sorry, Tamsin," he said quietly. And turned back to the Stone.



HE USED THE AUTHORITY on Lex first.

Lex felt it coming. Felt the stolen gold gather in Elric like a storm gathering over the mountains. He couldn't move. He couldn't let go of the Twin Stone; if he let go, the whole weight of the Anchor would fall back on his father all at once, on the half-trapped man in the crystal with no Authority left to hold it. He could feel it pulling. Dragging. Trying to tear itself out of his hand. He held on.

"I'm sorry, Lex," said Elric again. And reached out with the stolen Root, the way Lex had reached for the Lumen Wardens in the white corridor. Not in words. In fire. In intent. In the language under language.

LOCK.

It hit him like a hammer.

Not on his body. Deeper. On the place under his breastbone where the seal was, where the fire was. Where the door had broken on the night of the gloamhounds and the gold had poured through.

Something slammed shut.

He felt it go. The fire. Not out. *Shut in.* Behind a door. A new door, heavier than the old one, iron and gold and black, slammed and bolted and locked. He felt it the way you feel a forge-door slam: the sudden absence of heat on your face, the roar of the fire muffled to nothing.

His panel, at the edge of his vision, went dark.

Not silver-dark. Not severed, the way Vane's chains had severed it. *Dark.* Gone.

LEX VEY

CLASS: ████████ — LOCKED

Lock authority: ELRIC THORNE
(stolen Root)

Level: —

Skills: —

Stat bonuses: SUSPENDED

His legs went. All at once. Like a puppet with its strings cut. Every point he'd spent, every level he'd climbed, every bit of strength and speed and endurance the Lattice had given him over the last three months, gone. He was a nineteen-year-old blacksmith's apprentice again. Strong, for a boy who swung hammers. Nothing more.

And the weight of the Anchor tore itself out of his hand.



HE SCREAMED. HE DIDN'T know he was screaming.

He felt it go. The right half of the world, the half he'd been holding. It ripped out of his grip like a rope tearing through his palms, and fell back along the threads toward the crystal, and he heard his father, frozen halfway out of the crystal, make a sound like a man being crushed under a falling wall.

Antho was still holding the left half. Alone.

Lex felt it through the Bloodbond. Felt his brother's knees buckle. Felt the cold deep pool of him strain and shake and crack. Antho was screaming too. Holding half the world alone.

"*Let go,*" Elric said to him. "*Let it go back, Anthoren, or it'll crush you.*"

Antho didn't let go.

Elric reached for him with the stolen Root. Lex felt it gather. Felt Elric reach not for Antho's class, the broken error-class that wasn't really in the Lattice at all, but for the *Bloodbond*. The thread between them. The thing that held Antho's Clarity up. The thing that let them reach for each other.

SEVER.

And it *bounced*.

Lex felt it hit the Bloodbond and slide off. Like a blade glancing off good armor. Like Vane's chain sliding off Oathkeeper.

Elric's eyes went wide. He looked down.

At the hammer. Anvilson. Lying on the floor at Lex's feet, where it had fallen when his legs gave out. Its runes still glowing faintly in the dark iron. All five of them.

STAY. The bearer cannot be severed from those he holds dear by any working of the Lattice or the Hollow.

"Ah," said Elric softly. "The boy's runes." He almost smiled. "Of course. Of course he'd make something like that. He's his father's son."

He lifted his staff instead.

He didn't strike Antho. He struck the lantern.

The Keeper's Lantern, hanging at Antho's belt. Twelve *Hush* runes on its black iron frame, one for every ward-nail in the Hollowmaw. The little ever-burning flame behind its glass chimney. Gold lightning leaped from Elric's staff and hit it squarely.

The glass shattered. The iron frame *melted*. The little flame inside went out.

And the voice in Antho's head came roaring back.

◆ ◆ ◆

LEX HEARD IT. EVEN with his own power locked, he heard it. Through the Bloodbond, the Bloodbond Elric couldn't cut. A wet, hungry, *delighted* roar.

[FREE free free free FREE —]

CLARITY: 71 → 44 ▼▼▼

44 → 19 ▼▼▼

19 → 6 ▼▼▼

 — IN CONTROL

Antho's hand came off the Twin Stone.

The left half of the world fell back along the threads into the crystal. The whole weight of the Anchor. All of it. Onto the half-trapped man inside, with no Authority left in him, frozen halfway out with his arm reaching for his sons.

The crystal *flashed*. Black. And Arion's face went still. Not dead. Lex could see it wasn't dead. But *still*. Grey. Eyes open and fixed. The way the statues in the Oracle's gorge were still. Waiting.

ANCHOR – RETURNED TO CRYSTAL

Bearer: ARION VEY

Authority: 0

Status: STASIS (critical)

Lattice integrity: 58% → 54%

And Antho turned around.

His eyes were black. Fully black. Edge to edge. The shadows were pouring off him, not coiled and quiet the way they'd been since the Hollowmaw, but wild, uncontrolled, a black storm boiling up off his body and filling the low round room. They tore at the walls. They tore at the floor. Ashka shrieked and leaped off his shoulder and fled.

And Antho opened his mouth, and the voice that came out wasn't his.

[warm,] it said. Wet and soft and hungry. [so warm. the little brother. so warm. smells of fire. mine now. mine.]

He turned his black eyes on Lex.

Lex was on his knees on the cold stone floor. No class. No power. No fire. Just a blacksmith's apprentice with a dead man's hammer lying beside him, looking up at his brother's face with something else looking out of it.

"*Antho*," he said.

The thing wearing his brother's face smiled.



HOLLOW-KNIGHTS CAME DOWN THE stair.

Lex heard them before he saw them. Heavy black-armored feet on the old worn steps. They came through the door in a rush, four, six, ten of them, with white eyes and dripping black swords, and they didn't look at Lex or Antho at all. They went straight to the crystal.

Elric stood aside to let them pass.

They took hold of the crystal. Ten of them, black-gauntleted hands on its faceted walls. With Arion frozen halfway out of it, his arm reaching, his face grey and still. And they *lifted*. The crystal came up off the floor of the cellar like a coffin being raised from a grave. They carried it toward the door. Toward the stair. Up.

"No—" Lex tried to get up. His legs wouldn't hold him. He fell. Tried again. "No—*Father*—"

Elric looked at him. The gold light was still pouring off his storm-charms. His face was grey and set.

"He'll be safe," the old sorcerer said quietly. "Morvane needs him alive. Needs the knot whole, to graft himself onto it. It'll take time. Months." He looked away. "He won't feel anything. He's in stasis. He won't feel any of it."

"*You don't know that.*"

Elric didn't answer.

The Hollow-knights carried the crystal out through the door and up the stair. Lex heard their feet. Heard them climbing. Heard the crystal knock against the narrow walls of the spiral, *tock, tock*, like a bell tolling.

Elric followed them to the door.

He stopped there. He turned back. He looked at the low round room: at Brisk lying dead on the floor, at Antho standing in a storm of black shadow with his eyes gone dark, at Lex on his knees beside the Twin Stone with nothing left.

"I'm sorry, Lex," he said, for the third time. His voice was very quiet. "You were right to be suspicious. Your father always trusted too easily." He paused. "I'm glad you don't."

He turned and went up the stair.



LEX DIDN'T KNOW HOW long he knelt there.

The black storm around Antho filled the room. It was growing. Spreading. Reaching for the walls, the ceiling, the stair. Reaching for him. He could feel it coming closer, cold and hungry, the way the gloamhound's bite had been cold on the Ashbourne green a lifetime ago.

[warm ... warm ... so warm ...]

He had no fire. He had no Ironskin. He had no class, no skills, no Root. He reached for Ember, in the place where Ember always was.

Nothing.

Not silence. *Nothing*. The place where Ember had lived for three months, the dry calm courteous voice in the back of his head, was gone. Shut away behind the same new door as the fire. He called for it. Thought its name, over and over, the way he'd thought it on the first night by the campfire in the foothills.

Ember. Ember. Ember.

Nothing came back.

He was alone. For the first time since the night of the gloamhounds, he was completely, utterly alone in his own head.

The black storm reached him.

It wrapped around his legs, his arms, his chest. Cold. So cold. Like the gloamhound's bite. Like the Rimewarden's roar. Like the thing in the Hollow. He felt it going *into* him. Felt the grey creeping in at the edges of his sight.

And his hand found the hammer.

He didn't tell it to. It just found it. The way his hand had always found Anvilson in the dark, the way it found it in the morning before his eyes were open. His fingers closed around the haft. And the hammer was *warm*.

It was still warm.

Elric had locked his class. Locked his fire. Locked Ember. Locked everything the Lattice and the Root had given him. But the hammer wasn't the Lattice. The hammer wasn't the Root. The hammer was a *thing he had made*. With his own hands. On an anvil in Ashbourne, with Brannoc striking, and a horseshoe nail folded into its heart. And a thing that is made, *remembers*.

It remembers the hand that made it. And the hands it held.

The runes were still glowing. All five of them. Faint. Red-gold. In the dark iron.

VEY. The Hand Held Out. Once per day: give your strength to another.

He looked up at his brother.

At the thing wearing his brother's face, standing in the storm of black shadow.

He didn't have much strength left to give. He didn't have a class, or levels, or mana. He had a nineteen-year-old smith's body and a nineteen-year-old smith's heart and a hammer that remembered.

He gave it anyway.

He held out his hand. Not toward the black storm. Toward Antho. Toward the place, under all that black, where his brother was. Drowning. Holding the door with nothing left.

And through the hammer, through the rune, through the Bloodbond that Elric couldn't cut, he gave him *half*. Half of everything he had. Not mana. Not health. Something under both. Warmth. The hearth on a winter night. The lantern in the window.

Look after me, he thought. I'm right here.



THE BLACK STORM STOPPED.

It hung in the air of the low round room, frozen, the way the world had frozen on the Ashbourne green when the seal first cracked. And in the middle of it, Antho's head came up.

His eyes were black. But at the center, very faint, so faint Lex almost missed it, there was a pinprick of grey.

"Lex," said Antho. His own voice. Cracked to pieces. Barely there.

CLARITY: 6 → 14 ▲
14 → 23 ▲

"I'm here," said Lex. "I'm right here."

"It's so loud. Lex. It's so loud. The lantern's gone. I can't—I can't hold—"

"Then don't hold it alone." Lex got up. He didn't know how. His legs were water. But he got up, with the hammer in his hand, and walked through the frozen storm of black shadow to his brother, and put his free hand flat on Antho's chest, over his heart. The way he had in the Thornwood. "I don't have any fire. He took it. I don't have anything." He

swallowed. "But I've got you. And you've got me. And that's enough. That has to be enough."

Antho stared at him with his black-and-grey eyes.

Then, very slowly, the shadows began to fall.

Not all of them. Not like on the steps of the Oracle, or in the Hollowmaw. They fell sullenly. Reluctantly. Some of them stayed, coiled around Antho's ankles and wrists like black chains. The roaring in Lex's ears through the Bloodbond didn't stop. It just dropped. From a roar to a snarl. From a snarl to a growl.

But Antho's eyes came back. Grey, mostly. Black at the edges.

CLARITY: 23 → 29 ▲

 — *restrained (barely)*

Clarity anchor: ACTIVE (no Root)

Antho sagged against him. Lex held him up. They stood there in the low round room, the two of them, holding each other, with Brisk dead on the floor and the Twin Stone dark beside them and the crystal gone.

Above them, through the ceiling, the screams were getting louder.



THEY CAME UP THE spiral stair into fire.

The keep was burning. Not with Lex's fire, gold and clean. With something else: a sullen grey-black fire that rolled along the floors and climbed the walls and gave off a thick choking smoke that smelled of wet ash and nothing. Gloam-fire. It ate the old timbers of the keep like acid eating cloth.

And through the smoke, shapes. Gloamhounds loping. Mistwraiths drifting. Grey stretched men. Black Hollow-knights.

And people. Their people. The Ashen Banners. The deserted Wardens. Dame Brand's knights. Fighting. Falling. Running.

"*The courtyard*," gasped Antho. He was leaning on Lex, staggering. "*The gate. We have to—*"

A shape came out of the smoke at them.

Not a Gloamed thing. A woman. Small and slim, with a fox-red braid and a bow in her hand and blood running down her face from a cut on her scalp.

"HAMMER."

Wren hit him like a thrown stone. She wrapped her arms around him and Antho both and held on so hard Lex felt his ribs creak. Then she let go and stepped back and stared at him.

"*What happened?*" she said. "*What happened down there? I felt it. Through the fellowship. I felt your bar go out. Like a candle. I thought you were—*" She stopped. "*Your eyes.*"

"What about them?"

"They're grey," said Wren. "They're just grey."

"Elric," said Lex. His voice cracked. "It was Elric. He took Father. He took my class. He—" He couldn't finish.

Wren's face went very still. Then very hard.

"I know," she said. "Seraphine saw. From the tower."

"*Seraphine—*" Antho's head jerked up.

"She saw the postern wards go down. She can read wards. She knew who'd done it; she said only someone with a passkey could. She ran down the tower stair before Garrick could stop her." Wren's voice was flat. "She got to the cellar stair as Elric was coming up. Behind the crystal. She called him a traitor. Out loud. In front of everyone." Wren swallowed. "He hit her. With lightning. Gold lightning."

Antho made a sound like something tearing.

"She's alive," said Wren quickly. "She's *alive*. Garrick caught her. He's got her. In the courtyard. But she's bad, Antho. She's really bad." She grabbed his arm. "Come on. *Come on.*"



THE COURTYARD WAS HELL.

Smoke and grey fire and screaming. The great gate stood open, smashed off its hinges, and through it the Gloam was pouring in a black river. Hollow-knights fought on the walls. Gloamhounds tore through the stables. Somewhere Teodra Hale's voice was roaring orders, hoarse and cracked. Somewhere Dame Brand's knights were holding a corner by the north tower, a knot of plain grey armor surrounded by black.

And in the middle of the courtyard, on the steps of the keep, there was a knight.

Garrick had Seraphine across his knees. She was lying limp, her spectacles gone, her grey robe burned black down one side, her face white as paper. Her breath was coming in short, shallow, bubbling gasps. Garrick was crouched over her on the keep steps with Oathkeeper in one hand, its blade blazing blue-white, and every Gloamed thing that came within reach of it shattered and didn't rise.

He looked up as they came out of the smoke.

"*Lad*," he said. And his face, seeing Lex alive, did something Lex would remember for the rest of his life.

Antho dropped to his knees beside Seraphine.

"*Seraphine*," he said. "*Seraphine. Sera.*" His scarred hands hovered over her, shaking, not knowing where to touch. "*Look at me.*"

She didn't look at him. Her eyes were closed. Her lips were blue.

"She's dying," said Garrick quietly. "The lightning went into her. Into her chest. She's got maybe minutes." He looked at Lex. "Can you—you did it for me. On the stair at Avaloria. The hand thing. The healing."

The Hand Held Out. Once per day.

He'd already used it. On Antho. In the cellar.

Lex looked down at the hammer in his hand. At the runes, glowing faint and red-gold. At the fourth one. The open hand.

Once per day.

He'd given Antho half of what he had. He didn't have much left. A nineteen-year-old smith's body, locked out of everything that had made him strong. Bruised, battered, burned, shaking with exhaustion.

He knelt beside Seraphine on the keep steps. He laid the hammer across her chest. He put his own hand over it.

Please, he thought. *Please. I know it's only once a day. I know I already used it. I know I don't have anything left.* He pressed down on the hammer. *But I made you. I made you with my own hands. And you remember the hands you held.*

Please.

The fourth rune flickered.

And something went out of him. Not much. A thread. A last thin thread of warmth, from the very bottom of him, from the place under the locked door, the place even Elric's stolen Root couldn't reach. It went

down his arm, through his hand, into the hammer, and through the hammer into the thin burned body lying on the steps.

He felt his own heart stutter. Felt the grey creep in at the edges of his sight.

Seraphine's eyes opened.

She gasped. A real breath. Deep. Ragged. Her lips went from blue to grey to faintly pink. Her eyes, unfocused without her spectacles, wandered across the smoky sky and found Antho's face bending over her.

"*Antho?*" she whispered.

Antho made a sound and put his forehead down against hers and didn't say anything at all.

Lex sat back on his heels on the keep step. The world was swimming. He couldn't feel his hands.

"*Lad.*" Garrick's hand on his shoulder. Steadying him. "*Lad, stay with me.*"

"I'm here," Lex said. It came out a whisper. "I'm here."

"Good." Garrick's voice was rough. "Good. Because you need to *run*."



HE DIDN'T WANT TO run. He'd never wanted to run less in his life.

But Teodra Hale's voice was screaming *RETREAT* across the burning courtyard. And the Gloam was still pouring through the shattered gate. And above them, in the smoky sky, a vast grey shape was circling. With something hanging beneath it, held in its great grey claws. Something faceted, glowing faintly, with a man's arm reaching out of it.

And on Sorrowmaw's back, standing upright between its vast shoulders, two figures. One tall and thin and white, in a long white coat. And one tall and thin and grey, in a long grey cloak, with brass storm-charms on it that blazed gold.

The dragon turned east. Its silent wings beat once, twice. And it flew away over the burning walls of Fort Caldris, toward the grey country and the bruise on the horizon, with their father hanging in its claws.

"*The sally port,*" said Wren. She had Lex by one arm. Antho had Seraphine in his arms, carrying her, her head on his shoulder. Ashka had

come back out of nowhere and was clinging to his back, shrieking. "*North wall. There's a sally port. Teodra's getting people out that way. Come on.*"

"*Garrick—*"

The old knight was standing up.

He stood on the keep steps with Oathkeeper in his hand, the blade blazing blue-white and gold, looking out across the courtyard at the shattered gate. At the black river pouring through it. At the Gloamed things coming.

"Go," he said.

"*Garrick, come with us—*"

"Somebody has to hold the gate, lad. Long enough for the rest to get out the sally port. Three hundred people came here because Thorne asked them." His jaw tightened. "Somebody has to stand on the steps."

"*No—*"

Garrick turned and looked at him. His scarred face was calm. Very calm. The calm of a man who has stood in a lot of doorways and knows exactly what this one is.

"I swore an oath on this sword," he said. "To you. To your brother. To the girl with the bow. To stand on the steps, wherever the steps are, for as long as I can stand." He smiled. It was a real smile, warm and crooked. "These are the steps, Lex. And I can still stand."

He turned back to the gate.

"Go," he said. "And find your father. And bring that traitor's head back to me in a sack. And tell my girl I kept my oath."

He walked down the keep steps into the courtyard, toward the shattered gate and the black river pouring through it, with Oathkeeper blazing in his hand. And he didn't look back.

Wren dragged Lex away.



THEY CAME OUT THROUGH the sally port in the north wall into cold dark air and a steep slope of rock and heather falling away below them. People all around them. Teodra Hale's Ashen Banners, what was left of them. Deserted Wardens, bloody and stumbling. A handful of Dame

Brand's knights, carrying their wounded. All of them running north, away from the fortress, into the dark.

Lex looked back once.

Fort Caldris was burning. The keep, the towers, the walls. Grey-black fire climbing into a sky full of smoke. And at the shattered gate, small and far away, there was a light. Blue-white and gold. Flashing. Flashing. Holding.

Then the smoke covered it.

He turned and ran.



MUCH LATER, IN THE grey hour before dawn, they stopped in a fold of the hills a dozen miles north. What was left of them. Perhaps a hundred, out of three hundred. Lying in the heather, bleeding, weeping, too exhausted to move.

Lex sat with his back against a rock and Anvilson across his knees and looked at nothing.

He called up his status. Out of habit. The way he had every morning for three years in the forge at Ashbourne.

LEX VEY

Age: 19

Class: ████████ – LOCKED

Level: –

MIG 16 AGI 9 VIT 14

INT 13 SPI 4 RES 15

(base values)

ROOT: ██████ – SUPPRESSED

Sixteen. Nine. Fourteen. Thirteen. Four. Fifteen.

The numbers from the morning Elric walked into the forge. The numbers he'd looked at every day for three years. The numbers he'd thought were him.

Spirit: 4.

He sat there in the heather and looked at it for a long time.

Then he closed his eyes and reached, one more time, for the place in the back of his head where a dry calm courteous voice had lived for three

months. Where it had called him *Smith*, and then *Lex*, and then *little smith*. Where it had sung his mother's lullaby off-key in a Founders' waystation in the ice.

Ember.

Nothing.

Ember, please.

Nothing at all.

Beside him, Wren sat down in the heather. She didn't say anything. She just leaned her shoulder against his, the way she did. And a little way off, Antho sat with Seraphine's head in his lap, stroking her hair, staring east at the grey smudge on the horizon where the smoke from Fort Caldris still rose into the dawn.

Lex sat between them, with nothing left, and for the first time since he was eleven years old, kneeling in the wet grass outside a burning house, he wept.

CHAPTER 26

THE DEPTHS OF DESOLATION



THE SURVIVORS SCATTERED ON the third day.

There was no choice. Teodra Hale said it bluntly, standing in the heather at the head of the ragged column with her greatsword over her shoulder and a bloody bandage around her head. A hundred people moving together through open country left a trail a blind man could follow. And they were being followed. Ashka had seen them from the air: grey riders on the southern road, and black shapes moving in the hills to the east, and once, very high, a vast grey dragon circling.

"We split," said Teodra. "Small groups. Different directions. Meet again at the Hollin's Cross ruins in a month, if we're alive." She looked at Lex. "Not you."

"What?"

"Not you. Not your brother. Not the girl with the burns." Teodra's face was hard. "They're not hunting us, smith. They're hunting *you*. Every group you travel with is a group that dies." She jerked her head south, toward the road where the grey riders were. "The Spire's put out a new notice. I heard it from a shepherd yesterday. *The wildcaster brothers opened Fort Caldris to the Blight. Three hundred dead. Five thousand crowns. Each.*"

"That's a lie."

"Course it's a lie. Kell doesn't care. She's got a story that makes her look right and makes you look like monsters, and Thorne's not around to

contradict it." Teodra spat. "Five thousand crowns is enough to make honest men into dogs."

Lex didn't say anything.

Teodra looked at him for a long moment. Her broad scarred face softened, very slightly.

"I've been a sellsword for thirty years," she said. "I've fought for kings and merchants and lords and thieves. I've never once fought for something I believed in." She paused. "I believed in this. In that crystal. In your father walking out of it." She shook her head. "Thorne took that from me too. But I'm not done." She put her three-fingered hand on his shoulder. "Get your fire back, smith. However you do it. Then send for me. I'll come."

Dame Brand said much the same, more briefly, before she took her knights west toward Highcrest. *I'll tell her what happened. All of it. She'll know the truth, even if no one else does.*

By noon, the hills were empty.

There were four of them left. Lex. Antho. Wren. Seraphine, on a litter of cloaks and ash-poles that Lex and Antho carried between them. And Ashka, gliding overhead on her silver-framed wing, watching.



THEY FOUND THE TOWER on the fifth day.

It was Wren who saw it. A grey stub of stone on a ridgetop, half-hidden in a stand of twisted rowans. An old Founders' watchtower, Seraphine said faintly from the litter, when they got close enough for her to see the open hand and the flame carved over the door. Built nine hundred years ago, abandoned for six hundred. The roof had fallen in. The stair had rotted away. But the ground floor was dry, and the walls were thick, and the door, when Lex put his shoulder to it, still swung on its hinges.

They carried Seraphine inside and laid her on a heap of dead bracken against the wall.

And then they stopped.

They hadn't stopped since Caldris. Five days of walking, carrying, hiding, walking again. Five days of looking over their shoulders, of sleeping in shifts, of eating whatever Ashka caught and whatever Wren could find. Five days of not thinking.

Now they stopped. And the thinking came.



LEX TRIED TO FORGE on the second night.

He knew it was stupid. He knew it wouldn't work. But Antho had been bad the night before, very bad, and Lex had sat up with him until dawn, and he'd been thinking, all through the long dark hours, about the Keeper's Lantern. About twelve *Hush* runes on a black iron frame. About how he'd made it once, in Hedda's forge, and how he could make it again.

He had iron. A few crossbow bolts left in his pack, the last of the Wardens' bolts from the Hollowmaw. He had Anvilson. He had a fire, a real fire, built of dead rowan in a ring of stones in the middle of the tower's floor.

He didn't have Heat Shaping. He didn't have Ember Strike. He didn't have Runic Forging, or Forge Sense, or anything else. When he reached for them, in the old way, through the silver panel, there was nothing there. Just the dark. Just the locked door.

So he did it the old way. The way Brannoc had taught him before there was any Lattice in it at all.

He heated a bolt in the fire until it glowed. He laid it on a flat stone. He struck it with Anvilson.

It was all wrong. The fire wasn't hot enough; rowan wood burned too fast and too cool. The stone wasn't an anvil; it was a rock, and the bolt skidded across it. Anvilson was far too heavy for fine work; it was a war-hammer, not a tool. The iron cooled before he could shape it. He put it back in the fire. Heated it again. Struck again. It bent wrong. He straightened it. It cracked.

He tried to put a rune into it.

Hush. He knew the shape. He'd struck it twelve times into the Keeper's Lantern, in Hedda's forge, with Ember reading the notes aloud to him. He knew every curve of it.

He struck it into the cooling iron.

Nothing. No gold. No glow. No ring. Just a dent in a bent crossbow bolt. A shape. A scratch. Meaning nothing.

He tried again. And again. And again.

At some point he realized Wren was sitting beside him.

He didn't know how long she'd been there. He didn't look at her. He was staring at the bolt on the stone, at the twelfth dead *Hush* scratched into its cooling iron, at the crack running through the middle of it.

"It doesn't work," he said. His voice sounded strange. "It doesn't work. I can't—I can see the shape. I know the shape. But it doesn't *go in*. It just sits there." He put down the hammer. His hands were shaking. "It's just a dent."

Wren didn't say anything.

"Three months," said Lex. "Three months ago I was a smith. Level nine. Spirit of four. And I was fine. I was *fine*." He laughed. It came out cracked. "And then Elric walked into the forge and told me I was something else. Something more. And I believed him. And it was *true*. It was true for three months." He picked up the bent, cracked bolt and looked at it. "And now I'm a smith again. Level nothing. Spirit of four. And I can't even make a lantern."

"Lex—"

"What am I?" He turned and looked at her. His eyes were burning. "Without it? Without the fire, without Ember, without the class? What am I? I'm *nothing*. I'm a blacksmith's apprentice with a heavy hammer and a dead man's name. I can't heal you. I can't protect Antho. I can't save Father. I can't do *anything*."

Wren looked at him for a long moment.

Then she reached out and took the bent bolt out of his hand, and set it down on the stone, and took his hand instead.

"I met you," she said, "in the Last Hearth. In Thistledown. You walked in with a hammer on your shoulder and asked Grell for a guide to the Hollowmaw, and everyone in the room went quiet." She turned his hand over in hers, looking at his palm. At the burn scars. At the calluses. "You were level eight. You'd forgotten to spend your points. You didn't know how to fight. You'd nearly been eaten by a bear."

"I know."

"And I watched you. While you talked to Grell. And then while you walked back across the room." Her thumb moved across his palm. "You had a hole in your coat, on the left shoulder, where you'd fallen in the

stream. You had mud to your knees. You looked like you hadn't slept in a week." She looked up. "And when Grell told you no, you didn't shout. You didn't threaten him. You said *thank you for your help*, and turned to go." Something moved at the corner of her mouth. "Nobody ever says thank you to Grell."

Lex didn't say anything.

"I didn't follow you because of your class, Hammer," said Wren. "I didn't even know your class. I didn't know about the fire or the gold eyes or the Root or any of it." She held his gaze. "I followed you because you paid me in full before we left. Because you fixed my bow without being asked. Because you sat by my campfire and told me about your brother, and you weren't ashamed." Her voice dropped. "Because you're kind. And stubborn. And you don't give up. And none of that was ever in your panel."

Lex's throat had closed up.

"The Lattice didn't make you," said Wren. "It just gave you some numbers. You were already *you* before the numbers." She squeezed his hand. "You're still you. Level nothing. Spirit of four. You're still the idiot who walked into the warlock's cave and sang to him."

He couldn't speak.

So he didn't. He just sat there by the fire, in the ruined tower, with the bent bolt on the stone and his hand in hers, and after a while she leaned her head on his shoulder, and they sat like that until the fire burned down.



ANTHO'S WORST NIGHT CAME on the fourth.

It had been building since Caldris. Since the lantern shattered. Lex could feel it through the Bloodbond: the voice in his brother's head, roaring, unchained, hammering at the door Antho was holding shut with nothing but his own will. Every day his Clarity sank a little lower. Every night it sank further.

CLARITY: 29 → 24 → 21 → 17

 – *ascendant*

Seventeen. Below twenty. *The Murmur can act through him.*

It did, a little. Small things. Antho would stop in the middle of a sentence and his eyes would flicker black and his lips would move with words that weren't his. *Warm. Hungry. Little brother.* And then he'd shake his head and blink and his eyes would come back grey and he'd say, very quietly, *sorry. Sorry. What was I saying?*

He stopped sleeping. He sat up all night by the fire with his hands pressed to his temples and his bone flute in his lap, playing the Lantern Song over and over, until his lips cracked and bled. Ashka wouldn't leave him. She lay across his feet and crooned to him in her deep rumbling purr, and sent him pictures Lex could feel through the Bloodbond: *Sky. Lightning. Antho laughing. Antho, Antho, stay.*

On the fourth night, the flute stopped.

Lex woke to silence. Total silence. No flute, no crooning, no crackle of the fire. He sat up. The fire had burned down to embers. In their faint red glow, he saw his brother.

Antho was standing in the middle of the tower floor. Very still. His back to Lex. His arms at his sides. And the shadows were rising off him. Slowly. Silently. Not in a storm, the way they had in the cellar. In a column. A single smooth black column rising from his feet to the broken roof and out into the night sky, like smoke from a chimney on a windless night.

Ashka was pressed against the far wall, her wings mantled, her golden eyes wide, absolutely silent.

CLARITY: 9 ▼▼▼

WARNING

 **IN CONTROL**

Blackout imminent

"Antho," said Lex.

His brother turned around.

His eyes were black. Completely black. Not a pinprick of grey. And his face was calm. That terrible, peaceful, serene calm Lex had seen in the mirror on the silver road. The face of a man who had never once heard a voice in his head, because he *was* the voice.

"Hello, little brother," it said.

Lex got up.

"*You're so warm,*" said the thing wearing Antho's face. It took a step toward him. "*I've been wanting you since the cave. Since you walked in with your fire and your hammer and your stupid song. So bright. So warm.*" Another step. "*And now the fire's locked away. And the little voice in your head is gone. And you're just warm. Just meat and blood and a little bit of heat.*" It smiled. "*Nobody to stop me.*"

"I'm right here," said Lex.

"*I know. That's what I'm saying.*"

It came at him.

Not with shadows. With hands. Antho's hands. Long and scarred and cold as ice. They closed around Lex's throat.

Lex didn't fight. He didn't have anything to fight with. He was a nineteen-year-old smith with base stats, and his brother was level thirty-eight, and the thing wearing him had nine hundred years of hunger behind it.

He put his arms around his brother instead.

He wrapped them around Antho's thin body and held on. The way he had in the passage of the Hollowmaw, the first night. The way he had in the Thornwood. The way he had in the cellar at Caldris. He held on, with the cold hands closing around his throat, and he put his mouth next to his brother's ear, and with what breath he had left, he sang.

Little light, little light, burning low.

The hands tightened.

Keep the door for the ones who go.

He couldn't breathe. The grey was creeping in.

If the dark comes calling—

And from the bracken against the wall, faint and cracked and feverish, another voice joined his.

—don't you mind—

Seraphine. She'd woken. She was lying on her litter with her burned face turned toward them and her eyes open, unfocused without her spectacles, and she was singing. She didn't have much of a voice either. It shook and cracked and wandered off the tune. She'd only heard the song a

handful of times, around the campfire, on the road north. But she knew the words.

—a lantern's lit for the ones behind.

The hands loosened.

Just slightly. Just enough for Lex to drag in one breath.

He sang again. Seraphine sang with him. Two broken voices in a ruined tower in the middle of the night.

Little light, little light, burning low...

And then a third voice.

Very faint. Very far away. Coming from somewhere deep inside the thing that had its hands around Lex's throat. Antho's voice. Cracked to pieces. Drowning.

...keep the door...

CLARITY: 9 → 11 ▲

...for the ones who go...

CLARITY: 11 → 14 ▲

The hands came off Lex's throat. He felt his brother's body go rigid in his arms. Felt it shake. Felt the war going on inside it, the voice and the man, the hunger and the boy who'd collected lanterns.

"Lex," said Antho. His own voice. Barely. "*Lex, I can't—it's too strong—I can't hold it—*"

"I've got you."

"You don't have anything. He took it."

"I've got *you*." Lex held on harder. "That's all I need. That's all I've ever needed." His voice cracked. "You're the one who keeps the door, Antho. You said so. On the silver road. *I keep the door. That's what I am.*" He pressed his forehead against his brother's. "So keep it. Just for tonight. Just until morning. I'll be right here. I won't let go."

The column of shadow rising from Antho's feet wavered.

CLARITY: 14 → 16 ▲

They stood like that all night.

Lex didn't know how. He would never know how. His legs should have given out. His arms should have given out. But they didn't. He stood in the middle of the ruined tower floor with his brother in his arms and sang the Lantern Song until his voice was gone, and then kept singing it in a whisper, and then just kept *thinking* it, through the Bloodbond, over and over and over. And Seraphine sang from her bracken until she fell back into her fever. And Wren woke, and saw them, and didn't say anything at all. She just came and stood on Antho's other side and put her arms around both of them. And Ashka crept out from the wall and wound herself around their ankles, crooning.

The column of shadow wavered. Thinned. Sank.

CLARITY: 16 → 19 → 21 → 24

And when the grey light of dawn came through the broken roof of the tower, Antho's eyes were grey.

Mostly.



"IT'S NEVER BEEN THAT bad," Antho said later. His voice was a ruin. He was sitting by the rekindled fire with a blanket around his shoulders, shaking. "Not since the first year. Not since before the cave." He stared into the flames. "It was the lantern. Without it—" He stopped. "I didn't know how much it was doing. I didn't know how close it was."

"I'll make you another," said Lex.

Antho looked at him. "With what?"

Lex didn't answer.

"You tried," said Antho quietly. "I saw you. Two nights ago. With the bolt and the rock." He wasn't unkind. Just very tired. "It didn't work, Lex. It doesn't work without the fire. You know that."

"Then I'll get the fire back."

"How?"

Lex didn't have an answer for that either.

"Elric locked it with Root," said a voice from the bracken.

They both turned. Seraphine was awake again. Her face was still grey and her burns still raw, but her eyes were clear, and she'd found her spectacles somewhere, one lens cracked. She was looking at them both.

"Elric locked your class with Root," she said. Her voice was hoarse and thin but very precise. "Stolen Root, but Root. That's the deepest layer. The foundation. Nothing in the Lattice can touch it." She coughed, and winced. "Nothing in the Lattice can *unlock* it, either. No skill. No Prerogative. No item. Not even another Vey, I think, unless they have more Authority than the one who set the lock. And Elric took sixty-four points from your father."

"So it's permanent," said Lex flatly.

"I didn't say that." Seraphine pushed herself up on one elbow. It obviously hurt. She did it anyway. "I said nothing *in the Lattice* can unlock it."

Antho went very still.

"There was magic before the Lattice," said Seraphine. "The Barrow-King was a sorcerer-king before the Lattice. The Thorn Mother was bound before the Lattice. And the Founders themselves were Listeners. They used the old magic. The elemental magic. The magic that doesn't have classes or levels or panels." She looked at Lex. "Aurelian was a Listener. And a smith. That's how he made the Lattice. He *forged* it. With the old magic. With fire." She coughed again. "The Lattice is built on top of the old magic, Lex. Like a house built on a foundation. If Elric's locked the house, then you need to go *under* the house."

"How?" said Lex. "How do I go under it?"

"I don't know." Seraphine sank back onto the bracken. "Nobody knows. The Listeners died out nine hundred years ago. The Order hunted down the last of them. All their records were destroyed."

"*All* of them?" said Antho.

Seraphine closed her eyes. She was quiet for so long that Lex thought she'd fallen asleep again.

"Not all of them," she said at last. "There's a place. The Drowned Archive. Qel'Varran. It's in my footnotes. A Founders' library, older than the Leafbound Archive. It was half-sunk in a fen when the rivers changed course, six hundred years ago. The Order never found it. They didn't know

where to look." She opened her eyes. "Some of the commentaries say the Founders kept the Listeners' records there. The old ones. From before the Weaving. If there's anything left anywhere about magic without the Lattice—"

"Where?" said Lex.

"North," said Seraphine. "Two days, maybe three. In the Saltmere Fens." She smiled weakly. "I've always wanted to see it."



THEY LEFT THE TOWER the next morning.

Lex carried the front of Seraphine's litter. Antho carried the back. Wren went ahead, scouting, and Ashka glided overhead, and they walked north through rolling grey hills under a grey sky.

Antho's Clarity held at twenty-four. Barely. He didn't play the flute anymore; his lips were too cracked. But he walked. And when the voice in his head grew loud, and his eyes flickered black, Lex would set down his end of the litter and go back and put his hand on his brother's shoulder, and wait, and after a while Antho's eyes would come back grey, and they'd pick up the litter and go on.

On the second day, the hills gave way to flat land. Wet land. Reeds and sedge and black pools of still water, stretching away to the horizon under a sky the color of old pewter. The air smelled of salt and rot. Herons stood motionless in the shallows and rose on great slow wings as they passed. Mist lay on the water in long grey skeins.

"The Saltmere," said Seraphine from her litter. "The fens. The rivers come down out of the hills and spread out into the sea marshes here. Hundreds of square miles of it." She was quiet for a moment. "People drown here. Every year. The ground looks solid and isn't."

"Wonderful," said Wren.

They went carefully. Wren led, testing every step with a pole she'd cut from a willow. They went slowly, single file, through the reeds and along the edges of the black pools, following the faint, barely visible line of an ancient causeway that Seraphine said ran out into the fen from the hills. Stone, under the mud. Founders' stone. If you knew where to put your feet.

On the third day, at evening, they saw it.

A dome. Rising out of the reeds a mile ahead. Grey stone, green with moss and black with age, half-sunk in the fen so that only its upper half showed above the water, like the top of a skull rising out of a bog. There were windows in it, round ones, most of them broken. And at its very crown, carved into the stone, so worn that Lex could barely make it out, an open hand. And above the palm, a flame.

"*Qel'Varran*," whispered Seraphine.

Lex stood at the edge of the black water and looked at the half-drowned dome.

He thought about the Leafbound Archive, and the *Book of Making*, and the hammer drawn on its last page with four runes on its head. He thought about the Founders' smith who'd forged the Lattice with fire. The old magic. The magic under the house.

He looked down at his hand. At the burn scars. At the calluses.

You were already you before the numbers.

"Come on," he said. "Let's go and find out what's under the house."

CHAPTER 27

THE DROWNED ARCHIVE



THEY WENT IN THROUGH a window.

There was no door. Or if there was, it was somewhere far below the black water of the fen, under six hundred years of silt and reeds. The only way in was one of the round windows in the dome's flank, a broken one, its glass long gone, just above the waterline. Wren found it. She waded out along the edge of the dome waist-deep in the cold black water, testing every step with her pole, and came back with her lips blue and her eyes bright.

"There's a floor inside," she said, teeth chattering. "Under the window. Dry. Mostly."

They passed Seraphine through first, on her litter, Lex lifting her from the water and Wren pulling her through from inside. Then Antho, slowly, shaking. Then Ashka, who flew in through the window with a disgusted sneeze of sparks, having refused to get her feet wet. Then Lex, last, hauling himself up over the stone sill with Anvilson on his back.

He dropped down inside and stood up and looked around.

They were on a gallery. A narrow stone walkway running around the inside of the dome, high up, just below the windows. Below it, the dome fell away into darkness, and at the bottom of the darkness, far below, Lex could see the faint gleam of water. Still and black. Filling the lower part of the dome like water in a bowl.

And all around the walls, from the gallery down to the water and below it, there were shelves.

Stone shelves. Carved into the curved wall of the dome itself, ring after ring of them, spiraling down into the dark. And on the shelves, books. Thousands of them. Rotted and swollen and black with damp, most of them. Lumps of pulp that had once been books. But here and there, on the higher shelves, ones that had been warded, or cased, or simply lucky, were still whole.

"*Qel'Varran*," whispered Seraphine from her litter. Her voice was full of wonder and grief. "Oh. Oh, look at it. Look at all of it. Six hundred years underwater." She reached out a burned hand toward the nearest shelf, toward a black lump that might once have been a codex. "All that knowledge. Gone."

"Not all of it," said Antho quietly. He was standing at the edge of the gallery, looking down into the dark. "Something's down there. I can feel it."

DELVE ENTERED

THE DROWNED ARCHIVE

Floors: 3

Recommended level: 30 - 38

Wren and Antho saw the panel. Lex didn't.

He knew it was there. He could see their faces go still and unfocused as they read it. But nothing appeared at the edge of his own vision. No silver. No gold. Nothing. The Lattice didn't know he was in its Delve. The Lattice didn't know he was anywhere.

"Thirty to thirty-eight," said Wren. She looked at him. "I'm twenty-four. Capped. Antho's thirty-eight with his Clarity in the gutter. Seraphine can't walk." She paused. "And you're—"

"Nothing," said Lex. "I know."

"I wasn't going to say nothing."

"What were you going to say?"

Wren looked at him. At the hammer on his back. At his grey eyes.

"Stubborn," she said.



THE GALLERY SPIRALED DOWN.

It ran around the inside of the dome in a long slow corkscrew, between the shelves, down toward the black water at the bottom. They carried Seraphine's litter between them, Lex and Antho, and Wren went ahead with her bow, and Ashka glided in slow circles through the dark air of the dome, her scales giving off a faint blue glow that was the only light they had.

The first guardian came out of the shelves.

Lex didn't see it at first. It looked like a book. A big one, bound in black leather, sitting on a shelf at the edge of the gallery. And then it unfolded. It opened like a book opening, and kept opening, pages spreading out like wings, like fins, and inside it was not paper but *ink*. Black liquid ink, swirling, rising up out of the open pages in a column, taking shape.

Letters. It was made of letters. Thousands of them, black and wet and swirling, words and glyphs and fragments of Wellsript, all churning together into a shape like a man made of smoke. Its face was a blur of overlapping words. Its hands were long dripping strokes of a pen.

INKWRAITH – Level 33
Archive Guardian

"*Back*," said Wren. She loosed an arrow. It went straight through the Inkwraith and clattered against the shelf behind. The creature didn't even flicker. It turned its blur of a face toward her and reached out one dripping hand.

Where the hand passed through the air, the air went *blank*.

Lex saw it. A smear of nothing, like a word scraped off a page. And Wren, who had been nocking her second arrow, stopped. Frowned. Looked down at the arrow in her hand as if she'd never seen one before.

"What's this?" she said. Puzzled. "What—what do I—"

"*Wren!*"

The Inkwraith's hand was reaching for her face.

Antho threw his shadows at it.

He did it without thinking, the way he'd done it a thousand times. The shadows came up off him in a black wave and wrapped around the Inkwraith and *beld*, and the creature writhed in them, its swirl of letters churning. And Antho staggered, and his eyes went black at the edges, and

Lex felt it through the Bloodbond like a knife: the Clarity dropping, the voice surging.

CLARITY: 24 → 17 ▼▼

"Antho, stop! Let go!"

"If I let go, it takes her!"

Lex looked at the Inkwraith. At the swirling black letters. At the dripping strokes of its hands.

Ink, he thought. It's ink.

He knew ink. Not the way Seraphine knew it. Not the words. The *stuff*. Brannoc bought it every spring from the tinker who came through Ashbourne, for the Reeve's ledgers and the chapel's prayer-books, and Lex had watched the tinker make it in his cart. Oak galls crushed and soaked. Iron salts. Gum. Water.

Iron gall ink. With iron in it.

And what did every smith know about iron and water?

He didn't have Heat Shaping. He didn't have Ember Strike. He didn't have anything the Lattice had given him.

But he had a pack. And in the pack, wrapped in oilcloth, he had a flint and a steel, and a twist of dry tinder, and a little clay pot of lamp oil that Wren had bought in a village on the road north. Because he was a smith, and smiths always carry fire.

He knelt on the gallery floor. He struck the steel against the flint. Sparks. Ordinary orange sparks. They fell on the tinder. It smoldered. He blew on it, the way he'd blown on ten thousand forge-fires. It caught.

He poured the oil over a wad of rag from his pack, and lit the rag, and threw it.

It struck the Inkwraith full in its churning chest.

And the ink *boiled*.

Not burned. Ink doesn't burn well. But it boils. It boils and it dries and it cracks and it flakes, and the water goes out of it in a hiss of steam, and what's left is just a crust. A dry brown crust of iron salts and oak galls, crumbling.

The Inkwraith shrieked. A thin, papery, rustling shriek, like ten thousand pages being torn at once. It writhed in Antho's shadows. Steam

poured off it. Its swirl of letters went from black to brown to grey, and slowed, and stiffened, and *cracked*.

It fell apart. A shower of dry brown flakes pattering down onto the gallery floor like dead leaves.

Antho let go of the shadows. He sat down hard on the stone, gasping, his eyes flickering black and grey.

Wren blinked. She looked down at the arrow in her hand.

"Oh," she said. "Oh, right. That's an arrow." She looked up at Lex. Her face was white. "I forgot what an arrow *was*. For a second. I forgot."

"It eats words," said Seraphine faintly from her litter. "The Inkwraiths. It's in the commentaries. The Founders made them to guard the archives. They eat *meaning*. Anyone who isn't supposed to be here, they make them forget why." She was staring at the dry flakes on the floor. "How did you do that?"

Lex looked down at the flint and steel in his hand.

"It's fire," he said. "Just fire. Ordinary fire." He turned the steel over. "You don't need the Lattice to make fire. Smiths have been making fire since before there was a Lattice. Since before there was anything." He put the flint and steel back in his pack. "I forgot that. For a while."



THERE WERE MORE INKWRAITHS. Many more. They came out of the shelves as the gallery spiraled down, one at a time, then in twos and threes. Lex burned them all. Ordinary fire. Oil-soaked rags and burning torches made of shelf-wood and the last of the lamp oil.

It was slow. It was clumsy. It was nothing like an Ember Strike. Twice an Inkwraith got its dripping hand on him before he could burn it, and he lost things. The name of the inn in Saltreach where Garrick had told them he used to drink. The color of his mother's eyes. He'd find them again later, in pieces, the way you find dropped coins in grass. But in the moment, they were gone, and there was only a blank smear where they'd been.

But he burned them. One after another. A smith with a torch.

And he wasn't nothing.



AT THE BOTTOM OF the dome, the gallery ran out into the water.

It just stopped. The stone walkway went down into the black water and vanished, still spiraling, the shelves going down with it into the dark. The water was perfectly still. Perfectly black. It filled the whole bottom of the dome like ink in an inkwell.

"*Down there*," said Antho. He was standing at the edge, looking into the water. "Whatever I felt. It's down there."

"We can't go down there," said Wren. "It's water. We'd drown."

"Not all of it is water." Seraphine had pushed herself up on her litter. She was squinting through her cracked spectacles at the curved wall of the dome, where the shelves went down into the dark. "Look. There. Just below the surface."

Lex looked.

There was an arch. Set into the wall, below the gallery, just under the water. A round stone arch with Wellsript carved around it. And through the arch, faintly, so faintly he thought he might be imagining it, a glow.

Gold.

"Wards," said Seraphine. "Founders' wards. On the arch. They're old, but they're holding. They're keeping the water *out*." She looked at Lex. "There's a room behind that arch. A dry room. Under the water." She swallowed. "That's where they'd have kept the most important things."

Lex looked at the black water. At the faint gold glow beneath it.

"How far down?" he said.

"Ten feet," said Wren. She'd knelt at the edge and was peering into the water. "Maybe twelve. Then the arch. You'd have to swim down and through." She looked up at him. "In the dark. In the cold."

"I can swim."

"Can you swim twelve feet straight down in freezing black water and find an arch you can barely see and get through it before you run out of breath?"

Lex looked at her.

"Probably not," he said. "But I'm going to try."



IT WAS THE COLDEST thing he'd ever felt.

Colder than the Frostvault. Colder than the gloamhound's bite. The black water closed over his head and the cold went into him like a thousand needles, and for a moment he couldn't move, couldn't think, couldn't do anything but hang there in the dark with his heart hammering.

Then he kicked.

Down. Into the dark. Following the curve of the wall with one hand, the shelves going past under his fingers, slimy and cold. He couldn't see anything. He couldn't feel his feet. His lungs were burning. *Ten feet. Twelve.* The gold glow was there, ahead, faint, wavering. He kicked toward it.

His hand found stone. Carved stone. The arch.

He pulled himself through it.

And came up, gasping, into air.

He was in a room. Small. Round. Dry. The water ended at the arch behind him in a flat black wall, as if someone had sliced it off with a knife. The Founders' wards. Holding for six hundred years.

He crawled out onto a stone floor. Coughing. Shaking. Soaked. And looked up.

The room was lit. By a fire.

It was burning in the middle of the floor, in a small round hearth of white stone. A fire. Real fire. Orange and gold and red, dancing, crackling softly. And there was no wood in the hearth. No coal. No oil. No fuel at all. Just the fire, burning on the bare white stone, the way Seren's lamp burned on the rock above the Hollowmaw.

Except that Lex hadn't made this one.

Nobody had made this one. Not for six hundred years. Not for nine hundred.

He knelt beside it. He held out his hands, shaking with cold.

And the fire *leaned* toward him.

The way the forge-fire had leaned in Ashbourne, the evening Elric came. The way it had always leaned, his whole life, when he walked past the hearth. Toward him. Like a flower toward a window. Like a dog toward its master.

He went very still.

He hadn't called it. He *couldn't* call it. Elric had locked his class, locked his Root, locked everything. When he reached for the fire inside him, there was only a door, iron and gold and black, bolted shut.

But this wasn't the fire inside him. This was fire. Just fire. The fire that had been in the world since before the Lattice. Since before the Founders. Since before anything.

And it knew him.

He didn't know how he knew that. But he did. He knelt by the hearth with his hands held out and felt the warmth soak into his frozen fingers, and felt something else, too, very faint, like a whisper in a language he almost understood. Not words. Something under words. A sort of *recognition*. The feeling of being looked at by something very old and very patient that had been waiting a long time for someone to come and kneel by its hearth.

Who are you? he thought. Not in Root. Not in the language under language. Just thought it.

The fire crackled.

And, faint as a breath, something answered. Not a voice. A *feeling*. Warmth, and patience, and something almost like amusement. As if the fire had been asked a very simple question by a very small child.

I am Flame, it seemed to say. *Who are you*?**



HE DIDN'T KNOW HOW long he knelt there. Long enough for his clothes to start steaming. Long enough for the shaking to stop.

Then he looked around the room.

There were shelves on the walls here too. But these weren't carved from the stone. They were bronze. And on them, not books, but cases. Bronze cases, sealed, with Wellscript engraved on their lids. A dozen of them.

And on a low stone table beside the eternal fire, a single book.

It was small. Bound in something that wasn't leather, something grey and supple like the skin of a seal. There was no title on its cover. Only a symbol. Not the open hand and the flame. Something else.

Six circles, arranged in a ring. And in the center of the ring, a seventh, empty.

He picked it up.



HE BROUGHT IT BACK up through the black water wrapped in oilcloth, and two of the bronze cases with it, tied to his back with Wren's climbing rope, which she'd thrown down to him. It took three trips. On the last one, he nearly didn't make it; his legs cramped in the cold and he sank, and the dark closed over him, and he thought very clearly *this is a stupid way to die*. And then something grabbed him by the collar and hauled him up, and he broke the surface choking, and it was Antho, soaked to the neck, his eyes black-and-grey and furious.

"*You idiot*," his brother said. "*You stupid, stupid—*"

"I know."

"*I can't lose you too. Do you understand? I can't. Not you too.*"

"I know, Antho." Lex coughed up black water. "I know."

Antho dragged him out onto the gallery and held onto him, shaking, and didn't let go for a long time.



SERAPHINE READ THE BOOK that night.

They'd made a camp on the gallery, high up, near the broken window, with a fire Lex had built from shelf-wood and lit with flint and steel. Seraphine sat propped against the wall with the grey book open on her knees and her cracked spectacles on her nose, and read by the firelight. Her lips moved. Her burned fingers turned the pages, slowly, carefully, as if afraid they'd crumble. They didn't. Whatever the book was made of, it had lasted nine hundred years without a mark.

The others waited.

It was a long time before she looked up. When she did, her face was very strange.

"It's the Listeners' Codex," she said. "The real one. The one the Order spent three hundred years trying to destroy." She touched the page. "It's not about the Lattice at all. It was written *before* the Lattice. By the last of the Listeners, the ones who refused to take part in the Weaving." She swallowed. "It's about the Wells."

"The Wells?" said Wren.

"The six sources of power. The old magic. The magic under the house." Seraphine turned the book so they could see the symbol on the first page: six circles in a ring. "Flame. Stone. Tide. Gale. Radiance. Shade." She touched each circle in turn. "The Listeners didn't have classes or levels. They *listened* to the Wells. Learned to hear them. And the Wells answered." She looked at Lex. "Like the fire. In the room under the water. Did it—"

"It leaned toward me," said Lex. "It knew me." He swallowed. "I asked who it was. And it said *I am Flame*. Not in words. But it said it."

Seraphine stared at him.

"You heard it," she whispered. "With your class locked. With your Root suppressed. You *heard* the Well."

"Is that—is that what it was?"

"That's what the Codex says. *The first stage of Listening is to hear. The second is to be heard. The third is to speak. The fourth is to command. The fifth is to become.*" She turned a page. "And it says—" She stopped. Read it again. "It says the Wells aren't part of the Lattice. They're *under* it. The Lattice draws on them, the way a mill-wheel draws on a river. But the river doesn't belong to the wheel." She looked up. "Elric locked the wheel, Lex. He didn't lock the river."

Nobody said anything for a long moment.

"Can you learn it?" said Antho quietly. "Listening. From the book?"

Seraphine shook her head slowly.

"No. Not from a book. The Codex says so. Over and over. *Listening cannot be learned from words. It must be learned from one who listens.*" She turned to the last page. "And then it says this." She read it aloud, her voice very soft. "*When the net is woven and the Wells are bound beneath it, and the last of us is hunted, let one remain. Let the youngest of the Listeners, who would not take the net, go into the white waste, to the Stillwater, and keep the old fire burning. And let any who would learn to listen, after the Weaving, seek him there.*"

"Him," said Wren.

"There's a name," said Seraphine. She traced the line of old script with one burned finger. "*Malachi.*"

The fire crackled.

"Nine hundred years ago," said Antho slowly. "The youngest of the Listeners. Nine hundred years."

"I know."

"He'd be dead. He'd have to be dead."

"The Barrow-King wasn't dead," said Wren. "Not exactly. The Thorn Mother wasn't. The Oracle wasn't." She looked at the fire. "Nothing in this whole stupid business has been as dead as it ought to be."

Seraphine was still looking at the page. Her face had gone very still.

"There's more," she said quietly. "A note. In the margin. Different hand. Much later. Faded." She squinted through her cracked lens. "It says—" She stopped.

"What?" said Lex.

Seraphine looked up at him. Then at Antho.

"It says, *Malachi, brother of Aurelian, who said to him on the night of the Weaving: you do not cage a storm by becoming the bars.*"



ANTHO FOUND THE OTHER thing, later, in one of the bronze cases.

He'd opened it while the others slept. Lex woke in the grey hour before dawn and saw his brother sitting by the fire with the case open on his knees and a sheet of thin bronze foil in his hands, covered in tiny engraved Wellschrift. He was staring at it.

"What is it?" said Lex quietly.

Antho didn't look up.

"It's about the Hollow," he said. "And the thing in it. The hunger." His voice was very flat. "The Listeners wrote about it. Before the Weaving. When it first woke, in the Sundering." He turned the foil over. "They didn't call it *the hunger*. They had another name for it."

"What?"

Antho was silent for a long moment.

"*The Unmaker*," he said.

The fire crackled. Ashka stirred in her sleep, and crooned, and settled.

"It says it doesn't want to eat things," said Antho. "Not really. Not the way animals eat. It says it wants to *unmake* them. To take them back to before they were. Before they had names. Before they had shapes." His

hands were shaking slightly. "That's why the Gloamed go quiet. That's why the Inkwraiths eat words. That's why Morvane wants everyone to be silent." He looked up at Lex. His eyes were grey, but very dark. "It wants everything to go back to nothing. To before. To the quiet before the first word."

Lex didn't say anything.

"And there's a thing at the bottom," said Antho. "A note. Like the one in the Codex. Different hand." He held the foil up to the firelight. *"It cannot be killed. It can only be held. And whoever holds it, it will try to become."*

He lowered the foil.

"Whoever holds it, it will try to become," he repeated quietly. "That's what's been happening to me. For eight years. That's what happened to Morvane." He looked into the fire. "That's what the Lattice has been doing. For nine hundred years. Holding it."

He put the foil back in the bronze case, very carefully, and closed the lid.

"I wonder what it's been trying to become," he said.



THEY LEFT QEL'VARRAN THE next morning.

Lex carried the grey Codex wrapped in oilcloth against his chest. Seraphine had made him promise not to let it get wet. Antho carried the bronze case. And as they waded back out through the black water toward the edge of the fen, Lex turned and looked back at the half-drowned dome one last time.

Deep under the water, in a dry round room behind a warded arch, a fire was burning on bare white stone. As it had for nine hundred years. As it would, he thought, for nine hundred more.

He couldn't feel it from here. He reached for it, the way he'd reached for it in the room, and found nothing but cold.

But he remembered the way it had leaned toward him.

I am Flame. Who are you?

"The Pale Wastes," said Seraphine from her litter, behind him. She had the old map open on her knees. Her finger was resting on a great blank

space far to the north and east, beyond the fens, beyond the hills, marked only with a few faint lines and a single word in old script. "The white waste. Three weeks. Maybe more. Across nothing."

"Is there water?" said Wren.

"The Codex says there's a place called the Stillwater. In the middle." Seraphine paused. "It doesn't say anything about water between here and there."

"Wonderful," said Wren.

Lex turned his face north.

He didn't have a class. He didn't have his fire. He didn't have Ember. He had a hammer, and a book he couldn't read, and a flint and a steel, and three people and a dragon who were still, impossibly, following him.

And somewhere out in the white waste, if a nine-hundred-year-old margin note could be believed, there was a man who knew how to listen.

"Then let's go and find out," he said.

INTERLUDE

THE SECOND MAN



DUSKHOLD DID NOT HAVE doors.

Elric Thorne had noticed that on his first night there, and he noticed it again every night after. The fortress had corridors, and halls, and stairs, and great vaulted chambers with ceilings lost in darkness. It had windows, narrow slits in walls of black glassy stone that looked out over the grey country. It had a throne room, and a great hall, and a chasm at its heart.

But it had no doors. Nothing could be closed. Nothing could be shut. Every room opened into every other room, and every corridor ran into every other corridor, and everywhere, in every one of them, the Quiet stood.

They lined the walls. Hundreds of them. Thousands, perhaps. Men and women and children, grey-skinned, white-eyed, standing perfectly still in rows along every corridor and around the edges of every hall, their hands at their sides, their faces blank. They didn't move. They didn't speak. They didn't blink. When Elric walked past them, their white eyes didn't follow him. They simply stood, the way the statues in the Oracle's gorge had stood, waiting.

And it was silent. That was the worst of it. Duskhold was utterly, perfectly silent. No wind. No echo. Even Elric's own footsteps on the black stone floor made no sound, as if the fortress swallowed them. He'd tried, the first night, to hum to himself. Something. Anything. An old marching song from the eastern march. The sound had come out of his mouth and simply stopped, an inch from his lips, as if it had walked into a wall.

He didn't try again.



HE WALKED TO THE chasm every evening.

It was in the center of the fortress. A great round hall, the largest in Duskhold, open to the grey sky at the top. And in the middle of its floor, the floor simply ended. A pit. Not round. Ragged. Torn. Like a wound in the earth that had never healed. Black, utterly black, so black that the eye slid off it. Cold air rose out of it in slow invisible waves. And the smell, wet ash and rot and nothing, so thick here that it coated the inside of Elric's mouth like oil.

The Vhessa breach. The first. The worst. Sixteen years old.

Morvane had built his fortress around it, the way a pearl is built around a grain of sand.

And on the edge of the pit, on a great black plinth that had grown up out of the floor like a fungus, stood the crystal.

Elric stopped at the edge of the hall and looked at it.

It wasn't clear anymore. Not entirely. Black veins ran through its faceted walls now, branching, spreading, like cracks through ice. Like the veins under Morvane's white skin. They were thicker every evening. Every evening, a little more of the crystal had gone dark.

And inside it, half out of it, frozen, Arion.

His head and one shoulder and one arm were outside the crystal, as they had been when the Hollow-knights lifted it off the cellar floor at Caldris. Reaching. His face was grey and still. His eyes were open, fixed, staring at nothing. The rest of him was still inside, upright, his other arm at his side, his long dark coat hanging straight.

Elric walked toward him.

He did it every evening. He didn't know why. He told himself it was to watch Morvane's progress. To see how far the black veins had spread. To know how long it would be before the graft was complete and the net ran through Morvane and Morvane kept his promise.

He stood at the foot of the black plinth and looked up at his oldest friend's frozen face.

Arion's eyes were looking at him.

Elric's heart stopped.

They hadn't been. They'd been fixed on nothing, staring past him. He was sure of it. Every evening for three weeks, he'd stood here, and Arion's eyes had stared at nothing.

Now they were looking at him.

Grey. Unblinking. Still. But *looking*.

"Arion?" Elric whispered.

The sound stopped an inch from his lips. Duskhold swallowed it.

But the grey eyes moved. Just slightly. Just a fraction. Focused. On his face.

And somewhere, faint as frost forming on glass, faint as a voice heard through a wall, not in the air but in the place under the air, where the Root was, where the stolen gold still burned in Elric's chest like a coal swallowed whole, something spoke.

Was it worth it, old friend?

Elric stood very still at the foot of the plinth.

He opened his mouth. Nothing came out. Duskhold took it.

So he answered the way Arion had asked. In the place under the air. With the stolen gold.

Not yet, he thought.

The grey eyes held his for a long moment.

Then they slid away again. Back to nothing. And the crystal was only a crystal, black-veined, with a frozen man in it.

Elric stood there until his legs ached. Then he turned and walked out of the hall, past the silent rows of the Quiet, into the corridors without doors.



HE'D BEEN EIGHTEEN WHEN he met Arion Vey.

He thought about it a great deal, in Duskhold. There was nothing else to do. No books. No conversation. No sound. Just walking the silent corridors, and standing at the edge of the chasm, and remembering.

Eighteen. A first-year novice at the Spire, Kindled two years before as a [Stormcaller], Epic grade, the best class anyone in his village had ever received. He'd been proud. So proud. A blacksmith's son from a fishing

town on the Saltreach coast, who'd put his hand on a cracked village Stone and seen *Epic* unroll in silver, and wept with joy in front of everyone.

He'd come to the Spire thinking he was the most gifted novice in a generation.

And then, in his second month, a boy had arrived from nowhere. A thin quiet boy with a forgettable face. And on his first day, the boy had walked into the great chamber at the top of the Spire to be presented to the Great Stone, and laid his hand on it the way every novice did. And the Great Stone had lit up like a bonfire. Every Warden in the building had felt it. Elric had been in the refectory, eating porridge, and his spoon had fallen out of his hand.

Arion had been nineteen. He'd looked nineteen for the next forty years.

They'd become friends. Elric had never been entirely sure how. Arion was quiet and clever and strange and didn't seem to want friends. But he'd sat down next to Elric in the refectory the next morning, the morning after the bonfire, and said *I'm told you're the best novice in the Spire, and I'd like you to teach me the Circles, because nobody else will tell me anything*. And Elric, who was eighteen and proud and furious and jealous, had looked at him and said *Why should I?* And Arion had said, with perfect simplicity, *Because I think you'd be good at it*.

He had been good at it.

He'd taught Arion the Circles, over a month. And on the last day, Arion had looked at the seven nested rings of light spinning over his own palm and said *Oh, I see, it's like folding steel*, and done it perfectly. And Elric had smiled, and clapped him on the shoulder, and said *well done*.

And gone back to his cell that night and lain awake until dawn.

That was the first time.



THERE HAD BEEN SO many times.

Arion making Adept two years before Elric. Arion making Master four years before. Arion being given Root access to the Great Stone, by blood, by right, on the day he turned twenty-five, when Elric had applied for the same access three times and been refused. Arion being named Warden-Architect at thirty, the youngest in the Order's history.

Arion finding the forbidden records. Arion going east. Arion coming back with a face like a grave. Arion meeting a freckled hedge-witch with flour on her cheek in a market square in Saltreach, and falling in love in an afternoon, and walking away from the Spire and everything in it to marry her, as if it were nothing. As if none of it had ever mattered.

And through all of it, Elric beside him. Teaching him. Helping him. Covering for him. Riding with him into the eastern march. Standing on the walls at Varrow Ford with lightning in his hands while Arion worked his impossible Root-magic in the river below. Earning the title *Tempest of Varrow Ford*, which was the only thing anyone ever remembered him for, and which he'd only earned because Arion needed someone to hold the walls while he saved the day.

Always beside. Always second. Always *well done*.

And Arion had never aged.

That was the thing Elric couldn't forgive. Not the Root. Not the gifts. Not the effortless first-try brilliance. He could have forgiven all of that. He *had* forgiven all of that, every day, for forty years, the way you forgive a storm for raining.

But Arion had never aged. And Elric had.

Every year, Elric had looked in the mirror and seen a little more grey. A few more lines. A little less strength in his arms, a little less sharpness in his eyes. And every year, Arion had looked exactly the same. Thirty. Thirty-five, maybe, by the end. Silver at the temples, a few faint lines around the eyes. A man in his prime. Forever.

The Root doesn't let you age, Arion had told him once, almost apologetically, when Elric finally asked. *Not the way the rest of you do. I don't know why. It's in the blood.*

The rest of you.

Elric had spent forty years beside a man who would never grow old. He'd poured his youth into helping that man become what he was. And at the end of it, he'd be a bent, toothless, half-blind old wreck in a chair by a fire somewhere, and Arion would come to visit him, still thirty-five, still brilliant, still kind, and pat his hand and say *well done, old friend*.

He'd asked for Sanction eleven years ago. Tier Four. Warden-Architect. Not because he needed it. Because it was the only thing left. The only thing

that might, maybe, let him stand beside Arion as an equal for once. Just once. Before the end.

And Arion had written back: *Not yet. Not because you aren't strong enough. Because you want it too much.*

Elric had read that letter in a rented room in Saltreach, by the light of a single candle, and something inside him had broken. Quietly. Like a bone breaking in sleep.

He'd gone to the Spire the next week and stolen the High Warden's passkey.

He hadn't known why. Not then. He'd only known that he needed to have something. Something that was his. Something Arion didn't know about.



MORVANE HAD FOUND HIM three years later.

Or he'd found Morvane. He was never quite sure which. He'd been on the eastern border, alone, looking for Arion, following some rumor. And he'd camped one night at the edge of the grey country. And in the morning, there had been a man standing at the edge of his camp. Tall and thin and white, in a long white coat.

Elric Thorne, Morvane had said. Softly. Reasonably. *Arion's friend. I remember you. From the eastern march. From Varrow Ford.*

He'd had a cup of tea with him. That was the absurd thing. They'd sat by Elric's campfire on the edge of the Blightmarch and drunk tea, and Morvane had talked. About order. About peace. About quiet. About the terrible noise of the world, all the wanting and hating and grieving and *grasping*, and how much better it would be if it simply stopped.

And then he'd said: *I know what Arion did to you. I know what he denied you. And: I could give it to you. When I hold the net. Whatever you want.*

Elric had told him to go to the Lady's own hell.

Morvane had smiled and gone.

But a year later, Elric had sent a raven east. Just a small thing. Just a rumor he'd heard, about a Warden patrol, about where they'd be. He'd told himself it was a test. To see if Morvane could be trusted. To find out

what Morvane knew about Arion. He'd been gathering intelligence. That was all.

And a raven had come back, with information about breaches that Elric couldn't have gotten anywhere else. Useful information. Information that might help him find Arion.

So he'd sent another.

And another.

Eight years of ravens. Small things. Always small things. Never anything that mattered. Never anything that would really hurt anyone. He'd told himself that every time. *I'm using him. Not the other way around.*

Until the night on the causeway in the Drowned Barrows, when he'd stood with Quill on his wrist and written *the waters that hold the sky*, and known, even as he tied the paper to the raven's leg, that it was not a small thing. That it was the biggest thing he'd ever done.

And Lex had seen him do it.

And he'd lied.



"YOU'RE THINKING ABOUT HIM again."

Morvane's voice. Soft. Pleasant. It was the only voice in Duskhold that made a sound. As if the fortress allowed its master to speak and no one else.

Elric turned. He was standing at one of the narrow window-slits in a corridor high in the fortress, looking out over the grey country. He hadn't heard Morvane come up behind him. Nobody ever heard Morvane come.

The white figure stood a few paces away. His long white coat. His long white hair. His face like porcelain, the black veins running under the skin. Fainter than they'd been before Avaloria. But spreading again. Every day a little thicker.

"Arion," said Morvane. "You're thinking about Arion. You always have that look."

Elric didn't answer. He couldn't. Duskhold wouldn't let him.

Morvane smiled. He lifted one white hand, a small gesture, and something in the air around Elric loosened. Like a hand being taken off his mouth.

"There," said Morvane. "You may speak. For a little while."

"How long?" said Elric. His voice sounded strange. Rusty. He hadn't heard it in days. "Until the graft is done?"

"Two months. Perhaps less." Morvane came and stood beside him at the window. "The crystal is resisting. Arion is stubborn, even in stasis. Even with nothing left. He's holding on to the knot with his bare hands." He shook his head, almost admiringly. "He always was the most stubborn man I ever knew."

"And then you hold the net."

"And then I hold the net. And then I rewrite it." Morvane's white eyes looked out over the grey country, toward the west, toward the green. "Every thread. Every knot. Every life. All of them running through me. One will. One voice." He smiled. "One quiet."

"And my Sanction," said Elric. "My Tier. What you promised."

Morvane turned his head and looked at him. For a long moment, he didn't say anything at all.

"Elric," he said gently. "Don't you understand yet?"

Elric's skin went cold.

"When the net runs through me," said Morvane, "there won't *be* Sanctions. There won't be Tiers. There won't be levels or classes or Ceilings. There won't be anything to want." He spread his white hands. "That's the gift. That's the whole gift. Not to *have* what you want. To stop *wanting* it."

"You promised me Warden-Architect."

"And you'll have it. You'll have everything. You'll have Root, and Authority, and Tier Four, and all the power you ever dreamed of." Morvane's voice was very soft and very kind. "And you won't care. Because you'll be quiet. Like them." He nodded at the corridor behind them. At the rows of grey white-eyed figures standing silent along the walls. "Isn't that what you really want, Elric? Isn't that what you've wanted for forty years? Not the Sanction. Not the Root. To stop *hurting*. To stop standing beside him and feeling it. To stop *wanting*."

Elric stared at him.

He thought about the mirror on the silver road. The young man on the white throne, crowned with gold, smiling. Alone. In an empty room.

"No," he whispered.

"Yes," said Morvane. "You'll see. When it's done, you'll see. You'll thank me." He put one white hand on Elric's shoulder. It was very cold. "You'll be at peace, old friend. At last."

He turned and walked away down the corridor without doors, between the silent rows of the Quiet. And as he went, the air around Elric tightened again, like a hand closing over his mouth, and the silence came back.



ELRIC STOOD AT THE window for a long time.

Then he went to the small bare room that Morvane had given him, high in a tower, and sat down on the hard narrow bed, and took out a piece of paper and a pencil.

Quill was on the windowsill. The raven had been very quiet since Caldris. He didn't speak. He didn't croak. He just sat on the sill and looked at Elric with his black bright eyes.

Elric wrote.

He didn't know who he was writing to. He wrote *A.* at the top, and then stopped, and crossed it out, and wrote *L.*, and stopped, and crossed that out too. Then he just wrote.

I'm sorry.

He looked at it.

He wrote it again. *I'm sorry.* And again. And again. Down the whole page. *I'm sorry. I'm sorry. I'm sorry. I'm sorry.* His hand shook. The pencil tore through the paper in places. He kept writing.

When the page was full, he stopped. He sat looking at it for a long time.

Then he held it in the candle flame until it burned. And dropped the ashes in the cup of water by the bed. And stirred them with his finger until they were gone.



LATER, MUCH LATER, IN the darkest hour of the silent night, Elric Thorne reached inside himself, into the place where the stolen gold burned like a swallowed coal.

Sixty-four points of Authority. Arion's Authority. Torn out of him at the moment of waking, through the black graft-glyph Morvane had inked on Elric's palm.

Morvane thought he had it all. Morvane had asked for it, on the first night in Duskhold. *Give it to me, old friend. I'll keep it safe. I'll use it for the graft.* And Elric had given it. Had stood at the edge of the chasm with his marked palm on the black plinth and let the gold flow out of him into the crystal, into the black veins, into Morvane's working.

Most of it.

Not all.

He'd kept back a shard. A sliver. Nine points. Hidden down deep, under the rest, the way Arion had once hidden a sliver of himself in a little boy's seal. He hadn't decided to do it. His hand had simply... held on. The way a drowning man's hand holds on to a piece of driftwood.

He held it now. In the dark. Nine points of gold, warm in the cold silence of Duskhold.

It wasn't much. It wasn't enough for anything. Not enough to free Arion. Not enough to stop Morvane. Not enough to undo what he'd done.

But it was his.

And as long as he held it, some small, stubborn, unquiet part of him couldn't be made silent.



ON THE WINDOWSILL, QUILL shifted his feet and ruffled his feathers.

And from very far away, so faint that Elric thought at first he'd imagined it, a World Notice unfolded across the inside of his eyes. Silver. Plain. The kind of thing the Lattice only said once in a generation.

But not this kind. This was smaller. A private notice. The kind that went only to those with Root.

ROOT SIGNATURE DETECTED

Location: SALTMERE FENS (approx.)

Signature: VEY (locked)

Status: -LISTENING-

Elric sat up on the narrow bed.

Listening.

Not the Lattice. Not the Root. Something else. Something he'd only ever read about in footnotes.

He stared at the word for a long time.

Then, slowly, impossibly, in the silent dark of Duskhold, where no sound was permitted and no hope was allowed, Elric Thorne began to smile.

"He'll find a way," he whispered. The words died an inch from his lips. He didn't care. *"He'll find a way. They always do. His father always did."*

He lay back down on the hard narrow bed and closed his eyes and held his nine stolen points of gold, and for the first time since Caldriis, he slept.

CHAPTER 28

A RAY OF LIGHT



THE PALE WASTES WERE white.

Not snow-white. Not cloud-white. A dead, flat, glaring white that went on in every direction to the edge of the world and stopped there, and the sky above it was so pale it was almost white too, so that on the worst days there was no horizon at all. Only white below and white above and the four of them walking through the middle of it like ants across a sheet of paper.

Salt. All of it. A great dry lakebed of salt, Seraphine said, from some sea that had dried up long before the Sundering. Crusted and cracked into a million hexagons, like the floor of a giant's kitchen. It crunched under their boots. It got into everything: their clothes, their packs, their hair, the corners of their eyes. It cracked their lips. It burned their skin by day and froze it by night, because the Pale Wastes were bitterly hot when the sun was up and bitterly cold when it went down, and there was nothing in between.

There was no water.

They'd filled every skin and bottle they had at the last stream on the edge of the fens. Wren had made them drink until they were sick. It lasted nine days. On the tenth day, Wren started rationing. On the twelfth, she stopped drinking her own share and started giving it to Seraphine when she thought no one was looking. On the fourteenth, Lex noticed, and started giving his to Wren, and Wren noticed, and they had a furious whispered argument in the middle of the white nothing while Antho and Seraphine pretended not to hear.

On the fifteenth day, the water ran out.



ASHKA FOUND THE SPRING.

She'd been ranging out ahead of them every morning, high and wide, gliding on the hot air rising off the salt, her storm-blue scales glittering against the white sky. She was bigger now. Much bigger. The size of a pony, almost, though still lean and light and long-limbed. The lightning in the storm on the northern moor had done something to her that hadn't stopped; she grew a little every week. Her silver wing-frame had stretched and stretched, the runes Lex had struck into it letting it grow with her, and the torn membrane inside it had almost healed.

On the morning of the sixteenth day, she came back from the east screaming.

Not a frightened scream. An excited one. She swooped down out of the white sky and landed in front of Antho in a spray of salt crystals, and pushed her long narrow head against his chest, and sent him pictures so bright and so loud that Lex felt them through the Bloodbond like a shout.

Water. Water. Little water. Under the white. Smells wet. Come. COME.

It was barely a spring. A crack in the salt crust, four miles east, with a little seep of brackish water pooling at the bottom, so salty it made Lex's eyes water to drink it. But it was water. They lay on their bellies around it and drank in turns, slowly, a mouthful at a time, the way Wren told them to. And then they filled the skins, a little at a time, as the seep refilled, and it took all day.

"Two more days," said Wren that night. She was sitting by their tiny fire of dried salt-brush, looking at the skins. "Maybe three. If we're careful."

"How far to the Stillwater?" said Antho.

Seraphine had the old map open on her knees. She'd been studying it every night by firelight, squinting through her cracked spectacles. Her burns had begun to heal, slowly, leaving shiny pink scars down the left side of her face and neck. She could walk now, with a stick, limping.

"I don't know," she said quietly. "The map says *the Stillwater lies at the heart of the white waste*. That's all. It doesn't say where the heart is." She looked up. "We could be a day away. We could be a month."

Nobody said anything.



LEX HEARD THE HUM on the seventeenth day.

He didn't know what it was at first. He thought it was his own blood, ringing in his ears from the heat and the thirst. They'd been walking since dawn, and the sun was a white hammer on the white anvil of the salt, and his head was pounding.

Then he realized it wasn't in his ears. It was in his *feet*.

He stopped walking.

"Lex?" Wren turned. Her face was burned red and peeling, her lips cracked and bloody. "What is it?"

"Shh."

He stood very still on the cracked white salt. He closed his eyes.

It was there. Faint. So faint. Coming up through the soles of his boots, through the salt crust, from somewhere deep below. A hum. A vibration. Like the hum he used to feel in iron when he was hammering it, the hum that told him where the slag pockets were. Like the hum of the fire in the room under the water at Qel'Varran.

Not the same. Different. Lower. Slower. *Heavier*.

Stone, he thought, and didn't know why he thought it.

He knelt. He laid his palm flat on the salt.

The hum got louder.

It wasn't coming from directly below. It was coming from his left. Northeast. It was stronger in that direction, like a sound you can hear better if you turn your head. And under it, faint, very faint, something else. A different note. Higher. Cooler. *Moving*. Like a stream running underground.

Water.

He opened his eyes. Wren was crouched beside him, staring at him.

"What is it?" she said. "What are you doing?"

"I can hear it," said Lex. His voice was hoarse. "The ground. Under the salt. There's rock down there. And it's—*humming*. And under the rock, there's something moving." He swallowed. "Water. There's water. That way."

He pointed northeast.

Wren looked at where he was pointing. At the flat dead white, going on to the edge of the world. Then back at him.

"You can *hear* it," she said slowly.

"I can hear it."

"Your class is locked. Your Root's locked. You can't do anything. You said so."

"I know." He looked down at his palm, flat on the salt. "This isn't the class. It's like the fire. In the room under the water. It's not the Lattice." He looked up at her. "It's *under* it."

Wren stared at him for a long moment.

Then she stood up, and shouldered her pack, and turned northeast.

"Then let's go," she said.



THEY WALKED NORTHEAST FOR a day and a night and half of another day.

Lex walked in front now. Every hour, he'd stop, and kneel, and lay his palm on the salt, and close his eyes, and listen. And every hour, the hum was a little louder. A little clearer. The heavy slow note of the stone, and the cool moving note of the water under it, and something else, something he couldn't name, a third note, warmer, steadier, like a fire burning in a hearth very far away.

He didn't know what he was doing. He just did it. The way he'd known which way to turn his wrist over a flawed horseshoe, on the morning Elric came. The way his hand found the hammer in the dark.

On the morning of the nineteenth day, the water ran out again.

On the evening of the nineteenth day, Seraphine fell and didn't get up.

She just went down, quietly, in the middle of the white salt, her stick clattering away from her. Antho was beside her in an instant. He knelt and

gathered her up and held her, and her face was grey under the shiny pink scars, and her lips were cracked and white.

"I'm fine," she whispered. "I'm fine. I just need—a minute—"

"You're not fine." Antho's voice was raw. "*Sera*, you're not fine."

"I'm *clinical*," said Seraphine faintly, and tried to smile.

Antho made a sound that wasn't a laugh.

CLARITY: 26 → 19 ▼



— stirring

Lex saw the black creeping into the edges of his brother's eyes. Saw the shadows beginning to rise off him, slow, curling, out of control.

"*Antho*." He went and knelt beside them. "*Antho, look at me.*"

"*She's dying, Lex.*"

"She's not dying. She's thirsty. We're all thirsty." Lex put his hand on his brother's shoulder. "The water's close. I can hear it. It's close."

"*How close?*"

Lex didn't answer. He didn't know. The hum was loud now, louder than it had ever been, but he didn't know how far it was. A mile. Ten. A hundred.

He knelt on the salt and laid both his palms flat on it, and closed his eyes, and *listened*.

Please, he thought. Not in Root. Not in words. *Please. Where are you? Help us. Please.*

And something answered.

Not the stone. Not the water. The third note. The warm one. The fire in the hearth very far away.

It got *louder*.

It came toward him. Through the stone, through the salt, through the cold dry air of the evening, like the warmth of a hearth when someone opens the door. And it wasn't coming from underground. It was coming from *in front* of him. From the east. From a little way off across the flat white salt.

He opened his eyes.

And there was a man walking toward them out of the sunset.



HE WAS SMALL.

That was the first thing Lex noticed. Very small, smaller than Seraphine, shorter even than Wren. Brown and wrinkled as a walnut, with a bald brown head and a wispy white beard that came down to his waist. He was barefoot on the salt. He wore a robe of undyed wool, very old, patched and darned a hundred times, belted at the waist with a length of rope. He carried a long staff of pale wood, gnarled and smooth with handling, and over one shoulder he had slung a goatskin bag that sloshed when he walked.

And he was laughing.

Not loudly. Softly, to himself, as he came across the white salt toward them. As if something had just occurred to him that was very funny, and he was enjoying it privately.

Ashka saw him and went absolutely still. Then she did something Lex had never seen her do for anyone but Antho. She lowered her long blue head to the salt, and spread her wings flat on either side of her, and *bowed*.

The little man stopped in front of her. He looked down at her with his head tilted on one side.

"Well, well," he said. His voice was high and cracked and very cheerful, like an old door hinge that someone had oiled. "A storm-drake. Haven't seen one of you in a very long time. Two hundred years? Three?" He reached out one gnarled brown hand and touched the top of her head, very gently. Ashka shivered all over and made a sound like a purring cat the size of a horse. "Hello, little sister. You've been hurt. Someone mended you. Someone with good hands." He looked at the silver frame on her wing, and his eyebrows went up. "*Very* good hands."

He turned and looked at the four of them.

At Lex, kneeling on the salt with his palms flat. At Wren, standing beside him with her bow half-raised and her face wary. At Antho, crouched with Seraphine in his arms, his eyes flickering black.

His gaze lingered on Antho for a long moment. Something in his wrinkled face went very still and very serious. Then it moved on, to Seraphine, and softened.

"Thirsty," he said. "Very thirsty. Silly children, walking out into the white with no water. Didn't anyone tell you there's no water in the white?" He unslung the goatskin bag from his shoulder and tossed it to Wren, who caught it out of the air by reflex. "Drink. Slowly. Give the sick one the first of it."

Wren stared at the bag in her hands. It was heavy. Full. It sloshed.

"Who are you?" she said.

The little man looked at her. Then at Lex. And his eyes, Lex saw, were the strangest eyes he'd ever seen. Not grey, not brown, not any one color. They seemed to change, as he looked at you. Brown like earth, then blue like water, then gold like fire, then grey like a storm. Shifting. Never still.

"I'm the one you've been looking for," he said. "Or one of them, anyway. I expect you've been looking for a lot of people." He grinned. Half his teeth were missing. "I'm Malachi."



LEX USED TRUE SIGHT without thinking. He couldn't, of course. His Root was locked. He reached for it out of habit and found only the iron door.

But Wren could Inspect. Every Lattice-bound person could Inspect, a little, the ordinary way. And Lex saw her eyes go unfocused as she looked at the little man, and then saw her face change.

"There's nothing," she said slowly. "There's no panel. There's nothing there."

Antho had looked too. His black-grey eyes were very wide.

"It says *no record*," he whispered. "The Lattice doesn't—it doesn't *know* him."

"Of course it doesn't." Malachi sat down cross-legged on the salt, as if he'd decided they were going to be there a while. "I never let it. I was there when it was made, you know. When my brother wove it. I stood beside him on the night of the Weaving and watched him do it." He shrugged. "I told him I didn't want to be in it. He was cross, but he respected it. He made a little hole in the net, just my size, and let me stay outside." He grinned again. "Very kind of him. He wasn't usually kind."

"Your *brother*," said Seraphine faintly, from Antho's arms. She'd taken a mouthful of water from the goatskin and was looking at the little man over the rim of it with her cracked spectacles askew. "*Malachi, brother of Aurelian.*"

"That's what they call me in the margins, is it?" Malachi looked delighted. "*Brother of Aurelian.* As if that's the most important thing about me." He shook his head. "He was the oldest. I was the youngest. There were five of us in between. He was always the clever one. I was always the one who laughed too much." He was quiet for a moment, and the laughter went out of his strange shifting eyes. "I miss him. Even now. Even after everything."

Lex stared at him.

"You're nine hundred years old," he said.

"Nine hundred and forty-one, actually. Nobody ever counts the forty-one." Malachi leaned on his staff. "The Wells keep you, if you listen to them long enough. Not forever. Nothing's forever. But a long time." He looked at Lex. "You've started listening. Haven't you. I heard you. Calling out across the white." His eyes went gold. "*Please. Where are you? Help us.* Very loud. Very rude. Like someone shouting in a library." He grinned. "I came to see who was making all the noise."

"You *heard* that?"

"The whole white waste heard it. The stone heard it. The water heard it. The fire in my hearth jumped right up out of the grate." Malachi tilted his head. "You've got a very loud voice, for someone who doesn't know how to use it yet."



HE TOOK THEM TO the Stillwater.

It wasn't far. That was the absurd thing. A mile, perhaps, across the white salt to the east. They'd been walking toward it for three days without knowing. And then the salt simply *dipped*. A shallow bowl in the white plain, so gentle you'd never notice it until you were standing at the edge. And in the bottom of the bowl, there was green.

A valley. A small one. A hidden one. Sunk down below the level of the salt, so that you couldn't see it until you were almost on top of it. And it

was *green*. Grass and trees and moss and ferns, so bright and so lush after nineteen days of white that Lex's eyes stung. There were fruit trees, heavy with apples and plums. There was a little stream, running down the side of the bowl in a series of tiny waterfalls. There were goats grazing on the slopes, white and brown, with bells around their necks that clanked softly.

And in the center of the valley, a pool.

It was small. Round. No bigger than the millpond at Ashbourne. And it was perfectly still. As still as Mirrormere. It held the sky the way the great lake had held it: every cloud, every streak of sunset, perfectly reflected. A little round mirror laid in the green bottom of the valley, holding a little round piece of the sky.

Beside it, there was a hut. Round, of grey stone, with a turf roof. Smoke rising from its chimney.

"Home," said Malachi cheerfully. "Not much. But I've had nine hundred years to get it how I like it."

He led them down into the valley.



INSIDE THE HUT, THERE was a fire.

Lex knew it the moment he ducked through the low doorway. It was burning in a round hearth of white stone in the center of the single room, and there was no wood in it, no coal, no fuel. Just fire, dancing on bare stone. The twin of the fire in the room under the water at Qel'Varran.

And it leaned toward him.

Harder than the one at Qel'Varran. Much harder. The flames bent toward him so sharply they almost lay flat, like grass in a wind. Like a dog straining at a leash toward its master.

Malachi stopped in the middle of the room and looked at the fire. Then at Lex.

"Oh," he said softly. "Oh, *my*."

"What?" said Lex.

"It knows you." Malachi's shifting eyes had gone gold, steady gold, and were fixed on Lex's face. "It *likes* you. That fire's been burning in that hearth for nine hundred years, and it's never once bowed to anyone but

me." He looked at the fire again. It was still leaning. "And it's not bowing to *me*, now."

Nobody said anything.

Malachi sat down slowly on a three-legged stool by the hearth. He looked at Lex for a long time.

"Sit down," he said at last. "All of you. You're very tired and very thirsty and one of you is very sick. And I have a pot of goat stew and a great deal of tea and more questions than I've had in nine hundred years." He reached out one gnarled hand toward the fire, and the flames, reluctantly, the way a dog reluctantly leaves its master to come to someone else, bent toward him and let him warm his fingers. "And then I'll tell you what you are. And what's wrong with you. And whether I can fix it."



HE FIXED SERAPHINE FIRST.

He did it after the stew, which was the best thing Lex had ever eaten in his life, and the tea, which tasted of honey and mint and something green and sharp that Lex didn't recognize. He made Seraphine lie down on a pallet by the fire. He knelt beside her. He looked at her burns: the shiny pink scars down the left side of her face and neck, and the worse ones under her robe, on her chest, where Elric's gold lightning had struck.

"Root-fire," he said. "Stolen Root. Burned with a Hollow-graft." He clicked his tongue. "Nasty. Very nasty. It's still in there, a little. Still burning, slowly. That's why you're not healing."

"Can you—" Antho started.

"Hush." Malachi didn't look at him. He held out one hand toward the door of the hut, toward the little round pool outside. And he *listened*. Lex could see him do it. His whole body went still. His shifting eyes went blue, deep blue, like water.

And water came through the door.

Not poured. *Flowed*. A thin stream of it, rising out of the pool and running through the air, across the grass, through the door, into the hut, like a silver ribbon unspooling. It came to Malachi's outstretched hand and curled around his fingers like a cat. Then he laid his hand on Seraphine's chest, over the worst of the burns, and the water went *into* her.

Seraphine gasped.

Lex saw it happen. Saw the water sink into the burned skin like rain into dry earth. Saw the angry red go pink, and the pink go pale, and the shiny scar tissue soften and smooth. Not all the way. Not perfect. But better. Much better. And something came *out* of her, too, as the water went in. A thin wisp of something gold and black, smoking, writhing, like a splinter drawn out of a wound. It hung in the air above her for a moment, hissing. Then Malachi flicked his fingers, and the little fire in the hearth leaped up and took it, and it was gone.

Seraphine lay on the pallet, breathing. Long, deep, easy breaths. Her face was still scarred, but the grey was gone from it. She opened her eyes and looked up at the little man.

"It doesn't hurt," she whispered. "For the first time since Caldris. It doesn't hurt."

"It'll scar," said Malachi. "I'm sorry. I'm good, but I'm not that good." He patted her hand. "The water can only give back what the body remembers. Your body remembers being burned now. It'll always remember a little." He smiled. "But you'll live. And you'll heal. And you'll be able to read your books without wincing every time you turn a page."

Antho had his hand over his mouth. His shoulders were shaking.

"*Thank you*," he said. It came out cracked to pieces. "*Thank you, thank you—*"

Malachi looked at him. And his smile went away.

"Don't thank me yet, deep one," he said quietly. "I haven't looked at you."



HE LOOKED AT ALL of them, that night. One by one.

He looked at Wren first. He sat in front of her by the fire and stared at her for a long time with his shifting eyes, until she squirmed and went red and said *what*? And then he laughed.

"Wind," he said. "You've been listening to the wind your whole life. Up on that mountain of yours. You hear it change before a storm. You smell it shift before an avalanche. You know which way the air's going to move

before it moves." He tilted his head. "You thought that was just being a good tracker. Didn't you."

Wren stared at him. "It *is* just being a good tracker."

"It's Gale," said Malachi. "One of the Wells. You've been half-listening to it since you were a little girl. Never knew what it was." He grinned. "And the Lattice capped you at twenty-four, did it? Silly thing. The Lattice doesn't know anything about the wind."

Wren had gone very still.

He looked at Seraphine. Not for long. "Clever," he said. "Very clever. Too clever, maybe. You think in words. The Wells don't speak in words." He patted her knee. "You'll be useful anyway. Someone has to write it all down."

He looked at Lex.

He looked for a very long time.

"Your wheel's jammed," he said at last.

"My what?"

"Your wheel. Your Lattice wheel." Malachi leaned on his staff. "Let me tell you what the Lattice is, smith. It's a waterwheel. A great big clever waterwheel that my brother built over the river of the world. The river is the Wells. All six of them. Flame and Stone and Tide and Gale and Radiance and Shade. They've been flowing since before there was anything to flow past. And Aurelian built a wheel over them, and the wheel turns, and it grinds, and it gives everyone a little sack of flour. Classes and levels and skills. Very useful. Very tidy." He shrugged. "And you've all been living your whole lives thinking the flour comes from the wheel."

Nobody said anything.

"It doesn't," said Malachi. "It comes from the river. The wheel just *turns* it." He looked at Lex. "And someone has jammed your wheel. Locked it. With stolen Root. Very nasty. Very clever. You can't turn it anymore." His eyes went gold. "But they didn't dam the river, smith. They *couldn't*. Nobody can. The river doesn't belong to anybody."

"So I can—"

"So you can stop mistaking the wheel for the river," said Malachi. "And learn to *swim*."

He looked at Lex a moment longer. Then something in his face softened.

"You've already started," he said. "You heard the fire at Qel'Varran. You heard the stone in the salt. You heard the water under it. You called out across the white, and *I* heard you." He shook his head slowly. "Nine hundred years, nobody's ever done that. Not without being taught. Not without a Listener sitting beside them for years, teaching them to be quiet." He grinned. "You're very loud. That's going to be the hard part. Teaching you to be quiet."

Lex didn't know what to say.

And then Malachi turned to Antho.



THE LITTLE MAN'S FACE changed.

The laughter went out of it. The cheerfulness. The grin. He looked at Antho, sitting by the fire with Seraphine's hand in his and Ashka curled at his feet, and his shifting eyes went dark. Grey. The grey of a storm cloud. The grey of a grave.

"Oh, child," he said softly. "Oh, deep one. What have they done to you."

Antho didn't move. His eyes were flickering black at the edges.

CLARITY: 31 → 27 ▼



— aware (*Listener presence*)

"I can see it," said Malachi. "In you. The hole. The door. Right there in the middle of you, open onto the bottom of everything." His voice was very quiet. "You've got a hole in your bucket, deep one, and it opens straight onto the bottom of the sea."

"I know," said Antho hoarsely.

"And the thing at the bottom of the sea knows you're there. And it's been pushing up through you. Trying to get out. For—" Malachi tilted his head, listening. "Eight years. Nine, nearly."

"Yes."

"And you've been holding it. Alone. With nothing but your own stubbornness and a little bone flute and your brother."

"Yes."

Malachi was quiet for a long time.

"My brother tried to hold it," he said at last. "Nine hundred years ago. He built the whole Lattice to hold it. The biggest working anyone's ever made, before or since. And he put himself into it, his own mind, at the root of it, so he could hold it forever." His shifting eyes were very dark. "I told him not to. On the night of the Weaving. I stood beside him and I said *Aurelian, you can't do this. You can't hold a thing like that by making yourself into the bars of its cage. It will become you. Or you will become it.*" He shook his head slowly. "He didn't listen. He never listened. He was the clever one."

Nobody spoke.

"*You do not cage a storm by becoming the bars,*" said Seraphine softly. "That's what the margin said."

"Did it?" Malachi smiled faintly. "Somebody wrote that down? How nice." The smile faded. "I was right, you know. About him. I've had nine hundred years to be sure." He looked at Antho. "And I'm going to be right about you too, deep one, unless you learn something very quickly."

"What?" Antho's voice was barely a whisper.

Malachi leaned forward. His shifting eyes went black. Not the black of the Murmur. Not the black of the Gloam. A different black. Soft. Deep. Peaceful. Like the sky between the stars.

"That the dark isn't your enemy," he said quietly. "It never was. *Shade* is one of the six Wells. It's as old as Flame. As old as Stone. As old as the river itself." He reached out and laid one gnarled brown finger on Antho's chest, right over his heart. "The thing in the Hollow is *not* Shade. It's a hunger that lives in the dark. A thief in an empty house. And it's been telling you, for eight years, that it *is* the dark. That the dark belongs to it. That every shadow you call up is its shadow, and every time you use them, you're letting it in."

Antho stared at him.

"It's lying," said Malachi. "The shadows were never its. They were always *yours*. They were Shade's. And Shade doesn't want to eat you." He smiled. A real smile, warm and gentle. "Shade wants to hold you. The way the night holds the stars."

CLARITY: 27 → 33 ▲



– agitated

"I don't understand," Antho whispered.

"No. You won't. Not yet." Malachi took his finger away and sat back on his stool. "But you will. I'll teach you. Both of you. All of you, if you'll let me." He looked around the little round hut at the four of them, firelit, exhausted, staring at him. "Starting at dawn."

"What do we do at dawn?" said Wren.

Malachi grinned. His gap-toothed, walnut-wrinkled grin, as cheerful as an oiled hinge.

"Nothing," he said. "Absolutely nothing at all. That's the hardest lesson there is."



AT DAWN, HE SAT them down at the edge of the still pool, in the cool grey light, with the goats' bells clanking softly on the slopes above.

"Sit," he said. "Close your eyes. Be quiet."

They sat. They closed their eyes.

"Quieter," said Malachi.

Lex sat on the damp grass by the pool with his eyes shut and tried to be quiet. It was harder than it sounded. His mind wouldn't stop. It ran in circles, the way a dog runs in circles before it lies down. *Father in the crystal. Elric on the stair. Garrick at the gate. Brannoc. Ember. The locked door.* Round and round and round.

"Quieter," said Malachi. "You're shouting, smith. I can hear you from here."

He tried.

An hour passed. Two. The sun came up over the rim of the valley and warmed his face. His legs went numb. His back ached. His mind kept running.

Ember.

He thought of the voice. The dry calm courteous voice that had lived in the back of his head for three months. That had called him *Smith* and *Lex*

and *little smith*. That had sung his mother's lullaby off-key in a Founders' waystation in the ice.

That was gone. Shut away. Behind the iron door.

I miss you, he thought. Not to anyone. Just thought it.

And in the silence after the thought, for the first time all morning, his mind stopped running.

It just stopped. Like a dog finally lying down. Like a hammer finally put down at the end of a long day. Everything went still.

And in the stillness, he heard it.

Not a voice. Not words. A sound. Very faint. Very far away. Like a fire burning in a hearth on the other side of a wall. Warm. Patient. Crackling softly.

I am Flame, it seemed to say. *I'm still here. I was always here.*

Who are you?

Lex opened his eyes.

The little fire in Malachi's hut, a hundred paces away up the slope, was leaning out through the open doorway. Leaning so far that its flames were licking out over the threshold onto the grass. Toward him.

Beside him on the bank, Malachi was looking at him. His shifting eyes had gone gold.

"*There*," said the little man softly. "There you are."

CHAPTER 29

THE SIX WELLS



"**THE FIRST STAGE IS** Listening," said Malachi. "You've done that. Very loudly. Congratulations." He was sitting cross-legged on a flat rock at the edge of the still pool, peeling an apple with a little bone knife, the peel coming off in a single long curl. "The second stage is Answering. That's harder."

"What's the difference?" said Lex.

"Listening is hearing the Well. Answering is the Well hearing *you*." Malachi held up the curl of apple peel and examined it critically. "You've heard Flame. Flame knows you're there. It leans toward you. It likes you, the way a cat likes a warm lap." He popped the peel into his mouth. "But it hasn't *answered* you yet. It hasn't done anything you asked. Has it?"

Lex thought about it. The fire in the hut had leaned out of the doorway toward him. The fire at Qel'Varran had leaned. But neither had *done* anything.

"No," he said.

"No." Malachi bit into the apple. "Because you haven't asked properly. You've been asking the way you asked the Lattice. *Ember Strike. Heat Shaping. Fire, do this.*" He chewed. "Like a man giving orders to a servant. The Lattice likes that. It's built for that. It's a wheel. You push it, it turns." He swallowed. "Flame isn't a wheel. Flame is a river. You don't give orders to a river."

"Then what do you do?"

Malachi grinned his gap-toothed grin.

"You tell it the truth," he said.



IT WAS THE HARDEST thing Lex had ever done.

Malachi built a fire for him every morning in a ring of stones by the pool. An ordinary fire, of dead apple-wood. He sat Lex down in front of it and told him to make it rise. Not with the Lattice. Not with Heat Shaping or Ember Strike or anything he'd learned in the last three months. With Flame. By *asking*.

The first day, nothing happened.

Lex sat in front of the fire and thought at it. *Rise. Please rise. Burn higher.* He thought it a hundred times. A thousand. The fire burned on, ordinary, crackling, indifferent. It didn't lean toward him the way the eternal fire in the hut did. It didn't do anything at all.

"You're giving orders again," said Malachi from his rock. "Politely, I'll grant you. *Please.* Very nice manners. Your mother raised you well." He bit into another apple. "Still orders."

"Then what do I *say*?"

"Not *say*. *Tell.*" Malachi chewed. "The truth. What's true about you, right now, sitting there. Fire doesn't care what you want. Fire cares what you *are*."

The second day, nothing happened.

The third day, Lex lost his temper. He'd been sitting in front of the fire since dawn, and it was afternoon, and his legs were numb and his back was aching and his mind was running in circles again, and the fire was just *sitting* there. Burning. Ignoring him. The way the Lattice Stone in Highcrest had ignored the girl in the brown dress. The way the Anvil of Ascent had said *not granted*. The way Elric had looked at him at the foot of the cellar stair and said *I'm sorry, Lex*, and taken everything.

And something in his chest went up like a forge with the bellows going full.

I'm ANGRY, he thought at the fire. *I'm so angry I can't breathe. He took everything. He took Father and he took my class and he took Ember and I couldn't stop him. I couldn't do ANYTHING.*

The fire *exploded*.

It went up in a column ten feet high, a roaring orange pillar that blew the stones of the ring outward in a scatter and scorched the grass in a circle around it and singed Lex's eyebrows clean off. He threw himself backward. The column hung there for a moment, howling, and then collapsed in a shower of sparks, and the fire was gone. Just ash. Just smoking ash.

Lex lay on his back on the scorched grass, staring up at the sky.

Malachi was laughing.

He was laughing so hard he'd fallen off his rock. He lay on the grass by the pool with his little brown body shaking and tears running down into his white beard, wheezing.

"*There!*" he gasped. "*There it is! That's Answering!*"

"I didn't mean to *do* that!"

"Of course you didn't! You never do, the first time!" Malachi sat up, wiping his eyes. "You told it the truth. You told it *I'm angry*. And it believed you. And it answered. With anger." He grinned. "Fire's honest, smith. It gives back what you give it. Anger gets anger. Grief gets grief. Love gets love." He got up and brushed the grass off his robe. "Now you know. The rest is just learning what you want to tell it."



IT CAME FASTER AFTER that.

Not easily. Never easily. But faster.

He learned that when he was angry, the fire was wild. Big and loud and hungry and impossible to control. It wanted to eat everything around it, and it didn't care whether that was a log or a tree or the hem of his coat.

He learned that when he was afraid, the fire was small. It shrank down into the coals and hid, the way he'd hidden in the loft above the forge after the cottage burned.

He learned that when he was sad, the fire was gentle. Low and warm and slow, like a hearth on a winter night. It didn't do much. But what it did, it did carefully.

And on the eighth day, he learned what happened when he told it about Brannoc.

He hadn't planned to. He'd been sitting in front of the morning fire, trying to make it rise without anger, and failing, and his mind had

wandered. To the forge in Ashbourne. To the old smith standing at the edge of the cobbles with his hand raised. To the lantern in the forge window in the middle of the day. To the hammer-oath. *What's struck on the anvil holds.*

I promised him I'd come back, he thought. Not at the fire. Just thought it. I miss him. He's the best man I know. He gave me everything and he never asked for anything back. I want to go home and tell him he was right. That the iron can sing. That I found my brother. That I'm sorry I left him alone.

The fire rose.

Not in a column. Not in an explosion. It just *rose*. Gently. Steadily. The flames lifting up out of the coals like a man standing up from a chair. Gold, not orange. Warm, not hot. They rose until they were as tall as Lex sitting down, and they held there, burning steady and clear and bright, without wavering, without smoke.

And they leaned toward him. And curled around his outstretched hand like the water had curled around Malachi's fingers. And didn't burn.

Lex stared at it.

Malachi had stopped peeling his apple. He was sitting very still on his rock, looking at the fire with his shifting eyes gone steady gold.

"*Love*," he said softly. "You told it about someone you love."

"Brannoc. The smith who raised me."

"Ah." Malachi nodded slowly. "That's the one. That's the truth it likes best, smith. Fire's a hearth before it's a weapon. Always was." He set down his apple. "Now you're Answering."



ANTHO LEARNED IN THE dark.

Malachi took him down into a cave under the hut on the fourth day. A small round chamber, carved out of the rock under the valley, reached by a ladder through a trapdoor in the hut's floor. It was completely dark. Not dim. Not shadowy. *Dark*. The kind of dark where you can't see your hand in front of your face, where your eyes make up shapes and colors because there's nothing for them to see.

Lex went down with them the first time, because Antho asked him to. He stood at the bottom of the ladder in the absolute black and felt his brother beside him, shaking.

"I don't like this," said Antho. His voice was very tight. "I don't like the dark. Not anymore. Not since—" He stopped. "It's *louder* in the dark."

CLARITY: 52 → 44 ▼



— encouraged

His Clarity had risen since they came to the Stillwater. Forty, forty-five, fifty, as the days went by, as Malachi fed them and made them sleep and sat with Antho by the eternal fire in the evenings and told him stories. Not the Keeper's Lantern's floor of fifteen. Not the Hollowmaw's eighty. But better. Much better.

Now, in the dark, it was dropping again.

"Of course it's louder," said Malachi's voice out of the blackness. Cheerful. Unconcerned. "The thief likes the dark. It's been telling you the dark is its house for eight years. Of course it's going to shout when you walk into it." A pause. "Sit down, deep one."

Antho sat. Lex heard him: the scrape of cloth on stone, a shaky breath.

"Now," said Malachi. "Listen."

"*To what?*" Antho's voice cracked. "*All I can hear is it. It's so loud. It's saying—it's saying—*"

"I know what it's saying. It always says the same thing. *Hungry. Warm. Let me in.*" Malachi's voice was very calm. "That's not what I want you to listen to. Listen *under* it."

"*There's nothing under it.*"

"There's always something under it." A pause. "What's under the noise of a crowd, deep one? When you're standing in a market square and everyone's shouting?"

Silence. Then, very faintly, Antho: "I don't know. I haven't been in a market in eight years."

"The ground," said Malachi. "The ground's under it. The ground's always there, quiet, holding everyone up, whether they notice or not." A pause. "What's under the noise of a storm?"

"The sky?"

"The sky. Quiet. Still. Holding the storm the way a cup holds water." Another pause. "So. What's under the noise of the thief, deep one? In the dark? What's holding *it* up?"

Antho didn't answer for a long time.

Lex stood in the absolute black at the foot of the ladder and listened to his brother breathe. Short, sharp, frightened breaths. Then slower. Then slower still.

He felt it through the Bloodbond before he heard anything. A change. In the cold deep pool that was his brother. The surface of it had been churning, whipped up by the thing at the bottom, the way a pond churns in a gale. And now, very slowly, something under the surface was *settling*. Not the thief. Something else. Something deeper than the thief. Older. Bigger. So big that the thief was only a small dark fish in it.

"*Oh*," whispered Antho.

"There," said Malachi softly.

"*It's—it's so big.*" Antho's voice was full of wonder. "*It's so big and so quiet. It's like—like the sky at night. Between the stars. It's not hungry. It's not anything. It's just—*there. Holding everything.*" His voice cracked. "*Holding me.*"

"That's Shade," said Malachi. "That's the Well. That's the dark that was there before the thief moved in." His voice was very gentle. "It's been under you the whole time, deep one. For eight years. Under the noise. Holding you up. You just couldn't hear it over the shouting."

CLARITY: 44 → 58 ▲▲

58 → 67 ▲▲

 — diminished

Attunement detected: SHADE

Stage: LISTENING

[UNTRACKED]

Lex heard his brother start to cry. Quietly. In the dark.

He didn't go to him. He didn't need to. He could feel through the Bloodbond that Antho wasn't alone in there anymore.



WREN LEARNED ON THE edge of a cliff.

There was a place on the rim of the valley where the green bowl of the Stillwater met the white salt plain above, and the edge was steep: a sheer drop of forty feet down a face of grey rock to the meadow below. Malachi took her there on the sixth day, with Lex and Antho trailing behind, curious.

"Stand on the edge," he said.

Wren stood on the edge. She didn't even hesitate. She'd been standing on the edges of cliffs her whole life.

"Now close your eyes," said Malachi. "And tell me which way the wind's going to blow."

Wren closed her eyes. She stood very still on the rim of the cliff, her fox-red braid stirring on her shoulder, her face lifted. Lex watched her. He'd seen her do this a hundred times on the road. Stop on a ridge, lift her face, close her eyes. *Weather Sense*, he'd thought, from her panel. *Journeyman 2*.

"From the west," said Wren. "In a moment. Gusting. Then it'll swing round north." She opened her eyes. "Why?"

"How do you know?"

"I just know. I always know. It's—" She frowned. "It's like hearing someone coming up the stairs before they open the door. The air sort of—*leans*. Before it moves."

"*Leans*," said Malachi. "Yes. Like fire leaning toward the smith." He grinned. "You've been listening to Gale your whole life, little climber. You just thought it was a skill in your panel." He stepped back from the edge. "Now. When the west wind comes. Step off."

Wren turned and stared at him.

"*Step off? Off the cliff?*"

"Off the cliff."

"It's forty feet!"

"It's forty feet to the ground, yes. If you fall." Malachi leaned on his staff. "I'm not asking you to fall. I'm asking you to step."

"Malachi—" Lex started forward.

"Hush, smith. She knows what she's doing. She just doesn't know she knows." Malachi didn't take his eyes off Wren. "When the wind comes, climber. Don't fall into it. *Step onto it*. Like a stair. Like a rock. Like a

branch. Like you've stepped onto a thousand handholds on a thousand mountains." His shifting eyes went pale. Pale grey. Pale as the sky. "It's there. It's always been there. You just never asked it to hold you."

Wren stood on the rim of the cliff and stared at him.

Then she turned around and faced the drop.

Lex couldn't breathe.

The wind came. From the west, gusting, exactly as she'd said. Lex felt it hit his face. Saw it stir the grass on the rim, saw it lift Wren's braid off her shoulder.

And Wren stepped off the cliff.

She didn't fall.

She *stood* on the air. For one heartbeat. Two. Her boot planted on nothing, on the empty wind forty feet above the meadow, her arms spread wide for balance, her face white with shock. The wind rushed past her, lifting her braid straight up, billowing her coat. And held her.

Then it swung north, exactly as she'd said it would, and she fell.

Not hard. Not fast. She *drifted*. Down. Slowly. Like a leaf. Like a feather. Spinning gently in the air, her arms still spread, forty feet down to the soft green meadow below, and landed on her feet in the grass as lightly as a cat jumping off a wall.

She stood there in the meadow, looking up at them. Her mouth was open.

Then she started to laugh.

She laughed and laughed, standing alone in the meadow at the foot of the cliff with her arms still spread, and Lex could hear it all the way up on the rim. A wild, delighted, disbelieving laugh, like a child's.

WREN ASHDOWN

Class: Tracker (Common)

Level: 24 (CAP)

Attunement detected: GALE

Stage: ANSWERING

[UNTRACKED]

Untracked.

Lex stood on the rim of the cliff and looked down at her, laughing in the meadow. And he thought of the mirror on the silver road, the one that had gone dark instead of shattering. Wren in the sky, flying, arms spread, braid streaming.

It could be. If you let it.

"The Lattice capped her at twenty-four," said Malachi quietly beside him. "Silly thing. The Lattice doesn't know anything about the wind."



SERAPHINE DIDN'T HEAR ANY of the Wells.

She tried. Every morning, she sat by the still pool with the others and closed her eyes and listened. Malachi sat beside her and talked to her, gently, patiently. *Under the noise. What's under the noise.* She tried for days.

On the tenth day, she opened her eyes and said, very calmly, "I don't hear anything."

Malachi looked at her.

"I hear words," said Seraphine. "That's all I've ever heard. Words, and the spaces between them. I hear what people say and what they don't say. I hear what the books say and what the footnotes say." She took off her spectacles and polished them on her sleeve. "I don't hear fire, or stone, or wind. I've tried. I'm sorry."

"Don't be sorry," said Malachi. "Not everyone hears the Wells. Not even in the old days. Most people didn't." He shrugged. "They still lived perfectly good lives. They baked bread and built houses and wrote books." He smiled at her. "Someone has to write it all down, clever one."

Seraphine looked at him for a long moment. Then she put her spectacles back on and nodded.

"Then I'll write it all down," she said.

She did. Every evening, by the eternal fire in the hut, she sat with the grey Listeners' Codex open on her knees and a stack of paper Malachi had found somewhere, and copied it out. Every word. And then she wrote down what Malachi said. Every lesson. Every story. Every joke, even the bad ones. Her neat cramped handwriting filled page after page after page.

"For whoever comes after," she said, when Lex asked. "So they won't have to find a nine-hundred-year-old man in the middle of a salt desert to learn how to listen."



THE STORIES CAME IN the evenings.

Malachi told them by the eternal fire, while the goats bleated outside and the stars came out over the rim of the valley. Stories about the time before the Lattice. About the Listeners. About the six of them, his brothers and sisters, and Aurelian, the oldest, the cleverest, the one who was always right.

"He was a smith," Malachi said one night. "Did you know that? The best smith who ever lived. He could make anything. Swords that sang. Shields that remembered every blow. A plough that turned the earth so gently the worms didn't notice." He smiled into the fire. "When I was small, he made me a little bell. Silver. No bigger than my thumb. It rang whenever I was sad, so he'd know to come and find me."

"What happened to it?" said Lex.

Malachi was quiet for a long moment.

"I threw it in the sea," he said at last. "The night after the Weaving. When he'd put himself into the net and I couldn't reach him anymore." He shook his head. "It rang and rang. All the way down."

Nobody said anything.

"He was afraid," said Malachi. "That's what nobody understands. They think he built the Lattice because he was wise. Because he saw what needed to be done and did it." He stared into the fire. "He built it because he was *afraid*. Afraid of the hunger. Afraid of what people did with power. Afraid of himself. Of what *he* might do, with all that strength, if nobody stopped him." His voice was very quiet. "So he built a cage. For the hunger, and for everyone else, and for himself. And then he got inside it and locked the door."

"And the hunger?" said Antho softly.

"Is still in the cage. With him." Malachi's shifting eyes went dark. "Nine hundred years. In the dark. Holding it. Holding it so close, so long, that I don't know anymore where he ends and it begins." He looked at Antho.

"Whoever holds it, it will try to become. I wrote that, you know. In the margin of a book in Qel'Varran. The night after the Weaving. I was very drunk. And very sad." He smiled faintly. "And very right."



ON THE ELEVENTH DAY, Lex asked about the lock.

He'd been putting it off. Afraid of the answer. But he'd been Answering Flame for three days now, steady and gold and warm, and Stone had started to hum back at him when he laid his hands on the rocks of the valley, low and slow and heavy, and he couldn't put it off any longer.

"Elric locked my class," he said. "With stolen Root. And when he did, Ember went quiet. The voice. The construct. My father's piece." He swallowed. "I can't reach it. I've tried every day. I've tried with the Wells. I can feel something, behind the lock. Warm. Faint. Like a fire behind a door. But I can't get to it."

Malachi looked at him for a long time.

"Your little voice," he said. "Your father's piece. It lives in your seal. Yes?"

"Yes."

"And your seal is part of your Root. And your Root is the lowest part of the wheel. The axle, if you like." Malachi turned his apple over in his gnarled hands. "When the thief locked your class, he locked the whole wheel. Axle and all. Your little voice is shut inside it, the way a man's shut inside a mill when someone bars the door."

"So how do I get him out?"

"You unjam the wheel."

"How?"

Malachi set down the apple.

"With the river," he said. "Same as anything." His shifting eyes went gold. "The thief locked your wheel with Root. Root is the strongest thing in the Lattice. Nothing in the Lattice can break it." He leaned forward. "But Root isn't the strongest thing in the *world*, smith. It's just the strongest thing in the wheel. The river's stronger. The river's always stronger. The river was here before the wheel, and it'll be here after." He tapped Lex on the chest, right over his heart. "You're a smith. You've got

Flame answering you. You've got Stone humming at you. What do smiths do with things that are stuck?"

Lex stared at him.

"Heat them," he said slowly. "Until they move."

"And then?"

"Hit them. Until they're the shape you need."

Malachi grinned his gap-toothed grin.

"Then go and find an anvil," he said.



THERE WAS AN ANVIL in the valley.

Lex hadn't known. He'd been there eleven days, and he'd walked every inch of the green bowl, and he hadn't seen it. But Malachi led him that evening to the far side of the still pool, where the slope of the valley met the rim of white salt, and pulled aside a curtain of hanging ivy, and behind it there was a cave. A shallow one. Barely more than an overhang. And in it, there was a forge.

Old. Ancient. A hearth of white stone, like the one in the hut, but bigger. A chimney carved up through the rock to the surface. And beside the hearth, an anvil. Black iron. Not white stone like the Anvil of Ascent. Iron. Real iron. Pitted and scarred and worn smooth on its face by long-ago hands.

There was a hammer lying on it.

Small. A hand-hammer. The kind you use for fine work. Its head was black iron, like the anvil, and its haft was some pale wood Lex didn't recognize, worn dark and smooth by a palm that had held it for years. And on its head, worn almost smooth, there was a mark.

An open hand. And above the palm, a flame.

Lex stood very still.

"His," said Malachi quietly. "Aurelian's. He made it when he was young. Before the Weaving. Before any of it." He looked at the little hammer for a long moment. "He gave it to me, the night before. *Keep it for me, Mal. I won't need it where I'm going.*" His voice was rough. "I brought it here. Built the forge for it. Nine hundred years, it's been lying on that

anvil." He looked at Lex. "Waiting for someone of the blood with the gift of the forge."

Lex couldn't speak.

"The hearth's cold," said Malachi. "It's been cold for nine hundred years. I could never light it. It's not my fire." He stepped back. "See if it's yours."



LEX KNELT IN FRONT of the cold white hearth.

He didn't reach for the Lattice. There was nothing there to reach for. He didn't reach for his Root. It was locked behind the iron door.

He reached for Flame.

He closed his eyes and listened, the way Malachi had taught him. Under the noise. Under the running thoughts and the grief and the fear. Down to the quiet place where the fire was. Not his fire. Not the Lattice's fire. *Fire*. The fire that had been in the world since before anything.

I'm here, he told it. I'm a smith. I'm my father's son and my mother's son and Brannoc's apprentice. I'm Antho's brother. I'm Wren's— He stopped. Started again. *I love them. All of them. I want to make something that will help them. I want to get my fire back so I can protect them. I want to find Ember. I want to save my father. I want to stop the thing that's hurting everyone.*

That's the truth, he told it. That's all of it.

He opened his eyes.

The hearth was burning.

Gold. Steady. Clear. Rising up out of the bare white stone without fuel or spark, the way the eternal fire in the hut burned, the way Seren's lamp burned on the rock above the Hollowmaw. It lit the little cave with warm gold light. It lit the black iron anvil, and the little hammer lying on it with the open hand and the flame on its head.

And it leaned toward him.

Behind him, he heard Malachi let out a long, slow breath.

"Nine hundred years," the little man whispered. "Nine hundred years, and it's burning again."

Lex stood up. He went to the anvil. He looked down at the little hammer.

Then he picked it up.

It fit his hand like it had been made for it. Like Anvilson's fit his hand. The pale wood of the haft was warm, and worn smooth in exactly the places his fingers fell.

He turned around. Malachi was standing in the mouth of the cave with his staff, and his shifting eyes had gone a color Lex had never seen in them before. Wet. Very bright.

"Tomorrow," said Lex. "At dawn. I'm going to forge."

"Forge what?"

Lex looked down at the little hammer in his hand. At the open hand on its head.

"Myself," he said.

CHAPTER 30

THE UNBOUND FORGE



THEY ALL CAME TO watch.

Lex hadn't asked them to. He'd told Malachi, the night before, that he was going to forge at dawn, and he'd gone to sleep by the eternal fire in the hut, and when he woke in the grey light before sunrise, they were all already up. Wren, sitting cross-legged by the cold hearth with her bow across her knees. Antho, leaning against the wall with Ashka draped over his shoulders like a blue-grey scarf the size of a pony. Seraphine, with her pen and her stack of paper and her cracked spectacles. Malachi, peeling an apple.

"We're coming," said Wren. "Don't argue."

"I wasn't going to argue."

"You were going to say *it's dangerous* and *I don't know what will happen* and *you should stay back*." She stood up. "You can say all that on the way."



THE FORGE IN THE cave behind the ivy was burning when they got there.

Lex had left it burning the night before. Gold and steady and clear, on the bare white stone of the hearth, without fuel or spark. It had burned all night. It leaned toward him the moment he ducked under the ivy.

He went to the anvil. Aurelian's anvil. Black iron, pitted and scarred. He laid Aurelian's little hand-hammer on it, beside Anvilsong. Two hammers. One nine hundred years old. One three months old. Both with an open hand and a flame struck into their heads.

"How?" said Seraphine quietly. She'd sat down on a rock near the mouth of the cave with her paper on her knees. "How do you forge yourself? I've been thinking about it all night. You can't put yourself on an anvil."

"No," said Lex. "But I can put the anvil in myself."

She stared at him.

He didn't know how to explain it. He'd been thinking about it all night too, lying by the eternal fire, listening to the others breathe. Thinking about the place under his breastbone where the seal was. Where the fire had been banked for fifteen years. Where Elric had slammed an iron door and bolted it.

It was a forge. He'd always thought of it that way, without knowing he did. *A fire with a forge-door bolted over it*, Elric had said, that first night in Ashbourne. And Ember had said it too, in the Frostvault. And Arion, in the prologue of everything, kneeling over a four-year-old boy who fought the seal like a cat in a sack, had thought *it has to be a forge-door. Iron, banded, locked, with the fire still roaring behind it*.

Everyone had always known it was a forge. Except him.

"I'm going to go in," said Lex. "To the place where the lock is. The way I go into the fire when I listen to it. Down. Under." He looked at the gold flame in the hearth. "And I'm going to take this with me."



HE KNELT IN FRONT of the hearth.

He laid his left hand flat on Aurelian's anvil. He picked up Aurelian's little hammer in his right. He looked into the fire.

And he went down.

It wasn't like Listening. Listening was quiet. Listening was sitting by the pool with his eyes closed until the running thoughts stopped and he could hear the fire on the other side of the wall. This was the opposite. This was *going through the wall*. Down past the quiet, past the place where the Wells were, down into the place where *he* was.

He'd never been there before. Not on purpose.

It was dark. Then it wasn't. It was a forge.

He knew it at once. Every stone of it. It was Brannoc's forge, in Ashbourne. The big brick hearth. The rack of tools. The slack tub. The brick ledge where Slag slept. Except it wasn't quite Brannoc's forge. It was bigger. Much bigger. The ceiling went up and up into darkness, and the walls went back and back, and there were things on the racks that Brannoc had never owned: the *Book of Making*, open; Wren's bow; a little clay lamp with a flame burning in it; a bone flute; a rune-struck lantern, shattered.

And the hearth was dark.

There was no fire in it. There was a door.

A great iron door, set into the brick of the hearth where the fire should be. Black iron, banded with gold and black, riveted, studded. Covered all over in glyphs. And across the middle of it, holding it shut, a lock. A massive iron lock, the size of a man's chest, shaped like a fist. And carved into the fist, in letters of black and stolen gold:

LOCKED. — E.T.

Lex stood in front of the iron door in the dark forge in the middle of himself, with Aurelian's little hammer in his hand, and looked at it.

He could feel the fire on the other side. His fire. Roaring. Trapped. Hammering at the inside of the door like a fist on a coffin lid.

And under the roar, faint, very faint, so faint he almost didn't hear it, something else.

A voice. Dry. Calm. Courteous. Muffled, as if speaking through a pillow.

[...Lex? Lex, is that you? I can hear you. I can hear you walking around out there. Lex?]

He put his free hand flat on the iron door.

I'm here, he thought. I'm here, Ember. I'm going to get you out.

[Ob,] said the muffled voice. And it sounded, for the first time since he'd known it, like it was crying. *[Ob, thank goodness. It's so dark in here, Lex. It's so dark and I couldn't find you.]*



IN THE CAVE BEHIND the ivy, kneeling in front of the gold fire with his eyes closed and his hand on the anvil and the little hammer raised, Lex began to strike.

The others saw it. Seraphine wrote it down, afterward, every detail, in her neat cramped hand.

He struck the empty air above the anvil. Again and again. *Tink. Tink. Tink.* The little hammer coming down on nothing, stopping a finger's width above the black iron, rising again. And every time it came down, the gold fire in the hearth *flared*. And every time it flared, something went across Lex's face. Pain. Effort. Strain. Sweat stood out on his forehead. His jaw clenched.

"It's not working," he said. His eyes were still closed. His voice was hoarse, strange, coming from very far away. *"The fire's not hot enough. I can't get it hot enough. The lock's too cold. It's Root-cold."*

"What do you need?" said Malachi quietly.

"Air. I need air. Like bellows. It needs more air."

Wren was already moving.

She went and knelt beside him at the hearth. She didn't ask what to do. She closed her eyes, and lifted her face, and *listened*. Lex felt her do it. Felt it through the fellowship, through whatever was between them. Felt her reach for the wind.

And the wind came.

It came down through the chimney carved into the rock. It came in under the ivy curtain. It came from everywhere, a rushing roaring gust, and poured into the hearth like air from a giant's bellows.

The fire *roared*.

It went from gold to white. It went up in a column that filled the hearth and licked up the chimney and set the ivy at the cave mouth smoking. And in the dark forge in the middle of himself, Lex felt the heat come up behind him like the sun rising. Felt the iron door in front of him begin to glow.

Red. Then orange. The glyphs on it burning. The gold-and-black bands beginning to soften.

Strike.

He struck. The little hammer came down on the iron fist of the lock. *CHANG.* The sound went through the dark forge like a bell. A crack ran across the fist.



"Where?" he gasped, in the cave. *"Where do I hit it? There are glyphs on it. On the lock. I can see them but I can't read them. They're Root-script. Elric's script. I don't know where the weak place is."*

Seraphine dropped her pen.

She came and knelt on his other side. She leaned close to his face, close to his closed eyes, as if she could see what he was seeing.

"Describe them," she said. "The glyphs. Exactly. Shape by shape. I'll read them."

He described them. His voice was cracked and strained. *A shape like a fist. A shape like a key turned backward. A shape like a coiled snake.* Seraphine listened with her eyes shut and her lips moving, translating, as fast as he spoke.

"Lock," she said. *"Bind. Root-held. Stolen—there. Lex. The fourth glyph, the snake. That's the Hollow-graft. That's how he tied stolen Root to his own will. It's the weakest part. It's not his. It's borrowed."* She opened her eyes. "Hit the snake."

CHANG.

The snake glyph cracked. The crack spread through the iron fist like a fracture through ice.

The lock screamed.

It wasn't a sound. Not in the cave. But in the dark forge, it was a shriek like metal tearing, and the iron fist *writhed*, and black smoke poured out of the crack, and in the smoke, a face. Elric's face. Grey and old and twisted with grief and rage.

You can't, it said. You can't. I locked it with your father's own Root. Nothing in the Lattice can—

I'm not using the Lattice, said Lex.

He struck again.



AND ANTHO.

Lex felt his brother before he saw him. Through the Bloodbond. The cold deep pool, stirring. Coming. Reaching.

The iron door was glowing white-hot now. The lock was cracked through and through, black smoke pouring from it, Elric's face screaming silently in the smoke. And on the other side of the door, Lex's fire was hammering, hammering, the whole door shaking on its hinges.

But it was too hot.

He could feel it. The door was going to *burst*. Not open. Burst. Shatter. Like a cracked crucible in the forge. And when it burst, everything behind it would come out at once. Fifteen years of fire. All at once. And it would take him with it. And Ember. And the cave. And maybe the valley.

[*Lex,*] said Ember, through the door, faint and frightened. [*Lex, it's too hot. It's too fast. You're rushing the quench.*]

Mind the quench.

He knew. He knew, and he couldn't stop. The fire was too big and too hungry and it had been locked away too long, and it wanted *out*.

And then something cool touched his back.

A hand. Long-fingered. Scarred. Cold as a winter night. It lay flat between his shoulder blades in the dark forge in the middle of himself. And from it, flowing into him, came *dark*. Not the Gloam. Not the hunger. *Shade*. Soft and deep and peaceful, like the sky between the stars. Like the night holding a fire safe until morning.

I keep the door, said Antho's voice. In his head. Through the Bloodbond. *That's what I do. Let me keep this one.*

The cool flowed into the white-hot iron. Not putting the fire out. *Holding* it. Steadying it. The way the night holds a banked hearth, the way cold water holds hot steel in the quench: not rushing, not fighting, just *there*, drawing off the excess, letting the metal settle into its temper.

The door stopped shaking.

The roar behind it dropped. From a scream to a growl. From a growl to a deep steady thrum. The sound of a forge with its bellows working in rhythm. The sound of a fire that knows it's going to be let out, and is willing to wait for it.

Now, said Antho. *Now, Lex. Gently.*

Lex raised Aurelian's little hammer.

Tink.

Not a blow. A tap. The lightest touch. The way you'd tap a finished blade to hear it ring. On the very center of the cracked iron fist, on the snake.

The lock fell apart.

It didn't shatter. It didn't burst. It simply *came apart*, the way a well-made thing comes apart when you find the right place to touch it. The iron fist split along its cracks into a dozen pieces, and the pieces fell, and dissolved in the air before they hit the floor of the dark forge, and Elric's face in the smoke went with them, and was gone.

And the iron door swung open.



THE FIRE CAME OUT like dawn.

Not in a blast. Not in a column. It came out of the open hearth like the sun coming up over the edge of the world: slow, steady, unstoppable, gold. It filled the dark forge. It filled the high dark ceiling and the deep dark walls. It lit every tool on every rack. The *Book of Making*. Wren's bow. Seren's little lamp. The bone flute. The shattered lantern.

And it filled *him*.

He felt it come back. Every scrap of it. The heat in his chest. The strength in his arms. The quickness in his legs. All the points he'd spent and all the levels he'd climbed and all the skills he'd learned. Ember Strike. Heat Shaping. Ironskin. Slag Shot. Kindle. Runic Forging. Forge Sense. Pouring back into him like water into a dry riverbed.

But not the same.

Different.

Because it wasn't coming through the wheel anymore. Not only. It was coming from the river *and* the wheel. Together. Braided. The Lattice and the Well, gold and gold, so tangled together that he couldn't tell where one ended and the other began.

[...Lex?]

The voice was right there. Not muffled. Not through a door. In the back of his head, where it had always been. Dry. Calm. Courteous. Shaking.

[Lex? Is that—are you—why is it so warm? It's never been this warm before.]**

He laughed. It came out of him like a sob.

Ember.

[Hello, little smith,] said Ember. [I'm so sorry I wasn't there. I couldn't find you. It was so dark.] A pause. [I could hear you, you know. Through the door. Every time you said my name. Every single time.] Another pause, and the voice cracked. [You said it a great many times.]

I missed you, Lex thought.

[I know,] said Ember softly. [I heard that too.]



HE OPENED HIS EYES.

He was kneeling in front of the hearth in the cave behind the ivy. The gold fire was burning steady and clear. Aurelian's little hammer was in his right hand, resting on the black iron anvil. His left hand was flat beside it.

Wren was kneeling on his left, her eyes still closed, her face lifted, her fox-red braid streaming in a wind that was slowly dying. Seraphine was kneeling on his right, her cracked spectacles askew, her pen forgotten on the floor. And Antho was behind him, on his knees, with his scarred hand flat between Lex's shoulder blades.

And they were all staring at him.

"Your eyes," whispered Wren.

He didn't need to ask. He could feel it. The gold behind them. The heat.

His panel came up on its own. It didn't wait to be called. It just *opened*, the way a door opens when someone's been waiting behind it, and the light that came off it was brighter than it had ever been. Gold and gold. Root-gold and something else. Something warmer. Something older.

LOCK – BROKEN

Method: UNKNOWN (non-Lattice)

LEX VEY

Class: EMBERWRIGHT (Unique)

– WELL-BOUND –

Tier II – Level 30

MIG 47 AGI 46 VIT 58

INT 42 SPI 112 RES 45

Well-bound: all stats +10%

(Flame, Stone)

ATTUNEMENT (integrated)

Flame ANSWERING

Stone LISTENING

ROOT

Seal integrity: 8%

Authority: 0 → 31 / 100

(Well-fed regeneration: ×4)

NOTE: A class drawing on the Wells

cannot be locked by Root alone.

Cannot be locked by Root alone.

He read it twice.

[You've done something that's never been done,] said Ember quietly.
[You've tied the wheel to the river. Not just turned it. Tied it.] A long pause.
[I don't think Elric can do that to you again. I don't think anyone can.]

Behind him, Antho took his hand off Lex's back. Lex heard him sit back on his heels. Heard him breathe, long and slow.

And beside the cave mouth, leaning on his staff in the ivy, Malachi was looking at them. All four of them. Kneeling in a row in front of a nine-hundred-year-old hearth that hadn't burned in nine hundred years until last night.

His shifting eyes were wet.

"Bellows," he said softly. "And a reader. And a quench." He shook his head slowly. "He tried to do it alone, you know. My brother. Every single thing. He tried to do every single thing alone." He wiped his eyes with the back of his gnarled hand. "Took you four of you. And a smith." He

laughed, shaky. "That's the answer to the Oracle's question, smith. That's how you mend a net from inside. Not one pair of hands." He looked at the four of them. "*All* of them."



LEX FOUND WREN ON the cliff that afternoon.

The one at the rim of the valley, where Malachi had made her step off into the wind. She was sitting on the edge with her legs dangling over the forty-foot drop, looking out over the white salt plain to the horizon. She'd been there since noon. She'd gone very quiet after the forge.

He sat down beside her.

"You were the bellows," he said.

"I was the bellows." She didn't look at him. "I didn't know I could do that. Call the wind like that. Make it go where I wanted." She was quiet for a moment. "It felt like climbing. Like the best climb I've ever done. Like reaching for a handhold you can't see and finding it there."

"It *was* there."

"I know." She looked down at her hands. "It's been there my whole life. Malachi says so. I just never knew." She laughed, very softly. "Twenty-four. Capped. *Further experience will not be recorded.* And the whole time, there was a whole other thing under it. A whole other mountain."

Lex looked at her.

"Wren," he said.

She turned her head.

"I've got thirty-one Authority," he said. "It's coming back fast. Four times faster than it used to, Ember says. Because the Wells are feeding it." He took a breath. "And Ember says Unbind's not locked anymore."

Wren went very still.

"It said Tier Three and sixty Authority, before," said Lex. "In the temple. But that was the wheel's rule. The wheel's lock for the wheel's key." He looked at her. "Ember says the Wells change it. It says someone who's Answering a Well is already halfway out of the cage. The Ceiling's only on the wheel. And you're not only on the wheel anymore. You've got Gale."

"How much?" said Wren. Her voice was barely there.

"Thirty," said Lex. "It costs thirty."

She stared at him.

"You've got thirty-one," she said.

"I know."

"You'd have one left. One. If anything happened. If something came out of the salt at us tonight, if Morvane sent something—"

"I know."

"*Hammer—*"

"You told me not to make promises for you," said Lex. "On the moor. Before the storm." He held her gaze. "You said make them for me. Not for you." He swallowed. "So here's one for me. I want to see you fly. Not for a heartbeat off a cliff. *Fly*. Like in the mirror. That's what I want." He reached out and took her hand. "And I want it *with* you. Not for you. With you. Is that all right?"

Wren looked at him for a long, long time. Her green eyes were very bright. Her jaw was very tight.

"You're an idiot, Hammer," she said. Her voice cracked down the middle. "You're the biggest idiot I ever met."

"I know."

"Do it," she said.



HE DID IT STANDING on the rim of the cliff, in the late afternoon light, with the wind coming off the white salt plain and stirring her braid.

He didn't know how. Nobody had ever told him. Ember had only said *Unbind breaks a Ceiling*. That was all. So he did it the way he did everything. Like a smith.

He put his palm flat on her chest, over her heart. The way he'd put it on Antho's in the Thornwood, the way Antho had put it on his in the dark forge that morning. He felt her heart under it, hammering.

He reached down past the silver. Past the gold. Down to the place where the river ran.

And he looked at her.

Not with True Sight. Deeper. With the Wells. With Flame and Stone, the way he'd look at a bar of iron before he decided what to make of it. And he saw her. Not her panel. *Her*. A girl made of wind and stubbornness and

freckles, who'd climbed every mountain she'd ever seen and never once looked down. And around her, like a band of iron around a barrel, like a hoop around a wheel, a Ceiling.

Grey. Plain. Indifferent. A flat line of silver-grey, drawn tight around her at the level of twenty-four. Holding her in. Holding her down.

It wasn't the Lattice's. He could see that now. The Lattice under it was gold, Founders' gold, Aurelian's gold, and it went up and up forever, the way the Founders had meant it to. The grey line had been drawn *on top* of it. Later. By someone else. A Warden, three hundred years ago, with a pen and a ledger and a reason.

It's just a band, he thought. *A hoop. Someone hammered it on. I can hammer it off.*

He used Unbind.

He felt the thirty points of Authority go out of him in a single rush. Felt them go down his arm, through his palm, into her. Felt them meet the grey band around her, the Ceiling, the hoop of iron.

And he *struck*.

Not with a hammer. With himself. With Flame, answering. With his Root, unlocked. With every bit of fire he had and every bit of love, the way he'd struck the iron door that morning, the way he'd struck the snake glyph on Elric's lock.

The grey band *broke*.



WREN GASPED.

She arched back, her eyes flying open, her hands coming up to clutch at his wrist. A sound came out of her that wasn't a word. And the wind, the wind that had been stirring her braid, *roared*. It came up off the white salt plain in a great gust and swept up the cliff face and around them, lifting her braid straight up, billowing her coat, pulling at both of them like a giant's hand.

Over her head, a panel exploded open. Silver at first. Then cracking. Then something else showing through. Not gold, not Root. *Pale*. Pale blue-grey, like the sky over a mountain at dawn.

UNBIND – EXECUTED

Ceiling: BROKEN

WREN ASHDOWN

Class: TRACKER (Common)

→ re-rolling...

→ PATHFINDER (Rare)

"One who finds the way where
there is no way."

Level cap: REMOVED

Recovered experience: applied

Level: 24 → 25 → 27 → 29 → 31

ATTUNEMENT (integrated)

Gale ANSWERING

Wren stood on the rim of the cliff with her hands clutching his wrist and the wind roaring around her, and stared at the panel only she could see. And Lex watched her face. Watched it go from shock to disbelief to something he'd never seen on it before. Not joy. Bigger than joy. Something that broke open, like a seed splitting, like a door swinging wide.

"*Thirty-one*," she whispered. "*Thirty-one. Lex. It says thirty-one. It says no cap. It says—*"

She let go of his wrist.

She turned around, and looked at the edge of the cliff, and the forty-foot drop, and the white salt plain stretching to the horizon, and the wide pale sky.

And she jumped.

Not stepped. *Jumped*. Out. Off the rim. Arms spread wide, braid streaming, into the roaring wind.

And the wind caught her.

It didn't drift her down this time, like a leaf. It took her *up*. Lifted her. Carried her. Up past the rim of the cliff, past Lex standing on the edge with his heart in his throat, up into the pale afternoon sky, higher and higher, a small slim figure in a patched coat with a fox-red braid streaming out behind her like a banner, turning, wheeling, *flying*.

He heard her laugh. All the way up. Wild and delighted and disbelieving, carried down to him on the wind.

And then, high above the white salt plain, she spread her arms wide, and shouted something into the sky that he couldn't hear but didn't need to.

FREE.



AND EVERYONE IN ALDERMERE saw it.

Lex didn't know at first. He was standing on the rim of the cliff with his head tipped back, watching her fly, with tears running down his face. He didn't notice the panel unrolling in front of his eyes until it was already there, silver and plain and enormous.

WORLD NOTICE

A CEILING HAS BEEN BROKEN.

For the first time in three hundred years, one born to the Ceiling now climbs without limit.

The Root has unbound her.

He stared at it.

[Every person under the Lattice just saw that,] said Ember quietly. *[Every farmer. Every miner. Every Warden. Every capped smith at every anvil in every village from here to the sea.]* A pause. *[Brannoc just saw it, Lex. And Pell. And that girl in Highcrest. And the High Warden in her tower.]*

Lex stood on the cliff and looked at the notice.

For the first time in three hundred years.

[And Morvane,] said Ember. *[And Elric.]*



WREN CAME DOWN AT sunset.

She came down slowly, spiraling, the wind lowering her gently, until her boots touched the grass on the rim of the cliff beside him. Her face was wind-burned and wet and glowing. Her braid had come completely undone, and her fox-red hair was a wild tangle around her head.

She didn't say anything. She just walked up to him and put her arms around his neck and kissed him. Long and slow. The way he'd kissed her on the stair at Avaloria.

When she pulled back, she was smiling. The real one. The one that snuck up on her.

"*With* you," she said.

"With you."

"Not for me."

"Not for you."

"Good." She leaned her forehead against his. "Because I'm going to pay you back, Hammer. Every single point. I'm going to fly so high and fight so hard and find so many ways where there's no way that you'll be sick of me."

"I'll never be sick of you."

"You will. I'm very annoying. Ask anyone." She laughed. It was shaky. "Thirty-one. Lady of Lanterns. *Thirty-one.*"

Behind them, someone coughed.

They broke apart. Malachi was standing a little way off, leaning on his staff. Antho and Seraphine were behind him. Antho was grinning, a real grin, the crooked one that was exactly like Lex's. Seraphine had her pen out and was writing furiously.

"Very touching," said Malachi. "Very romantic. I'm delighted for you both." He was smiling too. But his shifting eyes had gone a color Lex didn't like. Grey. Storm-grey. "You do know what you've just done, though. Don't you."

Lex looked at him.

"You've just told every person in the world that the Ceiling can be broken," said Malachi quietly. "Every capped smith and every capped miner and every capped farmer from here to the sea. Every one of them just learned that it isn't forever. That it was never forever. That someone *did* it to them." He leaned on his staff. "And every Warden in the Spire just learned the same thing. And the High Warden. And the thing in the east with the white face."

Nobody said anything.

"They'll be coming," said Malachi. "All of them. Some to beg you to do it for them. Some to kill you before you can." He looked at Lex. "You've

done a very good thing, smith. A very brave thing. A thing my brother should have done nine hundred years ago." His voice was quiet. "And now you'd better go. Because this valley isn't hidden anymore. Not from anyone."

Lex looked east. Over the white salt plain. Toward the far horizon where, weeks and weeks away, a black fortress stood around a wound in the world, and a man in a crystal was being slowly unpicked by a thing with a white face.

"Then we go," he said.

"Where?"

He thought about it.

He thought about Morvane's army, massing. About the three hundred at Fort Caldris who'd become one hundred, scattered across the hills. About Teodra Hale saying *get your fire back, then send for me*. About every capped smith and miner and farmer in Aldermere, looking at a World Notice that said *a Ceiling has been broken*.

"Home," he said. "To Ashbourne." He looked at Wren. At Antho. At Seraphine. "And every village between here and there."

"To do what?" said Antho.

Lex looked down at his hands. At the burn scars. At the calluses. At the faint gold glow that came off his skin now, all the time, steady, like a hearth that would never go out.

"To raise an army," he said.

CHAPTER 31

REDEMPTION'S EMBRACE



MALACHI CALLED A STORM for Ashka on their last night in the Stillwater.

He did it standing at the edge of the still pool, at dusk, with his staff raised and his shifting eyes gone the pale grey of a winter sky. He didn't shout. He didn't chant. He just *listened*, for a long time, with his head tilted, the way a man listens for a voice in another room. And then he said something, very softly, in a language Lex didn't know. Not Wellscrip. Older than Wellscrip.

And the sky answered.

Clouds came up over the rim of the valley from nowhere. Black and roiling and lit from within by flickers of white. The wind rose. The goats on the slopes fled bleating for the shelter of the trees. The surface of the still pool, which had not moved in nine hundred years, shivered.

And the lightning came down.

Ashka was waiting for it. She'd been waiting all afternoon, ever since Malachi told her what he was going to do, pacing up and down the bank of the pool with her wings half-spread and sparks crawling along her spines. When the first fork came down out of the black sky, she leaped up to meet it.

It struck her in midair. And she *drank* it.

Lex watched it happen. Watched the lightning pour into her, blue-white, crackling, so bright he had to shield his eyes. Watched her scales blaze. Watched her wings beat once, twice, and *grow*. The silver frame on

the left one stretched, and stretched, the runes he'd struck into it at Hedda's forge flaring gold as they let it grow. Her neck lengthened. Her tail. Her legs. Her whole body swelled, the way a fire swells when you throw dry wood on it, until the pony-sized drake who'd leaped off the bank was something much, much bigger.

The second fork came down. She drank that too.

The third.

By the time the storm passed, there was a dragon standing on the bank of the still pool. A real one. Horse-sized and more, lean and long and blue-grey and shimmering, with a crest of sharp spines running down her back and great storm-colored wings folded along her sides. The silver frame on the left one was almost invisible now, so fine compared to the size of her, like a spider's web on a sail. The torn membrane inside it had healed completely.

She turned her long narrow head and looked at Antho. Her golden eyes were the size of plates.

And a picture came into Lex's head, so loud it made him stagger. *Sky. Storm. Lightning in her belly like a feast. Antho on her back. FLYING. FLYING TOGETHER.*

Antho was staring at her with his mouth open.

ASHKA – Storm-Drake

GROWTH STAGE: Adolescent → Young Adult

Level 14 → 27

Wing damage: 38% → 0% (HEALED)

Rideable: YES (2 riders)

"Two riders," said Seraphine faintly, reading over Antho's shoulder. "It says two riders."

"Lady of Lanterns," said Wren.

Malachi lowered his staff. He was leaning on it heavily, Lex saw. His wrinkled face was grey with effort. But his shifting eyes were bright.

"There," he said. "Now you won't have to walk."



LEX SPENT THE REST of that night in Aurelian's forge.

He'd been planning it since the morning he broke the lock. He'd talked to Ember about it, and to Seraphine, and to Malachi, who'd sat on a rock by the hearth peeling apples and offering suggestions that were sometimes brilliant and sometimes insane and sometimes both. He'd gathered the iron: the last of the crossbow bolts, and the bent cracked bolt from the ruined tower with twelve dead *Hush* scratched into it, and a chunk of black ore that Stone had hummed at him from under the roots of an apple tree, deep in the valley floor.

And he forged a new lantern for his brother.

It was nothing like the first. The first had been made with the Lattice's fire, on Hedda's anvil, in a hurry, with Wardens on the streets outside. This one was made with Flame. With the Well-fire that had burned in Aurelian's hearth for the first time in nine hundred years. On Aurelian's anvil. With Aurelian's little hammer.

He didn't hurry.

He folded the bent bolt from the tower into the core of it, the one with twelve dead runes scratched into its surface, the failure. He didn't hide it. He folded it in where it would carry the weight, the way he'd folded the horseshoe nail into Anvilson. *What's broken and mended is stronger at the mend.* He worked the black ore from under the apple tree around it. And he struck runes.

Ardent, so it would burn without fuel.

Hush, twelve times. One for every ward-nail in the Hollowmaw. One for every dead rune on the bent bolt.

And a new one. One he'd never struck before. One Ember found for him in the *Book of Making*, on a page near the end, with a note beside it in Aurelian's tiny hand that Ember read aloud very softly: *For those who keep the dark, that the dark may keep them.*

Shelter.

When he quenched it, he didn't use water. He held it out into the night air at the mouth of the cave, and called softly through the Bloodbond, and Antho came. His brother stood at the mouth of the cave and held out his hands, and the Shade came off them, cool and soft and peaceful, and wrapped around the glowing lantern, and drew the heat out of it slowly, slowly, like night drawing the heat out of the day.

The lantern cooled to black. A deep black, darker than iron should be, with a faint gold glow at its heart where the little flame burned behind a chimney of clear crystal Malachi had given him. The runes on its frame shimmered: gold for the *Hush*, and something else, silver-dark, like starlight, for *Shelter*.

ITEM CREATED

THE KEEPER'S LANTERN (Well-forged)

Focus – Grade: LEGENDARY

Maker: Lex Vey, Emberwright

Forged with: FLAME (Well-fire)

Quenched with: SHADE (Anthoren Vey)

Runes:

ARDENT – burns without fuel

HUSH ×12 – dampens Hollow voices

SHELTER – the bearer's Shade

attunement holds the Hollow back

of its own accord

Clarity floor: +30

Clarity decay: -60%

Hollow voices cannot act

through the bearer while lit

"For those who keep the dark, that

the dark may keep them."

FIRST LEGENDARY CREATED

Runic Forging → Journeyman 6

Antho took it from him in silence. He hooked it onto his belt. He stood very still in the mouth of the cave with his eyes closed.

CLARITY: 71 → 84 ▲

84 → 92 ▲

 – BARRED

"Ninety-two," whispered Antho.

He opened his eyes. They were grey. Completely grey. Not a speck of black at the edges.

"It's never been ninety-two," he said. His voice shook. "Not once. Not since I was sixteen. Not in the Hollowmaw, not on the road, not at

Avaloria." He put his hand on the lantern. "It's still there. I can feel it. But it's—*outside*. Like a dog outside a door. It can scratch, but it can't get in."

"That's the Shelter rune," said Lex. "It's yours, really. Your Shade. The lantern just helps it remember to hold."

Antho looked at him for a long time.

Then he stepped forward and put his arms around his brother, and held on.

"I didn't look after you," he said into Lex's shoulder. "For eight years. Mam told me to look after you, and I ran away and hid in a cave."

"You've been looking after me since the Hollowmaw."

"Not enough."

"It's enough." Lex held on too. "It's always been enough, Antho. You came out of the cave. That was enough."



MALACHI DIDN'T COME WITH them.

Lex had known he wouldn't. He'd asked anyway, the evening before they left, sitting by the eternal fire in the hut for the last time. And the little man had shaken his head and smiled his gap-toothed smile.

"Not yet," he said. "I'm nine hundred and forty-one years old, smith. I don't travel well. And someone has to keep the old fire burning." He nodded at the hearth. "Besides, there's something I need to listen for. Something I've been listening for a long time." His smile faded. "Something that might be waking up."

"What?"

Malachi was quiet for a long moment. He looked into the fire.

"My brother," he said at last.

The hut was very still.

"He's not dead, you know," said Malachi. "Aurelian. Everyone thinks he died, nine hundred years ago, when he put himself into the net. He didn't. He's *in* it. At the root of it. In the deepest place, where the Lattice holds the hunger down. He's been there the whole time." His shifting eyes went very dark. "Holding it. Becoming it. And he's been very, very quiet, for a very long time. Quiet like a man asleep. Quiet like a man in a dream."

"And now?" said Antho softly.

"And now someone has stood in the heart of the Anchor and executed a Reckoning. And someone has broken a Ceiling. And the whole net has felt it. Every thread." Malachi looked up. "Things that shake the net wake things that sleep in it."

Nobody said anything.

"I don't know that he's waking," said Malachi. "I don't know anything. I'm an old man who listens to fires." He leaned on his staff. "But if he is. If he ever speaks to you, either of you, any of you." His shifting eyes went to Lex. Then to Antho. "Don't trust him. Whatever he says. However kind. However wise. However much it sounds like the truth." His voice dropped. "He was my brother, and I loved him, and I still love him. But he's been holding the hunger for nine hundred years. And whoever holds it—"

"—it will try to become," said Antho quietly.

Malachi looked at him for a long moment.

"Yes," he said. "That."



IN THE MORNING, HE gave Lex the hammer.

Aurelian's little hand-hammer, with the open hand and the flame on its head. He held it out across the threshold of the hut, in the grey dawn light, while Ashka shifted and snorted on the bank of the still pool and the others loaded their packs onto her back.

"I can't," said Lex. "It's his. It's yours. You've kept it for nine hundred years."

"I've kept it for someone of the blood with the gift of the forge," said Malachi. "That's what he asked me. *Keep it for me, Mal. I won't need it where I'm going.*" He pressed it into Lex's hand and folded his gnarled brown fingers over Lex's own. The way, Lex thought, with a strange lurch in his chest, his father had once folded a little boy's fingers closed over a horseshoe nail in a muddy road. "He didn't say keep it for *him*. He said keep it for *me*. Meaning: until I didn't need to keep it anymore." He let go. "I don't need to keep it anymore."

Lex looked down at the little hammer in his hand.

"Thank you," he said.

"Don't thank me, smith." Malachi's shifting eyes were very bright. "Thank me by coming back. All of you. When it's done." He grinned. "I want to hear how the story ends. I've been waiting nine hundred years to hear how it ends."



THEY FLEW EAST.

Ashka carried two: Antho, always, on her neck, with his hands buried in her crest; and one other, taking turns. Seraphine, mostly, because her leg was still weak. Lex and Wren walked when the ground allowed it, and rode when it didn't. And Wren, more and more, flew.

She didn't need Ashka. She'd step off a ridge into the wind and the wind would take her, the way it had taken her off the cliff in the Stillwater, and she'd soar out ahead of them, high and far, scouting, her fox-red braid streaming. She couldn't stay up long. An hour, at first. Then two. Gale was Answering her, but it was still learning her, and she was still learning it. When she got tired, she'd come down in long gentle spirals and land beside Lex and walk for a while, flushed and laughing and windburned.

WREN ASHDOWN

Class: PATHFINDER (Rare)

Tier II – Level 33

New skill: WINDSTEP

Walk upon the wind.

Duration: 2 hrs (Gale-fed)

They crossed the white salt in four days, flying and walking. It had taken them nineteen on foot.

And on the fifth day, they came down out of the hills on the eastern edge of the Wastes into the Blightmarch.



THE BLIGHTMARCH WAS GREY.

Lex had known it would be. He'd heard it from Elric, from Seraphine, from Garrick. *The whole eastern province, gone grey.* He'd seen the grey on the north road at Ashbourne, on the bear in the mountains, on the miller's village. He thought he was ready.

He wasn't.

It went on forever. Rolling hills, once green, now the dead flat grey of ash. Trees, once leafy, standing bare and grey and still, their branches like the fingers of dead men. Rivers running grey and sluggish between grey banks. No birds. No insects. No wind. The Gloam lay over everything like a fog that never lifted, thick in the low places, thin on the hills, and the smell of it was everywhere: wet ash, rot, nothing.

And the silence. The total, perfect silence. Not even their own footsteps made much sound here. It was like walking through a world stuffed with wool.

"This was farmland," said Seraphine quietly from Ashka's back. "The best farmland in Vhessa. They called it the Granary of the East." She was looking out over the grey hills with her cracked spectacles. "Forty thousand people lived here. Sixteen years ago."

"Where are they now?" said Wren.

Nobody answered.



THEY FOUND FENMOOR ON the second day.

Wren found it, from the air. She came down out of the grey sky in a long fast dive and landed beside Lex, and her face was white.

"There's a village," she said. "Two miles south. In a valley." She swallowed. "There are people in it."

"Gloamed?"

"No. Yes. I don't—" She stopped. "Some of them. Not all. Some of them are *working*." She looked at Lex. "You need to see it."

They went on foot, to stay low. They crept up the last grey ridge on their bellies and looked down into the valley below.

It had been a village once. Small. Thirty houses, maybe, around a green, with a chapel at one end and a Lattice Stone in the middle. The houses were still standing. Grey, like everything else, but standing.

And there were people everywhere.

Most of them were standing still. In rows. At the edges of the green, along the lanes, outside the doors of the houses. Grey-skinned, white-eyed,

motionless. The Quiet. Like the ones Seraphine's letter had described. Like the ones Elric had seen on the border.

But in the middle of the village, there were others. Not standing still. *Working*. Thirty or forty of them, maybe. Men and women, old and young, thin and ragged and grey-faced. But not white-eyed. Their eyes were their own, brown and blue and green. And they were digging. With shovels and picks and their bare hands. A great trench, running across the village green, straight as a ruled line, west.

And as they dug, they were watched.

A thing stood at the head of the trench. Tall. Grey. Stretched, like the Gloamed miller had been. But it wasn't carrying a millstone. It was carrying a whip. A long black whip that dripped Gloam. And when one of the diggers slowed, or stumbled, or stopped to wipe their face, the thing cracked the whip, and the whip touched them, and they went *grey*. A little. A patch of their skin, where the whip had struck. And they flinched, and picked up their shovels, and dug faster.

"*Lady*," whispered Wren.

"They're making a road," said Antho. His voice was very flat. "Look at the line. It goes west. Straight west. Toward Caldor."

"For the army," said Seraphine. "Morvane's army. A road of Gloam. So it can march faster."

"And they're using *people* to dig it." Lex's hands had curled into fists on the grey ash of the ridge. The heat was coming off him. He could feel the grey grass around his fingers start to smoke. "Ordinary people. Not Quiet. Not yet." He swallowed. "He's keeping them awake. Just long enough to dig."

"And when they're done?" said Wren.

Nobody answered.

Below them, in the trench, a girl stumbled. Thin and small and dark-haired, fifteen or sixteen, in a patched brown dress. She went down to her knees in the grey earth with her shovel in her hands. And the tall grey thing with the whip turned its blank white eyes toward her, and raised its arm.

Lex stood up.



HE DIDN'T THINK ABOUT it. He just stood up on the ridge and went down the slope toward the village, with Anvilson in his hands and gold fire pouring off him, and somewhere behind him he heard Wren swear and Antho call his name and Ashka roar.

The Quiet turned their heads.

All of them. At once. Hundreds of grey faces with white eyes, turning toward him in perfect silence. Not attacking. Just *looking*. And the whisper came. Soft. From everywhere. From all of them.

[quiet ... be quiet ... bright one ... be quiet ...]

He walked through them.

They didn't stop him. They didn't move. They stood in their rows and watched him pass, and the whisper rose and fell around him like wind in dead grass, and he walked through them down the lane toward the green, toward the trench, toward the tall grey thing with the whip.

It saw him coming. It turned. It lowered its arm.

GLOAMED OVERSEER

Level 34 – ELITE

Corruption: 91%

The girl in the trench looked up. She saw him. Her eyes went wide.

The overseer raised its whip again. Not toward the girl. Toward Lex.

He didn't use Ember Strike. He didn't use Heat Shaping or Ironskin or Slag Shot or anything the Lattice had given him. He reached down, under the wheel, to the river. To Flame. And he told it the truth.

They're people, he told it. Just people. Like Brannoc. Like Pell. Like Wren's mother. And that thing is hurting them. And I want it to stop.

The whip came down.

And the fire came up.

Not from Anvilson. From the ground. From the grey earth of the village green itself, where the Gloam had soaked in so deep that nothing had grown in sixteen years. Gold fire. Rising up out of the ash in a ring around the overseer, around its feet, around its legs. Not burning the ground. Not burning the trench, or the diggers, or the grey houses. Burning *only the Gloam*. The fire found the black in the grey earth and ate

it, the way Lex's fire had eaten the cold in the gloamhound's bite, the way the eternal fire in Malachi's hut had eaten the splinter of stolen Root from Seraphine's chest.

The overseer screamed.

It was the same scream the Gloamed miller had made. Many voices at once. The Gloam pouring out of it in a black gout, writhing, and the gold fire catching it and tearing it apart. The tall stretched body shrinking, collapsing, the grey skin crumbling. The whip falling from its fingers and dissolving in the air.

And on the grey earth at the edge of the trench, where the overseer had been, a man. Lying on his back. Middle-aged. Bearded. In the remains of a reeve's robe.

Breathing.

GLOAMED OVERSEER – PURGED

Host: ALIVE

ATTUNEMENT: Flame – ANSWERING

New expression: PURGING FIRE

[UNTRACKED]

Lex stood in the middle of the village green with the gold fire dying down around his feet and looked at the diggers in the trench.

Forty of them. Thin and grey-faced and ragged. Staring at him with their own eyes. Brown and blue and green.

Nobody moved.

Then the girl in the brown dress, the one who'd fallen, climbed slowly up out of the trench. She stood on the edge of it in front of him with her shovel still clutched in her hands. She was shaking.

"Who are you?" she whispered.

Lex looked at her. At her thin face, her dark hair, her eyes. She looked so much like the girl in Highcrest that his chest hurt.

"My name's Lex," he said. "I'm a smith."



THEY FREED FENMOOR THAT day.

It took all of them.

Antho walked among the Quiet. All of them. Hundreds. Standing in their rows along the lanes and around the green. He went up to them one at a time, the way he'd gone to the Drowned Dead on the causeway, and laid his scarred hand on their chests, and *listened*. With Shade, now. Not with the broken Hollow-touched dark that had always risked the thief. With the Well. The deep, soft, peaceful dark between the stars.

And the Gloam came out of them.

Not all of them. Some were too far gone. Some had been Quiet too long, years, since the first year after Vhessa, and when Antho laid his hand on them, there was nothing left to call back. Only grey. Only silence. Those, he left. Gently. With his hand on their shoulder and his head bowed. And moved on.

But many came back. The ones who'd been taken recently, in the last year, the last months. Antho drew the Gloam out of them with Shade, and Lex burned it with Flame as it came, and they blinked, and their white eyes went brown and blue and green, and they looked around at the grey village as if waking from a long dream.

"*Quiet*," one old woman kept saying, when her eyes came back. "*It was so quiet. I couldn't hear anything. I couldn't hear my own heart.*"

Seraphine went among the freed ones with her paper and her pen and wrote down their names. All of them. *For whoever comes looking*, she said. *So they'll know who was here.*

Wren flew. Up and around, in wide circles over the valley, watching the grey hills for anything coming. Nothing came. Not that day.

And Lex went to the Stone.



IT WAS IN THE middle of the green, a few paces from the end of the trench. Small and grey and lichened, chest-high, roughly the shape of a gravestone. Like the Stone at Ashbourne. So like the Stone at Ashbourne that his heart turned over. It wasn't cracked. But it was grey. Not glowing at all. The Veil didn't gather around it. The Gloam had soaked into it like ink into a sponge.

He put his hand on it.

He could feel the Lattice in it. Faint. Struggling. The silver threads, choked with grey. And under them, the gold. Founders' gold. Aurelian's gold. Still there. Still holding, just barely.

And around the gold, around every thread, a grey band. The Ceiling. Thirty, forty grey bands, wrapped around thirty or forty threads. One for every capped person in the village.

[You can't do them all,] said Ember quietly. *[Not one at a time. You have twenty-three Authority. Unbind costs thirty.]*

I know.

[And most of them aren't Answering a Well. They're not halfway out of the cage, the way Wren was. It would cost more for them, not less.]

I know.

He stood with his hand on the grey Stone and thought about it.

It's a Stone, he thought slowly. *It's connected to the net. All the threads in this village run through it. It's like—* He stopped. *It's like an anvil. Everything that's forged in this village gets forged on it.*

[Lex—]

What if I don't Unbind them? One at a time? He pressed his palm flatter. *What if I Unbind the Stone?*

Ember was silent for a long moment.

[That's—] it began. And stopped. And started again. *[That's either the cleverest thing you've ever thought of or the stupidest. I genuinely can't tell which.]*

Can I do it?

[I don't know. Nobody's ever tried. Nobody's ever had Unbind, except the Founders. And they never needed to.] A pause. *[But the Stone's a node. A knot in the net. If you broke the Ceilings at the knot—at the source—it might break them for every thread that runs through it.]* Another pause. *[It would cost more than you have. Much more.]*

Lex looked across the green.

Antho was kneeling beside an old man in a Quiet row, his hand on the man's chest, his eyes closed. The Keeper's Lantern glowed steady at his belt. Ninety-one. Ninety-two.

Antho, Lex thought, through the Bloodbond.

His brother's head came up.



THEY DID IT TOGETHER. At sunset. With the whole village watching.

Lex on one side of the grey Stone, Antho on the other. Their hands flat on its cold surface, the way their hands had lain on the Twin Stone at Caldris, on the plates of the Bridge of Two Hands. Reaching for each other through it.

Shared Authority. Lex's twenty-three. Antho's strange, broken, unmeasurable store, deep as a well with no bottom.

And the Wells. Flame, from Lex, answering. Shade, from Antho, answering. Hot and cold. Bright and deep. The forge and the quench.

They reached into the Stone together. Down past the grey, past the silver, to the gold. To the knot where every thread in Fenmoor was tied.

And they found the Ceilings.

Thirty-eight grey bands. Wrapped around thirty-eight gold threads. One for every capped person in the village. Tight. Grey. Indifferent.

Together, said Antho.

Together.

Lex struck. Antho held.

It was like breaking the lock in the dark forge, only bigger. So much bigger. Lex felt the Authority drain out of him, out of both of them, in a single great rush. Felt the Stone groan under their hands. Felt the grey bands strain, and stretch, and resist.

And then the Wells came up under them like a tide coming in under a beached ship.

The grey bands *broke*.

All thirty-eight of them. At once. Like hoops bursting off a barrel. Like chains snapping. The sound of it went out through the Stone and into the net and out across the grey valley, a sound like a great bell ringing, and the Stone *blazed*.

Gold. The Gloam burned out of it in a single flash. And the Veil, the silver mist that hadn't gathered around it in sixteen years, came rushing back. Out of the grey air, out of the grey earth, swirling in around the Stone like water rushing into a drained pond, glowing, bright.

All across the village green, people were gasping. Crying out. Clutching their chests. Staring at panels only they could see.

UNBIND (STONE) – EXECUTED

Stone of Fenmoor: CEILINGS BROKEN

38 bound threads: UNBOUND

Authority expended:

Lex: 23 → 0

Anthoren:  → 

The girl in the brown dress was standing at the edge of the trench with her shovel still in her hands. She was staring at nothing. Tears were running down her face.

"*Healer*," she whispered. "It says *Healer*. It said *Laborer*. When I was Kindled. Last year. It said *Laborer, Common*." She looked up at Lex across the blazing Stone. "Now it says *Healer. Rare*. And there's no—there's no number at the end. There's no *cap*."

Lex couldn't speak.

All around the green, it was the same. People staring at their panels. People weeping. People laughing. An old man who'd been a *Farmhand* for forty years staring at the word *Herbalist* and sitting down very suddenly in the grey grass. A young man who'd been a *Laborer* holding up his hands and staring at them, at the faint blue light crackling between his fingers. *Stormcaller*, he was saying. *Stormcaller. Uncommon. Stormcaller.*

And the reeve, the man who had been the overseer, sitting up on the grey earth at the edge of the trench with his head in his hands, rocking.

Lex took his hand off the Stone. His legs were shaking. He had nothing left. No Authority. Hardly any mana. He felt like he'd hammered iron for three days without stopping.

Antho came around the Stone and caught him before he fell.

"*Thirty-eight*," his brother said. His voice was wondering. "Lex. Thirty-eight people. At once."

"I know."

"No World Notice." Antho looked up at the sky, as if expecting one. "Only the first one gets a notice. I suppose." He laughed. Shaky. "Just

thirty-eight people in a grey village in the middle of nowhere, who'll never be capped again."



THAT NIGHT, THE PEOPLE of Fenmoor lit a fire on the village green.

A real one. A bonfire. Of grey wood, dead wood, from the grey trees and the grey fences and the grey door of the reeve's house, which the reeve tore off its hinges himself and threw on the pile. Lex lit it with Flame. It burned gold.

And they sat around it, the thirty-eight unbound and the hundred-some freed from the Quiet and the four strangers and the dragon. They didn't say much. They didn't need to. They sat around the fire in the middle of the grey Blightmarch, the first fire Fenmoor had seen in two years, and warmed their hands, and looked at their panels, and wept, and laughed.

The girl in the brown dress came and sat down next to Lex.

Her name was Ilsa. She was sixteen. She'd been Kindled at the Fenmoor Stone the spring before the Gloam came, and gotten *Laborer*, and cried for a week. And then the Gloam had come, and the overseer, and the trench.

"What happens now?" she said. "When you leave. The thing in the east will send more. More overseers. More Gloam. We're in the middle of it. There's nowhere to go."

Lex looked at the fire.

"Come with us," he said.

Ilsa stared at him.

"All of you. Everyone who can walk. Everyone who wants to." He looked around the fire. At the thirty-eight with their new classes. At the freed Quiet, blinking in the firelight. "We're going west. To my village. Ashbourne. In the Vale. And every village between here and there." He swallowed. "We're going to do this. Everywhere we can. Free the Gloamed. Break the Ceilings. And then we're going to march east, and go into the thing's house, and take back what it stole."

"What did it steal?"

"My father," said Lex.

Ilsa looked at him for a long moment. Then she looked at her hands. At the faint warm glow that came off them now, that hadn't been there yesterday.

"I'm a Healer," she said slowly. "A Rare one. With no cap." She looked up. "Armies need healers. Don't they?"

"They do," said Lex.

"Then I'll come," said Ilsa.

All around the fire, people were listening. And one by one, slowly, they nodded.



THEY LEFT FENMOOR AT dawn. Two hundred people. Walking west through the grey Blightmarch toward the green.

And on the second day out, they met a man coming the other way.

He was a peddler. A thin, frightened, grey-faced man with a pack on his back and a mule with a cart, fleeing east, of all directions, toward the Blightmarch. He stopped dead in the road when he saw two hundred people and a dragon coming toward him, and went white as chalk, and tried to turn the mule around.

Wren dropped out of the sky in front of him and he screamed.

"*Easy*," said Wren. "Easy. We're not Gloamed. Where are you running from? Why east? Nobody runs *east*."

"The Vale," gasped the peddler. "The southern Vale. Under the Greyspine." He was shaking. "The black stuff came down off the mountains. A week ago. A whole river of it. Out of a hole in the Hollowmaw. The ward broke." He swallowed. "It's all gone grey. Thistledown. Coldwater. Millbridge." He looked at Lex. At the gold coming off his skin. At his face. "*Ashbourne*."

Lex went cold all over.

"The ward broke," he said. His voice sounded very far away. "In the Hollowmaw. The nails."

"I don't know about nails. I don't know about wards." The peddler was backing his mule away. "I just know it came down the north road like a flood, and everyone it touched went grey. And there's a thing in the middle

of it. In Ashbourne. On the green. A tall white thing." He shuddered. "And it's taken the Stone."

Behind Lex, he heard Antho make a sound.

The nails. Twelve ward-nails, forged from Warden crossbows, struck with *Bind*. Ninety-four percent. *For a good long while. Months, at least.*

It had been months.

And the man who'd made the green fire around the breach, who'd been holding it shut for four years, had been away. Far away. With his brother.

"*Ashbourne*," whispered Antho.

Lex turned and looked west. Toward the green. Toward the Greyspine. Toward the Vale, and the village, and the forge, and an old smith standing at the edge of the cobbles with his hand raised.

Hammer-oath. What's struck on the anvil holds.

"Ashka," he said. His voice was very quiet. "How fast can you fly?"

CHAPTER 32

THE UNBINDING



ASHKA FLEW FOR TWO days without stopping.

She carried Lex and Antho on her back, one behind the other, Antho on her neck with his hands buried in her crest and Lex behind him with his arms around his brother's waist and Anvilsong strapped across his back. She flew west over the grey Blightmarch and then over the green hills of Caldor beyond it, high and fast, her great storm-colored wings beating in a steady rhythm that Lex felt through his whole body like a heartbeat. She didn't stop to eat. She didn't stop to rest. When night came, she flew through it, by starlight. When she grew tired, she found the wind, the high cold river of wind that ran west across Aldermere above the clouds, and rode it.

Wren flew beside them.

She couldn't keep up all the time. Her Windstep lasted hours now, not minutes, but not days. When she tired, she'd drop down onto Ashka's back behind Lex, and he'd hold her while she slept, a few hours, against his chest, with the wind howling past. And then she'd wake, and step off into the air again.

Seraphine had stayed with the column from Fenmoor. Two hundred people, walking west. Someone had to lead them, she said. Someone who could read maps and wards and knew which roads the Wardens used. And Ilsa, the new Healer, had stood beside her with her thin chin raised and said *I'll help*. Lex had looked at the two of them, the burned scholar with her

cracked spectacles and the starved girl with her shovel-blistered hands, and thought they were the bravest people he'd ever seen.

"Go," Seraphine had said. She'd been looking at Antho. Not at Lex. "Go home. We'll be right behind you."

Antho had looked at her for a long time. Then he'd done something Lex had never seen him do. He'd stepped forward and kissed her on the forehead, quick and clumsy, and then turned away and climbed onto Ashka's back and not looked at anyone.

Seraphine had stood in the road with her hand on her forehead and her face bright red, and Wren had laughed so hard she'd had to sit down.



THEY CAME OVER THE northern arm of the Greyspine on the evening of the second day, and saw the Vale.

It was grey.

All of it. The whole long green valley Lex had been born in. Grey. The fields, grey. The hedgerows, grey. The river, a sluggish grey ribbon winding through grey meadows. The chestnut woods on the lower slopes, grey skeletons. And over all of it, lying thick in every hollow and dip, rolling slow and heavy down every gully from the mountains, the Gloam.

It came from the north. From the mountains. Lex could see it. A great black river of it, pouring down out of the high Greyspine like smoke from a chimney, down the gullies, down the slopes, spreading out over the Vale like ink spilled across a page. Its source was high above them, in the face of the highest mountain, where a great black cleft split the rock.

The Hollowmaw.

"No," whispered Antho.

The Gloam was pouring out of the cleft. Not a trickle. Not threads, curling up against an invisible wall. A *flood*. Black and endless, as if the mountain itself were bleeding.

The ward had broken. The ring of charcoal stones. The twelve ward-nails. Ninety-four percent. All gone.

And above the cleft, on the dark face of the mountain, so small it was almost nothing, there was a light.

Gold. Steady. Burning.

Seren's lamp.

Still burning. On its rock above the Hollowmaw, facing out over the world. Through the flood, through the Gloam, through the grey. The only light in all the darkened mountains.

Burns without fuel while the maker lives.

Antho made a sound. It wasn't a word.



THEY LANDED ON A ridge above the Vale, in the last of the light. Ashka was shaking with exhaustion. She folded her great wings and lay down in the grey heather and closed her golden eyes.

Antho slid off her neck and stood on the ridge, looking up at the Hollowmaw. At the black river pouring out of it. At the tiny gold light above it.

"I have to go up there," he said.

Lex had known he would say it. He'd known since the peddler on the road. He'd known since he saw the flood.

"Ashbourne," he said. "Brannoc. Everyone—"

"I know." Antho didn't look at him. "I know, Lex. Go. Go to Ashbourne. Save them." His jaw was tight. "But if I don't go up there and shut that door, there won't *be* an Ashbourne. Or a Thistledown. Or a Vale. It'll just keep coming. Forever. Until the whole south is grey." He finally turned his head. His grey eyes were very steady. The Keeper's Lantern glowed at his belt. "I keep the door, Lex. That's what I am. I said it on the silver road. I meant it."

"You'll be alone."

"I've been alone with it before."

"Not like this. Not with it this big."

"No," Antho agreed. "Not like this." Something moved at the corner of his mouth. "But I've got a Legendary lantern now. And Shade. And a dragon." He looked at Ashka, sprawled exhausted in the heather. "Once she's rested."

Lex stared at his brother.

He thought about the Hollowmaw. The cave full of lanterns. The breach in the cavern floor. Four years of his brother sitting on top of it,

alone, holding it shut with charcoal glyphs and stubbornness, while the thing at the bottom of it whispered in his head every waking minute.

Distance weakens the pull. The further he goes, the less purchase it has.

"It'll be stronger," Lex said. "Close to it. The thing in you. The link."

"I know."

"Your Clarity—"

"Is ninety-two." Antho put his hand on the lantern. "Ninety-two, Lex. It's never been ninety-two." He took a breath. "And I'm not going up there to sit on it this time. I'm not going to *hold* it." His grey eyes went dark. Not black. The soft deep dark of Shade. The sky between the stars. "I'm going to *close* it."

"Can you?"

"I don't know," said Antho. "Malachi thought I might. If I listened hard enough." He looked up at the mountain. At the tiny gold light. "And I've got something to listen *for*, now."

Lex looked at the lamp. Small and gold and steady. A light left on for the lost.

"Go," he said.



ANTHO WENT AT DAWN.

Ashka had slept the night through. She woke in the grey morning and stretched and shook her great wings and looked at Antho, and Antho climbed onto her neck without a word. He looked down at Lex.

"Don't die," he said.

"You either."

"I'll try." His brother's mouth twisted. "If I'm not back in three days—"

"You'll be back."

"If I'm not." Antho looked at him steadily. "Don't come after me. Don't. Do you understand? If I'm not back, it means I couldn't close it, and the thing's got me. And if you come up there, it'll get you too." His voice was very quiet. "Promise me."

Lex didn't answer.

"*Promise me*, Lex."

"I promise," Lex lied.

Antho looked at him for a long moment. Then he laughed, very softly.

"You're a terrible liar," he said. "You always were. Even when you were four."

Ashka spread her wings and leaped off the ridge, and caught the wind, and climbed. Up and up, toward the high grey peaks, toward the black river pouring out of the cleft in the mountain, toward the tiny gold light burning above it. Lex watched them until they were a speck against the sky. Then until they were nothing.

Wren put her hand in his.

"Come on, Hammer," she said quietly. "Let's go home."



THEY CAME DOWN INTO Ashbourne at noon.

There was no sun. The Gloam lay so thick over the Vale that the light was grey and flat and dim, like the light at the bottom of a pond. The road down from the foothills was grey dust. The fields on either side were grey. A grey crow sat motionless on a grey fence post and didn't move as they passed, and Lex saw that its eyes were white.

He'd walked this road a thousand times. Up to the high pastures with Brannoc to fetch the summer sheep. Down from the woods with a load of charcoal on his back. Up toward the mountains, three months ago, with Elric Thorne beside him and a hammer on his shoulder.

He didn't recognize it.

Then they came over the last rise, and he saw the village.

The roofs were grey. The walls were grey. The chestnut trees on the green were grey skeletons. The mill wheel on the river was still. The chapel steeple, which had been white, was grey. The Crooked Kettle was grey.

And on the green, there were people. Standing in rows.

The Quiet.

He knew them. Every one. Even from here, even grey, even motionless, he knew them. Farmer Tobbin, standing at the end of a row with his big farmer's hands hanging at his sides. Sister Agathe from the chapel. The Dunstan twins, side by side, the same height, the same grey faces, the same white eyes. Reeve Dunstan behind them. Gaffer Wim. The Tanners. Half

the village. More than half. Standing in silent rows on the grey green, facing inward.

Facing the Stone.

The old cracked Lattice Stone, in the middle of the green, where Lex had been Kindled three years ago. Where Elric had cut his thumb and the gold had poured out of the crack and lit the whole valley. It was black now. Not grey. *Black*. The crack down its face was black, and black veins ran out from the crack across the stone like cracks across ice. Like the veins under Morvane's skin.

And standing beside it, with one hand resting on the black Stone, there was a man.

Tall. Very thin. All length and no width. In a long black coat buttoned to the throat, though the coat wasn't black anymore. It was grey. And the man's face wasn't pale anymore. It was *white*. Chalk-white. Bone-white. With black veins running under the skin. His slicked black hair had gone white too, and hung loose around his narrow skull.

And around his left forearm, from wrist to elbow, he wore a chain. Not silver-black anymore. Just black. Dripping. Like the overseer's whip at Fenmoor.

"*Vane*," whispered Wren.

LUCIUS VANE

Class: GRAND INQUISITOR (*Epic*)

→ CORRUPTED: HOLLOW INQUISITOR

Tier III – Level 63

Corruption: 94%

The Inquisitor-General turned his head. Slowly. And looked up the road, at the rise, at the two figures standing on it.

His eyes were white.

He smiled.

"*Lexander Harrow*," he said. His voice carried across the grey village in the dead silent air. Cold and thin and precise, as it had always been. And under it, a second voice. Wet and soft. "*I knew you'd come home. Everyone comes home in the end.*"



"WHERE'S BRANNOC?" LEX SAID. His voice was very quiet. "I don't see Brannoc."

Wren was scanning the rows of the Quiet with her tracker's eyes. "He's not there. Neither's Pell. Or the woman from the tavern. Or the old one with the stick."

"Then where—"

"*There*," said Wren.

She was pointing. Across the green. Past the rows of Quiet, past the black Stone. To the far side of the green, where a low building of grey stone stood with its door open and a column of smoke rising from its chimney.

Not grey smoke. *Orange*. Lit from below by fire.

The forge.

And in its window, the window that faced the green, there was a lantern. Burning. Gold. In the middle of the grey day.

A light left on for the lost.

Lex's heart stopped.

"*Ahh*," said Vane. He'd followed Lex's gaze. His white eyes narrowed. "*The forge. Yes. Your old master's forge.*" His voice was soft and wet and amused. "*The one place in this village I haven't been able to quiet. He's been holding it for six days. The old man. With his hammer and his fire. Every time my Quiet go near it, he burns them.*" The smile widened. "*I don't know how. A capped smith. Level twenty-four. He shouldn't be able to do anything at all.*"

He lifted his hand off the black Stone.

"*But I have the Stone now*," he said. "*And through the Stone, I have everyone who was ever Kindled at it. Every thread.*" He turned his white eyes back to the forge. "*Tonight, I was going to reach through it and take him. Him and the boy and the women and the children hiding behind him. All at once.*" He looked back at Lex. "*But now you're here. So I'll take you first.*"

The black chain on his arm uncoiled.



IT CAME ACROSS THE green like a striking snake, dripping, black. Lex had seen it before. In Hedda's shop. In the drain. On the quay. He knew how fast it was.

He didn't dodge. He didn't need to. He reached down under the wheel to the river and *told the truth*.

This is my home, he told Flame. *These are my people. That man is wearing their silence like a coat. And I want him gone.*

The fire came up from the ground.

Not around Vane. Around *Lex*. A ring of gold flame rising out of the grey dust of the road, waist-high, roaring. The black chain hit it and *shrieked*. The Gloam on its links boiled away in a gout of black steam. The chain itself, the old Severance chain underneath, came through the fire glowing red, and struck Lex across the chest.

And did nothing.

He felt the glyphs on it try to cut him. *Sever. Sever. Sever.* Felt them reach for his silver threads, his Lattice threads. Felt them find them, and cut, and keep cutting.

And felt the gold underneath hold. And the river underneath *that*.

A class drawing on the Wells cannot be locked by Root alone.

Or severed by chains.

He reached up and grabbed the chain in his bare hand and *pulled*.

Vane came off his feet. He flew across the green toward Lex like a fish yanked out of a river, his long white coat flapping, his white eyes wide with shock. Lex let go of the chain and swung Anvilson in a single flat arc and caught the Inquisitor-General in the chest with an Ember Strike that lit the whole grey green gold for an instant.

Vane hit the ground thirty paces away and rolled and came up on his feet.

He was smoking. His grey coat was scorched. But he was smiling.

"*Oh*," he said softly. "*Oh, you've changed. You've grown.*" He tilted his narrow head. "*The Pale Warden told me you'd been locked. Emptied. That you were nothing now.*" His smile widened. "*How wonderful. You're more.*"

He lifted both arms.

And the Quiet came.

All of them. Every grey white-eyed figure on the green. They turned, at once, in perfect silence, and began to walk toward Lex. Farmer Tobbin. Sister Agathe. The Dunstan twins. Reeve Dunstan. Gaffer Wim. The Tanners. Half of Ashbourne. Walking toward him with their grey hands

reaching and their white eyes fixed and the whisper rising from every one of them, soft and wet.

[quiet ... quiet ... be quiet ... little smith ... be quiet ...]

Lex stopped.

He couldn't burn them. He *wouldn't*. They were his people. He'd shod their horses and mended their kettles and hinged their doors. The Dunstan twins had demanded one more *pfoom* on the morning he left.

"*Hammer!*" Wren shouted. She'd stepped up into the air, Windstep, hanging above the road with her bow drawn and an arrow burning gold on the string. Kindled. "*What do we do? I can't shoot them! It's the twins! It's the twins, Lex!*"

He didn't know.

The Quiet came closer. Ten paces. Five. Grey hands reaching.

And from across the green, from the open door of the forge, came a sound.

CHANG.



IT WAS A HAMMER on an anvil.

A big hammer. A sledge. Struck hard and true on good iron. Lex knew the sound. He'd heard it every day of his life since he was eleven. He'd know it in his sleep. He'd know it dead.

CHANG.

The Quiet stopped.

All of them. At once. They turned their grey heads toward the forge.

CHANG.

And in the doorway of the forge, enormous, bald as an egg, bearded like a thundercloud, with a twelve-pound sledge in his fists and a soot-black leather apron over a shirt that was grey with ash and dark with sweat, stood Brannoc Holt.

He wasn't grey. His face was red. Red and streaked with soot and running with sweat, his eyes bloodshot, his beard singed. He looked like he hadn't slept in six days. He probably hadn't. But he wasn't grey.

Behind him, in the forge, Lex could see the fire. Roaring. Orange and gold. And in front of it, the anvil. The one he and Brannoc had forged Anvilson on. Glowing faintly, all along its face, with a warm gold light.

Brannoc looked across the green at the Quiet. At Vane. At the black Stone.

And at Lex.

The big smith's face did something Lex would remember for the rest of his life.

"*Lad,*" he said. His voice was hoarse. Cracked. Barely there. "*Lad. You came back.*"

"Hammer-oath," said Lex. His own voice wasn't much better.

Brannoc lifted the sledge.

"*What's struck on the anvil holds,*" he said.

And brought it down.

CHANG.

The anvil in the forge behind him *blazed*. Gold light poured out of the doorway, out of the window, out of the chimney. It washed across the green like a wave. And where it touched the Quiet, they flinched. They stepped back. The whisper broke and stuttered.

[... bright ... too bright ... the forge ... the forge remembers ...]

"*The anvil,*" Wren breathed from the air. "*Lex, the anvil. It's glowing. Like your hammer.*"

He understood.

He'd forged Anvilson on that anvil. On the morning he left. With Brannoc striking. He'd poured fire into the iron, and runes, and the iron had *sung*. And the anvil underneath it had taken some of that. The way a hearthstone takes the heat of a fire and holds it long after. The way the causeway in the Barrows had taken three hundred and forty-six names.

A thing that is made remembers.

The anvil remembered.

And Brannoc, level twenty-four, capped for nineteen years, had been standing in that forge for six days, swinging his sledge on that anvil, and every time he struck it, it remembered a little louder. Remembered the fire. Remembered the runes. Remembered *Lex*.

And the Gloam couldn't stand it.



VANE SCREAMED.

It was the same scream the overseer had made. Many voices. Furious. He threw both his black chains at the forge doorway. At Brannoc.

Lex was there first.

He didn't know how. He was across the green before he knew he'd moved, faster than he'd ever moved, Well-fed and Root-fed and *angry*, and he caught both chains on Anvilson's haft as they came. They wrapped around the iron. Hissed. Smoked.

"*Brannoc*," he gasped.

"*Lad*."

"*Remember how we did it? The morning I left?*"

Brannoc looked at him. Then at the chains wrapped around Anvilson's haft. Then at the white thing on the other end of them, thirty paces away, pulling, its face twisted.

Something went across the big smith's face. Understanding. And then something else. Something almost like joy.

"*Striker and smith*," he said.

"*Striker and smith*."

Lex *pulled*. With everything he had. The chains went taut. Vane came off his feet again, flying across the green toward the forge, toward them, his white eyes wide. And as he came, Lex let go of the chains and stepped aside and dropped Anvilson's head to the ground, to the grey earth at the forge's threshold, like a smith laying a bar on the anvil.

Tink.

He touched it. Pointed. *There*.

And Brannoc Holt, level twenty-four, swung his twelve-pound sledge in a great arc over his head and brought it down exactly where Lex had pointed. Exactly where Vane landed.

CHANG.



IT WASN'T AN EMBER Strike. Brannoc didn't have Ember Strike. He didn't have anything. He was a capped smith with a sledge.

But the sledge had been struck on a remembering anvil a thousand times in six days. And the man swinging it had been a smith for forty years. And the place he struck was the place Lex had touched with Anvilson, the place the fire was.

The Gloam came out of Vane like water out of a dropped bucket.

All of it. At once. In a great black gout that rose into the grey air and hung there for a moment, writhing, shrieking. And the gold light from the forge door washed over it, and Lex reached for Flame and *told the truth, this is my home*, and the gold fire came up out of the ground and caught the black and tore it apart.

When it was gone, there was a man lying on the threshold of the forge.

Tall. Very thin. In a long coat, grey with ash. His hair was white, and would stay white. His face was pale, ordinary pale, with no black veins under the skin. And his eyes, when they opened, were the color of wet slate.

He stared up at the grey sky. He stared at Lex, standing over him. At Brannoc, standing over him with the sledge. At the forge behind them, blazing gold.

"*What*," whispered Lucius Vane. "*What—where—what have I—*"

He saw the green. The rows of Quiet. The black Stone. His own white chains, lying in the dust.

His face crumpled.

LUCIUS VANE – PURGED

Host: ALIVE

Corruption: 94% → 0%

Brannoc looked down at him. Then at the sledge in his own hands. Then at Lex.

"*Lad*," he said. "*What did I just do?*"

"You were the striker," said Lex. "Like always."



LEX WENT TO THE Stone.

The old cracked Stone, in the middle of the green, black-veined. The Quiet had stopped moving when Vane fell. They stood where they were, in their rows, grey and motionless. But the whisper had stopped. And some of them, Lex saw, were blinking. Slowly. As if waking.

He put his hand on the black Stone.

He could feel it. The Gloam in it. Vane had grafted it there, through the crack, the way Elric had grafted stolen Root through the black glyph on his palm. Every thread that ran through the Stone, every person ever Kindled at it, had a little Gloam in it now. A little grey. A little quiet.

And every thread had a grey band around it.

The Ceiling.

Three hundred years of it. Every person ever Kindled at the Ashbourne Stone. Every capped smith and farmer and miller and tavern-keeper. Brannoc, nineteen years at twenty-four. Pell. Mother Orla. Farmer Tobbin. Every one of them.

[You've got a hundred Authority,] said Ember quietly. *[Full. The Wells filled it on the flight.]* A pause. *[It'll cost all of it. Maybe more. Antho's not here to share the weight.]*

I know.

[You'll be empty. Again. With the Gloam still in the Vale and the breach still open and your brother alone on the mountain.]

I know.

He looked over his shoulder.

Wren had come down out of the air. She was standing at the edge of the green with her bow, watching him. Brannoc was standing in the forge doorway with the sledge in his hands and Vane at his feet. And behind Brannoc, in the doorway, crowding out to look, there were faces. Pell, straw-haired and gangly and wide-eyed. Mother Orla, with flour on her apron and tears on her face. Old Mag, leaning on her stick, her one good eye fixed on him. Children. A dozen children. All the children of Ashbourne, Lex realized. Brannoc had gathered them all in the forge.

Six days.

He turned back to the Stone.

"Wren," he said. "Can you give me some wind?"

She was beside him in an instant. "How much?"

"All of it."



HE DID IT THE way he'd done everything that mattered since the night of the gloamhounds. Like a smith.

He put both hands on the cracked black Stone. He reached down under the wheel to the river. To Flame. And Stone, which hummed at him from the ground of Ashbourne like an old friend, like it had been waiting for him to come home. And he reached up through the wheel to the Root. To the gold. To his hundred points of Authority.

And Wren gave him the wind.

She stood behind him with her hands on his shoulders and her face lifted and her eyes closed, and called. And the wind came down off the Greyspine. A clean cold mountain wind, the kind that came down the north road every autumn and set the shutters banging. It came down into the grey Vale and swept across the green and poured into the Stone through Lex's hands like air from a bellows into a forge.

And the Stone *caught*.

The crack down its face, the crack that lightning had made a hundred years ago, the crack that Lex's blood had gone into on the night Elric cut his thumb, lit up. Not black. *Gold*. The gold poured out of it and ran up the face of the Stone in branching lines, the way it had that night, and the black veins burned away in front of it like frost before a fire.

And Lex found the Ceilings.

All of them. Three hundred years of grey bands, wrapped around three hundred years of gold threads. Thousands of them. Every person ever Kindled at this Stone. The living and the dead. Brannoc. Pell. Orla. Tobbin. His own mother, Seren, Kindled here forty years ago as a *Washerwoman*. His brother, Antho, whose thread was black and gold and tangled, with an *ERROR* where the Ceiling should be.

And his own thread. Gold. With a grey band around it at twenty-four that had been burned through and broken on the night of the gloamhounds, and still hung there, a broken hoop, rusted.

He struck.



HE DIDN'T KNOW HOW long it took.

He knew it took everything. Every point of Authority. Every drop of mana. Every scrap of strength. He knew that somewhere in the middle of it his knees gave out and he would have fallen except that Wren was holding him up from behind. He knew that the wind roared and the Stone blazed and the gold poured out of the crack and up into the grey sky like a column of fire. He knew that the Quiet on the green, every one of them, threw back their heads at once and *gasp*ed, a great sound, like a crowd surfacing from deep water, and the Gloam came out of them in black wisps and burned away in the gold.

And he knew that the bands broke.

All of them. One after another and then all at once. Like hoops bursting off a barrel. Like chains snapping. Like ice cracking on a pond in spring, the sound going out across the whole frozen surface in a single long rolling *crack*. Three hundred years of Ceilings, breaking.

And then it was over. And he was on his knees in the grey dust of the green with his hands on the Stone, and the Stone was *white*. White and glowing, the way the Stones were meant to glow, with the silver Veil swirling back around it out of the empty air, and gold running bright down the crack in its face.

UNBIND (STONE) – EXECUTED

Stone of Ashbourne: CEILINGS BROKEN

Bound threads (living): 412

Bound threads (dead): 3,180

– ALL UNBOUND

Gloam: PURGED (Stone)

Dead.

He stared at it.

[The dead too,] said Ember softly. [Everyone ever Kindled here. Everyone the Ceiling ever held. You didn't just free the living, Lex. You freed the record. Every capped life that ever ran through this Stone is written in the Lattice now as unbound.] A pause. [Your mother's in there. As something other than a Washerwoman.]

Lex couldn't speak.



BRANNOC WAS STANDING IN the doorway of the forge.

He'd let the sledge fall. It lay at his feet, on the threshold, beside Vane, who was sitting up with his white head in his hands. Brannoc was staring at nothing. At something only he could see.

His face was wet.

Lex got up. He didn't know how. Wren helped. He walked across the green to the forge, past the rows of the Quiet, who weren't the Quiet anymore, who were blinking and weeping and clutching each other and staring at their hands. Past the Dunstan twins, who were holding onto each other and sobbing. Past Farmer Tobbin, sitting in the grass. Past Sister Agathe, kneeling, her lips moving in prayer.

He stopped in front of Brannoc.

The big smith looked at him. He didn't say anything for a long time.

"*Runesmith*," he said at last. His voice was a whisper. "It says Runesmith. *Rare*." He swallowed. "Lad, it says *Level twenty-four*. And then there's no number after. There's no *cap*." His great scarred hands were shaking. "Nineteen years. Nineteen years, I looked at that number every morning. And now it's—it just keeps *going*."

Lex didn't say anything. He couldn't.

"*Runesmith*," Brannoc said again. He looked down at his hands. At the anvil glowing gold behind him in the forge. "I don't know any runes. I never learned any runes. I can't even read."

"I'll teach you," said Lex.

Brannoc looked up at him.

And then the big smith reached out with both his huge hands and pulled Lex into his arms, and held on, and wept into his hair the way he had on the morning Lex left. And Lex held on too. And neither of them said anything at all.



"*Lex!*"

Pell came hurtling out of the forge and crashed into both of them so hard they nearly went over. The boy was crying and laughing at the same time, his straw hair standing straight up, his face blotched red.

"*Ranger!*" he shouted. "*Lex! Ranger! It says Ranger! I got Miller! At my Kindling! I got Miller, Lex, it was the worst day of my life, and I remembered what you said, I remembered, it's not the end, it's just what they'll let you be, and now it says RANGER—*"

"I know, Pell." Lex was laughing. He couldn't help it. "I know."

"*Uncommon!* It says *Uncommon!* I've never been *uncommon* at *anything—*"

Mother Orla was in the doorway, with flour on her apron and her hands over her mouth. Old Mag was beside her, leaning on her stick, looking at Lex with her one good eye.

"*Wisewoman,*" the old woman said drily. "Seventy-one years a *Herbwoman*, and now I'm a *Wisewoman.*" She sniffed. "About time someone noticed."

And behind them, the children. A dozen children. Too young to have been Kindled. Staring at all the adults weeping and laughing on the green, not understanding.

But they would. In a few years. When they turned sixteen and walked up to the old cracked Stone on the green and put their hands on it. And there would be no grey band waiting for them. No Ceiling. No *this far, no further.*

Just the gold, going up forever. The way the Founders had meant it to.



THAT NIGHT, ASHBOURNE LIT every lantern it had.

Every one. In every window of every house. The chapel's lanterns, all of them, blazing on the steps. The tavern's. The mill's. The little clay lamps from the lantern service, one for every family, set out on every sill. Brannoc lit the one in the forge window again, the one he'd lit on the morning Lex left. Mother Orla lit a dozen on the tables outside the Crooked Kettle and opened every barrel she had.

The village sat on the green in the warm gold light and ate and drank and wept and laughed, and stared at their panels, and told each other their new class names over and over, as if afraid they'd forget them. *Hearthkeeper. Stonemason. Shepherd-Warden. Wisewoman. Ranger.* The Gloam was still in the Vale. Still thick in the hollows outside the village, still

pouring down from the mountains. The grey hadn't gone out of the fields or the trees. But on the green at Ashbourne, around the white Stone, it was gone. Burned away. And the lanterns held it back.

Lex sat on the edge of the green with his back against the wall of the forge and Wren beside him, and watched them.

"You did that," said Wren quietly.

"We did that."

"You did that." She leaned her head on his shoulder. "I just blew."

He laughed. It hurt; everything hurt; he had nothing left. Not a point of Authority. Barely a drop of mana. He felt like he'd hammered iron for three days and nights without stopping.

He looked up at the mountains.

At the Greyspine, dark against the night sky. At the highest peak. At the black cleft in its face, where the Gloam was still pouring out, a black river in the dark. At the tiny gold light above it.

Still burning.

While the maker lives.

And then, as he watched, something changed.

The black river pouring out of the cleft *faltered*.

He sat up. Wren sat up beside him.

The Gloam pouring down the mountain thinned. Wavered. Like a stream when someone upstream drops a stone in it. It slowed. It *stopped*.

And from the cleft of the Hollowmaw, high on the dark face of the mountain, came a light.

Not gold. Not Lex's light. Something else. Deep and soft and dark and somehow bright at the same time, like the night sky when the stars are out. Violet-black. Shimmering. It came out of the cleft in a slow steady pulse, like a heartbeat. Once. Twice. Three times.

And then the cleft was dark. And the black river on the mountain was only a black river, flowing downhill, its source cut off. Draining away. Growing thinner. Thinner.

And above the cleft, the tiny gold light burned on.

Lex stared at it.

[Lex,] said Ember. Its voice was shaking. [Lex, that was Shade. That was the Well. And the breach—]

I know.

ZONE ALERT – GREYSPINE

Breach (Hollowmaw): CLOSED

Method: UNKNOWN (non-Lattice)

Wren had her hand over her mouth.

All across the green, people were looking up at the mountain. At the place where the black river had been pouring out for a week, and now wasn't.

And Lex felt it. Through the Bloodbond. Faint and far away, so faint he almost didn't feel it. But there.

The cold deep pool of his brother. Very still. Very tired. And very, very quiet.

Not the bad quiet. Not the Quiet of the Gloam. The other kind. The kind that comes when something that has been screaming for eight years finally, finally stops.

I keep the door, said his brother's voice, in his head, faint as a whisper from the bottom of a well. *I kept it, Lex. I closed it. I'm coming home.*

CHAPTER 33

THE GATHERING OF THE UNBOUND



ANTHO CAME HOME AT dawn.

Lex was waiting on the north road, at the edge of the cobbles, where Brannoc had stood with his hand raised on the morning Lex left. He'd been there since before first light. Wren had brought him a blanket and a mug of Mother Orla's spiced cider and then gone back to bed, because, she said, there was no point both of them freezing to death waiting for a warlock.

He saw them first as a speck against the grey sky over the Greyspine. Then a shape. Then a dragon, blue-grey and shimmering, coming down out of the mountains in long slow spirals, her great wings barely moving, riding the cold morning air.

She landed on the north road in a gust of wind that sent the grey dust swirling. And sat there, folding her wings, her golden eyes half-closed with exhaustion.

Antho was on her neck. Slumped forward. His face buried in her crest.
"Antho."

His brother lifted his head.

He looked terrible. Grey-faced, hollow-eyed, his cheeks sunk, his lips cracked and bloody, as if he'd been sitting in the dark for three days without food or water or sleep. Which he had. His hands, where they gripped Ashka's crest, were shaking. The Keeper's Lantern at his belt was burning very low.

But his eyes were grey. Clear, still grey. And when they found Lex standing on the road, something moved in them that Lex had never seen there before.

Peace.

"Hello, Lex," said Antho. His voice was a whisper. "I closed it."

"I know. I saw."

"I *closed* it." Antho slid off Ashka's neck. His legs buckled when he hit the ground, and Lex caught him. "Lady of Lanterns. I closed it. The door. The one in the Hollowmaw." He was laughing, very weakly, against Lex's shoulder. "Four years, I sat on it. And all I had to do was—"

"What? What did you do?"

Antho didn't answer right away. He stood there leaning on his brother on the grey north road, breathing, while the sun came up over the mountains behind him.

"I listened," he said at last.



HE TOLD THEM LATER, in the forge, by the fire, with a bowl of Mother Orla's stew in his hands that he couldn't stop staring at, as if he'd forgotten what food was.

The cavern had been worse than he'd ever seen it. The ward-nails pulled out of the rock and scattered. *Pulled*, not broken; someone had come and taken them, he thought. One of Morvane's creatures. The green fire gone. And the breach—

"It wasn't a crack anymore," Antho said. "It was a *door*. As tall as the cavern. Wide open. And the Gloam was just—pouring out. Like a river out of a broken dam. And on the other side of it—" He stopped. His hands tightened on the bowl. "I could see it, Lex. For the first time. The other side. The Hollow."

Nobody spoke.

"It's dark," said Antho. "That's all. Just dark. Not like night. Not like a cave. Like—*before*. Before anything. Before light was a thing that could happen." He swallowed. "And it goes on forever. And in it, very far down, something was moving. Something huge. Coming toward the door." His

voice dropped to a whisper. "It knew I was there. It knew me. It's always known me."

"What did you do?" said Seraphine. She'd come in the night before with the Fenmoor column, two hundred people walking into Ashbourne's green by lantern-light, footsore and grey-faced and staring at the white Stone. She was sitting beside Antho now, very close, with her scarred hand on his arm.

"I sat down," said Antho. "In front of the door. Like Malachi taught us. And I listened."

"To the thing?"

"No. Under it." Antho looked into the fire. "Malachi said the thing in the Hollow isn't the dark. It's a thief living in the dark. And Shade—the real dark, the Well—is under it. Holding everything. Holding *it*." He was quiet for a moment. "So I listened for Shade. Under the noise. Under the hunger. And I found it. It was there. Holding the door frame, almost. Like the dark was the house and the door was just a hole someone had knocked in the wall."

"And then?"

"And then I asked it to close." Antho's mouth twisted. "Not *told*. Asked. Like you taught me to ask Flame, Lex. With the truth." He turned the bowl in his hands. "I told it I was tired. I told it I'd been holding this door for four years and I couldn't hold it anymore. I told it there were people down in the Vale who'd go grey if it stayed open. I told it about you. About Mam." His voice cracked. "I told it I was afraid."

The forge was very quiet. Brannoc had stopped working at the anvil. Wren had stopped mending her bowstring. Pell, sitting in the corner on his old upturned bucket, had his mouth open.

"And it started to close," said Antho. "Slowly. Like a wound closing. The dark—the *real* dark—just sort of... knitting. From the edges. And the thing on the other side felt it, and it *pushed*. It came up toward the door so fast. So hard. I could feel it. Like a wave coming up a beach." His hands were shaking. "And I thought: *I can't. I'm not strong enough. It's going to get through.*"

He stopped.

"And then I heard it," he said. "The singing."

Lex went very still.

"*Little light, little light,*" whispered Antho. "From the other side. From somewhere in the dark. Not far. Close to the door. A woman's voice." He looked up at Lex, and his grey eyes were swimming. "And the thing stopped pushing. Just for a moment. Like it did that night. In the kitchen. When she sang into it and it didn't know what a song was."

"*Antho—*"

"So I sang back," said Antho. "I sang the next line. *Keep the door for the ones who go.* And she sang the one after that. And I sang the one after. Back and forth. Through the door. Like we used to, in the cottage, when I was small and couldn't sleep and she'd sing a line and I'd sing a line." He was crying now. He didn't seem to notice. "And while we sang, the door closed. From both sides. Lex, I swear by everything, I felt it. Someone was pushing on the other side. Pushing it shut. With me."

Nobody said anything for a long time.

"It could have been the thing," said Antho at last, very quietly. "Mocking me. Using her voice. It's done that before." He wiped his face. "It could have been."

"Do you think it was?" said Lex.

Antho looked at him across the fire.

"No," he said.



ANTHOREN VEYClass: *HOLLOW-TOUCHED WARLOCK*→ *ERROR resolving...*→ *TWILIGHT WARLOCK (Unique)**"One who stands between the
dark and the dark, and keeps
the door."*

Tier II – Level 38 → 46

(breach closure: massive XP)

CLARITY: 94 / 100

Breach-link: *SEVERED (breach closed)*Hollow-link: *bound to host (dormant)*

ATTUNEMENT (integrated)

Shade *SPEAKING*Gale *LISTENING**Error resolving.*

Antho read it out loud, sitting by the forge fire, in a voice that wasn't quite steady. When he got to the end, he stopped and read it again. Silently. His lips moving.

"It's not an error anymore," he said. "It says it's not an error." He looked up. "Eight years. Eight years, every time I looked at my panel, it said *ERROR*. Like I was a mistake. Like the Lattice had looked at me and thrown up its hands." His voice cracked. "And now it says *Twilight Warlock. Unique. One who keeps the door.*"

Seraphine had her hand over her mouth. Ashka, curled in the forge doorway because she was far too big to fit inside anymore, lifted her head and crooned.

"*Speaking*," said Lex. "Shade's at Speaking. Malachi said that's the third stage. Listening, Answering, Speaking." He stared at his brother. "Mine's only at Answering."

"I had a lot of practice," said Antho. "Eight years of listening to the dark." Something moved at the corner of his mouth. The crooked thing. "Turns out I was listening to the wrong voice."



THEY CAME TO ASHBOURNE over the next ten days.

Lex hadn't sent for them. Not most of them. He'd sent Quill, who had turned up on the morning after the Unbinding, perched on the forge's chimney as if he'd never left, looking thin and battered and enormously pleased with himself. Nobody knew where he'd come from. Nobody knew whether he'd come from Elric, or escaped from Elric, or simply flown away from Duskhold on his own. He wouldn't say. He just sat on the chimney and croaked *found you* every time Lex came out of the forge, and ate every scrap of bacon Mother Orla gave him.

Lex sent him to Teodra Hale, with a message: *I got my fire back.*

But most of them came on their own.

They'd seen the World Notices. All three of them. *A Reckoning has been executed. A Ceiling has been broken.* And then, nine days later, a third one. Smaller. Stranger. Shown, Seraphine said afterward, only to those whose panels had ever carried a Ceiling, which was nearly everyone.

WORLD NOTICE (limited)

At the Stone of Ashbourne, in the southern Vale, every Ceiling has been broken.

Living: 412

Dead: 3,180

The Root has unbound them.

And people had read it, and stood very still in their fields and forges and mines and kitchens, and then picked up whatever they had and started walking.



TEODRA HALE CAME FIRST. On the fourth day. Riding in from the east at the head of sixty Ashen Banners, which was twenty more than she'd had before Caldris, because some of the scattered Wardens and knights and freed prisoners had found her in the hills and joined. She swung down from her horse on Ashbourne's green and looked at the white Stone, and the lanterns in every window, and the people walking around with their new class names written all over their faces.

"Huh," she said. "You weren't lying."

And behind her, on a borrowed horse, wrapped in bandages from head to foot, with his left arm in a sling and his face a patchwork of half-healed cuts and his grey hair singed short, there was a knight.

Lex didn't believe it at first. He stood in the doorway of the forge with a half-finished blade in his tongs and stared.

The knight looked across the green at him. And smiled. Crooked. Warm.

"*Lad*," said Garrick Dunmore.

Lex dropped the tongs.



"**TEODRA'S PEOPLE DRAGGED ME** out," Garrick said later. He was sitting on the bench by the forge fire, where Elric had sat on the first night, with a mug of Mother Orla's cider in his good hand and Lex and Wren and Antho crowded around him. "I held the gate as long as I could. Long enough, Teodra says. Long enough for most of them to get out the sally port." He stared into the fire. "And then a Hollow-knight put a sword through my arm and another one hit me on the head with something heavy, and I went down."

"And they didn't—"

"They were going to. I was lying in the gateway with three of them standing over me and Oathkeeper in the dirt where I'd dropped it." Garrick's mouth twisted. "And then Teodra came back. With twenty of her worst cut-throats. Back into the burning fortress. For one old knight." He shook his head. "I've told her she's mad. She says she knows."

"*Mad*," said Teodra Hale from the doorway, where she was leaning with her arms folded. "I prefer *sentimental*."

"Same thing, in a sellsword," said Garrick.

He looked at Lex.

"I didn't die," he said quietly. "I swore to stand on the steps for as long as I could stand, and I stood, and I fell, and I didn't die." He set down the mug. "So I suppose I'm still standing."

Lex couldn't speak. So he didn't. He just put his arms around the old knight, carefully, around the bandages and the sling, and held on.



SERAPHINE'S COLUMN HAD GROWN on the road.

She'd started from Fenmoor with two hundred. She walked into Ashbourne with five hundred. Every grey village they'd passed through on the way west, she'd stopped. Gathered the people. Found the ones who'd been taken by the Quiet only recently. And with Ilsa, the new Healer, beside her, and the young Stormcaller from Fenmoor who'd been a Laborer, and the old Herbalist who'd been a Farmhand, they'd done what they could. They couldn't break Ceilings. They didn't have Root. But they could pull the Gloam out of the newly-taken, slowly, painfully, with Ilsa's healing and the Stormcaller's clean lightning. And they could tell people about Ashbourne.

"I didn't do anything," Seraphine said, when Lex tried to thank her. "I just read the maps and told everyone where to walk."

"She organized five hundred people across a hundred miles of Blightmarch," said Ilsa, standing beside her, "with no food and no weapons and Gloamed things in every ditch." The girl's thin face was fierce. "She didn't sleep for six days. She carried a little boy on her back for two of them when his feet gave out." She looked at Seraphine. "She did *everything*."

Seraphine went red to the tips of her ears and pushed her cracked spectacles up her nose.

Antho was looking at her. Lex saw the look. He'd never seen his brother look at anyone like that.

**AND ON THE SEVENTH** day, the Wardens came.

Lex saw them first from the forge doorway. A column of grey cloaks coming up the south road from Millbridge. Two hundred of them, maybe more. Marching in step. And at the front, on a big grey horse, a tall lean man with a face like a hatchet.

Lex's heart stopped.

The column came up the road to the edge of the green and halted. The grey cloaks stood in their ranks, very still, very quiet. People on the green were backing away. Teodra Hale had her greatsword half-drawn. Garrick was on his feet with Oathkeeper in his good hand.

The tall man on the grey horse swung down. He walked across the green alone, toward the forge. Toward Lex.

He stopped in front of him.

"Harrow," said Daxian Roole.

"Captain."

"Not *Captain*." Roole's hatchet face did something that might have been a smile. "Not anymore. I was stripped of rank. Court-martialed. Sentenced to hang for treason." He paused. "That was three weeks ago."

"What happened?"

"I told the truth at my trial," said Roole simply. "In front of the whole High Council. I told them about the Hollowmaw. About the breach. About your brother holding it. About Vane. About the High Warden ordering me to falsify my report." He shrugged. "Kell sentenced me to hang anyway. It was a very short trial."

"And?"

"And then the World Notices started." Roole's pale blue eyes were steady. "*A Ceiling has been broken. And then every Ceiling at the Stone of Ashbourne.*" He looked past Lex, at the white Stone in the middle of the green, glowing in the morning light. "Every Warden in the Spire saw it. Every one. Even the ones who'd been there forty years. Even the ones who'd set the flags on the Stones themselves." He paused. "And some of them started asking questions. Out loud. In the refectory. In the corridors." His mouth twitched. "And some of them remembered a captain in the cells who'd stood up at his trial and said the same things."

"They broke you out."

"Two hundred and eleven of them." Roole glanced over his shoulder at the silent grey column at the edge of the green. "And they brought someone with them."

He stepped aside.

And behind him, coming across the green with a cudgel in her one hand and a scowl on her broad red face and her grey hair cropped short as a soldier's, there was the largest woman Lex had ever seen.

"Smith," said Hedda Vorne. "You owe me a hundred crowns of beeswax."



LEX LAUGHED UNTIL HE cried. He couldn't help it. He stood in the doorway of the forge with Hedda Vorne glaring at him and Daxian Roole standing beside her and two hundred Wardens at the edge of the green and the whole village staring, and he laughed until he had to sit down.

"*She* broke me out," said Roole, when he'd stopped. "Hedda. Personally. With her one arm and that cudgel." He shook his head. "Vane arrested her the night of the raid. Took her to the Spire. She spent a month in the cell next to mine." He paused. "She talked the entire time."

"Someone had to," said Hedda. "You're terrible company."

She looked at Lex. Then past him, into the forge. At the anvil. At the gold glow along its face. At Brannoc, standing beside it with a hammer in his hand and his mouth open.

Something in Hedda's broad red face changed.

"That anvil's *warm*," she said slowly.

"It remembers," said Lex.

Hedda looked at the anvil for a long moment. Then at Brannoc. Then at the hammer in Brannoc's hand, which was glowing faintly gold along its face, the way Anvilson did.

"*Runesmith*," she said. It wasn't a question. She'd read his panel. Of course she had. "You're a *Runesmith*. Level twenty-four. No cap." Her voice was very strange. "I put Lattice-enchantments on steel for twenty-two years with scrolls and ink. I never once—" She stopped.

Brannoc looked at her. At her empty sleeve. At her one huge hand on her cudgel.

"I'm just learning," he said. "The lad's teaching me. I can't even read."

"I can," said Hedda. "I can read everything. Every rune in every book in the Spire's armory." She looked at her empty sleeve. "I just can't hold the tongs and the hammer at the same time."

They looked at each other across the forge. The capped smith who couldn't read and the one-armed armorer who couldn't hold the tongs.

"Huh," said Brannoc slowly.

"Huh," said Hedda.

Lex left them to it.



THAT EVENING, ELOWEN DUNMORE rode into Ashbourne with fifty knights of the Silver Lattice and a letter sealed with blue wax and a small silver crown.

She found her father on the bench outside the forge, and stopped in front of him, and looked at the bandages and the sling and the singed grey hair. And Garrick looked up at her and said, very quietly, "I'm still standing, Elowen. I kept my oath."

And the young captain with the crooked nose sat down on the bench beside him, armor and all, and put her head on her father's good shoulder, and neither of them said anything at all for a long time.

The letter was for Lex.

He read it alone, by the forge fire, after everyone else had gone to sleep.

To the Smith with gold eyes.

The High Warden has declared the Unbinding a heresy and every Unbound an Anomaly to be Corrected. She has refused to send a single Warden against the thing in the east. She says it is a blight, as she has always said, and that the true threat to the realm is you.

My grandfather is dying. He will not live to the new year. He signs whatever Kell puts in front of him.

I cannot overrule her. Not yet.

But I can send you my knights, and Captain Dunmore, and every Silver Lattice officer who has sworn to me privately, which is more than Kell knows. I can open the royal armories in Millbridge and Highcrest to anyone who comes with a token I have enclosed. And I can tell you this, which I have not told anyone:

I was Kindled at sixteen in the Spire itself, at the Great Stone, and received the class of Sovereign, Epic. The flag that weighted it was set by Kell. I have known for seven years that I did not earn what I was given.

I would like to live in a world where no one is given what they did not earn, and no one is denied what they did.

Bring your father home. Then come to Highcrest.

—Lysandra

Lex sat by the forge fire and read it three times.

Then he folded it very carefully and put it in his coat, against his chest, beside his father's letter to Elric, which Elric had left behind in Ashbourne, Lex had discovered, in the drawer of the workbench, three months ago. On purpose, or by accident. Lex would never know.



THE WAR COUNCIL MET in the Crooked Kettle on the tenth night.

Mother Orla had cleared the tables and spread out Seraphine's map on the biggest one and lit every lamp she had. They crowded around it: Lex and Antho, Wren and Seraphine, Garrick with his arm in its sling and Elowen beside him, Teodra Hale, Daxian Roole, Dame Brand, Hedda Vorne, and Brannoc, who had insisted on coming even though he said he didn't know anything about wars, because he knew about Lex.

And Lucius Vane.

He sat at the far end of the table, apart from everyone, with his white hair and his slate eyes and a blanket around his shoulders. He'd barely spoken since the green. He ate when food was put in front of him. He slept when he was told to sleep. Roole had taken custody of him, and Roole kept him close.

But he'd asked to come. He'd said he had something to tell them.

"Lattice integrity," said Seraphine. She had her pen in her hand and her cracked spectacles on her nose and a sheet of figures in front of her. "Forty-seven percent. It was fifty-four after Caldrys. It's dropping. About a point a day." She looked up. "I think that's the graft. Morvane, unpicking your father from the Anchor, a thread at a time. Every thread he takes, the net loses a little."

"And when it gets to the end?" said Teodra.

"When it gets to forty, I think the graft takes. I think that's the point where there's more of Morvane in the knot than Arion." Seraphine set down her pen. "Seven days. Maybe less."

Nobody said anything.

"He's right," said a voice from the end of the table.

They all turned.

Vane was looking at the map. Not at them. His white hair hung around his narrow face. His slate eyes were very steady and very tired.

"I was in him," he said quietly. "In the Gloam. The Pale Warden's Gloam. For six days. On the green." He swallowed. "When you're in it, you can hear it. All of it. Every Quiet. Every Gloamed. It's all one voice. *His* voice." He shuddered. "I heard him. Talking to the crystal. Every night. Very gently. Like a man talking to a child. *Let go, Arion. Let go. It doesn't hurt. Let go.*"

"And Father?" said Antho. His voice was very cold.

Vane looked at him.

"He won't," he said. "He's holding on. With nothing. No Authority. No strength. Just—holding." He shook his head slowly. "The Pale Warden is very patient. But he's not used to waiting this long. He's angry. Under the gentleness. I could feel it."

"Duskhold," said Garrick. "What's it like? Defenses?"

"Walls of black stone. No doors. Thousands of Quiet in every corridor." Vane closed his eyes. "And at the center, a chasm. The Vhessa breach. The crystal stands at the edge of it. And over it, always, the dragon."

"How many Gloamed in his army?"

"In the field? Twenty thousand. Perhaps more. Massing on the border." Vane opened his eyes. "Waiting for the graft to finish. Then they march west. All of them."

Twenty thousand.

Lex looked around the table. At the faces in the lamplight.

Teodra's sixty Ashen Banners. Roole's two hundred Wardens. Elowen's fifty knights, and Dame Brand's twenty. Seraphine's five hundred from the Blightmarch, half of them Unbound now, the other half still frightened and grey-faced. And Ashbourne. Four hundred and twelve living Unbound, every one of them with a new class and no cap and no idea how to use it. Farmers and millers and tavern-keepers and smiths.

A thousand, perhaps. Fifteen hundred.

Against twenty thousand.

"We can't beat that," said Teodra flatly. "Not in a field. Not with farmers. Not if we had a year to train them."

"We don't have to beat it," said Lex.

They all looked at him.

He reached out and put his finger on the map. On the grey country in the east. On a single point, deep in the Blightmarch, marked in Seraphine's neat hand: *Duskhold*.

"We only have to get *here*," he said. "To the crystal. To Father. And to Morvane." He looked around the table. "If we free Father, and break the graft, Morvane can't hold the net. And if he can't hold the net, his army's just—Gloamed. Lost. Without a will to follow."

"And how do we get there?" said Roole. "Through twenty thousand?"

"We don't go through them," said Lex. "We go *around* them. Over them." He looked at Wren. At Antho. At the dragon lying in the doorway of the Crooked Kettle with her golden eyes half-closed. "A few of us. Fast. By air."

"And the rest?"

Lex looked down at the map. At the border. At the passes.

"The rest of you give him something else to look at," he said quietly.



IT TOOK THEM THE rest of the night to plan it.

Three fronts.

Teodra Hale and Daxian Roole would take the main force, all of it, every Unbound and Warden and sellsword who could hold a weapon, east to the Blightmarch border. To the Thornhollow Pass, where the old Vhessan road crossed into Caldor. Where Morvane's army was massing. They would hold the pass. Not to win. To *bold*. To be loud and bright and stubborn, to draw every Gloamed eye in the east toward them.

"Like a lantern in a window," said Teodra, with a grim smile. "Moths can't help themselves."

Elowen Dunmore and her knights would ride south and west, to the coast. To Saltreach. Vane had said there was a second force there: three thousand Gloamed coming up the coast road from the drowned villages of the south. If they reached Saltreach, the free cities would fall. Elowen would stop them. Or slow them.

"With fifty knights," said Elowen. "And whatever the Saltreach militia can scrape together." She looked at her father. "I've had worse odds."

"No, you haven't," said Garrick.

"I'm your daughter. I'll invent some."

And the third front was Duskhold.

Lex. Antho. Wren. Seraphine, because someone had to read the wards on the crystal, and nobody alive could read them better. And Garrick.

"No," said Lex, when Garrick said it. "Your arm. You can barely lift your sword."

"I can lift it." Garrick looked at him steadily. "I held the gate at Caldris with three holes in me. I'll hold whatever needs holding at Duskhold." He put his good hand on Oathkeeper's hilt. "I swore an oath on this sword, lad. To stand on the steps. Wherever the steps are." He looked at the map, at the black mark in the grey country. "Those are the steps. You know they are."

Lex looked at him for a long time.

Then he looked at Elowen. The young captain was sitting very still beside her father. Her face was pale. But she didn't say anything. She just put her hand on his.

"All right," said Lex.



HE FOUND BRANNOC IN the forge, afterward, in the grey hour before dawn.

The big smith was at the anvil. Hedda was beside him, on a stool, with the *Book of Making* open on her knee, reading aloud. Not the Wellscrip; she couldn't read that. Seraphine's translation, the copy she'd made in the Stillwater. *Ardent: the rune of held heat. The upstroke curves back like a flame folding over itself.* And Brannoc, with his tongue between his teeth and sweat running down his bald head, was striking it.

Into a sword blade. Plain steel. For the army.

The hammer came down. *Chang.* And something gold went into the steel. Faint. Wavering. Barely there. But there.

Brannoc stared at it.

"Did I—" he started.

"You did," said Hedda. She leaned over to look. "That's *Ardent*. Badly struck. The upstroke's crooked. It'll hold heat for about a week before it fades." She sat back. "But it's *there*."

Brannoc looked at the sword. Then up at Lex, standing in the doorway.

"Lad," he said. His voice was rough. "Lad, I did a rune."

"I saw."

"My first rune. Forty years at this anvil. *Forty years.*" He laughed, a big shaky boom of a laugh. "And it's crooked."

"So was my first one," said Lex.

He came into the forge. He picked up a hammer from the rack, a hand-hammer, the one he'd used for eight years before Anvilsong. He took his place on the other side of the anvil. Across from Brannoc. The way they'd stood on the morning he left.

"Show me," said Brannoc. "Show me how to make it straight."

They worked until the sun came up. Striker and smith. Smith and striker. Hedda reading. Brannoc striking. Lex guiding. Sword after sword. Spearhead after spearhead. Arrowheads for Wren and every archer in the Unbound. Each one with a rune struck into it. Brannoc's crooked ones and Lex's straight ones, side by side on the rack.

When the sun came up over the mountains, there were forty blades on the rack. And every one of them was warm.



LEX SPENT HIS POINTS that morning. He'd been carrying them since Fenmoor. Six levels, from the overseer and Vane and the Unbindings. Thirty-six points.

He spent them sitting on the edge of the green, by the white Stone, with the sun on his face.

LEX VEY

Class: EMBERWRIGHT (Unique)

— WELL-BOUND —

Tier II — Level 36

MIG 54 AGI 53 VIT 66

INT 48 SPI 130 RES 53

Well-bound: all stats +10%

ATTUNEMENT

Flame ANSWERING

Stone ANSWERING

Tide —

Gale —

ROOT

Seal integrity: 4%

Authority: 100 / 100

Four percent.

He looked at it for a long time.

[He's holding on,] said Ember quietly. [Vane was right. With nothing. But he's holding on.]

*Four percent, Lex thought.**[I know.]**Ember. When we get there. When we get him out.*

A long pause.

[I know what you're going to ask,] said Ember. [I've been thinking about it too. Since Avaloria. Since I spoke to him.] Another pause. [When the seal breaks completely, when he's free, I don't know what happens to me. I might go back into him. I might fade. I might stay.]

What do you want?

The silence was very long.

[I want to stay,] said Ember at last. Very softly. [I want to stay with you. I know I'm a piece of him. I know I came from him. But I've been with you for three months. Awake. I've watched you grow. I've watched you forgive. I've watched you break Ceilings and close breaches and fall in love.] A pause. [I'm not his anymore, Lex. Not really. I'm yours. If he'll let me be.]

Lex sat in the sun by the white Stone and didn't say anything for a while.

Then you'll stay, he thought. I'll ask him. And if he says no—
[He won't,] said Ember. [I know him. I am him, a little. He won't.] A
 pause, and something in the voice that might have been a smile. *[He always*
did let his children keep the things they found in the road.]



ANTHO KISSED SERAPHINE THAT evening.

Lex didn't see it. Wren did. She came and found him in the forge afterward, grinning so widely her face looked like it might split.

"*By the Stone,*" she said. "In front of *everyone*. She was telling him about the ward-glyphs on the crystal, Vane's description of them, and he just—" She made a gesture. "Mid-sentence. She was in the *middle of a sentence*, Lex."

"What did she do?"

"Finished the sentence." Wren was laughing. "*Afterward*. She finished the sentence and then she pushed her spectacles up her nose and said *that was very unscientific* and then she kissed *him*."

Lex laughed until he couldn't breathe.



THEY LEFT AT DAWN on the eleventh day.

The army went east first. A thousand strong, more or less. Fifteen hundred. Unbound farmers with Brannoc's crooked-runed swords. Wardens with their silver pins torn off. Sellswords and knights and Fenmoor folk and Ashbourne folk. Teodra Hale at the front on her big horse, roaring orders. Roole beside her, quiet and grim. Hedda in a cart, with a portable anvil and the *Book of Making* and her cudgel. Brannoc beside her, driving, with forty warm blades in the back.

Elowen rode south and west with her fifty knights, toward the coast and Saltreach. She stopped at the edge of the village and looked back at her father, standing on the green with his arm in its sling. She didn't say anything. She just raised her hand.

Garrick raised his.

And Lex and Antho and Wren and Seraphine and Garrick stood on Ashbourne's green beside the white Stone, with a storm-dragon lying in the grass beside them, and watched them all go.

Pell came running out of the forge as they were mounting. He had a bow on his back, a new one, Wren's old one, which she'd given him that morning, the one Lex had mended in Thistledown with the rune *Knit*. And a quiver of Brannoc's arrows. And a look on his face that Lex recognized, because he'd seen it in the mirror once, three months ago.

"I'm going with the army," Pell said. "With Teodra. As a scout. A Ranger." His face was very pale and very determined. "Brannoc said I could. If I stayed at the back."

"Pell—"

"You said it's not the end. What the Stone says. You said it's just what they'll let you be." Pell's chin went up. "Well, they let me be a Ranger now. So I'm going to *be* one."

Lex looked at him for a long time.

Then he reached out and ruffled the boy's straw-colored hair.

"Stay at the back," he said.

"I will."

"I mean it, Pell."

"I *will*." Pell grinned, the eager spaniel grin, and turned and ran after the army.



OLD MAG WAS THE last.

She came hobbling across the green on her stick as Lex climbed onto Ashka's back behind Antho. She stopped beside the dragon and looked up at him with her one good eye.

"Your mother," she said.

Lex looked down at her.

"When she came to me," said Old Mag. "The year after your father left. For the herbs. For the fever that wasn't a fever." She sniffed. "I told you she said you'd be a menace when you woke up."

"I remember."

"She said something else too." The old woman's eye was very sharp. "I didn't tell you. Didn't think you were ready." She leaned on her stick. "She said: *If they ever go looking for him, Mag, tell them he's not the only one who's lost. Tell them to leave a light on for both of us.*"

Lex went very still. On Ashka's neck in front of him, Antho had turned his head.

"I didn't know what she meant," said Old Mag. "Not then. I thought it was just grief. Talking." Her eye moved from Lex to Antho and back. "I'm not so sure now."

She turned and hobbled away across the green toward the forge, where a lantern was burning in the window in the middle of the day.

Lex and Antho looked at each other.

Neither of them said anything.

Then Ashka spread her great storm-colored wings, and leaped, and caught the wind, and climbed. Up over the white Stone and the lantern-lit windows and the grey fields of the Vale. Up past the Greyspine, where a tiny gold light still burned on a rock above a closed door. Up into the high cold river of wind that ran east across the world.

Wren stepped off the green into the air beside them and followed.

East. Toward the grey country. Toward the bruise on the horizon. Toward a black fortress with no doors, and a crystal at the edge of a chasm, and a man inside it who was holding on with nothing at all.

CHAPTER 34

WAR ON MANY FRONTS



I. The Pass

Pell had never seen so many of anything in his life.

He was lying on his belly on a ledge of grey rock high above the Thornhollow Pass, with Wren's old bow in his hands and an arrow on the string and his heart going like a hammer on an anvil, and he was looking east. Down the long grey valley where the old Vhessan road ran out of the Blightmarch and into Caldor. And the valley was full.

Not of people. Of grey.

It filled the road and spilled over onto the grey slopes on either side. It filled the whole valley from wall to wall, as far back as Pell could see, a slow grey tide moving west. Gloamhounds loping at its edges, low and fast. Mistwraiths drifting above it like smoke. Tall stretched grey Gloamed men in ranks, marching, their white eyes fixed ahead. Black-armored Hollow-knights among them, swords dripping darkness. And things Pell had no names for. Things that had been bears, or horses, or oxen, or *people*, once, and weren't anymore.

And it was silent. That was the worst part. Twenty thousand of them, coming up the valley, and not a sound. Not a footstep. Not a breath. Just the grey, moving, like fog rolling in off a cold sea.

Pell's panel was open at the edge of his vision. He'd been looking at it every few minutes since the Stone. He couldn't stop.

PELL MILLWARD

Class: RANGER (Uncommon)

Level: 7

Skills:

Archery Novice 6

Tracking Novice 3

Stealth Novice 4

Level seven. A week ago he'd been a level-one Miller. Now he was a level-seven Ranger, with a bow and a quiver of Brannoc's crooked-runed arrows and a promise to stay at the back.

He wasn't at the back. He was on a ledge three hundred feet above the pass, because Teodra Hale had looked at him and said *you're a Ranger, aren't you? Then go and range. Get up high and tell me what you see.*

He saw the end of the world, coming up the valley.

He wriggled back off the ledge and scrambled down the goat path to the pass, where the army was waiting.

**THEY'D BUILT A WALL.**

Not a real one. There hadn't been time for a real one. They'd been at the pass for two days, and in two days, fifteen hundred people had dragged every boulder and log and cart and barrel they could find into a long rough barricade across the narrowest point of the Thornhollow, where the road ran between two great shoulders of grey rock. It was chest-high in places. Waist-high in others. A dragon could have stepped over it.

But behind it, there were fifteen hundred people. And every one of them had a weapon that was warm.

Pell ran along the back of the barricade to where Teodra Hale was standing on a cart with her greatsword over her shoulder and her bandaged head bare to the wind.

"*Twenty thousand,*" he gasped. "*It's all of them. The whole valley. They'll be here by noon.*"

Teodra looked down at him. Her broad scarred face didn't change.

"Thank you, Ranger," she said. "Go and tell Captain Roole. Then go and find yourself a place on the wall." She paused. "Near the back."

Pell ran.



DAXIAN ROOLE WAS AT the center of the barricade with his two hundred Wardens, their grey cloaks a long line among the motley of farmers and sellswords and knights. He listened to Pell's report in silence. Then he nodded.

"Thank you," he said. And then, looking past Pell: "Vane."

Pell turned. The Inquisitor-General was standing a little way behind the line, alone, with his white hair blowing in the wind and his long coat buttoned to his throat. He'd asked to come. Roole had let him. Pell didn't understand why. Nobody did. The man had turned half of Ashbourne into grey statues.

But he'd also, Pell had seen it, stood at the edge of the green on the night of the Unbinding and watched the Quiet wake up, and wept.

"I'm here," said Vane quietly.

"You said you had something," said Roole. "On the road. You said you'd tell me when it mattered."

Vane looked east. Down the valley. At the grey tide coming.

"The Severance chains," he said. "My chains. They cut the Lattice. Silver threads. That's what they were made for." He lifted his left arm. The chain was wrapped around it again. Not black now. Not dripping. Silver-black, like oil on water, the glyphs on its links glowing faintly. *Sever. Sever. Sever.* "But they cut *threads*. Any thread. That's what Wellsript is: not *silver, thread*." He looked at Roole. "When the Pale Warden had me, I could feel his threads. Running out of him. Into every Gloamed in his army. Like a puppeteer's strings."

Roole went very still.

"I think," said Vane, "I could cut them."

"All of them?"

"No. Not all. I'm only one man with one chain." Vane's slate eyes were very steady. "But some. A few. Enough, maybe, to make a hole."

Roole looked at him for a long moment.

"It'll cost you," he said.

"Everything I did on that green," said Vane quietly, "cost *them*." He looked away. "Let me pay something back, Captain."



THE GREY CAME UP the pass at noon.

Pell was on the wall. Not at the back. He'd tried. He'd gone to the back, like he promised. And then he'd seen the line of Ashbourne folk at the barricade's left end, Farmer Tobbin and the Dunstan twins and Sister Agathe and Gaffer Wim and the Tanners, with their crooked-runed swords and their pitchforks and their brand-new class names and their faces white with terror, and he'd gone and stood with them. Because they were his.

The grey came up the valley like a wave coming up a beach. Slow. Silent. Unstoppable.

And Teodra Hale stood on her cart in the middle of the barricade and raised her greatsword and roared.

It was the loudest sound Pell had ever heard. It went up off the grey rocks and echoed down the valley, and the grey tide flinched. Actually flinched. A ripple went through it, like wind across a field of barley.

And fifteen hundred people roared with her.

Pell roared. He didn't know he was going to. It just came out of him. And beside him, Farmer Tobbin roared, and the Dunstan twins roared, and Sister Agathe, who had never raised her voice above a whisper in all the years Pell had known her, roared like a lion.

And the grey came on.



PELL REMEMBERED THE NEXT hours only in pieces.

Brannoc's arrows. That was the first piece. He nocked one, drew, loosed, the way Wren had shown him in the forge yard. And it struck a gloamhound in the chest, and the crooked rune on the head flared gold, *Ardent*, and the hound *burned*. Not much. Not like Lex's fire. A little gout of gold, and the hound screamed and staggered and came apart. He stared at it. Then he nocked another.

The barricade. Gloamed men climbing it, grey hands reaching. Farmer Tobbin swinging a crooked-runed sword in great clumsy arcs like a man scything barley, and every grey thing it touched flinching back with smoke

pouring off it. Sister Agathe, who'd become a *Lanternkeeper* at the Unbinding, standing on a barrel with her chapel lantern held high over her head, its light washing across the wall, and the Gloam shrinking from it like frost from a fire.

The Dunstan twins, side by side. Both *Shieldbearers* now. Uncommon. Holding a gap in the barricade with two great wooden doors they'd torn off the chapel and carried all the way from Ashbourne. The grey breaking against them like water against a rock.

Hedda Vorne's cart, behind the line, with a portable anvil bolted to the bed and a fire roaring in a brazier, and Brannoc Holt standing at it in his leather apron, and a line of people coming back from the wall with broken swords and bent spears. And Brannoc taking them, and heating them, and striking them, *chang, chang, chang*, with Hedda beside him on a stool reading runes out of the *Book of Making*. And handing them back. Warm.

Roole's Wardens, in the center, in their grey cloaks, fighting like a single creature. Silver light on their blades. Inquisition-light. Disciplined, steady, holding.

And Teodra Hale. Everywhere. On the cart. On the wall. In the gap. Her greatsword moving in great sweeping arcs, her voice never stopping, roaring orders, roaring curses, roaring jokes. Where she went, the line held.

But it bent.

It bent, and bent, and bent. The grey didn't stop. It didn't tire. It didn't flinch for long. It came on and on and on, and every time a farmer fell or a Warden fell or a sellsword fell, there was one less warm blade on the wall, and the grey came a little further.

By mid-afternoon, Pell's quiver was empty.

By late afternoon, the barricade's left end was gone. Tobbin was down, a grey bite on his shoulder, being dragged back by the twins. Sister Agathe's lantern was guttering.

And Pell saw Vane walk out in front of the wall.



HE DID IT ALONE. Through the gap where the left end had been. Out onto the grey road. Into the grey tide.

Nobody stopped him. Pell didn't think anyone saw him go except Pell, and Roole, who turned his head and watched and didn't move.

The Inquisitor-General walked out into the middle of the pass, with the grey all around him. Gloamhounds circling. Gloamed men turning their white eyes toward him. And he lifted his left arm, and the silver-black chain uncoiled from it.

It didn't strike. It *spread*.

It went out from him in every direction at once, longer than any chain could be, links upon links upon links, glowing, singing. *Sever. Sever. Sever.* It went through the grey tide like a net through water. And where it passed, the Gloamed things *stopped*.

Pell saw it. Saw a stretched grey man, mid-stride, freeze. Saw the chain pass through him. Saw something *snap*, a thread, invisible, a black string running from the grey man's back up into the sky toward the east. Saw the grey man stagger, and look around, confused, and then, slowly, sit down in the middle of the road. White eyes blinking.

Saw it happen again. And again. A hundred times. Two hundred. The chain spreading and spreading, the glyphs blazing, cutting thread after thread after thread.

Puppet-strings, Vane had said.

A hole opened in the grey tide around him. A great round hole, a hundred paces across, where the Gloamed things stood still or sat down or wandered aimlessly, cut loose from their master.

Vane stood in the middle of it. His chain was still spreading. His face was white. Whiter than it had been even when he was Gloam-taken. Blood was running from his nose. From his eyes.

"*Vane!*" Roole roared. "*Enough! Come back!*"

Vane didn't come back.

The chain spread further. Two hundred paces. Three. The hole grew. And Pell could see, even from the wall, that the chain was coming *out* of Vane. Not unspooling off his arm. Coming out of *him*. Out of his chest. Out of his life.

He'd said it would cost him.

The grey tide pulled back from the hole. Not much. A little. Like a wave that's hit a rock and doesn't know what to do.

And Lucius Vane, Grand Inquisitor of the Spire, who had turned half of Ashbourne into grey statues and hunted two brothers across half of Aldermere, stood in the middle of the Thornhollow Pass with a thousand Gloamed things sitting confused in the road around him, and looked back at the wall.

At Roole. At the Ashbourne folk. At Pell.

He smiled. A small, tired, strange smile.

And the chain went out of him completely, all at once, a great flash of silver-black light that rolled across the valley like a wave. And when it faded, he was lying in the road.

Very still.

The grey tide didn't come back into the hole. Not for an hour. Not for two.

By then, the sun was going down. And the grey, for the first time all day, *stopped*. Pulled back. Out of the pass. Into the valley. To wait for morning.

The wall had held.

THORNHOLLOW PASS – DAY 1

Line: HELD

Lattice integrity: 43%



II. The Causeway

Elowen Dunmore was not her father.

She knew it. She'd known it her whole life. Garrick Dunmore was a mountain. Broad and slow and patient, a man who stood in doorways. She was faster. Sharper. She'd made captain at twenty-two because she could read a battlefield like a book and move a company across it like a hand across a page. She didn't stand in doorways. She went *through* them.

But there was only one way into Saltreach from the south. A causeway. Two miles long and thirty feet wide, a raised road of fitted stone running across the salt marshes from the coast road to the city gates. And three thousand Gloamed coming up it.

And she had fifty knights.

And the Saltreach militia, which was four hundred dockworkers with boathooks, and a dozen sea-mages from the harbor guild who'd never fought anything but a storm.

"*Hold the causeway,*" she told them, from the back of her horse, at the city end of it, at dusk, with the grey tide coming up out of the marsh mist two miles away. "That's all. Just hold it. They can't come through the marsh. It'll swallow them. The causeway's the only way. Hold it, and the city stands."

"For how long?" said the harbor-master, a squat bald woman with a voice like a foghorn.

Elowen looked at the grey coming up the causeway. Three thousand. Silent.

She thought of her father. Standing on the chapel steps for three days, with half a sword. Standing at the gate at Caldris, with three holes in him.

I'm standing on the steps.

"For as long as we can stand," she said.



THEY STOOD FOR A night and a day.

Elowen remembered it the way her father would have, afterward: not as a battle, but as a *doorway*. Thirty feet of stone, and herself in it. Her fifty knights in a wedge across the causeway, shields locked, swords out. The dockworkers behind them with their boathooks, hauling Gloamed things off the edges of the causeway into the marsh, where the black water took them. The sea-mages on the city walls behind, calling the tide.

That was the thing she remembered best. The sea-mages, a dozen terrified harbor-guild wizards who'd never fought anything but a storm, standing on the walls of Saltreach in the dark with their arms raised. Calling the sea. And the sea *coming*. In the middle of the night, against the moon, against the season, the tide came in. Over the marshes. Up the sides of the causeway. Higher. Higher. Until the grey things on the causeway were wading, waist-deep, chest-deep, in black salt water.

And the Gloam *hated* the sea.

Elowen didn't know why. Nobody did. Maybe because the sea was older than anything. Maybe because it moved, always, never still, never

quiet. But where the salt water touched the Gloamed, they flinched and slowed and stumbled, and the black in them thinned. And her knights, standing on the high crown of the causeway with the tide lapping at their boots, cut them down.

But there were three thousand.

By dawn, she had thirty knights. By noon, twenty. The dockworkers had lost a hundred. The tide was going out. The sea-mages were collapsing on the walls, one by one, drained.

And the grey kept coming.

Elowen stood in the center of the wedge with her sword in her hand and blood running down her face from a cut on her scalp and her shield arm numb to the shoulder. She'd stopped counting how many she'd killed. She'd stopped thinking about anything but the next one, and the next, and the next.

And at noon, a sail appeared on the sea.

Then another. Then a dozen. Coming in from the west, out of the haze, fast, white sails full of a wind that came from nowhere. Saltreath ships. The merchant fleet. And at the prow of the lead ship, a figure, standing very straight, with a blue cloak streaming from her shoulders and a circlet of silver on her brow.

Elowen stared.

The ships came in to the marshes on the last of the tide, as close to the causeway as they could get. And over their sides poured men. Sailors. Marines. Knights. *More* knights, in blue cloaks with the silver crown on their shields, the Royal Guard, five hundred of them, wading through the shallows toward the causeway with their swords out.

And the woman at the prow of the lead ship lifted her arm, and pointed at the grey on the causeway, and her voice carried across the marsh as clear as a bell.

"For Caldor. For every Ceiling. For every Stone."

The Royal Guard hit the grey tide from the flank like a hammer hitting hot iron.

Elowen stood in the middle of the causeway and watched it happen and couldn't move.

"*Captain*," gasped Sir Aldous beside her. He was leaning on his sword, bloody to the elbows. "*Captain, is that—*"

"Yes," said Elowen. Her voice was very strange. "Yes. That's the Princess."

The grey broke.

SALTREACH CAUSEWAY – HELD

Royal intervention: CONFIRMED

LYSANDRA OF CALDOR

Class: SOVEREIGN (Epic)

Lattice integrity: 42%



III. The Sky

Lex didn't see either battle. He felt them.

He felt them the way you feel thunder before you see the lightning. In his chest. In his panel. In the Lattice itself, which he could feel now, all the time, faint and vast, like the hum of a great forge in another room. He felt it shudder when Vane's chain spread through the Thornhollow Pass. He felt it shudder again when the sea came in over the Saltreach marshes. Every Gloamed thread cut, every grey thing driven back, sent a little tremor through the net.

And he felt it *thin*.

LATTICE INTEGRITY: 42%

Every few hours, a point. Steady. Relentless. Like sand running out of a glass.

[He's speeding up,] said Ember quietly. *[Morvane. The graft. He knows we're coming. He's pulling faster.]*

They'd been flying for three days. East over the grey Blightmarch. Ashka's great wings beating steady, Antho on her neck, Lex behind him, Seraphine behind Lex with her arms around his waist and her face pressed against his back. Garrick had taken the last place, clinging on grimly with his good arm, his face grey with something that wasn't Gloam. He'd been

sick twice. He said he'd never been on anything higher than a horse and never intended to be again.

And Wren, flying beside them. Stepping on the wind. Coming down to rest on Ashka's back when her Windstep ran out, then stepping off again when it came back. Her face was windburned and tired and fierce.

They flew high. Above the grey. Above the Gloam that lay over the Blightmarch like a fog. Up where the air was thin and cold and clean, and the sky was blue, and the sun was bright. Below them, the grey went on forever. Above them, there was nothing but sky.

On the second day, the wraith-birds found them.



THEY CAME UP OUT of the grey like smoke rising from a fire. Black. Ragged. Bird-shaped, but too many wings, and too long, trailing tails of black mist behind them like streamers. Dozens of them. Hundreds. Rising up through the clean blue air toward the dragon, screaming. A high thin glass-cracking scream, like the gloamhounds, only higher.

GLOAM-WRAITH (avian) – Level 30
(×112)

"Down!" Antho shouted. *"Everyone down! Hold on!"*

Ashka folded her wings and dove.

Lex's stomach went up into his throat. Seraphine screamed into his back. Garrick swore a long string of words Lex had never heard him use. The wind howled past them so hard Lex couldn't breathe, and the grey came up toward them like the floor of a well.

And then Ashka spread her wings and pulled out of the dive, and the wraith-birds overshot, screaming, and tumbled past them into the grey.

And came back.

"They're faster than us!" Wren was beside them, Windstepping, an arrow on her string. *"Smaller. Faster. They'll catch us!"*

Lex looked back. The wraith-birds were climbing again. A black cloud of them. Coming.

He couldn't use Ember Strike. Not from a dragon's back. Not without setting fire to the dragon. He couldn't use Slag Shot; he'd lose his grip.

He reached for Flame.

I'm on a dragon, he told it. With my brother and my friends. And those things want to tear us out of the sky. And I want to protect them.

The fire came. Not from him. From the *air*. From the sunlight, the bright clean sunlight of the high sky. It came together around Ashka like a shell. A gold glowing shell of heat, shimmering, like Ironskin stretched over the whole dragon and everyone on her.

The first wraith-bird hit it and burst like a soap bubble.

The second. The third. A dozen. They came at the shell screaming and burst against it in black puffs of smoke, and the smoke burned away in the gold.

But there were a hundred.

"Lex!" Antho, twisting round on Ashka's neck. "Lex, you can't hold that forever! I can feel it through the Bloodbond! It's eating you!"

He knew. He could feel the mana draining out of him. Fast. Too fast. Eight hundred. Seven hundred.

And Wren stepped off the wind.

Not into the dragon's shell. *Away* from it. Out into the open sky. Into the black cloud of wraith-birds.

"WREN!"

She didn't look back. She stood on the empty air with the black cloud all around her, and she raised her bow. Not to shoot. She held it over her head in both hands, the way Sister Agathe held her lantern.

And she called the wind.

Not a breeze. Not a gust. A *gale*. It came screaming out of the clean blue sky from every direction at once, a great roaring spiral of wind with Wren at its center. The wraith-birds caught in it were torn apart. Shredded. Their long ragged wings ripped to streamers. Their black mist-tails torn off and scattered across the sky like ash in a chimney draft.

Lex had never seen anything like it. Wren, small and slim, with her fox-red braid whipping around her head and her bow raised high, standing in the eye of a storm she'd made.

The wraith-birds that weren't caught fled. Screaming. Down into the grey.

And Wren's Windstep ran out.

She fell.



ASHKA WAS ALREADY DIVING.

Lex didn't tell her to. Nobody did. The dragon simply folded her wings and dropped, faster than she'd ever dropped, a blue-grey streak plunging toward the grey sea of Gloam below, after the small falling figure with the fox-red braid.

Lex leaned out over the dragon's side as far as he could. Seraphine was holding onto his belt with both hands. Garrick was holding onto Seraphine.

Wren was falling face-down, arms spread, toward the grey. She wasn't screaming. She was looking up. At them. At the dragon coming down after her. And her face, as Ashka came alongside, was absolutely calm.

Lex grabbed her wrist.

Ashka spread her wings. The jolt nearly tore Lex's arm out of its socket. He held on. Held on. Ashka pulled out of the dive a hundred feet above the grey, so close that the Gloam swirled up around her wingtips like smoke, and climbed. And Lex hauled Wren up onto the dragon's back and into his arms, and held her, and held her, and didn't let go.

"Idiot," he said into her hair. "*Idiot. You stupid, stupid, brilliant—*"

"*I know,*" said Wren, muffled against his chest. She was shaking. Laughing and shaking. "*I know, Hammer. I know.*"

WREN ASHDOWN

Gale: ANSWERING → SPEAKING

New skill: TEMPEST

Call the storm. Be its eye.

"*Speaking,*" whispered Wren, reading it. "Lex. Gale's at Speaking now. Like Antho's Shade." She laughed, wild and breathless. "Malachi said that was the third stage. I skipped past you."

"I know."

"I'm going to be *unbearable*."

"You were always unbearable."

She hit him in the chest. Then she kissed him. Then she put her head on his shoulder and fell asleep, instantly, exhausted, in the middle of the sky.



THEY SAW DUSKHOLD ON the evening of the third day.

It rose out of the grey like a broken tooth. Black. Glassy. Enormous. Not built. *Grown*. Out of the earth itself, black Gloam-stone rising in towers and spires and walls that leaned and twisted at angles that hurt to look at. No windows that Lex could see. No doors. No banners. No lights.

And around it, for miles in every direction, the Quiet.

They stood in the grey fields around the fortress in rows. Thousands of them. Tens of thousands. Grey and white-eyed and motionless, facing inward, toward the black towers. Like iron filings around a lodestone.

And over the fortress, circling, slow and silent, a vast dead shape with grey wings.

Sorrowmaw.

Ashka saw it and made a sound that broke Lex's heart.

"*At the center,*" said Seraphine, behind him. Her voice was very quiet. She'd taken out the map Vane had drawn for them, by the fire in the Crooked Kettle, and was holding it against Lex's back to read it in the last of the light. "*A round hall. Open to the sky. The chasm's in the middle. The crystal's on a plinth at the edge.*" She swallowed. "*Vane said there's no roof on the hall. You can see the sky from inside. He said the dragon goes in and out that way.*"

Lex looked at the black fortress. At the center of it, where the towers leaned together around something. At the faint grey glow rising from that center, like light coming up out of a well.

"Then that's how we go in," he said.

LATTICE INTEGRITY: 41%

SEAL INTEGRITY: 2%

Two percent.

[*He's almost gone,*] said Ember. Its voice was barely a whisper. [*Lex. He's almost gone.*]

I know.

Antho had turned on Ashka's neck. He was looking back at Lex. In the dusk, his grey eyes were very dark. Shade-dark. The sky between the stars.

"Together?" he said.

Lex looked at his brother. At Wren, waking in his arms, blinking at the black fortress. At Seraphine, with the map against his back. At Garrick, grey-faced and grim, with his good hand on Oathkeeper's hilt.

At the dragon under them, staring at the vast grey shape that had been her father, circling over the black towers.

"Together," he said.

Ashka folded her wings, and dove.

CHAPTER 35

DUSKHOLD



SORROWMAW SAW THEM HALFWAY down.

Lex felt it before he saw it. A change in the air. A cold that came up from below like water rising in a well. And then the vast grey shape that had been circling lazily over the black towers *turned*. Its great dead wings tilted. Its long neck swung round. And its blank white eyes, each the size of a cartwheel, fixed on the blue-grey dragon diving out of the dusk.

It opened its jaws.

"*Ashka*—" Antho shouted.

The Gloam came out of Sorrowmaw's mouth in a torrent. Black and oily and endless, a river of it, pouring up through the darkening air toward them like smoke up a chimney. Lex threw up the gold shell of heat around them. Felt it take the first of the black flood. Felt it *strain*.

And Ashka didn't dodge.

She went straight into it.

She folded her wings tight and plunged into the black torrent like a diver into a lake, and Lex felt the gold shell shudder and buckle around them, felt the Gloam hissing and boiling against it on every side, felt Seraphine screaming into his back and Garrick's good hand clamped on his shoulder like a vise. Black all around. Black and cold and roaring. He couldn't see. He couldn't breathe.

And then they were through.

Out the other side of the black river, into clear air, with the vast grey shape of Sorrowmaw directly in front of them. So close Lex could see the

cracks in its grey scales. The black seeping from them. The white eyes, blank and enormous, staring.

Ashka screamed.

Not a battle cry. Not a roar. The high thin plaintive cry Lex had heard at Avaloria. The cry of a hatchling calling.

Father. Father. Father.

And Sorrowmaw *stopped*.

It hung in the air above the black towers, its great wings beating slow and silent, and its white eyes fixed on the little blue-grey dragon in front of its face. And something moved in them. Deep in the white. A flicker. Gold. A deep molten amber, slit-pupiled like a cat's.

The way it had at Avaloria. For one heartbeat.

But this time it didn't go away.

It *flickered*. Gold, then white. Gold, then white. Like a candle in a draft. Like a man trying to wake from a nightmare.

[Lex,] said Ember. [He's fighting it. The Gloam. He's fighting it. Like Antho fights the thief.]

"Ashka," said Antho. His voice was very quiet. He was leaning forward on her neck, his hands buried in her crest. "*Ashka. Put us down. On the tower. The one by the hall. Then go to him.*"

The dragon twisted her long neck around and looked at him. Her golden eyes were enormous and wet.

"*Go to him,*" said Antho. "*He's in there. He's still in there. I can hear him. Shade can hear him.*" His voice cracked. "*Go and remind him who he is. The way Lex reminded me.*"



SHE PUT THEM DOWN on the top of a black tower at the edge of the great round hall.

There was no parapet. No battlement. Just a flat glassy top of black Gloam-stone, slippery and cold, leaning out at a sickening angle over the hall below. They slid off her back one by one: Antho, Lex, Seraphine, Garrick. Wren stepped off the air beside them.

And Ashka leaped back into the sky.

Lex watched her go. Up toward the vast grey shape hanging over the fortress. A small blue-grey dragon, barely a tenth its size, flying straight up at it with her silver-framed wing beating hard and her cry going out across the grey sky. *Father. Father. Father.*

Sorrowmaw turned to meet her.

Lex didn't see what happened next. Antho grabbed his arm.

"*Lex.*" His brother's voice was a whisper. "*Lex, look down.*"

He looked down.



THE GREAT HALL OF Duskhold was round, and vast, and had no roof.

From the top of the tower, Lex could see all of it. The black walls curving away on every side, glassy and smooth. The floor, far below, black too. And standing on the floor, in rows, in rings, filling the whole hall from wall to wall: the Quiet. Thousands of them. Grey and white-eyed and motionless. All facing inward.

Toward the center.

In the center of the hall, the floor simply ended. A pit. Ragged. Torn. Black. So black that the eye slid off it and wouldn't stay. Cold air rose out of it in slow waves that Lex could feel even from the top of the tower. And the smell. Wet ash. Rot. Nothing.

The Vhessa breach.

And on the edge of the pit, on a great black plinth that had grown up out of the floor like a fungus, stood the crystal.

It wasn't clear anymore. It was almost entirely black. Black veins had spread through it so thickly that only a few faint faceted patches of clear crystal still showed, like windows in a burned house. And through them, Lex could see his father. Still frozen halfway out. Head and shoulder and one arm outside the crystal, reaching. The rest inside. His face grey. His eyes open.

His eyes were closed.

They'd been open. At Caldris, and in every report since. *Open and fixed.* Now they were closed.

SEAL INTEGRITY: 1%

And standing in front of the crystal, with one white hand pressed flat against its black-veined surface, was Morvane.

He wasn't looking up. He didn't need to. He was very still, very calm, his long white coat hanging straight, his white hair stirring in the cold air rising from the pit. Black threads ran from his fingers into the crystal. Thousands of them. Fine as spider silk. And from the crystal, other threads ran out. Silver ones. Gold ones. Running *into* Morvane. Through his hand. Up his arm. Into him.

The net. Running through him. Thread by thread.

LATTICE INTEGRITY: 41% → 40.6%

GRAFT: 94%

"Ninety-four," whispered Seraphine. She was lying flat on the glassy tower-top beside Lex, peering over the edge through her cracked spectacles. "Lex. The graft's at ninety-four. When it hits a hundred—"

"I know."

"We have minutes. *Minutes*."

Lex looked down at the hall. At the thousands of Quiet. At the black pit. At the white figure with his hand on the crystal.

There was no way down. The tower's sides were sheer, glassy black, two hundred feet to the hall floor. No stair. No ladder. No doors. Duskhold had no doors.

"Wren," he said.

She was already moving. She stepped off the edge of the tower into the air, and caught the wind, and held out her hand.

"One at a time," she said. "I can carry one at a time. Down to the floor." She looked at the thousands of Quiet below. "Somewhere near the crystal. Somewhere clear."

"There isn't anywhere clear."

"Then I'll *make* somewhere clear."



SHE TOOK GARRICK FIRST. Because, she said, if there was going to be a fight at the bottom, someone should be standing on the steps when the rest of them got there.

The old knight didn't argue. He took her hand with his good one and stepped off the tower into nothing, and his face went the color of ash, and he swore very quietly and very continuously all the way down. Wren lowered him through the cold air in a long spiral, down toward the floor of the hall, toward a place near the black plinth where the Quiet stood thinnest.

And as they came down, the Quiet turned their heads.

All of them. At once. Thousands of grey faces with white eyes, turning upward, toward the two figures coming down out of the sky. In perfect silence.

And then the silence *broke*.

Not a scream. Not a roar. A whisper. From every one of them. Rising up out of the hall like steam out of a cauldron.

[bright ... bright ... quiet them ... quiet the bright ones ... quiet ...]

They began to move.



GARRICK HIT THE FLOOR and drew Oathkeeper in one motion. Blue-white fire ran along the blade. Frost bloomed from it. And the first grey hands that reached for him shattered into splinters and didn't rise again.

Bind.

Wren went back up for Seraphine. Then Antho. Each time, the Quiet surged toward the place where they landed, and Garrick met them, and held.

And then she came back for Lex.

He took her hand. He stepped off the edge of the tower. And for one long moment he was falling through the cold dark air above the hall of Duskhold, with the black pit below him and the white figure at its edge and the thousands of grey faces turned upward, and nothing holding him up but Wren's small hard hand and the wind she was calling.

"Don't look down," she said. "Climber's rule."

He looked at her instead. At her windburned freckled face, set and fierce. At her fox-red braid streaming upward in the air.

"I love you," he said.

He hadn't meant to. It just came out. The way the fourth rune had come out on the anvil in Ashbourne.

Wren looked at him. Her green eyes went very wide.

"Now?" she said. *"You're telling me NOW?"*

"It seemed like a good time."

"We're FALLING into a FORTRESS full of—"

"I know."

She stared at him. Then she laughed. Wild and helpless, in the middle of the dark air above Duskhold.

"You're an idiot, Hammer," she said. *"I love you too."*

Their feet hit the black floor.



THE SILENCE CAME DOWN on them like a lid.

Lex felt it the moment his boots touched the black stone. Duskhold's silence. The silence Elric had walked through for weeks. It pressed against his ears. It filled his mouth. When he opened it to shout to Garrick, nothing came out. The sound died an inch from his lips.

He could hear the whisper of the Quiet. Only that. Rising and falling around them like wind in dead grass. [*quiet ... quiet ... quiet ...*] The fortress let its own voice through. Nothing else.

Garrick was fighting in silence. Oathkeeper rising and falling, blue-white and gold. No clang of steel. No grunt of effort. Just the whisper, and the cold, and the grey hands reaching.

Lex looked at Antho. His brother's mouth was moving. Nothing came out.

Bloodbond, Lex thought. And reached.

[Can you hear me?]

[Yes.] Antho's voice. In his head. Clear as a bell. *[Yes. Through the Bloodbond. It can't stop that.]*

[Ember?]

[I'm here,] said Ember. *[It can't stop me either. I'm on the inside.]*

Lex looked at Wren. At Seraphine. At Garrick. They had no Bloodbond. No voice in their heads. Only hands and eyes.

Seraphine was already moving. She had a stick of charcoal in her hand, she always had charcoal, and she was writing on the black floor. Big letters. *CRYSTAL. WARDS. NEED 5 MIN. COVER ME.*

Garrick read it over his shoulder. He nodded. He turned and planted his feet in front of her, between her and the Quiet, with Oathkeeper raised. *On the steps.*

Wren nocked an arrow. Kindled it with a thought from Lex, gold fire running down the shaft. She turned to face the other way.

And Lex and Antho turned toward the crystal.



MORVANE HADN'T MOVED.

He was standing exactly where he'd been, with his white hand on the black crystal, the black threads running from his fingers into it and the silver and gold threads running out of it into him. His back was to them. He hadn't turned around. He hadn't looked up when they came down out of the sky.

But he spoke.

His voice was the only voice in Duskhold that made a sound. Soft. Reasonable. Pleasant. Coming from everywhere at once, the way the whisper of the Quiet did.

"Hello, boys," said Morvane. *"I was wondering when you'd come."*

He still didn't turn.

"You're too late, I'm afraid," he said. *"Ninety-five percent. Ninety-six. He's letting go, at last. Your father. He held on so long. Longer than anyone could. But he's letting go now."* His voice was almost tender. *"He's very tired. He wants to rest. I'm going to let him rest."*

Lex walked toward him across the black floor. Antho beside him. The Quiet parted before them. Not attacking. Just *stepping back*, the way they'd stepped back on Ashbourne's green from the remembering anvil. Making a path. A long straight path through the grey rows, from where they stood to the plinth at the edge of the pit.

As if Morvane *wanted* them to come.

[It's a trap,] said Ember. [Lex. It's obviously a trap.]

[I know.]

[You're walking into it anyway.]

[He's my father.]

[I know,] said Ember softly. [I know. I'm just saying.]

They were halfway down the path when the lightning hit them.



IT CAME FROM THE side. From the black wall of the hall, where an archway opened into one of the corridors without doors. Gold lightning. Root-gold. It struck the floor between Lex and Antho and the black stone *exploded*, and they were flung apart, Lex one way and Antho the other, rolling, sliding across the glassy floor.

Lex came up on one knee with Anvilson in his hands.

Elric Thorne was standing in the archway.

He looked old. Older than Lex had ever seen him. Bent. Grey. Hollow-cheeked, as if he hadn't eaten in weeks. His grey cloak hung off him like a sack. The brass storm-charms on it were dull and tarnished. His lightning-scarred staff was in his hand, and its head was crackling with gold.

And his eyes.

His eyes were the eyes of a man who hasn't slept since he did something terrible.

His lips moved. No sound came out. Duskhold took it. But Lex could read them. He'd been reading lips since the vision in the Barrow-King's hall.

I'm sorry.

He raised his staff again.



LEX DIDN'T WANT TO fight him.

That was the strangest part. He'd imagined this, every night since Caldri. Lying awake in the ruined tower, in the Pale Wastes, in the Stillwater. Imagined finding Elric. Imagined the old man's face when Lex walked up to him with his fire back and his class unlocked and Ember in his head. Imagined hitting him. Burning him. Making him *pay*.

Now he was here. And Elric was standing in the archway, old and grey and hollow, with gold lightning crackling on his staff and *I'm sorry* on his lips.

And Lex didn't want to fight him.

The lightning came anyway.

He threw up Ironskin. Gold heat over his skin, Well-fed now, thicker than it had ever been. The lightning hit it and *splashed*, like water on a hot forge, gold on gold, and scattered across the black floor in crackling streams. He felt it through the heat. Felt the stolen Root in it. His father's Root.

He stood up.

Elric's eyes went wide.

He struck again. Harder. Lightning poured off his staff in a torrent, gold and blue-white, the stolen Root and his own Stormcaller power together. Lex took it on Anvilson's head. The hammer *drank* it. The runes blazed. *Ardent*. Held heat. Held lightning. The hammer glowed white in his hands.

He walked toward Elric through the storm.

The old sorcerer backed away. Into the archway. Into the corridor. His face was white. His lips were moving. Lex couldn't read them now; Elric was talking too fast, too frantically.

Lex reached him.

He didn't swing the hammer. He reached out with his free hand and took Elric's staff, the lightning-scarred ash staff with the gold crackling on its head, and *pulled* it out of the old man's grip. As easily as taking a stick from a child.

Elric staggered back against the wall of the corridor.

Lex held the staff. He looked at it. At the lightning dying on its head. At the brass storm-charms on the cloak of the man in front of him.

Then he reached for Root. For the Lattice. For the place under the air where the stolen gold burned in Elric's chest like a swallowed coal.

[What are you doing?] said Ember.

[Looking,] said Lex.

He used True Sight.

ELRIC THORNE

Class: STORMCALLER (Epic)

Tier III – Level 67

AUTHORITY: 9 / 100

Source: STOLEN (ARION VEY)

Held back from graft: 9

(concealed)

CONDITION:

Sleep: none (31 days)

Grief: ██████████

Hollow-graft (palm): ACTIVE

– Morvane's thread

Held back. Concealed. Nine points.

Lex looked up from the panel. At the old man pressed against the corridor wall.

Elric was weeping.

He wasn't making a sound. Duskhold wouldn't let him. But the tears were running down his grey hollow face into his beard, and his whole body was shaking.

His lips moved. Slowly. So Lex could read them.

I kept some. For him. I couldn't give it all.

Lex stared at him.

He'll quiet me too, said Elric's lips. When it's done. He told me. Everyone. Me too. His mouth twisted. I gave him everything. I gave him your father. And he's going to make me nothing.

[Lex,] said Ember very quietly. [The graft on his palm. Morvane's thread. It's still active.]

Lex looked down. At Elric's left hand, pressed flat against the black wall. At the mark on the palm. Black. Branching. Like cracks in porcelain.

And running from it, so fine he'd never have seen it without True Sight, a thread. Black. Running out of the corridor, into the hall, across the floor, to the white figure standing at the crystal.

A leash.

[He can feel Elric,] said Ember. [Through it. Everything Elric feels. Everything he does.] A pause. [He knows you're here. He's known since you landed.]

Lex looked at the thread. Then at Elric.

Elric was looking at it too. At his own palm. At the black mark.

Then he looked up at Lex. And his lips moved one more time.

Cut it.



LEX DIDN'T HESITATE.

He reached out with Anvilson, still glowing white with Elric's lightning, and laid the hammer's head against the black mark on the old sorcerer's palm. And he reached for Flame.

He betrayed us, he told it. He gave my father to the thing that's killing him. He killed Brisk. He nearly killed Seraphine. He locked me away and took Ember from me. He swallowed. And he's sorry. And he's asking for help. And I don't know if I can forgive him. But I can't leave him on a leash.

The fire came.

It went into the black mark on Elric's palm like a hot iron into wax. The mark *screamed*. Not Elric. The *mark*. A thin high shriek that tore through Duskhold's silence like a knife through cloth, and the black branching lines writhed and smoked and burned. And the thread running from them across the hall to Morvane went taut, and *snapped*.

Elric gasped. Out loud. A real sound, in the silent corridor. He crumpled against the wall and slid down it and sat on the black floor, clutching his burned hand to his chest.

And across the hall, at the crystal, Morvane's head *turned*.

For the first time since they'd landed. Slowly. Over his shoulder. His white eyes found Lex, standing in the archway of the corridor with a glowing hammer in one hand and Elric's staff in the other.

And something went across his porcelain face.

Not calm. Not patience.

Anger.



LEX DROPPED THE STAFF on the floor beside Elric.

The old sorcerer looked up at him. His face was wet. His burned hand was pressed to his chest.

"*Why?*" he whispered. Out loud. The fortress let him, now, with the thread cut. "*Why would you—after what I did—*"

"Because Father wouldn't have left you on a leash either," said Lex.

Elric stared at him.

"Stay here," said Lex. "Don't follow us. Don't help us. Don't hurt us." He turned toward the hall. "When this is over, you can tell him yourself what you did. To his face. Not through a crystal."

"*Lex.*" Elric's voice cracked. "*Lex, I can't—I can't face him—*"

"Then don't." Lex looked back at him. "But don't come near my brother again. Or my friends. Or my father. Ever." His voice was very quiet. "I'm not going to kill you, Elric. But I'm not going to forgive you either. Not today."

He walked back out into the hall.

Behind him, he heard the old man begin to sob. Out loud. For the first time in thirty-one days.



ANTHO WAS ON HIS feet.

He'd been flung against the wall when the lightning struck, and Lex could see a long cut on his forehead, bleeding into his eyes. But he was standing. The Keeper's Lantern was blazing at his belt. And the shadows were rising off him. Not wild. Not uncontrolled. Rising like smoke from a banked fire, slow and steady and *his*.

[You let him go,] said Antho's voice, through the Bloodbond.

[I cut his leash.]

[After everything.]

[After everything.]

Antho looked at him across the black floor. His grey eyes were very dark.

[Mam would have done the same,] he said at last. *[I think. I'm not sure I could have.]*

[You don't have to. I did it.]

Antho looked at him a moment longer. Then he nodded, once. And turned toward the crystal.

The path through the Quiet was still there. Long and straight. Leading to the plinth at the edge of the pit.

And at the end of it, Morvane had turned around.



HE WAS SMILING AGAIN. The anger was gone from his face. Smoothed away like a wrinkle in a sheet. But Lex had seen it. He knew it was there now. Under the calm. Under the patience. A fault line, running through the porcelain.

"You cut my thread," said Morvane softly. His voice came from everywhere. *"That was rude. Elric was useful."*

"He was your slave," said Lex.

"He was my friend. As much as he was anyone's." Morvane tilted his head. *"He gave me your father. Did you know that? Not just the Anchor. Not just the lake. He gave me the moment. The waking. The exact instant when Arion's Authority would flow out of the crystal and back into his body, defenseless."* He smiled. *"Forty years of friendship. He knew exactly when Arion would be weakest. Because he'd been watching him be strong for so long."*

"Stop talking," said Antho.

Morvane's white eyes moved to him.

"Anthoren," he said. *"The deep one. The keeper of the door."* His smile widened. *"You closed the Hollowmaw. I felt it. A whole breach, closed. With Shade."* He shook his head, almost admiringly. *"I didn't think anyone still could."*

"I'll close this one too," said Antho.

Morvane laughed.

It was a real laugh. Soft and delighted. It rolled around the great round hall and up into the open sky and the Quiet swayed in their rows like grass in a wind.

"This one?" he said. *"This one is the first, child. The oldest. The deepest. The wound that all the others spread from."* He gestured at the black pit behind him. *"You can't close it. No one can. Not even your father could. He*

tried." His white eyes glittered. *"Sixteen years ago. Right here. That's what he was doing, you know. When it opened. Trying to rewrite the net. To break every Ceiling at once."* He smiled. *"He was trying to do what you've been doing. All at once. With a single Rewrite."*

Lex went cold.

"He failed," said Morvane softly. *"And the net tore. Right here. And the hunger came through. And it found me, standing beside him."* He spread his white hands. *"He did this, boys. Your father. With his good intentions. Every breach. Every Gloamed. Every grey village. Every Quiet in this hall."* His voice dropped to a whisper. *"Have you never wondered why he left? Why he sealed you? Why he spent fifteen years in a crystal, holding the net together?"* He leaned forward. *"Guilt. Nothing but guilt. He broke the world, and he's been trying to hold the pieces together ever since."*

Nobody said anything.

Behind Morvane, in the black crystal, through one of the last clear windows, Lex saw his father's face. Grey. Eyes closed.

And a tear running down it.

[He can hear,] said Ember. Its voice was breaking. *[Lex, he can hear. He's listening to every word.]*

GRAFT: 97%
SEAL INTEGRITY: 1%
LATTICE INTEGRITY: 40.3%

Lex looked at the tear on his father's face.

He thought about a man walking up and down in the dark with a feverish child, singing off-key. A man folding a little boy's fingers over a horseshoe nail. *Keep it, little smith.* A man with a forgettable face cutting a piece out of himself and pressing it into a seal so his son would have someone, even if he couldn't be there.

A man who broke the world trying to free it, and spent fifteen years holding the pieces.

"I don't care," said Lex.

Morvane's smile flickered.

"I don't care what he did," said Lex. His voice was very steady. "I don't care why he did it. I don't care if it was guilt or love or both." He lifted

Anvilsong. It was still glowing white with Elric's lightning, and the gold of his own fire, and something else now. Something from the river. "He's my father. He sang to me. And you're hurting him."

He looked at Antho. His brother looked back. In the grey light of the hall, under the open sky, with the black pit yawning behind the white figure and the crystal and the tear, Antho's eyes were the deep soft dark of Shade.

[Together?] said Antho.

[Together.]

They walked down the path toward the crystal. Side by side.

And above them, in the open sky over Duskhold, a vast grey dragon screamed, and a small blue-grey one screamed back, and lightning split the clouds.

CHAPTER 36

THE FINAL CONFRONTATION



MORVANE DIDN'T FIGHT THEM the way anyone else had ever fought them.

He didn't throw Gloam. He didn't swing a weapon. He didn't send the Quiet. He stood at the edge of the pit with one white hand still pressed flat against the black crystal, the threads still running from it into him, and he *reached*.

Not for their bodies. For their threads.

Lex felt it the moment he stepped off the end of the path into the open circle around the plinth. A hand. Cold and soft and patient. Closing around something inside him. Not his heart. Not his breath. Something under both. The silver threads that ran out of him into the great net of the Lattice. Every skill. Every level. Every point he'd ever spent. A hand closing around all of them at once, the way a fisherman gathers up the lines of a net.

[He's holding the net,] said Ember, sharp and fast. [Ninety-seven percent of it. He doesn't need to fight you. He can reach into the Lattice and take hold of you from the inside.]

The hand *squeezed*.

Lex staggered. His panel flickered. Ember Strike went grey. Ironskin went grey. Heat Shaping. Slag Shot. Kindle. One after another, his skills dimmed, like lamps being turned down in a house at night.

LATTICE CONTROL — FOREIGN*Skills: SUPPRESSED (89%)**Source: MORVANE (graft 97%)*

"*There,*" said Morvane softly. His voice came from everywhere. "*You see? I don't need to fight you, Lexander. I am the net now. Nearly. And you're in it. Every one of you is in it. Every thread. Every knot.*" His white eyes were very calm. "*I can quiet you from the inside. Gently. Like turning down a lamp.*"

Beside Lex, Antho made a sound. Lex felt it through the Bloodbond: the same cold hand, closing on his brother's threads. Squeezing.

But Antho's threads weren't silver. Not most of them. They were black and gold and tangled, and they'd never been properly in the Lattice at all.

The hand slipped.

[It can't get a grip on me,] said Antho, startled. *[Not properly. I was an error for eight years. I've barely got any silver to hold.]*

And Lex had the river.

He reached down. Under the wheel. Past the silver threads that the cold hand was squeezing, past the gold of the Root, down to the place where Flame lived and Stone hummed and the river ran.

He's taking my skills, he told it. *The ones the Lattice gave me. He's turning them down like lamps.* He swallowed. *But I didn't get you from the Lattice. I got you from a fire under a lake. From a nine-hundred-year-old hearth. From a smith who raised me.*

The fire came up from the river.

Not through the Lattice. Not through any skill. It came up from under the wheel, from the Wells, like heat coming up through the floor of a forge. Gold. Steady. *His.* It filled him. And where it touched the cold hand closing around his threads, the hand *bissed*.

And let go.

LATTICE CONTROL — REJECTED*Well-bound class: UNAFFECTED*

Morvane's head tilted.

"*Ab*," he said. "*The Wells. Malachi's tricks.*" His smile flickered. "*I'd heard he was still alive. I didn't believe it.*"

He took his hand off the crystal.

For the first time since they'd landed, he stepped away from it. One step. Two. Toward them, across the black floor at the edge of the pit. And the threads that had been running from the crystal into him didn't break. They *stretched*. Followed him. Silver and gold, thousands of them, fine as spider silk, trailing from the crystal to his back like the strings of a great marionette, like the train of a vast shimmering cloak.

"*Then I'll do it the old way*," said Morvane.

The Gloam came off him in a wave.



IT WAS NOTHING LIKE the hounds. Nothing like the wraiths, or the overseer, or Vane. It was *everything*. It came off him in every direction at once, black and oily and endless, a tide of it, rolling across the floor of the hall toward them. And it didn't just come at them. It came at *everything*. It washed over the rows of Quiet, and the Quiet sighed and swayed and went greyer. It washed up the black walls of the hall. It rose up into the open sky.

And it was *loud*. For the first time in Duskhold, something was loud. The Gloam roared as it came, a sound like every scream Lex had ever heard all at once, the hounds and the wraiths and the miller and the overseer and the thing in his brother's head.

[*QUIET QUIET QUIET QUIET QUIET—*]

Lex threw up Ironskin. Well-fed. Gold. He threw it over himself and over Antho, stretching it, a shell of heat. The black tide hit it and *boiled*.

Antho threw up Shade. Not the wild uncontrolled storm of the cellar at Caldris. Something else. A dome. Soft and deep and dark, like the night sky between the stars, closing over the two of them inside Lex's gold shell. Dark holding fire. Fire holding dark.

The tide broke against them and split and roared past on either side like a river around a rock.

And behind them, across the circle, Lex heard Garrick roar.



HE'D FORGOTTEN.

He'd forgotten, for a moment, that they weren't alone. That behind them, at the edge of the circle, a scarred old knight with one good arm was standing over a burned scholar with a stick of charcoal, holding back a hall full of grey hands so she could read the wards on the crystal.

The black tide hit them.

Lex twisted around inside the gold shell and saw it. Saw the Gloam wash over the circle where Garrick stood. Saw Oathkeeper blaze blue-white and gold in the darkness, frost exploding out from the blade in a ring. Saw the black tide hit the frost and freeze and *shatter*, the way it always shattered against that blade. *Bind*. Gloam struck by this blade cannot re-form.

Saw Garrick standing in the middle of the frost-ring with his feet planted and his sword raised and the black tide breaking around him on every side, with Seraphine crouched at his feet scribbling frantically on the black floor and Wren beside him with her bow, loosing gold-fire arrows into the dark as fast as she could draw.

Holding.

On the steps.

And in the black tide, shapes. Hollow-knights. Dozens of them. Coming out of the Gloam on every side, black-armored, white-eyed, dripping swords raised. Coming at the circle. At Garrick.

"Garrick!"

The old knight didn't look round.



[Lex,] said Ember. [You can't help him. Not and hold the shell. Not and fight Morvane.]

[I know.]

[He knows too. He chose this. He's choosing it right now.]

Lex turned back.

Morvane was standing a dozen paces away, at the edge of the pit, with the threads of the net trailing behind him from the crystal and the black tide pouring off him. He was watching them. Watching the gold shell and the dark dome. His white eyes were very calm.

"*You can't hold that forever,*" he said. "*Either of you. I can feel your mana through the net, Lexander. Even under the Wells. You're burning it like a forge burns coal.*" He smiled. "*And Anthoren, I can feel the thief in you. Clawing at the door. It wants out so badly. It wants to come to me.*"

CLARITY: 94 → 87 ▼

 — RESONATING (Morvane)

Antho's jaw tightened. The Keeper's Lantern blazed at his belt.

"*It's not going to you,*" he said.

"*It already is. It always was.*" Morvane tilted his head. "*We're the same, you and I. Both of us full of it. The only difference is, I stopped fighting.*" His voice was gentle. "*You could stop too. You could rest. Lay down the door. Let it come through. Let it fill you, the way it filled me, and be quiet.*" He spread his white hands. "*No more voices. No more fighting. No more three-in-the-morning.*"

"No," said Antho.

"*Why not?*"

And Antho laughed. A short, cracked, startled laugh, inside the dome of Shade.

"*Because I've got a brother,*" he said. "*And a girl who finishes her sentences. And a dragon. And a mother singing on the other side of a door.*" His grey eyes were very steady. "*And none of them want me to be quiet.*"



THEY NEEDED THE RECKONING.

Lex knew it. Antho knew it. They'd known it since the cellar at Caldris, since the white figure with his hand on the crystal and the black veins spreading. *What is stolen, burns. What is hollow, is unmade.*

But the Reckoning took Authority. All of it. Lex had a hundred. Full. The Wells had filled it on the flight east, four times faster than the old way. Antho had whatever strange deep store he had, black and gold and unmeasurable.

And the Reckoning had failed, at Avaloria. Not failed. *Fallen short.* It had burned the stolen Root out of Morvane and torn away most of the Gloam. But it hadn't reached the deepest knot. The center. The place

where Corvin Morvane had stood beside Arion sixteen years ago and the hunger had found him.

[He's stronger now,] said Ember. [Ninety-seven percent of the net is running through him. The Reckoning judges what's lawful and what's stolen. And he's grafted himself onto the Anchor. He's made himself lawful. At ninety-seven percent, the Root might look at him and see the rightful bearer.]

[Then what do we do?]

[I don't know.] A long pause. *[Lex. I don't know.]*

And then, across the circle, Seraphine screamed.

Not in pain. In *triumph*.

"*HERE!*"

Lex twisted round. She was on her knees at Garrick's feet, inside the frost-ring, with charcoal smeared all over her hands and her face and her cracked spectacles. She'd covered the black floor around her with writing. Glyphs. Wellschrift. Copied from the wards on the crystal. And she was pointing at one. Jabbing at it with her charcoal-black finger.

"The keystone! The graft's keystone! It says BEARER! It's the glyph that names who holds the knot!" Her voice was cracking. *"He's written his own name in it! Over Arion's! It's his name, but Arion's is still there underneath! I can see it!"*

Lex stared at her.

"I'm a Scribe!" Seraphine shrieked. *"Master Inscribe! I wrote three hundred and forty-six names into the Lattice in one night! I can write ONE MORE!"*

She slapped her palm down on the black floor. On the glyph. And her eyes went blank and silver, the way they'd gone on the causeway in the Barrows, and her lips started moving.

Arion Vey. Arion Vey. Arion Vey.

And behind Morvane, in the black crystal, something *flickered*.



MORVANE FELT IT.

He spun around. Toward the crystal. Toward the threads trailing from it to his back. Lex saw them *shudder*. Saw a few of them, a dozen, a

hundred, go slack. Saw them pull away from Morvane's back and drift, uncertain, in the cold air rising from the pit. As if they'd suddenly remembered they belonged to someone else.

GRAFT: 97% → 94% → 91%

BEARER (keystone): CONTESTED

MORVANE (graft)

ARION VEY (inscribed)

"NO," said Morvane.

It was the first time Lex had ever heard him raise his voice. It cracked across the hall like a whip. The whole black tide of Gloam shuddered. The Quiet swayed.

He turned toward the frost-ring. Toward the scarred old knight and the burned scholar on the floor.

And he lifted his hand.

The Gloam came together in front of him. Not a tide. A *spear*. Black. Solid. Glassy. As long as a man, as thick as an arm, its point so sharp it seemed to cut the air around it. It hung in front of Morvane's outstretched hand for one heartbeat.

Then it flew.

Straight across the circle. Straight at Seraphine.



GARRICK STEPPED INTO IT.

He didn't hesitate. He didn't think. He was standing over her with Oathkeeper raised against the Hollow-knights, and he saw it coming, and he simply *moved*, the way he'd moved on the chapel steps and at the gate of Caldris. One step. Sideways. Between the spear and the girl.

It took him in the chest.

Lex saw it. Saw the black glassy point go through the old knight's breastplate, through the *Bulwark* rune Lex had struck into it in Hedda's forge, through him, and stop. An inch from Seraphine's back.

Garrick didn't fall.

He stood there, with the black spear through him, with his good hand still on Oathkeeper's hilt and the blade still raised. He looked down at the spear. Then up. Across the circle. At Lex.

And he smiled.

Crooked. Warm.

On the steps, said his lips. No sound. Duskhold took it.

But Lex heard it anyway.

"*GARRICK*—"

The old knight turned. Slowly. With the spear through him. He turned to face the Hollow-knights coming out of the black tide. And he raised Oathkeeper in both hands. Both. The bad arm too, the one in the sling. He tore it out of the sling and wrapped it around the hilt.

And Oathkeeper *sang*.

It was the loudest it had ever been. Louder than the burned smithy. Louder than the quay in Highcrest. A single vast singing note that tore through the silence of Duskhold like a bell through fog. The three runes on the blade flared gold all at once. *Bulwark. Bind. Oath.* And the frost exploded out from it in a ring fifty paces wide.

Every Hollow-knight it touched shattered.

Every Gloamed thing. Every black wisp. Everything in the ring around the old knight and the girl on the floor and the archer beside them froze, and cracked, and burst, and didn't rise.

And Garrick Dunmore, Knight-Errant, Oathbound, who had stood on the chapel steps for three days with half a sword and held the gate at Caldris with three holes in him, stood in the middle of the frost with his father's sword raised and a black spear through his heart, and held.

OATH – FULFILLED

GARRICK DUNMORE

"I swear to stand on the steps.
Wherever the steps are. For as
long as I can stand."

Then he knelt.

Slowly. The way he'd knelt in the burned smithy, the night Lex reforged Oathkeeper. With the sword point-down before him and both hands on the cross-guard and his grey head bowed.

And didn't get up.



LEX DIDN'T KNOW HE was screaming until his throat tore.

He didn't know he'd moved until he felt the gold shell go out of him in a single blast, outward, every scrap of fire in it, and saw it hit the black tide around Morvane and burn a hole in it fifty paces wide.

He didn't know Antho was screaming too, until he felt it through the Bloodbond. Not the thief. *Antho*. Grief and rage, eight years of grief and three months of brotherhood and a scarred old knight who had made him wash in a stream and taught him to play cards and never once looked at him like a monster.

Morvane turned back to them.

And for the first time, Lex saw something in his white porcelain face that wasn't calm, or patience, or even anger.

Fear.

Because Seraphine was still writing.

She hadn't stopped. She hadn't looked up. Garrick had died over her and she hadn't looked up. She was kneeling in the middle of the frost-ring with tears pouring down her charcoal-smeared face and her palm flat on the keystone glyph and her lips moving, moving, moving. *Arion Vey. Arion Vey. Arion Vey.*

GRAFT: 91% → 86% → 79%
BEARER (keystone): CONTESTED
ARION VEY – gaining

"*Antho*," said Lex.

His brother turned. His face was wet. His grey eyes were dark as the sky between the stars. The Keeper's Lantern was blazing at his belt like a small sun.

"*Now*," said Lex.



THEY REACHED FOR EACH other.

Not through the Twin Stone. Not through the plates of the Bridge of Two Hands. Not through anything. Just through the Bloodbond. Through the place where fire touched dark. Where the forge met the quench.

Lex poured his hundred points of Authority into it. All of it. Every scrap. And Antho poured back his own, deep and strange and black-gold and bottomless.

The Reckoning woke.

BLOODBOND PREROGATIVE: RECKONING

But it wasn't enough. Lex felt it. Felt the Root's judgment rise up and look at Morvane and *hesitate*. Felt it see the graft. Seventy-nine percent. Felt it see Morvane's name written in the keystone, and Arion's underneath, and *not know*. Lawful or stolen. Rightful or hollow. The Root couldn't tell.

[It's not enough,] said Ember. [Lex, it's not enough. The Root can't see through the graft. It's too tangled. It needs—]

[What?]

[Something deeper. Something under the Root. Something that was here before the net.]

The river.

Lex reached down.

Under the Reckoning. Under the Root. Under the gold and the silver and the wheel. Down to the place where Flame lived and Stone hummed and the river ran. And he *told it the truth*.

He killed Garrick, he told Flame. He's killing my father. He wants to make the whole world quiet. And I love them. I love all of them. Every noisy, grieving, stubborn, laughing one of them. He was weeping. He didn't care. *I want them to be loud. I want the world to be loud.*

And beside him, through the Bloodbond, he felt Antho reach down too. Into the dark. Into Shade. Not the thief's dark. The real dark. The night between the stars.

I keep the door, Antho told it. That's what I am. Not him. Me. And I want to keep it for everyone. Not just me. Everyone.

And the Wells answered.



The Reckoning *changed*.

Lex felt it change. Felt the gold and black of it, the Root-judgment, braided fire and shadow, suddenly fill with something else. Something rising up from underneath, the way the Wells had risen up under the Stone at Fenmoor, the way the tide comes in under a beached ship. Flame and Shade. Answering and Speaking. Hot and cold. Bright and deep. Not the wheel's judgment. The *river's*.

RECKONING – EVOLVED
RECKONING: DUSK AND EMBER
Root judgment, carried by the Wells beneath the net.
What is lawful, stands.
What is stolen, burns.
What is hollow, is unmade.
What is lost, is RETURNED.

What is lost, is returned.

The light came out of them.

It came out of their chests, from the place under the breastbone where the seals were. Gold from Lex. Violet-black from Antho. And from underneath, from somewhere far below, from the river, a third light. Not gold. Not black. *White*. Pale and clean and old, like the first light of the first morning.

The three lights braided together in the air between them and became one. A storm. A spiral. Fire and dark and light, twisting together into a single blazing column that lit the whole great round hall of Duskhold brighter than noon.

It struck Morvane.



AND THIS TIME, THE Root could see.

Lex saw what it saw. The Root-judgment, carried on the Wells, looking at Morvane. At everything he was. At every thread.

What is lawful, stands.

Silver threads, faint and few. The ghost of a hard rigid honest Warden-Commander named Corvin Morvane, who had loved order and believed in the Lattice.

Those, it left alone.

What is stolen, burns.

The graft. Thousands of threads. Silver and gold. Stolen from the net, stolen from the Anchor, stolen from the man in the crystal. Running from the crystal to Morvane's back like the strings of a marionette. The braided light found them, and *burned* them. Every one. And Morvane *screamed*, at last, the high thin inhuman scream he'd screamed at Avaloria, as his stolen net went up like dry kindling.

What is hollow, is unmade.

The Gloam. The black. The hunger. Not most of it, this time. *All* of it. Down to the very center. Down to the deepest darkest knot, the place where Corvin Morvane had stood beside Arion sixteen years ago at the edge of a pit that had just torn open and the hunger had come up out of it and *found* him. The braided light reached into him, all the way down, the white light from the river reaching where the Root alone had never reached.

And found it.

And unmade it.

What is lost, is returned.

And all the burned threads, the stolen silver and gold, didn't just vanish. They *went home*. Lex saw them. Saw them pour back out of Morvane in a great shimmering flood, like a river released from a dam. Back across the floor of the hall. Back to the crystal. Back into the black veins, which turned white as the threads poured into them, white and then clear, the black burning away in front of them like frost before a fire.

Back into the man inside.

GRAFT: 79% → 41% → 0%

BEARER (keystone): ARION VEY
RESTORED

STOLEN AUTHORITY: RETURNED
to ARION VEY: 55 / 100
(9 unaccounted)

LATTICE INTEGRITY: 40% → 47% → 52%



MORVANE FELL.

He fell slowly. The way Brisk had fallen in the cellar at Caldris. Like a coat sliding off a peg. He folded to his knees on the black floor at the edge of the pit, and then sideways, and lay there.

His white coat was white. His white hair was white. But his face wasn't porcelain anymore. It was a man's face. Old. Lined. Very tired. And his eyes, when they opened, were brown.

Ordinary brown.

Lex went to him. He didn't know why. He crossed the black floor and knelt beside the old man lying at the edge of the pit.

Corvin Morvane looked up at him.

"*Arion?*" he whispered. His voice was rough. Human. "*Arion, is that—*" He stopped. Blinkered. "*No. No, you're too young. You're—*" His brown eyes moved over Lex's face. "*You're his. You have his hands.*"

"I'm his son," said Lex.

"*His son.*" The old man was quiet for a moment. "*I remember. He had sons. He talked about them, in the east. Before.*" His brown eyes were very far away. "*He was so proud.*"

He was dying. Lex could see it. Sixteen years of Gloam, holding him together. And now it was gone, all of it, and there was nothing underneath but an old man who should have died at the edge of this pit sixteen years ago.

"*It was so quiet,*" Morvane whispered. "*Inside it. For sixteen years. So quiet. I thought—I thought it was peace.*" His voice cracked. "*It wasn't. It was nothing. It was just nothing.*" He looked up at Lex. "*Is it noisy? Out there? The world?*"

Lex looked down at him.

He thought about the green at Ashbourne on the night of the Unbinding. Everyone weeping and laughing and shouting their new class names. Pell screaming *Ranger*. The Dunstan twins sobbing. Mother Orla's barrels. Brannoc's boom of a laugh at his first crooked rune.

"Yes," he said. "It's very noisy."

Corvin Morvane smiled. A small, tired, human smile.

"Good," he whispered.

And closed his brown eyes, and was still.



THE QUIET FELL.

All of them. At once. Every grey white-eyed figure in the great round hall of Duskhold. Every one in the corridors without doors. Every one in the grey fields outside, for miles in every direction. They swayed, and sighed, a vast soft sound like wind going out of a sail, and folded to the ground.

Some of them didn't get up.

Most of them did.

Slowly. Blinking. Sitting up on the black floor and staring around them at the grey hall with brown eyes and blue eyes and green eyes. Touching their faces. Touching each other. Some of them began to weep. Some of them began to scream. Some of them just sat there, very still, as if they'd forgotten how to do anything else.

And the noise came back.

It came all at once, the way water comes back into a lock when the gates open. Weeping and shouting and calling of names. Someone laughing hysterically. Someone praying. Someone singing, very badly, a hymn Lex didn't know. The great round hall of Duskhold, which had not held a single sound in sixteen years, filled with the noise of thousands of people waking up.

It was the most beautiful thing Lex had ever heard.

MORVANE – DEFEATED

The Pale Warden is no more.

QUIET (Duskhold): RELEASED

Survivors: ~11,400

Lost: ~3,200

THORNHOLLOW PASS: Gloamed army

– will severed – COLLAPSING

SALTREACH: Gloamed – COLLAPSING



AND ABOVE THEM, IN the open sky, a dragon fell.

Lex heard it before he saw it. A great tearing rush of air, and a cry. Not a scream. Not a roar. A long, low, broken sound, like thunder rolling away over distant mountains.

He looked up.

Sorrowmaw was falling out of the sky.

Not diving. *Falling*. Its vast wings folded wrong, crumpled, its long neck trailing. And the grey was coming off it. Peeling away in great flakes like ash off a burned log, falling through the air around it like dirty snow. And under the grey, where it peeled away, there was *blue*.

Storm-blue. Shimmering. Like Ashka.

It hit the floor of the hall near the edge of the pit with a sound like a mountain falling, and the black floor cracked under it, and the people who'd been Quiet a moment before scrambled away screaming.

And a small blue-grey dragon came down out of the sky after it.

Ashka landed beside the great fallen shape. She folded her wings. She stood very still.

The great dragon lifted its head.

Its scales were blue now. Mostly. Patches of grey still clung to it, flaking away. Its wings were torn and crumpled. Black blood was running from a dozen wounds where the Gloam had held it together. It was dying. Lex could see that too.

But its eyes were gold.

A deep molten amber. Slit-pupiled like a cat's. Enormous. Fixed on the small blue-grey dragon standing in front of it.

And the great dragon made a sound. Low. Deep. A rumble, like a storm far away over the mountains. And Lex felt it. Not through his ears. Through his chest. A picture. Thrown out across the hall, so huge and so bright it nearly knocked him over.

A nest in the rocks. High. Cold. Lightning. Two eggs, blue as storm-clouds. One hatching. A tiny wet blue head, a tiny cry. Mine. Mine. MINE.

And then:

Little spark. Little Ashka. You flew. You FLEW.

Antho was beside Lex. His hand was gripping Lex's arm so hard it hurt. His face was wet.

"*Grave-Speech*," he whispered. "*I can hear him. His name. His real name. Thraxis.*" His voice broke. "*Thraxis of the Greyspine. Her father.*"

Ashka stepped forward.

She pressed her long narrow head against the great dragon's jaw. Very gently. The way she pressed it against Antho's chest when he was sad.

And Thraxis of the Greyspine opened his jaws, slowly, and breathed.

Not Gloam. Not fire. *Lightning*. A great slow stream of it, blue-white and crackling, pouring out of him into the small dragon pressed against his jaw. All of it. Everything he had left. Sixteen years of stolen storm, held down under the Gloam, pouring out at last into his daughter.

Ashka blazed.

Every scale lit up from within. Blue-white. Crackling. Her wings spread wide on either side of her, and *grew*, and her neck lengthened, and her body swelled, and the silver frame on her left wing stretched and stretched until it was finer than spider-silk on her vast shimmering membrane, and still held.

And when the lightning stopped, she was almost as big as he was.

ASHKA – Storm-Drake

Inheritance: THRAXIS OF THE GREYSPINE

GROWTH STAGE: Young Adult → ADULT

Level 27 → 49

Thraxis lowered his head to the black floor.

His gold eyes looked at his daughter for a long moment. Then, slowly, they moved past her. To Antho. To the gaunt young man with the lantern at his belt and the tears on his face, who had found a little broken-winged hatchling on a mountainside four years ago and carried her home.

And one more picture came. Faint now. Fading.

Keeper. Keeper of my spark. Thank you.

The gold eyes closed.

Ashka threw back her head and screamed. A long, high, terrible sound that went up through the open roof of Duskhold into the grey sky and on and on and on, until the clouds above the fortress split, and lightning came down, and the rain began.



LEX FOUND HIS BROTHER at the edge of the pit, afterward.

The Vhessa breach. The first. The worst. It was still there. Black and ragged and torn, cold air rising out of it. But smaller. Much smaller. When Morvane fell, when the graft burned and the threads went home, it had *shrunk*. Pulled in on itself, the way a wound pulls in when the poison's drawn out of it.

But it was still open.

Antho was kneeling at its edge with his hands flat on the black floor and his eyes closed. The Keeper's Lantern was guttering at his belt. Lex could feel him through the Bloodbond. Reaching for Shade. Trying to close it.

[I can't,] said Antho. [It's too deep. Too old. It's the first one. Everything else spread from it.] His voice cracked. *[I can make it smaller. I can't close it. Not alone.]*

[You're not alone.]

[You've got no Authority left, Lex. Neither have I. We spent it all.]

Lex knelt beside him anyway.

He didn't know what he could do. He had no Authority. Hardly any mana. He'd poured everything into the Reckoning. He was empty, the way he'd been empty after the Unbinding at Ashbourne, after the forge in the Stillwater.

But he put his hands on the black floor beside his brother's. And reached down. For Stone. For the old slow heavy hum of the earth under the fortress, under the pit, under everything.

It was there. It had always been there. Under the breach. Holding it. The way Shade held the dark, the way the ground held up a market square full of shouting people.

[Antho,] he thought. [It's not just Shade holding the door frame. It's Stone too. The ground. The earth around the hole.] He swallowed. *[You hold the dark. I'll hold the ground. Together.]*

His brother turned his head and looked at him.

[Together,] said Antho.

They reached down. Shade and Stone. Dark and earth. The night that holds the stars, and the ground that holds the night.

The breach shivered.

It didn't close. Not all the way. But it *narrowed*. Pulled in further. From a pit wide enough to swallow a house to a crack wide enough to swallow a man. The cold coming out of it dimmed. The smell faded.

And they couldn't do any more.

BREACH (Vhessa – ORIGIN)

Status: NARROWED (71% contained)

Full closure requires:



(three of the blood)

Three of the blood.

Lex looked at the words. Then, slowly, he turned his head.

The crystal stood on its plinth at the edge of the pit. Clear. Completely clear. Every black vein gone. Faceted and glowing softly from within, the way it had glowed in the heart of Avaloria. And inside it, half out of it, frozen with his head and shoulder and arm outside and the rest within, reaching—

Their father's eyes were open.

Grey. Clear. Looking at them.

And his reaching hand, the one outside the crystal, the long-fingered scarred smith's hand, *moved*.

Just the fingers. Just a little. Curling. Uncurling.

The way a man's hand moves when he's waking from a very long sleep.

SEAL INTEGRITY: 1% → 3% → 7%

ARION VEY

Authority: 55 / 100

Status: STASIS → WAKING



AND LEX, KNEELING AT the edge of the narrowed pit with his brother beside him and the rain coming down through the open roof of Duskhold and eleven thousand people weeping and shouting and laughing all around them, felt his panel open on its own.

TIER TRIAL – ANCHOR-POINT
Trial: "Pass judgment in the heart of the net, and carry it on the river."
COMPLETE
LEX VEY
Class: EMBERWRIGHT → evolving... → FORGEHEART SORCERER (Unique)
"One whose forge is the heart, and whose heart is a forge."
TIER III – MASTER
Level 36 → 51 (Morvane: CATASTROPHIC KILL)
ATTUNEMENT
Flame SPEAKING
Stone ANSWERING
ANTHOREN VEY
Class: TWILIGHT WARLOCK
TIER III – MASTER
Level 46 → 51
Shade SPEAKING
Gale ANSWERING
TITLE (both): THE PALE WARDEN'S BANE

He read it. All of it. He didn't feel anything.
He turned around.

Across the circle, in the middle of a ring of frost fifty paces wide, Seraphine was kneeling on the black floor beside a scarred old knight who knelt with his sword point-down before him and his grey head bowed. She had her charcoal-black hand on his shoulder. She was weeping. Wren was kneeling on his other side, her bow on the floor beside her, her face pressed into her hands.

The frost around them hadn't melted. Even in the rain.

Lex got up. He walked across the hall. Through the waking people, through the noise, through the rain. He knelt in front of Garrick Dunmore.

The old knight's eyes were closed. His face was calm. Very calm. The calm of a man who has stood in a lot of doorways and knows exactly what this one was.

Oathkeeper was in his hands. Point-down. Frost still blooming along the blade. And the three runes on it were glowing. Faint. Gold. *Bulwark. Bind. Oath.*

Still glowing.

Grows keener while the oath is kept.

Lex put his hand over the old knight's hands, on the cross-guard of his father's sword.

"*You kept it,*" he said. His voice was gone. It came out a whisper. "*You kept it, Garrick. You stood on the steps.*"

The runes on the blade flared once. Bright. Gold.

And then, slowly, gently, like a lantern turned down at the end of a long night, they faded.

CHAPTER 37

A NEW DAWN



ELRIC WAS GONE.

Lex went back to the corridor that night, after the rain had stopped and the stars had come out over the open roof of the great hall. After they'd laid Garrick down on his cloak at the edge of the frost-ring, with Oathkeeper on his chest and his hands folded over its hilt, and Seraphine had written his name on the black floor beside him in charcoal, in big plain letters, *SIR GARRICK DUNMORE, WHO STOOD ON THE STEPS*. After Wren had stopped crying, and Antho had stopped shaking, and the eleven thousand people who had been Quiet that morning had begun, slowly, to find each other in the dark.

He went back to the archway where he'd left the old sorcerer sitting against the wall with his burned hand pressed to his chest.

The corridor was empty.

The staff was still there. The lightning-scarred ash staff, lying on the black floor where Lex had dropped it. And beside it, folded small, a scrap of paper.

Lex picked it up. It was written in charcoal, in a shaking hand.

Tell him I'm sorry.

Tell him I couldn't.

Tell him I kept nine.

That was all.

Lex stood in the empty corridor for a long time, holding the paper.

[He's gone east,] said Ember quietly. *[Or somewhere. Into the grey. With nine points of your father's Authority and no staff and no raven and no one.]* A pause. *[Do you want to go after him?]*

Lex thought about it.

He thought about Brisk, folding to the cellar floor with a look of mild surprise. About Seraphine, burned black down one side. About the iron door slamming shut in the dark forge in the middle of himself, and Ember's voice going silent.

He thought about an old man sitting on the black floor of Duskhold, sobbing out loud for the first time in thirty-one days.

"No," he said.

He folded the paper and put it in his coat, beside Lysandra's letter and his father's letter to Elric.

And he picked up the staff, and carried it back to the hall.



MESSAGES CAME THROUGH THE night.

Quill brought the first one. The raven had stayed with them; nobody had seen him leave, and nobody had seen him come back, but around midnight he was simply there, perched on the edge of the black plinth beside the crystal with a scrap of paper tied to his leg. Lex didn't know how he'd gotten it. He didn't ask.

It was from Teodra Hale. Three lines, in a hand that looked like it had been written on a saddle in the dark.

They stopped. All at once. Just after sunset. Twenty thousand of them, and they just STOPPED. Sat down in the road. Some got up and started crying. Some didn't get up.

We held, smith. We held the pass.

Pell's alive. So's your old smith. He wants to know if you're eating.

Lex read it three times and then had to sit down.

The second came at dawn. From Elowen Dunmore. Delivered by a gull, of all things, a great grey herring gull that came down out of the sky over Duskhold and dropped a sealed letter on the floor at Lex's feet and flew away screaming.

Saltreach holds. The Gloamed on the causeway collapsed at sunset. The Princess came by sea with the Royal Guard. I have never seen anything like her.

Tell my father.

Lex looked at the letter for a long time.

Then he folded it very carefully and went and laid it on Garrick's chest, beside Oathkeeper, under the old knight's folded hands.



THEY WOKE THEIR FATHER at noon.

They'd waited. Lex and Antho had nothing left. No Authority. Barely any mana. They'd spent everything on the Reckoning and the breach, and their panels were dark and cold as a forge on a winter morning. But the Wells were still there, under the wheel. Ember said so. And the Wells fed the Root four times faster than the old way.

So they slept. In the great hall, at the foot of the black plinth, with the crystal glowing softly above them and their father's eyes open inside it, watching. Lex woke once in the night and looked up and saw those grey eyes looking down at him, and his father's reaching fingers curling, slowly, uncurling. As if he were trying to say something with them.

By noon, the Authority had come back. Not all of it. Forty points for Lex. Something unmeasurable for Antho. Enough.

They climbed onto the plinth. They stood on either side of the crystal, the way they'd knelt on either side of the Twin Stone at Caldris. Lex on the right. Antho on the left.

Wren and Seraphine stood at the foot of the plinth. Ashka lay curled on the black floor behind them, vast and blue and silent, her golden eyes half-closed, still grieving. All around them, in the great hall, people had stopped. Stopped weeping, stopped searching, stopped talking. They stood and watched. Thousands of them. The ones who'd been Quiet. Watching two young men stand on a black plinth beside a crystal with a man inside it.

"Ready?" said Lex.

Antho looked at him across the crystal. His face was grey and hollow and exhausted. His eyes were very dark.

"No," he said.

"Truly answered," said Lex.

Antho laughed, very softly. Then he laid his hand on the crystal.

Lex laid his.



IT WASN'T LIKE CALDRIS.

At Caldris, they'd had to take the weight of the whole Anchor. The whole net. Every thread, every knot, every breach. It had come down on Lex like a mountain.

This time, it didn't come down at all.

Because their father was holding it.

Lex felt him. The moment his palm touched the crystal. Felt the net, the vast silver web of the Lattice spread over all of Aldermere, still frayed, still thin in places, but *held*. Held by a knot at the center. By a man. By fifty-five points of Authority that had been stolen and burned and returned. By a will that had held on, for fifteen years, with nothing at all.

And the man reached out to them through the crystal.

Boys, said a voice. Not in the air. In the place under the air. In the Root. Quiet and deep and a little rough. *Boys. I've got it. I've got the weight. You don't need to carry it this time.*

Then what do we do? Lex thought.

Just hold my hand, said his father. *Both of you. And pull.*



THEY PULLED.

Not with their bodies. With their Root. With Flame and Shade. With the Bloodbond, and the place where fire touched dark, and something else, something that wasn't Root or Well or anything Lex had a name for. Something that was just *two sons reaching for their father*.

And the crystal softened.

It went from hard to pliant, the way it had at Caldris. The faceted walls blurring. Drops of light running down them and falling and vanishing before they touched the plinth. And the man inside it took a step.

Lex saw his father's face come all the way through. His shoulders. His chest. His other arm. Pressing out through the softening wall of light like a

man pushing through deep water. His long dark coat. His legs. His feet, bare, coming down onto the black stone of the plinth.

He stood there. Outside the crystal. For the first time in fifteen years.
And the crystal behind him dissolved.

All at once. Like a soap bubble bursting. Like frost going out of a window in the sun. One moment it was there, tall and faceted and glowing. The next it was light, gold, rising up into the open sky over Duskhold in a slow shimmering column. And then it was gone.

CRYSTAL – DISSOLVED
ANCHOR KNOT: transferred to BEARER
ARION VEY
Class: WARDEN-ARCHITECT
Tier IV – Level 88
Status: AWAKE
Authority: 55 / 100

Arion Vey stood on the black plinth at the edge of the narrowed pit, in the grey noon light, with his sons on either side of him.

He swayed.

His legs buckled. Fifteen years of standing in a crystal, and his body had forgotten how to stand on its own. He started to fall.

Lex caught him. Antho caught him. One on each side.
And held him up.



HE WAS LIGHTER THAN Lex expected.

That was the first thing. He'd always imagined his father as big. The way four-year-olds imagine their fathers. Tall and strong and enormous. A man who could carry a child in one arm.

He wasn't big. He was a lean man of middle height, thin from fifteen years without food, his long dark coat hanging off him. Lex was taller. Broader. Antho was taller too. Their father stood between them, held up by them, and his head came barely to their shoulders.

His face was the face from the Thornwood memory. From the vision in the Barrow-King's hall. From the shape of light in the heart of Avaloria. A

lean face, lined, tired, with silver at the temples and a long straight nose and a jaw Lex had seen in still water on his brother's face. A face that was very hard to remember even while you were looking at it.

Except Lex could remember it now. He was looking at it, and it wasn't sliding away. It was staying. Sharp and clear and real.

His father's grey eyes moved from one of them to the other.

His lips moved. Nothing came out. He'd forgotten how. He swallowed, and tried again. And this time, faint and cracked and rough as a rusted hinge, his voice came out into the air of Duskhold. Not through the Root. Not through a ghost. Out of his own mouth.

"Lexander," he said.

Lex couldn't speak.

His father turned his head.

"Anthoren."

Antho's face did something terrible.



ARION VEY STOOD ON the black plinth at the edge of the narrowed pit, held up by his sons. And he lifted his hands. Slowly. Shaking. As if they weighed a hundred pounds each. And laid one on Lex's face, and one on Antho's.

His palms were warm.

They were real. Flesh and bone. Long-fingered and scarred across the knuckles, a smith's hands, like Lex's own. Warm against his cheek.

"Look at you," whispered their father. *"Look at you both."*

And then his face crumpled, and he wept.

He wept the way Elric had wept, at Avaloria. Like a man who has been holding something in for fifteen years and can't hold it anymore. His thin shoulders shook. His hands stayed on their faces, trembling. And the tears ran down his lined face and into the silver stubble on his jaw, and he didn't wipe them away.

Lex was weeping too. He didn't know when he'd started.

And Antho—

Antho stood very still with their father's hand on his face. His jaw was clenched. His grey eyes were fixed on the man in front of him, and they were dry. Perfectly dry. His whole body was rigid.

"*I'm sorry,*" said their father. His voice cracked to pieces. "*Antho, I'm so sorry. I'm so sorry. I know you said don't. I know you're not ready. But I'm so—*"

"*I know,*" said Antho.

It came out flat. Hard. Like a door closing.

Their father stopped.

"*I know you're sorry,*" said Antho. "*You said it at Avaloria. With your eyes, if not your mouth.*" His voice didn't rise. "*I've been thinking about it for months. Whether I want to hear it. Whether I can.*"

Arion's hand was still on his face. Shaking.

"*You weren't there,*" said Antho. "*When it broke. When Mam went into the dark. When the whole village called me a murderer and I walked up into the mountains barefoot in the snow because I couldn't think of anything else to do. You weren't there for eight years.*" His jaw worked. "*And then you were a ghost in a crystal. Telling us about Aurelian. About the Lattice. About how you'd been sure. So sure you'd come back.*"

"*I know.*"

"*And Morvane said you broke the world.*" Antho's voice dropped. "*Right here. At this pit. He said you were trying to free everyone and you tore the net open and the hunger came through. He said every breach and every Gloamed and every grey village was you.*" His grey eyes held their father's. "*Was he lying?*"

The great hall of Duskhold was utterly silent. Eleven thousand people, holding their breath.

"*No,*" said Arion Vey.



HE TOLD THEM. **STANDING** on the plinth at the edge of the pit, held up by his sons, with eleven thousand people listening.

He'd found the records in the Spire's sealed vault, twenty years ago. The truth about the Ceiling. That the Founders hadn't made it. That the Wardens had added it, three hundred years ago, for money and power and

fear. That every capped smith and farmer and miner in Aldermere had been capped by a decision made in a room in the Spire by men who would never have to live under it.

"I couldn't bear it," he said. "I had Root. I could see it. Every grey band around every gold thread. Millions of them." His voice was very quiet. "And I thought: I can fix this. I'm a Vey. I'm Warden-Architect. I have the Root. I can reach into the net and rewrite it. All at once. Break every Ceiling in the world in a single night."

He looked down at the pit.

"Rewrite is forbidden," he said. "Even for us. Even for the blood. The Founders forbade it. Aurelian himself. Because the net is old and tired and holds something terrible down, and if you pull on it too hard, too fast, it tears." His mouth twisted. "I knew that. I'd read every codex. I knew exactly what the risk was."

"And you did it anyway," said Antho.

"And I did it anyway." Arion closed his eyes. "I came here. To Vhessa. Because the net is thinnest here; it always has been. Corvin came with me. He didn't know what I was going to do. He thought we were investigating a fault. I didn't tell him." His voice cracked. "I knelt here. At this spot. And I put my hands on the floor, and I reached into the net, and I pulled."

Nobody spoke.

"It tore," whispered Arion. "Right here. Under my hands. Like a rotten sail in a gale. And the hunger came up through it. And Corvin was standing beside me. And it found him first." He opened his eyes. They were wet and red and very, very old. "Every breach since has spread from this one. Every grey village. Every Gloamed. Every Quiet in this hall." He looked around at the eleven thousand faces watching him. "Every one of you."

He looked at Antho.

"And your seal broke because I'd been pouring everything I had into holding the net together after I tore it," he said. "Because I couldn't come home. Because I'd made it so I couldn't come home." His hand on Antho's face was shaking so badly it was barely touching. "Your mother went into the dark because of what I did here. You spent eight years in a cave because of what I did here." His voice broke completely. "I did this. All of it. I broke

the world trying to free it. And then I hid in a crystal for fifteen years holding the pieces, because it was easier than facing what I'd done."



THE SILENCE WENT ON for a long time.

Lex stood on the plinth with his father's hand on his face and didn't know what to say. He didn't know what to feel. He'd known. Some of it. Morvane had told them, in this hall, yesterday. *He broke the world.* He'd said *I don't care.* He'd meant it, yesterday.

But yesterday his father had been a face in a crystal with a tear on it. Today he was a thin shaking man with warm hands, standing between them, saying it out loud.

[Lex,] said Ember quietly. [I didn't know. I swear I didn't know. He never gave me that piece.]

[I know.]

[He kept it. For himself. The guilt.] A long pause. *[I think he thought it was his to carry. Alone.]*

[Like Antho,] Lex thought. [Like Antho in the cave.]

[Yes,] said Ember softly. [Exactly like that.]

Antho hadn't moved. He was standing rigid with their father's hand on his face, staring at him. His grey eyes were dry. His jaw was clenched.

And then, very slowly, he lifted his own hand. And put it over their father's. On his own face.

"The Oracle asked me a question," he said.

Arion looked at him.

"On the steps. Before the first song." Antho's voice was very quiet. *"She asked what grows heavier the longer it's carried, and lighter the moment it's set down. What can only be set down by another's hand."*

Their father's face went very still.

"I said guilt," said Antho. *"And she said: whose hand?"* He swallowed. *"And I didn't know. There wasn't anyone. And the stone started climbing up my legs. And Lex stepped up and said: mine. His hand. Because he was the one I'd left."*

He held their father's gaze.

"*I'm the one you left,*" he said. "*Me. And Mam, but she's—*" He stopped. Started again. "*I'm the one. So I suppose it's my hand.*"

"*Antho—*"

"*I'm not ready to say it's all right,*" said Antho. "*It isn't. It won't be. Not for a long time. Maybe not ever.*" His voice cracked. "*But I'm ready to stop carrying it. Mine. My part of it. Eight years of it.*" He pressed their father's hand against his face. "*And I'm ready for you to stop carrying yours. Fifteen years of it. You don't have to hold it alone anymore. Not in a crystal. Not anywhere.*"

Arion Vey stared at his eldest son.

"*I forgive you,*" said Antho. It came out cracked to pieces. "*Not because you deserve it. Because I'm tired. And because Mam would have. And because the Oracle's been thinking about Lex's answer for nine hundred years and she said nobody ever brought anyone who could answer for them.*" His face finally crumpled. "*I'm bringing you, Father. I'm answering for you.*"

Their father made a sound Lex had never heard a person make.

And then the three of them were holding each other on the black plinth at the edge of the pit, father and sons, arms tangled, faces wet, while eleven thousand people who had been Quiet the day before stood in the great hall of Duskhold and watched, and wept with them.



IT WAS A LONG time before anyone let go.

When they did, their father was smiling. Through the tears. A tired, cracked, astonished smile, like a man who has walked out of a long dark tunnel into sunlight and can't quite believe it's real.

"*Your mother,*" he said. "*She'd have hit me. With a loaf of bread. Hard.*" He wiped his face with the back of his shaking hand. "*She always said I was the cleverest fool she ever met.*"

Antho laughed. It was wet and broken, but it was a laugh.

And Lex, standing beside them, felt something stir in the back of his head.

[Lex,] said Ember. [May I?]

[May you what?]

[Speak. Out loud. To him. Like at Avaloria.]

Lex looked at his father.

"There's someone who wants to say bello," he said.

Arion's face went very still.

[Hello,] said Ember. Out loud. In the air. Faint and gold, like a voice heard through a wall, coming from the place on Lex's chest where the seal had been. *[Hello again. You're awake. You're really awake.]*

Their father stared at the place where the voice came from.

"Ember," he said softly.

[You remembered my name.]

"I'll never forget it." Arion's voice was rough. "I felt you, you know. Through the crystal. Every time he said it. Every time he called for you, in the dark, when the thief locked you away." He swallowed. "I wanted to answer. I couldn't."

[I know,] said Ember. *[I couldn't either.]* A pause. *[I need to ask you something. I've been afraid to.]*

"Ask."

[The seal,] said Ember. *[It's almost gone. Seven percent. When it goes completely, when you lift it, I don't know what happens to me. I'm a piece of you. You cut me off and pressed me in. When the seal goes, I might go back. Into you. Where I came from.]* Its voice shook. *[I don't want to. I want to stay with him. I know I'm yours. But I've been his for three months. And I'd like to stay his. If you'll let me.]*

Arion Vey looked at the place on his son's chest for a long time.

Then he reached out and laid his warm smith's hand flat over it. Over the seal. Over the place where the iron door had been, and the forge, and the fire.

"Ember," he said gently. "I cut you out of myself on the worst night of my life. I took my patience, and my courtesy, and my terrible jokes about smelting. And the part of me that sang to him when he was sick." His grey eyes were very bright. "I took the part of me that was a father. And I gave it to him. So he'd have one. Even if I couldn't be there."

[I know.]

"I gave you away," said Arion. "I don't get to take you back." He pressed his palm flatter. "You were always a gift. You were always his."

And he reached into the seal, into the last seven percent of the working he'd made fifteen years ago on a stormy night in a cottage in Ashbourne, and he did something Lex couldn't see but could *feel*. Like a knot being untied. Gently. Carefully. The way you'd take a splint off a healed bone.

SEAL – RELEASED BY MAKER

GUARDIAN CONSTRUCT: EMBER

Bound to: LEXANDER VEY

Status: FREE (by gift)

[Oh,] said Ember. Very softly. [Oh. Oh, thank you.]

"Look after him," said their father. "The way I couldn't."

[I will,] said Ember. [I always have.] A pause, and something in the gold voice that was very nearly a laugh. *[And he looks after me. Mostly by forgetting to spend his points.]*

Arion laughed. Out loud. The real laugh, the one from the Thornwood memory, his whole lined face creasing up.



THEY CLOSED THE VHESSA breach that afternoon.

All three of them. Kneeling at the edge of the narrowed pit, on the black floor, with their hands flat on the stone. Arion in the middle. Lex on his right. Antho on his left. The way the three carved hands had lain on the Twin Stone at Caldriis, waiting.

Three of the blood.

Lex reached down for Stone. Antho reached down for Shade. And their father, who had been a Listener's husband for eleven years and had learned a little of the old magic in that time, though nothing like his sons, reached into the Root. Into the net. Into the place where he'd torn it sixteen years ago.

And he didn't pull, this time.

He *mended*.

Lex felt it. Felt his father's fifty-five points of Authority go into the edges of the tear, slow and careful, like a smith drawing two pieces of hot iron together on the anvil. Felt Antho's Shade come up underneath, holding the dark, steadying it. Felt his own Stone come up around it, the

ground, the earth, the slow heavy patience of the world holding the edges in place while the mend took.

And felt the river, under all of it. Flame and Shade and Stone. The Wells. The thing that had been here before the net and would be here after.

The breach *closed*.

Not with a bang. Not with a flash. It simply *healed*. The way a cut heals: slowly, from the edges, the black growing narrower and narrower, the cold coming off it fading, the smell going, until there was only a thin dark line on the black floor of the hall. And then not even that.

Just floor.

BREACH (Vhessa – ORIGIN)

Status: CLOSED

LATTICE INTEGRITY: 52% → 58% → 61%

WORLD NOTICE

Lex looked up.

WORLD NOTICE

The first wound has been closed.

Three of the blood knelt where the net was torn, and mended it.

The Gloam's source is sealed.
The Blightmarch will heal.

All across the great hall, eleven thousand people were reading it.

And all across Aldermere, Lex knew, everyone else was reading it too. Every farmer, every miner, every Warden. Brannoc at Hedda's portable anvil in the Thornhollow Pass. Pell, alive, with Wren's old bow. Teodra Hale and Daxian Roole, standing over twenty thousand grey shapes sitting confused in a road. Elowen Dunmore on a causeway in Saltreach, beside a princess. Wren's mother on a step on Fennel Street, coughing. Malachi, in a hut in a green valley in the middle of a white waste, peeling an apple.

And somewhere, maybe, an old man in a grey cloak with no staff and nine stolen points of Authority, walking alone into the grey.



THAT EVENING, LEX SAT with his father at the edge of the great hall, where the open roof let in the last of the light.

Antho was asleep, curled against Ashka's vast blue flank, with Seraphine asleep against him. Wren had gone off with Ilsa, the Healer from Fenmoor, who'd arrived with the first of the people coming east from the pass, to help with the wounded. The great hall was full of noise. Weeping and laughing and calling of names. Someone, somewhere, was playing a fiddle.

His father was sitting with his back against the black wall and a bowl of soup in his hands, which he kept forgetting to eat. He was looking at the people. All of them. His grey eyes moved over them slowly, one face after another.

"Every one of them," he said quietly. "I did this to every one of them."

"And you closed it," said Lex. "Today. Every one of them is going to get to go home because you closed it."

"You closed it. You and your brother. I just knelt between you."

"You knelt in the middle," said Lex. "That's where the hard part is."

His father looked at him. Something moved in his tired face.

"You sound like Brannoc," he said.

Lex stared at him. "You know Brannoc?"

"I know of him. Your mother talked about him. In her letters." Arion turned the bowl of soup in his hands. "She wrote to me, you know. Every month. For seven years. Until the fire. I could never write back. I couldn't risk the Order tracing the letters. But she wrote anyway." His voice was very soft. "She told me everything. Your first steps. Your first words. Antho's first questions about the stars. The day you found the horseshoe nail in the road and wouldn't let it go." He smiled faintly. "The day she took you to Brannoc's forge for the first time, and you stood in the doorway and stared at the fire, and wouldn't leave until he let you pump the bellows."

Lex couldn't speak.

"She said," said his father, "Brannoc is the kind of man who would catch a falling child without thinking about it. And then pretend he hadn't done anything at all."

"He did," whispered Lex. "When the cottage burned. He caught me."

His father was quiet for a long time.

"*Then I owe him,*" he said at last. "*More than I can ever pay.*"

"He said to tell you something," said Lex. "When I found you." He swallowed. "He said: tell your father his son's the best smith I ever trained. And if he wants to argue about it, he can come down to Ashbourne and argue with *me*."

Arion Vey looked at his son for a long, long moment.

Then he laughed. And then he wept. And then he laughed again. And he set down the soup, and put his arm around Lex's shoulders, and pulled him close. The way, Lex thought, he must have done once, a long time ago, before the seal, before the storm, when Lex was small enough to hold in one arm.

"*I'll go,*" said his father, into his hair. "*I'll go to Ashbourne and argue with him. I'd like that very much.*"



MUCH LATER, WHEN THE fiddle had stopped and most of the hall was asleep, Lex asked the question he'd been carrying since the Hollowmaw.

"Father," he said. "Mam."

His father went still beside him.

"Antho says he heard her," said Lex. "In the Hollowmaw. When he closed the breach. Singing. On the other side of the door. Singing the Lantern Song back to him. He says someone pushed on the door. From the other side." He swallowed. "And at Avaloria, in the chasm, I heard it too. A woman's voice. Very far down."

His father didn't say anything.

"And Old Mag," said Lex. "In Ashbourne. Before we left. She said Mam told her once: *tell them he's not the only one who's lost. Tell them to leave a light on for both of us.*"

The silence went on for a long time.

"You said you felt the door close," said Lex quietly. "At Avaloria. *I felt her walk into it. I felt the door close behind her. From the other side.*" He

turned his head and looked at his father. "You never said she died. Not once. Antho noticed. He said you never said it."

His father was looking at the floor. At the place, across the hall, where the breach had been, and wasn't anymore. His lean face was very still. The face that slid off your attention like water off oiled leather. Lex could see it sliding now. Could see his father, after fifteen years of making himself forgettable, reaching for that old habit. Making himself hard to read.

"*Lexander,*" he said at last. Very quietly. "*I'll tell you. Both of you. Everything. I promise.*" He swallowed. "*But not tonight. Not here.*"

"Why not?"

His father looked at him. And his grey eyes, in the dim light of the great hall, were full of something Lex couldn't name. Not guilt. Not grief. Something stranger. Something almost like *fear*.

"*Because I need to be sure,*" said Arion Vey. "*Before I give either of you a hope like that. I need to be sure.*"

He put his arm back around Lex's shoulders.

And didn't say anything else.



LEX LAY AWAKE FOR a long time that night, in the great hall of Duskhold, with his father asleep against the wall beside him and his brother asleep against a dragon and eleven thousand people breathing in the dark.

[He's hiding something,] said Ember quietly. *[Again.]*

I know.

[Another locked door. I can feel it. I don't have that piece either.] A pause. *[He's kept a great many pieces for himself.]*

I know.

[Are you angry?]

Lex thought about it.

He thought about a thin shaking man with warm hands, saying *I broke the world* out loud in front of eleven thousand people. About Antho's hand over their father's, on his own face. *I'm answering for you.* About the breach, closing, under three pairs of hands.

No, he thought. *Not tonight.*

[Good,] said Ember. *[Neither am I.]* A pause. *[But I'd like to know. Someday.]*

So would I.

He lay looking up through the open roof of Duskhold at the stars. Clear and bright and countless, over the grey country, over the healing Blightmarch, over the whole noisy, grieving, laughing, waking world.

And somewhere, he thought, very far down, under the net, under the Wells, under everything, in the dark before the first word, a woman was singing.

Little light, little light, burning low.

Keep the door for the ones who go.

He fell asleep before he could hear the rest.

CHAPTER 38

WHAT REMAINS



THEY BURIED GARRICK DUNMORE in Highcrest, in a garden, under a pear tree.

It was the garden of a small grey house on a quiet street in the middle tiers of the city, halfway between the crowded Lower Town and the mansions above. The house had been his, once. His and Mara's. Elowen had kept it after her mother died, and kept the garden, and the roses her mother had planted, and the pear tree her father had planted on the day Elowen was born.

Mara Dunmore was buried under the roses. Elowen had asked if her father could lie beside her. Nobody had said no.

It was a small funeral. Elowen had wanted it small. Lex and Antho and Wren and Seraphine. Teodra Hale, in a clean shirt for once, with her greatsword on her back. Daxian Roole, in a plain brown coat. Hedda Vorne, with her cudgel. Brannoc, who had insisted on coming, who had walked into the garden with his huge hands clasped in front of him and his bald head bowed and said, very quietly, to Elowen, *I didn't know him long. But I knew him well enough.* Pell, with Wren's old bow. Dame Brand and the twenty knights who'd ridden with them from Mirrormere, what was left of them.

And Arion Vey, standing at the back, very straight, with his forgettable face and his silver temples and his hands clasped behind his back.

And at the gate, in a plain grey cloak with the hood up, so plain that nobody would have looked at her twice if not for the two Royal Guards

standing very quietly on either side of her in the street, Queen Lysandra of Caldor.

The old king had died eight days after the World Notice that said *the first wound has been closed*. In his sleep, the physicians said. Peacefully. Some people in Highcrest whispered that he'd seen the notice, and smiled, and closed his eyes.

Lysandra had been crowned four days later. On the same day, she had dismissed High Warden Isaura Kell from office, in front of the whole High Council, for crimes against the realm. Kell had walked out of the Spire before the guards could reach her. Nobody knew where she'd gone.

The new queen didn't come into the garden. She stood at the gate, with her hood up, through the whole thing. And when it was over, she turned and walked away up the street without a word, and her guards went with her.

But Lex saw her face, just for a moment, before she turned. And it was wet.



SERAPHINE READ THE WORDS.

Not the old Warden words, the ones they said over knights of the Silver Lattice. Elowen hadn't wanted those. *He broke that oath*, she'd said. *Or they broke it for him. Either way, he wouldn't want it.* So Seraphine had written something new. She stood at the head of the grave under the pear tree with a sheet of paper in her scarred hands and her cracked spectacles on her nose, and read it in her clear precise schoolteacher's voice.

"Garrick Dunmore was a knight. Then he wasn't. Then he was again.

"He stood on the steps of a chapel for three days with half a sword so that forty people could live.

"He stood in the gate of Fort Caldris with three holes in him so that a hundred could run.

"He stood over me on the floor of Duskhold, so that I could write one name, and took a spear meant for me.

"He made a warlock wash in a stream. He taught a dragon to steal bacon. He was terrible at cards. He made up proverbs and pretended they

were his father's. He told a smith's apprentice that a man who sharpens his sword at the battle has already bled.

"He swore an oath, on a sword that had been broken in shame and made whole in purpose. To stand on the steps. Wherever the steps were. For as long as he could stand.

"He kept it."

She folded the paper. Her hands were shaking.

"Sir Garrick Dunmore," she said. "Who stood on the steps."

Nobody said anything for a long time.



LEX GAVE ELOWEN THE sword afterward.

He'd carried it all the way from Duskhold. Wrapped in Garrick's own cloak, on Ashka's back, across the healing Blightmarch, over the green hills of Caldor, to Highcrest. He hadn't unwrapped it once. He hadn't been able to.

He unwrapped it now, in the garden, under the pear tree, and held it out to her across the fresh-turned earth.

Oathkeeper.

The blue-white sheen of the blade. The old cross-guard. The old leather-wrapped hilt. The silver pommel engraved with a lattice, which had been her great-grandfather's, and her grandfather's, and her father's. The three runes along the fuller: *Bulwark. Bind. Oath.* Dark now. Not glowing. The frost that had always formed on it in warm air wasn't forming.

Elowen looked at it for a long time.

"It's dark," she said. "The runes. They were always lit. When he carried it. I saw them on the quay, at the Rivergate. They were gold."

"*Oath,*" said Lex. "*Bound to the one who swears upon it. Grows keener while the oath is kept.*" He swallowed. "He kept it. All the way. And then it was finished. So it went dark."

Elowen didn't say anything.

"It's yours," said Lex. "It was always going to be yours. He'd want you to have it." He held it out further. "You don't have to swear anything. You don't have to do anything. It's just your father's sword. And your grandfather's. You can hang it on the wall."

Elowen reached out and took the hilt.

She held it in front of her, point-down, the way her father had held it in the burned smithy on the night Lex reforged it. She looked at the dark runes. At the blue-white blade. At the silver pommel.

And then she did what her father had done.

She went down on one knee in the earth of the garden, beside the fresh grave, under the pear tree he'd planted on the day she was born. With the sword point-down before her and both hands on the cross-guard. And bowed her head.

"I swear," she said. Her voice was very steady. *"To stand on the steps. Wherever the steps are. For as long as I can stand."* She lifted her head. Her dark eyes were wet. *"Like he did."*

And Oathkeeper *rang*.

A long, clear, singing note, rising up through the branches of the pear tree into the grey Highcrest sky. The three runes along the blade flared gold. All at once. *Bulwark. Bind. Oath.* And frost bloomed along the steel, and spread, and sparkled in the thin autumn light like a field of snow at dawn.

OATH SWORN – Elowen Dunmore

Bound to: OATHKEEPER
(second bearer)

ELOWEN DUNMORE

Class: KNIGHT-CAPTAIN (Rare)

Title gained: Oathbound

Elowen stayed on her knee for a long moment, looking at the sword.

Then she stood up, and sheathed it in the battered old scabbard Lex had brought along with it, and it slid home with a sound like a sigh.

She looked at Lex across her father's grave.

"Thank you," she said. *"For making it remember."*



THERE WERE OTHER FUNERALS. Too many.

Old Tamsin Brisk, castellan of Fort Caldris, who had beaten everyone at cards except Arion Vey. They found what was left of him in the cellar under the burned keep, beside the dark Twin Stone. Arion buried him

himself, at the foot of the spur below the fortress, and stood over the grave for a long time without speaking. And then knelt and laid his palm on the earth, and Lex felt him do something with the Root. Small. Gentle. When he stood up, there was a mark on the stone they'd set over the grave. An open hand, palm up. And in the palm, a playing card.

Lucius Vane, Grand Inquisitor of the Spire, who had died in the middle of the Thornhollow Pass with a thousand Gloamed things sitting confused in the road around him. Daxian Roole buried him at the top of the pass, on a ledge looking east, where Pell had lain on his belly and watched the grey come up the valley. Roole carved the name on the stone himself, with a chisel and a mallet, badly. *LUCIUS VANE*. And under it, after a long time thinking: *HE CUT THE STRINGS*.

"He did terrible things," Roole said, standing over it. "On the green at Ashbourne. In a hundred places before that. I hunted beside him for ten years. I saw what he was." He was quiet for a moment. "And at the end, he walked out alone into twenty thousand of them and gave his life to cut a hole. For people he'd have chained a month before." He shook his head. "I don't know what that makes him. I don't know if it balances anything."

"Maybe it doesn't have to," said Lex. "Maybe it's just what he did at the end."

Roole looked at him.

"You sound like your father," he said.

And the others. The ones whose names Lex didn't know. Ashen Banners. Wardens with their pins torn off. Unbound farmers from Fenmoor and Ashbourne. Knights from the causeway at Saltreach. Seraphine wrote down every name she could find. Pages and pages of them. Lex struck them into stone with *Remembrance*, the rune he'd found on the causeway in the Barrows. A long wall of grey stone, at the top of the Thornhollow Pass, beside Vane's grave. Every name glowing faintly gold for a moment as it went in, and then fading into the grey.

I was here.

Farmer Tobbin's name was on it. Lex struck it himself, and then had to stop for a while.



THE BLIGHTMARCH BEGAN TO heal.

Not quickly. Not all at once. Sixteen years of Gloam don't wash out of the land in a season. But the source was sealed. The first wound was closed. And without it, the grey had nowhere to come from.

Lex saw it from Ashka's back, flying west from Duskhold toward Highcrest. Here and there, in the grey country below, a smudge of green. A patch of grass in a grey field. A single tree with a few leaves on it, standing among grey skeletons. A stream running clear between grey banks. Small things. Very small.

But green.

[It'll take years,] said Ember. [Maybe decades. The land remembers being hurt. Like Seraphine's scars.] A pause. [But it'll heal. The way she's healing.]

And the people. The eleven thousand who'd been Quiet in Duskhold. And the twenty thousand who'd sat down in the road at the Thornhollow Pass when Morvane fell. And the three thousand on the causeway at Saltreach. Many of them came back. Slowly. Blinking. Like people waking from a long fever. Some of them remembered their names. Some of them didn't, at first, and had to be told. Some of them remembered everything they'd done while they were Quiet, and those were the worst, the ones who sat by themselves and wouldn't speak.

Ilsa, the Healer from Fenmoor, went among them. With the young Stormcaller who'd been a Laborer, and the old Herbalist who'd been a Farmhand, and every Unbound Healer and Herbalist and Lanternkeeper who'd marched east. They went among the waking and laid their hands on them and did what they could.

And some of them didn't come back at all. Some of them had been Quiet too long. Since the first year. Since before. They sat in the grey fields with their white eyes and didn't move.

Antho went among those. Every day, for weeks. With Shade. He'd sit beside them, one at a time, with his scarred hand on their shoulder, and listen. And sometimes, very rarely, something would stir. A flicker in the white eyes. A word. A name. And he'd call it out, gently, the way he'd called the names of the Drowned Dead on the causeway, and sometimes, very rarely, they'd come back.

Mostly, they didn't.

"I keep thinking," he said to Lex once, sitting by a fire in the healing grey country, "that it could have been me. If you hadn't come up the mountain. If you hadn't sung." He stared into the flames. "I'd have ended up like them. Eventually. Sitting in a field. Quiet." He was silent for a long moment. "I want to do for them what you did for me. And I can't. Not most of them."

"You're doing it for some of them," said Lex.

"Not enough."

"It's enough," said Lex. "It has to be enough. It's what we've got."



WREN'S MOTHER STOPPED COUGHING.

Not all at once. Not completely. Master Fenwick the physic said the grey-lung would always be there, a little, a scar on the inside where the Gloam had been. But with the source sealed and the Gloam gone from the mines at Coldwater, it stopped getting worse. And then, slowly, it started getting better.

Wren went to see her. In Highcrest, in the narrow stone house on Fennel Street. Lex went with her.

Maren Ashdown was sitting on the step in the thin autumn sunshine, as she'd been sitting the first time, with Tam and Robbie on either side of her. She was still thin. Still grey-threaded. But her color was better. And when she saw her daughter coming up the street, she stood up.

On her own.

Wren stopped in the middle of the street.

And then she did something Lex had never seen her do. She didn't run. She *flew*. She stepped off the cobbles into the air and the wind took her, Windstep, Tempest, Gale at Speaking, and carried her up the street in a rush of air that sent every shop sign rattling and every hat flying, and set her down on the step in front of her mother as lightly as a leaf.

Maren Ashdown stared at her daughter.

"*Wrennie*," she said faintly. "*You're—you just—*"

"*Pathfinder*," said Wren. She was grinning so widely her face looked like it might split. "*Rare. Level forty-one. No cap.*" Her voice cracked. "*Mam. No cap.*"

Maren Ashdown looked at her for a long moment.

Then she started to cry, and to laugh, and to cough, all at once, and pulled her daughter into her arms. And Tam and Robbie piled on top of them both, shouting, and the whole street came out of their houses to see what the noise was.

Lex stood at the bottom of the step and watched.

After a while, Maren looked up at him over Wren's head.

"*Hammer*," she said.

"Ma'am."

"You brought her back."

"She brought herself back. I just—"

"*Don't*," said Maren Ashdown, exactly the way her daughter said it. "*Don't try. Do.*" She held his gaze. "You did."



ARION WENT TO ASHBOURNE in the first week of winter.

Lex went with him. Antho too. And Wren, and Seraphine, and Ashka, who landed on the green beside the white Stone and sent every child in the village shrieking for joy.

Brannoc was in the forge.

Of course he was. He was at the anvil, with Hedda Vorne on a stool beside him reading from the *Book of Making*, and Pell pumping the bellows, and a half-finished sword glowing orange in the tongs. The forge was full of the music of the work. The roar of the bellows. The hiss of the slack tub. The *chang* of the hammer. And every few strikes, a faint gold flicker, as a rune went into the steel.

Straighter, now. Still a little crooked. But straighter.

He looked up when they came in.

He saw Lex first. His soot-streaked face split into a grin. And then he saw the man standing beside Lex. Lean and grey-eyed and silver at the temples, with a forgettable face and his hands clasped behind his back.

The grin went away.

Brannoc set down the hammer.

He set down the tongs. He wiped his hands on his leather apron, slowly, very carefully, the way he did when he was thinking about something. And then he came around the anvil and walked across the forge and stopped in front of Arion Vey.

He was a head taller. Twice as broad. He looked down at the man in front of him for a long, long time.

Arion looked back up at him. He didn't say anything.

"*You're him,*" said Brannoc at last.

"*I'm him.*"

"*You left.*"

"*I left.*"

"*Fifteen years.*" Brannoc's voice was very quiet. Very even. The voice of a man holding something very heavy very carefully. "*She waited for you. Seren. Every night. A lantern in the window. Every single night until the fire.*"

"*I know.*"

"*And the boys. The little one came to me with nothing. Eleven years old. Nothing. Not a coat. Not a shoe. Not a family.*" Brannoc's jaw worked. "*I gave him a cot in the loft and a hammer and eight years of breakfasts. And I'd do it again. Every day. But it should have been you.*"

"*Yes,*" said Arion. "*It should have been me.*"

The forge was very quiet. Pell had stopped pumping the bellows. Hedda had closed the *Book of Making*. Lex stood in the doorway with his heart pounding.

Brannoc looked at Arion for a long moment more.

Then he drew back his huge right fist, and punched him.



IT WASN'T A HARD punch. Not by Brannoc's standards. Lex had seen him punch through a barn door once, for a bet. This was gentler than that.

It still knocked Arion Vey flat on his back on the forge floor.

He lay there. Staring up at the rafters. Blood trickling from his nose.

Brannoc stood over him, flexing his hand.

"*That,*" said Brannoc, "*was for Seren.*"

Arion looked up at him.

"Fair," he said, through the blood.

And then Brannoc reached down with the same huge hand and took Arion's, and hauled him up off the floor in one easy pull, as if he weighed nothing. And held on.

"And this," said Brannoc, and his voice cracked, "is for bringing the boy back. Both of them. And for the anvil singing. And for every Ceiling in this village. And for whatever you did, for fifteen years, in that crystal, holding the world together." He was shaking Arion's hand like he was trying to pump water out of it. "Your son's the best smith I ever trained. You hear me? The best. And if you want to argue about it—"

"I don't," said Arion. He was laughing. And crying. And bleeding. "Lady help me, I don't. I agree with every word."

"Good," said Brannoc. "Then you can buy me a drink."



THEY SPENT THE WHOLE night in the Crooked Kettle.

Arion and Brannoc, at the corner table, by the fire. Talking. Lex watched them from across the room. Brannoc doing most of it, at first, in his great rumbling voice, with his huge hands moving. And Arion listening. Leaning forward. Asking questions. Laughing, sometimes. Once, very quietly, weeping, with his face in his hands, while Brannoc sat across from him and didn't say anything at all, just put one huge hand on his shoulder and left it there.

[What do you think they're talking about?] said Ember.

Me, thought Lex. Antho. Mam. The forge. Fifteen years.

[Fifteen years is a lot to talk about.]

They've got time now.

Mother Orla kept bringing them ale. Old Mag came in and sat down with them for an hour and told Arion something that made him go very still and then laugh until he choked. Pell hovered nearby, wide-eyed, listening to every word.

Toward dawn, Lex saw Brannoc pull something out of his apron pocket and put it on the table between them.

It was a letter. Old. Folded. The paper yellow and soft.

Arion looked at it. Then at Brannoc. Then he picked it up, very carefully, and unfolded it, and read it.

His face did something Lex couldn't see from across the room. But he saw his father's shoulders shake.

He found out later what it was. Brannoc told him, the next morning, at the anvil.

"Your mother," said Brannoc. "She gave it to me. The year before the fire. Said if anything ever happened to her, and that man ever came back, I was to give it to him." He struck the iron. *Chang. "I've had it in my apron eight years. Never read it. Never opened it. Wasn't mine to open."*

"What did it say?"

Brannoc struck the iron again. *Chang.*

"Don't know, lad," he said. "Didn't ask. Didn't need to." He paused, the hammer raised. *"But your father read it three times. And then he folded it up and put it inside his coat, against his chest. And then he said: She knew. She always knew. Even then."*

He brought the hammer down. *Chang.* A rune went into the steel. Gold. Almost straight.

"Knew what?" said Lex.

Brannoc looked at him across the anvil.

"Didn't ask that either," he said.



ANTHO WENT BACK TO the Hollowmaw in the second week of winter.

Lex went with him.

They flew up on Ashka, on a clear cold morning, over the grey Vale that was beginning, here and there, to go green again. Up past Thistledown, where someone had taken down the painted sign that said *NO WARLOCKS* and burned it on the green, and replaced it with a new one that said *THE LAST HEARTH: ALL WELCOME*. Up past the Teeth and the Frostvault. Up to the great black cleft in the face of the highest mountain.

The Gloam was gone. The ring of charcoal stones was still there, scattered in the snow, but nothing pressed against it anymore. The stunted

grey pine at the base of the cliff had a single green shoot growing out of its side.

And above the cleft, on its flat rock, facing out over the world, Seren's lamp was still burning.

Antho stood in front of it for a long time.

Then they went into the cave.

The lanterns were all still there. Hundreds of them. Hanging from every spike and outcrop and rope in the long passage and the great bell-shaped cavern. Tin lanterns and brass lanterns and paper lanterns and the fine glass carriage-lantern with the broken handle and the battered miner's lamp. Eight years of them. Collected one by one.

Unlit.

"I want to light them," said Antho quietly. "All of them." He looked at Lex. "Can you?"

It took them nine days.

Lex struck *Ardent* into every one. Every tin frame, every brass bowl, every clay base. Some of them he could strike with Anvilson. Some of them, the fragile ones, the paper and the glass, he had to coax, the way he'd coaxed the rune into Seren's lamp: warming the surface with Flame until it would take the mark, pressing the rune in with the tip of Aurelian's little hand-hammer, slowly, a fraction at a time. His hands ached. His eyes watered. Antho sat beside him every hour of every day, holding each lantern while he worked on it, and saying nothing.

And when each one was done, Antho lit it. Not with Flame. He couldn't. With a single spark from Ashka, who sat in the mouth of the cavern breathing tiny careful sparks into each lantern as Antho held it up to her, her great golden eyes half-closed with concentration.

And then he'd hang it back up. Where it had been.

On the ninth night, they lit the last one.

It was the fine glass carriage-lantern with the broken handle. The one that looked like it had come from some noble's coach. Antho held it up. Ashka breathed a spark. The little *Ardent* rune Lex had coaxed into its brass base caught, and the flame came up gold behind the glass.

Antho hung it on its spike at the mouth of the passage, where the first lantern had hung, the one Lex had seen on the night he came up the mountain alone.

Then they walked out of the Hollowmaw together, down the long passage, between the lanterns, and stood on the snow outside and turned around and looked back.

The mountain was full of light.

Every lantern. Hundreds of them. Burning gold in the long passage and the great cavern, so many that the light poured out of the great black cleft in the mountain's face like light pouring out of an open door. It lit the snow. It lit the ring of charcoal stones. It lit the rock above, where Seren's lamp sat on its flat stone, small and gold among all the others now. Not alone anymore.

From across the valley, from the Frostvault's exit, from the Teeth, from Thistledown far below, from anywhere in the whole eastern Greyspine, anyone looking up would see it. The mountain that had been dark for eight years. The cleft where the mad warlock lived.

Blazing with lanterns.

A light left on for the lost.

Antho stood in the snow and looked at it with tears frozen on his face.

"I'm going to stay," he said.

Lex turned his head.

"Here. In the Hollowmaw." His brother's voice was very quiet. "*Not hiding. Not this time.*" He looked at the blazing cleft. "*Malachi said there are things that need keeping. Old things. Forgotten things. The Listeners' records. The Founders' codices. Everything the Order tried to destroy.*" He pulled the grey Codex out of his coat, the one from Qel'Varran, which Seraphine had given him to keep. "*Somebody needs to keep them. Learn them. Teach them. Somebody who listens.*" He looked at Lex. "*And somebody needs to watch the door. In case it ever opens again.*"

"Alone?"

"Not alone." Antho looked at Ashka, sprawled in the snow beside them, enormous and blue and shimmering in the lantern-light. "*And Seraphine's going to be Royal Archivist in Highcrest. The Queen asked her.*" His mouth twisted. "*She says Highcrest is only four days' flight by dragon. She says she'll*

come every month. With books." He paused. *"She says she'll finish her sentences."*

Lex laughed. It came out wet.

"And you?" said Antho. "What will you do?"

Lex looked out over the dark mountains. At the Vale, far below, where a white Stone glowed on a green. At the faint lights of Ashbourne, where an old smith and a one-armed armorer were teaching each other to strike runes.

"I'm going to teach," he said. "Anyone who wants to learn. To forge. To listen. To strike runes." He looked down at his hands. "There are four hundred and twelve Unbound in Ashbourne alone who don't know how to use their new classes. Thousands more, everywhere we've been. And none of them have a Malachi." He swallowed. "Someone has to show them."

"A school," said Antho.

"A forge," said Lex. "A big one. With lots of anvils."

His brother looked at him for a long moment.

Then he smiled. The crooked one. The one that was exactly like Lex's.

"Of course," he said. "Of course you'd make it a forge."



THEY STOOD ON THE snow in front of the blazing Hollowmaw for a long time, the two of them, side by side, shoulders touching, with a dragon at their feet and a mountain full of lanterns at their backs.

"Lex," said Antho at last.

"Yeah."

"Do you remember the stone? At the millpond? That skipped five times?"

"I remember."

Antho was quiet for a moment.

"When this is all done," he said. "When the school's built, and the Codex is copied, and everything's quiet. The good kind of quiet." He looked at Lex. "Will you come back here? To the mountains? There's a lake, on the other side of the Teeth. Very still. Very flat." Something moved at the corner of his mouth. "Perfect for skipping stones."

Lex looked at his brother.

"Yes," he said.

"I'll beat you," said Antho. "I've been practicing. For eight years. On that tarn behind the cave."

"You won't."

"I will. I'll count."

"You always count."

"I always count," Antho agreed. "And this time, I won't lie about the number."

They laughed. Both of them. Standing in the snow in front of a mountain full of lanterns, two brothers who had been estranged for eight years and had found each other in the dark. Laughing like idiots.

And above them, on its flat rock, Seren's little lamp burned on, gold and steady.

Not alone anymore.

CHAPTER 39

LEGACY OF THE SORCERERS



THE FIRST FESTIVAL OF Sorcerers was held in Ashbourne, on the green, a year to the day after the Unbinding.

Nobody planned it. That was the thing Lex remembered best, afterward. Nobody sat down in a room and decided there would be a festival. Nobody sent out invitations. Nobody built a stage.

People just came.

They came up the south road from Millbridge in carts and on foot. They came down the north road from Thistledown, where the Last Hearth had a new sign and a new keeper and a waiting list for its rooms. They came over the Greyspine on the high passes, from the healing Blightmarch, from Fenmoor and the grey villages that were growing green again. They came from Highcrest, from Saltreach, from the Fells and the moors and the fens. Farmers and miners and smiths and millers and tavern-keepers. Wardens with no pins. Sellswords. Knights.

Unbound, most of them. People who had stood in front of a Stone in the last year and felt something break, and looked at their panels and seen a number with no end.

They came to Ashbourne because that was where it had started. The first Stone. The one with the crack down its face that glowed gold now, all the time, day and night. They came to stand in front of it and look at it. To touch it, some of them. To lay their palms flat on its face and close their eyes.

And on the evening of the anniversary, as the sun went down behind the Greyspine, they lit lanterns.

Every one they had. In every window. On every sill. Hung from the chestnut trees on the green. Set out in rows along the edge of the cobbles. Carried in hands. Thousands of them. Tin and brass and clay and paper and glass, in every size and shape, until the whole village of Ashbourne glowed gold in the blue dusk like a coal in a banked fire.

A light left on for the lost.

The Lantern Service, they'd always called it, on the green at Ashbourne. Every autumn. A little clay lamp in every window, for the ones who hadn't come home.

Now they called it something else.

Lex heard a child say it first. A little girl, five or six, sitting on her father's shoulders at the edge of the green with a paper lantern in her hands, staring at the glowing Stone. *Papa, is this the Sorcerers' Festival? The one with the brothers?*

And her father had looked up at her, and at the Stone, and at the forge across the green with its doors thrown open and twelve fires burning inside, and said: *Yes, love. This is the Festival of Sorcerers.*

And it stuck.



THE FORGE HAD GROWN.

It wasn't Brannoc's forge anymore. Not only. It had swallowed the house next door, and the barn behind it, and the field behind the barn. There were twelve anvils now, in a long open hall with a roof of timber and slate and walls that could be thrown open in the summer to let the heat out. Twelve hearths. Twelve sets of bellows. And at every anvil, from dawn to dusk, someone working.

Students. That was what they were called, though most of them were older than Lex. Unbound smiths from every corner of Caldor who'd heard there was a place in the southern Vale where you could learn to strike runes. Where a capped smith who'd been level twenty-four for nineteen years would stand beside you at the anvil and show you the upstroke of *Ardent*, and tell you it was crooked, and show you again.

The Ashbourne Forge. Nobody called it a school.

Brannoc was its master. He hadn't wanted to be. He'd said so, loudly and often, in the first months. *I can barely read, lad. I've been striking runes for half a year. I don't know enough to teach anyone anything.* And then a young smith from Millbridge had come to the door, a girl of seventeen, Kindled the spring before as a *Smith*, Common, and Unbound at the Millbridge Stone in the autumn. And she'd stood in the doorway staring at the fire, and wouldn't leave until he let her pump the bellows.

Brannoc had looked at her for a long time. Then he'd handed her the bellows handle without a word.

He was level thirty-one now. *Runesmith*, Rare. He could strike *Ardent* and *Steadfast* and *Knit* and *True*, and they were almost straight. He still hummed hymns while he worked, badly. He still cooked eggs on the anvil.

Hedda Vorne ran the reading room. A small stone building beside the forge, with shelves on every wall and Seraphine's copy of the *Book of Making* chained to a lectern in the middle. Every student who came through the forge spent a month in Hedda's reading room before they were allowed near an anvil. Learning the runes. Their shapes. Their names. What they did. Hedda taught it with her one hand and her cudgel and a voice like gravel in a bucket, and her students were terrified of her and adored her, and she pretended not to notice either.

And Lex taught everything else.

How to listen to the iron. How to hear the flaws in it. How to shape the channel, and then let the fire flow. How to tell Flame the truth.

That last one was the hardest. Most of them couldn't. Most Unbound couldn't hear the Wells at all, any more than Seraphine could. They could strike runes, with the Lattice's help, the way Brannoc did. They could make good things. Warm things. But they couldn't reach down under the wheel to the river.

A few could. One in thirty, maybe. One in fifty. The girl from Millbridge was one. Lex had watched her sit in front of a cold hearth for nine days, the way he'd sat in front of Malachi's fire by the still pool, and on the tenth day the fire had leaned toward her.

She'd burst into tears.



WREN FLEW IN FROM the north an hour after sunset, as the lanterns were all being lit.

Lex was standing in the doorway of the forge. He saw her coming. A small dark shape against the blue dusk sky over the Greyspine, getting bigger. Not on a dragon. On the wind. Arms spread, braid streaming, riding the cold mountain air down into the Vale.

She landed on the green in front of the forge in a gust that sent a hundred paper lanterns swinging. People scattered, laughing. A few of them cheered.

"*Show-off*," said Lex.

"*Always*," said Wren. She was windburned and grinning. "You should see the passes. There's snow on the Teeth already. And the Frostvault's got a new guardian. Bigger than the Rimewarden. Ugly." She pushed her braid off her shoulder. "I didn't fight it. I just looked. I'll take Pell up next week."

"You're going to take Pell into a Delve?"

"He's level twenty-two. He's ready." She looked at him. "*You took me* into a Delve at level nineteen."

"You took *me*."

"Details." She came up the step and stood in front of him. "Hello, Hammer."

"Hello."

She kissed him. In the doorway of the forge, in front of the whole festival. Someone wolf-whistled. Lex suspected it was Pell.

WREN ASHDOWN

Class: PATHFINDER → evolving...

→ MISTWALKER (Epic)

"One who walks where the Veil is
thickest, and is never lost."

Tier II – Level 46

ATTUNEMENT

Gale SPEAKING

She'd evolved in the spring. In the Greyspine, on the high snowfields above the Hollowmaw, alone, in a blizzard. She'd come back three days

later and walked into the forge and stood in the middle of the floor until Lex looked up from the anvil, and then said, very calmly, *Mistwalker. Epic.* And then burst into tears, and laughed, and kissed him, and gone to sleep for a day and a half.

The mirror on the silver road. The one that had gone dark instead of shattering. Waiting.

It didn't have to wait anymore.



HIS FATHER ARRIVED AT midnight. Of course he did.

Lex had known he would come. Arion Vey had come to Ashbourne every month for a year, on the first of the month, without fail. Sometimes on a horse. Sometimes in a carriage, when the Queen insisted. Once, memorably, on Ashka, when Antho had flown down from the Hollowmaw to fetch him and the two of them had arrived together in a gust of wind that took the roof off the Crooked Kettle's privy.

He came every month, and he spent the day in the forge with Lex and Brannoc, and he spent the night in the Crooked Kettle with Brannoc, arguing.

They argued about everything. About runes. About whether *Ardent* was better struck with a light hammer or a heavy one. About the correct way to brew tea. About Lex. Mostly about Lex. Brannoc would say *the lad's the best smith I ever trained* and Arion would say *I agree entirely* and Brannoc would say *then why are you arguing with me* and Arion would say *I'm not arguing, I'm agreeing loudly* and they would both laugh until Mother Orla threw them out.

Lex didn't understand it. He'd stopped trying.

[They like each other,] Ember had said, after the third month. *[Very much. They just don't know how to say so. So they argue.]*

That's ridiculous.

[It's very common among men of a certain age.] A pause. *[Your father did the same with Elric, for forty years. Argued about everything. Loved him the whole time.]*

His father came down the north road at midnight, on foot, in a long dark coat, with his hands clasped behind his back. He stopped at the edge

of the green and looked at it. At the lanterns. At the glowing Stone. At the forge with its twelve fires.

His face, in the gold light, was very still.

Lex went out to meet him.

"You're late," he said.

"*I'm always late,*" said Arion. "*Your mother used to say I'd be late to my own funeral.*" He was looking at the lanterns. "*This is—*" He stopped. "*This is the Lantern Service. The one she used to bring you to. Every autumn.*"

"They're calling it something else now."

"*I heard.*" Something moved in his father's lean face. "*The Festival of Sorcerers.*" He shook his head slowly. "*The Queen wants to make it a royal holiday. All across Caldor. Every year. She asked my advice.*"

"What did you say?"

"*I said she should ask you.*"

Lex looked at him.

"*It's your festival,*" said Arion quietly. "*Yours and your brother's. And Brannoc's, and Wren's, and Garrick's, and every Unbound in Aldermere.*" He looked at the glowing Stone in the middle of the green. "*I just broke the world. You mended it.*"

"We mended it," said Lex. "Three of us. At Duskhold."

"*You let me kneel in the middle,*" said his father. "*That's not the same thing.*"



THEY WALKED AROUND THE green together, through the lanterns and the crowds.

Arion Vey was advisor to the Queen now. He hadn't wanted to be that, either. He'd said, loudly and often, in the first months, that he was the last person in Aldermere who should be advising anyone on anything, since the last time he'd decided he knew best, he'd torn a hole in the world. And Queen Lysandra had looked at him across the council table in the castle at Highcrest and said: *Which is exactly why I want you. You know what it costs to get it wrong.*

So he advised. He sat at the council table beside Daxian Roole, who was Warden-Commander now of an Order that didn't call itself the Wardens

of the Lattice anymore. It called itself the Keepers. And the first thing Roole had done, on the first day, was send every Keeper in Caldor to every Stone in Caldor with orders to remove every flag. Every *WEIGHT* and every *DENY*. Every rigged Kindling. Three hundred years of them.

It had taken six months.

And the Queen had decreed that any Stone a Vey could reach would be Unbound. Every Ceiling. Every one. Lex and Antho had spent the year traveling to them, one at a time, on Ashka's back. Ashbourne. Fenmoor. Thistledown. Millbridge. Coldwater. Highcrest itself, the Lower Town Stone where the girl in the brown dress had been made a Laborer. A hundred Stones. Two hundred.

There were thousands. It would take years.

But the Queen had said: *Then it takes years. We've had three hundred years of the other way.*

"*She's very good,*" said Arion, as they walked. "*The Queen. Better than I expected. Better than anyone expected.*" He was quiet for a moment. "*She reminds me of your mother, a little. The way she looks at you. As if she can see straight through to the thing underneath, and has decided, against all sense, that she likes it.*"

Lex didn't say anything.

They'd reached the Stone. The old cracked Stone in the middle of the green, glowing gold. Children were sitting around its base with their lanterns, staring up at it. One little boy was pressing his palm against its face, very solemnly, his eyes shut tight.

Arion stopped. He looked at the Stone for a long time.

"*She was Kindled here,*" he said quietly. "*Your mother. Forty years ago. Washerwoman, Common.*" His voice was very soft. "*She told me about it once. In Saltreach. She said she cried for a week. She said she'd wanted to be a singer.*"

Lex turned his head.

"*It's in the record now,*" said Arion. "*You Unbound her. With the dead. Three thousand one hundred and eighty of them.*" He reached out and laid his palm on the Stone, beside the little boy's. "*I looked. After. With the Root. I looked at her thread.*"

"What does it say?"

His father was quiet for a long time.

"*Listener*," he said at last. "*Rare. Level twenty-four. And then no cap.*" His mouth twisted. "*She was always a Listener. She just never had the class for it. The Lattice never knew.*"

He took his hand off the Stone.

"*And her thread*," he said, so quietly Lex almost didn't hear it, "*doesn't end.*"

Lex went very still.

"*The dead have threads that end*," said Arion. "*In the record. A last date. A last place. Like a line drawn under a column of numbers.*" He was looking at the Stone. Not at Lex. "*Hers doesn't end. It just—goes somewhere the Lattice can't follow.*"

"Father—"

"*I said I'd tell you when I was sure.*" Arion turned and looked at him. His grey eyes, in the lantern-light, were very bright. "*I'm not sure, Lexander. Not yet.*" He swallowed. "*But I'm closer than I was.*"



ANTHO CAME AT THE darkest hour of the night.

Lex heard Ashka first. The great beat of her wings, overhead, in the dark. Then the roar of wind as she came down. And then a gasp from the whole festival, thousands of people looking up at once, as a vast blue-grey dragon dropped out of the night sky and landed on the green beside the glowing Stone, so lightly that not a single lantern was knocked over.

She was bigger again. Lex could swear it. She seemed to grow every time he saw her. The size of a barn now, maybe, with wings that could have shaded half the green. The silver frame on her left wing was so fine against the vast membrane that you could only see it when the light caught it, a thread of spider-silk on a sail.

Antho slid off her neck.

He looked different. A year in the Hollowmaw. A year of reading and listening and teaching. His black hair was cut short, and his beard trimmed close, and he wore a long dark coat that might once have been a Warden's but had no pin. The Keeper's Lantern hung at his belt, glowing steady.

And his eyes, when he turned them on the crowd, were grey. Clear grey. With the soft deep dark of Shade underneath, like the sky behind the stars.

ANTHOREN VEY

Class: TWILIGHT WARLOCK (Unique)

Tier III – Level 57

CLARITY: 96 / 100

ATTUNEMENT

Shade SPEAKING

Gale ANSWERING

Tide LISTENING

There were people behind him on Ashka's back. Three of them. Young. Wide-eyed. Clinging to the dragon's crest with white knuckles.

"Students," said Antho, when Lex came across the green to meet him. He looked faintly embarrassed. "From the Lantern Keep. They wanted to see the festival." He nodded at the three of them, climbing shakily down from Ashka's back. "Two of them hear Shade. One hears Tide, I think. Maybe." His mouth twisted. "It's hard to teach. Malachi made it look easy."

"Malachi had nine hundred years."

"Malachi," said Antho, "sent me a letter last month."

Lex stared at him.

"By goat," said Antho. "A goat walked into the Hollowmaw with a letter tied round its neck. All the way from the Stillwater. Across the Wastes." He shook his head. "I don't know how. I don't want to know how."

"What did it say?"

Antho reached into his coat and pulled out a scrap of paper. He handed it to Lex.

It was written in a spidery, cheerful, slanting hand.

Deep one—

Well done. All of you. I heard the World Notice. The first wound closed. I danced around the pool. The goats thought I'd gone mad.

But listen. The fire in my hearth has been doing something strange. Leaning east. Not toward you. Toward something else. It's never done that before.

I think he's waking up.

Be careful.

—M.

P.S. Tell the smith his little hammer is very happy with him. I can tell.

Lex read it twice. Then he looked at Antho.

"He," he said.

"Aurelian," said Antho quietly. "He means Aurelian."



SERAPHINE HAD COME WITH them.

She'd been on Ashka's back too, Lex realized, behind the students. Royal Archivist of Caldor, in a plain grey dress with ink on her fingers and new spectacles on her nose, uncracked. The scars down the left side of her face had faded to pale silver lines, like frost on a window. She climbed down from the dragon and came across the green and put her hand in Antho's without looking at him, the way Wren did with Lex.

"We've been reading," she said. "In the Lantern Keep. The bronze cases from Qel'Varran. The ones Antho brought out." She pushed her spectacles up her nose. "There's a lot about Aurelian. Things that aren't in any other records. Things the Order destroyed everywhere else."

"Like what?" said Lex.

Seraphine looked at Antho. Antho looked at the ground.

"Like the fact that he's not just *in* the net," said Seraphine quietly. "He *is* the net. The root of it. His mind. His will. Holding it together. Holding the hunger down." She was quiet for a moment. "And the Listeners believed, the ones who wrote the bronze foils, that he'd been holding it so long he couldn't tell the difference anymore. Between himself and it."

Whoever holds it, it will try to become.

"And there's something else," said Antho. He looked up. "Something about the Lattice. About how it works. How it's *powered*." His grey eyes were very dark. "We don't understand it yet. We need more time. More records."

"But?"

Antho looked at Seraphine. She nodded slightly.

"But there's a word," said Antho. "In the oldest foils. Over and over. A word for what the Lattice takes from everyone who's in it. A little bit. From every spell. Every skill. Every level." He paused. "*Tithe*."



LEX DIDN'T SLEEP THAT night.

He sat on the step of the forge, as the lanterns burned down and the festival went quiet and people curled up to sleep on the green under the stars. Wren asleep with her head in his lap. Ember quiet in the back of his head. His father asleep in the Crooked Kettle, having argued with Brannoc until Mother Orla threw them both out at the third hour. Antho and Seraphine asleep against Ashka's vast warm flank, with the three students from the Lantern Keep curled up nearby.

He sat on the step and looked at the Stone. Glowing gold in the middle of the green.

[You're thinking,] said Ember. [You have the little line between your eyebrows.]

Wren says that.

[Wren is right about most things.] A pause. [What is it?]

Aurelian, Lex thought. Mam. The Tithe. Elric. He looked up at the stars. It's not over. Is it.

[No,] said Ember quietly. [I don't think it is.]

We mended the first wound. We freed Father. We Unbound two hundred Stones. He looked down at his hands. At the faint gold glow that came off them, always, steady, like a hearth that would never go out. And there are still thousands of Stones. And breaches we haven't found. And Elric, out there somewhere, with nine points of Father's Authority. And Kell, gone. And something waking up at the bottom of the net.

[And your mother,] said Ember softly. [With a thread that doesn't end.]

Lex didn't say anything.

[Lex,] said Ember, after a while. [Do you remember what Brannoc said? On the morning you left?]

He said a lot of things.

[He said there's always an unless.] A pause. [You just have to find it.]

Lex looked at the Stone. At the crack down its face, glowing gold. At the children's lanterns around its base, burning low.

There's always an unless, he thought.

[Yes,] said Ember. [And you've found every one so far.] A pause, and something in the gold voice that was very nearly a smile. [Little smith.]



VERY FAR TO THE east, beyond the healing Blightmarch, beyond the place where Duskhold had stood and was now only a ring of black crumbling stone around a patch of floor where nothing grew, beyond the end of every map in Seraphine's collection, there was a land the old texts called the Sundered Lands.

Nobody went there. Nobody had gone there in nine hundred years. It was where the war of the sorcerer-kings had been fought hardest, and where the world had nearly broken, and where the Veil grew thin and strange and the ground did not always stay where you left it.

An old man was walking through it.

He walked slowly. He had no staff. He leaned on nothing. His grey cloak hung off him like a sack, and the brass storm-charms on it were dull and tarnished, and some of them had fallen off. He had walked a very long way. He had not slept much. He had not eaten much. He had not spoken to anyone in a year.

He had nine points of stolen Authority, held very close, deep inside him, like a coal swallowed whole.

And he had a voice.

It had started a month ago. Faint, at first. Like a whisper heard through a wall. In the place under the air, where the stolen gold burned. He'd thought at first that it was the thief. The hunger. The thing that had filled Corvin Morvane and spoken through Anthoren Vey and wanted *him* so badly, Antho had said, more than it wanted most people.

It wasn't the thief.

It was a man's voice. Old. Very old. Patient, and clever, and kind. The kindest voice he'd ever heard. And it knew his name.

Elric Thorne, it said, in the dark, in the Sundered Lands, under a sky with too many stars in it. *Elric. You've stood beside the blood your whole life. Beside Arion. Beside his sons. Always beside. Always second.*

The old man stopped walking.

I know what that's like, said the voice. *I had brothers too. Six of them. I was always the one they stood beside.* A pause. *Would you like to stand above it, instead? Just once?*

The old man stood very still in the strange dark land.

There's something here, said the voice gently. *Something I made, a long time ago, and broke, and hid. A key. In three pieces.* A pause. *The first piece is very close. Under your feet, almost. In the ruin on the hill.*

The old man looked up.

There was a hill. He hadn't noticed it before. Low and round and bare, with a ruin on its crown. Grey stone, very old, the walls half-fallen. And carved over its broken doorway, worn almost smooth by nine hundred years of wind, a symbol.

An open hand. And above the palm, not a flame.

A keyhole.

The old man looked at it for a very long time.

He thought about a smith's apprentice standing over him in a black corridor, holding his staff. *I'm not going to kill you, Elric. But I'm not going to forgive you either.* He thought about a young man burning a black mark off his palm with fire, so he wouldn't have to wear a leash. He thought about an old friend in a crystal, with grey eyes, asking *was it worth it?*

Not yet, he'd answered.

He climbed the hill.



AT THE FESTIVAL OF Sorcerers in Ashbourne, in the darkest hour before dawn, three people with Root in their blood woke at the same moment.

Lex, on the step of the forge, with Wren's head in his lap.

Antho, against Ashka's flank, with Seraphine asleep beside him.

And Arion Vey, in a narrow bed in an upstairs room of the Crooked Kettle, with a yellowed letter from his wife folded against his chest.

They woke because a panel had opened in front of their eyes.

Not silver. Not gold. Black. Edged with something that was neither, a color none of them had ever seen in the Lattice before. And on it, a single line.

A KEY HAS BEEN TURNED.

Lex stared at it.

Across the green, against the dragon's flank, he saw his brother sit up. Saw Antho's grey eyes, wide, find his across the dark.

And in the upstairs window of the Crooked Kettle, a candle was lit. And a lean face with silver at the temples appeared in the glass, and looked down at the green. At his sons.

Even from across the green, even in the dark, Lex could see his father's face.

It had gone white.



ON A FLAT ROCK high on the dark face of the Greyspine, above a cleft that blazed with a hundred lanterns, a little clay lamp burned on, gold and steady, facing out over the world.

And very far down, under the net, under the Wells, under everything, in the dark before the first word, someone was singing.

Little light, little light, burning low.

Keep the door for the ones who go.

If the dark comes calling, don't you mind.

A lantern's lit for the ones behind.



Here ends The Sorcerer's Reckoning, Book One of the Lattice Chronicles.

The story continues in The Sorcerer's Legacy.

THE STORY CONTINUES



Book Two of The Lattice Chronicles

The Sorcerer's Legacy